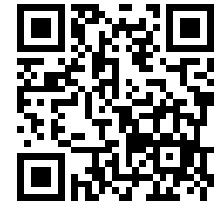
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STUDIA PATRISTICA

VOL. XLIV

Papers presented at the Fifteenth International Conference
on Patristic Studies held
in Oxford 2007

Archaeologica, Arts, Iconographica
Tools
Historica
Biblica
Theologica, Philosophica, Ethica

Edited by
J. BAUN, A. CAMERON, M. EDWARDS and M. VINZENT

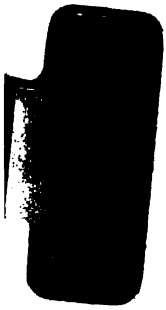
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Table of Contents

I. ARCHAEOLOGICA, ARTS, ICONOGRAPHICA

James A. Francis, Lexington, Kentucky
Biblical not Scriptural: Perspectives on Early Christian Art from Contemporary Classical Scholarship 3
Peter Widdicombe, Hamilton, Ontario
The Drunkenness of Noah and the Patristic Legacy in Text and Art 9
Lee M. Jefferson, Danville, Kentucky
Superstition and the Significance of the Image of Christ Performing Miracles in Early Christian Art 15
Rocco Borgognoni, Firenze
No Animals in the New Paradise? The 'Hall of Philia' from Antioch and the Patristic Exegesis of Isaiah's 'Peaceable Kingdom' 21
Anne Karahan, Stockholm
The Issue of περιχώρησις in Byzantine Holy Images 27
István M. Bugár, Debrecen
Images of Jews and Christians in the Seventh Century: The *Narratio de Imagine in Beryto* and its Context 35
Vladimir Baranov, Novosibirsk
The Doctrine of the Icon-Eucharist for the Byzantine Iconoclasts.... 41

II. TOOLS

Martin George, Bern & Katharina Bracht, Munich
Mneme Database Church History: A Presentation 49

III. HISTORICA

Josef Rist, Bochum
Das Orakel des Apollon in Daphne und das Christentum 57
Thomas Heyne, Oxford
Were Second-Century Christians 'Preoccupied' with Physical Healing and the Asclepian Cult? 63
Dennis Paul Quinn, Pomona, California
Roman Household Deities in the Latin Christian Writers: Tertullian, Arnobius, and Lactantius 71

Digitized by Google

Claire SOTINEL, Tours
Ancient Christianity and the Techniques of Information 77
David WOODS, Cork
The Deathbed Conversion of Galerius Maximianus to Religious Tolerance: Fact or Fraud? 85
Mikhail M. KAZAKOV, Smolensk, Russia
Letters of Western Bishops to the Emperor Theodosius I and Relations between Eastern and Western Churches at the End of the Fourth Century 91
David L. RIGGS, Marion, Indiana
Apologetic Performance and Saint Stephen as Civic Patron in Late Roman Africa 105
Vincenzo MESSANA, Palermo
Aspetti istituzionali e riferimenti normativi in Salviano di Marsiglia 111
Salvatore COSTANZA, Agrigento
Fonti patristiche sulla Sicilia nella valutazione degli studiosi contemporanei 119
Geoffrey GREATREX, Ottawa
The Fall of Macedonius Reconsidered 125

IV. BIBLICA

Benoît GAIN, Grenoble
Le respect dû au Livre des Écritures: Quelques témoignages patristiques 133
Eric SCHERBENSKE, Chapel Hill
The Vulgate *Primum Quaeritur*, Codex Fuldensis and the Hermeneutical Role of Early Christian Introductory Materials 139
Joseph VERHEYDEN, Leuven
Before Embarking on an Adventure: Some Preliminary Remarks on Writing the NTP Commentary on the *Gospel of Mark* 145
Enrica RUARO, Caprauna
Flying with Fleshy Wings: Ps.-Basil's Demonology in the Exegesis of *Isaiah* 2:20 157
Paul M. BLOWERS, Johnson City, Tennessee
Making Ends Meet: Variable Uses of the Psalm Title *Unto the End* (εἰς τὸ τέλος) in Greek Patristic Commentators on the Psalter 163
Hanneke REULING, Haarlem
Rabbinic Responses to Christian Appropriation of the Hebrew Bible: The Case of *Psalm* 22:1 (MT) 177
Catherine Brown TKACZ, Spokane, Washington
Esther as a Type of Christ and the Jewish Celebration of Purim 183

Digitized by Google

Hannah HUNT, Leeds
Sexuality and Penitence in Syriac Commentaries on Luke's Sinful Woman 189
Stephen MORRIS, New York
Blood and Holy Communion: Late Antique Use of *Luke* 8:42-8 195
Mark EDWARDS, Oxford
Orthodox Corruption? *John* 1:18 201
Hellen DAYTON, Washington DC
On the Use of *Luke* 10:38-42 – Jesus in the House of Mary and Martha – for Instruction in Contemplative Prayer in the Patristic Tradition 207
Jonathan YATES, Villanova, Pennsylvania
The Use of *Rom.* 2:14-5 in the Christian Latin Tradition ca. 365-ca. 411 – Augustine Excepted 213
Marco RIZZI, Milan
Romans 13 in Early Christian Exegesis 227
Judith L. KOVACS, Charlottesville, Virginia
A Letter 'Weighty and Powerful': The Importance of 1*Corinthians* in the Early Church 235
Riemer ROUKEMA, Zwolle
Paul's Admonitions on Idol Offerings (1*Cor.* 8 and 10) in Patristic Interpretation 249
Ilaria RAMELLI, Milan
In Illud: Tunc et ipse Filius...: Gregory of Nyssa's Exegesis, its Derivations from Origen, and Early Patristic Interpretations Related to Origen's 259
Dominika A. KUREK-CHOMYCZ, Leuven
Scenting the Aroma of Christ: 2*Cor.* 2:15-6 in Origen's Interpretation 275
Blossom STEFANIW, Erfurt
Exegetical Curricula in Origen, Didymus, and Evagrius: Pedagogical Agenda and the Case for Neoplatonist Influence 281

V. THEOLOGICA, PHILOSOPHICA, ETHICA

Marie-Odile BOULNOIS, Paris
'Dieu jalous': Embarras et controverses autour d'un nom divin dans la littérature patristique 297
Kari KLOOS, Regis University, Denver
Christ the Revealer: Patristic Views of the Mediation of Christ in the Old Testament 315
Columba STEWART, Collegeville
Monastic Attitudes toward Philosophy and Philosophers 321

Digitized by Google

Jennifer NIMMO SMITH, Edinburgh
From Gorgias to Gregory of Nazianzus – a Platonic Formula Revisited 329
Frances YOUNG, Birmingham
Creation and Human Being: The Forging of a Distinct Christian Discourse 335
Julia KONSTANTINOVSKY, Oxford
Soul and Body in Early Christian Thought: A Unified Duality? 349
Stefanie FROST, Göttingen
How the Early Christians Discovered the Soul 355
Richard SORABJI, Oxford
Graeco-Roman Origins of the Idea of Moral Conscience 361
Vít HUŠEK, Olomouc, Czech Republic
Human Freedom According to the Earliest Latin Commentaries on Paul's Letters 385
Rowan WILLIAMS, Canterbury
'Tempted as we are': Christology and the Analysis of the Passions 391
Kevin UHALDE, Athens, Ohio
The Sinful Subject: Doing Penance in Rome 405
Hennie STANDER, Pretoria
The Church Fathers on Pity 415
Karin SCHLAPBACH, Ottawa
Spectaculum naturae as 'Theatrical' Experience: New Uses of an Old Comparison 421
Carol HARRISON, Durham
Transformative Listening: Constructing the Hearer in Early Christianity 427
Geoffrey D. DUNN, Brisbane
The Functions of Mary in the Christmas Homilies of Augustine of Hippo 433
Antonia ATANASSOVA, Boston College
Theological and Cultic Components of Mariology in the Context of Ephesus 447
Elena GIANNARELLI, Firenze
Body, Clothing and Female Identity 461
Valeria NOVEMBRI, Siena
Philosophia and Christian Culture: An Antidote for Female Weakness in Jerome's Letters 471
Leena Mari PELTOMAA, Vienna
Roles and Functions of Mary in the Hymnography of Romanos Melodos 487
Francesca DI MARCO, Firenze
Undressed: The Naked Female Body as a Sign of Holiness in Apocryphal and Hagiographical Literature 499

Digitized by Google

Stephen J. SHOEMAKER, Eugene, Oregon
Asceticism in the Early Dormition Narratives 509
Niki TSIRONIS, Athens
Desire, Longing and Fear in the Narrative of Middle-Byzantine Homiletics 515
Peter GEMEINHARDT, Göttingen
Holiness and Education in Late Antique Hagiography 521
Piotr ASHWIN-SIEJKOWSKI, Chichester
Porphyry's *Sententiae* an Ethical/Spiritual Guidebook to the Neoplatonic Life 527
Bronwen NEIL, Brisbane
Blessed are the Rich: Leo the Great and the Roman Poor 533
Brian MATZ, Leuven
Alleviating Economic Injustice in Gregory of Nyssa's *Contra usurarios* 549

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Abbreviations

AA.SS	see ASS.
AAWG.PH	Abhandlungen der Akademie der Wissenschaften in Göttingen Philologisch-historische Klasse, Göttingen.
AB	Analecta Bollandiana, Brussels.
AC	Antike und Christentum, ed. F.J. Dölger, Münster.
ACL	Antiquité classique, Louvain.
ACO	Acta conciliorum oecumenicorum, ed. E. Schwartz, Berlin.
ACW	Ancient Christian Writers, ed. J. Quasten and J.C. Plumpe, Westminster (Md.)/London.
AHDLMA	Archives d'histoire doctrinale et littéraire du moyen âge, Paris.
AJAH	American Journal of Ancient History, Cambridge, Mass.
AJP	American Journal of Philology, Baltimore.
AKK	Archiv für katholisches Kirchenrecht, Mainz.
AKPAW	Abhandlungen der königlichen Preußischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, Berlin.
ALMA	Archivum Latinitatis Medii Aevi (Bulletin du Cange), Paris/Brussels.
ALW	Archiv für Liturgiewissenschaft, Regensburg.
AnalBoll	Analecta Bollandiana, Brussels.
ANCL	Ante-Nicene Christian Library, Edinburgh.
ANF	Ante-Nicene Fathers, Buffalo/New York.
ANRW	Aufstieg und Niedergang der römischen Welt, ed H. Temporini *et al.*, Berlin.
AnSt	Anatolian Studies, London.
AnThA	Année théologique augustinienne, Paris.
APOT	Apocrypha and Pseudepigrapha of the Old Testament in English, ed. R.E. Charles, Oxford.
AR	Archivum Romanicum, Florence.
ARW	Archiv für Religionswissenschaft, Berlin/Leipzig.
ASS	Acta Sanctorum, ed. the Bollandists, Brussels.
AThANT	Abhandlungen zur Theologie des Alten und Neuen Testaments, Zürich.
Aug	Augustinianum, Rome.
AugSt	Augustinian Studies, Villanova (USA).
AW	Athanasius Werke, ed. H.-G. Opitz *et al.*, Berlin.
AZ	Archäologische Zeitung, Berlin.
BA	Bibliothèque augustinienne, Paris.
BAC	Biblioteca de Autores Cristianos, Madrid.
BASOR	Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research, New Haven, Conn.
BDAG	A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and Other Early Christian Literature, 3rd edn F.W. Danker, Chicago.
BEHE	Bibliothèque de l'École des Hautes Études, Paris.
BETL	Bibliotheca Ephemeridum Theologicarum Lovaniensium, Louvain.
BGL	Benedictinisches Geistesleben, St. Ottilien.
BHG	Bibliotheca Hagiographica Graeca, Brussels.
BHL	Bibliotheca Hagiographica Latina Antiquae et Mediae Aetatis, Brussels.

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BHO	Bibliotheca Hagiographica Orientalis, Brussels.
BHTh	Beiträge zur historischen Theologie, Tübingen.
BJ	Bursians Jahresbericht über die Fortschritte der klassischen Altertumswissenschaft, Leipzig.
BJRULM	Bulletin of the John Rylands Library, Manchester.
BKV	Bibliothek der Kirchenväter, ed. F.X. Reithmayr and V. Thalhofer, Kempten.
BKV2	Bibliothek der Kirchenväter, ed. O. Bardenhewer, Th. Schermann, and C. Weyman, Kempten/Munich.
BKV3	Bibliothek der Kirchenväter. Zweite Reihe, ed. O. Bardenhewer, J. Zellinger, and J. Martin, Munich.
BLE	Bulletin de littérature ecclésiastique, Toulouse.
BoJ	Bonner Jahrbücher, Bonn.
BS	Bibliotheca sacra, London.
BSL	Bolletino di studi latini, Naples.
BWAT	Beiträge zur Wissenschaft vom Alten Testament, Leipzig/Stuttgart.
Byz	Byzantion, Brussels.
BZ	Byzantinische Zeitschrift, Leipzig.
BZNW	Beihefte zur Zeitschrift für die neutestamentliche Wissenschaft, Berlin.
CAr	Cahiers Archéologique, Paris.
CBQ	Catholic Biblical Quarterly, Washington.
CCCM	Corpus Christianorum, Continuatio Mediaevalis, Turnhout/Paris.
CCG	Corpus Christianorum, Series Graeca, Turnhout/Paris.
CCL	Corpus Christianorum, Series Latina, Turnhout/Paris.
CCSA	Corpus Christianorum, Series Apocryphorum, Turnhout/Paris.
CH	Church History, Chicago.
CIL	Corpus Inscriptionum Latinarum, Berlin.
CP(h)	Classical Philology, Chicago.
CPG	Clavis Patrum Graecorum, ed. M. Geerard, vols. I-VI, Turnhout.
CPL	Clavis Patrum Latinorum (SE 3), ed. E. Dekkers and A. Gaar, Turnhout.
CQ	Classical Quarterly, London/Oxford.
CR	The Classical Review, London/Oxford.
CSCO	Corpus Scriptorum Christianorum Orientalium, Louvain. Aeth = Scriptores Aethiopici Ar = Scriptores Arabici Arm = Scriptores Armeniaci Copt = Scriptores Coptici Iber = Scriptores Iberici Syr = Scriptores Syri Subs = Subsidia
CSEL	Corpus Scriptorum Ecclesiasticorum Latinorum, Vienna.
CSHB	Corpus Scriptorum Historiae Byzantinae, Bonn.
CTh	Collectanea Theologica, Lvov.
CUF	Collection des Universités de France publiée sous le patronage de l'Association Guillaume Budé, Paris.
CW	Catholic World, New York.
DAC	Dictionary of the Apostolic Church, ed. J. Hastings, Edinburgh.

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DACL	see DAL
DAL	Dictionnaire d'archéologie chrétienne et de liturgie, ed. F. Cabrol, H. Leclercq, Paris.
DB	Dictionnaire de la Bible, Paris.
DBS	Dictionnaire de la Bible, Supplément, Paris.
DCB	Dictionary of Christian Biography, Literature, Sects, and Doctrines, ed. W. Smith and H. Wace, 4 vols, London.
DHGE	Dictionnaire d'histoire et de géographie ecclésiastique, ed. A. Baudrillart, Paris.
Did	Didaskalia, Lisbon.
DOP	Dumbarton Oaks Papers, Cambridge, Mass., subsequently Washington, D.C.
DOS	Dumbarton Oaks Studies, Cambridge, Mass., subsequently Washington, D.C.
DR	Downside Review, Stratton on the Fosse, Bath.
DS	H.J. Denzinger and A. Schönmetzer, ed., Enchiridion Symbolorum, Barcelona/Freiburg i.B./Rome.
DSp	Dictionnaire de Spiritualité, ed. M. Viller, S.J., and others, Paris.
DTC	Dictionnaire de théologie catholique, ed. A. Vacant, E. Mangenot, and E. Amann, Paris.
EA	Études augustiniennes, Paris.
ECatt	Enciclopedia Cattolica, Rome.
ECQ	Eastern Churches Quarterly, Ramsgate.
EE	Estudios eclesiasticos, Madrid.
EECh	Encyclopedia of the Early Church, ed. A. Di Berardino, Cambridge.
EKK	Evangelisch-Katholischer Kommentar zum Neuen Testament, Neukirchen.
EH	Enchiridion Fontium Historiae Ecclesiasticae Antiquae, ed. Ueding-Kirch, 6th ed., Barcelona.
EO	Échos d'Orient, Paris.
EtByz	Études Byzantines, Paris.
ETL	Ephemerides Theologicae Lovanienses, Louvain.
EWNT	Exegetisches Wörterbuch zum NT, ed. H.R. Balz *et al.*, Stuttgart.
ExpT	The Expository Times, Edinburgh.
FC	The Fathers of the Church, New York.
FGH	Fragmente der griechischen Historiker, Berlin.
FKDG	Forschungen zur Kirchen- und Dogmengeschichte, Göttingen.
FRL	Forschungen zur Religion und Literatur des Alten und Neuen Testaments, Göttingen.
FS	Festschrift.
FThSt	Freiburger theologische Studien, Freiburg i.B.
FTS	Frankfurter theologische Studien, Frankfurt a.M.
FZThPh	Freiburger Zeitschrift für Theologie und Philosophie, Freiburg/Switzerland.
GCS	Die griechischen christlichen Schriftsteller, Leipzig/Berlin.
GDV	Geschichtsschreiber der deutschen Vorzeit, Stuttgart.
GLNT	Grande Lessico del Nuovo Testamento, Genoa.
GNO	Gregorii Nysseni Opera, Leiden.

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GRBS	Greek, Roman and Byzantine Studies, Cambridge, Mass.
GWV	Geschichte in Wissenschaft und Unterricht, Offenburg.
HbNT	Handbuch zum Neuen Testament. Tübingen.
HDR	Harvard Dissertations in Religion, Missoula.
HJG	Historisches Jahrbuch der Görresgesellschaft, successively Munich, Cologne and Munich/Freiburg i.B.
HKG	Handbuch der Kirchengeschichte, Tübingen.
HNT	Handbuch zum Neuen Testament, Tübingen.
HO	Handbuch der Orientalistik, Leiden.
HSCP	Harvard Studies in Classical Philology, Cambridge, Mass.
HThR	Harvard Theological Review, Cambridge, Mass.
HTS	Harvard Theological Studies, Cambridge, Mass.
HZ	Historische Zeitschrift, Munich/Berlin.
ICC	The International Critical Commentary of the Holy Scriptures of the Old and New Testaments, Edinburgh.
ILCV	Inscriptiones Latinae Christianae Veteres, ed. E. Diehl, Berlin.
ILS	Inscriptiones Latinae Selectae, ed. H. Dessau, Berlin.
J(b)AC	Jahrbuch für Antike und Christentum, Münster.
JBL	Journal of Biblical Literature, Philadelphia, Pa., then various places.
JdI	Jahrbuch des Deutschen Archäologischen Instituts, Berlin.
JECS	Journal of Early Christian Studies, Baltimore.
JEH	The Journal of Ecclesiastical History, London.
JJS	Journal of Jewish Studies, London.
JLH	Jahrbuch für Liturgik und Hymnologie, Kassel.
JPTh	Jahrbücher für protestantische Theologie, Leipzig/Freiburg i.B.
JQR	Jewish Quarterly Review, Philadelphia.
JRS	Journal of Roman Studies, London.
JSJ	Journal for the Study of Judaism in the Persian, Hellenistic and Roman Period, Leiden.
JSOR	Journal of the Society of Oriental Research, Chicago.
JThSt	Journal of Theological Studies, Oxford.
KAV	Kommentar zu den apostolischen Vätern, Göttingen.
KeTh	Kerk en Theologie, 's Gravenhage.
KJ(b)	Kirchliches Jahrbuch für die evangelische Kirche in Deutschland, Gütersloh.
LCL	The Loeb Classical Library, London/Cambridge, Mass.
LNPF	A Select Library of Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers of the Christian Church, ed. P. Schaff and H. Wace, Buffalo/New York.
L(O)F	Library of Fathers of the Holy Catholic Church, Oxford.
LSJ	H.G. Liddell and R. Scott, A Greek-English Lexicon, new (9th) edn H.S. Jones, Oxford.
LThK	Lexikon für Theologie und Kirche, Freiburg i.B.
MA	Moyen-Âge, Brussels.
MAMA	Monumenta Asiae Minoris Antiqua, London.
Mansi	J.D. Mansi, Sacrorum conciliorum nova et amplissima collectio, Florence, 1759-1798. Reprint and continuation: Paris/Leipzig, 1901-1927.
MBTh	Münsterische Beiträge zur Theologie, Münster.

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MCom	Miscelanea Comillas, Comillas/Santander.
MGH	Monumenta germaniae historica. Hanover/Berlin.
ML	Mediaevalia Lovaniensia, Louvain.
MPG	See PG.
MSR	Mélanges de science religieuse, Lille.
MThZ	Münchener theologische Zeitschrift, Munich.
Mus	Le Muséon, Louvain.
NGWG	Nachrichten der Gesellschaft der Wissenschaften zu Göttingen.
NH(M)S	Nag Hammadi (and Manichaean) Studies, Leiden.
NovTest	Novum Testamentum, Leiden.
NPNF	See LNPF.
NRSV	New Revised Standard Version.
NRTh	Nouvelle Revue Théologique, Tournai/Louvain/Paris.
NTA	Neutestamentliche Abhandlungen, Münster.
NT.S	Novum Testamentum Supplements, Leiden.
NTS	New Testament Studies, Cambridge/Washington.
OBO	Orbis biblicus et orientalis, Freiburg, Switz.
OCA	Orientalia Christiana Analecta, Rome.
OCP	Orientalia Christiana Periodica, Rome.
OECS	Oxford Early Christian Studies, Oxford.
OLA	Orientalia Lovaniensia Analecta, Louvain.
OLP	Orientalia Lovaniensia Periodica, Louvain.
Or	Orientalia. Commentarii editi a Pontificio Instituto Biblico, Rome.
OrChr	Oriens Christianus, Leipzig, then Wiesbaden.
OrSyr	L'Orient Syrien, Paris.
PG	Migne, Patrologia, series graeca.
PGL	A Patristic Greek Lexicon, ed. G.L. Lampe, Oxford.
PL	Migne, Patrologia, series latina.
PLRE	The Prosopography of the Later Roman Empire, ed. A.H.M. Jones *et al.*, Cambridge.
PLS	Migne, Patrologia, series latina. Supplementum ed. A. Hamman.
PO	Patrologia Orientalis, Paris.
PRE	Paulys Realenzyklopädie der classischen Alterthumswissenschaft, Stuttgart.
PS	Patrologia Syriaca, Paris.
PTA	Papyrologische Texte und Abhandlungen, Bonn.
PThR	Princeton Theological Review, Princeton.
PTS	Patristische Texte und Studien, Berlin.
PW	Paulys Realencyclopädie der classischen Altertumswissenschaft, ed. G. Wissowa, Stuttgart.
QLP	Questions liturgiques et paroissiales, Louvain.
QuLi	Questions liturgiques, Louvain
RAC	Rivista di Archeologia Cristiana, Rome.
RACh	Reallexikon für Antike und Christentum, Stuttgart.
RAM	Revue d'ascétique et de mystique, Paris.
RAug	Recherches Augustiniennes, Paris.
RBen	Revue Bénédictine, Maredsous.
RB(ibl)	Revue biblique, Paris.

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RE	Realencyklopädie für protestantische Theologie und Kirche, founded by J.J. Herzog, 3e ed. A. Hauck, Leipzig.
REA(ug)	Revue des études Augustiniennes, Paris.
REB	Revue des études byzantines, Paris.
RED	Rerum ecclesiasticarum documenta, Rome.
RÉL	Revue des études latines, Paris.
REG	Revue des études grecques, Paris.
RevSR	Revue des sciences religieuses, Strasbourg.
RevThom	Revue thomiste, Toulouse.
RFIC	Rivista di filologia e d'istruzione classica, Turin.
RGG	Religion in Geschichte und Gegenwart, ed. Gunkel-Zscharnack, Tübingen
RHE	Revue d'histoire ecclésiastique, Louvain.
RhMus	Rheinisches Museum für Philologie, Bonn.
RHR	Revue de l'histoire des religions, Paris.
RHT	Revue d'Histoire des Textes, Paris.
RMAL	Revue du Moyen-Âge Latin, Paris.
ROC	Revue de l'Orient chrétien, Paris.
RPh	Revue de philologie, Paris.
RQ	Römische Quartalschrift, Freiburg i.B.
RQH	Revue des questions historiques, Paris.
RSLR	Rivista di storia e letteratura religiosa, Florence.
RSPT, RSPh	Revue des sciences philosophiques et théologiques, Paris.
RSR	Recherches de science religieuse, Paris.
RTAM	Recherches de théologie ancienne et médiévale, Louvain.
RthL	Revue théologique de Louvain, Louvain.
RTM	Rivista di teologia morale, Bologna.
Sal	Salesianum, Roma.
SBA	Schweizerische Beiträge zur Altertumswissenschaft, Basel.
SBS	Stuttgarter Bibelstudien, Stuttgart.
ScEc	Sciences ecclésiastiques, Bruges.
SCh, SC	Sources chrétiennes, Paris.
SD	Studies and Documents, ed. K. Lake and S. Lake. London/Philadelphia.
SE	Sacris Erudiri, Bruges.
SDHI	Studia et documenta historiae et iuris, Roma.
SH	Subsidia Hagiographica, Brussels.
SHA	Scriptores Historiae Augustae.
SJMS	Speculum. Journal of Mediaeval Studies, Cambridge, Mass.
SM	Studien und Mitteilungen zur Geschichte des Benediktinerordens und seiner Zweige, Munich.
SO	Symbolae Osloenses, Oslo.
SP	Studia Patristica. Papers presented to the International Conference on Patristic Studies held in Oxford, successively Berlin, Kalamazoo, Louvain.
SPM	Stromata Patristica et Mediaevalia, ed. C. Mohrman and J. Quasten, Utrecht.
SQ	Sammlung ausgewählter Quellenschriften zur Kirchen- und Dogmengeschichte, Tübingen.
SQAW	Schriften und Quellen der Alten Welt, Berlin.

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SSL	Spicilegium Sacrum Lovaniense, Louvain.
StudMed	Studi Medievali, Turin.
SVF	Stoicorum Veterum Fragmenta, ed. J. von Arnim, Leipzig.
TDNT	Theological Dictionary of the New Testament, Grand Rapids, Mich.
TE	Teologia espiritual, Valencia.
ThGl	Theologie und Glaube, Paderborn.
ThJ	Theologische Jahrbücher, Leipzig.
ThLZ	Theologische Literaturzeitung, Leipzig.
ThPh	Theologie und Philosophie, Freiburg i.B.
ThQ	Theologische Quartalschrift, Tübingen.
ThR	Theologische Rundschau, Tübingen.
ThWAT	Theologisches Wörterbuch zum Alten Testament, Stuttgart.
ThWNT	Theologisches Wörterbuch zum Neuen Testament, Stuttgart.
ThZ	Theologische Zeitschrift, Basel.
TLG	Thesaurus Linguae Graecae.
TP	Transactions and Proceedings of the American Philological Association, Lancaster, Pa.
TRE	Theologische Realenzyklopädie, Berlin.
TS	Theological Studies, New York and various places; now Washington, D.C.
TThZ	Trierer theologische Zeitschrift, Trier.
TU	Texte und Untersuchungen, Leipzig/Berlin.
USQR	Union Seminary Quarterly Review, New York.
VC	Vigiliae Christianae, Amsterdam.
VetChr	Vetera Christianorum, Bari (Italy).
VT	Vetus Testamentum, Leiden.
WBC	Word Biblical Commentary, Waco.
WUNT	Wissenschaftliche Untersuchungen zum Neuen Testament, Tübingen.
WZKM	Wiener Zeitschrift für die Kunde des Morgenlandes, Vienna.
YUP	Yale University Press, New Haven.
ZAC	Zeitschrift für Antikes Christentum, Berlin.
ZAM	Zeitschrift für Aszese und Mystik, Innsbruck, then Würzburg.
ZAW	Zeitschrift für die alttestamentliche Wissenschaft, Giessen, then Berlin.
ZDPV	Zeitschrift des Deutschen Palästina-Vereins, Leipzig.
ZKG	Zeitschrift für Kirchengeschichte, Gotha, then Stuttgart.
ZKTh	Zeitschrift für katholische Theologie, Vienna.
ZN(T)W	Zeitschrift für die neutestamentliche Wissenschaft und die Kunde der älteren Kirche, Giessen, then Berlin.
ZRG	Zeitschrift für Rechtsgeschichte, Weimar.
ZThK	Zeitschrift für Theologie und Kirche, Tübingen.

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I. Archaeologica, Arts, Iconographica

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Biblical not Scriptural: Perspectives on Early Christian Art from Contemporary Classical Scholarship

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For over twenty years, a fundamental shift has been taking place in our approach to early Christian art as our attention has been refocused on art as a visual language in its own right, the dynamics of seeing, and the importance of the viewer in constructing meaning.[1] At the same time, scholars have explored the nature of text and scripture in early Christianity, discovering ways of appropriating the biblical message quite different from the literacy and literalism of our age.[2] My purpose in this paper is to further substantiate this more recent approach to early Christian art by demonstrating its consistency with work in Classical Studies on nature of visuality, textuality, and literacy, and also to argue that the most useful way to study the earliest identifiably Christian images is to set them in the context of Greco-Roman understandings and practice.

Traditionally, early Christian images were interpreted by literal reference to Scripture or theological doctrine, as if they could be no more than mere 'illustrations' of a text or intellectual process. Certainly our current understanding of the fluidity of pre-Constantinian Christianity should make us cautious in this, but more concretely, a good number of Roman funerary paintings in catacombs and tombs indicate that early Christian images were doing something other than creating a 'Bible for the illiterate'.[3] Scholars have had perennial difficulty explaining the presence of Orpheus, Dionysiac imagery, and even Hercules and

[1] Mary Charles Murray, *Rebirth and Afterlife: A Study of the Transmutation of some Pagan Imagery in Early Christian Funerary Art*, BAR International Series 100 (Oxford, 1981) was a pioneering work, followed by Paul Corby Finney, *The Invisible God: the Earliest Christians on Art* (Oxford and New York, 1994); Robin Jensen, *Understanding Early Christian Art* (London and New York, 2000) and *Face to Face: Portraits of the Divine in Early Christianity* (Minneapolis, 2005); as well as the important work of Jaś Elsner, *Art and the Roman Viewer: the Transformation of Art from the Pagan World to Christianity* (Cambridge, 1995) and *Pagan Rome and The Christian Triumph: the Art of the Roman Empire AD 100-450*, Oxford History of Art (Oxford, 1998).

[2] See: Averil Cameron, *Christianity and the Rhetoric of Empire: the Development of Christian Discourse* (Berkeley and Los Angeles, 1991); Frances M. Young, *Biblical Exegesis and the Formation of Christian Culture* (Cambridge, 1997); Kim Haines-Eitzen, *Guardians of Letters: Literacy, Power, and the Transmitters of Early Christian Literature* (Oxford, 2000).

[3] A common paraphrase of Gregory the Great from his letters to Serenus, bishop of Marseilles: *Epp.* 9.209 and 11.10 (CCSL 140A, 768 and 873). Gregory never mentions 'Bible', and it is even unclear exactly what sort of images he is referring to, except that they are on the walls.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 3-8.
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Athena in Christian burial chambers. Even within ostensibly biblical scenes, we are confronted with Jesus holding a wand while raising Lazarus and Noah emerging from a box after the flood without a boat or pair of animals in sight.[4] All the while, the non-narrative, staccato presentation and multivalent or ambivalent symbolism of these images challenges a discursive method of interpretation.

Also for the past twenty years, the intellectualized approach to interpreting visual artifacts has been challenged in Art History generally, with scholars of ancient art being among the most articulate exponents of dealing with visual artifacts on their own terms, not as merely reflective, but independently constructive of personhood, society, and culture.[5] Early Christian art presents a special case in this regard. Since Christianity is claimed to be a revealed religion, one with (eventually) a divine authorizing text, it may be only common sense to read images in light of that text and refer all interpretation to it and the theology that expounds it. But even so, did 'text' and 'reading' mean the same thing for ancient Christians as they do for us? In a world in which three-quarters of the population were illiterate, the knowledge and spread of Christianity, indeed of any religion, could not have been a matter of reading, at least not in the way we commonly understand it.[6] Harry Gamble states categorically that 'nothing remotely like mass literacy existed, nor could have existed, in Greco-Roman societies, because the forces and institutions required to foster it were absent'. Christians cannot be supposed to have differed from the general population in this despite the importance of the revealed text since 'acquaintance with the scriptures did not require that all or even most Christians be individually capable of reading them and does not imply that they were'.[7] As scripture itself

[4] See the illustrations in André Grabar, *Christian Iconography: a Study of its Origins* (Princeton, 1968); M.Ch. Murray, *Rebirth* (1981); P.C. Finney, *Invisible God* (1994); and R. Jensen, *Understanding* (2000) for examples.

[5] See: Christiane Sourvinou-Inwood, *'Reading' Greek Culture: Texts and Images, Rituals and Myths* (Oxford, 1991), 3-23; Andrew Stewart, Introduction to 'Self-Definition in Hellenistic Art', in Anthony Bulloch *et al.* (eds.), *Images and Ideologies: Self-Definition in the Hellenistic World* (Berkeley and London, 1993), 200; Jay Martin, Vision in Context: Reflections and Refractions, in: Teresa Brennan and Martin Jay (eds.), *Vision in Context: Historical and Contemporary Perspectives on Sight* (New York, 1996), 1-12; Simon Goldhill and Robin Osborne (eds.), *Art and Text in Ancient Greek Culture* (Cambridge, 1994); Jaś Elsner (ed.), *Art and Text in Roman Culture* (Cambridge, 1996); Jeremy Tanner, Portraits, Power, and Patronage in the Late Roman Republic: *Journal of Roman Studies* 90 (2000) 18-50; John R. Clarke, *Art in the Lives of Ordinary Roman: Visual Representation and non-elite Viewers in Italy, 100 B.C.-A.D. 315* (Berkeley, 2003); and Thomas Habinek, Latin Literature between Text and Practice: *Transactions of the American Philological Association* 135 (2005) 83-9.

[6] Ramsay MacMullen, *Christianizing the Roman Empire: AD 100-400* (New Haven, 1984), 21 with n. 14.

[7] Harry Y. Gamble, *Books and Readers in the Early Church: a History of Early Christian Texts* (New Haven, 1995), 4-5, citing William V. Harris, *Ancient Literacy* (Cambridge, Mass., 1989); see also F.M. Young, *Biblical Exegesis* (1997), 10-28, and Raffaella Cribriore, *Gymnastics of the Mind: Greek Education in Hellenistic and Roman Egypt* (Princeton, 2001).

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indicates, Christianity was spread by preaching, and in its earliest period bears more resemblance to an oral tradition or mythology than it does to our familiar form of literacy. The literary culture of Antiquity was also itself profoundly oral in character. Authors wrote or dictated with an ear to the sound of their words and under the assumption that what they wrote would be audibly read both in public reading and in the ancient practice of reading aloud privately. As a result, 'no ancient text is now read as it was intended to be unless it is also heard, that is, read aloud'.[8] Hearing the text read aloud, particularly in the context of the liturgy, was the fundamental way in which all Christians appropriated scripture, not only the illiterate.

The simple ability to read might, however, not actually be a major consideration at all. It is a modern prejudice to assume that once people could read, they would somehow abandon orality and visuality in favor of the textual and literal, that reading trumps all other modes of reception and comprehension. It is as if an ancient Christian who learned to read would, as a result, suddenly turn into Martin Luther – *sola scriptura*! The mere acquisition of reading does not entail the end of aural or visual perception and comprehension, neither does it necessitate the end of the primacy of the aural and visual.[9] In both medicine and philosophy, for example, the 'living voice' of the teacher was considered superior to books as a vehicle for imparting knowledge.[10] Literate and educated persons can be as aurally and visually oriented as those who cannot read. The issue is one of culture, not education.

Texts appropriated through hearing do not possess the fixity of those assimilated and conceptualized according to modern practices of reading. As Frances Young contends, the scriptural text was itself 'symbolic' of a greater and higher reality. Understood 'sacramentally' scripture was a 'linguistic sign' which represented the reality to which it referred.[11] Similarly Averil Cameron states: 'Like visual art, early Christian discourse presented its audience with a series of images. The proclamation of the message was achieved by a technique of presenting the audience with a series of images through which it was thought possible to perceive an objective and higher truth'.[12] Given this understanding, we must be wary in establishing a literal, one-on-one correspondence between

[8] H.Y. Gamble, *Books* (1995), 204. Though silent reading in Antiquity was more common than has generally been thought, see A.K. Gavrilov, Techniques of Reading in Classical Antiquity: *Classical Quarterly* 47 (1997) 56-73. A. Cameron, *Christianity and the Rhetoric* (1991), 73-84 discusses orality in the Christian context; F.M. Young, *Biblical Exegesis* (1997), 10-28 offers a very useful and compendious survey of literacy in the Roman Empire, aural reception, etc.

[9] See J.P. Small, *Parallel Worlds* (1997), 172.

[10] Cribriore, *Gymnastics*, 145-6.

[11] See F.M. Young, *Biblical Exegesis* (1997), 119-30; also A. Cameron, *Christianity and the Rhetoric* (1991), 47-50.

[12] A. Cameron, *Christianity and the Rhetoric* (1991), 57.

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Christian images and scripture. Robin Jensen draws the connection between this form of aural appropriation and art: 'This explains why certain subjects were so often portrayed in abbreviated or unexpected ways. The viewer had already moved beyond the literal meaning of the narrative to its deeper messages. Christians would see for themselves, in pictorial form, the interpretations or symbolic associations they were regularly hearing in their weekly homilies and their baptismal catecheses'.[13] The sacred text, because it was assimilated aurally, lent itself to visuality. The Christians responsible for such works as the catacomb paintings did not use images merely to illustrate their texts or use texts to justify their images. Rather, both these modes of expression and communication were grounded in a common religious experience.[14]

This view of the independence of early Christian images is grounded in ancient painterly practice and the relationship, or lack thereof, between image and text in the ancient Greek world. Illustrating Homer, for example, the 'sacred text' of classical culture, never seems to have been a project of ancient art.[15] Similarly, vase painters virtually never represent a scene found in literature exactly as it is described by the text. Artists operated from their own set of priorities, choosing their inspiration and composing their images as they saw fit, without feeling beholden to the written word.[16] Indeed, in the Greek world, this could even be true of written texts themselves in relation to the events they describe. Recall Thucydides' famous comment on 'making up' the speeches in his history (1.22). Accuracy and fidelity to events or texts in Antiquity lacked our concept of literalism. It can be easy to forget that truth and literalism are really two different things, and no one would be so bold as to call Thucydides a liar on that account. But what if the artist never even laid eyes on a text and drew 'literary' inspiration from oral reading or performance?[17] What if, as artists are wont to do, a painter did not look or think of a text at all but looked instead to other artists' depictions? In that event, 'Classical pictures do not match texts because they were never meant to'. Instead, an artist illustrated a story not a text; the artist recalled and represented a story, not its words.[18]

[13] R. Jensen, *Understanding* (2000), 78.

[14] See F.M. Young, *Biblical Exegesis* (1997), 17-9 on the 'rule of faith' as an extracanonical framework for the reading and interpretation of scripture.

[15] Anthony Snodgrass, *Homer and the Artists: Text and Picture in Early Greek Art* (Cambridge, 1998), ix.

[16] Jocelyn Penny Small, *Wax Tablets of the Mind: Cognitive Studies of Literacy and Memory in Classical Antiquity* (London, 1997), 177-201, esp. 189-91.

[17] J.P. Small, *Parallel Worlds* (1997), 4-5. A notable parallel is the wife of Namatius, sixth-century bishop of Clermont, in Gregory of Tours, *Historia Francorum* II 17.

[18] J.P. Small, *Parallel Worlds* (1997), 157; Albert B. Lord, Memory, Meaning, and Myth in Homer and Other Epic Oral Traditions, in: Bruno Gentili and Giuseppe Paioni (eds.), *Oralità: Cultura, Letteratura, Discorso* (Rome, 1985), 50. See also Peter Stewart, *Roman Art* (Oxford, 2004), 124-5, and M.Ch. Murray, *Rebirth* (1981), 46, 98, 103 for a direct application to early Christian art.

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This pattern of thought and practice in artistic production and its relation to text, expounded in relation to classical Greece, is in concert with the situation described by recent work in early Christian art and literacy. The underlying reason for this is simply that the artists who produced the earliest Christian images operated within the ideas and practices of ancient visual artistry in general. Neither their subject, their inspiration, their patrons, any personal belief that may have had, nor the existence of a Christian sacred text would have required them to depart from the artistic concepts and practice they knew.

Murray, for example, argued that artists who depicted Noah popping out of a box chose to represent the *arca* iconographically as the chest of Danaë, turning the biblical story into a symbol of salvation and resurrection – rescue from certain death – giving it a new depth of meaning by visual means.[19] Arguably, all it would take is one artist. The painters, or tomb-painters, of Rome would likely have known one another and their work. One could easily imagine a painter having been given his first commission by a Christian asking for advice among his comrades with experience in painting Christian tombs. Painters would also certainly use familiar and practiced motifs and styles for analogous scenes, such as using Endymion for Jonah reclining next to his gourd. Vines simply make nice decoration, whether they are Dionysiac or not.[20] Orpheus and pagan shepherd-figures would be rich in funereal meanings, whether they represented the 'Good Shepherd' or not.[21] And what of Jesus' wand in the raising of Lazarus? Clearly, it demonstrates that detailed textual literalism was not necessary. There could be a pagan precedent, or maybe an artist thought it added drama to his scene (and it would only take one artist to do so). We have to admit, to our chagrin, that this detail might actually be unimportant. Perhaps the artist saw a healing or miracle take place using a wand, or heard a story about one. If the artist were a Christian, perhaps the healer he saw was a wandering prophet, or perhaps he saw the leader of his congregation dramatically act out the story in this fashion during preaching or worship. Liturgy and ritual have, I think, been undervalued as sources for Christian artistic representation.

Let me conclude by making a very broad statement. That many early Christian writers were concerned with theology and doctrine is obvious, but what of those believers quite comfortable with the society and culture of the empire, those who, for example, could afford painted tombs? Did they have clear, articulated, and strongly held theological concepts, ones that would exclusively distinguish them from their non-Christian fellows? The earliest Christian art suggests that at least some among them did not. Whether pagan motifs and figures in this

[19] M.Ch. Murray, *Rebirth* (1981), 98-111.

[20] P.C. Finney, *Invisible God* (1994), 185-91, stresses the importance of understanding that tomb paintings present a mixture of images that are decorative, religiously symbolic, and funerary.

[21] On Orpheus, see M.Ch. Murray, *Rebirth* (1981), 37-63; on pagan shepherd-figures, Nikolaus Himmelmann, *Über Hirten-Genre in der antiken Kunst* (Opladen, 1980).

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art carried any sort of 'syncretistic' religious meaning or not, the simple fact is that the Christians who had these tombs painted were clearly not uncomfortable with such images. Might the images reveal a layer of early Christianity invisible in the written sources? One of an easy tolerance of their surrounding culture and its religion?[22] Whatever the case may be regarding this larger question, it is apparent that a broader approach to early Christian art is both well-founded and necessary. We have in past approached Christian art either in a vacuum, studying it only within the confines of Christianity, or only with a view to what made it distinctive from pagan art. We would do better to begin by examining its similarities to classical art and its commonalities in the dynamics and practice of ancient visuality and literacy, rooting it firmly in its social and historical context, as recent studies have begun to do.

[22] It is not my intention to suggest any antipathy between Christian intellectuals or clergy and ordinary believers in this regard, or between writers and image makers, as has been posited in the past; see P.C. Finney, *Invisible God* (1994), 291-2.

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The Drunkenness of Noah and the Patristic Legacy in Text and Art

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On the ceiling at the entrance to the Sistine Chapel is Michelangelo's *The Drunkenness of Noah*, the first of nine scenes depicting Creation, the Fall, and the life of the Patriarch. These scenes are among the best-known works in the history of Christian art. But why should *The Drunkenness*, which does not obviously fit with the others and is not obviously edifying, have been given such prominence? We might have thought, were we to read it through the moralising eyes of the Reformation, that it was placed there to demonstrate that however admirable Noah may have been, he, like everyone else, was also a sinner and that still there was need for the redemptive work of Christ. But this hypothesis is almost certainly wrong. A more plausible explanation lies in the patristic interpretation of *Genesis* 9:20-27. The Fathers were not interested in the passage primarily for its moral teaching. However uneasy the unedifying scene may have made them feel, Noah was for them a paragon of righteousness, and they do not dwell on the drunkenness. Rather, their interest lay in the doctrinal teaching that could be derived from the passage. For Cyprian of Carthage and Augustine, reading the passage allegorically, and for those who came after them in the Latin tradition until the Reformation, the Patriarch in his very inebriation was a type of Christ.[1]

The story is a simple one. We are told in *Genesis* 9:20-27 that following the Flood, Noah planted a vineyard. He drank some of the wine, became drunk, and lay asleep in his tent with his genitals exposed. His son Ham saw him in this condition, and told his two brothers, Shem and Japheth, who took a cloak, laid it on their shoulders, and, walking backwards, eyes averted, covered their father. When Noah awoke from his stupour, he blessed his two worthy sons and cursed Canaan, the son of Ham.

Origen was the first to make a theological virtue of Noah's drunkenness. For Origen it was an intoxication in the Spirit,[2] but he does not go on to make a connection between the drunkenness and the passion, as Cyprian of Carthage was to do. The connection turns on the eucharist. In the course of giving

[1] The passage was less frequently discussed in the Greek tradition. Chrysostom, however, preached a lengthy sermon on it, *Hom. in Gen.* 29 (PG 53, 260-274), in which he gives it a literal-moral reading and makes no connection between Noah and Christ.

[2] *Cant.* III 5 (SC 376, 542).

Studia Patristica XLIV, 9-13.
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instruction in *Letter* 63 about how the eucharist is to be celebrated, Cyprian cites the example of Noah. Reproving those who think that the chalice is to contain water only, Cyprian quotes *John* 15:1, 'I am the true vine', as proof that the blood of Christ is the wine and not the water, and thus that the wine must be included.[3] This is confirmed by the actions of Noah, who 'projected the figure of the Lord's passion because he drank wine, because he was inebriated, because he was made naked in his home, because he was reclining with his thighs naked and exposed, because the nakedness of his father was noticed by his second son and reported outside, but covered by the other two'.[4] Noah thus showed forth 'a type of future truth, drank not water, but wine, and thus expressed an image of the Lord's passion'.[5] It is not clear from the passage how much of the incident Cyprian intends his readers to take as indicating the passion, but he is certain that the Patriarch's drinking of the wine does just that. Playing on the occurrence of the word 'inebriates' in *Psalm* 22:5, 'Your chalice which inebriates, how excellent it is', Cyprian goes on to argue that the chalice of the Lord must contain wine, as 'it inebriates as Noah drinking wine in Genesis also inebriated', although in the case of the chalice, it is an inebriation which makes sober, because it 'raises minds to spiritual wisdom'.[6]

It was Augustine who gave the typological reading of the passage its classic formulation. He refers to Noah's drunkenness on a number of occasions, and reproduces Cyprian's interpretation of the incident in *De Doctrina Christiana* IV 21.[7] In his more lengthy treatments of the passage, in *De civitate Dei* and *Contra Faustum Manicheum*, he gives it a wholly typological reading.[8] In *De civitate Dei* XVI 1, he explains that 'the vineyard planted by Noah, the drunkenness resulting from its fruit, the nakedness of the sleeping Noah, and all the other events recorded in this story, were laden with prophetic meanings and covered with prophetic veils'.

Taking his cue from the wine, as Origen and Cyprian had done, Augustine in *De civitate Dei* XVI 2 canvasses two possible interpretations of the passage. In the first, he links Noah's drinking of the wine with the cup that Christ must drink and thus with the crucifixion. Christ himself 'planted a vineyard about which the prophet says, "The vineyard of the Lord of Hosts is the house of Israel" (*Isaiah* 5:7), and he drinks of its wine. And the wine may be interpreted

[3] *Ep.* 63.2 (CChr.SL 3c, 391).
[4] *Ep.* 63.3 (CChr.SL 3c, 391-2).
[5] *Ep.* 63.3 (CChr.SL 3c, 392).
[6] *Ep.* 63.11 (CChr.SL 3c, 403-4).
[7] CChr.SL 32, 151-2.
[8] In *De peccatorum meritis et remissione et de baptismo parvulorum* II 12, Augustine, keeping to the literal level, acknowledges that Noah truly was drunk and that drunkenness is a sin. But he is concerned lest we blow Noah's failure out of proportion, 'for we read that Noah was once drunk, but God forbid that it should be thought that he was an habitual drunkard' (CSEL 60, 83-4).

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reference to that cup of which he speaks when he says, "Are you able to drink of the cup which I am going to drink?" (*Matth.* 20:22) and "Father, if it is possible, let this cup pass me by" (*Matth.* 26:39) where it obviously means his passion'.[9] The second interpretation is more elaborate:

> Or, since wine is the product of the vineyard, this meaning may be preferable, that from the vineyard itself, that is from the race of the Israelites, was descended the flesh which he assumed for our sake, and the blood, so that he might suffer his passion. 'He was drunk' – that is, he suffered – and 'he was naked'; for then his weakness was laid bare, that is, was made evident. As the Apostle says, 'He was crucified through his weakness' (2*Cor.* 13:4). And that is why he also says, 'The weakness of God is stronger than men and the foolishness of God is wiser than men' (1*Cor.* 1:25). Moreover, after saying 'he was naked' the Scripture adds 'in his own house' (*Gen.* 9:21), thus indicating that Christ was destined to endure the cross and death, at the hands of the people of his own flesh and blood, members of his own family, namely the Jews.[10]

The vineyard is the flesh and blood of the house of Israel that Christ assumes in order that he may undergo the passion for our sake. Noah's drunkenness anticipates Christ's suffering, and Noah's nakedness anticipates the making evident the weakness of Christ. Augustine's quotation of 1 and 2*Corinthians* reflects one of his principal themes, namely that the divine humility, to which the incarnation and passion attest, is fundamental to human salvation. That this took place 'in his house' indicates that it would be at the hands of the Jews that he would be crucified and die. In *Contra Faustum Manicheum* XII 24, Augustine observes that Christ 'had drunk of his own vine that cup that could not pass from him, and has slept in his passion, as in the drunkenness of the folly which is wiser than men; and so, in the hidden counsel of God, the disclosure had been made of that infirmity of mortal flesh which is stronger than men'.[11] It is possible that in the phrase 'slept in his passion', Augustine is alluding to Christ's death, although he may be referring more broadly to the apparent passivity of Christ's divinity in the whole of the passion.

In *c. Faust.* XII 23, Augustine explains that Ham's action in looking at his father is the action of Jews who, 'saw the nakedness of their father, because they consented to Christ's death'.[12] Ham, whose name means *calidus* (hot), also symbolizes the heretics, whose spirit is one of impatience rather than of wisdom,[13] and who declare 'in mockery' what the Christians honour in reverence.[14] Shem and Japheth, by contrast, are those 'who do not see the nakedness of their father, because they do not consent to Christ's death', indeed, they

[9] *De civ. Dei.* XVI 2 (CChr.SL 48, 499-500).
[10] *De civ. Dei.* XVI 2 (CChr.SL 48, 500).
[11] *C. Faust.* XII 24 (CSEL 25, 353).
[12] *C. Faust.* XII 23 (CSEL 25, 351).
[13] *De civ. Dei.* XVI 2 (CChr.SL 48, 498-9).
[14] *C. Faust.* XII 24 (CSEL 25, 353).

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'honour it with a covering'.[15] The drunkenness of Noah unambiguously prefigures the incarnation and passion of Christ.

The Reformation marks a radical shift in the way in which Scripture was read and set the pattern for the Modern approach. Luther's discussions of *Genesis* 9:20-27 provide a telling illustration of the change. The Augustinian interpretation had become a common-place in the Middle Ages. In his first two treatments of the passage, a sermon of 1519 and another of 1523,[16] Luther reproduces the typology of Augustine, although in the second, his focus has changed; he is no longer concerned with what the passage tells us about Christ, but rather with what it tells us about Noah and the nature of salvation. The drunkenness demonstrates that salvation comes through faith and not through works. By 1536, however, in his *Lectures on Genesis*, he places a lengthy attack on the allegorical reading of Scripture immediately before his treatment of *Genesis* 9:20-27 and makes no reference to the typological reading, let alone acknowledging that he had ever employed it.[17] The passage is of interest this time strictly for its ethical teaching. The Patriarch's drunkenness is recorded in the Bible to demonstrate that even the perfect can sin; but the burden of the interpretation no longer lies with Noah but with Ham. Having put the Word and the fear of God out of his heart, Ham no longer has respect either for his parents or for those in positions of authority in either church or state.[18] No reference is made in the discussion to any connection between Noah and Christ.

The representation of the drunkenness in art developed more slowly than it did in text. Only three examples survive from the Early Church. The earliest is the fourth century catacomb fresco in Cubiculum A of the Via Latina.[19] The second, in the *Cotton Genesis* of the fifth century, survives only in charred fragments, but it probably was the model for the mosaics of San Marco.[20] The full story appears to have been depicted, for in the mosaics Noah is shown drinking, followed by the scene of him lying, fully exposed, in his tent and seen by Ham, which in turn is followed by scenes of his being covered, and the cursing and the blessing. His posture is the one he would be given until the sixteenth century – reclining, three-quarters facing, ankles crossed, head supported with his right-hand, either naked or clothed, the narrative context almost always shown.[21] The third is in the *Vienna Genesis* of the sixth

[15] *C. Faust.* XII 23 (CSEL 25, 351).

[16] *WA* 9, 349-50 and 14, 204-208.

[17] *WA* 42, 367-77.

[18] *WA* 42, 377-93.

[19] Antonio Ferrua, *The Unknown Catacomb: A Unique Discovery of Early Christian Art*, trans. Iain Inglis (New Lanark, 1991), 153-8 and pl. 64.

[20] *The Illustrations in the Manuscripts of the Septuagint, Volume I Genesis. The Cotton Genesis: British Library Codex Cotton Otho B.VI*, edited by Kurt Weitzmann and Herbert L. Kessler (Princeton, 1986), 18-29.

[21] Otto Demus, *The Mosaics of San Marco in Venice*, vol. 2: Plates, pt. 2, *The Thirteenth Century*, (Chicago, 1984), pls. 169-74.

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century. There the scene is depicted in much the same way as it is in the *Cotton Genesis*.[22]

In the early Medieval period the scene appeared in manuscript illuminations and occasionally on church walls in Old Testament cycles. But it was not until the early thirteenth century that the typological reading of the passage began to be depicted. In the *Bibles Moralisées*, for example, *The Drunkenness* is paired with *The Mocking of Christ*.[23] In the *Biblia Pauperum*, it flanks *The Mocking of Christ* on the left, *The Derision of Elisha* flanking *The Mocking* on the right.[24] An especially telling use of the image appears in a late fifteenth century manuscript, *The Hours of the Virgin* (Rouen, 1475-90), as the minor illustration to a scene of the nativity.[25] Here it signals that the infant born into the 'vineyard', to reproduce Augustine's usage, is the one who is to die. That it could be so employed without textual explanation suggests how deep-rooted the typological interpretation of the passage had become by the time of Michelangelo.

Finally, a drawing by the Mannerist Maerten Heemskerck of 1559, and a painting by the neo-Mannerist Bernardo Cavallino of c. 1650. In both, the posture of Noah is in sharp contrast to the traditional portrayal. In the former, Noah is seated facing the viewer, not three-quarters facing, legs splayed, and the viewer's eye is drawn to rest finally on the Patriarch's graphically displayed genitals.[26] In the latter, a pendant which forms a pair with his portrayal of a carousing and libidinous Lot and his daughters, the viewer looks down from above along the sprawled figure of the dissipated Noah, from his head, which is in the foreground, to his equally vividly depicted genitals.[27] In these representations, the interest lies in the consumption of alcohol and sexual degeneracy, in the ethical and not the doctrinal significance of the story.

What we see in the tradition of the interpretation of *Genesis* 9:20-27, then, in both text and art, is a movement that takes an apparently unpromising story, redeems it and brings it onto the theological and artistic center stage, only to see it reduced to the realm of historical narrative and morality with the abandonment of the allegorical reading of Scripture in the Early Modern period. The unpromising image, made central to Christian devotional and public art, had fallen. For the Fathers and the Medieval tradition, what was most important about such a text is what it tells us about Christ. For the Reformers and the Modern tradition, what was most important is what it tells us about humankind; christology had given way to anthropology.

[22] Emmy Wellesz, *The Vienna Genesis* (London, 1960), 5-6 and pl. 2.

[23] Gerald Guest, *Bibles Moralisée: Codex Vindobonensis 2554 Vienna, Österreichische Nationalbibliothek, Manuscripts in Miniature No. 2*, (London, 1995), 3v.

[24] Avril Henry, *Biblia Pauperum: A Facsimile and Edition* (Ithica, 1987), c.

[25] ms. Den Haag, 133 D 17, Koninklijke Bibliotheek, The Hague, fol. 41r.

[26] *Tegninger af Maerten van Heemskerk*, coll. cat. (Copenhagen, 1971), pl. 55.

[27] *Bernardo Cavallino of Naples 1616-1656*, ex. cat. (Cleveland, 1985), pls. 14 and 15.

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Superstition and the Significance of the Image of Christ Performing Miracles in Early Christian Art

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From Cicero's *De natura deorum* onward, *superstitio* was the bête noire of classical and patristic literature. In Late Antiquity, the Latin term *superstitio* and its Greek cousin *deisidaimonia* were popularly imbued with a negative valence. Pagans and early Christian writers preferred to describe true religion in philosophical terms while denigrating superstitious behavior. Healings, particularly divine healings, were not categorized under the rubric of *superstitio* in pagan and Christian contexts. In what follows, I will describe the development of the negative characterization of *superstitio*, and illustrate its usage by pagan and Christian authors. Finally, I will introduce the motif of Christ performing healings and miracles in early Christian art of the third and fourth centuries to validate the Christian understanding of *superstitio*. The examples of Christ in early Christian art vividly illustrate the conflict between pagans and Christians, as well as the value of portraying Christ as the dominant healer for the purposes of Christian self-definition. Early Christian art follows the apologists' rebuke of *superstitio*, however the aniconic rhetoric of the apologists apparently went unheeded.

Superstitio and *deisidaimonia* are inextricably linked.[1] Until 69 BCE, *deisidaimonia* and *superstitio* were held to contain similar understandings of the gods and not all uses were negative. The earliest usage of *deisidaimonia* as a noun can be traced to Aristotle's successor Theophrastus around 319 BCE, and it was not exactly unfavorable. In his *Characters*, Theophrastus includes a chapter on *deisidaimonia* that found sheer humor in the eccentricities of superstition.[2] The earliest usage of *superstitio* appeared in 190 BCE, as Plautus used the adjective form *superstitiosis* to refer to prophecy.[3] Around twenty years later, the poet Ennius similarly employed *superstitiosis* to describe 'prophetic' predictions in his work *Alexander*.[4] As the Roman interest in prophecy and oracles grew,

[1] See Morton Smith, Superstitio: *SBLSP* 20 (1981) 350. Also see Pieter G.R. De Villiers and E. Germiquet, *Religio* and *Superstitio* in Early Christianity and Graeco-Roman Society: Christian Perspectives on Paganism: *APB* 9 (1998) 52-69.

[2] Theophrastus, *Characters* 16. The term appears even earlier as an adjective in a similar context in Menander's comedy *Deisidaimon*.

[3] Smith, Superstitio, 349.

[4] See Cicero, *De divinationes* 1.132. Cicero quotes a passage from Ennius connecting *superstitio* to prophecy in his work *Telamo*, but his usage is deceptive. Cicero manipulates the passage

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superstitio evolved into a Latin equivalent to *deisidaimonia* insinuating religious practices distinct from established Roman religion. *Superstitio* and *deisidaimonia* were both assumed as referring to prophecy or divination, not necessarily fear of the gods. Thus from the beginning of its usage, *superstitio*, while connoting a sense of *religio*, was understood as foreign or non-Roman.

Cicero is the earliest author to use the noun *superstitio*, and is primarily responsible for tearing away any understanding of *superstitio* in the positive sense. *Superstitio* is characterized as a baseless fear of the gods while the term for religion, *religio*, is understood as proper and pious worship.[5] Cicero described the origin of the word as coming from *superstes*, meaning 'survivor', from older generations that spend an exceeding amount of time in prayer, clinging on to their excessive piety.[6] The orator affirmed *religio* as a positive expression of the preservation of ritual and tradition in relation to the gods, while *superstitio* is branded as excessive, antiquated, and decidedly negative.[7] In deriding *superstitio*, Cicero cast *religio* in a moral and ethical light that bears a relationship with the authority of the state.[8] Still, senators and wealthy Romans continued to consult oracles, *haruspices* or augurs, as even Cicero related the incident of Tiberius Gracchus summoning the *haruspices* when two snakes appeared in his home.[9] The belief in the ineffable is not absent in Roman *religio*. Cicero and other critics of *superstitio* remained devoted to religion and maintained observance of ritual minus the frivolity that marks superstitious behavior.[10] True *religio* is the realm of stability, indicated by the absence of any fear of the gods.

Into the first century, the negative valence was duly branded upon *superstitio* and is reflected in any further usage of *deisidaimonia*.[11] In both pagan and Christian contexts, *superstitio* became a term to describe an alien cult, or the irrational fear of the gods.[12] In the early second century, Plutarch (or Pseudo-Plutarch) attacked such fear in an essay *On superstition*.[13] The author rebukes *deisidaimonia*, and is particularly concerned with atheism, calling it the most

to highlight *superstitio* as a term of abuse. Vergil utilizes the term *superstitio* in a positive and negative sense in his *Aeneid* 12.817 and 8.187. See Smith, Superstitio, 352.

[5] Cicero, *De nat. deo.* 1.42.

[6] Cicero, *De nat. deo.* 2.28.

[7] Cicero, *De nat. deo.* 2.28.

[8] Cicero, *De nat. deo.* 1.42.

[9] Cicero, *De div.* 1.36. Also see *id.*, *De leg.* 2.33; *id.*, *De div.* 1.127-128.

[10] Plutarch was even a priest at the temple of Delphi late in his years.

[11] A form of *deisidaimonia* is used by the author of Luke/Acts in *Acts* 17:22, and should not be interpreted as a favorable expression. The positive references of *deisidaimonia* faded along with positive instances of *superstitio*, directly after Cicero.

[12] Against the Christians, see Pliny the Younger, *Ep.* 10.96; Tacitus, *Annals* 15.44.3-4; 11.15.1; 13.32.3; Suetonius, *Vita Neronis* 16.2.

[13] The essay has usually been ascribed to Plutarch, but it is questionable whether he is its true author or not. There are strong traces of Epicureanism, and the anti-Apollo rhetoric is something that Plutarch would not author. See Plutarch, *De superstitione*, 170A; 171.

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wretched of all things. However, the author argues that atheism is the direct product from *deisidaimonia*, connecting the two insufferable qualities.[14] *Religio* is the pure ambit that lies between the abominable polarities of superstition and atheism, distinguished by piety and philosophy.

At every opportunity, the apologists attempted to couch Christianity as a *religio* in a similar manner.[15] The understanding of *superstitio* and *deisidaimonia* as terms of abuse persisted into the era of Christianity. *Superstitio* became the comprehensive expression to rebuke non-Christians and cast Christianity as the true religion.[16] The term became less of an articulation of excessive devotion and more of a label connoting religious perversion. Lactantius makes the Christian definition clear.[17] In his opinion, the Ciceronian distinction between *superstitio* and *religio* is far too slight. Pagan *religio* is superstitious since it addresses false gods, while true *religio* is the worship of the one true God.[18] For the church fathers, anything outside of this understanding was *superstitio*. Roman authors implored their audience to abandon atheism and *superstitio* by describing *religio* as the broad, philosophical middle. Christian authors subsequently identified their faith in similar terms occasionally drawing the ire of critics, and discovered the utility of the term *superstitio* to describe anything non-Christian.[19] The aim of the apologists' polemic was to attempt to portray Christianity within that religious mean and not near any polarity.

Pagans and Christians appear united in differentiating divine healing from *superstitio*. Religious miracle stories were abundant in Late Antiquity with healing accounts, arguably, given the most prominence.[20] Pagan miracle stories accentuate healings and indicate that pagans did not consider divine healing as *superstitio*.[21] Similarly, for the church fathers the healings and miracles of Jesus did not fit into the category of superstition. In the patristic sources, one can

[14] Morton Smith, De Superstitione, in: *Plutarch's Theological Writings and Early Christian Literature*, ed. by Hans Dieter Betz (Leiden, 1975), 3.

[15] See Justin, *Apol.* I 2-3 (PG 6, 329-31B).

[16] Justin, *Apol.* I 2 (PG 6, 329A-B); Tert., *Adv. Marc.* 1.9.2 (CSEL 47, 301); *id.*, *Scorp.* 10.6 (CSEL 20, 167); *id.*, *Apol.* 6.7-8 (CSEL 69, 17); notably throughout Minucius Felix, *Octavius*.

[17] Lactantius, *De div. inst.* 4.28 (CSEL 19, 388-91).

[18] *Ibid.*

[19] Such as Celsus' argument that Christianity is not a true philosophy, see Origen, *C. Cels.* 1.3-4 (PG 11, 657-664). Identifying Christianity as a true philosophy certainly was valuable to the apologists and some non-Christians took notice. Galen commented that Christianity should be regarded as a philosophy, see Robert Wilken, "Collegia, Philosophical Schools, and Theology," in *The Catacombs and the Colosseum: The Roman Empire as the Setting of Primitive Christianity*, ed. by Stephen Benko and John J. O'Rourke (Valley Forge, PA, 1971), 277.

[20] There are over twenty references of the healing power of Christ in the four Gospels, the most belonging to Matthew. These do not include miracles or exorcisms, but healings.

[21] Illustrated by the allure and influence it held for sitting emperors, including a healing performed by Vespasian. See Tacitus, *Hist.* 4.81-82; Marcus Aurelius, *Medit.* 1.6; Julian, *C. Galil.* 1:235d. For example, Philostratus, *Vita Apoll.* 7.38; Aelius Aristides, *Orat.* 48.21

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witness a keen interest in purveying a sense of Jesus not only as a healer but as the preeminent healer, hinting at a competition with pagan healing cults, specifically the cult of Asclepius. Celsus speaks of a tangible Asclepius healing men and performing good, forcing Origen to respond using the exact phrasing of his opponent, indicating the impact the subtle comparison carried.[22]

For the apologists, *superstitio* was used as a brush to paint the faith of their rivals as morally incorrect.[23] The apologists diverged from the methods of their contemporaries by targeting the use of cultic images, especially idols. In Rome, Gaul, and North Africa, pagans and gnostics were cast as image worshipers, and guilty of idolatry, a vice that separates the pure from the impure.[24] As in any war of words, the Christian brush was disproportionately applied; not all pagans were idolatrous. The author of *On superstition* regards the use of cultic images in low esteem, although images in varying degrees of capacity were a part of pagan religious practice, not to mention the imperial cult.[25] Nevertheless, the pagan use of images is a weakness the apologists exploited.[26]

The apologists may be considered iconophobic, however early Christians were not fundamentally aniconic. Their main concern was idolatry not imagery. It is uncertain whether the message of the apologists was received or not.[27] The material evidence of the third and fourth centuries can venture an answer, and at least illuminate the common strategies of the two genres. The significant volume of visual art may suggest that the aniconism of the apologists was largely disregarded. It seems more likely that the Christian attitude towards images was not as puritanical as the apologists suggest. The aniconism of the early Christians was endorsed in certain situations when it would provide leverage against their opponents. The motivation to destroy pagan images was not indicative of aniconism. It stemmed from a desire to destroy the groups that observed traditional Roman religion.[28] Attacking idols is not indubitable evidence that early Christians were aniconic. In text and art, mimicry is not the sincerest form of flattery but the cleverest tactic in a war for religious supremacy. Just as pagan notions of *superstitio* were appropriated, non-Christian image use was infused with a Christian understanding, eradicating any patina of idolatry.

[22] Origen, *C. Cels.* 3.24 (PG 11, 947A-C); also see Justin, *Apol.* I 22 (PG 6, 361B); Tert., *Ad nat.* 2.14.42 (CSEL 20, 127).

[23] See Michele Salzman's article, 'Superstitio' in the 'Codex Theodosianus' and the Persecution of the Pagans: *VC* 41 (1987) 172-88.

[24] Justin, *Apol.* I 9 (PG 6, 340A-C); Iren., *Adv. haer.* 1.24.5 (SC 264, 327); Tert., *Apol.* 33-34 (CSEL 69, 82-3).

[25] See Plutarch, *De super.*, 167D-E.

[26] Min. Fel., *Oct.* 2 (CSEL 2, 4); Justin, *Apol.* I 29 (PG 6, 373A-B); Lact. *De div. inst.* 2.4.1-14 (CSEL 19, 107-110); Tert., *De idol.* 3-4 (CSEL 20, 32-34).

[27] Paul Corby Finney, Idols in Second and Third Century Apology: *SP* 17/2 (Elmsford, NY, 1982) 684-7.

[28] Such as the incident of the destruction of the Serapeum in Alexandria ordered by Bishop Theophilius in 391.

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Primary examples of visual art in the catacombs and on sarcophagi from the third and fourth centuries readily portray Christ performing healings and miracles. In catacomb frescoes and sarcophagi frontals, this theme is ubiquitous.[29] The art reflects the supposition of the apologists regarding *superstitio.* Healings and miracles are not considered superstitious and are rather cherished qualities of their chosen deity. Frequently depicted with what appears to be a wand, the images of Christ in the catacombs and on sarcophagi boldly display the melding of supercessionism with pagan and non-pagan influences. Scholars have disagreed concerning whether these images of Christ intentionally recall Asclepius, Cynic philosophers, pagan holy men, or Moses.[30] Any answer does not necessitate one exclusive source. The context of healing suggests Asclepius due to popularity of the cult and the direct comparisons with Christ in Christian and non-Christian sources. The images of the miracle working Christ in the catacombs, with the wand and in close proximity to Moses, may emphasize Christ as the new Moses.[31] In this motif, Jesus is pulling from several traditions, not solely one, and I believe Asclepius and Moses are both intentionally evoked. Evidently, the image of Christ appropriated elements of Christian rivals to supplant them effectively in a visual medium.

The figure of Jesus as the supreme healer and miracle worker was apparently most relevant and palatable to early Christian audiences. Jesus the exorcist skirted the realm of *superstitio*, as did any characterization of Jesus as a magician.[32] Healings, nature miracles, and resurrections were of obvious value due to their applicability to reality, and provisional comfort for the world to come. As opposed to pagan images, these images of Christ were not for temples or public consumption; they were in a funerary environment. They were private monuments for the dead, often the very rich dead. The artisans assimilated styles and themes of Christian rivals to portray Christ as superior to Asclepius the healer and Moses the miracle worker. The art certifies for the dead what they believed in life: they were not atheists nor superstitious, but observed the true Christian *religio* with Christ as the supreme deity.

[29] In the catacombs surrounding Rome and Naples; the sarcophagi are largely found in the Museo Pio Cristiano at the Vatican, and the Musée de l'Arles et de la Provence Antiques in Arles. Friedrich Gerke has charted the progression of representations of Christ in his *Christus in der spätantiken Plastik*, 3rd ed. (Mainz, 1948). Also see David Knipp, *"Christus Medicus" in der frühchristlichen Sarkophagskulptur: Ikonographische Studien der Sepulkralkunst des späten vierten Jahrhunderts* (Leiden, 1998).

[30] In Erich Dinkler, *Christus und Asklepios* (Heidelberg, 1980), 19; Paul Zanker, *The Mask of Socrates* (Berkeley, 1995), 300.

[31] Evident in the catacomb of Via Latina.

[32] Iren., *Adv. haer.* 1.23.4 (SC 264, 321). In the Gospels, Jesus was more interested in healing than in exorcising demons, see *Mark* 9:38. See Morton Smith's, *Jesus the Magician* (San Francisco, CA, 1978); Thomas Mathews, *The Clash of the Gods* (Princeton, NJ, 1993), 54-91, and rebuttals in Paul Corby Finney, Do You Think God Is a Magician? in: *Akten des Symposiums Frühchristliche Sarkophage* (Deutches Archäologisches Institut, 1999), 99-108, and Howard Clark Kee, *Medicine, Miracle, and Magic in New Testament Times* (New York, 1986), 112-14.

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As the apologists appropriated the polemical style of their opponents to assert Christianity as a true *religio*, early Christian art incorporated stylistic influences of their rivals. In text and art, there is a common emphasis on healing and miracle personified in Jesus. Jesus is depicted as the healer and miracle worker *par excellence*, indicating his peerless nature and inculcating faith. Both corpuses of evidence illustrate that healing and miracle working was not the depraved superstition the pagan authors and Christian apologists attacked. In fact, the influence healing and miracle working exerted over the Late Antique public was quite estimable.

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No Animals in the New Paradise? The 'Hall of Philia' from Antioch and the Patristic Exegesis of Isaiah's 'Peaceable Kingdom'

Rocco BORGOGNONI, Firenze

On the 11th May 1934 William Alexander Campbell, the field director for that year of Princeton University's campaign in Antioch, noted in his diary: 'On the left of the Antioch-Daphne road the mosaic crew [i.e. the team in charge of locating mosaics outside the excavation area in danger of being damaged] found a mosaic representing a lion facing a water buffalo, and above the pavement was a section of a marble grill'.[1] When the archaeologists cleared the whole surface area in the days that followed, a mosaic appeared 13m long by 1.70m wide with some parts missing; the granite columns found along with it suggested that the mosaic decorated a long colonnaded hall, that was immediately called the 'Hall of Philia'. The panel, rimmed with a broad border, represents four couples of animals facing each other, a predator and its traditional prey but without any manifestation of hostility: a lion and a zebu, a tiger and a boar, a leopard and a goat, a lioness and a stag and another pair, the only partially preserved visible remains of which are the back end of a bear. The beasts stand out against a plant background of trees and shrubs, with birds flying between them or perched on them. The eye is attracted by a column standing between the first couple of animals that conceals the trunk of a tree at the back, on which the word ΦΙΛΙΑ is inscribed in two lines.[2] Without extending the dig any further, the archaeologists merely lifted the mosaic dividing it into five sections, and then it was obtained by the Baltimore Museum of Art, where it is now exhibited.

The first publications contained very scanty information, and an attempt at interpretation was put forward in 1938 by Charles Rufus Morey, organizer of the 'Committee for the Excavation of Antioch' and chairman of Princeton's Department of Art and Archaeology. His hypothesis was that the ΦΙΛΙΑ inscription

[1] William Alexander Campbell, *Antioch Field Diary, 1934 Season*, unpublished field diary (1934), Department of Art and Archaeology, Princeton University, 168.

[2] Charles Rufus Morey, The Excavation of Antioch-on-the-Orontes: *Proceedings of the American Philosophical Society* 76 (1936) 637-51: 650 and pl. X, fig. 19; William Alexander Campbell, The Third Season of Excavation at Antioch-on-the Orontes: *American Journal of Archaeology* 40 (1936) 1-10: 8 and fig. 10; Richard Stillwell (ed.), *Antioch on-the-Orontes II. The Excavations 1933-1936* (Princeton, 1938) 182 n. 44.

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referred 'to the fighting qualities of the Asiatic buffalo' portrayed alongside, based on Arab chronicles telling of herds of buffalo that were introduced by caliphs in the region north of Antioch, as a means of contrasting the lions that infested the area.[3] Apart from the obvious anachronism, the tame stance of the animals and the equidistance of the inscription between the first two of them immediately made this suggestion implausible.

The explanation put forward by the archaeologist and biblical scholar Roland de Vaux OP, in an article on a mosaic discovered in Ma'in, Jordan, published that same year in *Revue Biblique* is instead more convincing. Although only the hind legs and tail of a bovid appeared in this mosaic floor, there was also a partially preserved inscription from the book of Isaiah that identified the image beyond all doubt with the well-known 'Peaceable Kingdom' described by the prophet (*Isaiah* 11:6-9; 65:25). Then de Vaux introduced parallels between the Ma'in mosaic, an unequivocal version that had come to light in Madaba, and the newly discovered 'Hall of Philia'.[4] De Vaux's interpretation was furthered and added to by Doro Levi in his research at the Institute for Advanced Study in Princeton. Levi acknowledged that the mosaic was the iconographic transposition of Isaiah's paradisiacal kingdom, but the animals were from the pagan repertory. He also provided further parallel examples from the Near East including some non-Christian ones, such as the mosaic floor paving the Beth Alpha synagogue.[5] Consequent to the suggestions of de Vaux and Levi, the mosaic has subsequently been raised to the status of evidence of a mixture of Old Testament motifs and renowned pagan hopes of the restoration of a heavenly age.[6]

De Vaux's and Levi's hypothesis is bolstered by the discovery in both the eastern and western Mediterranean of an increasing amount of this iconography, mostly in the form of mosaics, some of which incorporate the prophet's words.[7] Interestingly enough, though, none of these inscriptions contains the term φιλία, and most of them are found in connection with consecrated buildings (churches or synagogues) where the nature of the place would make captions superfluous and hence explain their absence. Unfortunately, the lack of ulterior archaeological enquiry further to the unexpected discovery of the 'Hall

[3] Charles Rufus Morey, *The Mosaics of Antioch* (London, New York and Toronto, 1938), 42.

[4] Roland de Vaux, Une mosaïque byzantine a Ma'in (Transjordanie): *RB* 47 (1938) 227-58: 233-4 and pl. XI.1.

[5] Doro Levi, *Antioch Mosaic Pavements* (Princeton, 1947), 317-9 and pls. LXXII, CXXX c, CLXXIV a.

[6] Zoltán Kádár, Φιλία τῶν ζώων: *Acta Antiqua Academiae Scientiarum Hungaricae* 16 (1968) 257-70: 262-3.

[7] André Grabar, *L'art de la fin de l'antiquité et du moyen âge*, II (Paris, 1968) 760-2; Michele Piccirillo, *Chiese e mosaici di Madaba* (Jerusalem, 1989), 179, 219; Giovanna Bucci, Mosaici pavimentali del Vicino Oriente con raffigurazioni di animali in pace: *Felix Ravenna*, ser. 4, 153-156 (1997-2000) [Ravenna, 2004] 351-415.

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of Philia' prevents reconstruction of its context. However, some general impressions can be drawn from the mosaic itself and from the few scanty archaeological remains. Though the kind of the building that contained the hall is unknown, the large size and excellent quality of the mosaic work are remarkable, so much so that Marlia Mango deemed it comparable to the peristyle mosaics in the imperial palace in Constantinople.[8] While providing inconclusive evidence as to the type of building that contained them, the columns and the fragment of a marble grill (the discovery of which is published here for the first time) point to it being a construction of some importance.

The only inscription on the mosaic that my comments will focus on here is, of course, the one that holds the key for interpreting the mosaic itself; its very presence shows the patron's intention that the work not be purely decorative. In my opinion, the soundness of de Vaux's and Levi's interpretation can only be tested by viewing the 'Hall of Philia' in the light of exegetical texts on the book of Isaiah written by the Church Fathers in the Eastern Mediterranean, which also open interesting perspectives on the society and culture of Antioch and the Near East. The Old Testament book of Isaiah is known as one on which Christian thinkers produced much explanatory work. Considering only those by Eusebius onwards, the first aspect that emerges is that all surviving commentaries resort to Christological and de-eschatologizing allegories to explain the 'Peaceable Kingdom' despite the animals variously representing (even in the same exegetical work) human moral characteristics, or a series of peoples and beliefs together in the Church, or groupings of a ever more articulate society.[9] Such univocity of so much Christian exegesis must surely have some bearing on understanding the meaning of the mosaic, in particular considering that the representatives of the 'school' of Antioch gravitated around the same metropolis of which Daphne was an affluent suburb. Making the issues understandable to a broader public than the learned by couching the explanations in less erudite texts and serial homilies, for example John Chrysostom's on Isaiah, gave the great mass of the faithful access to allegorical interpretations.

The second aspect, and a partial reappraisal of this, is that some of the comments on Isaiah's passages on the 'Peaceable Kingdom' in late antique exegetical works, such as that by Jerome, were hostile against Jews, judaizing Christians and Millenarists awaiting literal fulfilment of the prophecy – or so at least their critics declared.[10] While part of the debate had its roots in a tradition of dispute or was perhaps conceived as an internal discussion between exegets,

[8] Marlia Mundell Mango, *Artistic Patronage in the Roman Diocese of Oriens, 313-641 AD*, unpublished thesis (D. Phil), Univ. of Oxford, 71 and figs. L-T.

[9] Euseb., *In Isaiam* 1.62; 2.56 (GCS Euseb. 9, 83.33-84.26; 399.20-400.7); Hier., *In Esaiam* 4 (CCL 73, 150.1-153.96); *ibid.*, 18 (CCL 73A, 767.106-769.154); Cyril. Alex., *In Isaiam* 2.1; 5.6 (PG 70, 320D-325B; 1428A-D); Ioh. Chrys., *In Isaiam* 2.2 (SC 304, 106.51-108.60); Theod. Cyr., *In Isaiam* 4 (SC 295, 46.415-48.439); 20 (SC 315, 330.501-512).

[10] See Hillel I. Newman, Jerome's Judaizers: *JECS* 9 (2001) 421-52.

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the urban context of religion in Antioch in the late fourth and fifth centuries was very varied and lively, even though Christianity was growing in importance. The largest synagogue in the city was located in Daphne itself, and attendance by Christians was so high that the matter troubled Chrysostom;[11] in Daphne there were also Christian *martyria* and polytheistic temples and shrines; not to mention sumptuous secular buildings, including an imperial residence and Ardabur's private bath as represented in the mosaic border from Yakto.[12] Antioch was also a fertile arena for followers of Apollinaris, a community still present in the fifth century who held the same Millenarian beliefs with which many Fathers took issue against the bishop of Laodicea.[13] While policies against non-Christian places of worship conducted by Theodosius I must had had some effect and his grandson of the same name proceeded with a temporary confiscation of synagogues, the sophist and member of the urban élite Isocasius stood trial for paganism as late as 468 C.E.[14] and further attacks on the Jews date even later to the end of Zeno's reign.[15] So, the issue of whether patrons and/or beneficiaries of the mosaic were not only 'orthodox' Christians also depends on chronology. While Janine Balty still backs Levi's initial proposal of dating it to the fifth century,[16] it was suggested that it be considered of the sixth century. In the sixth century, however, the cultural and religious climate of the city changed definitively; indeed the large synagogue in Daphne was razed to the ground in 507 C.E. and replaced by a *martyrium* of St Leontius, and persecution and trials against pagans from Antioch increased.[17]

In the light of this there is little likelihood that an iconography of this kind adorning a floor in the surroundings of late antique Antioch be neutral. The same doubt on the many ways of interpreting early byzantine images of the natural world and whether they should be taken literally or allegorically was raised twenty years ago by Henry Maguire. He also considered the standpoints of the Church Fathers and opted for prudence in allegorizing, except when there are clear signs supplied by designers and craftsmen in the work itself.[18] None of the explanations offered by the Church Fathers used the word φιλία to define the new relationship between animals/men or animals/peoples but

[11] Robert Louis Wilken, *John Chrysostom and the Jews: Rhetoric and Reality in the Late 4th Century* (Berkeley, Los Angeles and London, 1983), 37.

[12] Glanville Downey, *A History of Antioch in Syria from Seleucus to the Arab Conquest* (Princeton, NJ, 1961), 83, 472, 642-3, 656-9.

[13] Laurence Vianès-Abou Samra, L'eschatologie d'Apollinaire de Laodicée à travers les *Fragments sur les Psaumes*: *AnnSE* 21 (2004) 331-71.

[14] Downey, *A History*, 483-4; *PLRE* II, 633-4.

[15] Downey, *A History*, 499.

[16] Janine Balty, *Mosaïques antiques du Proche-Orient: Chronologie, iconographie, interprétation* (Paris, 1995), 106.

[17] Downey, *A History*, 506, 623, 558-9, 563-4.

[18] Henry Maguire, *Earth and Ocean: The Terrestrial World in Early Byzantine Art* (University Park, 1987).

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there were a few resorting to abstract terms, including Cyril of Alexandria's δμοψυχία. By contrast, the adjectives φίλος and φίλιος appear in Nonnos of Panopolis' *Dionysiaca*, in a scene of Bacchic dancing where wild and tame animals join together joyfully on the occasion of Beroe's birth, even though it has been suggested that the Egyptian poet could have been influenced by the biblical theme.[19] Needless to say, however, it was not necessary that the mosaic follow the commentary to the letter, including that of its terminology, for it to portray its basic meaning. Furthermore, the original imagery of Isaiah's text clearly speaks of the absence of deadly danger, beginning with the offspring of the stock of Jesse, and the generic term φιλία is often found in Greek to mean non-hostility between beasts, as appears in Aristotle's zoological works or in the *Physiologus*.

The issue remains, however, as to why there was no unambiguous reference to a Christian context (we are unsure that the building containing such a large and well-made mosaic was indeed a church); or why, more simply, Isaiah's verses were not quoted as they were elsewhere. If they had been, they would have ruled out any possibility of an interpretation not referring directly to the Old Testament, including polytheistic ones, while leaving open the issue of an allegorical or literal reading of the scene. On the contrary, while φιλία is attested in connection with animal ethology it still has what those viewing the mosaic would have felt as a strong human connotation. Likewise the animals of Nonnos are represented anthropomorphically as Bacchantes. This could have led to an allegorical interpretation of the image, especially given the absolute absence of the humans described in the original biblical text, while not ruling out other ways of interpretation. The question is whether the 'classical' heritage of the Golden Age should be seen exclusively in a purely formal and literary idiom by the same kind of allegorical shift through which the *Oratio ad sanctorum coetum* saved Virgil's Fourth Eclogue in the footsteps of the Church Fathers.[20] Or could we go so far as to allow an ambiguity and a multiplicity of meanings acknowledging a possible pagan interpretation of the picture in accordance with processes somehow like those sketched by Jaś Elsner about some pieces of late antique art?[21] This would place the mosaic at the crossroads of different religious and cultural traditions, sacrificing none of them, confirming de Vaux's and Levi's suggestion and distancing the iconography's patrons and intended viewers culturally (and perhaps chronologically too) from the accusers of Isocasius and those who attacked the Jewish community; as well as from those exegets and polemicists who rejected a literal interpretation of

[19] Non. Panop., *Dionysiaca* XLI 185-211; Domenico Accorinti (a cura), Nonno di Panopoli, *Le Dionisiache*, IV (Milano, 2004), 160.

[20] *Oratio ad sanctorum coetum* 20 (GCS Eus. 1, 183.14-16).

[21] Jaś Elsner, *Art and the Roman Viewer: The Transformation of Art from the Pagan World to Christianity* (Cambridge, 1995), 249-87.

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the 'Peaceable Kingdom'. However, the question of whether the mosaic floor of the 'Hall of Philia' contains further evidence of that 'kind of miracle' of cohabitation and cultural interlacing that characterized the late antique Near East as Glen Bowersock's latest fascinating book suggests,[22] is too early to say – further study is required.

[22] Glen Bowersock, *Mosaics as History: The Near East from Late Antiquity to Islam* (Cambridge, MA, 2006), 122.

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The Issue of περιχώρησις in Byzantine Holy Images

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This article will study Byzantine aesthetics and its intrinsic affiliation to the Church fathers' dogmatic reflections on and interpretations of 'divine' and 'human'. It will explore how the theology of ὀρθοδοξία, 'sound doctrine' and 'the traditional and universal doctrine of the Church' is deciphered into Byzantine image theology. Foci are on how Byzantine holy images reveal the notion of περιχώρησις (Lat. *communicatio idiomatum*) in the sense of: (1) 'interpenetration' of divine and human in the God-man, and the holy drama; and (2) 'coinherence' of the three divine ὑποστάσεις of Father, Son and Holy Spirit. A cardinal hypothesis is that Byzantine aesthetics originates in how the Church fathers define and hand over the orthodox tradition.

John Damascene when considering the Annunciation refers to the Theotokos as a 'divine temple',[1] and the Akathistos Hymn proclaims, 'We see the holy Virgin as a torch full of light, shining upon those in darkness. For by kindling the immaterial light she guides all to divine knowledge...',[2] she is a 'container of the uncontainable God' (θεοῦ ἀχωρήτου χώρα),[3] and 'a living temple'.[4] She 'gave birth to the light',[5] and is thus honored as an 'immovable tower of the Church' and an 'impregnable wall of the kingdom'.[6] The liturgy announces on the Feast of the Virgin's *koimesis*: 'The source of life is laid in the grave and her tomb becomes a ladder to heaven'. In addition, Christ is believed to personify the living heaven, whereas the Church and the church building, as alleged by Patriarch Germanos, signify heaven on earth.[7] From an orthodox standpoint the body of a church thus connotes both divine and human. It is Theotokos' orthodox manner (ὀρθοδόξως) of actions towards God and her pure body that constitute the physical substratum for the Incarnation and the Passion that reopens the gate[8] to heaven. When light, the prime metaphor for divine transcendence, interpenetrates the church building it is therefore possible

[1] *Homilia de dormitione BMV* 2.17 (SC 80, 166-7).

[2] *The Akathistos Hymn* 21.1-4, in Leena Mari Peltomaa, *The Image of the Virgin Mary in the Akathistos Hymn* (Leiden, 2001).

[3] *Ibid.* 15.6.

[4] *Ibid.* 23.2.

[5] *Ibid.* 3.14.

[6] *Ibid.* 23.13-4.

[7] Patriarch Germanos (PG 98, 381-2B).

[8] See *Ez.* 44:1-4.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 27-34.
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to regard this as an apophatic meta-image of the Incarnation, a paradoxical indication of God beyond concepts, of the divine that no human being can neither explain through thoughts nor words, logic or images.

Basil the Great declared that the lives of saints 'lie before us like living images (εἰκόνες) of God's government, for our imitation (μιμήματι) of their good works'.[9] Since a holy image portrays the saints and narrates their lives, a holy image in a quite like manner constitutes a locus for mimesis of the lives lived by those who are closest to God. Yet, as Basil calls to our attention, things begun in time also end in time, and since the creation begun in time we cannot doubt its end.[10] His point of course is that everything created is inevitably exposed to corruption (φθορά). It is thus out of dogmatic necessity that the semiotics of Byzantine aesthetics implies causality between divine and human. If Byzantine representations would be characterized by an exclusive mundane corporeality they would ask for mimesis of that which is temporal, between two events (διάστημα), and leave aside that which connotes the eternal divine.

Chalcedonian Christology (451) defines the relation of two natures in Christ through four negative adverbs: 'without confusion' (ἀσυγχύτως); 'without change' (ἀτρέπτως); 'undividedly' (ἀδιαιρέτως); 'inseparably' (ἀχωρίστως).[11] Christ is true God and true human. Belief in this reciprocity of human and divine is what grants each believer salvation and eternal life in the kingdom of God as well as authorizes anthropomorphous images of Christ. The immanent God, i.e. the indwelling presence of God in the world, and things created constitute didactic vehicles for reaching knowledge of God who is both invisible (divine) and visible (human). To promote knowledge of and facilitate encounters with God and the saints a holy image should reveal this twofold Christian reality.

Gregory of Nyssa underscores, heaven and earth meet in Christ through the power of the Theotokos' virginity, and God and humankind is forever brought together.[12] The Incarnation took place in time and space, yet, it has implications beyond that which is created and circumscribed by time and space. In the writings of the Fathers it is clear that the holy drama is 'beyond' (ὑπέρ) the laws of interval (διάστημα), i.e. the laws of corruption (φθορά) that constrains everything created. The holy drama of God in the world is characterized by active interpenetration (περιχώρησις) of human and divine. Byzantine religious aesthetics thus mostly repudiates from authentic delineation of space and corporeality. Corporeality should not distract actions towards God but serve to reach experience of deification (θέωσις). The believer should contemplate the

[9] *Letter* II (Basil to Gregory of Nazianzos), in: *Saint Basil: The Letters*, Roy J. Deferrari (ed. and Eng. tr.) (Cambridge, Mass., 1950), 1:15.

[10] *Homilia in Hexaemeron* 1.3, Eng. tr. Agnes C. Way in (FC 46), 7.

[11] Gr. tr. in *PGL*.

[12] *De virg.* 2.3.

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image so to raise from the visible temporal to the invisible divine. In accordance with Basil the Great's remark, the honor paid to the image should pass on to the prototype,[13] and not to the material and tactile image itself. Beauty in a holy image is what contributes to divine wisdom (σοφία), experience of the eternal beauty of God's spiritual activity. To support my conclusion I refer to Basil the Great's declaration that beauty to God is what is brought to perfection according to the principle of art and which contributes to the usefulness of its end.[14] What a holy image should do, as John Damascene emphasizes, is to lead us through matter to the immaterial God.[15] If the believer is exclusively entangled in material and physical beauty the believer will be kept in spiritual darkness. The icon then serves as an idol not a holy image.

In his treatises on the Divine Images John Damascene underscores, 'it is impossible to make an image of God who is incorporeal, invisible, immaterial and with neither shape nor circumscription nor apprehension; how can what cannot be seen be depicted?'[16] Yet, he is indubitably conscious of the intricate and mystic interpenetration of divine and human in Christianity. Thus, he also emphasizes the necessity of depicting 'in bodily form what is invisible and bodiless, because we cannot behold the bodiless without using shapes that bear some analogy to us... For we see images in created things intimating to us dimly reflections of the divine.'[17]

St John's disparate statements enlighten us on the precarious assignment of delineating or teaching on the immaterial uncreated divine reality of the Godhead. Regardless of Christian dogmas in words or in image, it is impossible not to consider the divinity (θεολογία) of God. Yet, imagery didactics on the divine have to be apophatic, beyond concepts not to trespass against the orthodox causality between dogma and image. An apophatic meta-image of the triune divine is for example, the inundation of light through a tripartite window interpenetrating the image (εἰκών) of the church, or a coinherent triune light effect of brilliance in images of Christ with the three-armed golden cross inscribed within a golden nimbus. In both cases we can observe how three become one through interpenetration and coinherence (περιχώρησις) of light and brilliance as apophaticisms for the invisible and incomprehensible trinitarian God of one substance (οὐσία) in three Persons (ὑποστάσεις). For patristic authority I turn to Gregory of Nazianzos' poetic definition of the trinitarian doctrine: 'In three suns which penetrate one another, single would be the light',

[13] *Lib. de Spiritu sancto* 18.45 (PG 32, 149).

[14] *Hom. hex.* 3.10, Eng. tr. Way in (FC 46), 53.

[15] *De sacris imaginibus orationes* 2.23, in: Andrew Louth, *St John of Damascus: Three Treatises on the Divine Images* (Crestwood, N.Y., 2003), 77. A Swedish translation by Olof Andrén, with introduction by A. Karahan, was published in Skellefteå 2008, Johannes Damaskenos. Tre försvarstal mot dem som förkastar de heliga bilderna.

[16] *Ibid.* 2.7 (see 3.4).

[17] *Ibid.* 3.21 (see 1.11). See *Rom.* 1:20.

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for the Word and the Spirit are two rays of the same sun, or 'rather two new suns'.[18] In addition to the didactics on the Trinity (what God is) the prime Christian significance of Christ and the cross is of course indisputably Incarnation and Cross-death, i.e. salvation and resurrection to all believers. Other features in monumental mosaics or murals that can be regarded as apophatic meta-images for the uncircumscribed divine are vegetal and geometric patterns that integrate narration with images of saints and different effects of light and brilliance. Examples are to be found in San Vitale, Ravenna (c. 547), Hosios Loukas (early tenth century), Daphni (c. 1100), Byzantine Cappadocia, and the Chora Church, Istanbul (early fourteenth century). The potentiality of uncircumscription lies in these patterns lack of closed formula. Features from the visible world, leaves, flowers and geometric figures as well as the squared form that signifies the Four Corners of earth interact with the potential of uncircumscription, the timeless eternity of the divine paradise that through the blood of Christ will be granted all believers. Other apophatic meta-images for the incomprehensible divine are circles and triangles, as well as features such as gold, pearls and gems that create brilliance, especially when interacting with flickering candle lights or light entering through windows in walls or cupolas. When images of holy persons, narration and apophatic meta-images of the neither perceptible nor understandable transcendent divine interact in room and space περιχώρησις is implied in the sense of both οἰκονομία, Christ's redeeming activity in death and resurrection, and θεολογία, the teachings about God, the divinity.

There is a great difference between κήρυγμα, proclamation of the gospel that can be openly announced and narrated, and δόγμα, the esoteric significance of God that is only known to a few.[19] For the Christian believer it is possible to understand the reality of the corporeal God-man, yet, as proclaimed in the dogmas, to fully understand or make accurate images of the immaterial Trinity is impossible. The transcendent Trinity is regarded to be above and independent of the universe, uncircumscribed (ἀπερίγραφος) and eternal, inexplicable and beyond taxonomy. Thus to teach about the Trinity in painting without being convicted of heresy demanded an extraordinary aesthetic approach that avoided concretion and materialization of God's supreme transcendence (ὑπεροχή).

I would like to argue that in a like manner as the fourth-century Cappadocian fathers used apophatic theology to reach God beyond reason and words, Byzantine aesthetics used apophatic meta-images for teaching on God's triune transcendence.[20]

[18] Discussion in Vladimir Lossky, *Orthodox Theology: An Introduction* (Crestwood, N.Y., 1989), 46.

[19] See Basil the Great, *De Spir.* 27. 66.

[20] See Ari Ojell, *One Word, One Body, One Voice: Studies in Aphophatic Theology and Christocentric Anthropology in Gregory of Nyssa* (unpubl. PhD thesis) (Helsinki, 2007).

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According to sound doctrine and the traditional and universal doctrine of the Church (ὀρθοδοξία) God is often referred to in terms of light and brilliance. It is thus no coincidence that effects of light and brilliance constitutes the foremost meta-image for the divine. The uncircumscribed, non-tactile and immaterial characteristics of natural light, brilliance of gold, silver and gems, and complementary colors that mixed together ideally produce white color were the best suited for the didactic role of the Trinity.

The theology of the ὁμοούσιος becomes prominent in Nicaea – albeit not with Nicaea, but only years later – as a result of a debate that was initiated by Apollinarios of Laodikeia in response to the over-monadic theology of Markellos of Ankyra and Photinos.[21] The final interpretation of the term ὁμοούσιος, 'of the same substance', the Son and the Father are identical in essence, co-essential, i.e. the Son is fully divine, is also particularly associated with the theological substratum that characterizes the modes of thought of Basil the Great, Gregory of Nyssa, and Gregory of Nazianzos.[22] The Cappadocian father Gregory of Nazianzos discusses the Trinity's properties and the interchangeable relationship of three divine persons, while Gregory of Nyssa focuses on the Holy Spirit's divinity and consubstantiality,[23] as well as on the generation of the Son from the Father.[24] Gregory of Nyssa identifies three divine ὑποστάσεις that share in one concrete, identical divine substance (οὐσία). For God is one. Since, 'if we observe,' he underscores, 'a single activity of Father, Son and Holy Spirit in no respect different in the case of any, we are obliged to infer unity of nature from the unity of activity.' Difference among the ὑποστάσεις rises out of their mutual relationships – the Father is Cause, the Son is of the Cause directly, the Holy Spirit of the Cause mediately. 'The question of existence is one and that of the mode of existence is another,' Gregory of Nyssa emphasizes, to elucidate that his notion of 'cause' does not imply division in nature. He discusses the relations of distinction within the divine existence and the operations of the Godhead extending from the Father, through the Son and in the Holy Spirit.[25] Gregory of Nyssa confirms that the Son 'is linked to' (συνάπτεται) the Father, and the Spirit 'is in touch with' (ἔχεται) the Only-begotten.[26] Father, Son, and Spirit are recognized as forever with one another in a perfect trinity

[21] For this information I am indebted to Markus Vinzent; see Georg L. Prestige, *St. Basil the Great and Apollinaris of Laodicea* (London, 1956); Reinhard M. Hübner, *Der Paradox Eine: Antignostischer Monarchianismus im zweiten Jahrhundert* with contribution by Markus Vinzent (Leiden, 1999), 211.

[22] On development and use of the term ὁμοούσιος, see Philip Rousseau, *Basil of Caesarea* (Oxford, 1994), 94-132; Frances M. Young, *The Making of the Creeds* (London, 1991); G.L. Prestige, *God in Patristic Thought* (London, 1952), 197-218.

[23] *The Oxford Dictionary of Byzantium* (Oxford, 1991), 1.379.

[24] See *C. Eun.* 1.26, Eng. tr. in NPNF-2, 5. 70.

[25] Discussion and Eng. tr. by Leo Donald Davis, *The First Seven Ecumenical Councils (325–787)* (Wilmington, Delaware, 1990), 113-4.

[26] *C. Eun.* 1.42.

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'consequentially and conjunctively' (ἀκολούθως καὶ συνημμένως).[27] Three divine persons but one 'nature' (φύσις), God, Gregory of Nazianzos states.[28] Their basic 'unity (ἕνωσις) is the Father, out of whom and towards whom are reckoned the subsequent Persons, not so as to confuse them but so as to attach them'.[29] Gregory of Nazianzos sermonizes that in the Godhead there is complete identity of substance among the persons, but they are distinct because each differs in relation to origin. The personal property of the Father is to be unoriginate, whereas the Son is originate from the Father, and the Holy Spirit proceeds or goes forth from the Father in a manner different from that of the Son[30].

To explain the ὁμοούσιος concept Basil introduced the distinction of one οὐσία (substance) in three ὑποστάσεις (Persons). He argued that μία οὐσία τρεῖς ὑποστάσεις was the only acceptable formula.[31] To Basil, οὐσία denoted the existence or essence or substantial entity of God, while ὑπόστασις signified the existence in a particular mode, the manner of being of each Persona.[32] Basil the Great explained the term ὁμοούσιον as relational – the divine οὐσία is the Father's οὐσία, shared with the Son by begetting him and with the Spirit through procession.[33] Basil declared that faith confesses distinction in ὑπόστασις and community in οὐσία; ὑπόστασις relates to the individuality of each, whereas οὐσία relates to the principle of community.[34] Basil identified the idea of coinherence of the ὑπόστασις one within the other and accentuated the properties of the three ὑποστάσεις Fatherhood, Sonship and Sanctification.[35] Rousseau emphasizes that 'it was the quality of 'being related' that claimed priority, and problems connected with the mode of generation were of less significance – indeed, they were, in the end, beyond understanding and should not even be discussed.'[36] Apophatic meta-images of the Cappadocians' interpretations of the trinitarian issue are for example the community and flux of light that appears when beams of light penetrates a tripartite window and three become one, or when coinherence of brilliance shines from three golden cross-arms inscribed in a golden nimbus (triune relational activity). Or, as in the motif of the Anastasis in the Chora Church, Istanbul, where the light mandorla that surrounds Christ is divided into three consecutive zones of light blue, light

[27] Greg. Nys., *De Spiritu sancto contra Macedonianos* 12, Eng. tr. in G.L. Prestige, *God in Patristic Thought* (1952), 255.

[28] *Oratio* 42.15 (SC 384, 82).

[29] G.L. Prestige, *God in Patristic Thought* (1952), 254-5.

[30] L.D. Davis, *The First Seven Ecumenical Councils (325–787)* (1990), 117.

[31] The formula implies that the one substance of God is fully and equally possessed by each Persona, Father, Son and Holy Spirit, see Basil. Caes., *Hom.* 24.4 (PG 31, 605B).

[32] Johannes Quasten, *Patrology* (Westminster, Maryland, 1994), 228.

[33] *Letter* LII, in *Saint Basil: The Letters*, Deferrari (1950), I 332-4.

[34] *Ep.* 38.5.

[35] L.D. Davis, *The First Seven Ecumenical Councils (325–787)* (1990), 114.

[36] *C. Eun.* 2.20-22, discussion in Ph. Rousseau, *Basil of Caesarea* (1994), 107.

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gray and white color (three divine ὑποστάσεις), formerly also studded with golden stars (shared brilliance indicating the one οὐσία). The coloration of the mandorla produces a beaming light effect that is in coinherence with the light effect of Christ's garments drawn in the same coloration as the mandorla. A tripartite window below the motif intensifies the meta-image of the divine light. Through the apophaticism of brilliance three become one, as to imply the impetus of the trinitarian God of one οὐσία, an active coinherence and communion of divine trinitarian transcendence. The Cappadocian Fathers' modes of thought on the ὁμοούσιος issue – Gregory of Nyssa's identification of a divine existence characterized by the Godhead's operations extending *from* the Father, *through* the Son and *in* the Holy Spirit, or Gregory of Nazianzos' identification of an interchangeable relationship of three divine persons with reference to their *relation of origin*, or Basil the Great more articulate identification of *a supra-mundane particular mode of each of the three persons* – identifies a meta-physical, triune relational supramundane reality, and not merely a similarity of being that answers to the implication of the belief in the ὁμοούσιος in holy images.

In my doctoral thesis I have explored other subtle meta-images for the Trinity, at the Chora Church.[37] Four motifs, the Bearing of the Ark of the Covenant, the Installation of the Ark in the Holy of Holies, and two scenes of Moses and the Burning Bush, are set into a conceptual and triangular spatial relation within the tectonic body of the parekklesion. Through space, geometry and color is the believer taught of the triune divine not possible to draw, perceive or understand. Other examples are: the well with three curved vertical faces of consecutive steps in purple (God's common οὐσία), in the motif of the Annunciation to the Virgin at the Well, and reoccurring *tituli* with the notion of ἡ χώρα in the sense of uncircumscription and uncontainable with regard to Christ Pantokrator and the Theotokos.

Since Christian faith teaches about one triune protagonist, God, there is always the omnipresence of the anthropomorphous Christ. The apophatic meta-image of brilliance can never be the sole protagonist, because as stated in Matthew's gospel, Christ said – 'All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me'.[38] Thus even an image of the Pantokrator manifests apophatically both interpenetration of human and divine, and coinherence of the three divine ὑποστάσεις of the Trinity.

If contemplated beyond matter the material beauty of an image carries a potential to create spiritual beauty in the beholder. This is why the value of gold, stones and gems lie primarily in their ability to create brilliance, and not

[37] Anne Karahan, *Byzantine Holy Images and the Issue of Transcendence and Immanence*, (unpubl. PhD thesis), 2005, 231-6, to be publ. by Peeters Publishers, in Orientalia Lovaniensia Analecta, No. 176.

[38] *Matth.* 28:18.

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in them being the most costly of matters. Authentic temporal beauty that might ensnare the believer in temporal instead of spiritual beauty is incongruous with the theology of ὀρθοδοξία. Spiritual experience beyond ocular perception can only those reach who purify and open their hearts for communication with God. For patristic authority I refer to Gregory of Nyssa, *Sermon of the Beatitudes*, who emphasizes that those who want to see the radiant divine light must purify their hearts and remove from the eyes of their souls the darkness caused by material entanglements. A pure heart will help the soul perceive the transcendent brilliance of God, Gregory writes. The anticipation of the Beatific Vision, the greatest knowledge of the supreme Beauty will be granted those who through κάθαρσις, purification and relentless struggle against sin prepare themselves for a return to the original image of God in humankind.

The antithesis of spiritual darkness is luminous darkness that imparts potentiality for communication with God. When discussed focus is on two passages in the Scriptures: 'He made darkness his covering around him, his canopy thick clouds dark with water' (*Psalm* 18:11), and Moses' ascent of Mount Sinai to meet with God who reveals himself in luminous darkness.[39] In *Vita Mosis* Gregory of Nyssa emphasizes that what enables Moses to meet with God is the luminous darkness, since it impedes from a deadly face-to-face encounter with God.[40] In line with this interpretation of luminous darkness I see a parallel to how the material covering of a holy image prevents the believer from dying of communion with God. The luminous darkness of a holy image conduces heaven and earth to meet in a similar way as heaven is believed to have been interacting with earth in the Incarnation.

[39] *Ex.* 19:18-24, 'Mount Sinai was wrapped in smoke, because the Lord had descended upon it in fire ...'

[40] See *Ex.* 33:20, God said, 'you cannot see my face; for no one shall see me and live'.

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Images of Jews and Christians in the Seventh Century: The *Narratio de Imagine in Beryto* and its Context[1]

István M. BUGÁR, Debrecen

The subject of my paper is a document that can with good reason be dated to the seventh century, a period of multifarious change. It is a homily attributed to Athanasius of Alexandria on the conversion of the Jewish community of Beirut[2] as a result of an icon-miracle.[3] The text was quoted at Nicaea II,[4] and used widely as a sermon for the Sunday of Orthodoxy in Byzantium after 843.[5] Preachers, however, unlike the fathers of the Council, were not philologists and thus handled the text in a way similar to the performance of Byzantine chant; the established pattern left enough space for the performer for an individual interpretation. There are four old printed editions, but no thorough research on the complicated textual history has been previously attempted.[6]

In the ninth century the text reached the Latin West through a translation of the Acts of Nicaea II and became extremely popular.[7] The homily survives also in Church Slavonic,[8] while Armenian[9] versions and Syriac reminiscences[10]

[1] The research leading to this paper has been made possible by the generous support of the Fondation MSH. My expenses of participating at the conference were covered by the Hungarian National Research Found (OTKA T049128). I am particularly grateful for the kind advices of Vincent Déroche and for the help of the colleagues at the IRHT, Paris.

[2] For (earlier) data on Jews in Antioch, see Samir Kassir, *Histoire de Beyrouth* (Paris, 2003), 61-2; for an Arabic source on the story see *ibid.* 65.

[3] CPG 2262; BHG^{na} 780-789; 1389.

[4] Mansi 13, 24e-32a.

[5] Several manuscripts provide explicitly this rubric, while in other collections the place of the sermon in the Lenten cycle shows its function.

[6] I could track down 115 manuscripts, which represent four types of text: the basic version represented by Mansi 13, 24-32 and PG 29, 805-812 (group α). Variants appear to indicate that not all versions derive from the Acts of Nicaea. The basic text has been ornamented in different ways and to different extant; a rather extreme and atypical example is printed in PG 29, 797-805 (group β). An unedited group (γ) rewrites the text entirely, while preserving traces of the exemplar. Attribution to Athanasius occasionally disappears. A final, high-style anonymous reworking is dated to the late tenth century and edited by Ernst von Dobschütz, Eine Fastenpredigt über das Christusbild von Beryt: *Zeitschrift für wissenschaftliche Theologie* 45 (1902) 382-94.

[7] Ernst von Dobschütz, *Christusbilder* (Leipzig, 1899), 282** n. 2.; see BHL 4227.

[8] See CPG 2262.

[9] See BHO, 100.

[10] Wallis Budge, *The History of the Blessed Virgin and the History of the Likeness of Christ which the Jews of Tiberias Made to Mock at* (London, 1899), I 166-73; II 185-94.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 35-40.
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show its spread in Oriental Christianity. The translation of the miraculous image of the story to Constantinople as a result of the campaigns of John Tzimiskis is reported by the historian John the Deacon, who, in his turn, repeats the story with his own words.[11]

It is tempting to connect our *Homily* with the *Questions to Antiochus* (*QAD*),[12] similarly attributed to Athanasius. The *QAD* and our homily are indeed associated in the iconophile florilegium of *Codex Par. gr. 1115*.[13] Further, the *QAD* appears to allude to the event described in our sermon by asking rhetorically: 'How a lifeless panel (στήλη) receiving an arrow (βέλος), drew forth blood?'[14]

However, the origin and date of the *QAD* is a 'thorny question' itself,[15] and the case of *Question* 39 is even more complicated; at least its place is unstable in manuscripts within a sub-series of questions dealing with the comparison of Christianity with other religions, mainly Judaism, where the problem of the veneration of the cross is addressed among others.[16] The relevant themes are well known from the Christian-Jewish polemical literature of the late sixth and the seventh century. Besides quoting an edifying story from the *Pratum Spirituale*,[17] the *QAD* here appears to be especially dependent on the well-known polemical writings of Leontius of Neapolis from the first third of the seventh century.[18] Thus it is in the Jewish-Christian polemical context that the problem of images is raised in the *QAD*, like in Leontius. Although the questioner in the case of the *QAD* is a Christian, there is no need to think of the Iconoclastic Controversy. Problems often discussed in the fervent Jewish-Christian debates – whether real or imaginary –, were internalized by Christianity. And indeed, in the seventh century images became a leading issue in Jewish-Christian debates, unlike before. The cause of this may be double. First, the growth of the role icons played in Christian worship,[19] second, a gradual an-iconic turn in Judaism.[20] The Jewish-Christian debate has thus contributed to the outbreak

[11] Leo Diaconus, *Hist.* X 4-5 (166,23-168,3 Bonn); see *Patria Constantinopoleos*, ed. T. Preger III 213.

[12] E. v. Dobschütz, *Christusbilder* (1899), 280** n. 2.

[13] This manuscript begins by verbal quotation but then gives a largely abbreviated and altered story: 254rv: see Alexander Alexakis, *Codex Parisinus Graecus 1115 and its archetype* (Washington D.C., 1996), esp. 170-2.

[14] *QAD* 39 (PG 28, 621).

[15] Anastasios Sinaites, *Quaestiones et responsiones*, ed. Munitiz CCSG 59, LII with further literature. For other views see V. Déroche, Polémique anti-judaïque et émergence de l'Islame (7e-8e siècles): *REB* 57 (1999) 156-8, and Hans Georg Thümmel, *Die Frühgeschichte der ostkirchlichen Bilderlehre* (Berlin, 1992), 247-52. For reasons I cannot detail here, I prefer his earlier dating for the original text, which was different form that printed in PG.

[16] *QAD* 40; see esp. 43.

[17] C. 45.

[18] H.G. Thümmel, *Frühgeschichte* (1992), 136; see *ibid.* 240-1; 368-73.

[19] See esp. Averil Cameron, Images of Authority: *Past and Present* 84 (1979) 3-35.

[20] See Günther Lange, *Bild und Wort* (Würzburg, 1968), 62-3, but see Steven Fine, Iconoclasm and the art of the late-ancient Palestinian synagogues: *JRA* Suppl. 40 (2000) 183-94.

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of iconoclasm in the next century.[21] So even if the reference to bleeding images in the *QAD* were not borrowed directly from our *Homily*, we still have come closer to the context of the latter.

Next, a number of similar stories from roughly the same period comes to our aid, the first of which is related by Gregory of Tours, in his *De gloria martyrum* 21. Several motives of our story reappear also in a Coptic sermon attributed to Theophilus of Alexandria,[22] which appears to predate the Arab conquest.[23] There, however, it is a panel depicting the Virgin, which is maltreated by the new Jewish tenant of the flat. Finally, a narrative about a Jew stabbing an image in the Hagia Sophia and then throwing the bleeding panel into the well may also come from the pre-iconoclastic period. The conversion of the guilty, contained in some versions, may belong to the original form here as well.[24]

E. Kitzinger, who first connected Gregory, our *Homily* and the Coptic sermon, thought of the same story being amplified, eventually confused during the Iconoclastic Controversy, or even later.[25] However, the stories, despite the parallel motives, are far from being identical. The conclusion is especially different: in Gregory the attacker is executed, in our *Homily* the sick of the Jews are recovered and than the entire community converts, in the *Coptic* text cures follow later, while the Jew converts as a result of the blood-miracle alone. In the two latter the icon is not in a church, but left over by a Christian in an apartment. Such events may not have been uncommon, as witnessed by a historical source, according to which in the eleventh year of the reign of Maurice Jews were banished from Antioch, because a new Jewish tenant of a flat had allegedly humiliated an icon of the Virgin by passing urine on it.[26] Or, St. Adomnan reports a story heard by Arculf in Constantinople in the 670s:[27] a Jew saw an icon on panel depicting the Virgin in somebody's flat, and having learnt whose portrait it was, he took it and threw it into a latrine before himself using it. We have no information, says Adomnan, about his later life, but the image has been rescued and cleaned, and still emits oil, as seen by Arculf.[28]

Thus, it appears that – as opposed to abstractly amplified tales – our story echoes a very vivid and concrete historical situation: the Jewish-Christian

[21] See V. Déroche, Polémique (1999), 161.

[22] CPG 2625.

[23] William H. Worrell, *The Coptic Manuscripts in the Freer Collection* Part II (New York-London, 1923), 125-6; see Katarzyna Urbaniak-Walczak, Zwei verschiedene Rezensionen der Homilie über die Auferstehung der Jungfrau Maria von Theophilus von Alexandrien: *Göttinger Miszellen* 101 (1988) 73-4.

[24] Patrick Andrist, Les Objections des Hébreux: *REB* 57 (1999) 123-39.

[25] Ernst Kitzinger, The Cult of Images in the Age before Iconoclasm: *DOP* 8 (1954) 84-150, 101 with n. 59.

[26] Agapius de Manbidj (PO 8, 439-40). See Gilbert Dagron, Introduction historique: *Travaux et Mémoire* 11 (1991) 17-46, 19.

[27] IV 5 (CChr.SL 175, 233-4).

[28] In a preceding story: *ibid.* VI 4 (CChr.SL 175, 229-31).

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polemics of the late sixth-early seventh century, of which we have ample sources.[29] Further, where would Leontius take his reference to bleeding images? Hardly from Gregory. Rather, by his time such stories were common. Gregory is, however, revealing in a different way. In the West a similarly fierce Jewish-Christian debate took place somewhat earlier, in the second half of the sixth century.[30] Gregory's story must reflect exactly this conflict. One might even venture that the iconoclasm of bishop Serenus of Marseilles at the end of the century grew out of these polemics.[31]

A comparison with a further edifying story is telling. Anastasius of Sinai[32] recites how an Arab occupier of the church of St. Theodore at Carsatas shot an arrow (σαγίτας) against the icon of the saint. Neither he nor his company repented seeing the blood emitted by the wound, thus they all died. Here, just like in Gregory, in Leo Deacon's version of the Beirut episode, its Syriac reworking,[33] or in Arculf's narrative, there is no conversion. It is obvious that the concerns of the author of our sermon, but also to some extent those of the Coptic story were quite different.

Leontius in his early career (before 640) was active in Alexandria in the circle of St. John the Almsgiver, Patriarch of Alexandria, whose *Vita* he composed.[34] N. Baynes[35] drew attention to a testimony from John Moschus's *Pratum Spirituale*,[36] where Moschus speaks about a certain Cosmas, who possessed the greatest private library in Alexandria and was engaged in composing polemical writings in order to convert Jews. Leontius may well have been employed in Cosmas's enterprise. In fact, the imperial efforts of the period to enforce religious unity[37] culminated in the forced baptism of Jews under Heraclius, a measure highly debated in its time and apparently not applied widely.[38] Events, like the Persian conquest of Palestine, also highlighted how problematic Jewish-Christian relations were. No wonder that the issue drew interest of people of

[29] Vincent Déroche, La polémique anti-Judaïque au VI[e] et au VII[e] siècle: *Travaux et Mémoire* 11 (1991) 275-311 (esp. 275-97); see Patrick Andrist, Répertoire des manuscrits de polémique antijudaïque: *Byzantion* 70 (2000) 270-306.

[30] G. Dagron, Introduction (1991), 34-8.

[31] See Gregory the Great, *Epistulae I-II Sereno* (CChr.SL 140, 768; 140A, 873-6). For Pope Gregory's role in the Jewish-Christian controversy of the time see G. Dagron, Introduction (1991), 35-6.

[32] François Nau, Le texte grec des récits utiles à l'âme d'Anastase (le Sinaïte): *Oriens Christianus* 3 (1903) 56-75, n. 44, 64-5.

[33] See n. 10 above.

[34] See Vincent Déroche, *Études sur Léontios de Néapolis* (Uppsala – Stockholm, 1995), 117-53.

[35] Norman Hepburn Baynes, *Byzantine Studies and Other Essays* (London, 1960), 226-39.

[36] C. 172 (PG 87/3, 3040D); see G. Lange, *Bild und Wort* (1968), 63 and Averil Cameron, Byzantines and Jews: *BMSC* 20 (1966) 249-74, 262-4.

[37] A. Cameron, Images (1979), 3-35; G. Dagron, Introduction (1991), 17-8.

[38] *Ibid.* 30-2; Andrew Sharf, Jews in Byzantium, in: *Jews and other minorities in Byzantium* (Ramat-Gan, 1995), 52-79, 58.

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the period, as witnessed by further stories of Moschus.[39] In Alexandria, still a place of learning and of the encounter of Christian, Jewish and Pagan thought, a sign of the vivid intellectual conflict can be the dialogue of John, bishop of Thessalonica.[40] Beside these indicators, the attribution of our text and its Coptic parallel to the famous patriarchs of Alexandria, Athanasius and Theophilus, respectively, also points to Alexandria as a probable milieu.[41]

After setting the sermon into a context, let me return to its telling. It has turned out that the author expresses his definite optimistic views on the possibility of Jewish conversion. He suggests that this cannot be forced, but only voluntary and by inner conviction. He cites Titus 2:4 to the effect that God's will is the salvation of all. He accepts the charge of *christoktonoi* against Jews by saying that it is not only hereditary, but they would repeat it given the possibility. A comparison with a discussion in the *QAD* is conducive: there it is stated that only baptism exempts one from inheriting one's ancestors's sins.[42]

Our author goes further: he proves that even the sin of *christoktonia* is forgiven, in the spirit of Christ's words on the Golgotha: 'Forgive them, for they know not what they do' (*Luke* 23:34 RSV). The infinity of God's mercy is reinforced in the preface added in some manuscripts: our sins compared to God's mercy are like sparkles to the ocean.[43] This may be expressed also by the fact that we see a *palindrome* of Christ's passion: the suffering of the icon is followed by the repetition of nearly all of Christ's miracles – just the other way round than in Jesus' life.

The liturgical connotations are especially powerful. The humiliation of the image is a re-enactment of the passion, just like in the Byzantine rite of the *proskomydia*, the preparation of the holy gifts by the priest before the divine liturgy. This is strengthened already in the preface by the motive of the darkening of the Sun, which is repeated in an intermezzo at the peak of the narrative. Quotations from the creed reinforce the liturgical allusions. The appearance of Christ's blood alludes to the anaphora and the communion, while the mixing of blood with water may refer to the rite of the *zeon*.

The sermon reflects the general tendency of the period emphasising the physical meaning of incarnation[44] as opposed to certain monophysite tendencies, Judaism and later Islam. When the author at the peak of the story breaks the narrative with his own comments, he compares the miracle just occurred to the incarnation. Already at the *Quinisexta* council icons became the main

[39] C. 176.

[40] A.H. Armstrong, Some Comments on the Development of the Theology of Images: *SP* 9 (1966) 117-26.

[41] The epithet 'archbishop of Alexandria' is missing from the title in the manuscripts of the Acts of Nicaea II, where the actual book is produced and read out exactly.

[42] *QAD* 67 (PG 28, 633-6).

[43] E.g. Oxford, Lincoln D. gr. 1, fol. 116^{v}; Vind. hist. gr. 38, fol. 108^{v}.

[44] A. Cameron, Byzantines (1966), 267; see Germanus, *Ad Thomam* (PG 98, 168C-D).

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witnesses of incarnation,[45] thus the distinguishing mark of Christianity. Humiliating icons is thus a pendant of their veneration: a visible sign of one's relation to Christianity and the doctrine of incarnation, a powerful expression of this attitude.

[45] Canon 82 (Mansi 11, 977sq).

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The Doctrine of the Icon-Eucharist for the Byzantine Iconoclasts

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In light of the Byzantine Iconoclasts' rejection of icons, one may wonder in what way the Iconoclasts perceived the Eucharist as being an image of Christ's body[1] yet the real body and blood of Christ. If for the Iconoclasts the Eucharist is an image which is *almost* reality, where did this Iconoclast concept of the Eucharist as an image come from, what does this "almost" mean and what exactly is the theology behind this notion?

Robert Taft noticed a massive inclusion of Antiochean elements in the liturgical exegesis of Patriarch Germanus in eighth-century Constantinople.[2] Thus, in search for theological predecessors of the Iconoclastic Eucharistic doctrine we may turn to the Antiochean tradition and to the liturgical exegesis of Theodore of Mopsuestia. Indeed, a passage from the main Iconoclastic doctrinal source – the *Horos* of the Council of Hiereia (754) – resembles the Eucharistic doctrine of Theodore of Mopsuestia. Let us compare two texts starting with Theodore of Mopsuestia:

> Indeed, the body of our Lord, which is from our own nature, was previously mortal by nature, but through the resurrection it moved to an immortal and immutable nature. When the priest, therefore, declares them [bread and wine] to be the body and the blood of Christ, he clearly reveals that they have so become by the descent of the Holy Spirit, through whom they have also become immortal, inasmuch as the body of our Lord was after the Resurrection.[3]

In the *Horos* of Hiereia the Eucharistic gifts are as well paralleled with the body of Christ in that they too are 'anointed' by the Holy Spirit, furthermore, the role of the priest as mediator is clearly stressed:

[1] The doctrine of the Eucharist as an image can be found in the writings of Constantine V (PG 100, 333B, 336A, 337A); the main passage can be found in the *Horos* of the Iconoclastic Council of Hiereia (*Mansi* 13, 261DE, 264A-C). The basic study on the Iconoclastic doctrine of the Eucharist is: Stephen Gero, The Eucharistic Doctrine of the Byzantine Iconoclasts and Its Sources: *Byzantinische Zeitschrift* 68 (1975) 4-22.

[2] Robert Taft, The Liturgy of the Great Church: An Initial Synthesis of Structure and Interpretation on the Eve of Iconoclasm: *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 34/35 (1982) 45-75.

[3] Ed. and trans. Alphonse Mingana, *Commentary of Theodore of Mopsuestia on the Lord's Prayer and on the Sacraments of Baptism and the Eucharist*, Woodbrook Studies 6 (Cambridge, 1933), 104 (hereafter: Mingana) = eds. Roger Devreesse and Raymond Tonneau, *Les homélies catéchétiques de Théodore de Mopsueste: reproduction phototypique du Ms. Mingana Syr. 561 (Selly Oak Colleges Library, Birmingham)*, Studi e Testi 145 (Rome, 1966), 553 (hereafter: Devreesse-Tonneau).

Studia Patristica XLIV, 41-46.
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The bread of the Eucharist, as true image of his natural flesh through the coming of the Holy Spirit, becomes consecrated divine body, while a priest who makes the anaphora mediates in the transferring [of the bread and wine] from the realm of the profane to the realm of the holy. As the natural animated and rational flesh of the Lord was anointed into divinity by the Holy Spirit, the same way the divine bread, the divinely-handed icon of his flesh, is filled with the Holy Spirit together with the chalice of life-giving blood from his side.[4]

The notion of the Eucharist as the real body and blood of Christ on the one hand, and sign and symbol on the other, can be found in several passages of Theodore of Mopsuestia.[5] The Antiochean doctrine of the Sacraments as a symbol, *typos*,[6] which is rooted in the reality it signifies, seems to be derived from the doctrine of two *katastases* or two states of reality: the state of mortality, corruption, and corporeality in the present age, and the state of immortality, impassibility, and spirituality in the future age, where Christ has already entered after His Resurrection. The ultimate parallelism between the type and the archetype highlights the role of the priest in Theodore's exegesis: the celebrating priest offers the Eucharistic sacrifice as a representative of Christ, the high priest, who offered His own Body as a sacrifice at his death on the Cross.

The Eucharist for Theodore of Mopsuestia serves as the *image* of Christ's body which was transformed after His Resurrection, the image given to us as a token of future realities or as a seed of a future plant.[7] The material Sacraments correspond to our state in a material *katastasis* whereas Christ as first-born from the dead already exists in a different, glorious state of reality. What does this mean in terms of the qualities of Christ's Resurrected body? Theodore of Mopsuestia gives the answer – just like ours in the future, it has been transformed from the material state of this *katastasis* into the spiritual state of the spiritual *katastasis*:

... incorruption, glory and power will come then to man through the working of the Holy Spirit, which affects both soul and body, the former with immortality and the latter with immutability; and that the body which will rise from the dead and which (man) will put on will be a spiritual and not a natural body (1*Cor.* 15:42-4).[8]

Yet, we can assert the influence of the Antiochean Sacramental theology upon Iconoclastic Eucharistic doctrine only if we can also find the traces of the doctrine of *two katastases* in Iconoclastic theology. If we can show that the Iconoclasts also believed that Christ's body after his Resurrection is a 'spiritual'

[4] *Mansi* 13 (264B-C).

[5] Mingana, 72 (467 Devreesse-Tonneau), see Mingana, 74 (473 Devreesse-Tonneau). The debate on the Sacramental theology of Theodore is summarized in Frederick McLeod, The Christological Ramifications of Theodore of Mopsuestia's Understanding of Baptism and the Eucharist: *Journal of Early Christian Studies* 10 (2002) 41-50.

[6] See Mingana, 17 (325 Devreesse-Tonneau).

[7] Mingana, 98 (537 Devreesse-Tonneau), see *ibid.* 65.

[8] Mingana, 56 (423-5 Devreesse-Tonneau).

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body, then we will be able to explain why the consecrated host is a consubstantial *image* of that intangible body, and for the Iconoclasts the material gifts of the Eucharist correlate not to the material unresurrected body of Christ, but are the icon of the body of Christ already resurrected, the way it exists now.

The doctrine that Christ after the resurrection abolished his earthly existence according to the flesh is reflected in the *Horos* of Hiereia and other Iconoclastic texts.[9] The Iconoclastic *florilegium* of Hereia contains a Scriptural verse that pertains to the Iconoclastic understanding of the dichotomy between Christ's state after the Resurrection and ours still expecting it: 'If we knew Christ according to flesh, now by no means we know Him (as such)' (2*Cor.* 5:16). The same Scriptural verse is discussed in the second *Antirrheticus* of Theodore the Studite. Theodore's Iconoclast uses the verse for supporting the utter incircumscribability of Christ after his Resurrection stating that the visibility of Christ's body to the Apostles after the Resurrection can be explained not by the tangibility of Christ's resurrected body but rather by God's condescension to human weakness which needs to see God in corporeal form, in a way, as a miracle against the nature of Christ's resurrected state, similar to Prophets' visions of the divinity in corporeal form in the Old Testament, and these visions do not possess any dogmatic value for the justification of images:[10]

> Using the means of condescension, the Lord showed himself to the Apostles after his Resurrection having the properties of his body, but neither in coarseness nor in circumscription: thus he was seen in the midst of them while the doors were closed, and again he became invisible for them.[11]

In addition to these implicit occurrences of the two *katastases* doctrine, the *Horos* of Hiereia explicitly testifies to the concept of the two different states of Christ's body, held by the Iconoclasts. In the Iconoclastic formula of the Christological union in the *Horos*, the Iconoclasts mention Christ's soul that mediates 'between the divinity and the coarseness of flesh (σαρκὸς παχύτητι).'[12] And yet, in the *anathema* of the same *Horos* Christ's body is described as 'God-like' (θεοειδεστέρον) and without 'coarseness' (ἔξω παχύτητος).[13] The possible reason for the seeming discrepancy of these two texts is that the Iconoclasts in two descriptions of Christ's body must have meant the body in different states: the coarse one before the Resurrection (in the Christological formula), and the subtle, 'God-like' body after the Resurrection (in the anathema). These two different doctrines of Christ's body expressed by one Council in one *Horos* point to the doctrine of two *katastases*: the first description related to the reality of

[9] *Mansi* 13 (285B-C).

[10] PG 99, 365A.

[11] PG 99, 384D. The argument occurs in a fragment from the *Peuseis* of Constantine V, which alludes to the same scriptural passage from *John* 20:19-23 (PG 100, 437B).

[12] *Mansi* 13 (257A-B).

[13] *Mansi* 13 (336D).

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the historical Incarnation, and the second one is related to the future, when Christ will come to judge the living and the dead in a body transformed after his Resurrection.[14]

Having established a tentative connection between the Iconoclastic doctrine of the Eucharist and the Sacramental theology of the Antiochean school, we should turn to the last question: What is the relation between the consecrated host and the real body of Christ, or, in other words, how do the Iconoclasts themselves qualify the difference between the two. The Iconoclastic Emperor-theologian Constantine V stated, first, that the consecration transforms bread and wine from the realm of things 'made-by-hands' to the realm of things 'not made-by-hands',[15] and, second, that the Eucharist is a legitimate image since it is consubstantial with its prototype – Christ's flesh.[16] The term 'not made-by-hands' (ἀχειροποίητος) seems to develop a particular meaning in the controversy suggesting the Iconoclasts' peculiar doctrine on Christ's resurrected state. The New Testament depicts the resurrected body, particularly of Christ, as a house or a tabernacle 'not made-by-hands'.[17]

Can we reconstruct what happens with bread and wine after their consecration and transformation into things *not made-by-hands* according to the Iconoclasts? Constantine V calls the Eucharistic gifts not Christ's body and blood themselves but the *typoi* of that body. By making the distinction, Constantine V seemed to imply that consecrated bread and wine in a certain aspect are different from Christ's body and blood, in spite of their mutual consubstantiality and by the common quality of being *not made-by-hands*. Since the host, both before and after the consecration, is circumscribable, palpable, limited by the dimensions of space and made of 'coarse' matter, it is possible to suggest that the difference between the host and the body of Christ according to the Iconoclasts must have been precisely in those characteristics. The iconoclasts held the 'coarse' host as the consubstantial image, or 'icon', of Christ's subtle, resurrected body. There is no contradiction in the holy gifts being called both the *typoi* of Christ's body and consubstantial with it if we take into account the Antiochean notion of *typos* which is precisely such an image that has its ontological part in reality. We can present our hypothesis on the Eucharistic doctrine of Constantine V in the following scheme:

Material, made-by-hands (χειροποίητα)	bread and wine before the consecration: 'antitypes of the true things' (*Hebr.* 9:24)

[14] Vladimir Baranov, The Theological Background of the Iconoclastic Church Programmes: *Studia Patristica* 40 (2006) 169-72; *id.*, The *Vita Tarasii* as a Source for Reconstruction of the Iconoclastic Theology, in: *Universum Hagiographicum: Mémorial R. P. Michel van Esbroeck, s.j. (1934-2003)*, eds. Alexey Mouraviev and Basil Lourie, Scrinium 2 (St. Petersbourg, 2006), 334-9.

[15] PG 100, 337C.

[16] See PG 100, 225A.

[17] *Mark* 14:58; 2*Cor.* 5:1.

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Material, not made-by-hands (ἀχειροποίητα)	the same bread and wine after the consecration as consubstantial *typoi* of Christ's body and blood (σῶμα κατὰ θέσιν)
Immaterial, not made-by-hands (ἀχειροποίητος)	the subtle spiritual body of Christ after his Resurrection (σῶμα κατὰ φύσιν)

It is very tempting to create an ideal aniconic model based on the Antiochean doctrine of the two *katastases*. Indeed, any kind of reality rendered by means of pictorial representations reflects *this* mutable world whereas the main message of the whole Gospels is to present and attract a Christian to another Heavenly immutable and incorruptible world. The best way to do it and the best language to use is verbal language primarily (as did Jesus Himself), or in case of a visual message – the language of symbols and signs (and primarily the sign of the Cross, invoking the core doctrines of the Christian faith – Immolation and Resurrection).

An attempt to connect the apparent lack of interest towards religious images in the Church of the East with the doctrine of the two *katastases* was made by Irénée-Henri Dalmais.[18] However, as any model, it tends to play down the value of certain archaeological evidence on the presence of religious images in the 'Nestorian' Church. Yet, this archaeological evidence,[19] poses difficulties with its interpretation and dating, and these uncertainties do not allow one to conclude the opposite, namely, the wide-spread cult of images in the Church of the East.

To conclude: In two places of the *Horos* the flesh of Christ is described in seemingly contradictory terms: in the Christological union the flesh is 'coarse', whereas when Christ comes for the last judgement, his flesh will be 'out of coarseness'. The seeming contradiction can be resolved if we take them as relating to different periods of Christ's life: unconfused union and 'coarse' flesh *before* Christ's resurrection, and the same flesh becoming subtle, luminous, and deified *after* the Resurrection. Such a doctrine can be identified with the Antiochean teaching on two *katastases* or two states of reality.

This doctrine pre-conditioned the whole of the Iconoclastic Eucharistic theology. To 'false' icons, the Iconoclasts contrast the 'true' one – the bread and wine of the Eucharist consecrated into Christ's body and blood. Since the real body of Christ after his Resurrection is spiritual and incircumscribable, able to

[18] Irénée-Henri Dalmais, Un 'aniconisme nestorien'? Une legende et son interprétation, in: *Nicée II, 787–1987: Douze siècles d'images religieuse*, Nicolas Lossky and François Boespflug (eds.) (Paris, 1987), 63-71.

[19] Jean Dauvillier, Quelques témoignages littéraires at archéologiques sur la présence et sur le culte des images dans l'ancienne église chaldéenne: *L'Orient Syrien* 1 (1956) 297-304; Emmanuel Delly, Le culte de saintes images dans l'église syrienne orientale: *L'Orient Syrien* 1 (1956) 291-6; Kenneth Parry, Images in the Church of the East: The Evidence from Central Asia and China: *Bulletin of the John Rylands University Library of Manchester* 78.3 (1996) 143-62.

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appear and disappear, coming through closed doors, the circumscribable host of the Eucharist may only be an image of such a body, albeit a consubstantial image. The process of the consecration transforms bread and wine from the realm of things *made-by-hands* into *not made-by-hands*, whereas icons without such consecration remain in the realm of things *made-by-hands*, the term used in many places for the description of Pagan idols by the Bible.

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II. Tools

Martin George & Katharina Bracht

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Mneme Database Church History: A Presentation

Martin George, Bern & Katharina Bracht, Munich

1. What you need

Most patristic scholars are engaged in teaching church history. Probably you share our experiences with multimedia support in lectures. Students are not satisfied by listening to oral communication only. There is often an express wish for didactical support of the teacher's message through visual media. As a lecturer cannot always offer exciting stories illustrating his point verbally, she or he needs to make up for it with pictures, maps, diagrams, or with audio clips in a PowerPoint presentation – in a word, with a multimedia offer. Students in lectures appreciate it a lot, if the media presentation is concise, if it does not interfere with but supports the oral communication, and if particularly important parts of it are printed out and given to the students.

Also e-learning systems are growingly popular. In an internet site installed for the students of a course, the teacher provides selected contents of his or her lectures that were presented by PowerPoint, other electronic means, or handouts before, and thus provides support for the students preparing for their examinations.

All this is attractive and certainly valuable from a didactic perspective, if done in just dimensions, limited to meaningful information, not overplayed for the sake of entertainment. But how does one manage all the work connected with it? First you have to find material which is significant and meaningful, suitable and of high didactic quality; then you have to scan it, maybe modify it according to your needs and insert it into your PowerPoint presentation. Also it is imperative to find a way to administrate all the material collected in the course of a teaching life at university. All this takes an incredible amount of time, discouraging many colleagues to try to enhance their lectures and seminars by using multimedia support.

2. What we offer

Mneme Database Church History offers materials to fulfil these needs: It contains pictures, maps, and diagrams, plus many of the most important source texts in the original language and in a modern translation (as a rule in German or English). The material covers all periods of Church History, from the Early

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Church up to Modern Times, with an emphasis on the Patristic period. We have tested all the material in our lectures and seminars, and we have put into the database only those materials that proved to be didactically meaningful, sorting out those which, after a course was held, proved unfit to our own opinion or were ill received by the students in their evaluations of our courses. Thus the material finally taken into *Mneme Database Church History* is double-checked by professors and students. Everything a user finds in *Mneme Database Church History* then is, as it were, 'ready to use': Download it and insert it straight away into your PowerPoint presentation or your e-learning system. That saves many hours of searching, scanning, and modifying, and will make it easy to fascinate students with quality didactical material. As a matter of course, *Mneme Database Church History* is non-commercial and designed strictly for use in teaching only.

3. How the project started

We are currently teaching Church History at different universities, Martin George at the University of Bern, Switzerland, Katharina Bracht at the LMU Munich, Germany. Yet some time ago we had to teach similar introductory courses of 2000 years of Church History at our respective universities during the same term. So we decided to join our efforts and prepare our lectures together. We founded a pool of digitalized didactic material to which the two of us gave input and which both of us used alike. When we told other professors and lecturers in Church History about it, they were interested to have access to it. So we thought the time fit to open our pool to others engaged in teaching Church History or the History of Christianity at university level and to transform our initial project into a proper database.

4. Mneme Database Church History

4.1. *The structure of the database*

Mneme Database Church History is classified into four distinct menus: 'Chronology', 'Geography', 'Individuals' and 'Topics'. The database contains mainly material for teaching university students. But as many of our students are going to be teachers in schools or adult educational institutions, we have also included material which may be useful for general teaching of church history. You will find a corresponding category 'Resources for Religious Education' on the bottom of the base menu (see fig. 1: Base Menu).

These main menus allow to browse *Mneme Database Church History*, if you need material concerning a certain period of Church History, or a certain

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geographical site, or a certain person, or if you look for material about a specific subject occurring across various periods of time. In this last case you look up under 'Topics'.

The menu 'Chronology' consists of seven submenus: Pre-Christian Times, Ancient Church and Middle Ages (both of them again subdivided according to the common periodisation of these eras), followed by Reformation/Early Modern Europe, Modern Times, 19th and 20th Centuries, and Postmodern Times (see fig. 2: Chronology).

The menu 'Geography' consists of submenus according to continental or regional classifications on the one hand, and political classifications on the other hand. A certain location thus is classified according to its geographical position and/or according to its being a part of a historical political entity such as the Roman Empire (see fig. 3: Geography).

A most important menu next to 'Chronology' is the menu 'Topics'. Here you find different topics which we have taught and which generally are to be taught in Church History Courses. You will find general subjects such as 'Christian Art and Architecture' or 'Christian Doctrines and Theology', and special subjects such as the 'Persecution of Christians', 'Heresies and Sects', etc. (see fig. 4: Topics).

4.2. *Searching the database*

We invite you to an example of a particular search. Let's suppose that you have to teach about the persecution of Christians in the time of the Early Church and that you are looking for the rescript of Roman Emperor Trajan as your main source text as well as for significant illustrations.

STEP 1: You log in with your name and your personal password.

STEP 2: You choose 'Search' and type the keyword you are looking for, e.g. 'Trajan'.

STEP 3: The result of your search will at first be shown on an image desk. Here you can see six so-called thumbnails (i.e. miniature images) indicating that you have access to a list of Roman emperors in both pdf and doc formats, to the rescript of emperor Trajan (i.e. Pliny the Younger, *Epistulae* X 96f.), also in both pdf and doc formats, and finally to pictures of a statue of Trajan and of a coin from the time of his reign, both as jpg files. All of these six thumbnails are ready for your download!

STEP 4: If you are especially interested e.g. in the coin, you can zoom in onto this thumbnail. You see larger pictures of the coin's front and back on the left, and you are provided with additional information on the right, in this example with title, subtitle, classifying keywords, description of the object, electronic format, type of media (here: picture), and information as to the copyright status of the database's documents.

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STEP 5: When you have finished browsing the database having found what you were looking for, you press the download button and download the didactic material you need. Everything is ready to use for PowerPoint presentations, for e-learning documents, and for printed handouts.

4.3. *The Didactic Quality of the Research Results*

The quality of the didactic material you download depends not only on the selection and precision of texts and translations, maps, tables, and photographs of artefacts and documents, but also on the concise description of the object presented. Take again as an example the coin of Roman emperor Trajan mentioned in 4.2., steps 3 and 4. The description of the object would here decode the abbreviations on the front and back of the coin, in order to demonstrate the conflict of conscience Christians experienced when using such a coin as currency for their shopping and trading. The front reads around a crowned male head: IMPCAESNERVATRAIANAUGGERM, characterizing the ruler as IMPerator (supreme commander), as CAESar (person of great dignity), named after NERVA (adopted by Nerva AD 97), himself being named TRAIANus, as AUGustus (worthy of veneration), and as GERManicus (victor over the Germans). The back reads around a female figurine of fruitfulness: P.M.TR.P.COS. III.P.P., characterizing Trajan further as Pontifex Maximus (high priest in charge of religion in the Roman Empire), endowed with TRibunica Potestas (tribune of the people, the plebeians), as COnSul III (for the 3rd time around AD 105), and as Pater Patriae (father of the homeland). With this description it becomes plausible why Christians would have problems even using simple coins which claim that the emperor is to be venerated and followed as high priest of Roman state religion.

5. How to join the *Mneme Database Church History*

It is easy to join us – the only important principle to note is that we are running the database on the principle: 'Do ut des' – I offer in order that you offer as well.

If you are interested in using the database, you have to sign an agreement in which you affirm this principle, agree to the conditions of use, and confirm that you will use the material only for educational ends. Consequently you are granted access to the database by receiving the password.

Conditions of use are the following: If you are teaching church history at university or in school, you may have unlimited use of the database, but you will have to accept the obligation to add at least *one* new piece of your own didactic material per year, material which you found significant and useful in your lectures. Of course you are welcome to add more! Thereby we hope to increase the size and the scope of the database continually and at the same time

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to have some peer control concerning the didactic quality of its contents. We have checked the copyright status for the data we contributed ourselves. It is granted strictly for use in universities and schools. Every user who has signed up with *Mneme Database Church History* is fully responsible to use all data material contained therein for university or school purposes only and to secure copyright for any material he or she is adding to *Mneme Database of Church History.*

You will find the text of the user's agreement for *Mneme Database Church History* at the above mentioned conditions on our homepage www.mneme-kirchengeschichte.eu

For further questions, suggestions, and comments write an e-mail to: admin@mneme-kirchengeschichte.eu

Fig. 1: Base Menu

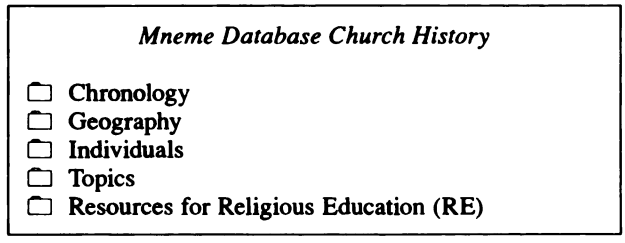
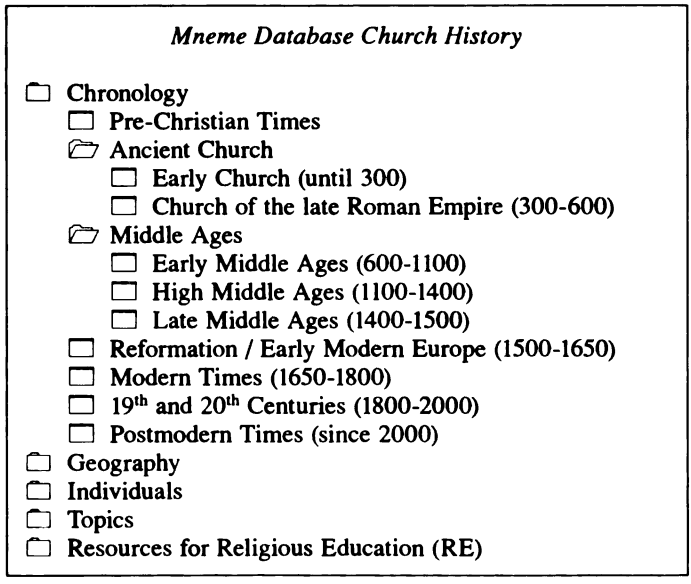


Fig. 2: Chronology



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Fig. 3: Geography

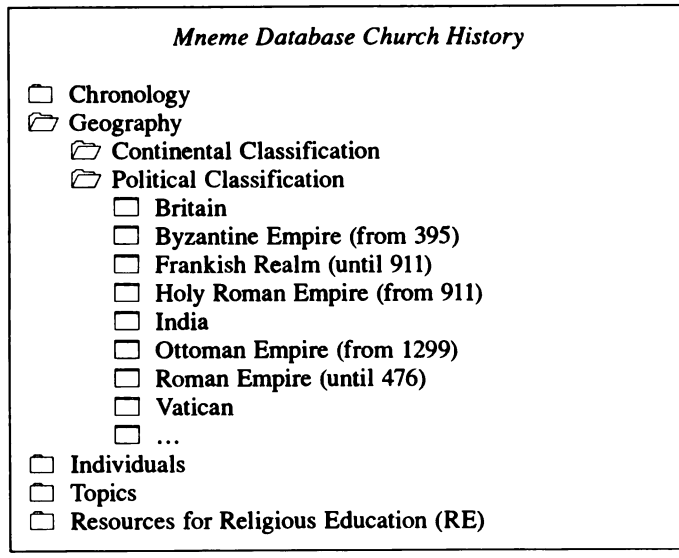
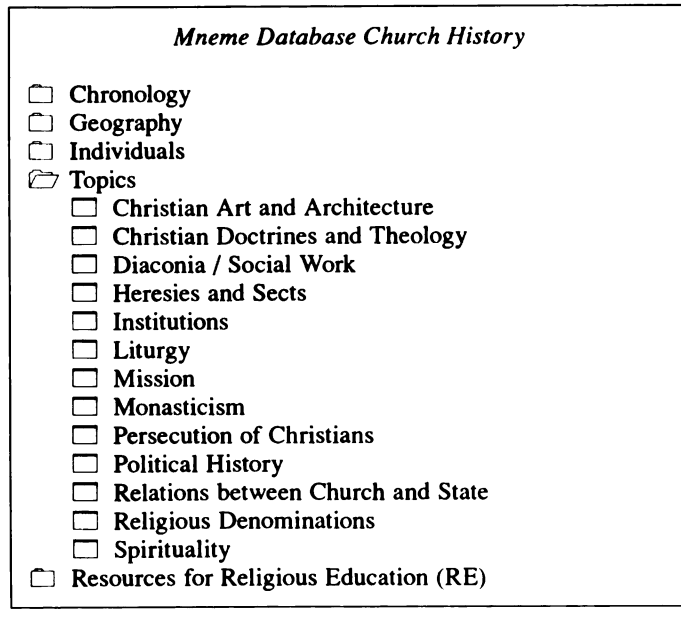


Fig. 4: Topics



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III. HISTORICA

Salvatore Costanza
Geoffrey Greatrex
Thomas Heyne
Mikhail M. Kazakov
Vincenzo Messana
Dennis Paul Quinn
David L. Riggs
Josef Rist
Claire Sotinel
David Woods

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Das Orakel des Apollon in Daphne und das Christentum

Josef RIST, Bochum

Der landschaftlich schön gelegene Ort Daphne, rund 8 km südlich der Metropole Antiochia, ist in der Antike Sitz eines überregional bekannten Apollon-Heiligtums. Dessen Geschichte ist aus mehrfachem Grund eng verwoben mit dem frühen Christentum. Nachdem in den letzten Jahren immer wieder Einzelaspekte dieser Beziehung behandelt wurden, versucht der vorliegende Beitrag eine Zusammenschau und Bewertung der Ereignisse.

Topographie und Ursprung des Heiligtums

Daphne liegt auf einem 250 Metern über dem Meeresspiegel gelegenen Plateau. Üppige Vegetation, ein auch im Hochsommer angenehmes Klima und zahlreiche Quellen machen die Siedlung zum angenehmen Wohnort vermögender Antiochener.[1]

Gegründet wird das erstmals 189 vor Christus in einer Inschrift erwähnte Daphne von dem Diadochen Seleukos I. Nikator im dritten vorchristlichen Jahrhundert. Den antiken Besucher erfreuen eine Reihe von Sehenswürdigkeiten, so ein olympisches Stadion und ein Theater.

Eng verbunden ist Daphne mit dem Gott Apollon. Hier, so der Mythos, soll sich die Nymphe Daphne auf ihrer Flucht vor dem zudringlichen Gott in einen Lorbeerbaum – griechisch: δάφνη – verwandelt haben.

In Daphne befindet sich ein großer heiliger Hain; in dessen Mitte steht ein beeindruckender Apollon-Tempel. Dieser geht in seiner ersten Bauphase ebenfalls auf Seleukos zurück. In der Cella des Tempels steht eine vom Athener Erzgießer Bryaxis gefertigte monumentale Statue des Gottes. Nach Libanios ist der Gott als Kitharode dargestellt; die unbekleideten Körperteile sind in Marmor ausgearbeitet. Der mit einem vergoldeten Chiton bekleidete Apollon trägt in seiner Linken die Phorminx, während die andere Hand eine Schale hält. Das Haupt schmückt ein Lorbeerkranz.[2]

[1] Vgl. Immanuel Benzinger, Daphne 3, in: *PRE* 4 (1901) 2136-8; *Libanios, Antiochikos (or. XI).* Übersetzt und kommentiert von Georgios Fatouros und Tilman Krischer (Wien and Berlin, 1992), 131-4, 247-58. Zur Frühgeschichte siehe auch Glanville Downey, *A History of Antioch in Syria from Seleucus to the Arab Conquest* (Princeton/NJ, 1961), 82-6.

[2] Vgl. Libanios, *Or.* 60, 9-11. Vgl. Otto Jessen, Daphnaios 1, in: *PRE* 4 (1901) 2135f.

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Mit dem Tempel eng verbunden ist Daphne als Orakelstätte. Über die Art und Weise, wie der Gott mit den Bittstellern kommuniziert, sind wir leider schlecht informiert. Sicher ist, daß das Orakel eng mit den zahlreichen Quellen der Umgebung verbunden ist. Am südlichen Rand des Plateaus befinden sich ihrer fünf, von denen drei namentlich bekannt sind; die wohl berühmteste wird in Analogie zu Delphi als Kastalia bezeichnet.[3]

Über die frühe Geschichte des Orakels liegen zwei Notizen vor. Aus der Rückschau des 4. Jahrhunderts berichtet Ammianus Marcellinus, daß Kaiser Julian es unternimmt, die „prophetischen Wasseradern der Kastalischen Quelle wieder zu öffnen, die der Kaiser Hadrian mit gewaltigen Felsblöcken verschüttet haben soll."[4] Unklar bleibt allerdings in der Darstellung, ob mit Hadrian am Beginn des 2. Jahrhunderts das Orakel wirklich zu einem ersten Ende kam oder aber lediglich die Quelle zugeschüttet wurde.

Ein weiteres Detail über die Aktivitäten des Hadrian überliefert der Kirchenhistoriker Sozomenos. Demnach taucht der um Rat bittende Kaiser ein Lorbeerblatt in die Quelle. Als er es herauszieht, findet er die Antwort des Apollon auf das Blatt geschrieben vor.[5] Beide Zeugnisse legen nahe, daß die Quelle – wohl die Kastalia – im Mittelpunkt der mantischen Aktivitäten steht; zumindest ist vom Tempel hier keine Rede. Allerdings merken die Berichterstatter ausdrücklich an, daß ihre Informationen vom Hörensagen stammen.[6] Zudem stehen die Notizen in Spannung zu anderen Berichten des 4. Jahrhunderts, unter anderem einer Schilderung des Kaisers Julian, die eher der Statue des Apollon die zentrale Rolle beim Orakel zuzuweisen scheinen.[7] Letztlich läßt sich das Verhältnis von Quelle und Tempel nicht befriedigend klären. In jedem Fall scheint das Orakel – verglichen mit Delphi und Didyma – letztlich von untergeordneter Bedeutung gewesen zu sein.[8]

Diokletian und Daphne

Nach seinem Sieg über Licinius 324 erläßt Kaiser Konstantin eine Reihe von Gesetzen;[9] darunter befindet sich auch ein in der *Vita Constantini* des Eusebius

[3] Vgl. *Libanios, Antiochikos (or. XI)* 249f.

[4] Amm. Marc. 22, 12, 8 (ed. Wolfgang Seyfarth, *Ammianus Marcellinus: Römische Geschichte.* Dritter Teil [Berlin, 1970], 44; Übersetzung: 45). Übernommen bei Sozom., *Hist. eccl.* V 19,11. Zur Schließung unter Hadrian vgl. Downey, *History* 222, Anm. 103.

[5] Vgl. Sozom., *Hist. eccl.* V 19,11.

[6] Vgl. ebd.: φάσι bzw. Amm. Marc. 22,12,8: *dicitur.*

[7] Vgl. Jul., *Misop.* 361 C (ed. Friedhelm L. Müller, *Die beiden Satiren des Kaisers Julianus Apostata* [Stuttgart, 1998], 160): ἐπεστήμεν γὰρ εἰσελθόντι μοι πρῶτον τὸ ἄγαλμα.

[8] So auch Richard P.C. Hanson, The Oratio ad sanctos attributed to the Emperor Constantine and the Oracle at Daphne: *JThSt* 24 (1973) 505-511, hier: 508.

[9] Vgl. Averil Cameron and Stuart G. Hall (eds.), *Eusebius: Life of Constantine* (Oxford, 1999), 243f.

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von Caesarea überlieferter Lehrbrief an die östlichen Provinzialen (ἐπαρχιώταις ἀνατολικοῖς).[10] Am Anfang kommt Konstantin auf den Beginn der Christenverfolgung des Diokletian zu sprechen und berichtet: „Man erzählte, daß Apollo zu der Zeit aus irgendeiner Höhle und finsterem Winkel, nicht aber aus dem Himmel (οὐχὶ δ' ἐξ οὐρανοῦ) – Variante: aus einem Menschen (ἐξ ἀνθρώπου)[11] – das Orakel verkündet habe, daß also die Gerechten auf der Erde verhinderten, daß er die Wahrheit sagen konnte und er deshalb falsche Orakelsprüche aus den Dreifüßen machte. Das beklagte nämlich in der Tat seine Priesterin (ἱέρεια) – Variante: Priesterschaft (ἱερεία) –,[12] die niedergeschlagen ihre lockigen Haare lang herabwallen ließ und vom Wahnsinn getrieben wurde, als das Übel unter den Menschen."[13] Im Folgekapitel werden die angesprochenen Gerechten von einem Orakelpriester aus der Umgebung des Kaisers als Christen identifiziert – und Diokletian beginnt unmittelbar darauf seine Verfolgungsmaßnahmen.[14] Wenige Verse weiter resümiert Konstantin: „Dies wäre ihnen (den Christen) nicht zugestoßen, wenn jene gottlose Weissagung unter den Orakelsprüchen des Pythiers nicht trügerische Kraft besessen hätte."[15]

Der hier genannte antichristliche Orakelspruch findet scheinbar eine Erläuterung in einer Bemerkung bei Laktanz. Dieser ist ab 299 am Hof des Diokletian und somit Augenzeuge. Laktanz berichtet, daß Diokletian einen Haruspex zur Kultstätte des Apollon nach Didyma geschickt habe. Der befragte Gott habe die geplanten christenfeindlichen Maßnahmen für gut befunden. Bei Laktanz heißt es: „Jenes (d. h. das Orakel) antwortete als ein Feind der göttlichen Religion".[16] Daraufhin beginnen im Jahr 303 die Verfolgungsaktionen.

Vielfach wird angenommen, daß es sich hier um die Beschreibung ein und derselben Begebenheit aus verschiedenen Perspektiven handelt.[17] Eine scheinbare epigraphische Verifizierung bietet Henri Grégoire mit einer phantasiereichen Rekonstruktion einer mittlerweile nicht mehr vorhandenen Inschrift aus Didyma.[18]

[10] Vgl. Euseb., *Vit. Const.* 2, 48-60.

[11] Konjektur von Elizabeth DePalma Digeser. Sie wird begründet mit dem Befund der Handschriften – nur eine Handschrift überliefert οὐρανοῦ – und der älteren Ausgabe von Heikel (ed. Ivar A. Heikel, GCS 7, Leipzig, 1902). Vgl. Elizabeth DePalma Digeser, An Oracle of Apollo at Daphne and the Great Persecution Oracle: *Classical Philology* 99 (2004) 57-77, hier: 59 Anm. 13.

[12] Zweite Konjektur von Digeser. Als Begründung wird auf die Übersetzung von Cameron – Hall, *Eusebius* 112 verwiesen. Vgl. Digeser, Oracle (2004), 60, Anm. 15.

[13] Euseb., *Vit. Const.* II 50. Übersetzung: Bruno Bleckmann – Horst Schneider (eds.), *Eusebius von Caesarea: De vita Constantini*, Fontes Christiani 83 (Turnhout, 2007), 279, 281.

[14] Vgl. Euseb., *Vit. Const.* II 51, 1.

[15] Ebd. II 54. Übersetzung: Bleckmann – Schneider, *Eusebius* 283.

[16] Lact., *De mort. pers.* XI 8 (ed. S. Brandt and G. Laubmann, CSEL 27/2, 186,5f.): respondit ille ut divinae religionis inimicus. Vgl. Joseph Fontenrose, *Didyma* (Berkeley u. a., 1988), 206 (= R 33).

[17] Belege bei Digeser, *Oracle* 62, Anm. 23.

[18] Inschrift: *CIG II, 1120 Nr. 2883d.* Vgl. Henri Grégoire, Les chrétiens et l'oracle de Didyme, in: *Mélanges Maurice Holleaux* (Paris, 1913), 81-91. Kritik u. a. bei Wolfgang Kuhoff, *Diokletian und die Epoche der Tetrarchie* (Frankfurt a. Main, 2001), 268f.

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Allerdings gibt es auch für zwei getrennte Ereignisse eine Reihe von Unterstützern. Sie verweisen darauf, daß das recht gut dokumentierte Vorgehen bei der Orakelübermittlung in Didyma nicht der Schilderung des Eusebius entspricht, sondern sich vielmehr auf Delphi beziehen müsse, nicht zuletzt da der Dreifuß und die Pythia konkret angesprochen werden.[19]

Von Daphne war bislang noch nicht die Rede. Dies ändert sich erst mit einem 2004 in der Zeitschrift *Classical Philology* publizierten Artikel. Unter der Überschrift *An Oracle of Apollo at Daphne and the Great Persecution* postuliert Elizabeth DePalma Digeser, daß der von Konstantin überlieferte antichristliche Orakelspruch im Jahr 299 in Daphne ergangen sei. Wichtige Argumente sind, daß zum einen die religionspolitische Situation des Jahres 299 für die Einholung eines Orakelentscheides gegenüber dem Jahr 303 wesentlich angemessener erscheint sowie andererseits die Art der beschriebenen Übermittlung des Spruches besser zu Daphne anstatt zu Delphi oder Didyma paßt. Gestützt wird die These durch eine Fülle scharfsinniger Beobachtungen, die zahlreiche, in anderen Kontexten bekannte Quellen zu einer beeindruckenden Synopse zusammenfaßt.[20]

Die zweifellos interessante These hat aber auch eine Reihe von Schwächen. Sie erfordert zunächst im Text des Eusebius, wie oben kenntlich gemacht, an zwei Stellen Konjekturen. Auch werden eine Reihe von anderweitig überlieferten Zeugnissen zu Daphne in Beziehung gesetzt, die nicht unproblematisch sind. Hier ist insbesondere die Aktivität des als Christenfeind aus Antiochia bekannten Theoteknos zu nennen, von dessen Tätigkeit in Daphne wir in den Quellen keine Kenntnis besitzen.[21] Fraglich erscheint zudem das Postulat eines besonderen Eigenstandes von Daphne gegenüber den mantischen Praktiken anderer Orakelstätten.[22] Einiges – Name der Quelle Kastalia, Lage der Quelle in mittelbarer Nähe zum Heiligtum – spricht vielmehr dafür, daß sich Daphne bei einer Reihe von Gegebenheiten stark an die Situation in Delphi anlehnt. So müssen letztlich Zweifel bleiben, inwiefern Daphne bereits 299 eine entscheidende Rolle in der Kirchengeschichte spielt.

Babylas, Kaiser Julian und der Brand in Daphne

Auf sichererem Boden stehen wir bei jenen Ereignissen in der Mitte des 4. Jahrhunderts, in welche Kaiser Julian, der Leichnam des Märtyrerbischofs Babylas und Daphne involviert sind.

[19] Vgl. mit Stellennachweisen Digeser, Oracle (2004), 62, besonders Anm. 27.

[20] Kernthese: Digeser, Oracle (2004), 75. Ausführliche Begründung: ebd. 63-69.

[21] Zur Person vgl. Bruno Bleckmann, Theoteknos, in: *Der Neue Pauly* 12/1 (2002) 405.

[22] Im Gegensatz zu den Priesterinnen in Delphi und Didyma postuliert Digeser für Daphne „an attendant (or theurgist) whose rites... gave voice to the prophetic statue at Daphne" (Digeser, Oracle (2004), 58).

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Das einschneidendste Ereigniss für das Heiligtum in Daphne ist der Brand des Apollontempels und die Zerstörung des Standbildes am 22. Oktober des Jahres 362. Die Meinungen über die Brandursache differieren. Ammianus Marcellinus spricht davon, dass „der Tempel durch einen so schrecklichen Zufall unerwarteterweise vernichtet"[23] wurde; zudem kennt er auch noch eine im Volk kursierende Version: demnach verursacht der kynische Philosoph Asklepiades mit seinen vor dem Standbild abgestellten Wachskerzen durch Funkenflug den schrecklichen Brand.[24] Von christlicher Seite wird das Unglück vornehmlich als Strafe Gottes gedeutet.[25] Kaiser Julian, der sich der Sache besonders annimmt, verdächtigt hingegen die Christen der Brandstiftung, setzt eine Untersuchungskommission, der unter anderem auch Libanios angehört, ein und verhängt vorbeugend Sanktionen gegen die Christen: Der Herrscher schließt die Große Kirche in Antiochien – Gottesdienste finden aber weiterhin in der sogenannten Alten Kirche der Meletianer statt – und läßt liturgische Gerätschaften einziehen. Schließlich muß aber auch Julian zugeben, daß die Brandursache nicht geklärt werden kann.[26]

Vorangegangen war ein verbissener Kampf zwischen Heiden und Christen um den Besitz des prestigeträchtigen Ortes. Wichtige Informationen gibt die 378/379 entstandene Schrift *De sancto Babyla* des Johannes Chrysostomus († 407).[27] Ihr Held ist der in der Mitte des 3. Jahrhunderts getötete antiochenische Ortsbischof Babylas. Johannes berichtet, daß der bis 354 als Caesar des Ostens in Antiochia residierende Gallus die sterblichen Überreste des Babylas aus der Stadt nach Daphne bringen läßt. In der Folge sei das Orakel verstummt.[28] Wohl ruht Babylas nicht allein in Daphne. Ähnlich wie aus Didyma bekannt, dürften auch die hiesigen Christen ihre Toten im heiligen Bezirk bestattet haben.[29]

Kaiser Julian kommt im Juli des Jahres 362 unmittelbar vor seiner Kampagne gegen die Perser nach Antiochia und besucht auch Daphne. Hier erhält er einen weiteren positiven Bescheid für den geplanten Feldzug, ja er will von der

[23] Amm. Marc. XXII 13, 2 (ed. Seyfahrth 46): Quo tam atroci casu repente consumpto.

[24] Vgl. ebd. XXII 14, 3.

[25] Vgl. Sozom., *Hist. eccl.* V 20, 5.

[26] Zur Schuldfrage vgl. Jul., *Misop.* 346 B (ed. Müller 136): τὸ τῆς Δάφνης δσάκις εἰσῆλθον τέμενος, προδοθὲν μὲν ὀλιγωρίᾳ τῶν φυλάκων, ταῖς δὲ τῶν ἀθέων ἀνδρῶν τόλμαις ἀφανισθέν. Auch Libanios vermutet Brandstiftung. Vgl. Libanios, *Or.* 60,8. Zur Untersuchungskommission vgl. Joh. Chrys., *Bab.* 95f. 107. Nach Thdt., *Hist. eccl.* III 11,5 werden νεωκόροι als Täter genannt. Zu den kaiserlichen Sanktionen vgl. Hans-Ulrich Wiemer, *Libanios und Julian* (Vestigia, 46) (München, 1995), 193.

[27] Vgl. Josef Rist, Chrysostomus, Libanius und Kaiser Julian: Überlegungen zu Inhalt und Umfeld der Schrift *De sancto Babyla, contra Iulianum et gentiles (CPG 4348)*, in: *Giovanni Crisostomo: Oriente e occidente tra IV e V secolo* (SEA 93/2) (Roma, 2005), 863-82. Textausgabe: Maragret A. Schatkin u. a., *Jean Chrysostome: Discours sur Babylas* (SC 362) (Paris, 1990).

[28] Translation: Joh. Chrys., *Bab.* 67. Verstummen des Orakels: ebd. 73; so auch Sozom., *Hist. eccl.* V 19,14.

[29] Zu Didyma vgl. Sozom., *Hist. eccl.* V 20,7.

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Kultstatue des Apollon selbst Zeichen erhalten haben. Der Besuch an sich ist nicht außergewöhnlich, macht der Kaiser doch an sämtlichen am Weg liegenden Orakelstätten Station.[30] Wenig begeistert ist Julian, als er von der Anwesenheit des Babylas erfährt. Er befiehlt die Entfernung des Leichnams des Märtyrers aus Daphne, was auch umgehend geschieht und zu gewaltsamen Auseinandersetzungen zwischen Heiden und Christen in Antiochia führt.[31] Es folgt der bereits beschriebene Brand mit der Zerstörung des Tempels; unergiebige Nachforschungen schließen sich an.

Mit dem Tod Julians 363 schließlich tritt der endgültige Niedergang des paganen Daphne ein. Die Tempelruine wird nicht wieder aufgebaut; Johannes Chrysostomus berichtet noch 378 von einer Trümmerlandschaft. Das Heiligtum selbst dürfte wohl schließlich Ende des 4. Jahrhunderts geschlossen worden sein.[32]

Unsere kleine tour d'horizon zeigt, wie wenig wir – abgesehen von der Spätphase im 4. Jahrhundert – letztlich über das Apollon-Orakel von Daphne wissen. Gleichzeitig kommt dem Ort in den Auseinandersetzungen zwischen Heiden und Christen im 4. Jahrhundert eine bedeutende Rolle zu. Allein schon deshalb lohnt sich bereits die Beschäftigung mit der Thematik.

[30] Vgl. Fontenrose, *Didyma* 25. Zur Befragung des Orakels in Daphne durch Julian vgl. Thdt., *Hist. eccl.* III 10,1f.

[31] Der Leichnam des Babylas kehrt nach Antiochien zurück, wo er außerhalb der Stadt zunächst auf dem großen christlichen Friedhof bestattet wird. Vgl. Joh. Chrys., *Bab.* 87. 93.

[32] Zur Situation um 378 vgl. ebd. 94. Zur Schließung der Tempel siehe *CTh* XVI 10,9. 10,13.

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Were Second-Century Christians 'Preoccupied' with Physical Healing and the Asclepian Cult?

Thomas HEYNE, Oxford

According to Adolf von Harnack and several scholars who succeeded him, early Christianity *'deliberately ... assumed the form of "the religion of salvation or healing."'*[1] Most recently, Amanda Porterfield argued that early Christians had a 'preoccupation with sickness' and 'disseminated their religion as a means of healing.'[2] Porterfield based her argument on Hector Avalos and R.J.S. Barrett-Lennard, who in turn relied upon Victor Dawe, Evelyn Frost, and Morton Kelsey.[3] Together, these scholars have produced numerous Patristic citations to argue that the supernatural healing of physical disease was 'a major factor, perhaps the key one, in the growth of early Christianity'.[4] Indeed, some scholars have also posited that second-century Christians demonstrated unparalleled hostility towards the healing Cult of Asclepius.[5] One must ask: was second-century Christianity truly a healing cult that showed 'unequalled concern' with Asclepius, supernatural healings, and physical disease?[6] Amazingly, no scholar (to my knowledge) has analysed in detail the evidence that Frost, Dawe, and others have given.[7] By focusing upon the citations made to the Christian writers of c. 100-175 – viz., the Apostolic Fathers and early Greek Apologists – I shall show that scholars have exaggerated and misinterpreted Patristic evidence in their arguments that healings were a major concern for post-Biblical Christians.[8]

[1] Adolf von Harnack, *Mission and Expansion of Christianity in the First Three Centuries*, James Moffatt (transl.), vol. 2 (New York, 1962), 108. Emphasis original.

[2] Amanda Porterfield, *Healing in the History of Christianity* (Oxford, 2005), 47.

[3] Hector Avalos, *Health Care and the Rise of Christianity* (Peabody, Massachusetts, 1999); R.J.S. Barrett-Lennard, *Christian Healing After the New Testament* (New York, 1994); Morton Kelsey, *Healing and Christianity* (London, 1973); Victor Dawe, *The Attitude of the Ancient Church Toward Sickness and Healing* (Boston Univ. Dissertation, 1955); Evelyn Frost, *Christian Healing* (Oxford, 1940).

[4] L.D. Hankoff, Religious Healing: *Journal of Psychohistory* 19 (1992) 387-407, 404.

[5] *E.g.* Ludwig and Emma Edelstein, *Asclepius: A Collection and Interpretation of the Testimonies* (Baltimore, 1998). See n. 31 below.

[6] See L. and E. Edelstein, *Asclepius* (1998), 132.

[7] For a different approach (published after this paper was delivered), see Gary Ferngren, *Medicine and Health Care in Early Christianity* (Baltimore, 2009).

[8] In a larger, still unpublished version of this paper, I include the New Testament and Christian and pagan writings after 175. However, my point stands here as well: if Christians

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Several examples from the so-called Apostolic Fathers (c. 100-140) will demonstrate how scholars have stretched the evidence, positing a promise of healing and preoccupation with sickness where none explicitly exists.[9] First, Dawe claims that the *Letter of Clement* states that Christians 'are protected from hunger, disease, and untimely death'.[10] Clement indeed says that 'protection [from death] is afforded to those that are chastened of the Lord', but his description of Job's trial scarcely shows a promise of physical health; in fact, Clement makes no mention of disease.[11] Second, Dawe argues that Polycarp 'exhorts the elders to heal the sick', as in *Jm.* 5:14.[12] Yet Polycarp says only that presbyters should be 'visiting the sick, and neglecting not the widow, the orphan, or the poor.'[13] He makes no mention of cure by Jacobean anointing, which was not evidenced again until the third century.[14] Next, Porterfield asserts that the *Letter of Barnabas* 'insisted' that Christians had a 'promise of health, fertility, and prosperity'.[15] But *Barnabas*'s 'living forever' is meant only spiritually, and bodily bliss is promised only after the resurrection of the dead.[16] Fourth, Kelsey cites *Barn.* 16 to show belief in Christ's atonement 'on man here and now, his flesh, and his diseases, bodily or otherwise,' but *Barnabas* speaks only allegorically of Christians as the new spiritual temple and makes no mention of disease.[17] Finally, Frost, Dawe, and Kelsey try to use the last lines of *Hermas* to prove that early Christians believed that failing to heal the sick successfully was a grave sin.[18] In fact, *Hermas* is most likely speaking of almsgiving for material poverty (*eget*), not miraculous healing for physical disease.[19] Indeed, the good works that *Hermas* mandates include assistance for orphans, widows, and the poor, but the sick are not specified.[20] Thus, one finds little evidence for particular concern for sickness and cures.

More surprising still is the misinterpretation of Ignatius. *Pace* Frost and Kelsey, it seems almost impossible that Ignatius is promising physical healing 'here and now' when he writes of the 'perfection of immortality' or 'Christ our

from c. 100-175 were 'preoccupied' with health and disease, one would expect to find a reasonable amount of contemporary Christian evidence. One does not.

[9] I rely on Johannes Quasten, *Patrology*, vol. 1 (Notre Dame, 1990) for dates.

[10] V. Dawe, *The Attitude of the Ancient Church Toward Sickness and Healing* (1955), 64.

[11] *EpCor* 56. I use the ANF translations (Grand Rapids, 1951).

[12] V. Dawe, *The Attitude of the Ancient Church Toward Sickness and Healing* (1955), 64.

[13] *PolPhil* 6.

[14] Tert., *Ad Scap.* 5.

[15] A. Porterfield, *Healing in the History of Christianity* (2005), 62.

[16] *Barn* 6,11.

[17] M. Kelsey, *Healing and Christianity* (1973), 146; *Barn* 16.

[18] *Herm* III.10.4; V. Dawe, *The Attitude of the Ancient Church Toward Sickness and Healing* (1955), 65; M. Kelsey, *Healing and Christianity* (1973), 149; E. Frost, *Christian Healing* (1940), 19. 64.

[19] Carolyn Osiek, *Shepherd of Hermas: A Commentary* (Minneapolis, 1999), 261.

[20] *Herm* II 8, III 5.3.

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inseparable life', 'eternal life', and 'true life'.[21] Indeed, in the self-portrait of an enthusiastic martyr it is repeatedly argued that Christians must die in order to live.[22] Next, Dawe assumes that the Smyrneans's 'gifts' include healing, but Ignatius specifies χάρισμα elsewhere only as the gift of right doctrine.[23] Avalos cites *IgnEph* 7 to contend that Ignatius 'denounces those who misuse, apparently for healing, the divine name'.[24] In fact, Ignatius attacks only false Christians who 'carry about' (περιφέρειν) Christ's name, not false healers who 'misuse' it.[25] The larger context is an exhortation to accept right doctrine and the Bishop Onesimus, not a promise of physical cures.[26] Thus, Frost and others are unjustified in assuming a corporeal interpretation for Christ the 'physician' and the men 'who can scarcely be cured'.[27] Ignatius, like Hermas and many ancient writers,[28] drew on medical metaphors freely; in other letters he wrote of the 'deadly drug' and 'wound' of heresy, but he never showed preoccupation with physical disease or healing.[29] Furthermore, Ignatius, like the other Apostolic Fathers, never specified care of the sick when listing the essential acts of charity.[30] In sum, only by giving the writings of these authors a particular slant can scholars demonstrate the kind of concern for cures that one might find in a healing cult.

Turning to the Asclepian cult, one is surprised by the dearth of evidence for Christians' concern for their supposed archrival. Numerous scholars have posited a conflict of 'singular bitterness' between the Asclepian cult and Christianity in the second century, [31] but these scholars can unveil little evidence of hostility before the third and fourth centuries. None of the Apostolic Fathers even mention Asclepius. Recent studies have also shown that Christian usage of ἰατρός or σωτήρ do not derive primarily from Asclepius.[32] Finding diatribe

[21] E. Frost, *Christian Healing* (1940), 86; M. Kelsey, *Healing and Christianity* (1973), 146; *IgnEph* III 17; *IgnMagn* 1; *IgnPhil* 9; *IgnTral* 9.

[22] *IgnRom* 2; *IgnMagn* 5.

[23] V. Dawe, *The Attitude of the Ancient Church Toward Sickness and Healing* (1955), 63; *IgnSmyr*, preface; *IgnEph* 17; *IgnPol* 2.

[24] H. Avalos, *Health Care and the Rise of Christianity* (1999), 82.

[25] *IgnEph* 7. I use the *TLG*. See Reinhard Hübner, *Der Paradox Eine* (Leiden, 1999), who posits the Ignatian letters into a later anti-Gnostic and anti-Marcionite debate.

[26] *IgnEph* 6-9.

[27] *Ibid.* 7; E. Frost, *Christian Healing* (1940), 88. See also M. Kelsey, *Healing and Christianity* (1973), 146; V. Dawe, *The Attitude of the Ancient Church Toward Sickness and Healing* (1955), 152. See R. Hübner, *Der Paradox Eine* (1999), 174f.

[28] *Herm* II 3.11; III 8.11; 9.28; 10.2. See Michael Dörnemann, *Krankheit und Heilung in der Theologie der frühen Kirchenväter* (Tübingen, 2003).

[29] *IgnTrall* 6; *IgnPol* 2-3. See *IgnEph* 20.

[30] *IgnSmyr* 6; *EpCor* 38; *Herm* II 8; III 5.3; *Did* 5; see *Barn* 3.

[31] L. and E. Edelstein, *Asclepius* (1998), 132; V. Dawe, *The Attitude of the Ancient Church Toward Sickness and Healing* (1955), 84; H. Avalos, *Health Care and the Rise of Christianity* (1999), 50; Rene Ruttimann, *Asclepius and Jesus* (Univ. Harvard Dissertation, 1987), 12.

[32] M. Dörnemann, *Krankheit und Heilung* (2003), 88.

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where none exists, Rene Ruttimann posits that Ignatius was attacking Asclepius when he mentioned the 'one physician' and the 'ravening dogs'.[33] However, the 'ravening dogs' derive from a popular proverb, and Ignatius describes Christ as κύριος, not σωτήρ.[34] There is simply no conclusive evidence that early Christian writers were promising physical health to compete against Asclepius. Furthermore, the repeated Patristic exhortation to accept suffering and death for eternal rewards would have had little appeal for Asclepian devotees.[35] Indeed, Papias and *Hermas* even suggested that God might send illness.[36] Thus, the evidence from c. 100-140 scarcely supports the theory of Christian preoccupation with health, healing, and the Asclepian cult.

When we turn to the next generation of Christian writers, we find a slowly growing, but still unremarkable, interest in healings and Asclepius. The early Greek Apologists (c. 125-175) mention exorcisms, cures, and Asclepius only rarely, and they do so to make larger theological points. Thus, scholars must exaggerate or misinterpret the evidence to demonstrate a special concern with bodily health.

To begin with, Frost, Dawe, and Kelsey cite the miracles mentioned by the apologist Quadratus, implying that he was describing contemporary healings.[37] In truth, Quadratus refers only to Jesus's healings, not to cures in his own day.[38] Frost and Kelsey also cite Theophilus as evidence for physical cures Theophilus 'had witnessed'.[39] On closer inspection, however, the 'healing from sickness by God' he describes is simple natural bodily regeneration from injury – no more spectacular than the return of the sun or the growth of trees.[40] Indeed, the passage cited suggests that contemporary healings were *not* known by Theophilus, for he is apparently unable to relate any contemporary miracles when asked for proof of raisings from the dead.[41]

Besides finding healings where none are mentioned, scholars have also interpreted the Apologists' metaphors too corporeally. Frost quotes Theophilus's words: 'Entrust yourself to the Physician', but she omits the rest of his sentence: '... and he will couch the eyes of your soul and of your heart'.[42] Similarly, Frost and Kelsey cite Justin's trust in 'our physician Christ', but the apologist is

[33] *IgnEph* 7; R. Ruttimann, *Asclepius and Jesus* (1987), 12.

[34] William Schoedel, *Ignatius of Antioch: A Commentary* (Philadelphia, 1985), 59.

[35] *Barn* 6,19; *IgnRom* 2-8; *MartPol* 1-3; see Clement, *Corinthians* 6-39.

[36] *Herm* I 2.10; III 6.3; Papias, *Fragment* 3 (in ANF).

[37] V. Dawe, *The Attitude of the Ancient Church Toward Sickness and Healing* (1955), 63; E. Frost, *Christian Healing* (1940), 64; M. Kelsey, *Healing and Christianity* (1973), 149.

[38] Euseb., *Hist. Eccl.* IV 3.2.

[39] M. Kelsey, *Healing and Christianity* (1973), 149; E. Frost, *Christian Healing* (1940), 65.

[40] E. Frost, *Christian Healing* (1940), 65; Theoph., *Ad Autol.* I 13 (miscited by Frost as II 13).

[41] Theoph., *Ad Autol.* I 13.

[42] E. Frost, *Christian Healing* (1940), 87; M. Kelsey, *Healing and Christianity* (1973), 146; Theoph., *Ad Autol.* I 7.

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clearly discussing bodily temperance and the final resurrection.[43] Next, Frost follows Lightfoot's translation of Mathetes just once, when it describes Christ as 'nurse' and 'strength' rather than as 'nourisher' and 'power'.[44] Finally, Athenagoras's mention of Christ as the 'idea and energizing power (ἐνέργεια) of all material things' is a reference to creation, not healing.[45] Thus, scholars appear to distort the evidence to show a special Christian concern with physical healing.

With Theophilus and Justin, we finally find contemporary evidence for the practice of exorcism, but the focus is not the restoration of bodily health, as scholars insist. Theophilus gives a single mention of contemporary exorcisms, but even here he admits that the exorcisms were infrequent and makes no mention of actual physical disease.[46] Justin Martyr speaks in four passages – more than any early Apologist – about contemporary exorcisms,[47] but his aim is to defend the Church, not to promise health.[48] Justin never claims that Christian exorcisms can heal the body (like the Asclepian incubations); in fact, Justin, Athenagoras, and Theophilus never actually state that demons cause corporeal disease.[49] Even if exorcism could impart physical healing, the Greek Apologists speak little of it, instead praising prophecy and care of the poor.[50]

Justin alone among the early Apologists suggests that some contemporary Christians possessed the gift of healing. But this suggestion comes only once (when he lists six other charismata), and Trypho's immediate incredulous response suggests that even Justin knew his claim was not well evidenced.[51] Justin never advertises a healing cult; instead, he warns against a pleasant earthly life and almost boasts that some Christians are 'maimed and blind'.[52] The Apologists scarcely promise physical healing for new converts.

What of Asclepius? Again, one can find remarkably little evidence for the purported 'stiff competition' between Christianity and the widely popular healing cult of the second century.[53] The Greek Apologists mention Asclepius only

[43] Justin, *De res.* 10; E. Frost, *Christian Healing* (1940), 86; M. Kelsey, *Healing and Christianity* (1973), 146.

[44] E. Frost, *Christian Healing* (1940), 88; Mathetes, *Letter to Diognetus*, 9.

[45] Athen., *Plea* 10; *pace* M. Kelsey, *Healing and Christianity* (1973), 146 and E. Frost, *Christian Healing* (1940), 86.

[46] Theoph., *Ad Autol.* II 8.

[47] Justin, *2Apol.* 6-8; *id.*, *Dial. c. Trypho* 30; 76; 85.

[48] *Pace* M. Kelsey, *Healing and Christianity* (1973), 149 and E. Frost, *Christian Healing* (1940), 86.

[49] Justin, *1Apol.* 26; 54; 57; 62f; *2Apol.* 5; Theoph., *Ad Autol.* II 8; Athen., *Plea* 27. See Elizabeth Leeper, *Exorcism in Early Christianity* (Duke Univ. Dissertation, 1991) and G. Ferngren, *Medicine and Health Care in Early Christianity* (2009), 51-3.

[50] Justin, *1Apology* 39-53; 44; 67; *id.*, *Dial. c. Trypho* 15; 34; 82; 124. See *1Cor.* 14:1. Only once does Justin include care of the sick: *1Apol.* 67.

[51] Justin, *Dial. c. Trypho* 39. See *Is.* 11:2.

[52] Justin, *1Apol.* 60; *2Apol.* 11-2; see *id.*, *Dial. c. Trypho* 69 and Tatian, *Admon. ad Graec.* 32.

[53] V. Dawe, *The Attitude of the Ancient Church Toward Sickness and Healing* (1955), 92.

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in passing, when they also denigrate a number of other gods and demi-gods – Zeus, Hermes, Dionysius, Herakles, etc.[54] Contrary to the suggestions of Edelstein and others,[55] Asclepius is never singled out for special comparison or slander – although Perseus and Zeus are.[56] Justin levels an attack on the Mithras cult, but not the Asclepian one; indeed, he almost seems to respect the 'great physician'.[57] Furthermore, the constant Christian exhortation to suffering and martyrdom shows little similarity to Asclepian writings. Whereas Aelius Aristides detailed numerous symptoms and cures, contemporaneous Christians recorded the gruesome deaths of martyrs – some of whom died with uncured diseases.[58] Thus, there are few signs of competition with Asclepius's ongoing miraculous healings.

There is apparently little evidence from c. 100-175 for Christian healings or preoccupation with disease. Only after 175, Christian writers do begin to write of contemporary healing miracles, although thaumaturgic hagiographies are still a long way in coming. Irenaeus is the first Christian to speak clearly of ongoing healings, but he does so with considerable reservation and clearly prefers prophecy.[59] Moreover, Irenaeus exhorts Christians to prepare for death, praising the 'beneficial effect' of an 'infirmity of the flesh'.[60] The Apocryphal Acts of John, Paul, and Peter (c. 150-200?) also speak of healings, but only amidst numerous other wondrous works, and even John must endure an uncured affliction.[61] These and other later sources certainly merit further discussion, but it appears that Christian concern for healings increased only slowly with time.

At least with the Apostolic Fathers and early Apologists, we find none of the preoccupation with disease or healing that one would find in the Asclepian cult. I conclude by answering a final objection: namely, that Christians perhaps decided not to write about their truly prevalent healing rites because they were afraid of pagan charges of magic. During the age when Galen praised miracles and emperors performed healings, however, it seems unlikely that non-Christians would have abhorred a sect whose defining characteristic was the public, miraculous, and gratuitous healings of others.[62] Besides, early Christians repeatedly

[54] Arist., *Apol.* 10; Justin, *IApol.* 21-2; 25; 54; Tatian, *Admon. ad Graec.* 8; 21; Theoph., *Ad Autol.* I 9; III 2; Athen., *Plea* 17; 30.

[55] See n. 31 above.

[56] Justin, *Dial. c. Trypho* 67; Theoph., *Ad Autol.* I 10.

[57] Justin, *IApology* 21-2; 65; 70.

[58] Euseb., *Hist. Eccl.* V 1.1-63, esp. 29.

[59] Iren., *Adv. Haer.* I 13,23-25; II 31-32.

[60] *Ibid.* V 3.1-2; *Fragments*, 11-12.

[61] *ActJoh* 113. See also G. Ferngren, *Medicine and Health Care in Early Christianity* (2009), 73-5.

[62] Wendy Cotter, *Miracles in Greco-Roman Antiquity* (New York, 1999) 40; R. Ruttimann, *Asclepius and Jesus* (1987), 72, 123; L. and E. Edelstein, *Asclepius* (1998), 243, 379; G. Ferngren, *Medicine and Health Care in Early Christianity* (2009), 69.

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wrote about martyrdom, prophecy, exorcism, and the Eucharist – even when pagans ridiculed such practices.[63] Had physical healing had been their 'preoccupation', second-century Christians would have written copiously to describe and defend it. Instead, they left us with exhortations to martyrdom and suffering, themes quite foreign to healing cults. Thus, any theory that posits second-century Christianity as a healing cult must remain in the realm of improvable speculation.[64]

[63] R.L. Fox, *Pagans and Christians* (New York, 1986), 328.

[64] I would like to thank Dr. Bernard Green, Dr. Mark Edwards, and Dr. Roy Heyne for their generous assistance in different aspects of this paper.

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Roman Household Deities in the Latin Christian Writers: Tertullian, Arnobius, and Lactantius

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The early Church Fathers put much effort in attempting to undermine the legitimacy of the traditional deities of Rome. For them, these 'so-called gods' were either evil demons masquerading as divinities or the memories of venerated men with no divine reality. Although they tended to focus on the deities of Roman civic religion, Tertullian, Arnobius, and Lactantius in particular singled out the gods of the household for special comment, focusing either on the demonic aspects of these gods or the misplaced deification by Romans in their homes. Attacking household deities was one of the strategies these Latin Church Fathers used to spread Christianity and maintain the supremacy of their faith not only in the civic sphere but also within the domestic sphere as well. They did this by using common pagan philosophical arguments on the popular cult of images. And, as decades of modern archaeology have demonstrated, honor paid to Roman domestic gods continued at least until the late forth century AD throughout the Roman Empire.[1] Thus these Christian writers were on the offensive against current household veneration, not simply empty rhetorical fancy or straw gods.

1. Tertullian

For Tertullian, worship given to anything other than the One True God was idolatry. The pagan gods were deified human beings, following common euhemeraen theories, and thus had no reality. Their images and names, however, were employed by unclean spirits, fallen angels, demons of pagan philosophical tradition, in order to take honor upon themselves and from God. Tertullian's tactics involved belittling the gods of the Roman household as unworthy of honor and their images susceptible to demonic presence.[2] In one

[1] For the continuation of worship of Roman domestic deities in Italy through much of the forth century, see Jan Theo Bakker, *Living and Working with the Gods: Studies of Evidence for Private Religion and its Material Environment in the City of Ostia* (Amsterdam, 1994), 12, 103, 146, 158. See also Kim Bowes, *Private Worship, Public Values and Religious Change in Late Antiquity* (Cambridge, 2008), 28, 234 n. 72 for a summary of the modern archaeological scholarship demonstrating the late forth century evidence for pagan domestic religion.

[2] Tertullian draws directly from Varro his understanding that the gods of Greco-Roman polytheism were simply deified men, as T.D. Barnes notes in his study of the Church Father.

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passage from the *Apologeticum*, Tertullian addressed the Lares as if they were simple images made of metal: 'The family deities you call Lares, you exercise a domestic authority over, pledging them, selling them, changing them – making sometimes a cooking-pot of a Saturn, a frying pan of a Minerva, as one or other happens to be worn down, or broken in its long sacred use, or as the family head feels the pressure of some more sacred home necessity.'[3] Tertullian condemns the worshippers of the Lares as impious, even by the standards of the Roman polytheists themselves. Making a pot from one of the sacred images of the domestic gods is the first mark of irreligion.[4]

Tertullian also focuses his rhetoric on how the Romans treat their most cherished domestic gods. In his *Ad Nationes* he asserts: 'There are your household gods, the Lares and the Di Penates, which you possess by a family consecration: you even tread them profanely under foot, you and your slaves, by hawking and pawning them for your wants or your whims.'[5] He ridicules them, much as Varro would, as minor deities and argued that they have been mistreated by their worshippers. He also notes that these gods receive the worst bits from the sacrifice, such as the head, fat, and hooves of the animals – a meal meant for dogs.[6] For Tertullian, Gods who would take such things were not worth honoring.[7]

Furthermore, Tertullian Christianized the classic arguments of euhemerism, arguing that there was much more at stake than simply honoring empty images: Pagans were actually inviting in and supplicating evil demons within their own homes.[8] Evil demons used the names of these gods for their own deceptive practices. Further attacking cherished Roman beliefs in the beneficent nature of their household deities, Tertullian asserts that the domestic gods that a baby first encountered were really evil demons set out to harm them. He writes in *De Anima*: 'Thus it happens that all men are brought into the world with idolatry as a midwife, whilst the very wombs that bear them, still bound with the

See, Timothy David Barnes, *Tertullian: An Historical and Literary Study* (Oxford, 1971), 105. Furthermore, J.H. Waszink and J.C.M. Van Winden, *Tertullianus, De Idololatria: Critical text, translation and commentary* (Leiden, 1987), 104-6, have demonstrated Tertullian's debt to Varro's *Antiquitates*, in particular the notion that the oldest phase of Roman religion did not use images.

[3] Tert., *Apol.* 13 (ANF III 29).

[4] As C.A. Contreras, Christian Views of Paganism: *Aufstieg und Niedergang der Römischen Welt* II 23.2 (1980), 974-1022, has argued, this charge against the pagan domestic gods was an attempt to prove that paganism was in fact irreligious, thus countering a similar charge often levelled against the Christians. For how pagans understood the relation between image and god, see Richard A. Gordon, The Real and the Imaginary: Production and Religion in the Greco-Roman World: *Art History* 2 (1979) 5-34. R.P.C Hanson, Christian Attitude to Pagan Religions up to the Time of Constantine the Great: *Aufstieg und Niedergang der Römischen Welt* II 23.2 (1980), 910-73, 913, has also shown that the Church fathers would usually grant that at least the educated pagans believed that the statues were not actually the gods, but rather stood in for them.

[5] Tert., *Ad Nat.* I 10 (ANF III 119).

[6] Tert., *Apol.* 14 (ANF III 29).

[7] *Ibid.*

[8] Tert., *De An.* 39 (ANF III 219).

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fillets that have been wreathed before the idols, declare their offspring to be consecrated to demons.'[9] Through euhemerism and demonization, Tertullian sets the stage for the policies of Christian leaders to expel domestic deities from the homes of pagan Romans.

2. Arnobius

Arnobius was once a pagan philosopher and thus possessed much knowledge about the Greco-Roman philosophical tradition.[10] After his conversion to Christianity, Arnobius put his knowledge to use in his *Adversus Nationes*, which was a sustained attack on Roman religious traditions. Instead of focussing on the demonic inhabitants of the images of the household deities, Arnobius chose another approach – that these images were empty of any beings at all. Even worse, domestic cult was rooted in profound confusion about who the gods actually were.

Arnobius states that some think the Lares are the gods of the homes, some that they are Manes, for some they are the heroes, for others they are the Larvae, and the souls of the departed dead.[11] In focusing on this, Arnobius zeroes in on the common confusion Romans had about their own domestic gods. '(It is) manifestly clear that you are confused, hesitate, and that you have nothing certain to say about the things that you maintain.'[12] Further, the polemic against the cult of statues may be traced back into the Greco-Roman philosophical tradition, from which Arnobius springs. For example, the pre-Socratic philosopher, Heracleitus of Ephesus, had distained the cult of statues, stating, 'That people who treat lifeless images as gods are like a man who holds conversations with houses.'[13] This is also true with other subsequent philosophers, such as Zeno, Chrysippus, and Origen's opponent in the third century, Celsus.[14] Thus, Arnobius attempted to position himself as the inheritor of, or even truer representatives of the classical tradition but continuing the rhetoric against the cult of images.[15]

Addressing the pagan dependence upon the authority of ancestral religion, Arnobius writes: 'Even if we do not personally know who the Lares are (says

[9] *Ibid.*

[10] For an important look at the life and legacy of Arnobius, see Michael Bland Simmons, *Arnobius of Sicca: Religious Conflict and Competition in the Age of Diocletian* (Oxford, 1995).

[11] Arnob., *Adv. nat.* III 41 (ACW VII 224).

[12] Arnob., *Adv. nat.* III 42 (ACW VII 225). This rhetorical strategy against paganism's lack of consistency was common in the Apologists. According to J.H.W.G. Liebeschuetz, *Continuity and Change in Roman Religion* (Oxford, 1979), 259.

[13] R.P.C. Hanson, Christian Attitude to Pagan Religions (1980), 911.

[14] *Ibid.*

[15] Mark Edwards, The Flowering of Latin Apologetic, in: *Apologetics in the Roman Empire: Pagans, Jews, and Christians* (Oxford, 1999), 197-222, 201.

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his hypothetical antagonist) ... who the Penates are, nevertheless the very agreement of the authorities proves that they do exist and that among the number of heaven dwellers they are represented.'[16] For Arnobius's argument, however, the fact that they do not actually know the names of the particular gods proves their error: 'Every one who seeks to obtain an answer from some divinity should of necessity know to whom he is making supplication.'[17]

Arnobius also shows that the Di Penates were evoked by naming specific gods. Showing how a pagan might avoid some sort of danger, he constructs the following hypothetical prayer:

> Help me, do help me, divine Penates – Thou Apollo, Thou Neptune – and remove by the clemency of your divine power all these evils by which I am consumed, terrified, and harassed.' He continues, 'Will there be any hope of getting aid from them if Ceres, Pales, Fortuna, or Genius Jovialis – not Neptune and Apollo – turn out to be the Di Penates?[18]

As we see, Arnobius uses domestic gods as easy targets to prop up his offence on Roman polytheism. In so doing, however, he is using tactics learned as a pagan rhetorician. Through these characterizations of the household deities as empty vessels, Arnobius exemplifies the philosopher's disdain for the cult of images.

3. Lactantius

Finally, Lactantius like Tertullian and Arnobius, was entrenched in Greco-Roman rhetoric and philosophy.[19] But unlike Tertullian who distinguished between the images of the domestic statuettes and the demons that dwelled within, and Arnobius who ridiculed pagans who did not know who their domestic deities actually were, Lactantius focused almost entirely on the danger posed on families who let demons their homes through domestic worship.[20]

Domestic religion for Lactantius was the origin of demonolatry.[21] The religion of the household locus for demons rather than of beneficent protectors looking out for the well being of the *familia*, as the pagan Romans would have it. The household gods actually cause sickness and death while promising to rid the home from them.[22]

[16] Arnob., *Adv. nat.* III 42 (ACW Hanson VII 225).

[17] *Ibid.*

[18] *Ibid.*

[19] For Lactantius's rhetorical strategies, see Edwards, The Flowering of Latin Apologetic, 204-6.

[20] Elizabeth Depalma Digeser, *The Making of a Christian Empire: Lactantius and Rome* (Ithaca, 2000), 88.

[21] For the origins of domestic religion, Lactantius blames Numa, who, credited with the establishment of the main religious institutions in Rome, distributed gods to families. See Lact., *Epit.* 22 (ANF VII 228-229).

[22] Lact., *De Div. inst.* II 15 (ANF VII 64).

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It is from the home that these demonic assaults first begin to infest the world by possessing human beings. The Genius, which was for pagans a good spirit, is for Lactantius an evil demon, and thus brings evil into the home.[23] In this way, Lactantius takes Tertullian's argument farther to stress that these domestic demons possess their worshippers as well as their worshippers's houses.

In his Epitome of the *Divine Institutes*, Lactantius writes:

(Demons) attach themselves, therefore, to individuals, and occupy houses under the name of Genii or (Di) Penates. To these temples are built, to these libations are daily offered as to the Lares, to these honor is paid as to the averters of evils. These from the beginning, that they might turn away men from the knowledge of the true God, introduced new superstitions and worship of gods.[24]

The evil spirits cling to humans because they wish to appear as guardians, Genii, for they seek to achieve some solace for their fall in seeking the ruin of humanity.[25] Thus, the domestic cult of the Genius of the paterfamilias is problematic for Lactantius since it honors not only the demons but also their rebellion against God. They can be repelled, however, by the sign of the cross,[26] showing the power of the Christian God in the act of exorcism since these so-called gods are actually agents of the devil.

Conclusion

Tertullian, Arnobius, and Lactantius acknowledged the important role the household deities had in the pagan Rome, belittling them as mere objects, or, worse, containers of evil. By the late fourth century, the traditional Roman household deities were still popular enough among the pagan population to warrant specific mention in the *Codex Theodosianus*: No one may 'venerate his Lar with fire, his Genius with wine, his Di Penates with fragrant odors; he shall not burn lights to them, place incense before them, or suspend wreaths for them.'[27] Thus, the work begun in the second century by the Latin Fathers started in motion a direct assault against some of the most popular gods of the Roman world. From its very beginnings, Christians understood full and well that in order to Christianize the Roman Empire they needed to strike at the Roman home and hearth.

[23] Emil Schneweis, *Angels and Demons According to Lactantius* (Washington, 1944), 92.

[24] Lact., *Epit.* 28 (ANF VII 232).

[25] E. Schneweis, *Angels and Demons* (1944), 73.

[26] Lact., *De Div. inst.* IV 27 (ANF VII 129).

[27] *Cod. Theod.* XVI 10. 12, *The Theodosian Code and Novels, and the Sirmondian Constitutions*, transl. C. Pharr (New York, 1969), 473. Considering the archaeological evidence for domestic religion continuing through the fourth century, and perhaps later, this prohibition may be taken with a straight face. See note 1.

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Ancient Christianity and the Techniques of Information

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'... the Church, having received this preaching and this faith, although scattered throughout the whole world, yet, as if occupying but one house, carefully preserves it. She also believes these points [of doctrine] just as if she had but one soul, and one and the same heart, and she proclaims them, and teaches them, and hands them down, with perfect harmony, as if she possessed only one mouth. For, although the languages of the world are dissimilar, yet the import of the tradition is one and the same. For the Churches which have been planted in Germany do not believe or hand down anything different, nor do those in Spain, nor those in Gaul, nor those in the East, nor those in Egypt, nor those in Libya, nor those which have been established in the central regions of the world. But as the sun, that creature of God, is one and the same throughout the whole world, so also the preaching of the truth shines everywhere, and enlightens all men that are willing to come to know the truth.'[1]

This famous extract of Irenaeus' *Adversus Haereses* written in the second half of the second century says much about how information mattered to Christians, and it says much about the reasons it mattered. It speaks of the fast spread of Christianity in various regions of the Empire and about the necessity of keeping unity of faith despite diversity, including diversity of language, and distance. The explanation given by the author of the old *Dictionnaire de Théologie Catholique*, who wrote in 1936 in the entry 'propagation admirable de la foi' was that: 'une propagation aussi admirable constitue un véritable miracle d'ordre moral, marquant une intervention positive de Dieu en faveur du catholicisme'.[2] If we don't find this satisfactory, we may nevertheless agree that production and control of information was a vital issue for early Christianity, and that information, the spreading of news, may be an important subject for the historian. Notwithstanding the possible exaggerations of Irenaeus about the actual area of dissemination of Christianity, or the fact that linguistic differences were of little importance in an Empire where Latin and Greek were widespread linguae francae, the fact remains that Christianity in Late Antiquity was organized not as a centralized institution, but as a great number of local churches, local communities eager to share the same faith and to be in communion with each other. Contrary to other religions, the core of Christianity was not ritual,

[1] Iren., *Adv. haer.* I 10.

[2] Albert Michel, s.v. Propagation admirable du christianisme: *DTC* 13,1 (Paris, 1936), col. 692-708.

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but knowledge, dogma. This meant that there was a need to know what the content of the shared faith was.

It is worth looking more closely to see on what sort of occasions information circulating from one community to another was needed. Originally, information was needed to spread the new religion, to spread Christianity and its doctrine. But it would be presumptuous to try to say anything new about the importance of letters and other forms of communication in Apostolic times, and I shall leave aside the much discussed question of missionary activity. For existent communities, information was primarily needed in cases of crisis, and controversies are logically the best place to start.

In some cases, we do not know precisely how local trouble was made known to a more important Church. In the case of the debate which inspired *The Dialogue of Origen with Heraclides*, Origen only says that 'it has come to my ears that here, and in these parts, here are people who believe that after leaving this life, the soul is deprived of sense and remains in the tomb, in its body.' The precise channel of information is not known, but it was essential for Origen to be informed so that he could be in a position to discuss the question with Heraclides. In many other cases, we can follow more precisely the way new controversies spread across the Empire. When Cornelius and Novatian were both elected bishops of Rome in 251, at a time when the discussion over the fate of the *lapsi* was raging, letters were sent to Cyprian by both parties (*litteris ... ab utrique parte susceptis*) which launched a complex process: while rumours were spread in Africa against Cornelius, the African bishops Pompeius and Stephanus, who happened to be in Rome, were asked to guarantee the authenticity of news transmitted by letters written by Cornelius and by other Italian bishops supporting him.[3] Even after Cornelius was officially recognized as legitimate by the African churches, a later letter of Cyprian (to Antonius) informs us that two streams of information were running concurrently in Africa: the official one, based on 'official' documents, 'the account of our fellow bishops in the whole world, who confirmed unanimously his election' and the 'lies of malicious detractors'.[4] In the same spirit, when Cyprian was struggling in Africa about the same question of *lapsi*, and before an African council could gather to make a decision, he wrote to the Roman clergy (without a bishop at the time) to inform it of the local situation and his personal position, and he got an approving answer.[5] In such circumstances, as often, information did not only trigger the controversy; it became part of it, supplying the actors with documents which were used on later occasions as arguments to defend their position. According to Eusebius of Caesarea, in the Roman council of 251, Cornelius could present 'letters, written in Latin, by Cyprian and his African colleagues' among the proofs of his legitimacy.

[3] Cyprian, *Ep.* 45.2.
[4] Cyprian, *Ep.* 55.9.
[5] Cyprian, *Ep.* 30.12.

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Beside informal and official means to spread news of a new controversy, we should not forget the efforts made by the inventors of 'new' ideas to promote their doctrinal views. Arius showed himself very resourceful in this matter: in a rather traditional way, he created a network of supporters by sending letters to well chosen addressees, but when he was expelled from the church of Alexandria, he went on campaigning all over Egypt and the East. Denouncing him and his supporters to the bishop of Constantinople, Alexander of Alexandria wrote:

'They are deceivers, and propagate lies, and they never adhere to the truth. They go about to different cities with no other intent than to deliver letters under the pretext of friendship and in the name of peace, and by hypocrisy and flattery to obtain other letters in return, in order to deceive a few silly women who are laden with sins.'[6]

Here as well as in the case of the correspondence between Rome and Carthage, letters have the double function of transmitting pieces of information and giving proof of a link between the sender and the receiver. By delivering letters, Arius was informing people of his situation and probably defending his views; by obtaining letters, he was collecting expressions of communion, possibly to be used in further councils. To complete the picture of Arius as a master in communication, we should remember the Thalia, a defence in verse of his doctrine in an entertaining popular form, known only by a few lines quoted ironically by Athanasius.

If a lot of energy was used to spread new controversies, even more efforts were displayed to let other churches know that a controversy had been ended. Let's take as a case study the way the council of Antioch condemning Paul of Samosate in 268 ended, according to Eusebius of Caesarea:

'The pastors who had assembled about this matter, prepared by common consent an epistle addressed to Dionysius, bishop of Rome, and Maximus of Alexandria, and sent it to all the provinces. In this they make manifest to all their own zeal and the perverse error of Paul, and the arguments and discussions which they had with him, and show the entire life and conduct of the man. It may be well to put on record at the present time the following extracts from their writing ...'[7]

Of course, after an 'orthodox' council, we expect a very official and formal process. In some respects this is what we get: only one letter was written, and then reproduced (nothing is said about possible translation), most probably to avoid any misunderstanding due to differences in wording, and the two bishops named are those of the most important sees: Alexandria and Rome, which suggests a hierarchical pattern of communication. That Eusebius could copy the letter itself – motivated by the same concern of authenticity – shows that such letters were kept in archives, so that communication went not only through

[6] Theod., *Hist. eccl.* I 4.58.
[7] Euseb., *Hist. eccl.* VII 30.

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space, but though time as well. Eusebius mentions only Dionysius and Maximus, but the letter was actually addressed 'To Dionysius and Maximus, and to all our fellow-ministers throughout the world, bishops, presbyters, and deacons, and to the whole Catholic Church under heaven'. If we understand this literally, as Eusebius did, it means that in Italy and in Egypt, only the metropolitan bishops received the letter, and they had the responsibility of transmitting the information to the bishops of their province; does this mean that in other provinces, the letter was sent to all bishops or to some chosen bishops, with the same responsibility? It is not a very likely hypothesis, as it would require first an up-to-date knowledge of ecclesiastical geography, and then considerable resources to send messages not only to Alexandria and Rome, but to Carthage, Gaul and the whole East. No Church in the third century had at its disposal the people and the money needed to carry out such a task.

It is therefore more likely that the address of the letter did not refer to actual people, but to an ideal area of dissemination of news, which was meant to express the unity, the catholicity of the whole Church. Even in later times, when synodical letters were more widely disseminated, it is doubtful that there were systematically sent to *all* bishops. It would be worth investigating the dissemination of synodical letters in relation with the development of regional church organization.

Controversies were not the only opportunity to transmit information. Every student of patristic texts understands what Guglielmo Cavallo means when he describes early Christian literature as an 'emergenza di scrivere molto', of a 'massiccio, talora frenetico scrivere' entirely devoted to doctrinal matters.[8] The concern for communication appears clearly in the introduction of the Martyrdom of Polycarp, written in the second half of the 2nd century; the church at Philomelium asked the church of Smyrna to send a written account of the events. To answer this request, 'one of the brethren' of Smyrna wrote the text. The conclusion of the text expresses the same urge of communication we have already seen in the address of the council of Antioch: 'When you have heard these things, send the letter to the brethren further on, so that they also may glorify the Lord.'[9] Even if this quote is part of the fourth century interpolations, it shows how much and why information mattered to Christians: not only causes of troubles had to be publicized, in order to avoid confusion and the spread of heresy, but occasions of celebration were also worthy of notice, in order to reinforce the sense of communion and the motivation of the faithful. That is why information was not only exceptional, in case of crisis, but routine, to nourish a permanently renewed sense of community.

[8] Guglielmo Cavallo, Diffusione e ricezione dello scritto nell'antichità cristiana: strumenti maniere mediazioni, in: *Comunicazione e ricezione del documento cristiano in epoca tardoantica, XXXII Incontro di studiosi dell'antichità cristiana (Roma, 8-10 maggio 2003)* (Roma, 2004), 13.

[9] Quoted by Kim Haines-Eitzen, *Guardians of Letters: Literacy, Power, and the Transmitters of Early Christian Literature* (Oxford, 2000).

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It is indeed remarkable that Christian communities developed a need for information not only when there was something exceptional to communicate, but as a condition of their existence. I am alluding here to the efforts made to broadcast the name of bishops; we have already heard of such a practice when speaking of Cyprian and Cornelius. We know for sure that in mid third century, it was already an established custom to communicate the name of newly elected bishops, even if we do not know how widespread and systematic it was (we know for example that Cyprian knew the name of the bishop of Lyon, but not that of the new bishop of Arles, which he requested from pope Stephen).[10] The important point is not that bishops in the third century actually knew the names of all their fellow bishops all over the inhabited world, but that they were supposed to know them, and to be able to communicate with all of them. But the organization improved with time; at the beginning of the fourth century, the bishop of Carthage, according to Augustine (reconstructing the case of Caecilian), 'saw himself united by letters of communion both to the Roman Church, in which the supremacy of an apostolic chair has always flourished, and to all other lands from which Africa itself received the gospel ...'[11]

The hierarchical pattern already visible in the synodal letter of the council of Antioch became more and more systematic. At the end of the fifth century (we do not have earlier documents), the newly elected bishop of Rome announced his election to all the Italian bishops within his jurisdiction, to the metropolitan bishops of the West (in Gaul, Spain, Africa, probably Northern Italy), to the patriarchs and to the emperors. At the beginning of the fifth century in Constantinople, later in the West, the names of the patriarchs were read out during the celebration of the mass; it was only a small – and obvious – piece of information, but it still kept the essential signification: it expressed the unity of the church through communion with distant communities. It is worth insisting how important such a practice, was: it has no direct parallel in the ancient world. By the reading of the diptychs, a piece of information was included in the ritual of the mass, it became part of the ritual (which is paradoxical) allowing every person attending the mass to know how catholic his church was. Thus at the end of the fifth and during the sixth century, diptychs became the main manifestation of failed – or restored – communion between churches, as can be seen in the schism of Acacius or during the schism of Milan and Aquileia.

Other media of communication were used, which contributed to bind the churches, or to inflame debates between them. Already in the middle of the third century, Denys, bishop of Alexandrian, sends every years 'Easter letters', addressed to 'the brothers of Egypt', precising the date of Lent and Easter,[12] a

[10] Cyp., *Ep.* 68.5.

[11] Aug., *Ep.* 43.7.

[12] Pierre Maraval, Alexandrie et l'Égypte, in: Charles and Luce Pietri (eds.), *Histoire du christianisme des origines à nos jours*, II, *Naissance d'une chrétienté (250-430)* (Paris, 1995), 885.

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practice which is well documented in the East in the fourth century, but unknown in the West until the very end of the fifth century.[13] Easter letters were designed for communication between a metropolitan church and its dependents, they did not claim to be addressed to all churches in the world.

It seems to me that Christianity so created specific needs in matters of information, and that Christians responded to these needs with a great deal of ingenuity. Some of the answers they reached were actually technical innovations. The use of the codex instead of the volumen was one of them.

This is too vast a subject to deal with here, but let me quote Régis Debray, the inventor of French 'médiologie' (study of media): 'En langue de médiologue: le codex à la place du rouleau, c'est une M.O. (matière organisée) réduite',[14] hence easier to convey, easier to communicate. Another 'technical' innovation might be the increasing use of the *sermo humilis*, the concern to speak in a way intelligible to the audience, whatever the audience is.[15] In this respect, Arius writing the Thalia is no different from many other Christian authors prepared to depart from traditional literary forms, and in some cases to renounce some of their literary skills in order to communicate more efficiently. Even more important are the organizational innovations. Not being a centralized institution, but yearning for unity, Christian churches made good use of all the supports of communication available to stay in touch, and made important progress towards organized and hierarchical systems of information.

At the same time, this organization was much more sophisticated than it was systematic, even in later times. The Roman Empire had developed a very efficient system of information.[16] One would expect to see the Christian churches benefit from the conversion of the Emperor to facilitate their communication. We all know that as early as 314, Constantine invited the bishops convoked to the imperial council of Arles to use the facilities of the *cursus publicus*, and we remember Ammianus complaining, at the end of the fourth century, that this most strategic and important tool of imperial policy was unjustifiably exploited to benefit clerics.[17] But if we enlarge our view, we can see that imperial intervention in matters of church communication were extremely limited. Everything to do with imperial councils indeed benefited of the best means of information known. Some conciliar canons were published as texts of law, and we know very precisely, in the case of the Conference of Carthage in 411, that the decisions of the Conference were publicly displayed in all the cities of the

[13] Martinus F.A. Brok, À propos des lettres festales: *Vigiliae Christianae* 5 (1951) 101-110.

[14] Régis Debray, *Dieu, un itinéraire* (Paris, 2001), 180.

[15] Michel Banniard, *Viva Voce: Communication écrite et communication orale du IVe au IXe siècle en Occident latin* (Paris, 1992), 75.

[16] Claire Sotinel, Information and political power in Late Antiquity, in: Philippe Rousseau (ed.), *The Blackwell Companion to Late Antiquity* (Oxford, 2009), 125-38.

[17] Amm., *Res Gestae* 16.18; Edward David Hunt, Christians and Christianity in Ammianus Marcellinus: *The Classical Quarterly N. S.* 35 (1985) 186-200, 186.

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province and that the *Gesta*, recorded by imperial scribes, were supposed to be available to everyone.

But such means were not used in the case of purely ecclesiastical meetings. Regional councils may have been recorded, but synodal letters only displayed the canons and the name of the participants (as for the first ecumenical councils). The area of dissemination of these letters is not clear: they were probably meant mainly for the bishops who had sat or should have sat in the council, as a memorandum of what should be communicated to their flock. If so, their role was to guarantee the authenticity of the decisions made, rather than to inform other people (except in the case of absentees). If the Churches wanted to communicate on subjects without direct relation with the emperor, they had to rely on their own resources, and these resources remained limited (with important differences between churches) until the end of Late Antiquity, if not later.

We do not know for sure the status and the number of the staff employed to keep record of circulating information – their existence is certain only in major churches like Rome – and we know for sure that no church had any permanent staff employed to carry mail.[18] It is not very surprising that, with a few exceptions, the Christian churches were not allowed to use the imperial post or other means of official communication. The contrary would mean that the Church was an imperial institution, which it was not, at least until the sixth century. And it is even less surprising that Christian churches could not imitate the imperial system. The post was one of the more costly items of public expenditure, and only fiscal resources could pay for it. There was nothing similar in the Church organization. When a church was important enough to organize some sort of information system, it kept on calling in occasional messengers. Even if these messengers were most often clerics, the model followed was much closer to private networks of communication than to the imperial post. Many prosopographical studies have demonstrated that private messengers were massively used to transmit letters, polemical works, and treatises.[19] These rough systems of information developed as 'corporate frameworks' rather than 'public networks' of communication, to use the categories of media studies.[20]

[18] Claire Sotinel, Le personnel épiscopal, enquête sur la puissance de l'évêque dans la cité, in: Éric Rebillard and Claire Sotinel, *L'évêque dans la cité: image et autorité* (Rome, 1998), 105-28.

[19] Valeria Novembri, I latori e i loro percorsi in Basilio di Cesarea e Paolino di Nola, in: *Comunicazione e ricezione* (2004), 319-28; Sigrid Mratschek, *Der Briefwechsel des Paulinus von Nola: Kommunikation und soziale Kontakte zwischen christlichen Intellektuellen* (Göttingen, 2002); Matilde Caltabiano, I latori della corrispondenza di Agostino tra idealizzazione e realtà: *Agustinianum* 41 (2001) 113-48.

[20] Sophia Menache, Introduction: The 'Pre-History' of Communication, in: Sophia Menache (ed.), *Communication in the Jewish Diaspora: The Pre-Modern World* (Leiden, New York, Köln, 1996), 1-13.

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Even in later controversies, large amount of information circulated wildly, without any control, either by imperial or ecclesiastical authorities. As late as mid sixth century, the deacon Pelagius took the initiative for informing the African clergy of the problems raised by the imperial edict condemning the *Three Chapters*, without asking either the emperor or pope Vigilius. Later during the controversy, the same pope could do nothing to prevent another deacon, Rusticus, secretly transmitting to Africa Italy unauthorised copies of the *Iudicatum* (548).[21]

Even more interesting is that, even in the cases when the imperial resources were used to spread ecclesiastical information, concurrent Christian networks were used all the same. All the councils are known more through translations and compilations gathered by various actors than through official documents;[22] these *publizistische Sammlungen* – as defined by their editor Edouard Schwartz – were almost always polemical, like the commented acts of the council of Aquileia (381),[23] the *collectio novariensis* containing the acts of the second council of Ephesus, made in Rome on pope Leo's orders,[24] or the Latin translation of the *Acts of Chalcedon* made by the deacon Rusticus during – and on the occasion of – the *Three Chapters* controversy.[25] In Africa after 411, even though the official *Gesta* were everywhere available, Augustine felt the need to write a *Breviarum* of the conference, as a more convenient tool to convince Donatists.[26] These few examples, chosen among many, suggest that using imperial resources was not seen by Christian authorities as the only (the best?) way to deal with information.

I would suggest that, somehow, the Christian churches chose not to imitate the centralized and efficient system of information of the Roman Empire, as they probably chose, to a certain extent, not to use it as much as they could have done. The reason might be that information had in the life of ancient Christianity a role deeply different from the role it played in the political life of the Roman Empire because – as I hope to have demonstrated – it was not (only) a tool of power and persuasion, but the only way to achieve communion in a multipolar organization. In many respect, this gave to information a new importance, even in the life of ordinary people. But exploring this – absolutely fascinating – aspect of the history of information in Late Antiquity would be the theme of another paper.

[21] Detailed account of Rusticus' campaign to defend the Three Chapters in: *PCBE Italie* 2 (1956-9).

[22] Ramon Teja, Silvia Acerbi, Forme di redazione e modalità di trasmissione degli acta conciliari: il II concilio di Efeso (449), in: *Comunicazione e ricezione* (2004), 183-94.

[23] *Scolies ariennes sur le concile d'Aquilée* (SC 267).

[24] *Collectio Nouariensis de re Eutychis*, ACO 2.2.1.

[25] ACO II 3.1, vii-xii; *PCBE Italie* 2 (1958).

[26] *Actes de la conférence de Carthage* (SC 194) 353-7.

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The Deathbed Conversion of Galerius Maximianus to Religious Tolerance: Fact or Fraud?

David Woods, Cork

Writing at Nicomedia c. 315, Lactantius composed a detailed account of the illness which killed the eastern emperor Galerius Maximianus in 311.[1] He describes how an ulcer appeared on his genitals, and how it refused to respond to any medical treatment. On the contrary, it grew ever larger and deeper, and became infected with 'worms', presumably maggots. Eventually, when his suffering had lasted for a year, Galerius issued an edict by which he ended the persecution of Christians. Lactantius records that the edict was published at Nicomedia on 30 April, and that Galerius died only a few days later.[2] Writing in Palestine c. 313/14, bishop Eusebius of Caesarea composed a similar account of the suffering and death of Galerius in the second edition of his ecclessiastical history.[3] He describes the same illness with the same symptoms, and again claims that this illness persuaded Galerius to issue his edict in toleration of Christianity.[4] He also reports that Galerius died immediately after issuing this edict.[5] Hence two contemporary sources agree that Galerius Maximianus died almost immediately after issuing an edict ending the persecution of Christians. Nevertheless, although most commentators seem ready to accept this happy coincidence at face value, that Galerius did indeed authorize the edict of toleration issued in his name immediately before his death, there is room for doubt.[6]

[1] Lact., *De Mort. Pers.* 33 (SC 39, 115-7).

[2] Lact., *DMP* 35.3 (SC 39, 118): 'Nec tamen ille hoc facto veniam sceleris accepit a deo, sed post dies paucos commendatis Licinio coniuge sua et filio atque in manum traditis, cum iam totius corporis membra diffluerent, horrenda tabe consumptus est.'

[3] See Timothy D. Barnes, The Editions of Eusebius' Ecclesiastical History: *GRBS* 21 (1980), 191-201.

[4] Eus., *Hist. Eccl.* VIII 16-17 (SC 55, 37-9).

[5] Eus., *Hist. Eccl.* VIII App. 1 (SC 55, 41): 'Αλλ' ὁ μὲν τῆς γραφῆς αἴτιος μετὰ τὴν τοιάνδε ὁμολογίαν αὐτίκα καὶ οὐκ εἰς μακρὸν τῶν ἀλγηδόνων ἀπαλλαγεῖς μεταλλάττει τὸν βίον.

[6] See e.g. William H.C. Frend, *Martyrdom and Persecution in the Early Church* (Oxford, 1965), 510, who suggests that Galerius may have drafted his edict at the instance of Licinius. Harold A. Drake, *Constantine and the Bishops: The Politics of Intolerance* (Baltimore, 2000), 152 accepts Galerian authorship, commenting that 'it was as rare in antiquity as it is now for rulers to acknowledge a policy error publicly, and the fact that Galerius did so is an indication of the enormity of his misjudgement.'

Studia Patristica XLIV, 85-89.
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There are two good reasons to doubt that Galerius authorized the edict of toleration issued in his name. The first is that it is doubtful whether he would have been physically capable of issuing any coherent instructions at this point in his illness, only days before his death. While it is impossible at this remove in time to diagnose the precise nature of his illness, it was clearly extremely debilitating and painful if there is any truth at all to the surviving descriptions of its origin and symptoms.[7] In reality, therefore, he ought to have spent his last days unconscious, or wandering in and out of consciousness, whether as a result of the pain, the sleep deprivation, the sheer physical exhaustion, or the effects of whatever medication the doctors had managed to administer to him.[8] The idea that he was in good enough physical or mental condition to play any part at all in the formulation of an important new piece of legislation beggars belief. The second reason to doubt that he authorized the edict issued in his name is that it contradicted everything which he had stood for previously. He seems to have been the driving force behind the initial decision to begin the persecution of Christians in 303, and even if one does not necessarily accept everything which Lactantius says about his activities at or about that time, his behaviour as the most senior of the tetrarchs from 305 onwards proves that he was fully supportive of the decision to persecute the Christians.[9] There is simply no good reason why he should have reversed a major policy decision so late in the day. One must beware here of falling into the trap of believing that he would necessarily have interpreted his illness as divine punishment for his persecution of the Christians. That is the Christian interpretation after the event, but Galerius was not a Christian.

So who really composed the edict of toleration, and why? It is important to bear in mind that it must have been obvious to all that Galerius was going to die by the time that the edict of toleration was issued in his name. Such was the nature and duration of his illness that there could have been no doubt towards the end about how it would end, regardless of one's medical knowledge or training. Indeed, it is not impossible that he may already have been dead

[7] The death of a tyrant as a result of 'worms' was a common literary theme. See e.g. Arthur Keaveney and John A. Madden, Phthiriasis and Its Victims: *SO* 57 (1982) 87-99. Furthermore, Lactantius does seem to have tried to lend his account a certain scientific plausibility by the use of technical medical phraseology. See James N. Adams, A Medical Theory and the Text at Lactantius, *Mort. Persec.* 33.7 and Pelagonius 347: *CQ* 38 (1988) 522-7. Nevertheless, there is no need to doubt that Galerius did die of a painful and debilitating disease, whatever its exact nature.

[8] On possible medications, see e.g. Ioanna A. Ramoutsaki, Helen Askitopoulou, and Eleni Konsolaki, Pain Relief and Sedation in Roman Byzantine Texts: *Mandragoras Officinarum, Hyoscyanos Niger* and *Atropa Belladona*, in: José C. Diz *et al.* (eds.), *The History of Anesthesia Proceedings of the 5th International Symposium on the History of Anesthesia, Santiago, Spain 19-23 September 2001* (Amsterdam, 2002), 43-50.

[9] For an attempt to minimize the responsibility of Galerius for the persecution, see P.S. Davies, The Origin and Purpose of the Persecution of AD303: *JThSt N.S.* 40 (1989) 66-94.

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when the edict of toleration was issued in his name.[10] The question, therefore, is who benefitted most from his apparent decision to reverse his long-held policy against the Christians. Obviously, Christians would have had the most to gain from such a reversal of policy, but it is highly unlikely that many Christians could have managed to survive undetected at the court of Galerius until this point, least of all at the level necessary to perpetrate the fraud under discussion here. Hence those who issued this edict in the name of Galerius were probably not really interested in this issue as such. Their interest would have lain rather in the political effect of this dramatic reversal of policy.

Here we have the benefit of hindsight. The fact that Maximinus renewed the persecution of Christians in the East in November 311 reveals where his sympathies really lay, that he was genuinely opposed towards Christianity.[11] In contrast, his subsequent actions reveal that Licinius did not feel strongly on the issue one way or the other. He seems to have recognised that he would have to tolerate Christianity in order to secure a better relationship with his western neighbour, whether that would be Constantine or Maxentius. This would then allow him to focus all his energy on dealing with Maximinus in the East. Indeed, the weakness of his strategic position is best revealed by the fact that Constantine managed to persuade him to proceed beyond mere toleration of Christianity and to order the restoration of all buildings and property which the Christians had lost during the persecution when the two men met at Milan in February 313 and agreed the so-called edict of Milan.[12] It is clear, therefore, that the apparent issue of the edict of toleration by Galerius immediately before his death worked to the advantage of Licinius in two ways. First, it provided him with a precedent for tolerating Christianity, the policy which he would need to pursue in order to cement good relations with his western neighbour. In particular, he could now tolerate Christianity while still claiming to be the true heir of Galerius. Second, it wrongfooted Maximinus whose tough enforcement of the edicts of persecution had always revealed him to be a committed anti-Christian. It was almost inevitable that he would renew the persecution again, and this would allow Licinius to criticize him for disrespecting the last wishes of his great predecessor Galerius.

It is my suggestion, therefore, that the key officials surrounding Galerius during the last days of his illness issued the edict of toleration in his name as

[10] Livia delayed announcing the death of Augustus in 14 until her son Tiberius could return to Italy from Dalmatia. See Tac., *Ann.* 1.5; Dio 56.31.1. Similarly, Agrippina delayed the news of Claudius' death in 54 until she had arranged things in favour of her son Nero. See Tac., *Ann.* 12.68. The greatest parallel is with the circumstances surrounding the death of Trajan in 117. His successor Hadrian received the letter reporting his adoption by Trajan only two days before he received the news of Trajan's death. The suspicion was that Trajan's wife and advisors were responsible for the letter of adoption rather than Trajan himself. See Dio 69.1; *SHA Hadr.* 4.

[11] In general on Maximinus' religious policy, see Stephen Mitchell, Maximinus and the Christians in AD312: A New Latin Inscription: *JRS* 78 (1988) 105-24.

[12] See Lact., *DMP* 48.2-12 (SC 39, 132-5); Eus., *Hist. Eccl.* X 5.2-14 (SC 55, 104-7).

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part of a conspiracy designed to favour the emperor Licinius against the emperor Maximinus.[13] They knew that civil-war was inevitable between Licinius and Maximinus, and they acted as they did in order to curry favour with Licinius. They realized that they would not be able to prevent Maximinus from immediately occupying the provinces under the direct control of Galerius, but this was their effort at damage control, their preparation for the final confrontation between the two eastern emperors in the near future. That a pro-Licinius faction was in control of the court at this stage is confirmed by the fact that Lactantius also claims that Galerius entrusted his wife and son to Licinius between his issue of the edict of toleration and his death.[14] Yet this claim is even more suspicious than the claim that Galerius issued the edict of toleration. The facts that Maximinus was Galerius' nephew and closest male relative by blood, that his daughter was betrothed to Galerius' illegitimate son Candidianus, and that his wife was probably Galerius' daughter or granddaughter, ought to have marked him out as the true heir of Galerius, to whom he would naturally have entrusted his wife Valeria and his son Candidianus.[15] Indeed, the fact that Valeria fled to Maximinus rather than Licinius following the death of her husband shows where she felt that she would be safest also.[16] So unless one believes that a dying Galerius ignored his wife's concerns for her safety and the legitimate claims to preference of his nearest male relative, the obvious suggestion is that the claim that he entrusted his wife and son to Licinius rather than to Maximinus was a deliberate fabrication. Once one admits this in the case of Galerius' alleged wish for his wife and son, one is forced to admit that the same is probably true of his alleged issue of the edict of toleration also.

It may be objected that the interpretation offered here is entirely speculative, and that neither Lactantius nor Eusebius preserve any firm evidence in support of the above reconstruction. Yet this is hardly surprising. Neither Lactantius nor Eusebius was an objective reporter of events, and it served their interests in each case to report exactly as they do. First, it appealed to their human desire for revenge at least, if not to their theological beliefs also, that the man whom they believed to have been responsible for the persecution of Christians should have publicly confessed the error of his ways before he died screaming. Hence they very much wanted to believe what the Licinian propagandists told them.

[13] The exact whereabouts of Licinius remain unclear, but he was probably in the diocese of the Pannoniae or the Moesiae. See Timothy D. Barnes, *The New Empire of Diocletian and Constantine* (Cambridge, Mass., 1982), 80-1. If he had been present at or near the court of Galerius at or about the time of his death, then his mere presence would have rallied Galerius' forces to his side. He would also have been escorted by his own elite troops. In such a situation, Maximinus could not have completed his occupation of Asia Minor as quickly as he did.

[14] Lact., *DMP* 35.3 (SC 39, 118).

[15] See Christopher S. Mackay, Lactantius and the Succession to Galerius: *CPh* 94 (1999) 198-209; Timothy D. Barnes, The Wife of Maximinus: *CPh* 94 (1999) 459-60.

[16] Lact., *DMP* 39.2 (SC 39, 122). The fact that Valeria was wrong to believe that she would be safe with Maximinus is irrelevant.

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Second, they would have been inclined to dismiss anything which Maximinus said simply because he was a fierce persecutor of Christians. They would not have wanted to mention the fact had he or any of his supporters claimed that the edict of toleration issued in Galerius' name was a fraud because this would have complicated their simplistic depiction of the tolerant emperors as good emperors and the persecuting emperors as bad emperors. The idea that a persecuting emperor might have had right on his side in this particular case was not an issue which they would have wished to pursue.

Yet there is one small piece of evidence which may suggest that Maximinus was far more suspicious of the edict of toleration attributed to Galerius than either Christian author has recorded. It is noteworthy that he did not promulgate the original edict of toleration itself throughout the territory under his control.[17] Instead, he ordered his praetorian prefect Sabinus to send a letter to the provincial governors by which he grudgingly restored a minimum of religious freedom to the Christians. The advantage of this course of action was that it allowed him to conceal the fact that Galerius himself had ordered the toleration of Christianity. It has usually been assumed that his procedure in this matter indicates merely his reluctance to enforce the full substance of the edict, but it may well reflect a reluctance to believe that Galerius himself had actually issued it. After all, no-one understood the propaganda value of forged documents more than Maximinus himself, as his circulation of the so-called *Acts of Pilate* during his subsequent renewal of the persecution reveals.[18] Indeed, he may well have considered his circulation of such anti-Christian forgeries a just revenge for the circulation of what he privately believed to be a forgery also, Galerius' edict of toleration, even if he never acquired sufficient evidence to allow him to declare this publicly.

[17] Eus., *Hist. Eccl.* IX 1.1-7 (SC 55, 44-5).
[18] Eus., *Hist. Eccl.* IX 5 (SC 55, 50-1).

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Letters of Western Bishops to the Emperor Theodosius I and Relations between Eastern and Western Churches at the End of the Fourth Century

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A crucial point in the history of Christianity in the fourth century is the problem of church unity. In modern historiography there are various approaches to it and there is a crucial question: where were the roots of the Great Schism between East and West – in the eleventh century, the eighth or, perhaps, even in the fourth? And how Christianity has come to it? The general approaches to the relationship between the eastern and the western churches in western historiography (mostly Catholic and Protestant) and in eastern historiography (mostly Orthodox) are sometimes diametrically opposite.

The purpose of this publication is the attempt to understand on the basis of available sources the nature of the relationships between the eastern and the western bishops. The analysis relates to the period, when the Roman empire was united for the last time in its history and when Christianity in its Nicene orthodox version became the only official religion in the huge empire of Late Antiquity, that is to say, when the conditions were the most favourable for church unity.

First, when approaching the problem of church unity, we have to keep in mind that the divergence of eastern and western Christendom was predetermined by the initial difference between economic, social, cultural and political conditions of the Eastern and Western parts of the Roman Empire.[1] Rome created the political unity of the world of antiquity and thus made it possible for Christianity to become a world religion. However, Rome failed to create a united world. Moreover, when the political unity during the crisis in the third century seemed to collapse, the unity of the Roman world turned out to be a fiction. From the third century onwards the division of the Roman empire became an almost permanent feature; from 285 A.D. (the beginning of the tetrarchy of Diocletian) until 395 A.D. (the final division of the Roman empire after the death of Theodosius), that is for a period of 110 years, it is hardly possible to count twenty years of relative unity.

These political conditions provided the background for Christianization. The legal status of Christianity after the so-called edict of Milan in 313 A.D., the

[1] Gennadiy G. Mayorov, *Formirivanie srednevekovoi philosophii. Latinskaya Patristica* (Moscow, 1979), 30f.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 91-104.
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increasing privileges of the clergy and the increase in the material wealth of the Church, allowed it to develop, as Russian church historian V. Bolotov defined, its entire hierarchical programme.[2] The result of the programme was an increase in the number of the clergy and the creation of new positions and offices within the church organization. The formation of the church hierarchy can be regarded as a reflection of the Christianization of the Roman society on the one hand, and a bureaucratization of the Roman state during the period of dominate on the other. In its search for integration within the empire the Christian Church tried to build its administrative, territorial and even internal structure into the structure of the Roman state. It goes without saying that it was very difficult to achieve religious unity when political unity was doubtful.

Another important factor of divergence was the process of Christianization itself, which was accompanied by both religious and political struggle. The forms of the struggle were different – from mutual accusations of heresy to local arguments and schisms, but the causes and the reasons were obvious. The bishops were striving for more authority, more power and more wealth. It was still possible to get more of those in the fourth century, when the structure of the church was still in the process of formation and there were still large territories and many people beyond Christian influence. That is why the first discussions about the priority of the episcopal sees took place in the fourth century after the edict of Milan and when Christianization had entered into its most active phase.

The significance of bishops and their episcopacies was determined by the economic and political importance of the centres over which they presided. The availability of a solid material basis, episcopal authority over a large territory, the increasing number of subordinate clergy, interested in increasing the power of their bishop, and the new position of ecclesiastical in relation to temporal power all formed the context for the formation of church-political groupings in the fourth century, which tried to spread their influence over large areas of Roman territory and claimed leadership in the whole Christian world. Rome and Milan were such centres in the West, Constantinople, Antioch and Alexandria in the East. These ecclesiastical centres were involved in intense rivalry for priority.

In fact, relations between eastern and western churches became fragmented in the middle of the fourth century during the controversies over Arianism and other heretical movements. It was Basil the Great who in the 370s attempted to re-establish peace inside the Church (*pax ecclesiastica*)[3] in the whole Roman Empire, and it was due to his efforts in 379 A.D., that the communion between East and West was restored for a time.[4] Certainly, it was an eastern initiative

[2] Vasiliy V. Bolotov, *Lectii po istorii drevnei cerkvi*, vol. 3 (Moscow, 1994), 153.

[3] Anton V. Kartashov, *Vselenskie sobori* (Moscow, 1994), 123. See also Georges V. Florovskiy, *Vostochnie otci IV-go veka* (Moscow, 1994), 60.

[4] Vasiliy V. Bolotov, *Lectii po istorii* (1994), vol. 3, 103.

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because of the fact, that the endless dissensions were tearing the eastern churches apart.[5] In contrast the church in the West seemed more united and peaceful because of lesser dissemination of Arianism there. Moreover, many orthodox (Nicene) bishops in the East needed external authority to solve their internal problems, and it was still felt that such authority belonged to Rome alone, as the centre of the Roman world.

However, Rome treated these requests for help and concern with a degree of indifference, which drew reproaches from the eastern bishops and in the first place from Basil himself.[6] The indifference of the Roman Church can be explained this way: claiming for unquestionable priority over church matters, the Roman Church did not so much wish, but rather was unable to do anything to establish order in the east. Even more so because until 378 A.D. the eastern part of the Roman Empire was ruled by Valens, an adherent of Arianism. Therefore, under such conditions, Rome could do nothing more than take the position of a detached observer posing itself as a master of destiny of the Church over the whole Roman Empire.

The claim of the see of Rome to be superior had been made from an early date, in view of Rome's importance as the capital of the Mediterranean world. As other churches were growing and strengthening during the process of Christianization, the Roman Church tried to keep its leading position and in the fourth century it repeatedly advanced a claim for priority. These claims were also based on the decisions of the Council of Serdica of 343 A.D., which ruled that dissatisfied bishops could appeal to Pope Julius I.[7] Although the rule had local restrictions, later popes interpreted it as an exclusive privilege given to the bishop of Rome forever.[8]

Nevertheless, the eastern churches soon proved their viability and independence. A great contribution to bringing the churches of the east to unanimity was made by the Emperor Theodosius, who applied his personal efforts to putting things in the eastern churches in order trying to cope with the difficulties without the interference from the West, but through the orthodox power of the East alone.[9]

The Council of Constantinople took place in May-June, 381 A.D. It was exclusively eastern in its membership, Egypt was represented only by Timothy of Alexandria, who arrived later and participated reluctantly.[10] Western bishops

[5] The critical situation of the churches in the East was vividly depicted in the letters of St. Basil the Great, *Ep.* 90, 191, 243 and some others (PG 32).

[6] Nikolay F. Chernyavsky, *Imperator Theodosiy Velikiy i ego tsarstvovanie v cerkovno-istoricheskom otnoshenii* (Sergiev Posad, 1913), 222.

[7] Mikhail E. Posnov, *Istoria Christianskoy cerkvi (do razdeleniaya cerkvei – 1054 g.)* (Kiev, 1991), 288.

[8] Samuil G. Lozinsky, *Istoria papstva* (Moscow, 1986), 28.

[9] Nikolay F. Chernyavsky, *Imperator Theodosiy* (1913), 236.

[10] Stephen Williams, Gerard Friell, *Theodosius: The Empire at Bay* (New Haven and London, 1995), 54.

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did not know about the convocation of this council, and what is more, they could not consider it ecumenical. One of the reasons why the East in fact ignored the West was the striving of the eastern bishops for independence from Rome, which had demonstrated an indifference to eastern matters and shaken the faith of the easterners in the sincerity and desire of the westerners to help them solve their problems. Besides the Council of Constantinople had only eastern problems on its agenda.[11]

In spite of continued controversies, then quite usual for the church councils of that time, one of the main results of the Council of Constantinople at that historical moment was the achievement of certain unanimity in the eastern churches.[12]

One of the main questions discussed at the Council was the Antiochian schism.[13] The church of Antioch was represented by sixty-five bishops, as some authors indicate,[14] and the chairman of several initial sessions was Melitius of Antioch. But during the sessions of the Council, according to Socrates,[15] he fell ill and died. The death of Melitius opened a new period of Antiochian schism as the council was faced with a dilemma: should they elect a successor to Melitius or admit Paulinus as a bishop unconditionally, with the expectation that the Meletians would join his party? The second way, advocated by Gregory of Nazianzus in front of the fathers of the Council, seemed more attractive. It was appropriate for the West that supported Paulinus and, what is more, as Lucifer had consecrated Paulinus[16] he could be considered a western protégé from the canonical and formal point of view and so such a decision could open the way for a revival of communion between East and West. However, the majority of the eastern bishops had no inclination to meet this rational proposition and one of the main reasons was that they did not want to yield to the West.[17] Therefore, the Council elected presbyter Flavian as a successor to Melitius.[18]

[11] Nikolay F. Chernyavsky, *Imperator Theodosiy* (1913), 233f. Harnack also regarded the absence of the Western bishops at the council as the important symptom of long felt need to put the Eastern church beyond the surveillance of the West and make it independent in the matters of faith. Adolf Harnack, *Istoria dogmatov* (Saint Petersburg, 1906), 339.

[12] The Council established its authority as an ecumenical council only later, when it was recognized as such in 451 A.D. by the council of Chalcedon, but the Roman church recognized it as ecumenical much later than that, in 530 A.D.; even then, that recognition concerned only the creed and not the canons which the Council issued.

[13] Vasiliy V. Bolotov, *Lectii po istorii* (Moscow, 1994), vol. 4, 108.

[14] Tayar Makariy, *Istoria Antiohiiskoy pravoslavnoy cerkvi ot ee osnovania do nachala XX veka. Vol. 1 S ee osnovania do padenia Konstantinopolya, s 34 g. po 1453 g.* (Moscow, 1978), 121.

[15] Socrates, *Hist. eccl.* V 9.

[16] Theodoret, *Hist. eccl.* III 5; Socrates, *Hist. eccl.* III 6, 9.

[17] N. Shorohov, *Vzaimootnishenia mezhdu cerkvami Vostoka i Zapada v perod pervih chetireh Vselenskih soborov* (Leningrad, 1975), 42; Alexey P. Lebedev, *Vselenskie sobori IV i V vv. (obzor ih dogmaticheskoi deyatelnosti v svayzi s napravleniyami shkol alexandriiskoy i antiohiiskoy)* (Saint Petersburg, 1906), 146.

[18] Socrates, *Hist. eccl.* V 9.

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The decisions of the council were guided and approved by the Emperor Theodosius. His edict significantly differed from his famous *Cunctos Populos* of 380 A.D.: there was no reference to Pope Damasus or Peter of Alexandria and the emperor pointedly emphasized only the eastern bishops. It is worth saying that in this edict Theodosius indicated the names of certain bishops as constituting foundation of eastern orthodoxy, communion with whom was treated as a primary and decisive guideline for the true faith, but the names of Flavian and Paulinus were omitted. In doing so the emperor probably demonstrated his hope for reconciliation between East and Eest or at least wanted to avoid further complications.[19]

Approximately at the same time with the Council of Constantinople the Council of Aquileia was convened in the West. Scholars are divided on the date.[20] To my mind, strong evidence for dating is provided by the fact that neither the participants in the Council of Aquileia, nor the participants in the Council of Constantinople knew anything about the convention of the bishops in the other part of the Christian world, though both councils were concerned with 'Arianism'. That drives us to the conclusion, that both councils took place at about the same time, *i.e.* at the end of spring or at the beginning of summer, 381 A.D.

The Council of Aquileia was intended as an ecumenical council, but it turned out to be a Council of only western bishops. It dealt with particular issues and its significance was limited. Nevertheless, when the western bishops learned about the Council of Constantinople they felt offended because they had not been invited and, more than that, they became very anxious at the claim of the eastern churches to be independent.

One letter of the Council of Aquileia and two letters of the western bishops to the Emperor Theodosius well illustrate the relationships between the western and eastern churches at that time. The general view is that all these letters were written by the hand of Ambrose of Milan and they are usually included in the collections of his letters,[21] named according to the first word of their Latin text – *Quamlibet*, *Sanctum*, and *Fidei*.

The first letter *Quamlibet*[22] from the participants of the Council of Aquileia was addressed to the Emperors Gratian, Valentinian II and Theodosius I. It is

[19] Nikolay F. Chernyavsky, *Imperator Theodosiy* (1913), 288-90; Stephen Williams, Gerard Friell, *Theodosius* (1995), 55.

[20] Many, including McLynn, Liebeschuetz, Paredi, Simonetti, Samuilov, referring to *gesta Concilii Aquilei*, give the date as 3rd-5th September, 381; others argue for the early date of 380 (Adamov, Spasskiy), Frend refers it to Easter, 381; Palanque and Beyenka date the letters of the Council to May, 381; Homes Dudden gives the period between May and June, 381.

[21] Ambrosius Mediolanensis, *Ep.* 12-4 (PL 14). In *Corpus Scriptorum Ecclesiasticorum Latinorum* (CSEL 82/3) ed. by M. Zelzer these letters are included in the section *Epistolae extra collectionem* (6, 9, 8). The latest edition in English translation: J.H.W.G. Liebeschuetz (ed.), *Ambrose of Milan: Political Letters and Speeches* (Liverpool, 2005). The editing and the first publication of these letters are attributed to Paulinus, secretary of Ambrose.

[22] PL 12; *Ep. extra collectionem* 6.

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clear from the text that the participants of the Council of Aquileia knew nothing at that time about the Council of Constantinople. Probably that explains the lack of logic in this letter as some scholars assert.[23] Anyway, more than half of the letter was dedicated to the dissensions among Catholics themselves[24] about the communion with Timothy, patriarch of Alexandria and Paulinus, patriarch of Antioch.

Both of them were in communion with the western bishops, but were condemned by the orthodox eastern bishops. Timothy was charged with Apollinarianism and was deposed by Gregory of Nazianzus.[25] Paulinus was the main rival of Melitius and claimed to be patriarch of Antioch, but he was accused of being schismatic,[26] although the eastern bishops did not mind Paulinus taking the position of patriarch of Antioch after the death of Melitius, as both were known as upholders of Nicene Creed.[27] In this respect, there was a special agreement, as the letter of the Council of Aquileia says,[28] that in case of the death of either Paulinus or Melitius the survivor would take the position of patriarch of Antioch.[29]

The participants of the Council of Aquileia emphatically asked the emperors to convene a council of all the eastern orthodox bishops at Alexandria.[30] This synod, as the letter of the Council of Aquileia pointed out, should discuss the question of communion. The appeal to the emperors for help was motivated by the fact that the irruption of the enemies and the troubles of the state were the obstacles for the western bishops to sending their representatives as referees for diffusing peace again.[31]

[23] Neil B. McLynn, *Ambrose of Milan: Church and Court in a Christian Capital* (Berkeley, 1994), 140. McLynn surmises that Melitius appealed to Emperor Gratian 'with a conciliatory note that was construed as an invitation to intervene'.

[24] *inter ipsos catholicos audimus crebras dissensiones esse*, *Quamlibet* 4.

[25] PL 16, col. 988, note 29.

[26] Matthews uses the expression 'technically a schismatic', John F. Matthews, *Western Aristocracies and Imperial Court A.D. 364-425* (Oxford, 1975), 124f.

[27] Socrates, *Hist. eccl.* II 44. Still in 362 A.D. on the initiative of St Athanasius a council of twenty two bishops, partisans of the Nicene creed, took place in Alexandria, V. Nozdrachev, *Raskol Meletia i Pavlina v Antiohii v svayzi s vzaimootnosheniami Vostoka i Zapada vo vtoroi polovine IV v.* (Leningrad, 1985), 69. This council made such a decision that the meletians and the eustaphians-paulinians can have the same orthodox meaning, N. Shorohov, *Vzaimootnishenia mezhdu cerkvami* (1975), 38.

[28] *Quamlibet* 5.

[29] Socrates, *Hist. eccl.* V 5, and Sozomen, *Hist. eccl.* VII 3 inform, that six melitian presbyters and six paulinian presbyters swore solemnly and publicly that after the death of one of their leaders (*i.e.* Melitius or Paulinus) they would not be candidates for election as a bishop but would stay under the authority of the alive bishop. By the way, the future bishop of Antioch Flavian was amongst these six melitian presbyters.

[30] Alexandria was a stronghold of orthodoxy not only for western bishops (*Quamlibet* 4), but in the eyes of the West and of Theodosius himself (*CTh* 16.1.2).

[31] *Quamlibet* 5.

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At a glance, the appeal of the western bishops to the emperors looks reasonable and might be interpreted as a real wish to establish peace in the Christian church. However, there was something else in this letter – the claim of priority of the West over the East in ecclesiastical matters. In addition, as N. McLynn suggests,[32] Ambrose tried to put pressure on Theodosius, who would be admitting the priority of the Council of Aquileia in consenting to the council at Alexandria. According to the expression of Russian church historian V. Bolotov, the western bishops demonstrated proconsular attitude towards the East.[33] Such an attitude is more evident in the next letter, addressed directly to the Emperor Theodosius.

The letter *Sanctum*[34] was written on behalf of Ambrose and other bishops of Italy (not named) soon after the previous one, when the news of Melitius' death and the election of Flavian, who was the leader of the 'Melitian faction',[35] and Nectarius, who was elected as a bishop of Constantinople, reached the West. It is still not certain whether or not a special council was convened on the occasion[36] or whether the letter was written by Ambrose according to prior arrangement with other bishops.

This letter again established the fact, 'that it has proved easier to get the heretics expelled than to establish concord among the Catholics.[37] The western bishops complained about the easterners, who acted contrary to what they had said in the previous letter, as on the death of Melitius, while Paulinus was still alive, another person was elected.[38] This person, who was imposed by the judgment of the western bishops on the Church of Antioch, is not named, but was none other than Flavian.

The election of Nectarius as the patriarch of Constantinople is also condemned in this letter,[39] although he was elected like Ambrose himself, not having been baptized and on the instructions of the Emperor.[40] Then, the western bishops defended Maximus, patriarch of Alexandria, who had been deprived of communion with the eastern churches for his machinations and fraud, but had been able to gain the western bishops' confidence by presenting at the Council of Aquileia counterfeit letters from Peter, the deceased patriarch of Alexandria.[41]

[32] Neil B. McLynn, *Ambrose of Milan* (1994), 141.

[33] Vasiliy V. Bolotov, *Lectii po istorii* (1994), vol. 3, 111.

[34] PL 13; *Ep. extra collectionem* 9.

[35] John F. Matthews, *Western Aristocracies* (1975), 125.

[36] In the literature it is sometimes called the Council of Italy or of Milan or of Ambrose.

[37] *Sanctum* 1.

[38] *Sanctum* 2.

[39] *Sanctum* 3.

[40] Nectarius descends from a noble family and belonged to the senatorial class (PLRE I, 621) as well as St. Ambrose. Sozomen says (*Hist. eccl.* VII 8) that Nectarius was elected at the council of Constantinople in 381 by instructions of the Emperor Theodosius.

[41] *Sanctum* 3.

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By this letter Ambrose and the western bishops were trying to put pressure on Theodosius to make him adopt measures pleasing to the West – 'to serve the interests of public peace and concord', as is emphasized in the text.[42] The form of the letter and its content leave no doubt about the intentions of the western bishops headed by Ambrose – they wished to determine the religious policy of the whole empire. They call their council general, saying that the Council of Constantinople was a synod of persons who declined a general council. They say that the Council of Constantinople was not lawful, as the bishops of the East should have sought the decision of the Churches of Rome, Italy, and of the entire West.[43]

The western bishops demanded a discussion of the whole matter of communion by holding a council of themselves and of the eastern bishops at Rome. At the same time, they offered an alternative – the restoration of Maximus and Paulinus at their sees at Antioch and Alexandria.[44] Overall, this letter showed the strong opposition of the West to the Council of Constantinople and its decisions and, at the same time, clearly expressed the claim of priority of the West over the East in all ecclesiastical matters.

It is also possible to detect a political tinge in the closing lines of the letter. The western bishops said that they had written this letter with the encouragement of the Emperor Gratian.[45] The bishops thus tried to get political support for their plans: relying on the authority of the emperor, who had appointed Theodosius, they claimed political as well as ecclesiastical support.

However, Theodosius did not feel obliged to follow the western bishops' urging. The subordinate position of the eastern churches to the West meant at that time a certain political dependence of the East upon the West, if we take into account the political significance of Christianity in the Roman world at the end of the fourth century. Theodosius rightly considered that by rising and strengthening the Church in his part of the Roman Empire, he would strengthen his own political position.

The reply of the eastern emperor to the western bishops has not survived, but we can judge what it was from the next letter of the western bishops to Theodosius. The tone of the letter leaves no doubt, that the emperor in a harsh manner tried to put the western bishops in their place, urging them to stick to their own business and reproaching them for an easy attitude in communication with the East.[46]

[42] *Sanctum* 4.

[43] *ad Ecclesia Romanae, Italiae, et totius Occidentis confugisse judicium ...* (*Sanctum* 4). Catholic Church historians who try to prove the priority of Rome in ecclesiastical matters often use this quotation.

[44] *Sanctum* 6.

[45] *Ibid.* 8. McLynn considers this reference to Gratian as the key to the whole letter, but the sense of this key is regarded as a peculiar invitation of the easterns to the council at Rome, Neil B. McLynn, *Ambrose of Milan* (1994), 142.

[46] Nikolay F. Chernyavsky, *Imperator Theodosiy* (1913), 310.

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In their reply to Theodosius, written again in the name of Ambrose and the other bishops of Italy, the westerns recurred to the same questions, but the tone of their next letter was quite different, in that they tried to vindicate themselves and rehabilitate their position. The letter *Fidei*[47] begins with a flattering laudation of the emperor's faith and an explanation of the motives that lay behind their previous letter.[48] The westerns carefully avoided naming eastern bishops and expressed their regret at the accusation that they had neglected the easterns' friendship.[49]

In the text of the letter they avoided the question of the appointments and elections of the persons, mentioned in the previous letters, as an explanation of Theodosius had been given.[50] After setting out their request to convene a council and an assurance that their letter was aimed at gaining favour from the emperor, the westerns tried to persuade Theodosius that they had not put forward any preliminary decision of that question and that they considered themselves beyond reproach.[51] In spite of the generally apologetic tone of the letter and its different attitude to the emperor's authority, the westerns stood their ground as before. Although this time they agreed to change the place of the ecumenical council because there were disturbances in Illyricum and had therefore sought a safer location near the sea.[52] In addition, they referred to a presbyter of the Church of Constantinople, Paul by name, who demanded that there should be a synod of both eastern and western bishops in the province of Achaia.[53]

Nevertheless, no matter how hard the western bishops tried to demonstrate their zeal for peace in the church, their ambitions went far beyond that. In this ecclesiastical matter they tried to act politically and directly through the emperor avoiding the ecclesiastical structures. In many aspects the intervention of the western bishops looked unjustified and unreasonable.[54] Nevertheless, the actions of the westerns seem to be quite logical and expected from the political point of view. The problem was that the count on Theodosius turned out to be a failure. The relationship between church and state in the East had taken a different pattern, compared to that in the West, and Theodosius himself was perspicacious enough to reveal the true intentions of the westerns, covered up with zeal for peace in the church.

Evidently, there was no reply from Theodosius to the letter *Fidei*. The emperor left the matter to the eastern bishops, who in the summer of 382 convened a

[47] PL 14; *Ep. extra collectionem* 8.
[48] *Fidei* 1.
[49] *Fidei* 2.
[50] *Fidei* 4.
[51] *Fidei* 5-6.
[52] *Fidei* 7.
[53] *Fidei* 6. No other source mentions such a proposition.
[54] Even a great church politician like Ambrose could not show his usual perspicacity in respect of eastern affairs, as Homes Dudden noted, his action 'was in all points injudicious', Frederick Homes Dudden, *The Life and Times of Saint Ambrose* (Oxford, 1935), 216.

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further council at Constantinople to give an answer to the westerns.[55] There, in Constantinople, they received an invitation of the emperor Gratian to come to the council in Rome.[56] According to Theodoret,[57] who preserves the letter from this Constantinople council addressed to Damasus, Ambrose, Ascholius and other bishops of the West, the eastern bishops stated that it was impossible for them to go to Rome, because they could not leave their churches, which just started the process of recovering for a longer journey, than that to Constantinople. At the same time the council sent three delegates (bishops Cyriacus, Eusebius and Priscianus) to Rome and, as the letter says, through them declared their peaceful intentions and zeal for the true faith. In addition, the letter stated firmly that the ordinations of Nectarius, Flavian and Cyril of Jerusalem were lawful, and the easterns asked the westerns to have communion with them: 'We beseech your reverence to rejoice at what has thus been rightly and canonically settled by us, by the intervention of spiritual love and by the influence of the fear of the Lord, compelling the feelings of then, and making the edification of churches of more importance than individual grace or favour.'[58]

The Council of Rome took place the same summer of 382 A.D. There were some representatives from the East present: Jerome, Epiphanius of Salamis, Paulinus of Antioch and the delegates of the Council of Constantinople, mentioned above.[59] Nominally, Pope Damasus was the chairman of the council, but it was Ambrose of Milan, who played the main role and who was the author of the major documents of the council.[60]

Contrary to the decision and the letter of the eastern bishops, the council of Rome did not change the former position of the West: Paulinus was accepted as the bishop of Antioch and Diodore of Tarsus and Acacias of Beroia, who had ordained Flavian, were deprived of communion with the West.[61] One of the most important decisions of the western bishops at the council was that in contrast to the third canon of the Council of Constantinople of 381, which

[55] N. King wrote: 'It is difficult to tell whether the Emperor is dictating to the council or the council to the Emperor. Probably the two are working hand and glove', Noel Q. King, *The Emperor Theodosius and the Establishment of Christianity* (London, 1961), 47. Chernyavsky noted, that they convened to give an emphatic general answer to the West for insulting the West, Nikolay F. Chernyavsky, *Imperator Theodosiy* (1913), 311.

[56] Anton V. Kartashov, *Vselenskie sobori* (1994), 135.

[57] Theodoret, *Hist. eccl.* V 8.

[58] Theodoret, *Hist. eccl.* V 9.

[59] Noel Q. King, *The Emperor Theodosius* (1961), 48.

[60] P. Galtier, Le tome de Damase: Date et origine: *Recherches de Science Religieuse* 26 (1936) 385-418. Undoubtedly, Ambrose was a more outstanding and important figure than Damasus, although he treated the primacy of the Roman see with respect. As B. Citterio showed, there was no rivalry between Milan and Rome at that time and the priority of Rome was generally accepted in the West, B. Citterio, Sant'Ambrogio e i suoi rapporti col vescovo di Roma: *ScCat* 68 (1940) 64-70.

[61] Sozomen, *Hist. eccl.* VII 11.

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determined the second position of Constantinople in the Christian world after Rome, Damasus and the council declared that the Roman church did not depend on the decisions of that council and that Rome granted the second place to Alexandria and the third to Antioch.[62] Damasus also promulgated the ecclesiastical primacy of the bishop of Rome, which 'rested not on the City's standing, nor the decisions of any synods or councils, but on the Roman martyrdoms of Peter and Paul and the text of *Matthew* 16:18'.[63]

In effect the decisions of the Council of Rome meant nothing else than breach in the relationship between East and West.[64]

During the next ten years East and West preserved this status quo in their relationship, in other words they were in fact in a state of confrontation. The question of the see of Antioch was raised again in 392 A.D. Before his death Paulinus, who has been never able to depose Flavian from the position of patriarch of Antioch, appointed Evagrius as his own successor against the canonical rules. However, Flavian remained in the good graces of the eastern bishops and the Emperor Theodosius himself, especially because of his role and success in quieting off the riot at Antioch of 387 A.D. In such a situation the westerns could not do anything better, than support Evagrius.[65] A synod was assembled by the westerns in Capua, to test the faith of both Evagrius and Flavian.[66] However, Flavian did not appear in Capua, using his illness as an excuse,[67] and appealed to Theodosius for help.[68] The synod of Capua could only entrust Theophilus of Alexandria and the bishops of Egypt with the discussion of this affair, but again neither Evagrius, nor Flavian ever came to Alexandria.[69]

Knowing the firm position of Theodosius on the Antiochian schism, Ambrose this time decided to use ecclesiastical structures, not political ones. As the western church continued to maintain communion with Egypt, the influential bishop of Milan wrote a letter to Theophilus of Alexandria, in which he complained about the difficulties in convening the new synod, reproached Flavian for his non-appearance at the meeting of the priests and even blamed Evagrius for abusing Flavian and defending himself, using his opponent's weakness, but not his own goodness.[70] Ambrose recommended Theophilus to summon Flavian again and in case of his obstinacy and non-appearance to take such measures

[62] Noel Q. King, *The Emperor Theodosius* (1961), 48. The explanation of such a distribution of the positions see: Stephen Williams, Gerard Friell, *Theodosius* (1995), 205f.

[63] Stephen Williams, Gerard Friell, *Theodosius* (1995), 55. The authors emphasize: 'Thus began a theory of Roman papacy, potent with future consequences.'

[64] Anton V. Kartashov, *Vselenskie sobori* (1994), 136.

[65] Theodoret, *Hist. eccl.* V 23.

[66] Ambrose, *Ep.* 56.2.

[67] Theodoret, *Hist. eccl.* V 23.

[68] Ambrose, *Ep.* 56.3.

[69] A.V. Kartashov, *Vselenskie sobori* (1994), 151.

[70] Ambrose, *Ep.* 56.3-5.

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for the preservation of general peace as may not destroy what has been built up.[71] In addition, Ambrose advised Theophilus to refer to the bishop of Rome,[72] as he had no doubt that what Theophilus determined he would also approve.[73]

It is clear from the letter, that this time the westerns did not want to suggest anything definite and specific and Ambrose's words may be understood as his confession of failure in solving the Antiochian affair. It became obvious that all their attempts to impose their opinion on the easterns had turned out to be fruitless, but the westerns could not admit it and accept the opinion of the easterns because of the ambitions.[74] What is more, the clear and firm position of Theodosius in this matter left absolutely no hope of the submission of the eastern churches to the dictates of the West.

Nevertheless, the sources give us some examples of effective cooperation between West and East in dealing with organizational problems and questions of appointments at the end of the fourth century. Thus, Sozomen tells a story[75] of Ambrose asking Nectarius to deprive of a certain priest Gerontius of his dignity who, having been a deacon of the church of Milan, had broken church discipline and offended Ambrose. Nectarius made some efforts to comply with the request of the bishop of Milan, but without success, as the advance was resisted by the people of Nicomedia, where Gerontius had become a bishop in the meantime. Nevertheless, some time later, John Chrysostom did expell Gerontius.

Failing to restore the order in the East by political means at the beginning of the 380s, the westerns tried to do it with the help of the Egyptian Church at the beginning of 390s, but this feeble attempt was a failure too. This time Theodosius interfered again and used his authority to persuade the westerns to accept the legates of Flavian. Meanwhile, in the same year, 392 A.D., Evagrius had died and Flavian, using his authority, made sure that no one was elected after Evagrius.[76]

In 394 Nectarius, Theophilus and Flavian met at the Council of Constantinople. During this meeting it turned out to be possible to reach some rapprochement in relationship between the confronting groupings, Alexandria and Antioch. Communion between the church of Antioch and the western churches was restored with the help of a special delegation, headed by the senior bishop of

[71] Ambrose, *Ep.* 56.6.

[72] The editors of the letters of Ambrose in *Patrologia Latina* draw attention to the fact that judgments by the Roman pontificate have long been asked for (PL 16, col. 1222, n. 49). But in this letter Ambrose only said that he would be pleased by the Roman Church approval:... *quod Ecclesia Romana haud dubie comprobaverit, laeti fructum hujusmodi examinis adipiscamur*, Ambrose, *Ep.* 56.7.

[73] Ambrose, *Ep.* 56.7.

[74] This word – *ambitione* – was used by Ambrose himself (*Sanctum* 6).

[75] Sozomen, *Hist. eccl.* VIII 6.

[76] Socrates, *Hist. eccl.* V 15. See also Vasiliy V. Bolotov, *Lectii po istorii* (1994), vol. 4, 118.

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the East, Acacias of Beroia,[77] but Flavian still refused to have communication with the clergy, which had been ordained by Paulinus and Evagrius.[78]

After the death of Ambrose and Nectarius in 397, communion between the Roman church and Flavian was restored through the mediation of John Chrysostom, who became the bishop of Constantinople. The Egyptian church became finally reconciled with Antioch even later, after the death of Flavian in 404, when the Roman church was headed by Pope Innocent (402-417).[79]

To sum up the preceding it should be noted, that in Russian orthodox historiography (Bolotov, Chernyavsky, Kartashov *etc.*) the interference of the western bishops in the matters of organization and appointments in the East is almost unambiguously treated as a matter of dictates and as pretension to an absolute priority in solving the problems of the Christian world.

In western historiography (Homes Dudden, Paredi, Williams *etc.*) milder evaluations of the conflicts are given, but it is admitted that the interference of the westerns in the eastern affairs was unreasonable from the very beginning and did not contribute to the unity of the Church or the establishment of the ecclesiastical peace even within orthodox Christianity.

In my opinion, the relationship between the western and the eastern bishops, reviewed above, suggest the following conclusions:

1. In the struggle between the eastern and the western churches mainly political methods were used involving several appeals to imperial authority.
2. The struggle reflected in a concrete way the difficulties of Christianization, connected with the formation of the church hierarchy, and the process of interaction of church and state.
3. Dogmatic questions were not the core of this confrontation, which was internal to orthodox Christianity; instead the conflict was disciplinary and canonical.
4. The goal of this struggle was not simply ecclesiastical peace, but also primacy.
5. The interference of the West in the Antiochian schism caused more trouble and sharpened the contradictions between the rivals, and the interference is evidence of a negative attitude of the West towards the East.
6. At the end of the fourth century, when the Roman Empire was united for the last time and when Christianity in its Nicene version was declared the only official religion of the state, it was still obvious that it was impossible to create a unified organization within the Christian church when political disunity of the Roman Empire and its disintegration loomed. The fact reflected the growing junction of the structures of church and state.

[77] Theodoret, *Hist. eccl.* V 23.
[78] Anton V. Kartashov, *Vselenskie sobori* (1994), 152.
[79] Theodoret, *Hist. eccl.* V 23.

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The seeds of discord, sown in the fourth century, fell upon fertile ground and brought about abundant shoots. The claims of Rome and Constantinople for primacy in ecclesiastical matters were always strong enough to make every new agreement between the churches of the East and the West short-lived, rather than leading to permanent peace. Meanwhile, the political events of the early Middle Ages steadily and gradually pushed Christianity towards the Great Schism. Its inevitability may seem evident to us now, when we are looking back at the religious and political demarches of the end of the fourth century. However, it was not clear to contemporaries.

On the other hand, though the relations between the two parts of the Christian world in Late Antiquity can hardly be considered cordial, there is not enough ground to perceive the episodes of confrontation as the actual beginning of the Great Schism. The Church had observed at least some formal unanimity during the following six centuries before the final split between the Catholic and the Orthodox branches of Christianity.

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Apologetic Performance and Saint Stephen as Civic Patron in Late Roman Africa

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On 20 December 415, John of Jerusalem unearthed what was believed to be the tomb of the Church's first martyr, Saint Stephen. Within a relatively short time after this discovery, portions of the proto-martyr's precious relics could be found in various Christian communities in North Africa.[1] The arrival of Stephen's relics had a profound impact on African Christianity, inspiring widespread outbreaks of Christian miracles and Christianizing propaganda in their wake.

To be sure, the African Church already possessed a rich harvest of venerable martyrs whose passion accounts, shrines, and festivals were fundamental to ecclesiastical life for both Catholics and Donatists.[2] However, there is nothing in the historical evidence for this veneration to suggest that any of these African saints had developed reputations as heavenly patrons who intervened in temporal affairs. So, for example, when Augustine was faced with an especially vexing dispute in his diocese around 405 and decided to submit the matter to divine scrutiny, he sent the disputants to the shrine of Felix at Nola where God's miraculous interventions through this saint had become well-known. Augustine deemed this journey necessary because, although Africa was filled with the bodies of its own meritorious martyrs, God had not chosen to bestow the gift of miracles on any of the African saints.[3] With the arrival of the proto-martyr's relics, however, the situation changed dramatically for African Christians. By the time Augustine composed his final book of *De civitate Dei* around 426, he was able to include an extensive litany of home-grown healings, including several that had originated at the shrine of Saint Stephen in Hippo Regius.[4]

As Saint Stephen's remains were distributed among various African churches and the miracles attributed to the proto-martyr proliferated beyond all expectations, Augustine and his episcopal colleagues became very keen on publicizing the emergence of their new miracle worker. They built memorial shrines,

[1] On the passage of Stephen's relics into Africa and Spain, see Scott Bradbury, *Severus of Minorca: Letter on the Conversion of the Jews* (Oxford, 1996), 16-25.

[2] See Yvette Duval, *Loca Sanctorum Africae: Le culte des martyrs en Afrique du IVe au VIIe siècle*, 2 vols (Rome, 1982).

[3] *Ep.* 78.3 (CSEL 34.2, 336).

[4] *De civ. Dei* XXII 8 (CCL 48, 815-27).

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enhanced the saint's position in the liturgical calendar, and encouraged recipients of Stephen's blessings to give public expression to their testimonies. In order to maximize the long-term propaganda value of the miracles, Augustine also exhorted church leaders to document Stephen's supernatural interventions in their local communities by publishing narratives that could help sustain their memory through public readings.[5]

Historians are fortunate to possess the literary fruits of one community's efforts to make good on Augustine's advice. *De Miraculis Sancti Stephani* records nineteen accounts of miracles associated with the presence of Stephen's relics at Uzalis, a city of colonial rank in Africa Proconsularis. The author of *De Miraculis* remains anonymous, but the work was commissioned around 425 by Evodius, Catholic bishop of Uzalis and long-time friend of Augustine.[6]

Although *De Miraculis* represents precious testimony to the impact of Stephen's relics within a local African milieu and its narratives are rich in circumstantial detail, the work has remained under-exploited by late-antique historians and patristic scholars. In years past, the lack of a critical edition of the text and of any translation into a modern language has no doubt inhibited scholarly engagement of the work. Happily, however, Jean Meyers and a group of French researchers have finally produced a critical edition of *De Miraculis*, along with a French translation and several essays of commentary on the text's historical and literary contexts.[7] This first ever full-scale study of *De Miraculis* should help generate the scholarly attention that this work deserves.

Nevertheless, as welcome as the Meyers volume is, the commentary fails to do justice to the apologetic intent and character of *De Miraculis*. There is no substantive attempt to place the work among contemporary ecclesiastical efforts to confront the persistent vitality of traditional religion in African society. Instead, the commentators take the 'triumph of Christianity' for granted and presume that few 'pagans' were left by the date of *De Miraculis*.[8]

This tendency among scholars to overestimate the power and influence of Christianity in late Roman Africa is a long-standing problem; and not one that can be addressed sufficiently here. Suffice it to say that a systematic examination of the literary, epigraphic and archaeological evidence for the religious complexion of early fifth-century North Africa yields a milieu in which traditional systems of divine patronage continued to shape everyday life far more

[5] See Victor Saxer, *Morts, martyrs, reliques en Afrique chrétienne aux premiérs siècles: Les témoignages de Tertullien, Cyprien et Augustin à la lumière de l'archéologie africaine* (Paris, 1980), 245-78.

[6] See Jean Meyers (ed.), *Les Miracles de saint Étienne: Recherches sur le recueil pseudo-augustinien (BHL 7860-7861), avec édition critique, traduction et commentaire* (Turnhout, 2006), 11-25, 81-7.

[7] J. Meyers, *Les Miracles de saint Étienne* (2006).

[8] For example, *ibid.* 103, 111, 117.

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often than the Church did.[9] My aim here is merely to highlight how *De Miraculis* functioned as an apologetic challenge to those, both inside and outside the church at Uzalis, who continued to rely upon the patronage of Romano-African deities to secure healthy, prosperous, and happy lives. In light of space constraints, we shall focus on three miracle stories in particular.

The first of these narratives traces the progressive healing of a young Christian woman of senatorial rank from Carthage named Megetia. She had been afflicted with paralysis and various other severe complications during the course of a pregnancy.[10] Her family feared that, even if she survived the pregnancy, she would not live through childbirth. We are informed that Megetia's father, husband, and father-in-law – all of whom were *pagani* and therefore enslaved to faulty *superstitiones* – had appealed to their gods in vain (*per artes daemoniorum*) for the restoration of the girl's health (II 2.1). The author of *De Miraculis* ridicules their supplications as delusional, seeking healing as they did from *daemones*, the corrupters of human health, instead of seeking *salus* from the God who created humanity (II 2.1).

In contrast to such vanities, we learn that Megetia's Christian mother, Vitula, was inspired by God to travel to Uzalis to supplicate Saint Stephen for the sake of her daughter's health. While offering her prayers and vows at the Saint's *memoria* there, she also implored Stephen to facilitate her husband's conversion to Christianity as a consequence of their daughter's healing. Upon her return to Carthage, both of Vitula's prayers were answered in due course. Megetia both survived childbirth and began to regain her strength and vigour, while Vitula's husband became a Christian catechumen in the months immediately following his daughter's safe delivery (II 2.2-4).

Megetia's restoration of health was only partial, however; a disfiguring paralysis in her face persisted. Vitula returned to Saint Stephen's shrine at Uzalis; this time with Megetia at her side. The mother and daughter prostrated themselves in supplication at the *memoria* for the better part of forty days. The women's testing was exacerbated, we are told, by persistent flurries of pagan reproach and mocking insults. Consequently, Vitula pleaded with Stephen to complete his healing in Megetia's body so that, rather than emboldening the enemies of the faith, he would instead assist such mockers in gaining the salvation of their souls (II 2.5). And indeed, in the wake of Megetia's complete restoration of health, additional Christian conversions resulted, including that of Megetia's husband (II 2.8).

The message here is clear of course: the willingness and ability of Saint Stephen to heal have proven superior to that of the patron deities whom the

[9] See David Riggs, *Pagans and Christians in central North Africa: reconsidering the growth of Christianity from Cyprian to Augustine*, unpublished D.Phil. Thesis (Oxford, 2005), 22-86, 200-87.

[10] *De Miraculis* II 2 (310-32 Meyers).

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Carthaginian élites had invoked in the narrative. Moreover, Saint Stephen has shown that he is equally interested in addressing the needs of his supplicants and in cultivating Christian converts among the enemies of the Church. In this regard, the 'pagan' élites at Uzalis were supposed to take their cues from Megetia's father and husband and, in the face of Stephen's miraculous demonstrations of Christian truth, 'now at last believe!' (II 2.7).

Unlike the story of Megetia's restoration of health, the next two narratives seek to root the heavenly patronage of Saint Stephen much more firmly within the civic context of Uzalis. In the first instance, a butcher in the city named Rusticianus was overwhelmed with anxiety because his son and a servant had failed to return home on schedule from a business trip to a distant region. As the days continued to pass, Rusticianus began to fear the worst. Amid this state of grief, Stephen appeared to the butcher in a dream. The saint assured him that his son and servant were still alive and that he had arranged for their safe return. Not only this, but Stephen also ensured him that the business trip would be a very profitable one. After Rusticianus awoke, everything turned out precisely as Saint Stephen had told him it would.[11]

While the focus of Stephen's patronage on commerce here is itself noteworthy, what is even more interesting about this narrative for our study is the nature of the saint's appearance to the butcher. On the one hand, Stephen's appearance to Rusticianus is unsolicited. In contrast to other accounts in *De Miraculis*, there is not the slightest suggestion that Rusticianus was a Christian or that he had invoked Stephen's aid. Instead, the saint has approached him in a dream bearing the gifts of his heavenly patronage: a very familiar scenario within Romano-African religion, as several ex-votive inscriptions attest.[12]

On the other hand, Stephen appeared to Rusticianus as a handsome young man dressed in the attire of a high-ranking civic notable (*primarius civitatis*). When the saint asked Rusticianus if he knew who he was, the butcher addressed him as 'my Lord of Uzalis' (*dominus meus Uzalensis*). In response, Stephen tells him, 'you have spoken well, for I am of Uzalis; but I am not who you think I am. For I am Stephen' (I 14). It is very tempting to conclude from this exchange that Rusticianus had initially identified his supernatural benefactor here as one of the traditional patron deities of Uzalis. At any rate, this narrative clearly intends to communicate both Stephen's desire to cultivate a special patronage relationship with the citizens of Uzalis and to show the saint's concern for the everyday preoccupations of the city's inhabitants.

Our final narrative presents an even bolder case for Saint Stephen's special role as the heavenly patron of Uzalis. On a certain day when the periodic markets (*nundinae*) were being held in the city, around noon-time the tranquil skies

[11] *De Miraculis* I 14 (300-2 Meyers).

[12] For votive dedications erected in response to divine visitations in dreams and visions, see *ILAfr.* 352, 360; *CCIS* II, 73; *C.*2632, 24213, 24217; *AE* (1966, 523); *ILAlg.* I 2069.

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suddenly turned dark and a monstrous windstorm began to rage. Amid the storm, everyone suddenly began to see overhead what looked like some kind of immense fiery snake (*draco*) hanging its head down from the clouds and then seeming to descend upon the city. The citizens of Uzalis began fleeing in fear and panic from the markets. The Christians proceeded to the *memoria* of Saint Stephen and began to invoke his aid. Almost immediately after the Christians started their supplications, the giant snake in the sky began to disappear into the clouds and the frightful weather dissipated until the skies were serene once more. Their wits and joy restored, the Christians offered up their collective gratitude to God and his friend Stephen for saving the city from such danger.[13]

The religious drama is heightened here by the significance of the day on which this miracle occurred. The periodic market-fair (*nundinae*) will have drawn significant crowds into Uzalis from the surrounding countryside. Moreover, it was common for local deities to preside as patrons over the success of these public gatherings.[14] By crediting Stephen with the salvation of Uzalis amid such circumstances, the Christians were, in effect, making the very bold and high-profile claim that their saint was a more efficacious supernatural patron of the city than its traditional patron deities.

According to the author of *De Miraculis*, however, an even greater miracle occurred on the following day, which helped to reinforce this claim. One of the church's sub-deacons, as he was travelling in a suburb of Uzalis, was accosted by a stranger, who church leaders assumed in hindsight to have been an angel. The stranger gave the sub-deacon a colourful wax painting on cloth (*velum variis pictum e cera coloribus*) for the church at Uzalis. The author tells us that the painting depicted Stephen carrying the glorious cross upon his shoulders as he protected the city gate from a monstrous serpent. For its part, the serpent was in the process of fleeing because of the approach of the 'triumphal martyr of Christ'. This painting, this *mysterio Dei*, was hung in front of the shrine of Saint Stephen so that everyone would know and remember by which *auctor* and *liberator* the city had been saved on the previous day. We are told that people of all ages came to the shrine of the *tantus patronus* of Uzalis to admire this *spectaculum grande*.[15]

This account, which shows Stephen upstaging the traditional patron deities of Uzalis, represents the resounding culmination of the author's apologetic attempt to cast the Church's proto-martyr as the city's *dominus* and *patronus communis*.[16] Evodius and his clergy hoped, of course, that the public recital of

[13] *De Miraculis* II 4 (340-6 Meyers).

[14] See, *e.g.* Ramsay MacMullen, Market-Days in the Roman Empire: *Phoenix* 24 (1970) 333-41.

[15] *De Miraculis* II 4 (340-6 Meyers).

[16] *De Miraculis* II 5 (346 Meyers).

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the miracle narratives of *De Miraculis* would undermine faith in the traditional gods as it promoted a new, more effective, heavenly benefactor for the people of Uzalis to invoke for health, prosperity, and safety. Unfortunately, we lack the evidence to discern how helpful or not such narratives may have been in bolstering the Church's appeal and influence at Uzalis. The recent confirmation of El Aliya as the ancient site of Uzalis engenders hope, however, that archaeological and epigraphic remains may eventually reveal more about the local narrative of Christianisation, especially in the post-Roman period.[17]

Hope of new discoveries aside, *De Miraculis* itself provides a precious window onto the competitive religious world in which African Christians still lived in the early fifth century. In doing so, the text also offers rare testimony to the role that Saint Stephen might play as a heavenly 'civic' patron in a local church's efforts to challenge the persisting influence of its city's traditional patron gods.

[17] Taher Ghalia, Le site d'Uzalis: recherches récentes en archéologie et en épigraphie, in: J. Meyers, *Les Miracles de saint Étienne* (2006), 81-7.

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Aspetti istituzionali e riferimenti normativi in Salviano di Marsiglia

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1. Salviano di Marsiglia è oggi riconosciuto a giusto titolo storiografo,[1] in forza del singolare valore testimoniale che sul complesso quadro degli eventi di fine impero ha soprattutto il suo *De gubernatione Dei.*

Quanto al tema della mia relazione, è appena il caso di ricordare che nel mondo antico e tardoantico i moduli costruttivi della storiografia (e di altri generi letterari) d'ordinario impedivano che questioni di natura istituzionale e giuridica fossero affrontate *in recto*, in modo tecnico e puntuale, poiché l'esigenza della verità storica era subordinata al rispetto di canoni stilistici secondo la tradizione letteraria.[2]

Ciononostante non è preclusa la possibilità che ci si avvalga di quella storiografia perché ci si renda conto sia di peculiari aspetti istituzionali della società di quei tempi, sia di specifici effetti o riflessi in essa suscitati dalla normativa imperiale: se è comprensibile che Salviano, come qualsiasi storiografo o letterato dell'antichità, non mostri un tecnicismo o un rigore assoluto nell'uso del linguaggio giuridico, peraltro problematici già nello stesso linguaggio dei giuristi e delle cancellerie imperiali, è parimenti comprensibile che gli scrittori antichi, cristiani compresi, non possano ignorare il diritto romano. Le nozioni

[1] Adalbert-Gautier Hamman, L'actualité de Salvien de Marseille. Idées sociales et politiques: *Augustinianum* 17 (1977), 381-93, particolarmente 381-2; José María Blázquez Martínez, *La sociedad del Bajo Imperio en la obra de Salviano de Marsella* (Madrid, 1990); Vincenzo Messana, Salviano di Marsiglia, in: Guido Bosio *et al.* (eds.), *Introduzione ai Padri della Chiesa. Secoli IV e V*, Strumenti della Corona Patrum 4 (Torino, 1995), 303-31; Francesco Paolo Rizzo, Il *De gubernatione Dei* nel quadro della problematica di fine impero: *QCCCM* 4-5 (1992-3 [1997]), 71-108; Vincenzo Messana, Fenomeni degenerativi e crisi morale nella società tardoimperiale. La testimonianza di Salviano di Marsiglia, in: Per orbem peregrinus. *Studi per il 25° anniversario di episcopato di A.M. Garsia*, Quaderni di Presenza Culturale 36 (Caltanissetta, 1999), 183-240; Vincenzo Messana, *Christianorum morbi* e *miseria temporis* in Salviano di Marsiglia, in: Serena Bianchetti *et al.* (eds.), *Poikilma. Studi in onore di M.R. Cataudella in occasione del 60° compleanno*, II (La Spezia, 2001), 865-89; Salvatore Costanza, Romani e barbari, cristiani e pagani nella concezione salvianea della storia (2ª parte: *De gubernatione Dei*): *Guttadauro* 6 (2006), 75-139.

[2] Marialuisa Navarra (ed.), *Riferimenti normativi e prospettive giuspubblicistiche nelle* Res gestae *di Ammiano Marcellino*, Accademia Romanistica Costantiniana, Materiali per una palingenesi delle costituzioni tardo-imperiali, Serie Prima 5 (Milano, 1994), 6, con note 19 e 20 (rinvii a François Paschoud).

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giuridiche, ad esempio, di *res communes*, o di *uti* e *frui*, su cui permane ognora vivo il dibattito storiografico, sono tra quelle cui specie gli autori cristiani antichi fanno frequentemente appello per spiegare la dottrina morale dell'uso dei beni e del diritto di proprietà, anche se talora con immagini o analogie più o meno convincenti.

2. Quest'ultima notazione mi agevola la presentazione del passo salvianeo di *Ad Ecclesiam* 3.7.33, e del suo ampio contesto a partire da 3.6.28.

Salviano, constatato pur con disappunto che i cristiani *divites* lasciano di consueto i propri beni di fortuna in eredità ai figli, vitupera tuttavia recisamente quei *multi parentes* che dividono il loro patrimonio in parti uguali ai figli e però, con sorprendente *inreligiosae mentis ingenium*, concedono ai *filii religiosi* di godere soltanto dell'usufrutto della parte loro spettante, il cui diritto di proprietà lasciano invece agli altri figli.[3]

A questo punto Salviano stabilisce una sorta di parallelismo, ma con un vistoso 'distinguo', fra tale comportamento dei *parentes* sedicenti cristiani e quello che nei confronti dei propri *liberti* assumono i *domini*: i quali lasciano beni e sostanze ai loro affrancati *meliore condicione* di quella dai suddetti genitori riservata ai *filii religiosi*. Mettendo a fuoco uno spaccato sociale particolarmente significativo sotto il profilo giuridico-istituzionale, egli puntualizza che i *servi* quanto meno *probi*, se non proprio *optimae servitutis* – alla figura del *servus* in Salviano ha ultimamente prestato attenzione il Costanza[4] –, ricevono *in usu cotidiano* dai loro padroni la *Romana libertas*: *in qua scilicet et proprietatem peculii capiunt, et ius testamentarium consequuntur, ita ut et viventes cui volunt res suas tradant, et morientes donatione transcribant*.[5]

Con tali sottolineature del portato della *Romana libertas*, Salviano lascia palesemente intendere quanto il suddetto parallelismo torni a totale disdoro dei *parentes* che discriminano i *filii religiosi* dagli altri figli.

Sennonché a quel parallelismo fa immediatamente seguire una comparazione che risulta ancor più disonorevole per essi: secondo lo storiografo di Marsiglia genitori siffatti agiscono, invero, come quei padroni che, giudicando i *servi non bene de se meriti* indegni della *civitas Romana*, li sottomettono al giogo della *Latina libertas*, e pur se li lasciano vivere *sub libertorum titulo*, non soltanto non vogliono che in punto di morte possiedano alcunché, ma pure ostacolano le loro ultime volontà, impedendo che essi, prima di morire, donino *quae superstites habent*.[6]

In questa comparazione mi sembra evidente che il riferimento salvianeo alla *Latina libertas* si richiami implicitamente a quella *lex Iunia Norbana* di età

[3] Salvianus, *Ad Ecclesiam* 3.6.28-30 (d'ora in poi *Eccl.*).
[4] S. Costanza, Romani e barbari (2006), 89-90 e nota 78.
[5] *Eccl.* 3.7.31.
[6] *Eccl.* 3.7.33.

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tiberiana, secondo la quale l'affrancamento di uno schiavo poteva limitarsi alla concessione del *ius Latinum*, fra le cui caratteristiche c'era quella che non consentiva allo schiavo affrancato di testare, cosicché dopo la sua morte i suoi beni tornavano in ogni caso, obbligatoriamente, al suo *dominus*: adattando *mutatis mutandis* l'adagio del Gaudemet sul latino giuniano[7] al *filius religiosus* di cui alla suddetta testimonianza salvianea, potrebbe dirsi che questi 'vit libre, mais meurt esclave'.

3. Intimamente orgoglioso del *Romanum ius* malgrado gli accadimenti dei suoi tempi lo spingano a un opposto sentire,[8] è nel *De gubernatione Dei* che Salviano tratta ampiamente della perdita della *Romana libertas* da parte dei Romani travolti dalla rovinosa *exactio publica*, le cui radici vede propagarsi nel degrado della *Christiana societas*. Le classi più abbienti dell'impero sono a tal punto rapaci, da ridurre in povertà chiunque entri in contatto con esse.[9] E chi detiene il potere politico incarna il peggior ladro per i *pauperculi*: le magistrature sono acquisto dei pochi a costo della *cunctorum vastatio*, la dignità di alti funzionari è *proscriptio civitatum*, la prefettura di taluni, che Salviano non vuol neppure nominare (*quos taceo*), è *praeda*, come sanno le province della Spagna, dell'Africa e della Gallia: *ut pauci inlustrentur, mundus evertitur*.[10] La corruzione politica e amministrativa ha di fatto pervaso soprattutto gli ambienti della *nobilitas*, la quale soltanto ha accesso alle cariche pubbliche e trae vantaggi dal sistema di malgoverno e di vessazioni: *dives potestas pauperem facit esse rem publicam*, constata Salviano,[11] quasi riecheggiando il sallustiano *nos habemus* [...] *publice egestatem, privatim opulentiam*.[12]

Egli, nel prendere atto delle miserande condizioni dello Stato, chiama in causa i singoli individui, veri artefici – secondo la mentalità salvianea e in generale cristiana – della cattiva o della buona salute delle istituzioni: *nullas esse iam rei publicae vires omnium conscientia est*;[13] *ecce quid valeant statuta legum, ecce quid proficit definitio sanctionum*.[14] Mediante quest'ultima espressione il Nostro dice che le leggi sono buone in sé, e sottolinea esplicitamente nel relativo contesto la *iusta rerum praeceptio*.

Può in tal senso considerarsi paradigmatico l'episodio riguardante uno di quei *Dei servi* giunto dall'Oriente nella viziosa e miscredente Cartagine prima che questa soccombesse ai Vandali: se egli non venne ucciso, lo si dovette – afferma Salviano – alla bontà non certo dei Cartaginesi, ma delle leggi, giacché i *duodecim*

[7] Jean Gaudemet, *Les institutions de l'antiquité* (Paris², 1982), 362.
[8] S. Costanza, Romani e barbari (2006), 136-7 e note 268-77.
[9] Salvianus, *De gubernatione Dei* 4.4.20 (d'ora in poi *Gub.*).
[10] *Gub.* 4.4.21.
[11] *Gub.* 1.2.11.
[12] Sallustius, *Cat.* 52.22.
[13] *Gub.* 7.9.34.
[14] *Gub.* 7.21.93.

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tabularum decreta vietavano che fosse messo a morte un uomo senza condanna giuridica.[15]

Ma tant'è: quella società, opulenta ai suoi vertici, *sub specie morali putrefacit*. E non solo. Quell'opulenza, in cui pullulano i vizi, deriva dall'accumulo malvagio (cioè immorale) e distorto (cioè, parimenti, illegale) delle fortune economiche, per l'innesco criminoso di una duplice deviazione del denaro: dallo Stato verso i *possessores*, e dai comuni cittadini verso i *possessores*.[16]

4. Sicché sono le imposizioni fiscali, più che le invasioni barbariche, a causare principalmente la rovina dei ceti più deboli e a provocare la fine della *Romana res publica*, per Salviano *vel iam mortua, vel certe extremum spiritum agens*, appunto perché *strangulata* dai tributi come da mani di briganti.[17] Si tratta di una perversa spirale involutiva di *latrocinium ac scelus*,[18] soffocatrice dei poveri, su cui si avvita l'inefficiente e corrotta amministrazione statale.

Salviano si oppone infatti non all'equo prelievo fiscale, ma ai perversi meccanismi con cui tasse d'ogni genere, balzelli supplementari e straordinari vengono caricati sulle spalle dei più deboli,[19] senza sfiorare quelle dei ricchi potenti.

Dei casi in tal senso segnalati dallo storiografo di Marsiglia mi sembra emblematico quello, puntualmente descritto, riguardante *publicae laetitiae nuntii* ed *epistolarii*: *veniunt plerumque novi nuntii, novi epistolarii a summis sublimitatibus missi* [...]. *Decernuntur his nova munera, decernuntur novae indictiones: decernunt potentes quod solvant pauperes, decernit gratia divitum quod perdat turba miserorum; ipsi enim in nullo sentiunt quod decernunt*.[20] Quanti arrivano nelle province inviati dai più alti dignitari per annunciare buone notizie pubbliche esigono, infatti, *munera*, o *sportulae*, che i provinciali deliberano di offrire loro: dunque *nova munera*, *novae indictiones*, ma esclusivamente a carico dei poveri. La vigorosa protesta di Salviano poggia implicitamente, anche questa volta, su un fondamento giuridico. In base a *C.Th.* 8.11.1-5 (anni 364-89), era vietata l'esazione per *publicae laetitiae* di contribuzioni straordinarie, di *sportulae* a carico di *tenuiores*. In particolare *C.Th.* 8.11.2 del 365, in forma di solenne editto ai provinciali, recita fra l'altro: *conlationi nullus locus, nulla sit licentia; nihil quisquam exigat, nihil audeat postulare*.

Non diversamente vanno di solito le cose quando si decretano provvedimenti di sgravi fiscali a favore di città in situazioni di particolare emergenza. Ne

[15] *Gub.* 8.5.23-4.

[16] F.P. Rizzo, Il *De gubernatione Dei* (1992-3 [1997]), 88, con note 48-9.

[17] *Gub.* 4.6.30. V. Messana, *Christianorum morbi* (2001), 875, nota 94; Salvatore Costanza, *Aspetti e problemi della fiscalità nel tardo impero romano. Normativa imperiale, fonti pagane e fonti cristiane a confronto*, Sintesi e Proposte 42 (San Cataldo-Caltanissetta, 2005), specialmente 74-85, con relative note.

[18] *Gub.* 4.6.30.

[19] *Gub.* 5.7.28-30.

[20] *Gub.* 5.7.30.

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constata direttamente un caso lo stesso Salviano (*ut nuper factum est*): una volta deciso dalle alte sfere del potere di diminuire *in aliquo* i tributi di *defectae urbes*, ecco che a trarne arricchimento sono esclusivamente i ricchi: *ilico remedium cunctis datum soli inter se divites partiuntur*, poiché, giustappunto in tali circostanze, i poveri sono considerati *extra numerum tributariorum*.[21] Che tale fenomeno fosse frequente, lo prova ad esempio *C.Th.* 12.1.173 del 410.

5. Un'altra frode, di enormi proporzioni, da Salviano denunciata ripetutamente, viene consumata attraverso il *patrocinium*, col quale, ottenuto a caro prezzo dai poveri contadini protetti, i ricchi sottraggono nuove terre al controllo del fisco.[22] Ne indicano la devastante pervasività vari testi legislativi – cui ha rivolto l'attenzione il Soraci[23] – che evidenziano l'interesse dello Stato a recuperare, con sanzioni pecuniarie pesantissime, ciò che tale fraudolento istituto ha sottratto ad esso.

Salviano mette sotto accusa il *patrocinium* principalmente nel libro V del *De gubernatione Dei*, ove serratamente stigmatizza le fraudolenze dei ricchi a danno dello Stato e dei poveri.

Egli tratta, anzitutto, degli abusi commessi dai potenti nell'esazione dei tributi, allorché questi vengono da essi resi arbitrariamente più esosi in funzione di grandi profitti personali: *exactionis publicae nomen in quaestus proprii emolumenta verterunt et indictiones tributarias praedas suas esse fecerunt*.[24] Financhè le loro tasse gravano sulle spalle dei poveri: *pauperculos homines tributa divitum premunt, et infirmiores ferunt sarcinas fortiorum*.[25] I quali sono indotti, quando non a fuggire presso i barbari, a cercare almeno protezione presso i signori di grandi proprietà terriere. È da tale forma di *patrocinium* che trae origine un'altra fonte di arricchimento per gli *honestiores*. Questi infatti *hac lege tueri pauperes videntur ut spolient, hac lege defendunt miseros ut miseriores faciant defendendo*.[26]

C.Th. 11.24.2, probabilmente del 370, ci dà le connotazioni della frode che Salviano poteva constatare ancora ai suoi tempi, lasciandoci intendere che essa era 'un'operazione fittizia di natura delittuosa (*commentis audacibus*), messa in atto per il trasferimento di fondi dalle mani di piccoli proprietari in quelle di potenti personaggi'.[27]

[21] *Gub.* 5.8.35.

[22] V. Messana, *Christianorum morbi* (2001), 876, nota 96.

[23] Rosario Soraci, Rapporti fra potere civile e potere militare nella legislazione processuale tardo-antica: *QCCCM* 3 (1991), 189-255.

[24] *Gub.* 5.6.25.

[25] *Gub.* 5.7.28.

[26] *Gub.* 5.8.39.

[27] R. Soraci, Rapporti (1991), 216, nota 40.

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Ciononostante i poveri diavoli sono costretti a subire l'imposizione dei tributi (*cum possessio ab his recesserit, capitatio non recedit*),[28] giacché i signori si impossessano delle loro terre, ma senza addossarsene gli oneri, e anzi continuano ad esigere dai medesimi poveri diavoli tali oneri, ma senza versarli al fisco.

A causa di questo nuovo e insopportabile fardello, gli oppressi vanno in cerca di un'ulteriore via di scampo: *fundos maiorum expetunt, et coloni divitum fiunt*.[29] Salviano qui si riferisce all'*inquilina condicio*, ossia alla particolare forma di *locatio-conductio* che caratterizzò il modo di produzione cosiddetto postschiavistico. I contadini *iugo se inquilinae abiectionis addicunt*,[30] abbandonano cioè volontariamente la propria terra per sottrarsi all'insopportabile tutela del *patronus*, e per trasferirsi in terre altrui come coloni: *suscipiuntur ut advenae, fiunt praeiudicio habitationis indigenae;* [...] *quos suscipiunt ut extraneos et alienos, incipiunt habere quasi proprios*. Si tratta non di *coloni censiti*, personalmente liberi anche se spesso vincolati alla terra dal *ius originarium*, ma di *adscripticii*, categoria cui mostra di richiamarsi Salviano con l'espressione, che alla precedente segue immediatamente, *quos esse constat ingenuos, vertuntur in servos*.[31]

Il colonato di cui parla il Nostro si origina dalla necessità avvertita dai contadini di uscire totalmente dallo stritolante ingranaggio fiscale, ed è verosimile che esso, già definito nelle sue coordinate storiche, 'sia subentrato' alla *locatio-conductio*.[32] Potrebbe così spiegarsi, ad esempio, *C.Th.* 11.24.1 del 360, secondo cui la condizione di colono in cui versa il contadino appare presupposta alla fuga da lui tentata per ottenere presso un altro *possessor* la protezione dal fisco.[33]

Resta comunque incontrovertibile sia che tale contadino, abbandonato il primo campicello per il quale era sottoposto a tributo, cerca presso il nuovo signore una condizione che lo esoneri per sempre dagli obblighi fiscali, sia che, una volta sottomessosi alla *inquilina abiectio*, egli perde il *ius libertatis*.[34]

6. Mi fermo qui. I dati presentati, ancorché pochissimi, riprovano – è mio convincimento – che lo storiografo di Marsiglia, al di là degli accenti appassionati o i toni infiammati che talora connotano la sua pagina, rivela una lucida capacità indagatrice della realtà del suo tempo, i cui complessi aspetti

[28] *Gub.* 5.8.42.
[29] *Gub.* 5.8.43.
[30] *Gub.* 5.8.44.
[31] *Gub.* 5.9.45; F.P. Rizzo, Il *De gubernatione Dei* (1992-3 [1997]), 91-5 e relative note (documentazione e bibliografia ragionata con rinvii ad Arnold Hugh Martin Jones, Luigi Capogrossi Colognesi, Lellia Cracco Ruggini, Andrea Giardina, *ecc.*).
[32] F.P. Rizzo, Il *De gubernatione Dei* (1992-3 [1997]), 95.
[33] R. Soraci, Rapporti (1991), 214-5.
[34] *Gub.* 5.8.44.

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e problemi – da quelli istituzionali e politico-amministrativi a quelli giuridici ed etico-sociali – individua legge e scandaglia valutandoli su un piano non astratto, e commensurandoli al concreto vissuto del singolo e della collettività. Anche per questo la sua opera, e in particolare il *De gubernatione Dei*, si conferma la 'fuente más reveladora', e 'la única que nos permite ver directamente toda la miseria de ese tiempo en su realidad atroz'.[35]

[35] J.M. Blázquez Martínez, *La sociedad* (1990), 9.

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Fonti patristiche sulla Sicilia nella valutazione degli studiosi contemporanei

Salvatore COSTANZA, Agrigento

Prospetto in questa sede alcune linee a mio giudizio tra le più significative dell'attuale dibattito storiografico su taluni testi patristici (intendo tale aggettivo *lato sensu*) relativi alla storia della Sicilia romano-imperiale,[1] intorno ai quali vi sono ancora questioni variamente *vexatae*.

1. Inizierei con la *quaestio* sull'identità di Panteno, di cui dà notizia Eusebio, il quale fra l'altro afferma che Clemente Alessandrino menziona Panteno come proprio maestro nelle *Ipotiposi* e negli *Stromati*.[2] Il medesimo Clemente, peraltro, in un breve passo degli *Stromati*, non riportato da Eusebio, si riferisce all'ultimo suo maestro chiamandolo 'ape siciliana'.[3]

Ha fatto il punto sulla questione, dopo la Cracco Ruggini,[4] il Pricoco nell'87, per il quale, quand'anche Clemente abbia voluto alludere a Panteno, 'niente prova che lo abbia fatto; in ogni caso' non 'c'è ragione alcuna per ritenere che in lui si debba vedere il maestro incontrato per ultimo, in Egitto, e che a lui si riferisca l'immagine della *Sikelikè mélitta*'. Pur ammesso che l'immagine dell'ape siciliana vada attribuita a Panteno, si tratta di 'un'immagine', di 'una metafora generata dalla celebrità del miele siciliano di Ibla, e non di una indicazione geografica'. A suo giudizio non ci sono né 'una prova seria' della sicilianità di Panteno, né 'un indizio ragionevole' in tal senso.[5]

Ciononostante l'erroneo dato biografico su Panteno continua ad essere registrato.[6]

[1] Vincenzo Messana, Storia e cultura della Sicilia tardoantica e preislamica. Percorso bibliografico orientativo: *Guttadauro* 2 (2002) 7-106.

[2] Eusebius Caesariensis, *HE* V 10.1-4; V 11.1-5; VI 13.2.

[3] Clemens Alexandrinus, *Str.* I 1.11.1-2.

[4] Lellia Cracco Ruggini, La Sicilia tra Roma e Bisanzio, in: *Storia della Sicilia*, III (Napoli, 1980), 1-96, 58, nota 18.

[5] Salvatore Pricoco, Da Fazello a Lancia di Brolo. Osservazioni sulla storiografia siciliana e le origini del cristianesimo in Sicilia, in: Vincenzo Messana *et al.* (eds.), *Il cristianesimo in Sicilia dalle origini a Gregorio Magno. Atti del Convegno di St., Caltanissetta, 28-29 ott. 1985*, Quaderni di Presenza Culturale 26 (Caltanissetta, 1987), 19-39, 37-9.

[6] Friedrich Prinz, Die Kirche und die pagane Kulturtradition (*sub prelo* in *Kokalos*); Francesco Paolo Rizzo, *Sicilia cristiana dal I al V secolo*, II.1, Istituto Siciliano Storia Antica, *Testimonia Siciliae Antiqua* I 14 (Roma, 2006), 104.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 119-124.
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2. Solo un rapido cenno alla seconda questione, riguardante la vicenda siciliana di Eracleone, discepolo dello gnostico Valentino, di cui alla notizia del *Praedestinatus*. Questa, già ritenuta 'incerta' ma non respinta dal Pace,[7] era stata accolta e rivalutata dal Linares in un suo volume del '78 a sostegno della remota antichità della diocesi lilibetana: volume che il Pricoco ha ben giudicato *tout court* 'inservibile', lucidamente dimostrando che il racconto dell'anonimo è 'totalmente destituito di fondamento storico e reso manifestamente incredibile dai grossolani anacronismi che lo infiorano'.[8]

Sulla notizia del *Praedestinatus* il Rizzo ha ultimamente ipotizzato che l'anacronistica narrazione dell'eresiologo potrebbe riflettere 'la realtà di una Sicilia rimasta sempre – per lo meno ufficialmente – immune dalle eresie, compresa quella dello gnosticismo'.[9]

3. E vengo alla terza questione, riguardante la lettera – di cui all'epistolario ciprianeo[10] – inviata dal clero romano nel 250/251 in Sicilia a proposito dei *lapsi*: testimonianza notoriamente importante, l'unica fra quella lucana sulla sosta di Paolo a Siracusa e quella eusebiana sulla partecipazione del vescovo siracusano Cresto al concilio di Arles del 314. Essa mi sembra tuttavia sia stata talora sopravvalutata dai moderni che l'hanno considerata indicativa dell'esistenza di numerose e già organizzate comunità cristiane nell'Isola, se non anche della loro dipendenza da Roma.[11]

Il Rizzo ha ora rilanciato tale *quaestio*: oltre a ritenere che i latori di quell'epistola dovettero 'transitare per quel porto siciliano che avrebbe loro consentito di salpare alla volta dell'Africa, ossia per il porto di Lilibeo'[12] – sembrando pertanto collocarsi sulla linea della Cracco Ruggini, secondo la quale 'si trattava evidentemente di comunità sulla rotta tra Roma e l'Africa'[13] –, egli reputa che i cristiani destinatari della medesima 'erano probabilmente quelli di Lilibeo'.[14] A suo dire, può ben costituirne il *pendant* l'*Epistula ad Marcellam* di Porfirio,[15] ove il filosofo neoplatonico polemizza verosimilmente

[7] Biagio Pace, *Arte e civiltà della Sicilia antica*, IV (Roma-Napoli, 1949), 5.

[8] S. Pricoco, Da Fazello (1987), 36-7 e nota 48.

[9] F.P. Rizzo, *Sicilia*, II.1 (2006), 104-5.

[10] Cyprianus, *Ep.* 30.5.2.

[11] Alberto Pincherle, Sulle origini del cristianesimo in Sicilia: *Kokalos* 10-11 (1964-5) 547-61, 553; Paolo Siniscalco, Lo sviluppo del cristianesimo e la Sicilia fino al IV secolo, in: Vincenzo Messana *et al.* (eds.), *Il cristianesimo* (1987), 61-84, 75; Lellia Cracco Ruggini, Il primo cristianesimo in Sicilia (III-VII secolo), in: Vincenzo Messana *et al.* (eds.), *Il cristianesimo* (1987), 85-125, 90.

[12] F.P. Rizzo, *Sicilia*, II.1 (2006), 107.

[13] L. Cracco Ruggini, La Sicilia (1980), 62, nota 33; *ead.*, Il primo cristianesimo (1987), 90.

[14] F.P. Rizzo, *Sicilia cristiana dal I al V secolo*, I, Istituto Siciliano Storia Antica, *Testimonia Siciliae Antiqua* I 14 (Roma, 2005), 49.

[15] F.P. Rizzo, *Sicilia*, II.1 (2006), 108-9; Vincenzo Messana, La Sicilia romana tardoimperiale: intellettuali e pluralità religiosa (*sub prelo* in *Greci, Latini, Musulmani, Ebrei: la coesistenza culturale in Sicilia. Atti del Convegno int., Palermo, 16-18 nov. 2006*).

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con i cristiani lilibetani. La suddetta lettera lascia comunque indovinare che al tempo della persecuzione di Decio i *libellatici* dovettero essere anche in Sicilia.

4. Quanto ai fatti storici che coinvolsero la Sicilia tra prima e seconda metà del IV secolo (segnalo *per incidens* che la documentazione atanasiana sul concilio di Serdica del 343 e sul ruolo assunto in merito dall'episcopato siciliano è stata valutata in modo parzialmente differente dal Rizzo[16] e dall'Otranto[17]), è noto che – tocco la quarta questione – fra quanti parteciparono al concilio di Antiochia del 363, convocato come quello di Serdica nell'ambito della controversia ariana, e comunicarono all'imperatore Gioviano di accettare l'*homoousios* niceno (con interpretazione omeousiana), figurava Εὐάγριος Σικελός / *Evagrius Siculus*, come trasmessoci unicamente da Socrate, poi riproposto da Cassiodoro-Epifanio.[18]

Orbene, nessuno ha mai messo in discussione le lezioni Σικελός[19] / *Siculus*, sulla base della tradizione manoscritta della *HE* di Socrate e della *HT* di Cassiodoro-Epifanio: nemmeno il Valesius, pur convinto che l'etnico Σικελός rimandasse a una città orientale sconosciuta,[20] il cui rilievo è richiamato nell'edizione di Hussey, ove è registrata la lezione Σικελῶν.

Sennonché nella sua recente edizione della *HE* di Socrate Hansen ha congetturato Σικίμων in luogo di Σικελός, ritenendo Sichem la sede episcopale di Evagrio, e così collocando in Oriente tutti i vescovi presenti ad Antiochia: congettura ultimamente giudicata dall'Otranto, con puntuale documentazione, infondata (Sichem non esisteva più da secoli), 'improponibile sul piano storico', 'anacronistica' e 'contraddittoria'.[21] Confermata la validità della *lectio vulgata* Σικελός, l'Otranto vede in Evagrio ad Antiochia un 'esponente' dei 'cosiddetti semiariani', diversamente dal Rizzo, secondo cui quella presenza di Evagrio sarebbe stata segno della 'necessità' della 'testimonianza diretta di un occidentale fedele all'ortodossia',[22] oltre che garanzia 'agli occhi dell'imperatore e della Chiesa' di 'ufficiale credibilità' al 'gruppo' antiocheno.[23]

[16] F. P. Rizzo, Il coinvolgimento della Chiesa di Sicilia nelle dispute conciliari del IV secolo, in: Serena Bianchetti *et al.* (eds.), ΠΟΙΚΙΛΜΑ. *Studi in onore di M.R. Cataudella in occasione del 60° compleanno*, II (La Spezia, 2001), 1069-83; F.P. Rizzo, *Sicilia*, II.1 (2006), 128-9.

[17] Giorgio Otranto, La Sicilia paleocristiana nei concili di III-IV secolo, in: Teresa Sardella *et al.* (eds.), *Euplo e Lucia, 304-2004. Agiografia e tradizioni cultuali in Sicilia. Atti del Convegno di St., Catania-Siracusa, 1-2 ott. 2004*, Quaderni di *Synaxis* 18 (Catania, 2006), 247-65, 253-5.

[18] Socrates Scholasticus, *HE* III 25.18; Cassiodorus, *HT* VII 4.14.

[19] Sulla variante Σικελῶν (*Siculorum*) cfr. PG 67, 454, nota 5.

[20] PG 67, 454.

[21] G. Otranto, La Sicilia (2006), 257-60.

[22] F.P. Rizzo, *Sicilia*, II.1 (2006), 130 e nota 17.

[23] F.P. Rizzo, Il coinvolgimento (2001), 1079.

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5. Le fonti patristiche testé citate vanno naturalmente lette nel complesso quadro storico della Sicilia di IV secolo,[24] con i suoi ricchi possidenti – perlopiù pagani – attaccati ai loro possedimenti, e preoccupati che essi potessero passare nelle mani della Chiesa.

Fu verosimilmente la Chiesa di Milano – accenno rapidissimamente alla quinta questione – tra le prime a beneficiarne. La tappa che Uranio Satiro, fratello di Ambrogio, fece nell'Isola compiendo un viaggio in Africa, probabilmente per ispezionare le proprietà di famiglia,[25] ha lasciato ipotizzare che in Sicilia vi fossero terre ambrosiane.[26] Convergente con tale ipotesi potrebbe essere il fatto che nel medesimo IV secolo operava in Sicilia un *Flavius Ambrosius*, avvocato alla corte del *consularis Siciliae*.[27] Ma circa la sua appartenenza alla famiglia del vescovo di Milano non c'è, attualmente, alcun elemento sicuro.[28]

6. Tra le fonti patristiche sulla Sicilia in epoca vandalica almeno un cenno riserverei, presentando la sesta questione, a Salviano di Marsiglia. Lo limito a una discussa espressione dello storiografo connessa all'altrettanto discusso *terminus post quem* della composizione del *De gubernatione Dei*, come ho puntualizzato in un recentissimo studio.[29]

Il dibattito storiografico moderno ha infatti preso tra l'altro in considerazione l'espressione *eversis Sardinia ac Sicilia* – s'intende, da parte dei Vandali –, di cui a *Gub.* 6.12.68. Tale espressione, per un'ipotesi risalente al Moricca,[30] viene solitamente riferita alla conquista della Sardegna avvenuta nel 461. Ma *evertere*, come ha notato fra gli altri il Lagarrigue,[31] suggerisce la medesima idea di *vastare*, e i Vandali poterono, prima del 461, saccheggiare altre volte la Sardegna senza conquistarla.[32]

A fare difficoltà perché si prendano in considerazione, con il Lagarrigue,[33] gli anni 440 e 456 vi sono, com'è stato argomentato, due passi di Idazio,[34] il

[24] Vincenzo Messana, Aspetti del cristianesimo nella *pars Occidentis* della Sicilia dalle origini alla metà del V secolo. Un contributo alla storia degli studi: *Guttadauro* 6 (2006) 21-48; Salvatore Costanza, Aspetti politici e socio-economici nella *pars Occidentis* della Sicilia romana tardoimperiale. Piste d'indagine e orientamenti degli studi: *Guttadauro* 6 (2006) 49-73.

[25] Ambrosius, *Exc.* 1.17.

[26] L. Cracco Ruggini, La Sicilia (1980), 10.13.66.78; Cesare Pasini, Chiesa di Milano e Sicilia: punti di contatto dal IV all'VIII secolo, in: Salvatore Pricoco *et al.* (eds.), *Sicilia e Italia suburbicaria tra IV e VIII secolo. Atti del Convegno di St., Catania, 24-27 ott. 1989* (Soveria Mannelli, 1991), 367-98, 375-8.

[27] *PLRE*, I, 52-3.

[28] F.P. Rizzo, *Sicilia*, II.1 (2006), 133, nota 17.

[29] Salvatore Costanza, Romani e barbari, cristiani e pagani nella concezione salvianea della storia (2ª parte: *De gubernatione Dei*): *Guttadauro* 6 (2006) 75-139, 75, nota 4.

[30] Umberto Moricca, Salviano e la data del *De gubernatione Dei*: *RFIC* 46 (1918) 241-55.

[31] SC 220, 14, nota 2.

[32] Hydatius, *Chron.* 86.

[33] SC 220, 14, nota 3.

[34] *Chron.* 120 e 177.

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quale proprio a quegli anni data azioni piratesche dei Vandali rispettivamente in Sicilia e Sardegna: l'espressione salvianea *eversis Sardinia ac Sicilia* 'si trova inserita in una sequenza così rigorosa e consequenziale di riferimenti alle intraprese vandale, che non lascia dubbi sull'esatta collocazione cronologica del fatto pertinente: l'*eversio Sardiniae ac Siciliae* segue alla *vastatio* delle città costiere della *Carthaginiensis* e precede il passaggio in Africa'.[35] Il *terminus post quem* della composizione del *De gubernatione Dei* non può pertanto non essere che il 439, di cui Salviano mostra di conoscere due grandi eventi.[36]

7. È noto che l'evento vandalico inferse il colpo decisivo all'ormai fragile aristocrazia nell'Isola: ripetute *depredationes* gensericiane, col puntuale riferimento all'assedio di Palermo del 440, sono insistentemente segnalate dalle fonti cristiane.[37] Di contraccolpi negativi per la Chiesa siciliana dice soltanto Idazio,[38] del quale la Molé Ventura[39] ha evidenziato una viscerale avversione alla stirpe barbarica e all'eresia ariana, che avrebbe potuto indurlo a dare eccessivo peso alle vicende dell'assedio di Genserico a Palermo e all'azione di Massimino l'ariano.

Sull'identità di Massimino, intorno al quale il dibattito storiografico è stato in questi decenni particolarmente vivace, verte la settima questione, con cui mi avvio a concludere.

Il García Moreno, sul finire degli anni '90,[40] ha colto nel testo idaziano un Massimino vescovo controversista, ipotizzando possa riguardare lui quanto tramandato su due eretici dal medesimo nome: egli avrebbe in Africa disputato con vescovi della statura di Ceriale e Agostino, e poi in Sicilia fatto altrettanto con altri vescovi, dai quali avrebbe subito le note conseguenze.

Il Pricoco ha recentemente affermato che non si può 'dire se e fino a che punto anche in Sicilia sia stato instaurato il clima di intolleranza religiosa creato dai Vandali in Africa, né collegare a un progetto del governo vandalo l'opera del vescovo ariano Massimino, che, secondo una notizia di Idazio, fu presente in Sicilia in quel periodo'.[41] Contemporaneamente la Cracco Ruggini

[35] Francesco Paolo Rizzo, Il *De gubernatione Dei* di Salviano nel quadro della problematica di fine impero: *QCCCM* 4-5 (1992-3) 71-108, 73-5; S. Costanza, Romani e barbari (2006), 107, nota 150.

[36] *Supra*, nota 29.

[37] Prosper Tiro, *Chron.* 1332 e 1342; Victor Vitensis, *Hist. persec. Vand.* 1.13-14; Cassiodorus, *Chron.* 1234 e 1235; Beda Venerabilis, *Chron.* 481; ecc.

[38] *Chron.* 120.

[39] Concetta Molé [Ventura], *Uno storico del V secolo: il vescovo Idazio* (Catania, 1978).

[40] Luis García Moreno, El Arrianismo vándalo y gótico en Sicilia, in: Rossana Barcellona *et al.* (eds.), *La Sicilia nella tarda antichità e nell'alto medioevo: religione e società. Atti del Convegno di St., Catania-Paternò, 24-27 sett. 1997* (Soveria Mannelli, 1999), 33-52.

[41] Salvatore Pricoco, Per un'introduzione all'età di Pascasino: popoli e culture nella prima Sicilia cristiana, in: Mariano Crociata *et al.* (eds.), *Pascasino di Lilibeo e il suo tempo: a 1550 anni dal Concilio di Calcedonia. Atti del Convegno di St., Marsala, 5-6 ott. 2001*, Storia e Cultura di Sicilia 11 (Caltanissetta-Roma, 2002), 11-28, 26.

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ha con la sua consueta acribia sottolineato che, quanto alla Sicilia occupata dai Vandali, 'dovette certo influire negativamente la presenza, sia in Africa sia in Sicilia, di quel Massimino ariano che è probabilmente da identificare con l'omonimo giovane seguace di Palladio di *Ratiaria*, acerrimo denigratore di Ambrogio (il quale aveva fatto condannare per arianesimo il suo maestro al concilio di Aquileia del 381) nella *Dissertatio contra Ambrosium*, a quanto sembra composta in Africa dopo il 438'.[42] Si tratta di un orientamento dalla studiosa manifestato in un precedente contributo: qui essa, non ritenendo 'si possa in ogni caso stabilire alcun legame fra la presenza di Massimino ariano e la nobiltà pagana con possedimenti nell'isola', puntualizzava che tuttavia 'decenni prima questa aristocrazia aveva guardato con simpatia a Palladio di *Ratiaria* e al suo discepolo Massimino in opposizione ad Ambrogio e a papa Damaso, al tempo del concilio antiariano di Aquileia del 381'.[43]

Sono dell'ultim'ora le ipotesi del Rizzo. Questi, già intervenendo su un'illuminante relazione del Giardina,[44] aveva sostenuto che Massimino fu 'vescovo degli ariani' in Africa, e motivato che non si può 'supporne un omonimo in Sicilia', né 'pensare che quello d'Africa vi si fosse trasferito come pastore della chiesa ariana', di cui non v'è 'traccia' nell'Isola.[45] Recentissimamente, sulla base delle testimonianze idaziane e agostiniane,[46] egli ha spiegato le espressioni d'Idazio *arianorum dux* e *damnatus a catholicis episcopis*, riguardanti Massimino e il suo ruolo nell'assedio di Palermo del 440, supponendo che 'Massimino facesse parte dell'avanguardia gensericiana e che l'episcopato locale' si trovasse 'nella necessità di contrastarne l'azione. La tesi di un Massimino vescovo ariano della Sicilia e di un concilio celebrato per condannarne la dottrina è quanto meno non necessaria'.[47]

Mi fermo qui. Dalla presentazione di alcuni *specimina* dell'articolato dibattito storiografico sulle fonti patristiche relative alla Sicilia spero siano emersi aspetti non marginali del *trend* dell'attuale ricerca. Spiace notare, purtroppo, che il medesimo dibattito mostri talora di non giovarsi di dati acclarati e risultanze acquisite.[48]

[42] Lellia Cracco Ruggini, La Sicilia nel V secolo e Pascasino di Lilibeo, in: M. Crociata *et al.* (eds.), *Pascasino di Lilibeo* (2002), 29-47, 33-4 e nota 12 (rinvii, fra l'altro, al Gryson e al Messana).

[43] L. Cracco Ruggini, Il primo cristianesimo (1987), 102.

[44] Andrea Giardina, Il quadro storico: Panormo da Augusto a Gregorio Magno: *Kokalos* 33 (1987) 225-49.

[45] Francesco Paolo Rizzo, Intervento: *Kokalos* 33 (1987) 249-51, 250.

[46] F.P. Rizzo, *Sicilia*, I (2005), 50, nota 117.

[47] *Ibid.* 17.

[48] *Supra*, nota 6.

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The Fall of Macedonius Reconsidered

Geoffrey GREATREX, Ottawa

On the evening of 7 August 511 the patriarch of Constantinople was escorted from the city under guard by the *magister officiorum* Celer. He was bound for Euchaïta, never to return; he was probably accompanied by Theodore Lector, who would in time provide one of the principal accounts of the events that precipitated his expulsion.[1] Although the circumstances of his downfall have been the subject of considerable discussion – unsurprisingly, given the wealth of material available – it remains the case that not all the relevant evidence has yet been brought to bear. It is our intention here to highlight one element that has failed hitherto to enter into accounts of these events.[2]

That element is a fragment of a letter from the future patriarch Severus of Antioch to bishop Soterichus of Caesarea in Cappadocia, preserved only on a limestone sherd of pottery from the monastery of Epiphanius at Thebes in Egypt and translated into Coptic. A preliminary edition of this letter was published by Walter Ewing Crum alongside the main body of Severus' correspondence in Syriac in Patrologia Orientalis already in 1919, and Crum republished the text with some minor changes and a new translation in the official excavation report of the monastery of Epiphanius in 1926. Despite these editions, it is not cited in any of the modern accounts just mentioned. It is worthwhile therefore to cite the letter in full in a new translation that I owe to my colleague Jitse Dijkstra.[3]

[1] Pseudo-Zachariah of Mytilene, *HE* VII.8 (CSCO 39/42, 47/32) with the transl. of Robert Phenix, Cornelia Horn, Geoffrey Greatrex, *The Miscellaneous History of Pseudo-Zachariah of Mytilene* (Liverpool, 2010), Theodore Lector 492 (GCS 3^2, 139.25-7) with Pierre Nautin, Théodore Lecteur et sa 'Réunion de différentes histoires' de l'église: *REB* 52 (1994) 213-43, 235-43.

[2] See Fiona Haarer, *Anastasius I* (Cambridge, 2006), 146-51, Mischa Meier, *Anastasios I. Die Entstehung des Byzantinischen Reiches* (Stuttgart, 2009), 264-6. In more detail, William H.C. Frend, The Fall of Macedonius in 511 – a Suggestion, in: Adolf M. Ritter (ed.), *Kerygma und Logos: Festschrift für Carl Andresen* (Göttingen, 1979), 183-95, see Brian E. Daley, Apollo as a Chalcedonian: A new fragment of a controversial work from early sixth-century Constantinople: *Traditio* 50 (1995) 31-49, 34-41. Michael Whitby, *The Ecclesiastical History of Evagrius Scholasticus* (Liverpool, 2000), 195 n. 174, notes both this letter and another one (to be discussed below) without entering into details.

[3] Severus, *Ep.* 118, PO 14.290-1 [= first edition] William E. Crum and Hugh G. Evelyn White, *The Metropolitan Museum of Art Egyptian Expedition: The Monastery of Epiphanius at Thebes. Part II. Coptic Ostraca and Papyri; Greek Ostraca and Papyri* (New York, 1926), no. 59 (text, 15, transl. 165) [= second edition]. We have published an edition of this letter, together with a translation of a further letter in Coptic (noted in n. 5 below), in a more wide-ranging study, Patriarchs and Politics in Constantinople in the Reign of Anastasius (with a reedition of *O. Mon. Epiph.* 59): *Millennium* 6 (2009).

Studia Patristica XLIV, 125-129.
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+ Apa Severus to Soterichus, the bishop of Cappadocia. [+] The Christ-loving and honoured general Patricius rose and said to him in just anger: 'It is not fitting for you to bring up again a synod, which everyone has rejected, by means of the *praxis* that you have drawn up'. That man answered and said: 'I for my part will not bring (forward) anything prejudicing the synod. As for that *praxis*, I drew it up at the command of the pious emperor because I wanted to bring some monasteries into the faith with us'. I answered and said: 'His Majesty did not know [back side:] that you wanted to confirm the synod by that *praxis*'. The honoured and Christ-loving patrician Paul, son of Vivianus, answered and said: 'And in order that you may reconcile to yourself four or five monasteries, you will dissolve the whole unity of the churches?' The Bishop Julian also said to him: 'Granted that you have drawn up that *praxis* because you desired to reconcile to yourself the monasteries, who then forced you to take oaths and signatures from the bishops, whom you ordain from time to time, so that they accept the council of Chalcedon?' +

Before commenting on the details revealed by this letter it is necessary to place it in context. Severus, it is well known, had come to Constantinople in 508 and rapidly gained the confidence of the emperor. His attempts to promote a more explicitly anti-Chalcedonian line did not meet with immediate success, encountering opposition not only in Constantinople, but also in Antioch and Jerusalem.[4] Probably in the first half of 511 the anti-Chalcedonians present in the capital introduced the words 'crucified for us' into the Trisagion, which sparked a riot. Blood flowed as supporters and opponents of the council fought it out in Hagia Sophia and the church of the Archangel; each side claimed that the other had behaved with outrageous brutality.[5] In this show of strength it was the patriarch who clearly gained the upper hand: the crowds hurled insults at the emperor, who retired to the palace and prepared to flee, should the need arise. Instead, however, he summoned Macedonius and endured his reproaches, claiming that he was now in agreement with him; as the patriarch made his way to the emperor, both people and soldiers signalled their support for him.[6]

The next event of which we hear is the signing of a document on Wednesday 20 July by Macedonius that at best passed over all mention of Chalcedon and at worst condemned it outright: Pseudo-Zachariah and Evagrius both claim that the patriarch abjured the council explicitly, while Theodore Lector states instead that he was tricked by Celer, the *magister officiorum*, into passing over the

[4] See (*e.g.*) William H.C. Frend, *The Rise of the Monophysite Movement* (Cambridge, 1972), 217-18, Alois Grillmeier, *Jesus der Christus im Glauben der Kirche*[2] II.1 (Freiburg, 1991), 306-14, Pauline Allen and C.T. Robert Hayward, *Severus of Antioch* (London, 2004), 8-9.

[5] Theod. Lect. 483-4 (GCS 3, 137.23-138.8) = Theophanes, *Chronogr.* 154.3-11 (blaming the anti-Chalcedonians), see the letter of Severus to Soterichus also preserved in Coptic, edited and translated into Latin by Gérard Garitte, Fragments coptes d'une lettre de Sévère d'Antioche à Sotérichos de Césarée: *Muséon* 65 (1952) 191-5, giving the opposite side, see Dijkstra and Greatrex, Patriarchs and Politics, for an English translation. Garitte, *art. cit.*, 185 n. 2, places the riot 'around 510', followed by M. Whitby, *Evagrius* (2000), 195 n. 175, but W.H.C. Frend, The Fall of Macedonius (1979), 189 assigns it with greater probability to 511.

[6] So Theod. Lect. 485-6 (GCS 3, 138.9-20) = Theoph. 154.11-22, naturally a biased source.

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councils of Ephesus and Chalcedon in silence.[7] Surprisingly, modern scholars have tended to give more credence to the former view, despite its inherent implausibility.[8] Macedonius had, after all, been a consistently vigorous defender of the council, at least in the recent past, even going so far as to excomunicate Flavian of Antioch when he had attempted to compromise with the anti-Chalcedonians.[9] The reason why Macedonius is seen as having performed such a sudden *volte-face* is that he was forced into it by Anastasius. Yet such an analysis relies on a serious misreading of the situation in Constantinople in the summer of 511. From the accounts of both Pseudo-Zachariah and Theodore Lector it emerges very clearly that it was the patriarch who was in the ascendant, despite the presence of Severus. Anastasius had had little choice but to effect a reconciliation with Macedonius after the riots, since the extent of popular support for the patriarch had swiftly become apparent. A measure of the disquiet felt in imperial circles is perceptible in the second letter of Severus to Soterichus, also preserved in Coptic, according to which Secundus (i.e. Secundinus), the brother-in-law of Anastasius, said to Macedonius after the riot, 'For I will not be ashamed before you, since the matter is settled for me as regards the faith and I do not fear the threat of some people. For, what is more, the philanthropy of God will protect us and our pious emperor.'[10] This position of strength, however, was at the same time an extremely dangerous one, leaving Macedonius vulnerable to accusations of fomenting revolt – which in the end was one of the reasons given for his banishment – and must have inclined him to seek a rapprochement with the emperor, in order that the evident breach between the two be seen to be healed. The document offered to him by Celer must therefore have seemed like a judicious way of lowering the temperature and was no doubt crafted to concede as much as possible to the anti-Chalcedonians while still being acceptable to Macedonius.

The patriarch's assent to the document undermined his position more than he had anticipated. Not only had he given ground to his opponents – although it is clear that he had always been willing to accept the Henotikon[11] – but he

[7] Pseudo-Zach. *HE* VII.8b (CSCO SS 39/42, 41/28), Evagr. *HE* III.31 (129.15-24), Theod. Lect. 487 (GCS 3, 21-5) = Theoph. 154.25-155.1. W.H.C. Frend, *Monophysite Movement* (1972), 218, see id., Fall of Macedonius (1979), 192, postulates a theological debate between Severus and Macedonius that preceded the signing; there is no reason to doubt the holding of the debate, but whether it took place on the same day is uncertain.

[8] So M. Whitby, *Evagrius* (2000), 181 n. 109, Peter Charanis, *Church and State in the Later Roman Empire* (Thessaloniki, 1974), 69, W.H.C. Frend, The Fall of Macedonius (1979), 191 (although at 190 he seems to accept Theodore Lector's version).

[9] Theod. Lect. 479 (GCS 3, 136.28-137.2), see F. Haarer, *Anastasius* (2006), 147.

[10] G. Garitte, Lettre de Sévère (1952), 195, see Athanasius' *Life of Severus*, ed. and transl. Edgar J. Goodspeed, PO 4.635 and the Arabic version, ed. and transl. Youhanna N. Youssef, PO 49.426/7. For Secundinus see *PLRE* II, Secundinus 5; he was consul in 511.

[11] Theod. Lect. 456 (GCS 3, 128.21), see A. Grillmeier, *Jesus der Christus* (1991), II.1, 301 and G. Garitte, Lettre de Sévère (1952), 196, where Secundinus refers to Macedonius' signature and his ongoing loyalty to the document.

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had also allowed them to open up a gulf between him and his most zealous supporters, the Akoimetae monks. A slight concession on the patriarch's part had put his whole position in danger, cutting him off from the base of his support; no doubt his opponents exaggerated the extent of his concession as far as possible, precisely in order to isolate him, thereby giving rise to the version according to which he rejected the council explicitly. Two days later, according to the letter of the presbyter Simeon, quoted *in extenso* by Pseudo-Zachariah, Macedonius presided at a dedication festival at a Martyr Church in the Hebdomon at which both Anastasius and Areadne refused to take communion from him. On Sunday 24 July the monks restored communion with Macedonius, but already on the following day some of them defected to the emperor and made accusations against him to the general Patricius. Anastasius then acted decisively, cutting off water supplies from the monasteries, assuring himself of the support of his court and arresting many of Macedonius' supporters; the patriarch himself was seized and interrogated by Celer and Severus. Having given donatives to the army to secure its support, Anastasius arrested the patriarch's deacon Pascasius on 1 August; he in turn accused Macedonius of raising a rebellion against the emperor. On Saturday 6 August the emperor held a formal meeting of his court at which he refused to hear a defence on Macedonius' behalf; on the following evening he was forced to leave the capital.[12]

The extract with which we are concerned fits somewhere within this fortnight. In it Severus describes how Macedonius was upbraided not only by Patricius, mentioned also in Simeon's account, but also by Paul, who became consul in 512, Severus himself, and a certain Julian, probably the bishop of Halicarnassus.[13] It is clear from their remarks that Macedonius has drawn up a

[12] Ps.-Zachariah, *HE* VII.8 (CSCO SS 39/42, 41-7/28-32), see Michael the Syrian, *Chronique*, ed. Jean-Baptiste Chabot, IX 9 (vol. 4, 164) and Th. Lect. 490 (GCS 3, 139.11-20) = Theoph. 155.9-17. Michael adds the otherwise unsupported detail that Macedonius was the uncle of the future rebel Vitalian. If this is correct – and it is an improbable invention – then the precariousness of Anastasius' position is underlined: Vitalian, the *magister militum per Thracias* launched an uprising that nearly unseated the emperor in 513 or 514 on which see Geoffrey Greatrex, Flavius Hypatius, *quem vidit validum Parthus sensitque timendum*: An investigation of his career: *Byzantion* 66 (1996), 120-42, 132-3, and F. Haarer, *Anastasius* (2006), 164-7. John of Beth Aphthonia, *Vita Sev.* (PO 2.236-7), see Theod. Lect. 490 (GCS 3, 139.11-20) and Theoph. 155.9-15 on the arrest of Macedonius.

[13] On Patricius see *PLRE* II, Patricius 14 and G. Greatrex, Flavius Hypatius (1996), 125-6. On Paul see *PLRE* II, Paulus 34, and John the Lydian, *De Mag.* III.48 (ed. and transl. Jacques Schamp [Paris, 2006], II 103 with I 2, dxcii-dxciv): he was rescued from bankruptcy by the emperor. According to Athanasius'*Life of Severus* (PO 4.636), he accommodated Severus at his house and played a leading role in promoting his views (cf. 616, 648), see PO 49.426/7, 408/9, 438/9. Julian of Halicarnassus' presence in Constantinople at this time is confirmed by Theod. Lect. 484 (GCS 3, 138.6-7). But another Julian may be intended: a Coptic fragment from Athanasius' work, PO 4.584, refers to a bishop Julius of Atramyttium who was prominent in the dispute with Macedonius (see PO 4.631-3, 637-8, PO 49.422/3-424/5, 428/9-430/1, referring in Arabic and Ethiopic to a Julian rather than Julius).

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praxis, i.e. a deposition or the acts (of a meeting),[14] that had specifically invoked Chalcedon. This he had circulated to four or five monasteries in order to bring them into communion, apparently with the authorisation of the emperor. The most plausible context for this discussion is the immediate aftermath of 20 July, the point at which Macedonius needed the most to restore his credibility with the Chalcedonian monks of the city. We may suppose therefore that it was on 21 July that he explicitly affirmed to the monks his backing for Chalcedon by means of his *praxis*. We may further suggest that he secured Anastasius' support – which is not denied by his interlocutors – by misrepresenting exactly what he would put in the document. The emperor is likely to have backed some sort of conciliatory move at this stage, being still unsure of the balance of power in the city: it was only on 25 July, following the defection of some of the monks to his side, that he began to move against the monasteries and to prepare the definitive removal of the patriarch. In 499, moreover, the patriarch had undertaken just such an initiative at the emperor's behest to end the secession of certain monasteries in Constantinople: Theophanes, here relying upon Theodore Lector, describes how Macedonius recommended to the emperor that a *synodos endemousa* approve what had been rightly laid down as doctrine at Chalcedon. This was done, he claims, by means of an *engraphos praxis*, although it appears that the monasteries continued to refuse to accept the Henotikon, even if they remained on good terms with Macedonius.[15] It is conceivable that the patriarch merely used the same *praxis* in 511, relying upon the authorisation he had obtained long before.

The exchange between Macedonius and the emperor's advisers probably falls therefore on or around 22 July 511, the day on which Anastasius refused communion from the patriarch. His accusers reproached him above all for bringing up the matter of Chalcedon again, an issue that they had hoped to sideline. Julian's criticisms went further, however. He notes how Macedonius' aim was not to bring the monasteries into communion with the emperor, but rather with himself, as indeed was surely the case; he also rightly accuses the patriarch of having consistently sought to ensure the adherence of his own appointees to the council by receiving written assurances from them, a point confirmed in case the of Soterichus himself, Severus' correspondent.[16]

[14] Geoffrey H. W. Lampe, *A Patristic Greek Lexicon* (Oxford, 1961), 1127, nos. 5-6.

[15] Theoph. 141.19-27 = Theod. Lect. 459 (GCS 3, 129.15-21) with *KG* 46 and A. Grillmeier, *Jesus der Christus* (1991), II.1, 303-4, F. Haarer, *Anastasius* (2006), 140-1. The monasteries named by Theophanes are those of Dius, of Bassianus, of the Akoimetae and of Matrona; both Ps.-Zach. *HE* VII 8 (CSCO SS 39/42, 42/29) and Theod. Lect. 488 (GCS 3, 139.2) mention Macedonius' visit to the monastery of Dalmatus in 511. These would therefore correspond to the 'four or five monasteries' referred to by Paul.

[16] Theod. Lect. 496 (GCS 3, 141.13-18) = Theoph. 153.12-15 with Ernst Honigmann, *Évêques et évêchés monophysites d'Asie antérieure au VIe siècle* (Louvain, 1951), CSCO 127, 109.

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Le respect dû au Livre des Écritures: Quelques témoignages patristiques

Benoît GAIN, Grenoble

La Bibliothèque Nationale de France a présenté du 9. IX. 2005 au 30. IV. 2006 l'exposition *«Livres de parole. Torah, Bible, Coran»*,[1] dans laquelle les organisateurs montraient le soin apporté par les juifs dans la copie de la Torah destinée à l'usage synagogal.[2] La section consacrée au christianisme était en revanche presque muette sur les usages liturgiques: la tradition chrétienne des premiers siècles n'entourait-elle pas de respect et d'honneur les livres sacrés?

Que les juifs attachent une valeur immense au livre sacré, est attesté par Josèphe qui rapporte qu'un soldat romain, ayant brûlé par malveillance un livre de l'Écriture, fut mis à mort.[3] Les chrétiens eussent-ils été aussi sévères? Le respect de la Bible dans sa matérialité n'est pas en effet pour eux la valeur suprême: ainsi, pour les Pères du désert la primauté revient à deux vertus. La pauvreté: «Un vieillard dit qu'un frère, qui ne possédait qu'un évangile, le vendit et en donna le prix pour nourrir les pauvres, en prononçant cette parole mémorable: 'J'ai vendu, dit-il en effet, la parole même qui me dit: *Vends ce qui t'appartient et donne-le aux pauvres*'».[4] Un autre apophtegme exalte l'obéissance: «Un ancien avait pour disciple son esclave. Pour le vaincre, il l'amena à pratiquer l'obéissance avec une telle perfection qu'il lui dit: 'Va prendre le livre qui a été lu dans l'assemblée et jette-le dans un feu bien allumé'. L'autre fit sans hésiter ce qui lui était commandé et, lorsqu'il eut lancé le livre, le foyer s'éteignit, afin de nous montrer que l'obéissance est belle, car c'est l'échelle du royaume des Cieux».[5]

Alors que les juifs ne détruisent jamais les livres bibliques mais enterrent dans une *gueniza*, avec autant d'égard qu'envers un être humain, les rouleaux impropres au service liturgique,[6] la législation ecclésiastique, tardive et moins catégorique, du VI[e] concile (691, c. 68) proscrit «à quiconque de détruire un des volumes de l'Ancien et du Nouveau Testament (...), de le déchirer ou de le

[1] Annie Berthier et Anne Zali (eds.) (Paris, 2005).

[2] *Ibid.*, 62-71.

[3] *Bel. Jud.* II 13, 2; éd. Benedictus Niese, §252-253, t. 6 (Berlin, 1955), 202.

[4] *Les Apophtegmes des Pères.* Coll. systématique, VI, 6 (SC 387) (Paris, 1993), 318-9; Evagre le Pontique, *Traité pratique* (SC 171) (Paris, 1971), 704-6.

[5] *Les sentences des Pères du désert. Nouveau recueil* (...) par Lucien Regnault (Solesmes [2]1977), 34 (pièce N 53).

[6] A. Berthier et A. Zali (eds.), 2005, 64 et 66.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 133-138.
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livrer à des marchands de livres (...), à moins que l'un ou l'autre volume ne fût totalement hors d'usage par les vers, l'humidité ou d'une autre manière».[7]

S'agit-il encore de respect pour le livre des Écritures quand on se faisait imposer les évangiles sur la tête en cas de céphalées? Réservé devant cette pratique, Augustin ne la condamnait pas absolument,[8] car il existait, surtout en Égypte, bien des coutumes apotropaïques, qui consistaient «à consulter les démons».

En revanche, Jean Chrysostome mentionne en 387 la coutume «des femmes et des enfants [qui] portent l'Évangile au cou comme un sûr préservatif. Hésiteriez-vous donc à imprimer en votre mémoire les préceptes et les lois de ce même Évangile[9]?» Ailleurs il précise l'origine de cette coutume: «(Les juifs) donnaient à ces petites bandes un nom qui marquait qu'ils les portaient pour *garder* la Loi. C'est ce que font encore aujourd'hui plusieurs femmes chrétiennes qui pendent l'Évangile à leur cou».[10] Peut-être faut-il voir une influence juive dans un autre usage, rapporté par Chrysostome dans le cadre d'une exhortation à prononcer le nom de Dieu avec respect: «Un serviteur n'ose appeler son maître par son nom sans y joindre quelque formule d'honneur (...). S'il vous faut ouvrir l'Évangile, vous vous lavez d'abord les mains, et pénétrés de respect et de piété, vous le prenez avec crainte et tremblement».[11] On sait que les juifs multipliaient les ablutions, et le traité *Yadaim* du Talmud est presque tout entier consacré au lavage des mains.

La *copie* de la Torah doit suivre des règles très précises (parchemin pur, calligraphie, mise en page). Rien de tel chez les chrétiens. Les moines, dont la copie des Écritures était souvent le principal travail, ne semblent pas avoir dû s'astreindre à des normes particulières, quoiqu'ils s'y fussent grandement appliqués. La qualification des copistes de la Bible ne paraît pas non plus avoir été réglementée avant un capitulaire de Charlemagne entérinant une prescription du concile d'Aix-la-Chapelle (789), de «choisir des hommes d'âge mûr».[12]

À l'origine, les livres bibliques (ce fut le cas de nos plus anciens manuscrits grecs ou latins) servirent pour la lecture liturgique.[13] Le support et la couleur de l'écriture reçurent parfois un traitement particulier. Ce sont les fameux parchemins (pas d'exemple de papyrus, trop fragiles?) teints en pourpre et surlesquels on écrivait en lettres d'or ou d'argent.[14] Technique attestée, selon

[7] Périclès-Pierre Joannou, *Discipline générale antique (IIe-IXe s.)*. T.I/1: *Canons des conciles œcuméniques* ... (Grottaferrata, 1962), 206, 5.

[8] Aug., *Tr. in Jo.* VII 12; *Ep.* 55,37.

[9] *Hom.* 7 au peuple d'Antioche, 5 (PG 49, 96).

[10] *Ibid.*, *Hom.* 19,4 (PG 49, 196).

[11] *Hom. in Matt.*72,2 (PG 58, 669).

[12] Joseph Hefele and Henri Leclercq, *Histoire des conciles*, t. 3 (Paris, 1909), 1027-34.

[13] P. Petitmengin, in: Jacques Fontaine and Charles Pietri, *Le monde latin antique et la Bible* (Paris, 1985), 95.

[14] Genèse de Vienne; Petropolitanus (Saint-Petersbourg, Bibl. publ. 5); Évangiles du Rossanensis; du Sinopensis (Paris, *Suppl. gr. 1286*): grec. Évangiles de Lindisfarne: latin. Codex Argenteus des Évangiles en gothique.

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F. Josèphe,[15] pour la Torah envoyée par Éléazar à Ptolémée Philadelphe (vers 270 [?] av. J.-C.), et connue aussi pour la littérature classique, mais qui se développa à l'époque romaine dans l'aristocratie ou à la cour impériale, puis parmi les chrétiens fortunés.[16] Était-ce de la vénération pour la Parole de Dieu ... ou plutôt un étalage de luxe, blâmé par Jean Chrysostome et Jérôme?[17]

On éprouve la même hésitation à propos de la reliure de certains évangéliaires – tels deux exemplaires milanais en ivoire de 400 environ – ou devant des coffrets magnifiquement ouvragés.[18] On comprend que ces œuvres d'art aient été conservées dans un *diaconicum*, mais quand Paulin de Nole mentionne ce local, c'est pour indiquer à son correspondant qu'on peut y lire l'Écriture individuellement en toute tranquillité.[19]

Cette sacristie est parfois le point de départ des processions liturgiques au cours desquelles l'évangéliaire est porté par un ministre, d'une part au début de la célébration, d'autre part en vue de la proclamation (la 'petite entrée' de la liturgie byzantine), le plus souvent par un diacre. À ces deux moments, l'assemblée se lève pour vénérer l'évangéliaire.[20] L'*Expositio (...) liturgiae gallicanae* (milieu du VII[e] s.) exprime le sens de cette procession: *uelut potentia Christi triumphantis de morte*.[21] La procession était plus longue quand l'Évangile était lu à l'ambon, ce qui demeura l'usage en Italie, du côté gauche ou du côté droit.[22]

Très tôt la procession de l'Évangile était accompagnée de luminaires (sept dans la liturgie gallicane), qui étaient au Bas-Empire portés devant les plus hauts dignitaires, ou qui entouraient le portrait de l'empereur, posés sur une table carrée.[23] À Vigilance de Catagurris reprochant aux chrétiens de brûler des lumières durant le jour, s. Jérôme répond en 406 que «par tout l'Orient, au moment de la lecture de l'Évangile, on allume les luminaires, *iam sole rutilante, non utique ad fugandas tenebras, sed ad signum laetitiae demonstrandum* (...), *ut sub typo luminis corporalis, illa lux ostendatur*»[24] et de citer *Ps.* 118:105.

La proclamation de l'Évangile s'accompagne actuellement, dans presque tous les rites, de l'encensement, soit qu'il la précède, soit qu'il affecte le livre lui-même, parfois présenté ouvert par le diacre (rite copte). Mais il n'en était pas

[15] *Ant. Jud.* XII 2, 11; éd. B. Niese, §89, t. 4 (Berlin, 1955), 87; Aristée, *Lettre à Philocrate*, 176.

[16] Charles Graux, art. Chrysographia: DAGR I/2 (1887) 1134-40.

[17] Chrys., *Hom.* 32 *in Joan.* (PG 59, 187); Hier., *Praef. in Job: Biblia Sacra iuxta Vulgatam versionem*, recensuit Robertus Weber (Stuttgart, [2]1975), I 732.

[18] Henri Leclercq, art. Évangéliaires: DACL V/1 (1922) c. 839-42.

[19] *Ep.* 32,16 (CSEL XXIX, 291).

[20] Le clergé ne doit pas s'appuyer sur des *reclinatoria*: Pierre Le Brun, *Explication (...) de la messe* I (Paris, [1]1716 = Paris, 1949), 206-7.

[21] PL 72, 91 C.

[22] Mario Righetti, *Historia de la liturgía* (BAC, 144), t. 2 (Madrid, 1956), 231, n. 95.

[23] Cf. *Notitia dignitatum*, éd. Eduard Böcking (Bonn, 1839), 12 et 8.

[24] *Contra Vigilantium*, 7 (PL 23, 346A).

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de même dans les tout premiers siècles: dans les célébrations, l'encens était ignoré, voire prohibé, comme il ressort de textes de Justin, d'Athénagore, de Tertullien et de Clément d'Alexandrie.[25] Ils vivaient en effet à une époque où les chrétiens étaient sommés d'offrir de l'encens devant l'image de l'empereur. Mis à part les rites funéraires, l'encensement fut longtemps réservé aux processions, à l'exclusion de l'autel, de l'église et des personnes (jusqu'au IX[e] s. à Rome). Or, le plus ancien témoignage que nous possédions d'un encensement de l'Évangile concerne la liturgie de Jérusalem. D'après le récit d'Egérie (383-384) la lecture, par l'évêque, de l'Évangile de la Résurrection lors des matines du dimanche à la rotonde de l'Anastasis, est précédée d'un encensement de tout l'édifice.[26]

En Occident, il faut descendre jusqu'au *Sacramentaire gélasien* (milieu du VII[e] s.) pour trouver mention d'une procession de l'Évangile avec cierges et encens, lors des cérémonies du baptême. Il en est de même lors de la messe papale décrite dans l'*Ordo Romanus I* (v. 690-700), où le diacre se rend à l'ambon pour chanter l'Évangile, précédé de l'encens et de torches allumées.[27] Le livre lui-même n'était pas encensé. Ces deux livres liturgiques, d'origine romaine, reflètent un emprunt des évêques aux usages de la magistrature romaine. L'encens qui accompagne la procession de l'Évangile n'est pas la figure des prières des fidèles: ici encens et lumières, selon Le Brun font «regarder Jésus-Christ comme la bonne odeur et la lumière de nos âmes».[28]

Dans le rite romain l'évangéliaire, dès le V[e] s. porté solennellement avant l'arrivée du pape, était placé sur un coussin déposé à même l'autel, qui représente le Christ, privilège que ce livre partageait seulement avec les vases appelés à contenir les Saintes espèces. L'autel était comme le trône de l'Évangile[29] et le diacre l'y prenait comme du Christ lui-même.

Dès le V[e] siècle, le pape baisait l'évangéliaire aussitôt après l'autel. Aux siècles suivants, le sous-diacre le présentait à tout le clergé. Dans le rite byzantin, après la lecture, le diacre le présente ouvert à baiser au prêtre ou à l'évêque.[30] Jonas d'Orléans († 842/3) donne le sens du baiser: «Et pourquoi cela, si ce n'est en l'honneur de celui de qui l'on croit que ce sont les paroles?».[31]

L'évangéliaire a aussi une fonction importante dans les ordinations épiscopales: pendant l'oraison consécratoire, deux diacres tiennent l'Évangile ouvert, sur la tête

[25] Justin, *I Apol* 13; Athén., *Legatio* 13; Tert., *De Cor.* 10; Clem. Alex., *Paid.* II 8, 67.

[26] *Peregr.* 24,10 (SC 21, 196).

[27] Dom E. Fehrenbach, art. Encens: DACL II/1 (1922) c.13 et 15.

[28] See 2*Cor.* 2:15; P. Le Brun, *Explication* ([1]1716 = 1949), 206.

[29] Louis Duchesne, *Origines du culte chrétien* (Paris, [5]1925), 172-3. Sur la procession précédant la proclamation de l'Evangile, M. Righetti, *Historia*, 2, 230-1.

[30] L. Duchesne, *Origines*, 173; Jean Bona, *Rerum liturgicarum libri duo* (Rome, 1671; tr. franç., *De la liturgie* [...], Paris, 1854), 1, 610.

[31] Jonas, *De cultu imaginum*, II (PL 106, 343A), cité par J. Bona, *ibid.*, 2, 164; P. Le Brun, *Explication* ([1]1716 = 1949), 211-2.

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du pape dans le rite romain depuis le IVe s., sur la tête de l'évêque selon les *Constitutions apostoliques*, et cela constitue le rite essentiel de la cérémonie.[32]

C'est sur l'évangéliaire qu'une moniale, dans la Règle de Césaire,[33] prend possession des clés de son office. Plus tard on prêtera serment sur l'Évangile.

Enfin, l'honneur le plus remarquable décerné à l'Évangile est son intronisation solennelle dans la salle où délibéraient les Pères conciliaires, puis son exposition, ouvert, sur un trône, image du trône divin.[34] Le premier exemple avéré est celui du concile d'Ephèse (431), dont nous possédons deux attestations: l'une dans la *Relatio ad imperatores* adressée aux empereurs: «Placé au centre du trône, le saint Évangile indiquait la présence du Christ lui-même»[35]; l'autre, de Cyrille d'Alexandrie dans l'*Apologeticus* à Théodose II.[36] L'Évangile fut également intronisé à Chalcédoine (451), à Constantinople III (nov. 680) et à Nicée II (24. IX. 787). Après Constantinople IV (869), où l'on ajouta la Croix, disparut un rite qu'avait adopté le cérémonial de la cour impériale, du moins depuis Justinien. Selon des études récentes il ne fut réintroduit qu'au concile de Ferrare (8. I. 1438), mais la signification du rite fut mal perçue. À Trente (13. XII. 1545) un autre rite lui fut substitué, mais on revint à Vatican I et II à la tradition, malgré une certaine maladresse dans la disposition (l'*Urbinas Latinus 10*, réalisé vers 1474/1482, fut offert à la vénération des Pères le 11. X. 1962, puis à chaque congrégation générale[37]).

La représentation du trône vide (*étoimasia*) à partir du Ve s., et probablement du IVe s., signifiait l'attente du jugement de Dieu. Son trône étant prêt, Il pouvait donc venir, selon l'interprétation du *Ps.* 9:9. L'idée du jugement est ensuite exprimée par les Pères pour qui les Écritures sont le Logos, le Christ: leur intronisation signifiait que le Christ était revêtu d'autorité, de majesté et du jugement divin. Au-dessus des Évangiles on représentait une colombe prête à prendre son envol, symbole du Saint-Esprit, jadis envoyé aux apôtres, à présent sur leurs successeurs réunis en concile.[38]

L'iconographie la plus ancienne – l'arc central de Sainte-Marie Majeure, de l'époque de Sixte III – exprime clairement cette conception, reprise à Ravenne (Baptistère des orthodoxes) et ailleurs, dans un sens anti-hérétique et surtout anti-arien.[39]

[32] L. Duchesne, *Origines*, 381-382; *Const. apost.* VIII 4, 6 (SC 336) (Paris, 1987), 142.

[33] *Reg. uirg.* 32,4 (SC 345) (Paris, 1988), 212.

[34] Voir H. Leclercq, art. Etimasie DACL V/1 (1922) c. 671-3, et surtout *Il libro del Vangelo nei Concili ecumenici* a cura di Romeo De Maio (Vatican, 1963 = tr. franç. *Le livre des Evangiles* (...), Vatican, 1963).

[35] Eduard Schwartz, ACO I, 1, 3 (Berlin, 1927), 4, 5-6.

[36] *Ibid.*, 83, 25-26.

[37] Copié sur un modèle carolingien, décrit par R. De Maio, 27-37 et les planches. A Vatican II, le ms. était ouvert à l'incipit de *Jean*.

[38] R. De Maio, *ibid.*, 21-2.

[39] Cf. l'art. du DACL, De Maio et Hermann-Josef Sieben, *Konzilsdarstellungen & Konzilsvorstellungen. 1000 Jahre Konzilsikonographie aus Handschriften und Druckwerken* (Würzburg, 1990).

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Un texte plus tardif enfin manifeste à quel point l'évangéliaire était en vénération. Le canon 3 de Constantinople III décide, le 28. II. 870, que «l'image sainte de Jésus-Christ notre Seigneur (...) sera vénérée du *même culte* d'honneur que le livre des saints évangiles».[40]

* * *

Ces rites et prescriptions compensent en quelque sorte les dispositions du concile *in Trullo* (c. 68) qui pouvaient paraître assez ternes par rapport à l'extrême vénération des juifs pour les rouleaux de la Torah.

De l'absence de témoignages antérieurs à la seconde moitié du IVe siècle, on ne doit pas, à notre avis, conclure à un accroissement de respect pour les livres saints à cette époque, car les descriptions que nous avons conservées des cérémonies liturgiques sont très peu nombreuses avant le IVe s. En revanche, avec la Paix de l'Église, les cérémonies purent se déployer dans les basiliques. D'autres supposent raisonnablement l'influence du canon, mais les preuves formelles semblent faire défaut.[41]

Peut-être certaines pratiques des chrétiens s'expliquent-elles par des influences juives et on est en droit de se demander pourquoi ils n'ont pas manifesté un respect plus absolu du Livre. L'explication implicite en serait à chercher, croyons-nous, dans l'existence d'autres *res* sacralisées: les huiles nécessaires pour certains sacrements, et surtout dans les Espèces eucharistiques elles-mêmes, dont le caractère sacré dépasse absolument même celui de l'Évangéliaire: il convenait donc de maintenir une hiérarchie entre la présence du Christ dans l'Église par sa Parole et dans son Corps.

[40] P.-P. Joannou, *Canons des conciles oecuméniques* (1962), 297.

[41] Rien sur cet aspect dans Lee Martin McDonald and James A. Sanders, *The Canon Debate* (Peabody, MA, ²2004).

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The Vulgate *Primum Quaeritur*, Codex Fuldensis and the Hermeneutical Role of Early Christian Introductory Materials

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The manuscript Codex Fuldensis transcribed in the mid 6th century is well-known for transmitting one of the earliest datable texts of the Vulgate revision.[1] It also incorporates numerous ancillary materials or paratexts alongside the actual text of the NT.[2] Among these paratexts is the *Primum Quaeritur* (*PQ*) prologue, known from its opening words and written as an introduction to this Vulgate revision of the *Corpus Paulinum*, which is widely attributed to Rufinus of Syria.[3] In this paper I argue that by lauding the OT and human capacity for virtue this prologue fronts an interpretation of Paul's letters in line with Rufinus' theology; this interpretation in the *PQ* is further brought into focus by contrasting it with alternative interpretations found in other paratexts from Codex Fuldensis, namely the Marcionite prologues and capitula.[4] The incorporation of paratextual materials, I argue, transformed early Christian manuscripts from mere receptacles of the text into vehicles for transmitting its interpretation.

[1] For the editio princeps see Ernestus Ranke (ed.), *Codex Fuldensis: Novum Testamentum Latine interprete Hieronymo ex manuscripto Victoris Capuani* (Marburg, 1868). For an overview and bibliography see Bonifatius Fischer, *Lateinische Bibelhandschriften im frühen Mittelalter* (Freiburg i. Br., 1985), 57-66.

[2] I build on Gerard Genette's theorizations of paratexts as mediators of interpretation; see *Paratexts: Thresholds of Interpretation* (transl. Jane Lewin; Cambridge, 1997).

[3] Almost all Vulgate manuscripts have either the original *PQ* or a prologue dependent on it. For a list of prologues and their manuscripts see Hermann J. Frede (ed.), *Epistulae ad Thessalonicenses, Timotheum, Titum, Philemonem, Hebraeos* (Freiburg i. Br., 1975-91), 99-107. For discussions of Rufinus as the author of the Vulgate revision of the *Corpus Paulinum* and the *PQ*, see *id.*, *Epistulae ad Philippenses et ad Colossenses* (Freiburg i. Br., 1966-71), 42-43; *id.*, *Epistulae ad Thessalonicenses*, 99-101; Uwe Fröhlich (ed.), *Epistula ad Corinthios I* (Freiburg i. Br., 1995), 220-22; and Bonifatius Fischer, Das Neue Testament in lateinischer Sprache, in: *Die Alten Übersetzungen des Neuen Testaments, die Kirchenväterzitate und Lektionare* (ed. Kurt Aland; Berlin, 1972), 1-92, 73. Texts of the *PQ*, other prologues, and capitula discussed here are referenced according to the edition John Wordsworth and Henry J. White (eds.), *Nouum Testamentum Latine, Editio Maior: Pars Secunda – Epistulae Paulinae* (Oxford, 1913-41).

[4] For a detailed discussion of the Marcionite prologues see Nils Dahl, The Origin of the Earliest Prologues to the Pauline Letters: *Semeia* 12 (1978) 233-77. For overviews and bibliographies of prologues, capitula, and other paratexts to Paul's letters in Latin manuscripts see Frede (ed.), *Epistulae ad Thessalonicenses*, 98-131.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 139-144.
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Foremost among the themes in Rufinus' *Liber de fide* that find prominence in the *PQ* is the role that example and habit play in fostering sinful or virtuous behavior.[5] Rufinus' belief in the goodness of human nature makes possible this attainment of virtue by example and also explains his esteem for the law and righteous luminaries of the OT, since human nature remained unchanged from Adam to Christ and thus allowed for virtuous behavior. In the *PQ* Rufinus develops these themes by addressing many standard topics of ancient prolegomena: e.g. the scope of a corpus, the order of its tracts, and their authenticity.[6]

The *PQ*'s description of the scope of Paul's letters reflects Rufinus' teachings on the origin of sin and the possibilities of human sinlessness. In his *Liber de fide* Rufinus maintains that human nature is good and sin is not passed down from Adam and Eve, for this would render God unjust.[7] Rufinus also contends that humans have the same rational soul as Jesus.[8] Since each individual soul is created by God, it could not be stained with sin; since sin is not passed down naturally, all humans are responsible for their own actions.[9] Although Rufinus does not indicate how sin is passed on, we are probably not remiss to envision Rufinus holding an opinion similar to Pelagius that sin is transmitted through the example of Adam and Eve's disobedience.[10] In fact for Rufinus, Jesus' triumph over the passions and his life of virtue serves as an exemplum for defeating vice and living virtuously.[11] In the *PQ* the role of exempla as paradigms for enabling virtue introduces the rationale for Paul's letters and structures their order. In the very first sentence of this prologue Rufinus questions why Paul would trouble to write these letters when so many examples for living are proffered in the gospels.[12] Similarly, the concern to arrange Paul's letters pedagogically

[5] For discussions of Rufinus' role in the development of Pelagianism, his authorship of the *Liber de Fide*, its date, and critical edition see Berthold Altaner, Der Liber de fide: ein Werk des Pelagianers Rufinus des 'Syrers': *Theologische Quartalschrift* 130 (1950) 432-49; François Refoulé, Datation du premier concile de Carthage contre les Pélagians et du *Libellus fidei* de Rufin: *Revue des Etudes Augustiniennes* 9 (1963) 41-49; Mary Miller (ed.), *Rufini Presbyteri Liber de Fide: A Critical Text and Translation with Introduction and Commentary* (Washington, 1964); Gerald Bonner, Rufinus the Syrian and African Pelagianism: *Augustinian Studies* 1 (1970) 30-47; Eugene TeSelle, Rufinus the Syrian, Caelestius, Pelagius: Explorations in the Pre-history of the Pelagian Controversy: *Augustinian Studies* 3 (1972) 61-95; Bryn R. Rees, *Pelagius: Life and Letters* (Rochester, N.Y., 1998), 20-25; Flavio G. Novolone and Aimé Solignac, Pélage et Pélagianisme, in: *Dictionnaire de spiritualité ascétique et mystique doctrine et histoire* (Paris, 1986), 2889-942. For the *PQ* in relation to Pelagius' thought see Gisbert Greshake, *Gnade als konkrete Freiheit: Eine Untersuchung zur Gnadenlehre des Pelagius* (Mainz, 1972), 52-3.

[6] For a discussion of ancient prolegomena see Jaap Mansfeld, *Prolegomena: Questions to be Settled before the Study of an Author, or a Text* (Leiden, 1994).

[7] Rufinus the Syrian, *Liber de fide* 38-39 (110, 112, 114 Miller).

[8] *Liber de fide* 40-43 (114, 116, 118, 120 Miller).

[9] *Liber de fide* 37-40 (108, 110, 112, 114, 116 Miller).

[10] Pelagius, *In Romanos* 5:12-6:21 (45-53 Souter).

[11] *Liber de fide* 49 (126 Miller).

[12] *Prologus* (1,1-3 Wordsworth et al.).

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to lead the reader to a more perfect faith evokes Rufinus' belief in human progress by following Jesus' perfect example.[13] The *PQ*'s call to pursue virtue and curtail sin resonates with the prominence of exempla and striving towards perfection in Rufinus' thought.

The possibility for human righteousness has far-reaching implications. Since human nature is good and humans are capable of righteousness even before the advent of Jesus, Rufinus (just like Pelagius after him) maintains that many in the OT led righteous lives; among them were Adam and Eve who after their disobedience exemplified righteousness.[14] Rufinus' belief in the goodness of human nature makes possible this positive evaluation of the righteous men and women from the OT and the prominent place of the law.[15]

The direct equation of the Decalogue with Paul's ten community letters in the *PQ* reflects this trust in the capacity for righteousness even before Christ's arrival, a view articulated more fully in Pelagian thought.[16] This prologue goes much further than reaffirming the Hebrew Bible as the Christian Old Testament: the law is supplemented, or at least fulfilled, by the gospels; the numerous examples for living offered in the gospels hark back to the perfect mandates of God later supplemented by the prophets.[17] Furthermore, Paul's teaching does not contradict the law or the Old Testament; according to the *PQ* by writing only ten letters Paul deliberately indicated that he did not oppose Moses but imitated him by writing ten letters just as Moses issued ten commandments.[18] This teaching aligns nicely with Rufinus' *Liber de Fide* wherein the Old Testament is cited as the source of the faith and a font of exemplary sinless lives[19] – a point even more fully developed in Pelagius' thought.[20] Rufinus' attempt to equate Paul's letters with the Decalogue and his concomitant inclusion of Hebrews in the Vulgate *Corpus Paulinum* as authentically Pauline illustrates the malleability of judgments regarding authenticity in early Christianity. Since Hebrews occupied a marginal status in the western canon,[21] Rufinus rehabilitates and incorporates it into Paul's corpus thus rounding out Paul's community letters at ten so as to link the OT and NT.[22]

[13] *Prologus* (3,10-12 Wordsworth et al.).
[14] *Liber de fide* 35-36 (104, 106, 108 Miller).
[15] *Liber de fide* preface, 23, 24, 25 (52, 84, 86 Miller).
[16] Pelagius, *Ad Demetriadem* 4-8 (*PL* 30 19-23).
[17] *Prologus* (1,3-2,2 Wordsworth et al.).
[18] *Prologus* (2,5-10 Wordsworth et al.).
[19] *Liber de fide* preface, 8, 35, 36, 37, 39 (52, 60, 104, 106, 108, 110, 112, 114 Miller).
[20] *Ad Demetriadem* 4-8 (*PL* 30 19-23).
[21] Although Hilary of Poitiers (d. 368) designated Hebrews as canonical in the west, afterwards Jerome still indicates that Hebrews was not unanimously accepted there; see Bruce Metzger, *The Canon of the New Testament: Its Origin, Development, and Significance* (Oxford, 1987), 159-62, 232-36. For discussion of Hebrews' authenticity and canonical status see Frede (ed.), *Epistulae ad Thessalonicenses; Pars II*, 1051-62.
[22] *Prologus* (2,3-10 Wordsworth et al.).

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Rufinus also recasts Hebrews' marginal position at the end of the corpus by utilizing a pattern of organization wherein this letter marks the culmination of Pauline thought. According to the *PQ* Paul's community letters have been arranged to demonstrate the movement from neophytic initiation in Romans to the perfection of the faith in the last tract, Hebrews.[23] This pattern represents isagogic concerns intent on narrating a move toward perfection step by step in each letter. Striving for perfection through the properly ordered reading of Paul resembles the pedagogical or psychagogical ordering patterns of Neo-platonic editions of philosophic corpora designed to raise the soul to the contemplation of the divine.[24]

Since Rufinus' positions are more fully communicated in Pelagius' thought, a few comments on their development in this trajectory are in order. In his *Epistle to Demetrias* Pelagius, like Rufinus, affirms that human nature is good, since humans have been made in God's own image and supplied with intellect and free will.[25] According to Pelagius the natural law from Rom 1-2 allowed OT luminaries from Adam to Moses to live righteous lives both before the law and Christ's incarnation.[26] Job is even the model of gospel virtue even though he lived long before Christ's advent and the gospel itself.[27] While Pelagius concedes that achieving righteousness is more possible after Christ's advent, he still maintains that righteousness was possible before the law and before Christ;[28] sin comes from habit and following the example of Adam's sin, not human nature.[29] The germ of Rufinian thought prefaced to the Vulgate revision in the *PQ* found full flower in Pelagius' concept of human nature and capacity for virtue. In contrast to Pelagius' positive valuation of the OT and faith in human capacity for virtue before Christ – views also found in Rufinus' *Liber de fide* and *PQ* – very different perspectives on the law and human righteousness emerge from other paratexts in Codex Fuldensis.

The juxtaposition of the so-called Marcionite prologues alongside the *PQ* casts into relief the interpretative role of paratextual materials. Whether or not these short summaries prefaced to most of Paul's letters in many Latin manuscripts ought to be attributed to Marcion, contrasting their view of the OT with that found in the *PQ* underscores the hermeneutical role of paratexts. Whereas the Marcionite prologues summarize Paul's letters with an overt polemic against Judaism, Jewish practice, and the law, the Vulgate prologue lauds the law and puts it on equal footing with the gospels and Paul. Not only does the *PQ* explicitly equate Paul's ten letters with the Decalogue and consistently downplay any

[23] *Prologus* (3,10-5,3 Wordsworth et al.).
[24] Mansfeld, *Prolegomena*, 58-116.
[25] *Ad Demetriadem* 2 (*PL* 30 17).
[26] *Ad Demetriadem* 4-6 (*PL* 30 19-22).
[27] *Ad Demetriadem* 6 (*PL* 30 22).
[28] *Ad Demetriadem* 8 (*PL* 30 22-23).
[29] *Ad Demetriadem* 8, 13 (*PL* 30 22-23, 27-28); cf. *In Romanos* 5:12-6:21 (45-53 Souter).

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anti-Jewish rhetoric found in the *Corpus Paulinum* itself, this prologue even begins by framing the gospel as the fulfillment of the law. Whether or not deliberately written against the Marcionite prologue, which lambasted the Galatians for turning back to the law, this description of the gospels as the fulfillment of the law and Paul's status as a second Moses stands in stark contrast with the interpretation found there.[30] This contrast between the Marcionite prologues and *PQ* exemplifies, I contend, how Codex Fuldensis represents a site of competing interpretations, where its paratextual materials of diverse background and perspective codify struggles for interpretative hegemony over the attendant *Corpus Paulinum*.

Before concluding I would like to adduce one further set of paratexts from Codex Fuldensis that communicate yet another hermeneutical perspective. Some capitula to Romans in this manuscript take a quite different interpretive stance, transmitting positions directly countering Pelagian theology.[31] In contrast to the *PQ* which fronts an interpretation aligning with Rufinus' and subsequently Pelagius' theology, these capitula highlight original sin, the need for grace and resonate with Augustinian thought.[32] I mention these capitula here briefly as further evidence for the importance of hermeneutics in the composition and deployment of paratexts in the margins of early Christian manuscripts, where they were juxtaposed alongside other (often conflicting) interpretations.

In closing the *PQ* fronts fundamental themes of Rufinus' thought; these themes structure and inform the summary of Paul's letters in the *PQ* and thus transmit an interpretive framework to the reader of the subsequent Vulgate revision. In order to convey this hermeneutic Rufinus draws on prolegomena traditions adapting them for his own hermeneutical purpose. This is most evident in the treatment of the scope and purpose of Paul's letters, where they are explicitly linked with the OT and the law. Rufinus' positive evaluation of the OT found in the *PQ* is not at all surprising and augurs its further development in Pelagius' thought. Furthermore, Rufinus' belief in the inherent goodness of humanity and possibility of achieving perfection through the extirpation of sin by emulating Christ and the patriarchs undergirds his ordering pattern designed to lead one to a life of virtue; in sum, the *PQ* recasts Paul's letters through the lens of Rufinus' theology which was further developed by Pelagius. Finally, this prologue's interpretation stands in stark contrast with that in the Marcionite prologues and some capitula found alongside it in Codex Fuldensis; this comparison of the *PQ* with the Marcionite prologues and the anti-Pelagian capitula in Romans underscores the interpretive role of paratexts. The prefacing of

[30] *Argumentum in epistulam ad Galatas* (355 Wordsworth et al.).

[31] *Capitula in epistulam ad Romanos* (45-61 Wordsworth et al.). For capitula to Paul's letters and bibliography see Frede (ed.), *Epistulae ad Thessalonicenses*, 120-31. For the anti-Pelagian tendency of these capitula see Donatien de Bruyne, Sommaires antipélagiens inédits des lettres de Saint Paul: *Revue Bénédictine* 38 (1926) 45-55.

[32] See especially *Capitulum* X (47, 49 Wordsworth et al.).

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diverse interpretations demonstrates that these prologues and capitula were far more than theologically neutral introductions to Paul's letters; they also fronted and transmitted an interpretation of the attendant corpus. Thus, the multiplicity of paratextual voices codified in Codex Fuldensis illustrates how early Christian manuscripts themselves became sites of competing interpretations for the text transmitted therein.

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Before Embarking on an Adventure: Some Preliminary Remarks on Writing the NTP Commentary on the *Gospel of Mark*

Joseph VERHEYDEN, Leuven

In planning a boat trip one does well to ask oneself three things. First, is there a boat? Second, is the necessary equipment available? And third, does one know the destination and how to get there? With regard to the project that is the topic of this paper, the first question can be answered very briefly. A boat has been prepared quite a long time ago already. It is called the 'Novum Testamentum Patristicum' (NTP). Only, for the past years it seems mainly to have been lying in the docks waiting to be repaired. Now it looks as if it has been made seaworthy again, and recently it has indeed sailed out once more and apparently under good auspices.

The second question can be answered equally briefly. Fortunately we do not have to travel blindly. There are detailed roadmaps and good guidebooks on the market. As a matter of fact, some of these are even so detailed that they sometimes become rather difficult to use and create problems of their own, as anyone who has worked through the long lists of the *Biblia Patristica* can testify. I will not go further into this issue.

The third question is far more difficult to answer, not in the least in my case. We are not just strolling around, we have a purpose and a pretty good idea of the destination, we do possess the *Gospel of Mark* and we want to explore how it was received, used, and commented upon in the Early Church, but for various reasons it appears to be less easy to get to this destination than one might think. There are a number of factors and dangers that risk to complicate the journey. My interest in this essay is in one kind of problems in particular, to find out where the treasures are hidden.

1. A first problem is to make sure that one has landed on the right shore and that treasure is to be found at all. This is not just a problem for those working on *Mark*, but it is particularly true in this case. It is true on a general level, for as a matter of fact the reception history of the *Gospel of Mark* in the Ancient Church has often also been in some way a non-history, or rather, the history of a non-reception. And it is above all true with regard to the earliest period. It is indeed a much debated and still ongoing issue whether any of the written gospels were used and commented upon in those dark ages that are the first decades of the

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second century. This is again especially so for *Mark*. *Matthew*, *Luke*, and *John* all have been studied individually for the traces they may have left throughout the second century.[1] Not so *Mark*. For a long time, the overall impression has been, and for many it still is, that his gospel was almost completely forgotten about shortly after it had been copied out by *Matthew* and by *Luke*, only to be saved from oblivion by a couple of prominent authors towards the end of that century who argued that it naturally had its place in a fourfold-gospel canon.[2] The important thing about this is that such a conclusion apparently came 'naturally' and caused no problems. Irenaeus does not appear to break new ground when including *Mark* in the quartet and he does not have to do any special pleading. It means that *Mark* had not just been languishing in a remote corner of the world. But from there to point out whether an author in these early days actually made use of the Second Gospel is often quite a step.

Let me just cite one example by way of illustration. It is an admittedly rather minor and quite complicated case. The view that the author of the so-called 'Unknown Gospel', or *Papyrus Egerton 2* (PE), was familiar with some at least of the written gospels has found quite some support among scholars, though it has by no means been accepted unanimously.[3] For Édouard Massaux, who in

[1] See the monographs by Édouard Massaux, *Influence de l'Évangile de saint Matthieu sur la littérature chrétienne avant saint Irénée* (Gembloux, 1950 = BETL 75, Leuven, 1986; Engl. Transl.: *The Influence of the Gospel of Saint Matthew on Christian Literature before Irenaeus*, New Gospel Studies 5.1-3 (Macon, 1990); Wolf-Dietrich Köhler, *Die Rezeption des Matthäusevangeliums in der Zeit vor Irenäus*, WUNT 2.24 (Tübingen, 1987); Andrew Gregory, *The Reception of Luke and Acts in the Period before Irenaeus: Looking for Luke in the Second Century*, WUNT 2.169 (Tübingen, 2003); Titus Nagel, *Die Rezeption des Johannesevangeliums im 2. Jahrhundert: Studien zur vorirenäischen Aneignung und Auslegung des vierten Evangeliums in christlicher und christlich-gnostischer Literatur*, Arbeiten zur Bibel und ihre Geschichte 2 (Leipzig, 2000); Charles E. Hill, *The Johannine Corpus in the Early Church* (Oxford, 2004).

For the Synoptic Gospels in general, but limited to the Apostolic Fathers: Helmut Koester, *Synoptische Überlieferung bei den Apostolischen Vätern*, TU 65 (Berlin, 1957); Andrew F. Gregory and Christopher M. Tuckett (eds.), *The New Testament and the Apostolic Fathers*. I. *The Reception of the New Testament in the Apostolic Fathers*; II. *Trajectories through the New Testament and the Apostolic Fathers* (Oxford, 2005).

[2] On Irenaeus and the concept of the fourfold-gospel canon, see, e.g. Graham N. Stanton, The Fourfold Gospel: *NTS* 43 (1997) 317-46; reprinted in *id.*, *Jesus and Gospel* (Cambridge, 2004), 63-91, esp. 63-8; *id.*, Jesus Traditions and Gospels in Justin Martyr and Irenaeus, in: Jean-Marie Auwers and Henk Jan de Jonge (eds.), *The Biblical Canons*, BETL 163 (Leuven, 2003), 351-68; reprinted in *Jesus and Gospel*, 92-109, esp. 105-8.

[3] For criticism, see, *e.g.*, Jon B. Daniels, *The Egerton Gospel: Its Place in Early Christianity* (unpublished diss. Claremont Graduate School, 1990), esp. 148-52: Mark and PE 'draw upon the same tradition, whether oral or written, for both authors seem to have added secondary material independently' (151); W.-D. Köhler, *Rezeption*, 451-2: dependence, if any, is indirect at best (through memory or oral tradition); John Dominic Crossan, *Four Other Gospels: Shadows on the Contours of Canon* (Minneapolis, 1985), 77-87, even argues for the opposite view and makes *Mark* 12:13-17 'directly dependent on the papyrus text' (86).

For a detailed discussion, see Frans Neirynck, Papyrus Egerton 2 and the Healing of the Leper: ETL 61 (1985) 153-60, reprinted in *id.*, *Evangelica II. 1982-1991: Collected Essays*,

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studying the reception of the *Gospel of Matthew* also duly noted traces of other New Testament writings, there can be no discussion that PE also knew *Mark*: 'L'emploi de *Mc.* ... est certain'.[4] Quite remarkably, Massaux does not focus on the evidence from Fragm. 1r (the story of the healing of a leper; see *Mark* 1:40-45 parr. *Matth./Luke*) that has raised so much polemics later on. Instead, he cites three instances from Fragm. 2r (Lührmann, 151 ll. 1-16 = Bell-Skeat ll. 43-59 = Gronewald ll. 50-66) that are all, in one way or another, somewhat problematic. Massaux rightly notes that the pericope on the Tribute to Caesar in *Mark* 12:13-17 parr. *Matth./Luke* is a most probable background for the question about what is due to royal authorities that is treated in this fragment (L ll. 6-8 = BS ll. 45-50).[5] PE has a double question, as in *Mark* 12:14 (diff. *Matth./Luke*), but for the larger part it is phrased differently and *Mark* 12:14 is not the only passage that resonates here:

PE ἐξὸν τοῖς βα(σι)λεῦσ[ιν ἀποδοῦ]ναι τὰ ἀν[ή]κοντα τῇ ἀρχῇ; ἀπ[οδῶμεν αὐ-] τοῖς ἢ μ[ή;]
Mark ἔξεστιν δοῦναι κῆνσον Καίσαρι ἢ οὔ; δῶμεν ἢ μὴ δῶμεν;

In the second question, if restored correctly,[6] the compound ἀποδίδωμι is a most natural variant that may have been inspired by ἀπόδοτε in *Mark* 12:17 (= *Matth./Luke*). However, PE does not repeat the verb in the second half. Massaux erroneously refers to the variant reading of *Mark* 12:14 in D it, but in these instances the second question is simply lacking, as is also the case in sy^{s}. While this could still be explained as a harmonisation towards, or influence from, the way the first question is formulated in *Mark* (and in *Matth./Luke*: no repetition of the verb), the differences between PE and *Mark* for the first question are more serious. In this instance, PE has not only omitted the disjunction (diff. *Mark* 12:14 parr. *Matth./Luke* ἢ οὔ), leaving only ἀποδοῦ]ναι as the sole verbal parallel to δοῦναι in *Mark* 12:14 (= *Matth./Luke*), but part of the wording of PE is closer to 2*Macc.* 14:8 (ὑπὲρ τῶν ἀνηκόντων τῷ βασιλεῖ), and maybe

BETL 99 (Leuven, 1991), 773-80 (780-3: Additional Note); see also by the same author, The Apocryphal Gospels and the Gospel of Mark, in: Jean-Marie Sevrin (ed.), *The New Testament in Early Christianity*, BETL 86 (Leuven, 1989), 123-75, esp. 161-7; reprinted in *Evangelica II*, 715-772, esp. 753-9 (and 771-2: Additional Note).

[4] *Influence*, 329.

[5] *Ibid.*, 330: 'Le canevas de tout l'épisode est celui du denier de César'. PE is cited here according to the recent edition of Dieter Lührmann, *Fragmente apokryph gewordener Evangelien in griechischer und lateinischer Sprache*, Marburger Theologische Studien 59 (Marburg, 2000), 142-53. Lührmann does no longer follow the verse numeration of the *editio princeps* by Harold Idris Bell and Theodore Cressy Skeat, *Fragments of an Unknown Gospel and Other Christian Papyri* (London, 1935), nor the one introduced by Michael Gronewald in his edition of the additional evidence for Fragm. 1r from PKöln 255: Unbekanntes Evangelium oder Evangelienharmonie (Fragment aus dem "Evangelium Egerton"): Kölner Papyri (P. Köln) 6 = Papyrologica Coloniensia 7 (Opladen, 1987), 136-45.

[6] There are some doubts about the μ of μή. Massaux notes the possibility that the last word may have been οὔ (*Influence*, 330 n. 4).

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one should also reckon with an echo of *Matth.* 17:25 (οἱ βασιλεῖς τῆς γῆς). Finally, there is the reaction of Jesus. In *Mark* he takes on the challenge and asks for a coin to illustrate his answer, but in PE he replies with a reference to *Isaiah*.[7] If PE had *Mark* 12:14 in mind, as I think it (also) had, one has to admit that the first question is formulated rather differently and that the parallel does not extend to the way Jesus is countering it. Hence the parallel with *Mark* is quite limited at best.[8]

For the first lines of Fragm. 2r, ... νόμενοι πρὸς αὐτὸν ἐξ[ετασ]τικῶς ἐπείραζον αὐτὸν λ[έγοντες (L ll. 1-2 = BS ll. 43-44),[9] Massaux cites as a parallel *Mark* 10:2 ('une question insidieuse') and also a variant reading of *Mark* 12:14 (ἐλθόντες ἤρξαντο ἐρωτᾶν αὐτὸν ἐν δόλῳ λέγοντες) and concludes: 'on peut relever le verbe πειράζω et chez *Mc.* et dans l'apocryphe'.[10] The second alternative has all the characteristics of being a later harmonisation in 'Markan' style combining into one *Mark* 12:18 (ἐπηρώτων αὐτὸν λέγοντες) – or the parallel to *Mark* 12:14 in *Luke* 20:21 (καὶ ἐπηρώτησαν αὐτὸν λέγοντες) – and the good Markan ἐν δόλῳ of 14:1. If the reading were known already to the author of PE (the oldest evidence for it is in codex W, which lacks λέγοντες), it in any case does not read πειράζω. The latter does occur in *Mark* 12:15 in the question of Jesus (τί με πειράζετε;), but this phrase is also found in the immediate parallel in *Matth.* 22:18.[11] On the other hand, if PE was influenced by the far-away parallel in *Mark* 10:2, Massaux's first suggestion, it would mean that it had in mind a very different context from the one to which it turns right after in ll. 6-8 = 45-50 (see the first case that is discussed above). If so, it should be noted that the parallel to *Mark* 10:2 in *Matth.* 19:3 – both introductory phrases – also reads πειράζω, and indeed is even closer to the text of PE than *Mark*, for it also has a participle form of λέγω. Moreover, the same πειράζω occurs once more in *Matth.* 22:35 par. *Luke* 10:25 (diff. *Mark* 12:28) to introduce a scene of opponents questioning Jesus. That PE could have introduced just one word from a different though not unrelated context than the one of *Mark* 12:13-17 is in itself not impossible and would be in line with what some have called its pastiche-like way of composing. And that this may indeed be the case is illustrated by the third instance Massaux discusses.

[7] See Joachim Gnilka, *Das Evangelium nach Markus* (Mk 8,27-16,20), EKK 2.2 (Zürich, Düsseldorf, Neukirchen-Vluyn, [5]1999), 152 n. 12: 'In der Antwort geht Jesus auch nicht auf die Frage ein, sondern zitiert Jes 29,13'.

[8] See F. Neirynck, Apocryphal Gospels, 1989, 715-72, 759: 'The formulation of the question in P. Eg. 2 is apparently influenced by Mark'.

[9] The first word is most probably to be supplemented as παραγενόμενοι (so Bell-Skeat, and Lührmann in the apparatus).

[10] *Influence*, 330.

[11] The latter is not mentioned as such by Neirynck in replying to Crossan's suggestion that Mark's πειράζειν may have come from PE (Apocryphal Gospels, 1989, 758). Likewise, it cannot be excluded that PE has combined *Mark* 12:14 and *John* 3:2 when formulating the question of the opponents (L. l. 3), but the few words on which PE and *Mark* agree are also found in *Matth.*

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This third instance, the participle ἐμβριμ[ησάμενος] (L l. 9 = BS l. 51), could of course be one more, now postponed, allusion to the Markan version of the Healing of the Leper (*Mark* 1:40-45, the verb in v. 43) that Massaux quite correctly regards as the source of the story in the latter half of Fragm. 1r.[12] But *John* also uses the same verb of Jesus in 11:33, maybe anticipating it from *Mark*'s version of the Anointing at Bethany (see 14:5, here said of some of those present), which follows right after in *John* 12:1-8. And *Matthew* adds it in the first of his two versions of *Mark*'s Healing of Blind Bartimaeus in 9:30 when introducing the motif of Jesus unsuccessfully requiring from those he has healed that they keep silent about it, the same motif that *Mark* had developed so emphatically in 1:45 where *Matthew* had left it out and of which there is no trace in PE either.[13] Thus, not only are there other occurrences of the verb in the gospels, apart from *Mark*, but maybe also the fact that *Matthew* and *John* both have moved the verb from its original context in *Mark* may have influenced PE to make a similar move.

Two short conclusions. First, if PE is to be labeled some sort of pastiche composition, it is not possible – as a matter of fact it would simply be against the very nature of the genre – to argue with absolute certainty from one (relatively clear) case that the same source text was also on the author's mind in the immediate context, especially since there are not a few differences (e.g., moving the motif of testing into the introduction diff. *Mark* 12:14). Second, if PE in Fragm. 2r is echoing the double question of *Mark* 12:14, not much is gained from it, one might say, for the reception history of *Mark* beyond the fact that an early Christian author apparently was caught or impressed by *Mark*'s vividness and emphasis in depicting the way the opponents put their question to Jesus. The double question does not seem to carry any particular theological relevance. A variant form of it is found also elsewhere in *Mark*, as well as in *Luke* (3:4 par. *Luke* 6:9). But even then it might be instructive to see how ancient authors were imbued with the biblical texts, maybe even before they were actually quoting them.

2. My second comment is of a totally different kind, indeed the very opposite of the previous one. There are destinations of which it is obvious that they contain treasure. They are standing out as rocks in the sea, clearly visible and open

[12] So also F. Neirynck, Apocryphal Gospels, 1989, 715-72, 759 ('the author retained a memory of what he had read in Mk 1,40-44'), who also refers to the phrase ἐκτείνας τὴν χεῖρα αὐτοῦ in Fragm. 2v (L 153 ll. 7-8 = BS l. 68) as further possible evidence of influence from *Mark* (759 n. 236 and 'Papyrus Egerton 2', 777-8), but the same phrase is also found in the parallel to *Mark* 1:41 in *Matth./Luke* and the additional τὴν δεξιάν in PE is missing from the gospel story.

[13] The text of P. Köln breaks off with Jesus's commandment to the leper to show himself to the priests and to perform the usual rituals (*Mark* 1:44 parr. *Matth./Luke*), but the very last words of PE, the 'Johannine' καὶ μηκέτι ἁμάρτανε (*John* 5:14), have no parallel in the Healing of the Leper.

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for all to grab them. However, this appears to be more difficult than one might have expected. There are only few such destinations that are of interest to us, and they all cause problems of various sorts. I again cite some examples.

a. Jerome's *Tractatus in Marci Evangelium* are among the very few patristic writings on the Second Gospel that have been preserved, and our oldest example of that kind. There is no reason in general to question their authenticity or the fact that Jerome ever preached or (had) published a selection of his homilies, as Vittorio Peri has argued for the *Tractatus in Psalmos*, which he claimed to be the work of Origen, adding that the case may not be different for the *Tractatus* on *Mark*.[14] But one should not forget that for a very long time the collection went under the name of John Chrysostom and was transmitted in the Latin version of his works.[15] Further, one should realise that there is manuscript evidence only for the first of the ten homilies (Morin's numbering). The others are available to us only through sixteenth-century editions of the works of Chrysostom. The edition of Venice of 1549, which was used by Germain Morin for his edition of 1897 that has been reproduced in CChr.SL (vol. 78) and most recently again in SC (vol. 494), was itself preceded by a Paris edition of 1536 that was based on a manuscript from the abbey of St Denis that apparently contained the whole collection of ten homilies (dividing them into fourteen: numbers 1-3 = Morin 1, and 4-6 = Morin 2), but that is now lost, probably already shortly after the edition was published when the abbey was plundered by the Hugenots in 1567.[16] Jean-Louis Gourdain admits that he was unable to compare the two, but trusts that the Venice edition is just a reprint of the Parisian one.[17] If he is right, it would mean that the annotator of the 1549 edition is not Erasmus, as Morin had suggested, but the Carthusian Godefroy Tilmann who is known to have annotated the Paris edition.

b. More problematic is the question of the commentary on *Mark* that once went under the name of Jerome, but has lost already long ago its status as an authentic work and most recently also as a learned commentary. It was first edited in 1516 by Erasmus who, in his own typical way, also immediately declared it to be inauthentic: *non magis sapiunt Hieronymum quam sorba ficum*. Michael

[14] Vittorio Peri, *Omelie origeniane sui Salmi*, Studi e Testi 289 (Città del Vaticano, 1980), 71 n. 31. For criticism, see Pierre Jay, Jérôme à Bethléem. Les Tractatus in Psalmos, in: *Jérôme entre l'Occident et l'Orient* (Paris, 1988), 367-80; Jean-Louis Gourdain, Jérôme exégète de la Transfiguration: *REAug* 40 (1994) 365-73, and *Jérôme. Homélies sur Marc. Texte latin de dom Germain Morin (CChr.SL 78). Introduction, traduction et notes* (SC 494) (Paris, 2005), 9-12.

[15] See Wolfgang Wenk, *Zur Sammlung der 38 Homilien des Chrysostomus Latinus*, Wiener Studien 10 (Wien, 1988).

[16] See J.-L. Gourdain, *Homélies sur Marc* (2005), 52 n. 3. The editions referred to in the text are *D. Iohannis Chrysostomi archiepiscopi Constantinopolitani opera*, 5 vols (Venetiis, 1549), II 263-71. *D. Iohannis Chrysostomi archiepiscopi Constantinopolitani opera* (Lutetia Parisiorum, 1536), II 318-27.

[17] J.-L. Gourdain, *Homélies sur Marc* (2005), 52: 'ne fait que reproduire le texte de l'édition parisienne'.

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Cahill, its most recent editor, follows Bernhard Bischoff in dating the work in the first half of the seventh century (so in his translation) or early in that century (in the edition).[18] He is more reserved than Bischoff in calling it an exponent of Irish exegetical tradition, but nevertheless characterises its author as a man 'in a position of authority and responsability'[19] – an abbott instructing an audience of non-uneducated monks – who, even though he never cites any of his sources by name, was well versed in the exegetical literature, including Gregory the Great and some lesser known authors.[20] Almost each of these assertions has now been challenged by Michael Gorman in a very severe review of Cahill's edition.[21] There is nothing that would link this commentary to an Irish milieu. Gone is the aura of the intellectual and the scholar, for the parallels that are cited in the apparatus of the edition are not close enough to be called a source.[22] And nothing argues for a seventh-century origin. The only point on which Gorman agrees is the position of the author (an abbott instructing his flock), who in his view may well have been writing in fifth-century Rome, as Morin had suggested long ago.[23] All this evidently matters a lot for interpreting the work.

c. But these are minor quarrels only compared to the immense problems that are raised by an anonymous work that is commonly referred to under the name of Victor of Antioch and that offers the largest collection of comments on *Mark* from the patristic era. Everything about this work remains a mystery: its author, date, genre, and sources, and nothing substantial seems to have been done on it since Joseph Reuss's monumental work on the catenae of 1941.[24] The work, a commentary for some (Reuss), a catena for others (Altaner[25]), is preserved in two recensions that overlap only partially. It is attributed in the manuscripts to Cyril of Alexandria (so three manuscripts of the first recension), or to Origen (five of the first recension), but most often to one Victor of Antioch (seven of

[18] Michael Cahill, *Expositio evangelii secundum Marcum*, CChr.SL 82 (Turnhout, 1997), 121*, and *The First Commentary on Mark. An Annotated Translation* (New York and Oxford, 1998), 6. See Bernhard Bischoff, Turning-Points in the History of Latin Exegesis in the Early Middle Ages, in: Martin McNamara (ed.), *Biblical Studies: The Medieval Irish Contribution*, Proceedings of the Irish Biblical Association 1 (Dublin, 1976), 73-160, here 88. The essay is the English version of Wendepunkte in der Geschichte der lateinischen Exegese im Frühmittelalter: *Sacris Erudiri* 6 (1954) 189-279.

[19] *Expositio*, 118*.

[20] *Ibid.*, 67*-78*.

[21] The Deceptive Apparatus Fontium in a Recent Edition (CChr.SL 82): *ZAC* 8 (2004) 8-22.

[22] *Ibid.*, 11-8.

[23] *Ibid.*, 20.

[24] *Matthäus-, Markus- und Johannes-Katenen nach den handschriftlichen Quellen untersucht*, Neutestamentliche Abhandlungen 18.4-5 (Münster, 1941), 118-41. Compare also Robert Devreesse, Chaînes exégétiques grecques, in: *Dictionnaire de la Bible. Supplément*, 1 (Paris, 1928), 1084-1233, here 1175-81.

[25] Berthold Altaner and Alfred Stuiber, *Patrologie: Leben, Schriften und Lehre der Kirchenväter* (Freiburg i. Br., Basel, Wien, [8]1978), 515.

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the first and ten of the second recension) of whom otherwise nothing is known and who may have been (one of) the compilator(s) of this work that is usually dated at the turn of the fifth and the sixth century. No lemmata are given in the first recension. In the second one two comments are identified as by Basil (on *Mark* 9:50) and by Theodore of Mopsuestia (13:32).[26] In addition, the names of some other fathers are cited in a number of scholia (see, e.g., at 14:3, where Origen, Apollinaris, and Theodore are mentioned). A good deal of the material is taken from Origen's commentary and Chrysostom's homilies on *Matthew* and from the collections of homilies on *Luke* by Cyril of Alexandria and Titus of Bostra.[27] The state of the text is deplorable. The work has been edited by Petrus Possinus (1672), Christian Friedrich Matthaei (1795), and John Antony Cramer (1844), but the first and third edition have been commonly disqualified as utterly useless. The one by Matthaei, while carefully done and more reliable according to Reuss, is based on only four manuscripts that were available to the editor in Moscow, three of them of the first and one of the second recension.[28] Reuss has offered a good survey of the manuscript evidence, but a critical edition is still lacking. This makes it very difficult also to reach firm conclusions on the way the 'Matthean' material has been used for compiling a catena/commentary on *Mark* or on what such a procedure implies, but it surely tells us much about the status of *Mark* and about the difficulties that follow from it in writing the reception history of this gospel.

3. I come to my third comment. If the first one was about finding out whether it is worth stopping by at all, because there are reasons to think that the author might not even have known *Mark*, and the second about the difficulties there may be in visiting 'the major centers', this third comment is about making detours and exploring lesser known places. We can be pretty sure that some treasure can be found, the authors evidently are familiar with *Mark*, but now the problem is how to identify what we are looking for, how to separate the gold from the gilded. The fact that the Synoptic Gospels often are very parallel is a blessing and a curse. It is obviously extremely interesting and important that there have been preserved several versions of the same story, but this has also complicated matters not a little, especially in the case of *Mark* which, being the shortest, also is the least distinctive and the least cited of the three.

[26] The first is from the *Asceticon*. It is identified as such only in a few manuscripts. The second lemma may have been taken from Theodore's commentary on Matthew, since it is not known that he also authored one on Mark. A number of manuscripts add a couple of other references to Theodore (on *Mark* 3:4 and 4:26-29). See R. Devreesse, Chaînes (1928), 1180, who also lists several other lemmata by other authors, but most of these are equally dubious and difficult to identify.

[27] See H. Smith, The Sources of Victor of Antioch's Commentary on Mark: *JTS* 19 (1917-18) 350-70.

[28] J. Reuss, *Katenen* (1941), 137.

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All this is of course well known, and it was indeed the last of the thirteen criteria Johann Jacob Griesbach put forward in dealing with patristic data in textual criticism, but which also apply for those working on the commentators themselves.[29] On the other hand, and looking upon things from the positive side, it is only by making this kind of detours that one is likely to make some of the more interesting discoveries.

When browsing through the source apparatus of critical editions one will often find references of the type, 'See *Matth.* 26:39. *Mark* 14:35. *Luke* 22:41', which all three refer to the same parallel verse in the gospels. The verse may be identical in all three, but more often than not we have to do with only a more or less closely parallel text. One should take care to establish the precise status of the reference. It may be just a general way of referencing by the editor, or it may represent a conflated citation, and if so, this may or may not have been done on purpose. It is a matter then of unearthing the distinctively Markan features, and to see whether they really have any significance for the argument of the author.

To give just one example, out of a million others, one that admittedly yields a rather negative result only: Sermo 153 of Caesarius of Arles,[30] which in part is a mere copy of Augustine's sermo 85 on the Rich Young Man, opens with a citation from 'the gospel' (*Dum evangelium legeretur ... audivimus dominum dicentem: si vis venire ad vitam, serva mandata*). In the apparatus of the CChr. SL edition it is correctly indicated that the citation is from *Matth.* 19:17, more precisely of v. 17b, a verse that has no parallel in *Mark* or *Luke*.[31] A few lines later Caesarius cites from the same context: *si vis perfectus esse, unum tibi deest: vende omnia*, etc. This citation is identified as 'ex Matth. 19,21 et Marc. 10,21', which again is correct, for the opening words are from *Matthew*, but *unum tibi deest* comes from *Mark*. There follow three more citations. The first one is again correctly identified by the editor as being from *Matth.* 19:18-19 (note the absence of an equivalent to *Mark*'s μὴ ἀποστερήσῃς and the phrase *diliges proximum tuum tamquam te ipsum* that is missing from *Mark* and *Luke*). The second one (*quam difficile est qui divitias habent, ut intrent in regnum caelorum*) is marked as 'ex Marc. 10,23 et Matth. 19,23'. The citation as a whole is closer indeed to *Mark* than to *Matth.*,[32] except for the sole 'reign of heavens', but *Mark* is here identical to *Luke* 18:24 (apart from the latter's *intrabunt* for

[29] See *Curae historiam textus Graeci epistolarum Paulinarum* (Jena, 1777), 25-8. On the whole issue of identifying biblical citations for text-critical purposes, see, a.o., Carroll D. Osburn, Methodology in Identifying Patristic Citations in NT Textual Criticism: *NT* 47 (2005) 313-43, 314f. (on Griesbach).

[30] Edited by Germain Morin in 1897 and reprinted in CChr.SL 103, 626-7.

[31] The Vulgate of v. 17b has a slightly different reading: *si autem vis ad vitam ingredi serva mandata.*

[32] See Vulgate *Mark* 10:23: *quam difficile qui pecunias habent in regnum Dei introibunt*; *Matth.* 19:23: *amen dico vobis quia dives difficile intrabit in regnum caelorum.*

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introibunt). The final citation (*si ita est, quisquam potest salvus fieri?*) is identified merely as 'Matth. 19,25' (Vulgate, *qui ergo poterit salvus esse*), but it seems the text is again closer to *Mark* (Vulgate *Mark* 10:26, *et quis potest salvus fieri*), which in turn is identical to *Luke* 18:26. The *Ancient Christian Commentary on Scripture* identifies the last two citations as 'Mt 19:22-23; Mk 10:22-23' and 'Mt 19:25; Mk 10:26; Lk 18:26' and cites that part of Sermo 153.2 at *Mark* 10:23-31.[33] But these almost random references hardly make it into a homily on *Mark*, and Caesarius does not seem to give any particular attention to the very few features that are peculiar to the Second Gospel.

4. Fourth and last comment. The more experienced traveller will always keep an open eye for the unexpected and for new discoveries, and will probably not be scared away from leaving the main paths, even at the risk of getting lost. The more adventurously minded, moreover, will probably even dare radically to go beyond the horizons and into the unknown. Some of these initiatives may prove to be most rewarding, and again this can be applied also to *Mark* when looking for traces of patristic material beyond the usual borders that are set to this era.

a. Whether or not Venerable Bede is still mentioned in a survey of patristic literature, be it as an Epilogue, as in Charles Kannengiesser's recent *Handbook*,[34] his homilies and commentaries are generally recognised to be profoundly marked by his familiarity with the patristic tradition. It is not that Bede offers a direct access to patristic texts that have not otherwise been preserved, but rather that he intentionally follows in the footsteps of the Fathers. This is most clearly the case in the *Homilies on the Gospels* which L.T. Martin has characterised as some sort of complement to the set of fourty homilies of Gregory the Great: 'Bede perhaps deliberately chose to compose his *Homilies* only on texts that Gregory had not treated'.[35] And it is not only about content, but also about form. The *Expositiones* on Luke (probably to be dated around 710) and on *Mark* (written between 715 and 730), that were published with an interval of at least one and maybe two decades, follow the same pattern of inserted citations in the margins, a pattern which Kannengiesser thinks was 'imposed on him by patristic authorities themselves'.[36] With Bede has begun the early reception history of the Fathers, while at the same time patristic exegesis is continued. He simply cannot be ignored in writing the NTP volume on *Mark*. The latter is true also for authors of an even later period.

[33] Thomas C. Oden and Christoph A. Hall (eds.), *Ancient Christian Comentary on Scripture. New Testament*. II. *Mark* (Chicago and London, 1998), 145.

[34] *Handbook of Patristic Exegesis. The Bible in Ancient Christianity* (Leiden and Boston, 2004), II, 1475-95.

[35] Cited with approval by Ch. Kannengiesser, *Handbook*, 1484, from the author's Introduction to the English translation of the *Homilies*.

[36] *Ibid.* 1491.

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b. In the middle of the ninth century, e.g., Isho'dad of Merv authored commentaries on all four of the gospels that contain a good number of citations from the Fathers, several of them, though not all, members of the Nestorian church, and from works that have largely been lost but for what has been preserved by Isho'dad.[37] His work has been called a 'gold-mine' for recovering the original Syriac text of Ephrem's commentary.[38] And the same epitheton could be used for what he has preserved of 'the Interpreter', i.e., Theodore of Mopsuestia. As one can expect, the commentary on *Mark* is the shortest of the four. It is not a detailed verse-by-verse explanation – the whole chapter six of *Mark* is rushed through in two pages –, but it contains some interesting information, the source of which is not always any longer traceable to us. Thus, Isho'dad does not say where he got the tradition he cites in the prologue that John Mark actually was the son Peter had with Mary and the brother of Rhoda (*Acts* 12:12).[39] Likewise, we do not know the origins of the story about how the daughter of Herodias was drawn while dancing on a frozen lake, a story Isho'dad tells at length in commenting upon *Matth.* 14:3-12 and recalls once more at *Mark* 6:17-29 and that was studied in some detail by J. Rendell Harris.[40] From the same chapter six of Mark Harris also drew attention to the way Isho'dad comments upon and removes the contrast between *Matthew* and *Mark* on whether or not the disciples are allowed to take a staff with them on their journeys (*Mark* 6:8 par. *Matth.* 10:9). According to Isho'dad, *Matthew* does not forbid what *Mark* allowed, but has Jesus warn the disciples not to accept anything from strangers while on their way, while *Mark* was merely listing what they could take with them from their own belongings, to which Isho'dad then adds the opinion of 'others' that *Matthew's* obsession with avoiding all sorts of covetousness is what one might expect from a former publican. Alternatively, Isho'dad also points to yet another opinion that traces the difference back to a mere mistake or confusion in the Syriac between the words 'except' and 'not even'. The former explanation Harris enthusiastically called a 'piece of exegetical subtlety' and 'a perversely ingenious remark'.[41] The identity of 'the others' is lost on us, but elsewhere Isho'dad duly mentions his source. It is from 'the Interpreter' himself that he takes over the information that Herodias and her daughter had the same name, thereby offering further witness for the reading αὐτοῦ in *Mark* 6:22 (τῆς θυγατρὸς αὐτοῦ Ἡρῳδιάδος).[42] From Isho'dad there

[37] See Mary Dunlop Gibson, *The Commentaries of Isho'dad of Merv Bishop of Hadatha (c. 850 A.D.) in Syriac and English.* I. *Translation.* II. *Matthew and Mark in Syriac* (Cambridge, 1911), I 123-45 and II 204-38.

[38] See J. Rendell Harris in the Introduction to Gibson's English translation (I, xvi).

[39] The information was cited once again most recently by Martin Hengel, *Der unterschätzte Petrus: Zwei Studien* (Tübingen, 2006), 215f.

[40] M.D. Gibson, *Commentaries* (1911), I xix-xx, and 61 and 133.

[41] *Ibid.* xxiii.

[42] *Ibid.* xxvi.

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are direct lines to the great commentaries of Dionysius Bar Salibi and into the *Gannat Busame*.

c. I add one last example of a yet more recent date. Reuss had concluded his survey of the gospel catenae with two short chapters on Theophylact and Euthymius Zigabenus.[43] The few comments in the latter's commentary on *Mark* that go beyond the usual cross-references to the parallels in *Matthew* are dismissed by Reuss as 'Eigengut des Zigabenus'.[44] But for Theophylact he refers to two excerpts from the comments on *Mark* 6:1-3 and 9:2-8[45] to illustrate how this author, while seemingly reproducing Victor of Antioch's catena, has also incorporated some material that is not found there and that most probably stems from earlier tradition: 'Quelle ist vielmehr ein Scholion ... in einer Hs, die den sog. Mk-Kommentar des Viktor von Antiochien mit einer Zahl von Erweiterungen enthält, die sich in den anderen Textzeugen nicht finden'.[46]

5. But it is time to conclude this journey, or rather, this first and still very selective outline of possible trajectories to be taken when really setting sail. I hope to have shown that I am fully aware of some of the dangers and challenges that lie before us in recovering what the Fathers had to say about our 'Second Gospel'. I also hope to have made the reader realise that this is not going to be a straightforward journey. We are not on a lineboat, but rather on a cruise or roundtrip, stopping by at various shores and collecting items and bits and pieces of what was left behind long ago. I have been told this way of travelling can be most enjoyable as well. I tend to believe this, for now at least.

[43] *Katenen* (1941), 221-37 and 238-43.

[44] *Ibid.* 242.

[45] In the first one those criticising Jesus in v. 3 are said to do so out of envy: τοσοῦτόν ἐστι κακὸν ὁ φθόνος. For 9:4-7 an allegorical interpretation is added to what is found in Victor.

[46] *Ibid.* 234.

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Flying with Fleshy Wings: Ps.-Basil's Demonology in the Exegesis of *Isaiah* 2:20

Enrica RUARO, Caprauna

The aim of this paper is to demonstrate that in early Christianity the kinship between bats and demons, far from being a commonplace, was a precious key used to explore and represent the true nature of demons. In order to achieve this task I will present and analyze an exemplary text, Ps.-Basil's[1] commentary on the verses of *Isaiah* 2:20: Τῇ γὰρ ἡμέρᾳ ἐκείνῃ ἐκβαλεῖ ἄνθρωπος τὰ βδελύγματα αὐτοῦ τὰ ἀργυρᾶ καὶ τὰ χρυσᾶ, ἃ ἐποίησαν προσκυνεῖν τοῖς ματαίοις καὶ ταῖς νυκτερίσι ('On that day a man shall cast out his abominations of silver and his abomination of gold, which they made to bow down to the vanities and the bats').[2]

These verses were the subject of the commentary of many Fathers and each of them metaphorically identifies bats with demons, even if on different grounds. Ps.-Basil's commentary is one of the most complete and interesting, for he tries to match every characteristic of demons with a biological or ethological characteristic of bats:

Ταῖς δὲ νυκτερίσι προσκυνεῖ ὁ τὴν τῶν δαιμόνων δύναμιν συγγενῆ οὖσαν τῷ σκότει θεοποιῶν. Ἡ γὰρ νυκτερὶς ζῷόν ἐστι νυκτὶ φίλον καὶ σκότει ἐνδιαιτώμενον, αὐγὴν ἡλίου μὴ φέρον, ἐν ἐρημίαις φιλοχωροῦν. Τί δὲ οἱ δαίμονες; Οὐ τοιοῦτοι; ἐρημοποιοί, τὸ φῶς ἀποφεύγοντες τὸ ἀληθινόν, τὸ τοῦ κόσμου παντός; – Ἡ νυκτερὶς καὶ πτηνόν ἐστι καὶ οὐκ ἐπτέρωται, ἀλλ' ὑμένι σαρκίνῳ διαπέταται τὸν ἀέρα. Τοιοῦτοι καὶ οἱ δαίμονες· ἀσώματοι μέν εἰσιν, οὐκ ἐπτέρωνται

[1] A recent English translation of the commentary by Nikolai Lipatov (*St. Basil the Great: Commentary on the Prophet Isaiah*. Transl. by Nikolai Lipatov, Texts and Studies in the History of Theology 9, Mandelbachtal and Cambridge, 2001) contends that the work is that of Basil, although the debate is not closed on the question of authorship.

[2] This text is Ps.-Basil's own quotation of the Bible. The Hebrew text seems to bear two interpretations, syntactically equal: 'In that day, men shall cast away their idols of silver, and their idols of gold, which have been made for themselves *to worship, to the moles and to the bats*' or 'In that day, men shall cast away their idols of silver, and their idols of gold, which have been made *for themselves to worship the moles and the bats*'. Modern versions of the Bible, such as King James's, favour the second interpretation. Ps.-Basil's quotation of the Bible is very likely based on the *Septuaginta* (γὰρ ἡμέρᾳ ἐκείνῃ ἐκβαλεῖ ἄνθρωπος τὰ βδελύγματα αὐτοῦ τὰ ἀργυρᾶ καὶ τὰ χρυσᾶ, ἃ ἐποίησαν προσκυνεῖν, τοῖς ματαίοις καὶ ταῖς νυκτερίσιν), but he reads the text as if the bats and the vanities were objects of worship. Another textual problem is the Hebrew word *haparparôt* that some Fathers translate as 'vanities' and some others (like Jerome) as 'moles'.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 157-162.
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δὲ τῷ θείῳ πόθῳ, ἀλλ' οἱονεὶ ἀπεσαρκώθησαν, ταῖς τῶν ὑλικῶν ἐπιθυμίαις προστετηκότες. Ἡ νυκτερὶς καὶ πτηνόν ἐστι καὶ τετράπουν, ἀλλ' οὔτε τοῖς ποσὶν ἀσφαλῶς ἐστήρικται, οὔτε τὴν πτῆσιν βεβαίαν ἔχει. Τοιοῦτοι δὲ καὶ οἱ δαίμονες· οὔτε Ἄγγελοί εἰσιν, οὔτε ἄνθρωποι· τῶν μὲν τὴν ἀξίαν ἀπολέσαντες, τῶν δὲ τὴν φύσιν μὴ ἔχοντες. Καὶ ὀδόντας ἔχουσιν, ὅπερ οὐκ ἔχουσιν ὄρνιθες· ἀμυντικοὶ δὲ καὶ οἱ δαίμονες, ὅπερ οὐ ποιοῦσιν Ἄγγελοι. Ἀλλὰ καὶ οὐκ ὠοτοκοῦσιν, ὥσπερ οἱ ὄρνιθες· ἀλλ' εὐθὺς ζῶα τίκτουσι. Τοιοῦτοι δὲ καὶ οἱ δαίμονες· εὐθὺς καὶ σὺν πολλῷ τῷ τάχει τελεσιουργοῦντες τὴν πονηρίαν. Ὥστε οἱ δαίμοσι προσκυνοῦντες, νυκτερίσι τροπικῶς εἴρηνται προσκυνεῖν.[3]

The first link[4] between bats and demons, which recurs in many other commentary, is related to the connection of both of them with the dominion of dark with all its traditional negative implications: bats in antiquity were considered to be night creatures par excellence, as the Greek term νυκτερίς, derived from νύξ (night) testifies, and were viewed as chthonic animals, bound to caves[5] and unable of bearing sunlight;[6] the connection between demons and the dark is quite commonsensical: the light represents the positive pole of being, the good, the truth and even Christ[7] himself, therefore dark represents the negative pole of being, evil, error and consequently demons, who were called by Paul 'lords of the all darkness'.[8]

The second link is the love for deserted, abandoned places: this is indeed a minor theme in the bat's imagery, since we can only find it briefly mentioned in Artemidorus;[9] reasonably Ps.-Basil is referring to the bats' habit of nesting

[3] 'He bows down to the bats, who deifies the power of demons which is akin to darkness. The bat is an animal loving night and dwelling in darkness, which does not bear the light of sun and is fond of desolate places. What are demons then? Are they not such as these, maker of desolation, fugitives from *the true light, which is for the whole word?* The bat is indeed winged, yet it is not furnished with feathers, but flies through the air by means of a fleshy membrane. Such are demons as well they are incorporeal, still they are not winged with the divine longing, but have as it were become fleshy, having clung to the lusts of material things. The bat is both a winged creature and a quadruped, but it neither stands steady on his feet, nor has a firm flight. Such are also the demons: they are neither angels, nor humans; they have lost the rank of the former, whilst they do not have the nature of the latter. Now, bats have teeth, something that birds do not have. Demons are also vengeful, something that angels are not. The bats also do not lay eggs as birds do, but they bring forth their young alive straightaway. Such are demons too: accomplishing evil straightaway and with a great swiftness. And so those who bow down to demons are figuratively said to bow down to the bats.' This translation is from *St. Basil the Great: Commentary on the Prophet Isaiah*. Transl. by Nikolai Lipatov (2001), 110.

[4] I will omit the last two comparisons, referring to teeth and the manner of giving birth, as they do not seem to offer any substantial contribute to the construction of the bat/demon specular image.

[5] Homerus, *Od.* XIV 1-6.

[6] Aristoteles, *Met.* II 993a 9-11.

[7] *John* 1:9-10.

[8] *Eph.* 6:10-2.

[9] *Onirocrit.* III 65.

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in uninhabited buildings or colonizing abandoned cities, even if it is not unlikely that actual deserts were the favored habitat for bats.

Ἐρήμωσις[10] refers to the destiny of those cities that were practising idolatrous cults: God punished them with devastation and they become the desolate domicile of wild animals (for example jackals, ostrich, owls, serpents, raven etc.) and of scary creatures in-between animals and demons, such as the *se'irim*[11]. The actual desert is in fact the natural abode of demons (Christ's temptation took place precisely there) and it is the place in which they used to tempt monks: they consider it their home so much so that in the *Vita Antonii* they are pictured as saying to the annoying monk that dares to disturb them: *Recede a loco nostro. Quid tibi et deserto?*[12]

Ἐρημοποιοί can even be meant in a moral sense: demons want to lay waste to human souls, tear them apart from God, rob them of their virtues, throw them into solitude: soul desertification is spiritual death.[13]

But the more original and interesting contribution by Ps.-Basil is found in the third link, an articulate comparison that is meant to illustrate the ambiguous status of demons: bats fly, not with feathered wings but with fleshy wings; so demons are incorporeal, but they do not put on their wings in longing for the Lord, rather they are melted with desires of material things and therefore they are almost covered by flesh.

Metaphorically speaking, possessing wings and being able to fly is equivalent to being an immaterial spirit (the idea that a spiritual being, *e.g.* the souls, must be winged seems to be an anthropological constant that was widely represented in all antiquity[14] and spread even among the Fathers, as it appears clearly from the famous assertion of Tertullian: *Omnis spiritus ales est. Hoc angeli et daemones.*[15] The word ἀσώματοι (incorporeal), referring to demons, leads us to the controversy about the body of demons: some Fathers (Origen[16], Tatian[17]) state that demons do have a body of some sort (composed of foul and heavy air, or fire), even if not a human body; and they differ from angels both in *physis* and *prohairesis*, *i.e.* from an ontological and a moral point of view; others[18] state that demons are pure spirits like angels, even if they differ by moral choice. This last idea, with the seal of Thomas Aquinas's authority,[19] was going to become the Church's official point of view on this subject, but

[10] See *PGL*, *s.v.* ἐρήμωσις
[11] *Lev.* 17:7; *Is.* 13:21; 34:14.
[12] *V. A.* 13.2.
[13] *Enarr. in Is.* I 19-20.
[14] Georg Weicker, *Der Seelenvogel in der Alten Litteratur und Kunst* (Leipzig, 1902).
[15] *Apol.* XXII 8.
[16] *C. Cels.* II 37.
[17] *De Orat.* 15.
[18] *Hom. Clem.* 9. 10.
[19] *Pot.* 6. 6-7.

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the thought that demons have a sort of body would endure for many centuries: in the eleventh century A.D. Michael Psellus in his *De operatione demonum* still states that while angels have a spiritual body without matter, demons have a body that is in a certain way, material, pathetic and obscure.[20] Ps.-Basil (who is quoted by Psellus as his principal source) shares this opinion, as becomes clear in another passage of his commentary[21] in which he states that demons do have a body, made of air, or fire or both these substances, and that they 'feed' this 'body' with the bloody smoke rising from sacrifices to pagan gods (who actually are demons in disguise). An echo of this last belief is even heard in our passage, because the term προστετηκότες, 'melted', 'consumed' with material pleasures, is the same term that Athenagoras used in his *Legatio pro Christianis*[22] to describe the bustle of demons about idol's blood: this word, which derives from τέκω, 'to rot', is connected with the idea of decay and putrefaction, and recalls the worst phenomena of the matter. Besides Ps.-Basil believes that demons are pathetic[23], *i.e.* they feel passions and desires like humans: using the verb ἀποσαρκόομαι, 'to be covered by flesh', he even seems to suggest that the final goal of every demon is basically a kind of blasphemous incarnation (it is noteworthy that the aforementioned verb is most often used to define Christ's incarnation).[24] In fact, as the evil souls of Plato's *Phaedo* wander around until they find a new body, demons, according to some Fathers,[25] in their quest for pleasures, may go searching for a human body to possess in order to enjoy the body's delights in a better way.

In Ps.-Basil's statement that demons do not put on their wings longing (πόθῳ) for the Lord, but that they are melted with desires (ἐπιθυμίαις) for material things, the influence of the Platonic image of 'wings of the soul' can be clearly seen:[26] if feathered wings represent the good desire that elevates the soul towards a higher spiritual status, flashy wings can quite properly represent the bad desire towards base objects that lowers the spirit down to the matter.

Even the opposition between πόθος and ἐπιθυμία is Platonic: the πόθος that the demons should have for God is the same πόθος that in the *Phaedrus*[27] defines the nostalgic desire of the souls for their first lives in the land beyond

[20] *De op. daem.* 7.
[21] *Enarr. in Is.* X 237.
[22] *Leg.* XXVI 1.
[23] *Enarr. in Is.* I 25
[24] See *PGL*, *s.v.* ἀποσαρκόομαι.
[25] *Hom. Clem.* 9, 10.
[26] For the fortune of this image among Neo-Platonist philosophers and Fathers of the Church see Pierre Courcelle, Tradition néo-platonicienne et tradition chrétienne des ailes de l'âme, in: *Atti del convegno internazionale sul tema: Plotino ed il neoplatonismo in Oriente ed in Occidente*, Roma, 5-9 *Ottobre 1970* (Roma, 1974), 266-325.
[27] *Phaed.* 253e; 252a; 251e.

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earth; and demons' ἐπιθυμίαι are the same ἐπιθυμίαι that identify the low desires for corporeal pleasures in the *Phaedo*.[28]

The fourth link between bats and demons is a natural outcome of the third: both bats and demons are described as in-between creatures: bats are in between birds and quadrupeds as demons are in between angels and humans.

The bat's middle nature was a widely known theme in antiquity, from Aesopus's tale of the bat and the weasel[29], to the riddle of the bat in the Platonic *Republic*[30], to the accurate scientific portrait of Aristotle:[31] apart from Aesopus (in which the double nature is a blessed sign of the virtue of μῆτις 'wiseness'), this middle nature is always spoken of as a defective status, a sum of two negations (nor... neither); Ps.-Basil firmly adheres to this way of thinking: bats can't walk firmly and fast and like quadrupeds, nor do they have the wide secure flight of the birds.

The intermediary nature of demons was a well known issue as well: it very likely started with Plato (the *locus classicus* is *Symp.* 202e 9) and it was upheld and elaborated upon by Apuleius[32] and Plutarchus[33] among others; this idea persisted even in Christian thought, as for example Lactantius testifies: *Qui autem sunt ex his procreati, quia neque angeli, neque homines fuerunt, sed mediam quamdam naturam gerentes ...*[34]

Angels are compared to birds because birds possess a natural and thorough capacity to flight with proper feathered wings, in the same way that angels are truly and purely immaterial; demons are compared to bats because bats are a monstrous kind of birds, with an uncertain flight and a repulsive, fleshy type of wings, in the same way that demons are a sort of decayed, genetically mutated species of angels.

A strong connection between moral choices and ontological status prevents demons from being considered as pure spirits: their moral deficiencies and their corporeal desires cry for a material element in their physical nature. In spite of the doctrines of the creation, of the incarnation and of the resurrection, which firmly state the substantial goodness of the body and matter, these last elements are still looked at as suspicious and insidious by some Fathers, since they seem incapable of conceiving a fully spiritual evil creature: if there is evil, matter must be involved.

Possibly, behind this attitude there could be a misread Platonism (as the large use of Platonic imagery in our passage might suggest) or, more precisely, the

[28] *Phaed.* 82c; 82e; 83e.
[29] *Fab.* 252 (Chambry).
[30] *Resp.* V, 478 c.
[31] *Part. an.* 697b, 1-9.
[32] *De deo Socratis* 6.
[33] *De defect. orac.* 10.
[34] *Div. Instit.* II 15.

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influence of the more pessimistic tendencies towards the body and matter that could be found in Middle Platonic and Neoplatonic philosophy.

In conclusion Ps.-Basil, through the comparison with bats gave us an inventive and fecund representation of demons' nature: moreover, his portrait of these bat-like demons not only enriches the theological and philosophical debate, but gives us also an indication about the author's attitudes towards the body and the bodily, attitudes that were shared by many other Fathers.

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Making Ends Meet: Variable Uses of the Psalm Title *Unto the End* (εἰς τὸ τέλος) in Greek Patristic Commentators on the Psalter

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Through the centuries, scores of Christian readers and singers of the Psalter have casually passed over the superscriptions of the Psalms, perhaps only noticing the attribution here and there to David, Asaph, or another, or else the strange name of a long-lost Hebrew tune, or the brief directives for musicians. As is well known to scholars of the Hebrew Bible and historians of biblical interpretation, however, in the Septuagint's translation of many of the titles of the Hebrew Psalms, there is what some, historically, have deemed a brazen permutation, others an imaginative rereading, of the original inscriptions. What were once designated as instructions to choirmaster and musicians in Israel's ancient liturgy are now thoroughly recast as the dedications of victory hymns to Christ (the 'spiritual' David) and the saints, or as signposts to salvation-historical and eschatological realities rooted prophetically in the Psalter.

The changes have undoubtedly aggravated not a few modern historical-critical interpreters of the Psalms. A cursory review of some of the major studies and commentaries of the last half-century reveals that the LXX translations of the Psalms titles are either entirely ignored or held in contempt for misconstruing the *hebraica veritas*.[1] The nineteenth-century British translator of the Septuagint, Sir Lancelot Brenton, was himself apparently embarrassed or disturbed by the quirkiness of the LXX titles, so he pressed still to find a musical-notational spin for some of them. Psalm 44's title – 'Unto the end, for those who shall be changed (τοῖς ἀλλοιωθησομένοις), for the sons of Korah...' – he innovatively translates 'For the end, for *alternate strains* by the sons of Core...'[2]

Be that as it may, the differences between the Hebrew and Greek versions of the titles hardly went unnoticed to patristic exegetes, the vast majority of whom,

[1] See e.g. Hermann Gunkel, *Introduction to the Psalms: The Genres of the Religious Lyric of Israel*, transl. James Nogalski (Macon, GA, 1998 [orig. German ed., 1933]), 349-51; Sigmund Mowinckel, *The Psalms in Israel's Worship*, transl. D.R. Ap-Thomas (New York and Nashville, 1967), vol. 2, 207-13; Artur Weiser, *The Psalms: A Commentary* (Philadelphia, 1962), 21-3; Hans-Joachim Kraus, *Psalms 1-59: A Commentary*, transl. Hilton Oswald (Minneapolis, 1988), 29. Kraus calls the LXX's translation of למנצח into εἰς τὸ τέλος 'completely enigmatic'.

[2] Brenton gives the same translation for the titles to *Pss.* 68 and 79.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 163-175.
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from Origen and Eusebius to the Cappadocian Fathers, from Jerome[3] and Augustine to Maximus the Confessor, embraced the inspired character of these permutations and extrapolated from them accordingly. Granted there were a few skeptics along the way. Theodore of Mopsuestia considered the Greek versions of the Psalm inscriptions, with few exceptions, as baseless and outright misleading.[4] His teacher Diodore of Tarsus judged them on their individual merits but likewise cautioned overzealous Christian interpreters of them.[5] Theodoret of Cyrus, as Robert Hill emphasizes in his recently published translation of the bishop's *Commentary on the Psalms*, thoroughly respected the Psalms titles in Greek but acutely felt the awkwardness of their detachment from the original Hebrew and strained to negotiate a historical referent for many of them.[6]

As Gregory of Nyssa specifically notes in his treatise *On the Inscriptions of the Psalms*, the most common title is the (usually opening) phrase 'Unto the end' (εἰς τὸ τέλος), which appears in 55 Psalms in the LXX, either by itself or as introducing a longer title.[7] Here the Greek translators were working with the Hebrew participial construction *lamnasseah*, which is usually translated 'to the director (or choirmaster)', though Sigmund Mowinkel has forcefully disputed this translation and argued that the Hebrew here would better be rendered 'To dispose (Yahweh) to mercy', or simply, 'for homage (to Yahweh)'.[8] The LXX translators, perhaps already in the interest of exploiting potential eschatological dimensions of the Psalms, as Martin Rösel has recently argued,[9] instead concentrated on the Hebrew noun *nesah* ('eternity' or 'perpetuity'): hence the translation εἰς τὸ τέλος. Most of the Greek patristic commentators, beginning with Origen and Eusebius, thoroughly enhance this *teleological* recasting of the Psalm title by recalling the alternative Greek translations as well: Aquila: 'to the author of victory' (τῷ νικοποιῷ); Symmachus: 'victorious' (ἐπινίκιος); and Theodotion: 'to victory' (εἰς τὸ νῖκος).[10] Added to these are

[3] E.g., see Jerome's vigorous defense of the titles in *Tract. in Ps.* 5.

[4] See his *Comm. in Ps.*, ed. Robert Devreesse, *Le commentaire de Théodore de Mopsueste sur les Psaumes* (Vatican City, 1939), 334, lines 27-29. See also the comments of J.-M. Olivier, Introduction to *Diodori Tarsensis Commentarii in Psalmos*, CChr.SG 6 (Turnhout, 1980), lxxxviii.

[5] See J.-M. Olivier, Introduction to *Diodori Tarsensis* (1980), lxxxviii-xc; also below and notes 27, 46, 47.

[6] See Robert C. Hill, ed. and transl., *Theodoret of Cyrus: Commentary on the Psalms*, 2 vols., FOTC 101-102 (Washington, 2000-1), vol. 1, 63, note 1; and notes *passim*.

[7] Greg. Nys., *Inscr. Psalm.*, II 2 (GNO V 72-3), transl. Ronald Heine, *Gregory of Nyssa's Treatise on the Inscriptions of the Psalms* (Oxford, 1995), 127.

[8] Mowinckel (1967, vol. 2, 212) notes how some targumic renderings have simply 'for praise'.

[9] Der griechische Bibelkanon und seine Theologie, in: Niels Peter Lemche, Troels Engberg-Pedersen and Henrik Tronier (eds.), *Kanon: bibelens tilblivelse og normative status: festskrift til Mogens Müller* (Copenhagen, 2006), 70; *id.*, Die Psalmüberschriften des Septuagintapsalters, in: Erich Zenger (ed.), *Der Septuaginta-Psalter: Sprachliche und theologische Aspekte* (Freiburg i. Br., 2001), 125-48.

[10] See beginning with *Ps.* 4:1 in *Origenis Hexapla*, ed. Frederick Field (reprint ed., Hildesheim: Georg Olm, 1964), II 90; et al. For early references, see e.g., Orig., *Sel. in Ps.* 4 (PG 12,

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the often elusive but exegetically enticing extensions of titles 'Unto the end' which provided the textual chemistry destined to fire the imaginations of five centuries of patristic exegetes. Gregory of Nyssa calls these extensions 'suggestions and advice related to [spiritual] victory, by means of which that which is eagerly desired might be attained.'[11]

Origen was the first Christian exegete to notice (in his *Commentary on Romans*, no less), that the title 'Unto the end', and other titles for that matter, do not always connect historically or thematically with the content of the Psalms they introduce. In this case it may well require allegorical interpretation to decipher the connection. One example Origen cites is the great penitential Psalm 50 (51), inscribed 'Unto the end, a psalm for David, when Nathan the prophet approached him for having gone into Bathsheba'. At first sight it is puzzling why Origen suggests that the title does not fit this Psalm, since its rueful verses are thoroughly in line with David's contrition over his adultery. But Origen sees this Psalm as much more concerned with the vindication of God as judge of the nations and their religious sects. In this case, Bathsheba in the title may very well serve as a symbol of the foreign sects, either of those that will betray God in the manner of a seductress, or those that will ultimately serve the God of Israel in the manner of the astute foreign wives of Solomon the wise.[12] What is striking is that a Psalm title can thereupon assume a whole life of its own, and occasionally does so in the spiritual interpretation of the Psalter.

Eusebius, however, indicates that a Psalm title normally indicates the subject matter (ὑπόθεσις) of the Psalm,[13] and Gregory of Nyssa likewise says that the Psalms titles in the LXX typically function either to introduce the Psalms they denominate or else to point beyond them to a higher moral or spiritual instruction.[14] This is true *a fortiori* of Psalms inscribed 'Unto the end' (εἰς τὸ τέλος). Rarely do patristic exegetes ignore this phrase simply as generic or inconsequential, although Hippolytus, interestingly, completely overlooks it in his long discussion of the Psalms titles in a recovered homily.[15] In the patristic commentaries I have studied, I find the phrase 'Unto the end' operating three basic ways: either (1) in a *prophetic / typological function*, as pointing to 'ends' adumbrated in the events or persons represented by the Psalm in question, viz.,

1132D-33C); Orig., *Hom. in Ps.* 38.1 (SC 411, 334,10-22); Euseb., *Comm. in Ps.* 4 (PG 23, 101A-C); Ps.-Athanasius, *Expos. in Ps.* 4 (PG 27, 72B-C); Theod., *Comm. in Ps.* 4 (PG 80, 888C).

[11] *Inscr. Psalm.* II 2 (GNO V 73-4), transl. R. Heine (1995), 128.

[12] Orig., *Comm. in Rom.* 2.14 (PG 14, 920-2).

[13] See e.g. his *Comm. in Ps.* 21 (PG 23, 201C); cf. Ps.-Athanasius, *Expos. in Ps.*, *passim*; Cyril., *Expos. in Ps.*, *passim*.

[14] Greg. Nys., *Inscr. Psalm.*, II 2 (GNO V 71-2), transl. R. Heine (1995), 126.

[15] See Hippolytus of Rome, *Homily on the Psalms*, ed. Pierre Nautin in: *Le dossier d'Hippolyte et de Méliton dans les florilèges dogmatiques et chez les historiens modernes*, Patristica 1 (Paris, 1953), 173,9-181,14.

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specific salvation-historical eventualities either in David's or Israel's own future or in the future frontier of the Christian dispensation; or (2) in a *properly eschatological function*, wherein the phrase signals in more panoramic terms how a Psalm anticipates the larger *eschatological transformation* inaugurated by the incarnation, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ; or finally, (3) in a *spiritual-pedagogical function*, in which the phrase often takes on a whole life of its own, as indicating the τέλος *of the moral and spiritual life* of the Christian which, while already framed within the confessions, laments, and doxologies of the Psalter, awaits 'fulfillment' now and in the future through the Christian's own ascetical response.

These three functions are by no means mutually exclusive. Indeed, they are normally integrated by the patristic commentators. Origen, for example, opens his comments on Psalm 4 by noting how Psalms entitled 'Unto the end' that are dedicated to David/Christ refer not only to Christ's own eschatological conquest but to the ultimate victories that he gives to all who in their ascetical struggles bring evil in subjection to him, and are themselves subjected to Christ, not by force but by persuasion.[16] Eusebius, in his comments on the title to Psalm 17,[17] clearly sees multiple possible functions of the title 'Unto the end' in this particular Psalm:

> It is absolutely necessary to acknowledge from this psalm that David dedicated the victory song set out here to the victories over his enemies and adversaries, to the Cause of every victory, the one who brought about the victories and is called [by Aquila] the Author of victory; and that this hymn of victory, or canticle, is uttered as an ode of David. 'Unto the end' is uttered either for the sake of the end relating to the last times of David's own life, after all his deeds and accomplishments; or for the sake of comprehending prophecy of future events to occur at the consummation of the age (ἐπὶ συντελείᾳ τοῦ αἰῶνος, see *Hebr.* 9:26); or thirdly, for the sake of leading the reader to the objectives (ἐπὶ τὰ τέλη) of the words of the forthcoming hymn, in which purposes we find the call of the Gentiles and prophecy concerning Christ.[18]

For most patristic commentators, the titles 'Unto the end' beg for typological and/or eschatological elucidation. 'Unto the end' defers us to one or more future fulfillments,[19] such as the alienation and punishment of the Jews, the calling of the Gentiles, or the saving acts of Christ and his final cosmic victory. 'Unto

[16] Orig., *Sel. in Ps.* 4 (PG 12, 1133A-B).

[17] Psalm 17's title reads: 'Unto the end, for David the servant [lit. child] of the Lord, who spoke to the Lord the words of this canticle, in the day that the Lord delivered him from the hands of all his enemies, and from the hand of Saul (see 2*Kings* 22, LXX)'.

[18] Euseb., *Comm. in Ps.* 17 (PG 23, 168A-B).

[19] Theodoret is an important commentator on this point, as he concedes that titles 'Unto the end' sometimes point ahead to Israel's own history, such as the captivity in Babylon (*Comm. in Ps.* 55 [PG 80, 1281C-84A); *ibid.* 56 [1289A-B]; *ibid.* 58 [1304A-C]; *ibid.* 59 [1316C-17A]; *ibid.* 61 [1329A]; *ibid.* 65 [1361A-B]; *ibid.* 68 [1400C-D]), but likewise even to much later events relating to the salvation of the whole world (*ibid.* 84 [1545B-C]; *ibid.* 138 [1933A-C]).

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the end, for the winepresses' (ὑπὲρ τῶν ληνῶν) in Psalms 8, 80, and 83, for example, is taken by Eusebius, Ps.-Athanasius, Cyril of Alexandria, Theodoret, and other exegetes as indicating the churches who have lately transcended Israel and are, in their ongoing mission, processing the wine of the spiritual vine, Christ himself.[20] 'Unto the end, for the hidden things of the Son' (*Ps.* 9; see 45) bespeaks the elusive intricacies of the mystery of the incarnation,[21] or else, as Basil of Caesarea would have it, the spiritual and eschatological secrets buried deeply within the Psalm and awaiting investigation by the pious.[22] 'Unto the end, for the octave' (*Pss.* 6 and 11) points ahead to the Eighth Day, the Lord's Day and the mystery of the Resurrection,[23] the spiritual circumcision,[24] or to the final Day of Judgment.[25] Gregory of Nyssa in his rich homily on Psalm 6, for example, discourses at length about the 'octave' as the transtemporal 'Eighth Day', the eschatological age of a new and spiritual circumcision. Noting the sober, penitential tone of the Psalm's subsequent verses, Gregory insists that such is altogether appropriate as a reverential response to the approach of divine judgment in advance of the Eighth Day.[26] His position is directly contradicted, however, by Diodore, who rebukes the 'old wive's tales of the practitioners of allegory', who dabble in exotic numerology and force the connection of this Psalm to the Eighth Day. Were that the case, says Diodore, one would expect precisely hymns of praise, not confessions of sin. Such speculative interpretation of the 'octave', then, deviates from what is clearly a penitential Psalm concerning David's adultery with Bathsheba.[27]

[20] Cf. Euseb., *Comm. in Ps.* 8 (PG 23, 125D); Ps.-Athanasius, *Expos. in Ps.* 8 (PG 27, 80C-1A); Cyril. Alex., *Expos. in Ps.* 8 (PG 69, 756D-57A); Theod., *Comm. in Ps.* 8 (PG 80, 913A-C); *ibid.* 80 (PG 80, 1520B); *ibid.* 83 (PG 80, 1537B-C). See the similar accounts of *Ps.* 5 ('Unto the end, for an inheritance'), the 'inheritance' being worthy believers in Christ: e.g., Euseb., *Comm. in Ps.* 5 (PG 23, 116A).

[21] E.g., Orig., *Sel. in Ps.* 9 (PG 12, 1185D); Euseb., *Comm. in Ps.* 9 (PG 23, 132A-B); Ps.-Athanasius, *Expos. in Ps.* 9 (PG 27, 84B-C); Greg. Nys., *Inscr. Psalm.* II 5 (GNO V 82-3); Aug., *Enarrationes in Ps.* 9 (PL 36, 116-117); *ibid.* 45 (514-5); Cyril. Alex., *Expos. in Ps.* 9 (PG 69, 761A-B).

[22] Basil. Caes., *Hom. in Ps.* 45 (PG 29, 416B-C).

[23] E.g. Euseb., *Comm. in Ps.* 6 (PG 23, 120A-B); *ibid.* 11 (140B); Ps.-Athanasius, *Expos. in Ps.* 6 (PG 27, 76C-D); Cyril. Alex., *Expos. in Ps.* 11 (PG 69, 796B).

[24] Did., *Comm. in Ps.* 6 (frag.), ed. Ekkehard Mühlenberg, *Psalmenkommentare aus der Katenenüberlieferung*, Bd. 1, Patristische Texte und Studien 15 (Berlin and New York, 1975), 135; Cyril. Alex., *Expos. in Ps.* 11 (PG 69, 796B).

[25] Ps.-Athanasius, *Expos. in Ps.* 11 (PG 27, 93C); Theod., *Comm. in Ps.* 6 (PG 80, 901B-C); *ibid.* 11 (941B).

[26] Greg. Nys., *Hom. in Ps.* 6 (GNO V 187-93). On Gregory's explanations of the title and his exegesis of *Ps.* 6, see Brian E. Daley, Training for 'the Good Ascent': Gregory of Nyssa's Homily on the Sixth Psalm, in: Paul M. Blowers, Angela Russell Christman, David G. Hunter and Robin Darling Young (eds.), *In Dominico Eloquio / In Lordly Eloquence: Essays on Patristic Exegesis in Honor of Robert Louis Wilken* (Grand Rapids, 2002), esp. 195-8.

[27] Diod. Tars., *Comm. in Ps.* 6 (CChr.SG 6, 32), transl. Robert C. Hill, *Diodore of Tarsus: Commentary on Psalms 1-51* (Atlanta, 2005), 19.

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Where there is a prophetic and/or eschatological explanation of a title 'Unto the end', the prosopology of the Psalm under consideration – its *dramatis personae*, as it were – often proved definitive.[28] The prosopology is often complex rather than simple. One or more voices or personas (πρόσωπα) may be speaking in the Psalm, and sometimes more than one persona can legitimately be uttering the same words, suggesting different but mutually consistent dimensions of the Psalm's meaning. Cyril of Alexandria's comment on Psalm 17 is exemplary:

> In the psalm, the person (πρόσωπον) of believers is introduced at times, while at other times, the person of Christ, each using human voices. This psalm too has the inscription 'Unto the end'. For the psalm comprehends the descent of the Only-Begotten, his ascension, his victory over the demons, the rejection of Israel, and the call of the Gentiles – which things happened in the end of the ages (ἐν τέλει τῶν αἰώνων), when the Only-Begotten became man. We too should be *children* of the Lord – which means 'servants'; and as we daily live honorably in virtue and works of light, we should be saved from all our enemies, especially *from the hand of Saul* – that is, from the activity and work of Satan ... Proceeding unto the end (εἰς τὸ τέλος) of victory (νίκης) we should be deemed worthy to give thanks to Christ, the author of victory.[29]

The dynamic prosopology of the Psalm, in this and scores of other cases, enables the much broader perspective on the salvation-historical τέλος. It projects the eschatological horizon of victory in Christ wherein the reader or cantor here and now is summoned to be the latest πρόσωπον, the newest 'voice' uttering the Psalm. Commenting on Psalm 41's title ('Unto the end, for understanding [εἰς σύνεσιν], for the sons of Korah'), Cyril identifies the sons of Korah as singers in David's time who, using this Psalm authored by David, were actually singing prophetically in the πρόσωπον of Israel a penitent confession such as Israel will undertake 'at the consummation of the ages' (ἐπὶ συντελείᾳ τῶν αἰώνων).[30] Eusebius, however, also asserts that the 'sons of Korah' ultimately represent, beyond the Jews themselves, *all* who thirst for Jesus Christ, the *font of [living] water* (see *Ps.* 41:2-3), and who have become, then, our exemplars, guiding us *now* 'to the end' of future realities.[31]

Crucial as well to the prophetic and/or eschatological exploitation of titles 'Unto the end' is the interpretation of the phrase in the light of *teleological* texts from the New Testament. The shining example in the Latin tradition certainly

[28] On the importance of prosopology in patristic interpretation of the Psalms, see the foundational work of Marie-Josèphe Rondeau, *Les commentaires patristiques du Psautier (IIIe-Ve siècles)*, Orientalia christiana analecta 220 (Rome, 1985), esp. vol. 2, 21-34, 40-72.

[29] Cyril. Alex., *Expos. in Ps.* 17 (PG 69, 820C-D).

[30] *Ibid.* 41 (PG 69, 1001). See Diodore, *Comm. in Ps.* 41 (CChr.SG 6, 253), who admits that the sons of Korah are temple singers (see 2*Chron.* 20:19), but sees the song as instead conveying the people's later longing for release from captivity in Babylon and for return to their land and temple (thus no christocentric reference).

[31] Euseb., *Comm. in Ps.* 41 (PG 23, 368A-D).

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is Augustine's consistent connection of the title *in finem* to Christ as the 'end of the law' (τέλος νόμου; *finis legis*) in *Rom.* 10:4, a correlation that exegetically funds the bishop's notion of the *totus Christus* (the solidarity of Christ with his Church), and indeed the whole christocentric reorientation of the Psalter, in his *Enarrationes in Psalmos*.[32] The Greek commentators for their part produce a variety of New Testament elucidations. Some indicate the denouement or consummation of history that has already begun in Jesus Christ. In Eusebius, Ps.-Athanasius, Basil, Cyril, Theodoret, and others, the ultimate fulfillment of Psalms 'Unto the end' is often captured in the phrase ἐπὶ συντελείᾳ τῶν αἰώνων, 'at the consummation of the ages',[33] a phrase not scripturally identified by the critical editors but in my judgment most definitely drawn from *Hebr.* 9:26, describing Christ's having appeared 'once for all *at the consummation of the ages*' (ἅπαξ ἐπὶ συντελείᾳ τῶν αἰώνων) in order to destroy sin through his sacrifice. Basil similarly relates the titles and contents of *Ps.* 45 and 48 to 1*Cor.* 15:24, the 'end' (τέλος) in which, Paul declares, Christ himself delivers his kingdom to God the Father.[34] 1*Corinthians*, with its integration of 'realized' and futurist eschatology, is in fact abundantly referenced. Origen and Eusebius relate *Ps.* 4 and its title to 1*Cor.* 15:22, the lifegiving in Christ which is the τέλος of all rational natures.[35] Psalms entitled 'Unto the end, for those who shall be changed (τοῖς ἀλλοιωθησομένοις)' (see *Pss.* 44, 59, 68, 79) are predictably read in the light of Paul's disclosures about resurrection and eschatological transformation in 1*Cor.* 15:28, 42-44, 51-52. The work of Didymus the Blind is exceptionally important in this connection, particularly his commentary on the title of Psalm 44, a full treatise of its own on the progressive physical and spiritual change 'unto the end' of this life and in the coming resurrection, thoroughly saturated with the ethics and eschatology of the Corinthian epistles.[36] (I shall have more to say about this text below).

Among the Psalms entitled 'Unto the end' are a few that truly elicit the breadth of the patristic exegetical imagination. Such is the case with Psalm 59, whose title celebrates some historic military victories of David but which is

[32] See Aug., *Enarrationes in Ps.*, esp. on *Pss.* 4, 11, 13, 14, 19, 20, 21, 22, 25, 30, 57 and esp. 46 and 55. On the title *in finem* as foundational to the *totus Christus* theme in the *Enarrationes*, see Michael Cameron, *Totus Christus* as a Hermeneutical Construct in Augustine's *Enarrationes in Psalmos*, in: Brian E. Daley (ed.), *The Harp of Prophecy: The Psalms in Early Christian Exegesis* (Notre Dame, IN, forthcoming).

[33] E.g., Euseb., *Comm. in Ps.* 13 (PG 23, 144B); *ibid.* 17 (168A); *ibid.* 30 (265B); *ibid.* 40 (361B); *ibid.* 59 (556A); Basil. Caes., *Hom. in Ps.* 59 (PG 29, 461C); Theod., *Comm. in Ps.* 21 (PG 80, 1008C-9A); Cyril. Alex., *Expos. in Ps.* 8 (PG 69, 757A); *ibid.* 9 (761A-C); *ibid.* 40 (993A); *ibid.* 41 (1000D); *ibid.* 52 (1108B).

[34] Basil. Caes., *Hom. in Ps.* 45 (PG 29, 416A); *ibid.* 48 (432B).

[35] Orig., *Sel. in Ps.* 4 (PG 12, 1132D-1133).

[36] See Did., *Comm. in Ps.* 45:1, ed. Michael Gronewald, *Didymus der Blinde: Psalmenkommentar (Tura-Papyrus)* (Bonn, 1970), vol. 5, 326,5-331,8 (= pp. 184-202). The section specifically dealing with the mystery of resurrection is 328,20-331,8.

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addressed 'to those who shall yet be changed'. The full, elaborate title reads: 'Unto the end, for those who shall be changed; for the inscription of a title; to David himself, for instruction, when he set fire to Mesopotamia of Syria and the Syria-Sobal, and Joab returned and killed twelve thousand in the Valley of Salt' (see 2*Kings* 8:1-13, LXX). And yet the subsequent verses of the Psalm 59, rather than dwelling on celebration and thanksgiving for David's successes, mainly combine lamentation and the invocation of divine aid, an inconsistency not lost on some of the patristic exegetes.[37] But such 'inconsistency' was, along the lines of Origen's campaign to identify and overcome scriptural *skandala*, simply the raw material for widened hermeneutical perspective. In some separate essays I have analyzed the evolving interpretation of this title in select Greek commentators; and what I have found is an ever more sophisticated teleology of penultimate and ultimate 'ends'.[38] Eusebius and Theodoret, for example, allow the proposed 'change' at the designated 'end' to be a future development in Israel's own post-Davidic history.[39] Eusebius, however, makes a distinction between the *relative* future prophetically projected in the title, a 'certain time' (καιρῷ τινι) after David's revered military exploits when Israel would wither in her prime (thus evoking lamentation), and the title's τέλος for us now (καὶ νῦν), the prospect of a change (μεταβολή) when the election of the Jews would give way to the calling of the Gentiles. Theodoret, reflecting an Antiochene conservatism, likewise sees David in this Psalm projecting future change, both captivity and redemption, for Israel, but is mute – at least in the shorter version of his commentary – on that change including the Christian dispensation.[40]

Not only Eusebius but Ps.-Athanasius (the yet unidentified author of the *Expositions on the Psalms*) and Basil of Caesarea see that future change as the threshold of the eschatological age in Christ that begins with the conversion of the Gentiles.[41] Ps.-Athanasius argues that in Psalm 59 David speaks in the persona of Christ for our instruction, since Christ himself has effected the change and renewal of things at the end of time and vanquished the foreign (that is 'spiritual') Gentiles. Interestingly, Ps.-Athanasius also sees the Psalm as

[37] E.g., Basil. Caes., *Hom. in Ps. 59* (PG 29, 461B).

[38] See Paul M. Blowers, A Psalm 'Unto the End': Eschatology and Anthropology in Maximus the Confessor's *Commentary on Psalm* 59, in: Brian E. Daley (ed.), *The Harp of Prophecy: The Psalms in Early Christian Exegesis* (Notre Dame, IN, forthcoming); *id.*, 'Interpreting Scripture', in: Augustine Casiday and Frederick Norris (eds.), *The Cambridge History of Christianity*, vol. 2: *Constantine to c. 600* (Cambridge, 2007), 618-36.

[39] Euseb. Caes., *Comm. in Ps.* 59 (PG 23, 556A-C); Theod., *Comm. in Ps.* 59 (PG 80, 1316C, 1317A).

[40] Theod., *Comm. in Ps. 59* (PG 80, 1316C-7A). In the longer version of the *Commentary*, there is a brief note on Ps 59:5 ('Save with your right hand...') identifying the 'right hand' – very much according to tradition – as the only-begotten Son.

[41] Euseb. Caes., *Comm. in Ps.* 59 (PG 23, 556B); Ps.-Athanasius, *Expos. in Ps.* 59 (PG 27, 268A-9A); Basil. Caes., *Hom. in Ps.* 59 (PG 29, 461C-4C); see also Orig., *Prol.* to *the Sel. in Ps.*, ed. Gualterus Rietz, *De Origenis Prologis in Psalterium* (Jena, 1914), 2, 24-34.

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heralding Christ's conquest of his enemies, signaled by the Jews beginning to treat Gentiles as kinsmen and to make a penitential 'return' so as to be worthy of Christ's grace.[42] Basil spreads the eschatological vista of this Psalm wide open, indicating that, in the consummation of the ages (συντελείᾳ τῶν αἰώνων), Christians who are already changing, moving from polytheism to piety, are also 'those who shall be changed' through continuing moral reformation.[43]

Gregory of Nyssa for his part moves the discussion fully into the orbit of the spiritual transformation and 'victory' of Christians as 'those who shall be changed'. He says that rather than following out the historical ἀκολουθία of events alluded to in the Psalm as key to its deeper meaning, it is really the title itself that is definitive. Indeed, the teleology of Psalm 59 fits perfectly into his teaching on the prospect of the soul's ever positive *change* in relation to the *unchanging* God, and he concurs with his older brother Basil that the 'inscription' of the title 'for instruction' as such is to be within the memory of the saints.[44] By the time we get to Maximus the Confessor, who wrote an entire *Exposition of Psalm 59*, the spiritual and eschatological implications of its title have been taken to a new level. Psalm 59's inscription, writes Maximus, points *both* 'to the transformation and change in inclination and free choice (τὴν γνωμικήν τε καὶ προαιρετικὴν μεταβολὴν καὶ ἀλλοίωσιν), from infidelity to faith, from vice to virtue, and from ignorance to the knowledge of God, which have come about for humanity at the end of time (ἐπὶ τέλει τῶν χρόνων) in view of the advent of Christ', *and* to 'the future natural change and renewal that will, in grace, transpire universally at the end of the ages (ἐπὶ τέλει τῶν αἰώνων, see 1*Cor.* 10:11) through the very same Savior and God, when every human race shall be translated from death and corruption to immortal life and incorruption through the anticipated resurrection.'[45]

In the face of these kinds of eschatological expansions on the Psalms titles, it is not surprising there were a few skeptics along the way. Diodore of Tarsus is again the most vocal critic, who on occasion flatly declaring against eschatological speculations where a Psalm title has an available historical referent. With the title to Psalm 17, for example, Diodore insists that the phrase 'Unto the end' has to do with events 'toward the end of the life of David himself',[46] no more no less. Commenting on Psalm 12's title he obviates potentially adventurous interpretations: 'It says 'Unto the end' instead of 'Concerning things to come'. *The latter simply is not the case.* For the theme (ὑπόθεσις) of the Psalm is obvious: it is uttered of David himself, when he fell into sin with Bathsheba'.[47]

[42] Ps.-Athanasius, *Expos. in Ps.* 59 (PG 27, 268A-9A).

[43] Basil. Caes., *Hom. in Ps.* 59 (PG 29, 461C-4C).

[44] *Inscr. Psalm.* II 4 (GNO V 79-82).

[45] Max. Conf., *Comm. in Ps.* 59 (CChr.SG 23, 3,7-23).

[46] Diod. Tars., *Comm. in Ps.* 17 (CChr.SG 6, 91,6-8); see *ibid.* 18 (CChr.SG 6, 108,3-5);

[47] *Ibid.* 12 (CChr.SG 6, 70,3-6); see *ibid.* 13 (CChr.SG 6, 73,3-8); 19 (CChr.SG 6, 118,5f., 12-16).

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Yet Diodore, here as elsewhere, is a fairly lone voice. By and large, the Fathers beheld in the Psalter, and in its titles, a spectacular preview of the unfolding mysteries of the consummation of world history in Christ.

Let me complete this paper by shifting gears and noting some instances where the phrase 'Unto the end' takes on, for certain patristic interpreters of the Psalms titles, a role of its own in constructing a teleology of the moral and spiritual life of the Christian. I have already briefly noted this pattern in Gregory of Nyssa's analysis of Psalm 59 in his treatise *On the Inscriptions of the Psalms*, but there are other important examples as well. Discussing the phrase εἰς τὸ τέλος in the prologue to one of his commentaries on the Psalms, Origen, followed later by Didymus in the Greek tradition and Hilary in the Latin, had offered for consideration some formal definitions of τέλος in Aristotelian and Stoic ethics. The 'end' is 'that for the sake of which other things act, but which itself acts for the sake of nothing else'; moreover, felicity, or εὐδαιμονία, is the σκοπός and ἔσχατον of the virtues.[48] Origen does not explain why he tenders these definitions; doubtless he could not ignore the fact that Aristotle's whole ethics began with the discussion of the τέλος of existents, while Stoics and Platonists had fiercely debated the doctrine of 'ends' and *the* End. Christianity, however, furnished its own version of the complex relationship between mediate ends and the final *Telos* in Christ. As Origen comments on the title of Psalm 4,

> Numerous Psalms in the LXX have the inscription 'Unto the end' while the rest of the Greek translations have renderings corresponding to 'Unto the end'. It is worthwhile, as far as our ability allows, to trace the sense manifested by this phrase. One must observe that, just as there is the 'end' (τέλος) of every art and science, upon which basis one sets out genuinely to pursue that art or science, so too there must be an 'end' of the rational nature itself. According to the Apostle, this end is to be made alive in Christ (1*Cor.* 15:22). We consider that the Psalms entitled 'Unto the end' inscribe a certain meaning of the end, and summon those who understand what those Psalms say to that end. For the end is victory for everyone who struggles. Since, therefore, as we indicate in advance, Christ is called 'David', the Psalms inscribed 'Unto the end' for David announce the end and victory of Christ.[49]

Basil is more explicit about the superiority of Christian 'ends'. Elucidating the title to Psalm 48 he observes that many of the pagan scholars have 'formed

[48] Orig., *Prol.* to the *Sel. in Ps.* (ed. Pitra, *De Origenis prologis*, 14,21-30); see Aristotle, *Eudemian Ethics* 1227B; *Nicomachean. Ethics* I 7.8; and in the Stoic tradition, Stobaeus 2.77.16ff (SVF 3,16); see also the texts on 'The End and Happiness' in: A.A. Long and D.N. Sedley (eds.), *The Hellenistic Philosophers* (Cambridge, 1987), vol. 2, section 63 (= pp. 389-404). Imitating Origen's citation of such definitions, see Did., *Comm. in Ps.* 35:1-2 (ed. M. Gronewald, vol. 4, 230,23-30) on τέλος as 'that for the sake of which everything else is done, but which itself is done for the sake of nothing', and as the 'desired end' (ἔσχατον ὀρεκτόν, see SVF 3,3,25ff.); see *ibid.* on Ps. 43:1 (307,24-28); *ibid.* on Ps. 44:1 (326,15-16). Also following Origen is Hil. Pict., *Tract. in Ps., Prol.* 18 (PL 9, 243).

[49] *Sel. in Ps.* 4 (PG 12, 1132D-3A); see Euseb. Caes., *Comm. in Ps.* 4 (PG 23, 101A-C).

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ideas concerning the end of humanity and have arrived at various opinions about the end', while for us Christians 'the end for which we do all things and toward which we hasten is the blessed life of the world to come'.[50]

At any rate, Origen sets a standard destined to thrive in the early Christian ascetic tradition. The Psalms really are prophesying about *a process of moral formation* and spiritual pedagogy that is global and individual, and ever moving toward completion. Again, as Origen states, 'Unto the end', bespeaks 'the end is victory (νίκη) for everyone who struggles', wherein we find ourselves in good company with David (Christ), Asaph, the sons of Korah, and a host of exemplars.[51] On the title and opening of Psalm 48 – which reads 'Unto the end, to the sons of Korah, a psalm. Hear these things, all you Gentiles, hearken all you who inhabit the earth, both the sons of the land and sons of men, rich and poor alike' (vv. 1-3) – Origen comments,

> It is possible that the inscription refers to the victory of each of those who conquer in their struggling. It is the voice of Christ calling all the Gentiles when he says 'Come unto me, all ye who labor' (*Matth.* 12:28). And since a poor son of the land is edified more simply, while the one who is able to transcend is benefited rather upon spiritual things, as he is a son of a man and of wealth, Christ therefore calls all at once (ἅμα) to the very same τέλος, as if to the same banquet, the same hearing. The calling of the wealthy and the poor to one and the same end calls us [now] to equality and humility.[52]

Basil by contrast sees the Savior in Psalm 48 calling three pairs of persons: Gentiles (pagans) and 'inhabitants of the earth' (Christians in the church); the 'sons of the land' who are attached to the things of the world, and the 'sons of men' who exercise a measure of reason; and the rich and the poor. His conclusion, however, follows Origen. The great Physician of souls calls all to the same spiritual victory in the church, to the same gathering and ecclesial habituation in love.[53]

Both Basil[54] and Gregory of Nyssa will thoroughly exploit this theme of the 'end' as spiritual victory in Christ. In his substantial comments on the phrase εἰς τὸ τέλος in the Psalms titles, Gregory extrapolates the majestic image of the stadium of life and the whole athletic struggle for the attainment of true virtue.[55] The teleology of all these Psalms titles 'Unto the end' thoroughly serves his larger doctrine of *epektasis*, or perpetual striving in the spiritual life.

Along the same lines, Didymus the Blind develops what in my findings is the most philosophically elaborate moral teleology of this title 'Unto the end'.

[50] Basil. Caes., *Hom. in Ps.* 48 (PG 29, 432A-B), transl. Agnes Clare Way, FOTC 46, 311, slightly altered.

[51] Orig., *Sel. in Ps.* 4 (PG 12, 1133A-B).

[52] *Ibid.* 48 (PG 12, 1441C-D).

[53] Basil. Caes., *Hom. in Ps.* 48 (PG 29, 433A-6A).

[54] See e.g., Basil. Caes., *Hom. in Ps.* 48 (PG 29, 432B-C).

[55] Greg. Nys., *Inscr. Psalm.*, Part II 2 (GNO V 72-4).

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As Richard Layton has demonstrated in his excellent recent monograph on Didymus as an ascetical instructor, the Psalms factored enormously into his spiritual pedagogy. The Psalter is a veritable textbook of the spiritual life, and through its evocative images and symbols the interpreter is engrossed in its narrative of pilgrimage, a transforming journey.[56] Didymus frequently comments at length on the Psalm title 'Unto the end', and recalls the formal definitions from Aristotelian and Stoic sources already culled by Origen. With Psalm 35's title he insists that the true τέλος is 'that for the sake of which everything else is done, but which itself is done for the sake of nothing else', so that the 'ultimate desirable' (ἔσχατον ὀρεκτόν) – perfect virtue – can never be identified with its means.[57] And yet believers have to pursue every means to attain to that end. Acquiring true virtue is thus at once a methodical process and a spiritual pilgrimage; what is more, it is a perpetual change (ἀλλοίωσις) in the direction of deification. In his long discourse on the title for Psalm 44, Didymus states this in some detail:

> Often we set forth definitions of ends: the τέλος is that which is beyond everything, the desired end (ἔσχατον ὀρεκτόν). Such is the case with the inscriptions 'Unto the end, for those who shall be changed'. When change reaches an extension (ἐπίτασις) such that it can no longer extend any further, it comes to the end of things, when God is 'all and in all' (1*Cor.* 15:28); then the quality can no longer be extended. All knowledge and virtue is a quality. Thus it is possible to begin in virtue and to prosper in it, and to be able always to attain to virtue already achieved. But when one has perfectly embraced virtue so as to lack nothing in it, one has been 'changed' 'unto the end'. We say exactly the same thing about knowledge and wisdom. One who is initiated in wisdom can still come under censure for sinning. For 'rebuke a wise man, and he will love you' (*Prov.* 9:8). No one is rebuked who has nothing on their account for which he shall be rebuked. This wise man submits to reproach because he is still newly formed and just initiated and capable of perpetual further progress. But when he acquires wisdom such that he no longer can increase in it, he has (already) 'been changed' 'unto the end'.[58]
>
> Those who shall be changed are those who, still being in the process of changing, anticipate when they will be 'at the end' of the change. For one does not begin in order not to be perfected, but with many progressions, to arrive at the very terminus of that quality whereupon one is changed. But what is the end (τέλος) other than deification (τὸ θεοποιηθῆναι), so that God may be 'all [and in all]' (see 1*Cor.* 15:28)?[59]

With Didymus, we can indeed once again say that the title 'Unto the end' has taken on a whole interpretive life of its own.

[56] *Didymus the Blind and His Circle in Late-Antique Alexandria* (Urbana and Chicago, 2004), 36-55.

[57] Did., *Comm. in Ps.* 35:1-2 (ed. M. Gronewald, vol. 4, 230,23-30).

[58] *Ibid.* 44:1 (ed. M. Gronewald, vol. 5, 326,15-25).

[59] *Ibid.* (ed. M. Gronewald, vol. 5, 328,20-22). See also the comments of R. Layton (2004), 43-8.

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Having said that, however, I want to conclude my paper by reiterating that this kind of moral teleology and instruction in virtue was by no means a flight of moralizing or spiritualizing fancy disconnected from the more traditional prophetic interpretations of Psalms entitled 'Unto the end'. Didymus respected what Origen, Eusebius, the Cappadocians, and other patristic commentators also recognized: that the whole complex relationship between mediate 'ends' (the historical horizon of human choosing and acting – a horizon shared by the biblical saints and by *us* living now) and the ultimate *Telos* of eschatological transformation in Jesus Christ, was an issue that could never be finally resolved in the dialectical exercises of philosophical ethics. It had instead to be spelled out through appeal to the narratives of ancient biblical saints whose lives teemed with prophetic adumbrations of the life in Christ, for the benefit of us now, 'upon whom', as Paul says in 1*Cor.* 10:11, 'the end of the ages has (already) come'. It had to be discovered, among other biblical sources, in the tapestry of victory hymns, doxologies, laments, and confessions arising from the rich spiritual prosopography and prosopology of the Psalms. The careful attention to this mysterious phrase 'Unto the end' was one among other sophisticated means by which these patristic commentators aspired to discern in the Psalter's own textual signals the connecting links between ancient testimonies, the present victories and struggles of the Christian faithful, and the future mysteries of resurrection and deification.

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Rabbinic Responses to Christian Appropriation of the Hebrew Bible: The Case of *Psalm* 22:1 (MT)

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While the influence of Jewish scriptural interpretation on Christian exegesis has long been acknowledged, only recently the reverse side came to be a focus of investigation, i.e. the influence of Christianity on rabbinic exegesis. As it appears, Christian 'occupation' of texts and biblical figures stimulated a rabbinic purposeful neglect of these same texts and figures in several cases; in others, the Rabbis choose to develop alternative readings, which countered Christian interpretative claims.[1]

However convincing the results are, *Entdeckerfreude* could easily lead to over-interpreting the evidence. For instance, when there is reason to assume a polemical background for a midrashic tradition, this does not necessarily imply a dispute with Christianity, rather than with another party. Further, the leading role of the text in midrashic discourse can hardly be overestimated. Especially in those cases where the meaning of the Hebrew text is unclear or uncertain, debate may as well be a sign of ongoing investigation.[2] Therefore, any claim that a specific midrashic tradition responds to Christian biblical interpretation should be supported by both tradition-critical and contextual evidence.

In this paper, I would like to contribute to the discussion by offering a case study on *Psalm* 22:1. This psalm was strongly appropriated in Christian writing, and its reception history is relatively well studied. As appears from the elaborate *dossier* published by Gilles Dorival, rabbinic and patristic interpretation of the psalm as such, and of verse 1 in particular, differ principally.[3] With the exception of the Antiochenes, the Church Fathers took verse 1 to refer to the death and resurrection of Christ; the Rabbis, in majority, maintain that the psalm speaks of Esther. Hence the title of Dorival's study: *David, Jésus et*

[1] For an example of rabbinic 'withdrawal', see Judith R. Baskin, *Pharaoh's Counsellors: Job, Jethro, and Balaam in Rabbinic and Patristic Tradition* (Chico, 1983). For the strategy of counter-exegesis, see Philip S. Alexander, Pre-Emptive Exegesis: Genesis Rabba's Reading of the Story of Creation: *JJS* 43 (1992) 230-44 and Hanneke Reuling, *After Eden: Church Fathers and Rabbis on Genesis 3:16-21* (Leiden, Boston, 2006), ch. 6, esp. 274-7.

[2] Such observations were also made during a recent expert meeting on the 'exegetical encounter between Church Fathers and Rabbis' concerning the book of Genesis (Cambridge, June 2007). The proceedings are to be published by Helen Spurling and Emmanouela Grypeou (Leiden).

[3] Gilles Dorival (ed.), *David, Jésus et la reine Esther: Recherches sur le Psaume 21 (22 TM)*, Collection de la *Revue des Études juives* 25 (Paris, Louvain, 2002).

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la reine Esther. Dorival finds that the messianic reading of *Psalm* 22 has pre-Christian origins; by the early second century, he states, the rabbinic tradition turned to a non-messianic interpretation, while the Church Fathers kept to the messianic interpretation.[4] Dorival maintains that the Rabbis changed the title of the Hebrew version of this psalm in order to 'de-messianise' it. Instead, he says, they promoted a prophetic reading in which the psalm regards Esther.[5]

It is my aim to evaluate the materials provided by Dorival against the background of the fore-mentioned discussion of rabbinic responses to Christian appropriation of the Hebrew Bible. I will first discuss the biblical text, and then give an analysis of the rabbinic materials.

The Biblical Text

The texts of *Psalm* 21//22 differ in several instances from each other. In the light of our inquiry, the second part of verse 1 is the most relevant occasion. The MT reads: 'On the doe of the morning' (על-אילת השחר). The LXX has: 'On the help of the early morning' (ὑπὲρ τῆς ἀντιλήμψεως τῆς ἑωθινῆς). Dorival maintains that the LXX has the older version, which corresponds to the Hebrew variant *eyalut* (strength, power). In his view, the Rabbis changed the vocalisation of *eyalut* (strength, or help in the LXX) into *ayyelet* (doe). This they did in response to christological interpretation of this verse as regarding the resurrection of Christ on Easter-morning. Thereby the Rabbis made the title 'historical, female and applicable to Esther', instead of 'messianic, male and applicable to Jesus'.[6] To support this claim, Dorival refers to the targumic rendering, which also contains the word 'strength', and therefore would seem to reflect the LXX rendering. The Targum on Psalms reads: 'On the strength of the regular sacrifice of the early morning'.[7] Dorival suggests that the application to the morning sacrifice became meaningless after the destruction of the Temple in 70 C.E., wherefore the Rabbis had no longer reason to maintain the supposedly older version.[8]

The difference between the versions clearly demonstrate the different starting points of the exegetes, and to some extend explain the interpretative roads taken by Judaism and Christianity. However, I am not convinced that a rabbinic

[4] G. Dorival, *David*, 2002, 5; G. Dorival, L'interprétation ancienne du Psaume 21 (TM 22): *ibidem*, 225-314, 293. Dorival explains minority positions (esp. Antiochene interpretation and messianic interpretation preserved in the midrash) in termes of revival of older interpretations.

[5] G. Dorival, L'interprétation ancienne (2002), 294: 'Les rabbins ont démessianisé le Ps 21'.

[6] G. Dorival, La Bible grecque des Septante et le texte massorétique: G. Dorival, *David* (2002), 13-25, 19.

[7] Luis Diez Merino (ed.), *Targum de Salmos*, Edicion Principe del ms. Villa-Amil no. 5, par Alfonso de Zamora (Madrid, 1982), *ad loc.*

[8] G. Dorival, La Bible grecque (2002), 19.

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response to Christian appropriation of the Hebrew Bible may be established here. My first hesitation concerns motivation. The Rabbis would not seem to be in need of changing the biblical text for reasons of application, as their methods of textual interpretation were highly flexible. Given the evidence of the targumic and also the hexaplaric versions, it is far more probable that there is a problem with the meaning of the Hebrew text, which is solved differently in different translations.[9] My second hesitation concerns the time period. It is generally assumed that the Rabbis were not very alarmed by Christianity in the early centuries. Responses to Christian claims are usually not found before the fourth century. The beginning of the second or even the third century would thus seem a very early date for a purposeful change of perspective. My last hesitation concerns the targumic evidence. Clearly, a targum on the Psalms existed before the beginning of the Christian era, but the redaction process of this targum probably lasted until the fifth century C.E.[10] Further, the fact that the Temple cult was no longer functioning after the year 70 was, for the Rabbis, no reason to abolish cultic interpretation of the Bible. The *Mishnah* received its final redaction only by the year 200, many of its pages being devoted to the cult of the Temple and related subjects, the rules being carefully preserved by the Sages in hope of restoration. As I see it, there is little ground to postulate an anti-Christian motivation for the (proto-)MT of *Psalm* 22:1 in its deviation from the LXX reading.

The Midrash on *Psalm* 22:1

The main source for rabbinic interpretation of the psalms is *Midrash Tehillim* or the midrash on the Psalms. Although the larger share of the materials collected in this midrash stems from the talmudic era, it received its final redaction possibly as late as the thirteenth century. This leads to a serious problem of methodological nature for any comparative inquiry. Dorival's study offers the only sensible approach to the problem, which is to present the materials of *MidrTeh* alongside a full overview of references to the psalm in other rabbinic documents. I here follow the same lead.

The subject of *Psalm* 22, more specifically: the meaning of the phrase *ayyelet / eyalut hashaḥar*, is a major topic in *MidrTeh*, occupying almost the first half of the entire midrash. The midrash explores the different possible connotations of the Hebrew words. So it explains the term 'doe' by referring to the stability of the doe's feet as a symbol for the firmness of the one trusting in God. It takes up the time-reference in 'morning', e.g. by understanding the

[9] Aquila: ἐλάφου, Symmachus: βοηθείας.

[10] On the early origins of the targum of Psalms, see Philippe Cassuto, Le Targum sur le Psaume 21 (TM 22), in: G. Dorival, *David* (2002), 29-36.

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psalm as intended for the morning praise. A great number of midrashim elaborate upon the connotation of (the arrival of) light at dawn. This leads to a discussion of dark times in the history of Israel and the lights or leaders that illuminated them in each period. A final connotation is that of waking up, and hence the subject of revival and restoration. Although *ayyelet* (doe) is the most common reading of the text, a number of midrashim refer to or imply the reading *eyalut* (strength).[11]

The prime key to the interpretation is found in the Esther story. Esther is compared to a doe who appeared in the morning after the night of Haman's ruling. The redaction of the midrashim is quite tight, resulting in a coherent arrangement of the collected materials with a constant return to the Esther story. While discussing verse 1, other verses are invoked to support the identification. So verse 2 is applied to the three day fast proclaimed by Esther, verse 3 to her cry for help. Verse 19 (*They divide my clothes among themselves, casting lots for my garments*) is taken to refer to the people of the palace, who expected Esther would fall into disgrace because of visiting the king on her own initiative.[12] This tradition is highly remarkable, as it is not occasioned by the biblical text and can only be explained by the purposeful and consequent application of the whole of the psalm to Esther. The 'opposite similarity' with Christian interpretation of the same verse is striking. Other important motifs in the interpretation are the exodus from Egypt, exile, suppression by foreign rulers, and hope for restoration, both in this world and in the world to come. Thus, *MidrTeh* offers a coherent rabbinic interpretation of the verse, in which the person of Esther functions as a synthesizing symbol.

I now return to the Dorival dossier, more specifically to the overview Philipe Cassuto produced of the extant rabbinic traditions on *Psalm* 22. The overwhelming interest in verse 1 in *MidrTeh* is not mirrored in other sources, where it has only three references (bT *Yoma* 29a, *Yalqut Shimoni* on Habakkuk and Esther). Apparently, the title of the Psalm raised questions in the specific context of the interpretation of the Psalter, rather than having an impact on other discussions. Rabbinic priorities are clearly demonstrated by the ample attention for verse 4 (*But you are the Holy One, enthroned upon the praises of Israel*, 18 references). The absence of *Esther Rabbah* in Cassuto's list points to a one-way inter-textuality: while the Psalm (in *MidrTeh*) is read in a very strong inter-textual relation with the Esther story, this connection is absent in the midrash on Esther.[13] From a chronological perspective, the interpretation of the Babylonian Talmud is the most useful one, as it leads us back to the talmudic era. The association with Esther is established in two of the four midrashim on our verse in de Bavli. The absence of tannaitic interpretation is complicating.

[11] *MidrTeh* (ed. Solomon Buber, Wilna, 1892 / Jerusalem, 1966), *Ps.* 22, sections 1-15.
[12] *Ibid.* 184, 21-8 (section 7, end) and section 27, beginning.
[13] Although not in the *Yalkut*.

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Christian authors of this period suggest that their Jewish colleagues attributed the psalm to David. So Tertullian, who polemicises against allegedly Jewish interpretation of verses 17-8.[14] A few centuries later, Jerome declares impious those who maintain that *Psalm* 2 is said *of David or of Esther and Mordecai*.[15] This statement confirms that the application of *Psalm* 2 to the story of Esther was well established by the end of the fourth century, and also that the subject of the psalm was a point of discussion between at least some Jews and Christians.

The image we gained is incomplete, and must necessarily remain so because of lack of additional evidence. We found a remarkably extensive exploration of the diverse connotations of the expression *ayyelet hashaḥar* in the Midrash on Psalms, covering several streams of interpretation including the reading *eyalut*, but with a strong emphasis on the interpretative tradition that identifies the doe of the morning as a reference to Esther. This pattern of interpretation is coherent and is also present in the remaining parts of the midrash on this psalm. The structure of the discourse and the consequent return to the leading motif point to a tight redaction of the collected materials. Further, we have seen that the interpretation of the psalm regarding Esther has been an established tradition at least since the fourth century C.E. There are no indications that this interpretation goes back to the tannaitic era. Last, we observed that the emphasis on the first verse in *MidrTeh* is not mirrored in other sources. All these observations would seem to suggest that the subject of the psalm was a topic of some concern for the Rabbis who composed and edited the midrash on Psalms.

Conclusion

The midrashic interpretation of *Psalm* 22:1 as found in *MidrTeh* would seem to be another example to support the thesis that the Rabbis responded to Christian appropriation of the Hebrew Bible. Although decisive proof is missing, there are a number of indications.

In my view, the reading of 'the doe of the early morning' with regards to Esther, is not necessarily polemical. It may also have resulted from common rabbinic hermeneutics, even if its origins are obscure to us. The subsequent favouritism of this motif and the attribution of the whole psalm to Esther are a better candidate for response. The attribution to Esther creates a parallel to

[14] *Adversos Iudaeos* 13,10; see G. Dorival, L'interprétation ancienne (2002), 280.

[15] *Comm. in Matth.* IV, on *Matth.* 27:46. As Dorival rightly points out, the first accusation may be directed against Antiochene interpretation, as much as against the Jews. The second opposed interpretation, however, is exclusively Jewish (G. Dorival, L'interprétation ancienne, 2002, 281). The fact that Jerome was well informed of current rabbinic exegesis is clearly demonstrated by his *Commentariolum* on this psalm (written before 393), which is also discussed by Dorival (*ibid.*).

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Christian interpretation, but now on the basis of a rabbinic paradigm. Moreover, the extensive and coherent exploration of verse 1 betrays an awareness of a debate on the subject of the Psalm, which cannot be explained on the basis of internal Jewish disputations or of problems in the text.

Although I therefore tend to agree with Dorival that the Rabbis responded to Christian interpretation, my estimation of the evidence differs from his in two aspects. First, I do not believe that the Rabbis changed the biblical text for polemical reasons. Rather, their strategy was to overload the text with *wanted* interpretation, as to prevent it being filled with *unwanted* reading. Second, I do not deem it likely that purposeful application of the Psalm to Esther in response to Christian interpretation should be dated as early as the second century. The fourth century would be a more sensible suggestion, both with regard to the textual evidence and in the light of the historical development of Jewish and Christian relations.

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Esther as a Type of Christ and the Jewish Celebration of Purim[1]

Catherine Brown TKACZ, Spokane, Washington

A Christian innovation in biblical exegesis was to interpret certain women such as Susanna and Jephthah's daughter as types of Christ, alongside men such as Jonah and Isaac.[2] The doctrinal context for this new interpretation was the spiritual equality of the sexes, as revealed in the Genesis account of Creation and emphasized by Jesus.[3] Significantly, the Gospels themselves indicated Susanna's role as a type of Christ: Matthew's account of the Passion of Christ contains seventeen passages, over fifty words, parallel to passages in Theodotion's account of the ordeal of Susanna, as detailed recently in *Gregorianum*.[4] Other biblical women were likewise interpreted as prefiguring Christ in His Passion.[5]

In each case, the women's acts and words grounded the new interpretation of them as types of Christ. Susanna, like Christ, was arrested in a garden and condemned by the 'Elders of the People' on the testimony of false witnesses. Jephthah's daughter was the only-begotten, beloved child who was sacrificed for the sake of the whole people. As one medieval commentary put it, 'Filia unica iepte unicu[m] dei filiu[m] fig[ur]abat'.[6] The widow of Zarephath gathered 'two sticks' ('Colligo duo ligno'), which St. Augustine construed as a reference to the Cross; twelfth-century sanctuary art depicted the widow alongside Christ with the Cross.[7]

[1] This research was supported by a grant from the National Endowment for the Humanities. I am grateful to the Dominican House of Studies, Washington, D.C., for hosting me during my research trip to use resources at The Catholic University of America and Dumbarton Oaks.

[2] Catherine Brown Tkacz, Women as Types of Christ: Susanna and Jephthah's Daughter: *Gregorianum* 85 (2004) 281-314.

[3] Catherine Brown Tkacz, The Doctrinal Context for Interpreting Women as Types of Christ: *SP* 40 (2006) 253-7.

[4] Catherine Brown Tkacz, ἀνεβόησεν φωνῇ μεγάλῃ: Susanna and the Synoptic Passion Narratives: *Gregorianum* 87 (2006) 449-86.

[5] Catherine Brown Tkacz, *Susanna victrix, Christus victor:* Lenten Sermons, Typology, and the Lectionary, in: Georgiana Donavin *et al.* (eds.), *Speculum Sermonis* (Turnhout, 2004), 55-79.

[6] London, British Library, Add. 15249, Biblia Pauperum, f. 15. The two Old Testament Types of Christ on this folio are Isaac and Jephthah's daughter. The verse caption for the latter depiction roundly condemns her father by punning on his name and the word 'inept': By use of an abbreviation mark the name and the adverb are spelled identically: 'Hic princeps iepte / tua nata necat[ur] i[n]epte'.

[7] For the likely inspiration for these artworks, see Montague Rhodes James, *Pictor in Carmine*: *Archaeologia* 94 (1951) 141-66, 161.

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Indeed, she is the only type of Christ on the 'magnificent rock-crystal cross' at Brussels.[8] Ruth being directed by Boaz to dip her bread in vinegar was interpreted in *Ruth Rabbah* as the Messiah suffering before entering his kingdom.[9] In a Resurrectional hymn for Pascha, Jairus's daughter functions dramatically as a type of Christ.[10] The woman in the parable who finds the lost coin is treated in Greek texts as Christ, the wisdom (σοφία) and power (δύναμις) of God.[11]

The scriptural account of Esther itself provides grounds for interpreting her, also, as a type of Christ. When the entire people were in danger of death, she explicitly affirmed that she was willing to 'expose myself to death and to danger'.[12] A parallel could be drawn between Esther's three days and nights of prayer and fasting (*Esther* 4:16, 5:1) and Jesus' period in the tomb. Or, her fast and prayer, undertaken ἐν ἀγῶνι θανάτου before she actually risks her life,[13] could have been identified as related typologically to Jesus' prayer in Gethsemane when he was ἐν ἀγωνίᾳ (*Luke* 22:44). Again, Esther's swooning at the moment when her life was in immediate danger (*Est.* 15:10-11, 17-18) could have been glossed as foreshadowing Christ's death. Likewise, the King's words could prefigure God the Father ordaining that the Son alone would not be bound by death, for Ahasuerus told Esther: 'Thou shalt not die: for this law is not made for thee but for all others' (15:13).

Significantly, the Lectionary suggests that Esther is a type of Christ. From the earliest evidence up through the pre-Vatican II modern Lectionary Mordecai's prayer anticipating Esther's risking her life for the people (Vulg. *Est.* 13:8-17) was read during Lent. Moreover, the prayer was attributed to Esther herself in at least the earliest lectionary and the version known to Rupert of Deutz: 'In diebus illis *oravit ester* dominum, dicens...'[14] In the Gospel lection Jesus foretold his death and resurrection and declared that he would be a ransom for many (*Matth.* 20:17-28). Thus the Old Testament prayer about Esther risking her life for the people foreshadowed Jesus's own giving of his life for the people.

[8] Otto von Falke and Heinrich Frauberger, *Deutsche Schmelzarbeiten des Mittelalters und andere Kunstwerke der kunst-historischen Ausstellung zu Düsseldorf 1902* (Frankfurt a.M., 1904), 77.

[9] Jacob Neusner (transl.), *Ruth Rabbah* (Atlanta, 1989), 126, interp. 5.A.

[10] Romanos the Melode, *Hymnes*, 5 vols., ed. José Grosdidier de Matons (Paris, 1964-1981), 4, 392-5.

[11] *E.g.*, Chrys., *Hom. in Lucam* (PG 61, 781-84); Cyril. Alex., *Comm. in Lucam* 5.8 (PG 72, 800-1).

[12] *Est.* 4:10-11, 15-16. On her risk, see Catherine Brown Tkacz, Ovid, Jerome, and the Vulgate: *SP* 33 (1996) 378-82, 381.

[13] LXX *Est.* 4:17k = Vulg. *Est.* 14:1, i.e., in the 'A' text: Roger David Aus, *Barabbas and Esther and other Studies in the Judaic Illumination of Earliest Christianity*, USF Studies in the History of Judaism 54 (Atlanta, 1992), 9, see also 10, 12, 14, the last associating this with Jesus's agony of the cross.

[14] Emphasis added. Rupert of Deutz also refers to *Est.* 13:8-18 as *oratio Esther* ('Esther's prayer'); *Liber de divinis officiis* 4:15 (CChr.SM 7, 127).

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However, Christian remarks about Esther are rare,[15] and only once is she treated as a type of Christ. Although Quotvultdeus provocatively stated that Esther 'laid down her life for her people', he proceeded to interpret her as a type of the Church.[16] One modern scholar averred that Rupert of Deutz interpreted 'Esther as an allegorical anticipation of Christ'.[17] But, although Rupert did assert that Esther's history is *dominicae passionis typus*,[18] he considered Mordecai to be the type of Christ. Rupert interpreted Esther as a figure of the soul or the Church, not Christ.[19] A single text suggests Esther as a type of Christ: The influential painter's guide, *Pictor in Carmine*, pairs the infant Christ with Esther, who would accomplish the liberation of the people.[20]

Why did Christians not interpret Queen Esther as a type of King Christ in the first or second century of Christianity? The initial obstacle to typological reading of Esther pre-existed the Incarnation: The Septuagint associated a cross with Haman, as T.C.G. Thornton demonstrated.[21] This diction allowed associating the villain Haman with Jesus crucified.

The Septuagint twice uses the verb σταυρόω 'to crucify' with regard to Haman.[22] In addition, three times Septuagint Esther uses the verb κρεμάννυμι, twice with the noun ξύλον,[23] which means 'firewood, timber' and by extension 'the Cross'.[24] Although the verb κρεμάννυμι primarily means 'hang', by pairing it with the phrase ἐπὶ τοῦ ξύλου, the Septuagint clearly indicated crucifixion. Mosaic Law marked that means of death as accursed: *Dtn.* 21:22-3 prescribes removing the criminal's body ἐπὶ τοῦ ξύλου and not leaving it there overnight. Into this law is interjected the statement that everyone who is 'hung on a tree' (κρεμάμενος ἐπὶ τοῦ ξύλου) is cursed by God.

The Evangelist Luke also used κρεμάννυμι to mean 'crucify'.[25] Justin Martyr quotes the addition to Psalm 96 (LXX 95), 'The Lord reigns ἀπὸ τοῦ ξύλου',

[15] Hans Bardtke, *Das Buch Esther*, Kommentar zum Alten Testament 17.5 (Gütersloh, 1963), 257-60.

[16] *Liber promissionum et praedictorum Dei* 86-87: Brian McNeil, Reflections on the Book of Judith: *Downside Review* 96 (1978) 199-207, 205-7.

[17] Karl F. Morrison, *Conversion and Text: The Cases of Augustine of Hippo, Herman-Judah, and Constantine Tsatsos* (Charlottesville, 1992), 39-113, 65-7.

[18] Rupert of Deutz, as in note 14 above.

[19] She is a figure of the soul's humility (*humilitas animae*) in *Commentaria in Canticum canticorum* (CChr.SM 3, 61.41). She was *Mardochei gladius*: *ibid.* (CChr.SM 3, 63.130). Rupert also mentions Esther in *Commentarium in Apocalypsim Johannis apostoli* 7.12 (PL 169, 1044.30), *Liber de divinis officiis* 12 (CChr.SM 7, 416.738), and *De glorificatione trinitas et processione spiritus sancti* 8.9 (PL 169, 169.26 and 50, 170.5, 175.7).

[20] M.R. James, *Pictor in Carmine*, 1951, 153.

[21] Timothy C.G. Thornton, The Crucifixion of Haman and the Scandal of the Cross: *JTS* N.S. 37 (1986) 419-26.

[22] *Est.* 7:9. See also Sept. *Est.* (Rahlfs) 8:12^{r} = Sept. *Est.* (Swete) E^{17,18}; Vulg. *Est.* 16:17-18.

[23] *Est.* 7:10, 8:7, 9:25: T.C.G. Thornton, Crucifixion of Haman (1986), 421 n. 8.

[24] T.C.G. Thornton, Trees, Gibbets, and Crosses: *JTS* N.S. 23 (1972) 130f.

[25] *Luke* 23:39, *Acts* 10:39: T.C.G. Thornton, Crucifixion of Haman (1986), 421 n. 8. In *Luke* 23:39 the participle refers to the men crucified alongside Jesus.

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indicating that Hellenistic Judaism interpreted ξύλον as 'cross'.[26] Christian authors continued to regard Haman's death as a crucifixion: Jerome, Paulinus of Nola, Evagrius, Eucherius of Lyons, Isidore of Seville, Rabanus Maurus, and Sulpicius Severus.[27] This helps explain why Christians interpreted Mordecai as a type of Christ: A cross had been prepared for him.[28]

The Septuagint account of Esther would have been the version most used by Jews during Purim before the Christian Era and for the next five centuries.[29] The roll of Esther was read annually, by men and also by women, as was specified by Rabbi Joshua ben Levi.[30] Thus the prevalent Jewish idea of how Haman died would have been 'by crucifixion'.[31] Certainly Josephus thrice uses σταυρος 'cross' for the means of Haman's execution.[32]

Early midrashim refer to Haman's death as crucifixion, and this interpretation increases in later Jewish commentaries, sometimes with what appears to be derogatory reference to Jesus.[33] Bear in mind that Haman was not merely executed: Ahasuerus publicly proclaimed Haman's execution to be divine retribution: 'God repaying him as he deserved'.[34] Thus for Jews to equate Jesus with Haman was to present Jesus as cursed. Several Jewish exegetical texts compare Haman and Jesus, and Israel Jacob Yuval suggests that 'anti-Christian intentions were involved in shaping at least some' of the contents of the Babylonian Talmud.[35] In Jewish commentaries on Esther, such as *Midrash Panim 'aherim B* from the early eighth century, Haman became a detested spokesman for 'Christian anti-Jewish polemic'.[36]

[26] T.C.G. Thornton, Trees, Gibbets, and Crosses (1972), 131.

[27] *E.g.*, Hieron., *Comm. in Gal.* (on *Gal.* 3:13) in PL 23, 362B: T.C.G. Thornton, Crucifixion of Haman (1986), 421, nn. 9-11, and 422, nn. 13-14.

[28] *Liber de divinis officiis* 4.15 (CChr.SM 7, 126-8).

[29] T.C.G. Thornton, Crucifixion of Haman (1986), 420.

[30] *B Megillah* 4a: T.C.G. Thornton, Crucifixion of Haman (1986), 420, n. 3.

[31] *Pace* Eliot Horowitz, The Rite to Be Reckless: On the Perpetration and Interpretation of Purim Violence: *Politics Today* 15 (1994) 9-54 at n. 36.

[32] Josephus, *Ant. J* 11.267, 280, see also 11.246, 261, 266, 267: T.C.G. Thornton, Crucifixion of Haman (1986), 421, nn. 9-11; T.C.G. Thornton, Trees, Gibbets, and Crosses (1972); R.D. Aus, *Barabbas and Esther* (1992), 11.

[33] See Katrin Kogman-Appel, The Tree of Death and the Tree of Life: The Hanging of Haman in Medieval Jewish Manuscript Painting, in: Colum Hourihane (ed.), *Between the Picture and the Word: Manuscript Studies from the Index of Christian Art* (Princeton, 2005), 187-208, 198-9. See also Edgar Wind, The Crucifixion of Haman: *Journal of the Warburg and Courtauld Institutes* 1 (1937-8) 245-8.

[34] Sept. *Est.* (Rahlfs) 8:12^{r} = Sept. *Est.* (Swete) E$^{17.18}$; Vulg. *Est.* 16:17-18.

[35] Israel Jacob Yuval, *Two Nations in Your Womb: Perceptions of Jews and Christians in Late Antiquity and the Middle Ages* (Berkeley, 2006), 93, 117, 130-1 n. 107, 167, see 58-60, 49-51; quotation from 51.

[36] Barry Dov Walfish, *Esther in Medieval Garb: Jewish Interpretation of the Book of Esther in the Middle Ages*, SUNY Series in Judaica: Hermeneutics, Mysticism and Religion (Albany, 1993), 287 n. 24. Walfish posits that such anti-Jewish statements probably date from the patristic era. Haman is given such speeches later as well, in fifteenth-century Iberian texts, for instance by Abraham Shalom (*Neveh Shalom* 69b) and by Joseph Hayyun, in Portugal: Walfish, 147-9.

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An 'anti-Christian animus' often characterized Purim from late antiquity.[37] By the fifth century A.D. the celebration of Purim could include enacting Haman's execution on a cross, thus making the wicked Haman into a type of Jesus. The Purim Law of 408 required provincial governors to prohibit the Jewish action of 'setting fire to and burning a simulated appearance of the holy cross'.[38] In Syria ca. 415, according to Socrates Scholasticus, a Christian child was hung on a cross, scourged, and died.[39] Response to perceived Jewish anti-Christian mockery at Purim is evident in a Byzantine pre-baptismal formula of abjuration for Jews. The eighth-century formula locates the Jewish festival on the first sabbath of the Christians's Great Fast and repudiates the practice of 'nailing Haman to wood and then mixing with him the emblem of a cross and burning them together, subjecting Christians to all kinds of imprecations and a curse'.[40]

The valiant Esther could have been a type of Christ. Perhaps St. Luke even hinted at that typology in his description of Jesus ἐν ἀγωνίᾳ in Gethsemane. The proximity of Pascha and Purim might have increased Christian appreciation for Esther as a type of Jesus-as-Christ, had not Jews interpreted the malevolent Haman as a type of Jesus-as-villain. Once some celebrations of Purim enacted, in an anti-Christian manner, the Septuagint's association of Haman with a cross, Esther's chance to become one of the women prefiguring Christ diminished. Later, by the fifth century, the Jewish innovation of associating Esther with Psalm 22 as a repudiation of Christian association of that Psalm with Jesus would further distance Christian and Jewish interpretation of Esther.[41] Her typology, hinted by the Lectionary and *Pictor in Carmine*, never developed.

[37] Eliot Horowitz, Purim, in: Carl Lindahl *et al.* (eds.), *Medieval Folklore: An Encyclopedia of Myths, Legends, Tales, Beliefs, and Customs*, 2 vols. (Santa Barbara, 2000; reprinted in 1 vol. in Oxford, 2002), 2, 812-4.

[38] 'Incendere et sanctae crucis adsimulatim speciem', *Cod. Theod. 16.8.18*: T.C.G. Thornton, Crucifixion of Haman (1986), 423 and n. 18. As Thornton notes, the wording of the law is such that it could imply that an effigy of Haman was also burned. See also I.J. Yuval, *Two Nations in Your Womb* (2006), 165-6, citing Eliot Horowitz, 'And It Is Turned Around': Jews against Their Enemies in the Festivities of Purim [in Hebrew]: *Zion* 59 (1994) 129-68. For modern scholarship on this law, see E. Horowitz, Rite to Be Reckless (1994), 24-5 et passim.

[39] T.C.G. Thornton, Crucifixion of Haman (1986), 424; E. Horowitz, Purim (1994), 812.

[40] PG 1, 1457C: T.C.G. Thornton, Crucifixion of Haman (1986), 424.

[41] Catherine Brown Tkacz, Esther, Jesus and Psalm 22: *Catholic Biblical Quarterly* 70 (2008) 709-28.

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Sexuality and Penitence in Syriac Commentaries on Luke's Sinful Woman

Hannah HUNT, Leeds

Romanus the Melode's *Ode 10 on the Sinful Woman* invites us to:
'Behold the harlot whom you see; consider her like the church
Crying out: 'I breathe
On the slime of my deeds.'[1]

Romanus is one of many late antique theological commentators to explore through Luke's 'sinful woman' the dangerous possibility of a woman – and a fallen one at that – as an exegete and enabler of redemption. The 'breathing' suggests not only the liturgical baptismal practice of the priest breathing upon the candidate as he asks, 'Do you renounce Satan?', but also Christ's gift of the Holy Spirit to his disciples.[2] Chapter 7.37-50 of Luke's gospel gives a parable of love and forgiveness and a rebuke to the Pharisee in the story of the 'sinful woman'. The woman approaches Jesus while he sits at table, bathes his feet with her penitent tears, anoints them with myrrh and wipes them with her long, loosened hair. The erotic overtones sharpen the theological message to readers sharing the Pharisee's caution about this woman being contaminating. The parable has been the inspiration for a huge number of theological commentaries in eastern and western Christianity. The starting point for many of those in Syriac seems to be the *Homily on the Sinful Woman*, attributed to Ephrem.[3] Details of the uncertainties surrounding the authorship of this and other texts can be found in my book *Joy-Bearing Grief*, which contains a chapter on this issue.[4]

In addition to the Ephremic corpus, other Syriac Homilies by Jacob of Serug will be referred to. Intriguingly, some Syriac texts introduce as a *dramatis persona* the figure of Satan, occasionally focusing the whole story around 'an externalized account, in dramatized form, of the inner psychological conflict

[1] *Kontakia of Romanus, Byzantine Melodist*, transl. Marjorie Carpenter, vol. 1 (Columbia, 1970), 107.

[2] *John* 20:22.

[3] *Ephrem's Homilies on Our Lord, Admonition and Repentance and The Sinful Woman*, transl. Albert Edward Johnston (Massachusetts, 1995).

[4] Hannah Hunt, *Joy-Bearing Grief: Tears of contrition in the Early Syrian and Byzantine Fathers* (Leiden, 2004).

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through which the woman might be thought to have gone'.[5] Another figure introduced by the Syrian tradition is the perfume seller, who pricks the woman's conscience. The transmission of this personification of sin to the western medieval context remains to be fully determined, but Mahr's *Relations of Passion Plays to St Ephrem the Syrian* (1942) opens the debate.[6] There is a plethora of homilies, verse and otherwise, on this text after Ephrem. Brock notes that this story is one motif that found its way from Syriac literature into Greek texts,[7] and Carpenter notes in her edition of the *Kontakia* of Romanos that this was 'a peculiarly oriental motif'.[8] Why was this story such a popular choice in the late antique Syrian world? Its popularity may be accounted for partially by the curious juxtaposition of ascetic anthropology and penitence: here is a sinner transformed by and through her tears of grief, which not only restore her to God but do so in full integrity as a person with a body, and an attractive one at that, not the ravaged and neglected body of the hermit. This penitent woman becomes a female mouthpiece of incarnational theology. This, together with the recurring and thoroughly Biblical concept of Mary as second Eve, is a powerful antidote to the dominant misogyny and patriarchal emphasis of much of the early Christian period.

A feature of the Syrian texts is the contrast between the superficial questions of Satan, who attempts to tempt the woman with the luxury and worldly prestige she has enjoyed, and the profound self-questioning of the woman. A brief example from a Syriac dialogue poem illustrates this:

Satan: He is holy, while you are unclean:
With the breath of his mouth he will finish you off.
You are entirely befouled with sin:
Why are you going to this holy man?

Woman: He is indeed holy and pure,
There is nothing evil abiding in him.
It is precisely because I am unclean that I go
To this holy man, so that he will make me holy too.[9]

In other texts the contrast is between the silent appeal of her eyes, and Jesus' ability to hear the words of her heart. Jesus sees 'with the interior eye of his divinity'.[10] Her tears speak although her lips remain silent, and her eyes beg without a word

[5] Sebastian Brock, The sinful woman and Satan: two Syriac dialogue poems: *Oriens Christianos* 72 (1988) 21-62.

[6] See my unpublished paper, Wiping the feet of Jesus with her hair: sexuality and penitence in the story of Luke's Sinful Woman, as seen by Ephrem and other Syriac writers, for the XV International Medieval Congress, 2006.

[7] Sebastian Brock, From Ephrem to Romanus: *StP* 20 (1989), 144.

[8] M. Carpenter, *Kontakia* (1970), 99.

[9] S. Brock, The sinful woman (1988), 46.

[10] Jean-Marie Sauget, Une homilie syriaque anonyme sur la Nativité, in: *Parole de l'Orient* VI and VII (1975-6) 159-194, 164.

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being uttered.[11] It is as if the externalized figures of sin and temptation can only find human words to use. The woman herself speaks with her whole body, and thus is her whole body restored and forgiven. It is through the attributes of a desirable woman that she is healed: from the same text, I translate:

Her eyes, indeed, which used to gaze on all sides – are now purified by the tears she lets fall.
Her hair bound her to evil actions – now she renounces them by wiping Jesus' feet with it.
Her lips, which she had soiled by kissing impure mouths – now she is sanctified by using them to kiss the holy feet.[12]

In this encounter between Jesus and the woman, the invisible eye of faith operates. In the *Homily On the Sinful Woman*, the author repeatedly refers to Jesus as: 'He Who knows what is secret'.[13] The 'interior eye of his divinity'[14] enables him to see that the woman's soul is predisposed towards penitence, and a parallel interior vision on the part of the woman enables her to recognize Christ as the Lord, and to plead for spiritual healing. Through her act of physically anointing Jesus' feet she knows he is truly man.[15] The prayer that she offers makes it explicit that it is through the manifestation of his humanity that she dares to approach God.[16] This exchange of unspoken recognition between Jesus and the sinful woman becomes externalized in order to provide evidence of Jesus' humanity and divinity. This is elaborated on in the *Homily On Our Lord*: it is when infirmities are brought into the open that they can be healed; the visible healing symbolizes the invisible healing of forgiveness.[17] The *Commentary on the Diatessaron* notes with regard to the woman with the haemorrhage, (whose story is juxtaposed to that of the sinful woman) that: 'By means of a woman whom they could see, they were enabled to see the divinity which cannot be seen. Through the Son's own healing his divinity became known, and through the healing of the afflicted woman, her faith was made manifest.'[18] These disclosures of Christ's divinity by unclean women can thus be implicitly compared with the revelation effected by the pure Mary, who 'enabled' his divinity to be seen and understood by housing and nourishing his physical body. Women therefore play an essential role in the articulation of Jesus' divinity, as corroborated by the fact that it was Mary Magdelene who sought and found Jesus at dawn on Easter Day.[19]

[11] *Ibid.*, 168.
[12] *Ibid.*, 169.
[13] A.E. Johnston, *Ephrem's Homilies* (1995), 14, 15, 340.
[14] J.M. Sauget, Une homilie (1975-6), 4, 164.
[15] Francois Graffin, Homélies sur la pécheresse: *L'Orient Syrien* 7 (1962) 175-220, 189.
[16] *Ibid.*, 189-91.
[17] A.E. Johnston, *Ephrem's Homilies* (1995), 18-21, 312-4.
[18] *St. Ephrem's Commentary on Tatian's Diatessaron*, transl. Carmel McCarthy: *Journal of Semitic Studies Supplement 2* (1993) 129.
[19] *John* 20:1-2 and 14-16.

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Jacob of Serug adopts yet another approach. In an extended metaphor about Jesus as the 'Hunter' or 'Plowman' of her true soul, the woman engages in an interiorised appeal with Christ himself, which bears no relation to the Lukan original:

The Evil One buried traps for me and caught me with his cunning.
Hunter of Truth, crush them, and I will be yours ...

Into the clear soul which the demons that adhered to it muddied,
Enter, Strong One, and expel them so that I might escape.

I have been a field of thorns in my sins for quite a long time now.
Plowman of Truth, weed out the bitter things from your field.[20]

The language used in this *memra* is extraordinarily sensual, a means of rehabilitating the sensual in the service of God? Jacob uses the theme commonly found in eastern Christian spiritual writings of the fecundity of repentance which repairs the sterility of sin. As in such diverse writers as Ephrem and Symeon the New Theologian, the vivid image of pregnancy and birth emphasizes the powerful nature of this metaphorical re-birth:

The Hunter ran and set traps in the streets she frequented.
He bound her with love so that she might not wander in vain.

He was spreading out a great net of repentance before her.
And she slithered and entered its great womb in naivete.

The message of salvation was bait for the wild woman.
And when she was engrossed in it, she came into the net of the House of God.[21]

The 'net of repentance' is a 'womb' enabling rebirth as a cleansed woman, not a disembodied soul. All the physical attributes of her former profession now permit the fecundity of repentance. The metaphorical eye of faith is what saves the woman:

She bent her head over to wipe his feet with her hair.
And just as in baptism she received holiness from the Holy One.

She entered into the second womb, the place of atonement,
So that in new birth she might become beautiful in a spiritual sense.

She grasped his feet to find a Sea of mercy at the banquet.
She was baptised in him and he cleaned and polished her, and she arose pure ...

Her love brought [her soul] into the crucible of mercy and smelted it there.
Its [refined] gold showed its beauty so that it might be a case ornament to the Lord of Kings.[22]

[20] Scott F. Johnson, The Sinful Woman: a *memra* by Jacob of Serug: *Sobornost* 24 (2002) 56-88, 67.
[21] *Ibid.*, 65.
[22] *Ibid.*, 71-2.

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As Ephrem puts it in Hymn 35 on Virginity:

By that thing by which she was lost, she was found, since she believed,
So that triumphant was the mouth that had condemned her,
And sanctified was the mouth that had defiled her,
And purified was the beauty that had debased her.

So here is a woman who earned her living through her body, earning a new, eternal, life through the correct use of that same body. Through typology this one woman becomes a representative, an exemplum, of redemption for the whole of humanity. The familiar Eve/Mary typology is given fresh emphasis because Jesus alone, and not the Pharisee, recognises her appeal. This revelation of faith and love has also an incarnational message. This is further complicated – or enriched – by what Marina Warner calls 'the muddle of Marys', in other words, the conflation of Marys in the gospel narratives and subsequent tradition.[23] Szoverffy's long analysis of 160 Magdalene hymns, and their use of legendary motifs, offers the useful insight that: 'the unity of this figure was accepted in the West from the time of Gregory the Great, but this view was never shared by the Eastern Church, and in France it was challenged in the XVIth century.'[24]

He also provides a useful list of panegyrical phrases and 'catchwords' used to denote Mary, including 'Peccatrix', 'Apostola', Nuntia, not to mention the *sponsa* of Christ. Interestingly, he notes that the dominant theme in these hymns is her conversion at the house of Simon, supposing her therefore to be Luke's sinful woman.[25] But is it as simple as this? Who is the sinful woman, and is she the same as Mary Magdalene? *Matth.* 26:6-13, *Mark* 14:3-9, *Luke* 7:36-50 and *John* 12:1-11 need to be considered for a full understanding of the various identities of women who anoint Jesus. Benedicta Ward has given an excellent account of medieval conflations of these characters.[26] Ephrem's *Commentary on Tatian's Diatessaron* juxtaposes the woman with a haemorrhage (whose faith, like the sinful woman's, supersedes her contamination) and the Samaritan woman at the well (another effectively unclean woman who comes close to Jesus in an act of service). If we look at the issue of anointing we must start with Susan Ashbrook Harvey's *Why the Perfume mattered*, and recognise the priestly connotations of anointing, and resurrection motif of the myrrophores.[27] Scott Johnson argues that: 'The Sinful Woman becomes a model for all Christians, and in her "baptism" – that is, her humble anointing

[23] Marina Warner, *Alone of All Her Sex* (London, 1976), 344-5

[24] Joseph Szövérffy, 'Peccatrix Quondam Femina': A Survey of the Mary Magdalen Hymns: *Traditio* 19 (1963) 79-146, 84.

[25] *Ibid.*, 95-6.

[26] Benedicta Ward, *Harlots of the Desert* (Kalamazoo, Michigan, 1987), 10-25.

[27] Susan Ashbrook Harvey, Why the Perfume Mattered: The Sinful Woman in Syriac Exegetical Tradition, in: *Essays in Honour of R.L. Wilken*, ed. P. Blowers (Grand Rapids, 2002), 69-89.

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of Jesus with oil and tears – she prefigures the baptism of the whole world symbolically.'[28]

This theme is corroborated by Kathleen McVey in her translation of Ephrem's *Hymns:* 'The anointing of Jesus by the sinful woman, perhaps to be identified here with Mary, sister of Martha, is placed in a line with priestly and royal messiahship, as well as being a model of forgiveness.'[29]

The significance of these key theological insights is considerable. Luke's account is of an anonymous woman, who trespasses the Pharisee's house, offers him the hospitality which his righteous host had failed to do, and does it in a peculiarly intimate way, using her own body – expressly, her own hair which a respectable woman would have kept covered – to acknowledge the humanity and divinity of Christ as well as her grief for her sin. Her act of love is understood only by Christ himself, and Luke makes this the basis for a parable on love and forgiveness. The Syrian commentators introduce personified aspects of the woman's repentance, or a dialogue between the woman and her own heart, or an inchoate appeal to Jesus. These texts illustrate the making visible the invisible – not just the 'eye of faith' but the whole dynamic of the incarnation. Superimposed upon this are liturgical 'messages', the baptism of tears, and the anointing with oil, suggesting an almost priestly role for this woman, whose ambiguous identity allows for various interpretations.

All this is set in the context of an evolving hagiography of penitent harlot saints: as Ashbrook Harvey asks, is this exegesis or hagiography? Perhaps we cannot answer this without more research, and instead maybe we can suggest that this anonymous woman could share with Mary Magdalen the high title of *apostola apostolorum.*

[28] S.F. Johnson, The Sinful Woman (2002), 57.
[29] Kathleen E. McVey, *Ephrem the Syrian: Hymns* (New York, 1989), 376.

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Blood and Holy Communion: Late Antique Use of *Luke* 8:42-8

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The anonymous woman with a twelve-year issue of blood has been used or manipulated by commentators, exegetes, and canon lawyers to both justify and condemn the exclusion of menstruating women from the reception of Holy Communion or even entering the Christian liturgical space.[1] She has been jostled, pushed, and pulled by later authors much as she was by the crowd during her original encounter with Christ. It remains to be seen whether she will ever be left alone or will continue to be torn in opposite directions by the devotional, liturgical, and spiritual uses to which she – and her image – is put.

The woman appears in *Luke* 8:42-8 (and its cognate periscopes[2]) as Jesus is going from exorcising the Gadarene demoniacs to raising Jairus's daughter from the dead. Although remaining nameless, the woman was later identified as coming from Caesarea Philippi. Eusebius describes, in his Book 7 of the *Ecclesiastical History*, that she 'was a native of this city' and 'the wonderful monuments of our Savior's benefit to her are still remaining.'[3] Before the gate of the house identified as hers, there is a bronze statue on an elevated stone pedestal, which depicts her kneeling before Christ, hands outstretched in supplication. Opposite her is a statue of Christ, 'clad in a mantle and stretching out his hand to the woman.' Furthermore, a 'certain strange plant' is growing through the stone in front of the woman and reaching up as high as the hem of the bronze garment of the Christ-figure; this plant is an 'antidote to all kinds of diseases.'

The next apparent mention of the *haemorrhoissa* is in the canonical letter of Dionysius of Alexandria. A pupil of Origen, Dionysius became bishop of Alexandria in 247 C.E. and served until his death in 264/5.[4] The canonical letter

[1] See *Apost. Const.* VI 5.27; *Dionysius of Alexandria*, Canon II; *Timothy of Alexandria*, Canons 6 and 7; *John the Faster*, Canon 17.

[2] *Luke* 8:40-8, *Matth.* 9:18-23; *Mark* 5:24-34. By this juxtaposition of incidents, the gospels seem to be making the identification of demon-possession, illness, and death. *Healing*, having the same Greek root as *wholeness* and *salvation*, is a euphemism for deliverance from sin, evil, and destruction.

[3] Euseb. Caes., *HE* VII 18. English transl. in C.F. Cruse, *The Ecclesiastical History of Eusebius Pamphilus* (London, 1892), 273.

[4] Euseb. Caes., *HE* VI 35. See C.F. Cruse, *The Ecclesiastical History of Eusebius Pamphilus* (1892), 238.

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was written approx. 260 C.E. and deals with four issues, including whether a woman ought to enter Christian churches during her menstrual cycle. Dionysius tells us that it is superfluous to even ask such a question because a 'faithful and pious' woman in such a state would not dare to either 'approach the Holy Table or touch the body and blood of Christ.'[5] He justifies this opinion by pointing out that 'not even the woman with a twelve-years issue would come into actual contact with him but only with the edge of his garment, to be cured.'[6] He continues that there is no objection to anyone praying to or remembering the Lord at any time or in any state whatsoever, but it is only appropriate to enter the Holy of Holies if one is totally clean in both soul and body.

Dionysius takes for granted that the physical aspect of a person is the direct expression or reflection of the spiritual, inner reality. Following in the footsteps of his master, Origen, Dionysius here seems to assume that the material flux and instability so obvious during a woman's menstrual cycle is akin to the spiritual instability and flux which results in the soul's fall from Paradise and taking a body in the first place. Only by regaining both physical and spiritual stability, motionlessness and *apatheia,* can spiritual growth be fostered or spiritual encounter even possible. One can dare to approach God only after an act of ascetic repentance, of turning from death or sin to life, similar to the necessity of mastering ascetic, practical knowledge before daring to attempt 'true theology'. There is also the influence of Alexandrian exegesis of Jesus's condemnation of hypocrisy: 'There is nothing outside a man which by going into him can defile him; but the things which come out of a man are what defile him.' (*Mark* 7:15, also *Matth.* 15:11) The Alexandrines were concerned that those things which came out of a person – such as semen or blood – were those which defiled one;[7] perhaps these things which came out of a person were seen as allegorical tie-ins with those other things which came out of people – lust, pride, anger, jealousy, arrogance – defiling and making them inappropriate participants in the Eucharistic banquet.[8]

Slightly later and further east than Dionysius, John Chrysostom in his *Homily 31 on Matthew*,[9] spends some time discussing various aspects of the woman's encounter with Christ. He begins by describing the woman's shame at her condition, reminding his congregation that the woman was 'unclean' according to the law of *Leviticus* 15:25 and that, being the first woman to

[5] Dion. Alex., *Canon II.* English transl. in D. Cummings, *The Rudder* (Chicago, 1957), 718-20.

[6] Dion. Alex., *Canon II.*

[7] An affiliated concern with semen and blood as barriers to ritual participation in Jewish thought and practice, though fascinating, is beyond the scope of this paper.

[8] Stephen Morris, Sex and Holy Communion: *SP* 40 (2006) 63-8.

[9] This series of sermons is dated 390 C.E. and set in Antioch by J.N.D. Kelly, *Golden Mouth: The Story of John Chrysostom – Ascetic, Preacher, Bishop* (New York, 1995), 90, 100. English transl. of the sermon based on or taken from that in *NPNF, first series*, vol. 10, 205-10.

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approach Christ in public, she did not realize how all-knowing he was and that she would not escape undetected. However, seeing him emerge from the house of tax-collectors, she had reason to hope that he would not reject the likes of her.[10] Chrysostom goes on to point out that even though she was wealthy, she was humble and did not think to invite Christ to her house. Not only was she humble, she had more faith than Jairus, who had come to invite Christ to his home in order to heal the ailing daughter. Confident of his power to heal, she did not think it necessary to do more than simply reach out and touch him.

Why did Christ insist on making public what the woman had done? Chrysostom asks. To exhibit her faith to the crowd and to Jairus, in particular. Jairus's faith, like that of his household servants, was doubtless wavering and needed bolstering. No doubt the synagogue official was also becoming anxious and angry at the delay; Christ wanted to reassure him that with faith, the delay would be of no consequence to the answering of his petition. Indeed, Chrysostom tells his hearers that it was because of her great faith, surpassing that of the ruler of the synagogue, that she merited the title, 'daughter.' Before continuing to comment on Jesus's encounter with Jairus and his deceased daughter, however, Chrysostom pauses to point out that by touching Christ's garments (and through them his body), and provoking his response, 'Who touched me?' the woman was also demonstrating the reality of the incarnation and the humility of Christ. He did not announce himself what had happened but gave the woman a chance to proclaim the good news of what had happened and not 'incur suspicion by saying it' himself. Divine humility and incarnation, physical encounter leading to healing and salvation, and the proclamation or preaching of this good news: the encounter of the woman in *Luke* 8 with Christ is the proclamation of the Gospel in miniature.

Roughly contemporaneous with and from the same vicinity as Chrysostom's preaching in Antioch are the *Apostolic Constitutions*.[11] In Book VI 28, the 'apostles' point out that a woman's menstrual cycle is given by God both for the fertility of mankind and the good health of each woman and that as a purely practical measure most women will stay at home more and move around less during their 'monthly purgation.'[12] Furthermore, husbands should avoid intercourse with their wives during their cycle 'out of regard for the children to be begotten.' This injunction is based both on *Leviticus* (18:19, 'Do not come near your wife when she is in her separation') and current medical theory which claimed that a child begotten during his mother's monthly bleeding would be

[10] In *Matthew* 9:18-23, the meeting of the *haemorrhoissa* follows Christ's calling of Matthew the tax-collector (*Matth.* 9:9) and then dining at his home in the company of 'many tax collectors and sinners' (*Matth.* 9:10-3).

[11] David A. Fiensy, *Prayers Alleged to Be Jewish: An Examination of the 'Apostolic Constitutions'* (Chico, California, 1985), 19-20.

[12] English transl. based on or taken from *ANF* VII 462-3.

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infirm or worse.[13] But they are quick to point out that this does not imply a divine injunction against associating with such women, for the Lord was 'not angry' with the woman who touched his garment, 'but healed her' commending her faith.[14] This, in fact, comes after a lengthy meditation on the error of the heretics who insist that a menstruating woman ought not partake of the Eucharist or pray or touch a Bible or enter a church. Such bleeding is ordained by God and does not drive away the divine Spirit, which would render damned a woman who died during her period.[15]

Cyril of Alexandria's *Commentary on Luke* expands on this,[16] comparing the woman's faith to that of Jairus.[17] Cyril, in fact, describes a more intricate dance of faith than has been described heretofore in our texts. Jairus's faith prompts hers and then Christ makes hers an example for Jairus.[18] Cyril points out that the miracle – as well as Christ's knowledge that power had gone forth from Him – demonstrates the divinity of Christ. Cyril goes on to elaborate how Christ's response ('Daughter, your faith has saved you: go in peace') is also for Jairus's benefit: it is faith, not the observance of the sacrificial rites, like that of the *haemorrhoissa* which won even Abraham the enviable title, 'friend of God.'[19]

The image of the *haemorrhoissa* was used in homilies and liturgical texts, canon law and art in a variety of ways. She is used to justify excluding menstruating women from Holy Communion (Dionysius). She is used to justify the reception of Holy Communion by menstruating women (*Apostolic Constitutions*). She is both an example of, and demonstration of, the faith in the healing power of Christ that a Christian ought to hold (John Chrysostom and Cyril of Alexandria). Her act of faith is also an opportunity for Christ to demonstrate the reality of the incarnation and the interaction of human and divine (John Chrysostom).

It is this interaction of human and divine realities that is problematic at the root of all these texts. Those which seek to exclude menstruating women from this interaction see this divine-human encounter as dangerous and are acting to protect the menstruating women, as well as God Himself. The women risk self-destruction if they approach Christ, present in either the Holy Communion or both the liturgical space and the community of believers, in an unfit state. For them to touch Christ would be almost like the interaction of matter and anti-matter; while Christ might not be destroyed in the resulting explosive power released, the women certainly would be and the divinity would at least

[13] Gillian Clark, *Women in Late Antiquity: Pagan and Christian Lifestyles* (Oxford, 1994), 197-9.

[14] *Apost. Const.* VI 28; English transl. based on *ANF* VII 463.

[15] *Apost. Const.* VI 27; English transl. based on *ANF* VII 462.

[16] English transl. by R. Payne Smith available in *Commentary of the Gospel of Saint Luke by Saint Cyril of Jerusalem* (Studion Publishers, Inc., no place given, 1983).

[17] Cyril. Alex., *Homily 45 on Luke*; transl. in Smith, 198.

[18] Cyril. Alex., *Homily 45 on Luke*; transl. in Smith, 199.

[19] Cyril. Alex., *Homily 45 on Luke*; transl. based on Smith, 199.

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suffer at least a damaged reputation (as the slayer of menstruating women). The women temporarily estranged from the Christian liturgical life would be able to resume their normal place in Christian society as soon as the immediate danger was past. The decision to exclude these women is more than simple *misogyny* or the exercise of male privilege (since men were also excluded form Holy Communion by these same authors if they had engaged in sexual intercourse the night before the Eucharist)[20] or an expression of late antique Christianity's love-hate relationship with the physical world and sexuality. These attempts to keep danger at bay should be read as attempts to protect humanity from annihilation. It is a common theme in Byzantine liturgical texts that reception of Holy Communion is a two-edged sword and can lead to damnation as well as salvation.[21] It is for the eternal welfare of both the individual women as well as the larger Christian community that these barriers were erected and the image of the *haemorrhoissa* used to bolster them. If even a bleeding woman with as much faith as evidenced by her encounter recorded in *Luke* 8 could not actually touch Christ, but only his garments, how could those Christians with so much more tepid a faith dare to touch what she did not?

Likewise, those texts which use the *haemorrhoissa* to encourage menstruating women to receive Holy Communion took the reality of this divine-human encounter seriously and wanted nothing to stand in the way of extending the healing and salvation available to humanity as the natural result of the incarnation. Why should the natural cycle of menstruation, ordained by God at the creation, stand in the way of appropriating such divine presence into the personal life of the believing women? While the encounter with Christ might be dangerous, it was also salvific. The texts of the *Constitutions*, Gregory's epistle, and John Damascene's prayer neither bar men from Communion after sex nor stress the dangerous aspect of Communion.

Rather, the texts that cite the *haemorrhoissa* as an example of faith are the ones that also stress the danger of encounter with Christ even as they urge the faithful to attempt such an audacious act of intimacy with the divine Other. The *haemorrhoissa* is an example to men as well as women in developing their relationship with the divine. All Christians, according to these authors, ought to be as bold, as daring, as trusting in the mercy and *philanthropia* of Christ as this woman was. Even as sinful humans must be protected from dangerous, unmediated contact with divinity, so must these same sinful humans reach out for and embrace that divine Other with carefree abandon. It is a chance that they (or we) all have to take.

[20] S. Morris, Sex and Holy Communion: *SP* 40 (2006) 63-8.

[21] Joh. Chrys., in his *anaphora* and 'Prayer Before Communion'; English translation available in *The Divine Liturgy According to St. John Chrysostom, with appendices* (New York, 1967), 67, 102; For the accuracy of the attribution of the anaphora to Chrysostom, see Robert Taft, The Authenticity of the Chrysostom Anaphora Revisited: Determining the Authorship of Liturgical Texts by Computer: *OCP* 56 (1990) 5-51.

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Orthodox Corruption? *John* 1:18

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In the last hundred years it has been common enough to treat a patristic text as a prolegomenon to dogmatics, as a diseased branch of philosophy, or as a phenomenon of the late antique; it is seldom allowed that it might be a legitimate exercise in the harmonization and elucidation of scriptural testimonies, though the majority of the surviving works were undoubtedly undertaken with this purpose. The Fathers have been banished to the other side of the wall which they themselves built round the 27 books of our New Testament; those who have colonized this demesne for profit do not care to know what lay outside it in antiquity. It has been the great merit of such scholars as Bart Ehrman[1] to remind the professional student of the New Testament that this volume has a history, that but for the triumph of a certain party in the early Christian world we should have no canon, and that our text of the works which constitute that canon acquired its present stability only because its readings were accepted by the victors. He argues that the text which they endorsed was not in every case the original, and that where the scribal tradition showed two readings in the fourth century, the one that prevailed will have been the beneficiary of orthodox favour, perhaps the product of orthodox corruption. This theory I believe to be irrefutable for the same reasons that make it unprovable: my object here is not to refute or prove, but to present my Sabbath-gleanings on the reception of a particular verse, *John* 1:18, which to my mind sit uneasily with a theory of corruption in the interests of any one sect.

The two readings that vie for dominance are *monogenês huios* and *monogenês theos*.[2] Ehrman holds that the former is the original, notwithstanding the unanimous testimony of the Alexandrian tradition to the latter. Against those who contend that the reading *monogenês theos*, which entails the existence of

[1] Bart D. Ehrman, *The Orthodox Corruption of Scripture: The Effect of Early Christological Controversies on the Text of the New Testament* (New York, 1996).

[2] *John* 1:18: 'the only-(begotten) *theos* who is in the bosom of the Father': Vaticanus, Sinaiticus and many others. 'The only-(begotten) *huios*': most Latin codices. Also attested: *monogenês* and *monogenês huios theos* (found in early Syriac MSS). On the preponderance of good MSS in favour of *theos* see Charles K. Barrett, *The Gospel according to John* (London, 1956) and Bruce Metzger, *A Textual Commentary on the Greek New Testament* (London and New York, 1971), *ad loc.* Barrett, however, holds that the sequel implies *monogenês huios*, while Metzger records a dissenting opinion. For discussion see B.D. Ehrman, *The Orthodox Corruption of Scripture* (1996), 78-82.

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a second God besides the Father, would not be invented if it were not already present in the text, he replies that Christians in the second century, being for the most part Gentiles, were more ready to entertain the notion of two gods than their Jewish predecessors. The argument that *monogenês* already carries the implication of sonship, so that *huios* would be a superfluous addition, is rightly dismissed on the grounds that the basic meaning of *monogenês* is unique, not 'only-begotten'; one might add that if this were any argument against *monogenês huios* being the author's phrase, it would be as good an argument against its being inserted by a scribe. He observes that the spurious reading *monogenês theos* is cited both by Gnostics and by their calumniators, and thus concludes that Alexandrian Christians, whether catholic or Gnostic, employed it in opposition to the adoptionists, who (in Ehrman's view) retained the more primitive *monogenês huios* because it did not imply that Jesus had been anything more than a human plenipotentiary of God.

A longer or more technical discussion would no doubt have explained why the reading *monogenês theos* did not gain additional strength, as Metzger had already argued, from its presence in two-newly discovered manuscripts.[3] Again, it might have explained why the adoptionists, who did not deny that Christ became God but only that he was born so, would have been averse to the reading *monogenês theos*. The conjecture that *monogenês huios* arose by assimilation to *John* 3:16 could perhaps be countered, as Ehrman hints, by positing a similar assimilation to *John* 1:1 to engender the bastard reading *monogenês theos*. What ought, I think, to be made more evident, even in a discussion of such small compass, is the identity of those Christians who might have superimposed the text that implied a second god on one that carried no intimation of ditheism. What we know of the ramification of Christian thought in the second century surely confirms what the history of citation indicates – that, if the reading *monogenês theos* is not original, it will have been the invention of those who are commonly known as Gnostics, so that, if there was 'corruption', it was hardly 'orthodox'. This objection, while not fatal to Ehrman's thesis, cannot be ignored, as it was offered in suppose of a verdict contrary to his by the man who first detected a 'corruption by the orthodox' in *John* 1:18.

Dean John William Burgon is remembered in the world of letters only for a frivolous couplet styling Petra, 'a rose-red city half as old as time'.[4] He was not, as this line suggests, a fundamentalist, but he was a disciple of the Oxford Movement, and as learned in Greek as any of its champions. The works that have caused a whole society to be named after him are his philippics against

[3] See B. Metzger, *A Textual Commentary* (1971), 17.

[4] John William Burgon, *Petra: A Prize Poem* (Oxford, 1845): 'Match me such marvel, save in eastern clime, / A rose-red city half as old as time.' Alleged on an internet site to have 'disappeared into obscurity' [by way of Oriel College, Oxford] after writing this sonnet, Burgon is also the eponym of a society devoted to the history of academic dress.

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the Greek text which underlay a new English version of the Bible, designed for use in Anglican churches. The hardy, but not immortal, offspring of this enterprise were the Revised and Revised Standard Versions: Burgon's tracts were debated, then admired, then briefly lamented before they passed into an oblivion which the more erudite justified by obloquy. Bruce Metzger, however, does less than justice to Burgon's scholarship when he accuses him of relying on a poll of manuscripts, failing to 'comprehend' the 'force of the genealogical method' and deploying only 'speculative' or 'theological' methods.[5] For Burgon it is the not the amanuenses but the doctors of the early Church – the authorities whose suffrage still determined the limits of the Biblical canon for the revisers – who can give the surest testimony to the content of those manuscripts from which our extant manuscripts, including Vaticanus and Sinaiticus, are derived.[6] The revisers appealed to one or both of these fourth-century codices to justify almost every deviation in their own text from the Greek archetype translated in the standard English version authorised by James I. To Burgon both were supposititious relics, proved by manifest inconsistencies to be riddled with errors and left to gather dust in ancient times for that very reason. The citations of the New Testament in Fathers, on the other hand, both before and after the dates when blundering copyists had produced the Vaticanus and Sinaiticus, would be found to agree more often than the two codices agreed with one another, and on all but a few occasions to give unanimous attestation to the *textus receptus* against the factitious Greek of Westcott and Hort, which was the idol of the revisers. It is obvious that, for all his assiduity and the brilliance of his invective, Burgon's method is utopian, not only because the Fathers are not in fact so much at one as he maintains, but because the majority of their works survive in manuscripts much later than the original, and no less prone to erroneous transcription or deliberate harmonization to match the scribe's memory of the Gospel than the manuscripts of the New Testament itself. For all that, it remains true that if infallible texts of the Fathers could be prepared, and if an exhaustive collation of their works were possible, this would deliver us the palladium which scholars of Burgon's day professed to have found in Vaticanus and Sinaiticus. The soundness of his method is admitted by textual commentaries, like that of Metzger himself, in which the Fathers are cited copiously to justify readings at odds with those which Burgon claimed to have proved on their authority.

Burgon holds that *monogenês huios* was the true reading, and that, since it so plainly indicated the primacy of the one God who is also the creator the

[5] B. Metzger, *The Canon of the New Testament* (Oxford, 1968), 136: 'What Burgon was apparently unable to comprehend was the force of the genealogical method, by which the later, conflated text is demonstrated to be secondary and corrupt. Instead of following the text of the few earlier manuscripts, Burgon preferred the readings supported by the majority of the later witnesses.'

[6] J.W. Burgon, *The Revision Revised* (reprint, New Jersey, 2000), 1-29.

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Valentinians 'depraved' it by the superimposition of the noun *theos*.[7] Eusebius knowingly countenanced both readings,[8] but the Fathers of the fourth century showed a marked, though not exclusive, predilection for the reading that was now in accordance with their own theology. Thus he alleges not so much a 'corruption by the orthodox' as a willing appropriation of a fraud that originated with the heretics. Burgon thus agrees with Ehrman that *theos* is the intruder, though in his view the orthodox were dupes of the forger rather than his accomplices, and it was only Valentinus whose theology prescribed the erroneous reading.

But when, if this is true, did it become the orthodox variant? Irenaeus is not so pertinacious in the reading *monogenes huios* as he is in his condemnation of Valentinus and his heirs. If, however, he formed a strong opinion on this question, it was occluded by a weak memory. Arguing at *Adversus Haereses* IV 20.6 for the indivisible unity of the Godhead, he appeals to *John* 1:18 in the form *Deum nemo vidit umquam, nisi unigenitus Filius, qui est in sinu Patris: ipse enarravit.* Four paragraphs later (*AH* IV 20.10), to illustrate the Son's power to reveal the Father, he repeats the quotation, except that it now reads *Unigenitus Deus, qui est in sinu Patris, ipse enarravit.* He cites the verse once elsewhere (*AH* III 12.6), reading *Unigenitus Filius Dei*; one might have thought that if any of these three variants had been adopted with a motive, it would have been maintained with zeal. It may be, of course, that the scribes have meddled with the original readings, but if that is so, we cannot say which is the true one, and we shall be obliged in any case to admit that a scribe who falsified the words of an apostle so inconsistently cannot have done so in any factious spirit.

It was not in fact the position of Irenaeus that survived intact to set the episcopal norm for by the beginning of the fifth century this admitted speculations that Irenaeus had found unpalatable and excluded or qualified much that he and his favoured predecessors had asserted without misgiving. It would therefore have been possible for a reading that he had sanctioned inadvertently to become a phylactery of orthodox teaching. But if the reading *monogenês theos* were tendentiously espoused by the Nicene party of the fourth century (this being what we now call the orthodoxy of that epoch), it would have been natural for opponents of the Nicene proclamation of Christ's divinity – men who were stigmatized as Arians by the Nicene party, and sometimes as adoptionists[9] – to

[7] J.W. Burgon, *Causes of Corruption of the New Testament Text* (Lafayette, IN, 1998, reprinted from: *The Traditional Text of the Gospels Vindicated and Edited*, London, 1896), 96: 'In verse 14 [John] had said that "*The Word was made flesh*", a statement which Valentinus was willing to admit. But the heretic and his followers denied that the Word was also the Son of God. As if to bar the door against this pretence, S. John in verse 18 announces that "*the only-begotten Son, who is in the bosom of the Father, He has declared Him*". So he establishes the identity of the Word and the only-begotten Son. What else could the Valentinians do with so plain a statement, but to seek to deprave it?' For the phrase 'corruption by the orthodox' see p. 95.

[8] Thus 'Son' at *In Iesaiam* 36.3 Ziegler; 'God' at *In Iesaiam* 378.39 Ziegler.

[9] See Athanasius, *Against the Arians* 2.11-12 on the interpretation of *Acts* 2:36.

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exhibit a vigorous preference for the reading *monogenês huios*. Yet this is so far from being the case that *monogenês theos* is the only variant that appears in the *Apology* of Eunomius, who notoriously held that the Second Person of the Trinity is not only a lesser being than the First but a creature of a different species. Either the alternative was unknown to him – which is to say that the Alexandrian tradition must have eclipsed all its competitors in the distant and important city of Cyzicus – or else it was no more evident to him than to Irenaeus that his theology entailed a particular reading of this verse.

Even the Alexandrian tradition is not cohesive. Clement, according to Staehlin, appears to know only *monogenês huios* (*Stromateis* I 25.169.4 at II 105.25 Staehlin), sometimes shortened to *monogenês* in his own glosses. The reading of Heracleon is uncertain, while Theodotus, in successive paragraphs, has first *monogenes theos,* then *monogenês huios* (*Excerpta* 6-7, at III 107.20 and 108.8 Staehlin). Origen consistently accepts *monogenês theos*, though in paraphrase this expands *to huios theou*, 'son of God', as in Irenaeus (*Commentary on John* Fr. 17 Preusschen). There are no compelling grounds, then for the imputation of forgery to any early Christian writer now considered orthodox.

Patristic scholarship can, however, perform a service to biblical criticism by upholding the proper sense of the term *monogenes*, which even in the fourth century can be rendered by *unicus* as often as by *unigenitus*. Among the enormities that even Burgon did not foresee was the creation of the New Revised Standard Version, in which *John* 1:18 receives a new wording: 'God the only Son'.[10] This is not a translation of a conflated text (though such existed, and are known to be inauthentic), but an application of Raymond Brown's false rendering of *monogenes* as 'only Son' in his Cyclopean commentary on John. Such bungling shows how much today's Biblical scholars stand to lose when they build high walls around their own discipline: so long as books like those of Ehrman and Burgon are excluded from this Eden, it is likely to produce more weeds than flowers.

[10] 'God the only son': see NRSV and Raymond Brown, *The Gospel according to John, Chapters I-XII* (New York, 1966), *ad loc.*

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On the Use of *Luke* 10:38-42 – Jesus in the House of Mary and Martha – for Instruction in Contemplative Prayer in the Patristic Tradition

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The first known English instruction in contemplative prayer, 'The Cloud of Unknowing',[1] refers to the Mary and Martha story (*Luke* 10:38-42), but even before that such a use of the story had a longstanding development in East and West. Clement of Alexandria (150-215) introduced the idea of contemplation in his interpretation of the passage.[2] Origen (185-254) first used this passage as a comparison of the active and contemplative lives.[3] On the history of the Lukan passage in the West one can read, e.g., the expositions in the two volumes on mysticism by Bernard McGinn,[4] the publications of Beverly Kienzle,[5] Daniel Csányi,[6] Alfons Kemmer,[7] Alois Maria Haas,[8] Dietmar Mieth,[9] Giles

[1] *The Cloud of Unknowing* 18, in: *The Cloud of Unknowing and Other Works / translated with an introduction and notes by Anthony Colin Spearing* (New York, 2001), 42f.

[2] Clem. Alex., *Liber quis dives salvetur*, 10 (PG 9, 613C-D). Clement of Alexandria applied the text of Luke in writing that God bids people make their free choice for obedient longing toward God and His grace, which is absolutely necessary for completing the circle of virtues in order to receive everlasting life. Even though one may argue that by doing this Clement hints at the very core of contemplative prayer here, nothing is said directly to indicate that the longing for God occurs through contemplative prayer. Clément d'Alexandria, *Les Stromates* (SC 30, 38, 278-279, 428, 446, 463). Even though one may guess that Clement of Alexandria hints at the passage of Luke in his *Stromatae* because of the similarity of the ideas, there is no direct reference to *Luke* 10:38-42 anywhere in the *Stromatae*.

[3] Orig., *Scholia in Lucam* 10 (PG 17, 353A-B).

[4] Bernard McGinn, *The Foundations of Mysticism* (New York, 1991), 69, 106, 126, 215, 249, 257; *id.*, *The Growth of Mysticism* (New York, 1994), 76, 143, 184, 185, 214, 222, 223, 278, 315, 356.

[5] Beverly Mayne Kienzle, *The Sermon* (red.), *Typologie des Sources du Moyen Âge Occidental*, (Turnhout, 2000), 81-3.

[6] Daniel Csányi, Optima Pars: Die Auslegungsgeschichte von *Lk* 10, 38-42 bei den Kirchenvätern der ersten vier Jahrhunderte: *Studia Monastica* 2 (1960) 5-78.

[7] Alfons Kemmer, Maria und Martha: Zur Deutungsgeschichte von *Lk* 10,38ff. im alten Mönchtum: *Erbe und Auftrag* (1964) 355-67.

[8] Alois Maria Haas, Die Beurteilung der Vita contemplativa und activa in der Dominikanermystik des 14. Jahrhunderts, in: *Gottleiden – Gottlieben: Zur volkssprachlichen Mystik im Mittelalter* (Frankfurt a. M., 1989), 97-108.

[9] Dietmar Mieth, *Die Einheit von Vita activa und Vita contemplativa in den deutschen Predigten und Traktaten Meister Eckharts und bei Johannes Tauler: Untersuchungen zur Struktur des christlichen Lebens*, Studien zur Geschichte der kath. Moraltheologie 15 (Regensburg,

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Constable,[10] Cuthbert Butler,[11] Blake R. Heffner,[12] Maurice de Gandillac,[13] Marcel Viller and Karl Rahner,[14] Theodore Camelot and Ignatius Mennessier,[15] and Mary Elizabeth Mason.[16] In Eastern monasticism there also exists a long tradition of employing the story of Mary and Martha in speaking of contemplative prayer, though so far no special scholarly study has appeared on the Byzantine exegesis which interprets the passage in terms of mental prayer. Famous authors, including Basil the Great (ca 330 – 379),[17] Evagrius Ponticus (346-399),[18] Macarius of Egypt (300-391),[19] Abba Isaiah (fourth century) (Word 21 'On Repentance', ch. 19),[20] the disciple of Symeon the New Theologian Nikitas Stithatos (eleventh century),[21] and Theophylact of Bulgaria (d. 1107) (On the Gospel of Luke, ch. 10),[22] employed and elaborated the interpretations of the story in writing on contemplative life. In these reflections on the figures of Mary and Martha the accepted line of interpretation in Orthodoxy, which views the deed of Mary as spiritually higher than that of Martha, predominates. Moreover, this point of view is consolidated in the Orthodox liturgical reading for Theotokos holidays. By combining this passage with *Luke* 11:27-28 ('Blessed is the womb ...') as the established and inseparable Gospel readings

1969), 29-117 ('Die Vorgeschichte des Modells Vita activa – Vita contemplativa'; 30-44 on Aristotle, 39f. on Plato).

[10] Giles Constable, 'The sisters together,' The Interpretation of Mary and Martha, in: *Three Studies in Medieval Religious and Social Thought* (Cambridge, 1995), 1-142.

[11] Cuthbert Butler, *Western Mysticism: The Teaching of Augustine, Gregory and Bernard on Contemplation and the Contemplative Life*, second edition with afterthoughts (New York, ²1966 [¹1922]), 157-223.

[12] Blake R. Heffner, Meister Eckhart and a Millennium with Mary and Martha, in: *Biblical Hermeneutics in Historical Perspective*, ed. Mark S. Burrows / Paul Rorem (Grand Rapids, 1991), 117-30.

[13] Maurice de Gandillac, Deux Figures Eckhartiennes de Marthe, in: *Métaphysique: Histoire de la philosophie. Receuil d'Etudes offert à F. Brunner* (Neuchâtel, 1981), 119-34.

[14] Marcel Viller / Karl Rahner, *Aszese und Mystik in der Väterzeit: Ein Abriß* (Freiburg i. Br., 1939 [= 1989]).

[15] Theodore Camelot, Action et Contemplation dans la tradition chrétienne: *La Vie Spirituelle* 327 (1948) 272-301. Theodore Camelot / Ignatius Mennessier, Aktives und kontemplatives Leben, in: *Die katholische Glaubenswelt* II: Moraltheologie (Freiburg i. Br., 1960), 961-94.

[16] Mary Elizabeth Mason, *Active Life and Contemplative Life: A Study of the Concepts from Plato to the Present*. With a Foreword by George E. Ganss (Milwaukee / Wisconsin, 1961).

[17] Bas. Caes., *Constitutiones Monasticae* 1.1 (PG 31, 1325B-1328C).

[18] Evagr. Pont., *Rerum monachalium rationes* 3 (PG 40, 1253D-1256A).

[19] Mac. Aeg., *Homiliae Spirituales*. 'De statu Adae antequam transgrederetur mandatum Dei: et postquam amisit propriam ac coelestem imaginem. Continet quoque homilia quasdam quaestiones valde utiles' 12.16 (PG 34, 568A-B); Mac. Mag., *De oratione* 15 (PG 34, 863D-866A).

[20] Is. Abb., *Orationes*. 'Oratio XXI. De paenitentia' 10 (PG 40, 1165CD-1166A).

[21] Nic. Pector., *Practicorum, physicorum et gnosticorum capitum centurae tres*. 'Physicorum capitum centuria secunda.' 2.98 (PG 120, 950C-953A).

[22] Theoph. Bulg., *Enarratio in Evangelium Lucae*. 'De oratione. De eo qui habebat daemonium surdum. De muliere quae vocem de turba extulit. De petentibus signum. De Pharisaeo interpellante Jesum. De miseria legisperitorum' 10 (PG 123, 851B-854C).

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for the holidays of the Virgin Mary,[23] Eastern Orthodox tradition assimilated Mary to Theotokos – God-Bearer, and according to monastic writings accepted Her as an incarnation of mental prayer. Thus she is possibly the highest spiritual guide for those who practice this ascetic discipline. I would like to take a look at these Eastern writings and to concentrate in this short paper on the key points in the interpretation of this passage with respect to contemplative life in medieval Eastern Orthodoxy, offering some comparison with the Western interpretations.

Even though one may find in the works of Origen the outline of the official Orthodox view on the topic,[24] the only extant exposition of it at any length was done by Basil the Great,[25] whose treatment appears to integrate various interpretations of the Desert Fathers. In developing this point of view, Basil speaks about the imitation of Christ, of his piety and virtue. He states that those who practice these two things together receive the fruit of Salvation. This mainstream opinion is not the only one which can be found in the Eastern tradition of instruction in contemplative life. If this was not specifically intended as a mediation of the opinions of Skete fathers of the Egyptian Desert, at least this view of Basil could be examined by the Desert Fathers. Evagrios shows a severe attitude towards Martha, whom he links to vanity, and especially to food, which prevents contemplative life and thus must be condemned.[26] Another opinion, expressed by St. Abba Isaiah,[27] who equates the roles of the sisters, appears to be the most sombre of known reflections. Martha and Mary are the models for imitation, who weep mutually before the Savior for the sake of the resurrection of their brother Lazarus-Mind, bound by his sins, and mutually take the care for him upon themselves, while the Mind after the resurrection reclines at the banquet with the Savior. While both of these opinions represent extremes of interpretation among the Desert Fathers, to St. Macarius the Great is ascribed the expression of the golden mean between these two opinions, which is closest to the opinion of Basil. According to Symeon Metaphrastes' paraphrase of St. Macarius,[28] Mary and Martha represent two different 'offshoots' growing from 'one good root.' Does it imply that each of these offshoots could live independently if the other dies? Probably the fable-like story of the Egyptian Paterikon,[29]

[23] M. Redus, *The Text of the Major Festivals of the Menologion in the Greek Gospel Lectionary*, 2 (Chicago, 1936), II 14.

[24] Orig., *Scholia in Lucam* 10 (PG 17, 353A-B).

[25] Evagr. Mon., *Rerum monachalium rationes, earumque juxta quietem appositio* 3 (PG 40, 1253D).

[26] Evagr. Pont., *Rerum monachalium rationes* 3 (PG 40, 1253D-1256A).

[27] Nic. Pector., *Practicorum, physicorum et gnosticorum capitum centurae tres* 2.98 (PG 120, 950C-953A).

[28] Mac. Aeg., *Homiliae* 12.16 (PG 34, 567A-B); *id.*, *De oratione* 14 (PG 34, 863D-866A).

[29] *De vitis partum liber quintus, sive verba seniorum, auctore graeco incerto (1), interprete Pelagio S. R. E. Diacono. De discretione. Verba Seniorum (b)* 10.69 (PL 73, 924B-C).

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translated into Latin, is directed against such a separation.[30] It describes the story of a young monk who upon coming to a monastery at Sinai attempted to instruct its constantly laboring monks, saying that 'Mary has chosen the best part ...' As a result he was given a book and installed in a cell without a meal. When he asked why he was treated this way, he received the response that he as a spiritual person probably did not need food, but the rest of the monks were people with earthly needs. It was said to him that Mary is also glorified because of Martha. Thus the opinion of Basil, though a moderate integration in comparison to the opinions of desert fathers, may become problematic when applied to the life of an ordinary monk.

In the eleventh century the fathers of Constantinople tried to solve this problem and as a result at least two interpretations based on promises of *theosis* appeared: the first promised *theosis* through the imitation of patterns of behavior and justice in this life, while the other promised it through the deeds of abstract Justice and Wisdom, helping in the resurrection of the Intellect. The first belongs to Gregory the Great,[31] but is transmitted by Theophylact of Bulgaria.[32] Theophylact, being a tutor of an imperial heir, wrote with an eye to educating the future ruler. This interpretation treats Mary and Martha as the models of two subsequent stages of the imitation of Christ. Here the unity of imitation of the two sisters together is possible only by the changing of roles by one person though the course of the whole life. Later Western interpretations offered by Cistercians suggest the shortening of time periods and a permanent transition between the roles of Mary and Martha by a sole person, but the essence remains the same: there are two different functions, each of them in its own separate period of time, and the wholeness of the time of life of a person creates a unity out of these two. Nevertheless, if as a result of the subsequent imitation of patterns of behavior and then patterns of contemplation, justice might take root in the soul of the imperial heir, an ordinary monk could simply be left in the first stage of the imitation of Martha for his entire life. Thus another theory was developed in Eastern Orthodoxy by a respected elder, Nikitas Stithatos (c. 1000-1090),[33] which supports the perpetual and simultaneous unity of *praxis* and *theoria*.[34] This interpretation permits independence

[30] The story is already attested by Palladius Helenopolitanus Episcopus for Silvanus and a Messalian monk in the Apophthegmata: Pal. Hel. Ep., *Historia Lausiaca. Appendix I. Apophthegmata Patrum. 'De abbate Silvano'* 5 (PG 65, 409B-D).

[31] Greg. Mag., *Homilia in Ezechielem* (PL 76, 809C).

[32] Theoph. Bulg., *Enarratio in Evangelium Lucae* 10 (PG 123, 851B-854C).

[33] Nic. Pector., *Practicorum, physicorum et gnosticorum capitum centurae tres* 2.98 (PG 120, 950C-953A).

[34] Note that according to Nil Sorsky (sixteenth century) who synthesized some strains of Byzantine thought and influenced the mainstream of Russian Orthodoxy, tradition did not connect contemplative prayer with special positions of the body, but stressed it as the prayer performed within the very heart, and because of this it may be practiced everywhere, anytime and during any activity. One can find notices about such performing of the Jesus Prayer in the

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from the limitations of time and position in the church. It presents a permanent liberalization of the intellect governing the soul during the active style of life. Nikitas Stithatos reworks the interpretation of Abba Isaiah, and brings the topic to a loftier level of the life of intellect. In his interpretation Martha becomes the incarnation of Justice, which offers as food for the Logos of God the sacrifice of suffering from evil, while Mary becomes the personification of Wisdom, which contemplates the Logos of God. Thus Nikitas overcomes and sublimates the vivid tragic intonation of Isaiah. According to Nikitas even the sisters work together in mutual effort, but the Logos of God makes Wisdom closer to Himself, for Wisdom's ability to subordinate the worse thoughts to the better thoughts makes the Mind alive. Mary and Martha are understood as located inside the soul, but outside of the Mind, contacting and helping this Mind and mediating between the Mind and God. If in the interpretation of Theophylact the connecting factor between the figures of Martha and Mary is time, in the Eastern Platonic interpretation of Nikitas it becomes the involvement of the sisters in one process working towards the unity of the human Mind and Logos of God, and in such a process each of the sisters finds her own way to help. Personifications of Wisdom and Justice work submissively on behalf of the concepts of the Human *Nous* and the *Logos* of God, which are joined to each other. This is an Eastern version of the idea that a person stays in the midst of the deeds, but the deeds do not reside in the mind of this, when this one acts according to the image of the Light of Life. Those souls 'redeem the time' which go continually by means of the Mind towards God, not according to the imitations of different images, but rather by the means of intellectual Truth and, moreover, Wisdom. A similar point of view on the passage was expressed by Meister Eckhart in Sermon 86,[35] but he involved in his explanation only Justice, omitting Wisdom, and where Nikitas wrote about deeds, Eckhart speaks about things, offering a more mundane level of interpretation in comparison with that of the Constantinopolitan Elder.

Thus, no matter how the patristic writers specifically interpreted the images of the sisters, the unity between the personifications of Martha and Mary remains the focus of interpretation in the pattern displayed by the traditional reading for the Theotokos's holidays. The combination of the two passages for the liturgy is a glorification of Her: Mary is not only one who has given birth

Life of Joseph of Volotsk and the instruction of Seraphim of Sarov, who advised hirelings to repeat the Jesus Prayer perpetually. See Г. Федотов, Святые Древней Руси. 11 (Москва, 1991), 180. See also С. Чичагов, *Житие Преподобного Серафима, Саровского чудотворца*, 2 (Серафимо-Дивеевский Монастырь, 1903), 37.

[35] Meister Eckhart, 'Intravit Iesus in quoddam castellum, in: Deutsche Werke / Meister Eckhart, *Predigten*. Vol. 1 (Herausgegeben und übersetzt von Josef Quint (Stuttgart, 1958), 24-44; *id.*, *Sermo* 86, in: Meister Eckhart, *Teacher and Preacher* (transl. by Bernard McGinn, edited by Bernard McGinn with the collaboration of Frank Tobin and Elvira Borgstadt) (Mahwah, 1986), 340.

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to and fed the Lord, but even more: she is one who hears the word of God and keeps it. Following this context the Virgin Mary appears to be related to contemplative prayer, moreover: she becomes the example for it. One finds out in the works of the Venerable Nikitas Stithatos[36] and then the Venerable Gregory Sinaites,[37] and above all in the works of the Venerable Nil Sorsky[38] the comparison of the state of the monk performing the Jesus Prayer to the state of a woman in the pangs of childbirth, on the border of life and death. Indeed the Virgin Mary is one who guides believers in the path of 'warm prayer'. For example, the Venerable Maximus Kapsokalivitos specifically prays before the miracle-working icon of the Mother of God for receiving the gift of 'warm prayer' and receives it while he venerates Her icon.[39] Another example: the angel appearing to the weeping St. Gregory Palamas announced that Theotokos said that she herself would guide Gregory on the path of the Jesus Prayer.[40] Thus she definitely plays the role of the highest possible spiritual director for those who persevere in asking for the warmth of the Light of Life in their prayers to her.

Nevertheless, the seeking of Eastern and Western parallels requires care on some points, particularly the different tradition in combining passages in the lectionaries. If Eastern Orthodox tradition attaches to *Luke* 10:37-42 the passage *Luke* 11:27-28, Latin tradition combined it with *Song of Songs* 2:10.[41] Even though both of them are read at the festivals of the Mother of God, the following difference exists: while the second combination is an exhortation to the Bride, the first is a glorification of the God-Bearer.

[36] Nic. Pector., *Practicorum, physicorum et gnosticorum capitum centurae tres* 2.100 (PG 120, 951A-C).

[37] Greg. Sin., *De quetudine et duobus orationis modis capita quindecim* 1 (PG 120, 1313A-B).

[38] Устав Монастырскій Нила Сорскаго, in: Нил Сорский, преп, *Нила Сорского Предание и Уставъ* (Санктъ-Петербургъ, 1912), 12.

[39] Из жития преподобнаго отца нашего Максима Капсокаливита. Об умной и благодатной молитве, in: Святитель Феофан, Затворник Вышенский. *Добротолюбие* (Паломник, 1998), V 511.

[40] Архимандрит Георгий, *Святитель Григорий Палама – учитель обожения* (Афон, 2000), 32-3.

[41] B. McGinn, *The Growth of Mysticism* (New York, 1994), 214, 222.

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The Use of *Rom.* 2:14-5 in the Christian Latin Tradition ca. 365-ca. 411 – Augustine Excepted

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This paper's title is a direct reflection of its nature as a component of a themed workshop on 'The Use of *Rom.* 2:14 (ff.).' And, while every effort has been made to ensure that it is freestanding, whatever contribution it makes will be by providing pieces to that much larger puzzle. The title should, however, make it clear enough what I will attempt: in what follows, I will offer an analysis of some of the extant evidence regarding the ways several of Augustine's Latin predecessors and contemporaries interpreted and applied the difficult assertions found in *Rom.* 2:14-5.

I will proceed in three basic steps. First, I will begin by highlighting a few of the most difficult issues that are generated by these verses. With this I am endeavoring to show: (1) the significant number of obstacles that any would-be commentator must face as he or she seeks to unpack the meaning and application of these verses; and (2) that, after more than 1900 years of reflection, a consensus as to their 'true' meaning and application remains elusive. Second, I will review some of the comments on *Rom.* 2:14-5 that were published in the Latin-speaking world between ca. 365-ca. 411 and that were probably available to Augustine. With this I am endeavoring to show the range of views and opinions that he may have looked to as he constructed his own exegesis of these verses.[1] Third and finally, I will review Pelagius's exegesis of these two verses as found in the extant works that are certainly attributable to him.

[1] Of the several attempts to survey and outline the influence of predecessors upon the thought of Augustine regarding Paul, the following are particularly helpful: Maurice F. Wiles, *The Divine Apostle: The Interpretation of St Paul's Epistles in the Early Church* (Cambridge, 1967), *passim*; G.J.M. Bartelink, Die Beeinflussung Augustins durch die griechischen Patres, in: Jan den Boeft and Johannes van Oort (eds.), *Augustiniana Traiectina: Communications présentées au Colloque International d'Utrecht 13-14 novembre 1986* (Paris, 1987), 9-24; A.A.R. Bastiaensen, Augustin et ses prédécesseurs latins Chrétiens, in: *ibid.*, 25-57; Karlfried Froehlich, Which Paul? Observations on the Image of the Apostle in the History of Biblical Exegesis, in: Bradley Nassif (ed.), *New Perspectives on Historical Theology: Essays in Memory of John Meyendorff* (Grand Rapids, MI, 1996), 279-99. Helpful for both the 'Augustinian' and the 'post-Augustine' histories of the exegesis of Paul and/or of our verses are: Werner Affeldt, Verzeichnis der Römerbriefkommentare der lateinischen Kirche bis zu Nikolaus von Lyra: *Traditio* 13 (1957) 369-406; Johannes Riedl, Die Auslegung von R 2,14-16 in Vergangenheit und Gegenwart: *Analecta Biblica* 17-8 (1963) 271-81; S. Lyonnet, 'Lex naturalis' quid praecipiat secundum S. Paulum et antiquam Patrum traditionem: *Verbum Domini* 45 (1967) 150-61; and esp. K.H. Schelkle, *Paulus Lehrer*

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Exegetical Issues and Obstacles in *Rom.* 2:14-5

Even the casual student of the history of Christian thought cannot be unaware of the substantial amounts of both energy and ink that have gone into efforts either to prove or to disprove the existence of some system of Natural Law and to delineate the implications of these arguments for the faithful.[2] In deciding to tackle *Rom.* 2:14-5, this workshop has taken up the distinct challenge of reviewing this question insofar as it has been linked to the Pauline passage that some scholars regard as the 'only' one in which Paul might be making reference to the '*nomos* of nature.'[3]

That same casual student is also probably aware that the possibility of a connection between our verses and Natural Law is neither the only nor the most difficult of the issues that they raise. Indeed, exegetes have shown that a close reading of *Rom.* 2:14-5 generates multiple exegetical ambiguities that must all be addressed if one desires anything approaching a coherent interpretation of the first three chapters of Paul's letter generally[4] or of *Rom.* 2:12-6 particularly.[5]

der Väter: Die altkirchliche Auslegung von Römer 1-11 (Düsseldorf, 1956), 77-85. M. Lackmann, *Vom Geheimnis der Schöpfung: Die Geschichte der Exegese von Römer 1,18-23, II,14-16 und Acta XIV,15-17, XVII,22-29 vom 2. Jahrhundert bis zum Beginn der Orthodoxie* (Stuttgart, 1952) was unavailable to me, though it was known to and incorporated by Schelkle.

[2] While dated, the place to begin regarding the western tradition and Natural Law is still Robert M. Grant, *Miracle and Natural Law in Graeco-Roman and Early Christian Thought* (Amsterdam, 1952), esp. Chapters 1-2. Also helpful are Gisela Striker, Origins of the Concept of Natural Law, and Brad Inwood, Commentary on Striker, in: J.J. Cleary (ed.), *Proceedings of the Boston Area Colloquium in Ancient Philosophy Volume II* (Lanham, MD, 1987), 79-94 and 95-101 respectively; and Gerard Watson, The Natural Law and Stoicism, in A.A. Long (ed.), *Problems in Stoicism* (London, 1971), 216-38. For the bold claim that 'St. Augustine introduced the fundamental concept of a theistic eternal cosmic law (lex aeterna) to Christian philosophy/theology,' see Terry L. Miethe, Natural Law, the Synderesis Rule, and St. Augustine: *Augustinian Studies* 11 (1980) 91-7, esp. 95, 97.

[3] John L. McKenzie, Natural Law in the New Testament: *Biblical Research* 9 (1964) 6. This claim comes at the end of a discussion of the various Pauline phrases containing the term '*nomos*' and in support of a still larger claim that '[t]o Paul, a Jew and a Pharisee, there was only one true law, the Law of Moses.' A fuller version of what he actually writes there runs '... *if* Paul speaks of a Nomos of nature, he does it only in Romans 2:14; and the presumption is against this meaning of the word' (italics added).

[4] Not a few modern exegetes regard this chapter as one of the most difficult in what all concede to be Paul's most difficult letter. For a thorough review of the many and various views on *Rom.* 2, see Klyne R. Snodgrass, Justification by Grace – to the Doers: An Analysis of the Place of Romans 2 in the Theology of Paul: *New Testament Studies* 32 (1986) 72-93, esp. 73-5, as well as footnotes 9-30.

[5] The bibliography on the place of *Rom.* 2 in Paul's thinking and/or on the exegesis of *Rom.* 2:12-16 is enormous. Two of the most helpful contemporary commentaries for *Rom.* 2:12-16 are those of Dunn and Cranfield. Respectively, see James D.G. Dunn, *Romans 1-8*, The Word Biblical Commentary 38A (Dallas, 1988), esp. 94-107 and C.E.B. Cranfield, *A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Epistle to the Romans, Vol. 1 Romans I-VIII*, The International Critical Commentary (Edinburgh, 1975), esp. 152-63. Also thorough is Robert Jewett, *Romans*, Hermeneia: A Critical and Historical Commentary on the Bible (Minneapolis, 2007), esp. 210-8. Other

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These questions include:[6]

1) Does the mention of 'ἔθνη (Gentiles)' in 2:14 refer to Gentile pagans, whether pre- or post-Christ's first advent, or to Gentile Christians? Regardless, how does this usage compare and/or fit with Paul's use of this term elsewhere?[7]
2) What is the best syntactical reading of the 'φύσει (by nature)' of 2:14? Does it go better with what precedes or with what follows? That is, do these Gentiles lack the law 'by nature' or is it that they are somehow able to follow (at least some of) its precepts 'by nature'?
3) What is the precise nature of the 'νόμος (law)' referred to repeatedly in 2:14-5? Is it the Mosaic Law, either in whole or in part? Or, is it in some sense some sort of Natural Law? Or, might it somehow be referring to both of these systems simultaneously?
4) Can this law be kept by human beings without any external assistance? That is, is anything approaching fulfillment of it either possible or likely?
5) What is the source and nature of the 'συνείδησις (conscience) mentioned in 2:15? That is, is this feature inborn or natural, or is it somehow taught or developed via an exposure to the law and its principles?

Rom. 2:14-5 in Latin Authors (ca.) 365 – (ca.) 411

The texts discussed below will be handled in the order of their composition – at least in so far as those dates are known. Origen will be discussed first even though, strictly speaking, his Pauline Commentary would not have been available to monolingual, i.e., 'Latin-only', western readers until ca. 406/407.[8]

helpful resources include: N.T. Wright, The Law in Romans 2, in: James D.G. Dunn (ed.), *Paul and the Mosaic Law* (Grand Rapids, MI and Cambridge, 1996), 131-50, esp. 143-8; Heikki Räisänen, *Paul and the Law*, WUNT 29 (Tübingen, 1983), *passim*, esp. 25-6. 102-9; David Greenwood, Saint Paul and the Natural Law: *Biblical Theology Bulletin* 1 (1971) 262-79; William C. Martin, The Bible and Natural Law: *Restoration Quarterly* 17 (1974) 193-221, esp. 211-8; and E.P. Sanders, Appendix 2: Romans 2, in: *Paul, the Law, and the Jewish People* (Philadelphia, 1983), 123-35.

[6] Although an important and hotly-debated question for modern exegetes, the degree to which Paul is making use of Stoicism or of Stoic language, principles or teachings in our verses is not addressed in this paper. For a persuasive take on this issue, see John W. Martens, Romans 2.14-16: A Stoic Reading: *New Testament Studies* 40 (1994) 55-67, where Martens concludes that, at least here, Paul is writing 'under the influence of Stoic tradition, particularly the idea of a law of nature.'

[7] For a contemporary argument in support of the view that these Gentiles are Gentile Christians, see Adrio König, Gentiles or Gentile Christians? On the meaning of Romans 2:12-16: *Journal of Theology for Southern Africa* 15 (1976) 53-60. See also C.E.B. Cranfield (1975), 155-6 (see n. 5 *supra*).

[8] Origen's profound influence on many of the Latin West's most prominent fourth- and fifth-century churchmen is beyond question. Perhaps less well known is the degree to which his *Romans Commentary* was available in the West via Rufinus's of Aquileia translation. See esp.

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Rom. *2:14-5 in Origen / Rufinus's* Commentary on Romans

Rufinus's ten-book digest of this commentary contains more than a dozen references to all or part of *Rom.* 2:14-5.[9] The most extensive exegesis of our verses occurs at II 7 (ix 1-4), i.e., the section where they provide the *lemma.*

According to Origen, the 'law' referred to here is not the Jewish cultic or ceremonial law, but the ethical laws that are best exemplified in the Ten Commandments. More generally, he believes this law to 'possibly (*fortassis*)' reference the notion that 'God is one and the Creator of all things', but that it all but certainly seems to 'agree with the evangelical laws (*cum euangelicis legibus conuenire*) where everything is ascribed to natural justice (*ad naturalem ... aequitatem*).' In other words, this 'law written on the hearts of the Gentiles' is most probably some form of the so-called Golden Rule since 'what could be nearer to the natural moral senses than that those things men do not want done to themselves, they should not do to others?'[10]

A few lines later, Origen goes on to add that this law is 'according to the Spirit, through which means alone it is possible for the law to be fulfilled. This ... is the work of the law which the Apostle says even the Gentiles are able to fulfill by nature. For when they do the things of the law it seems that God has written the law on their hearts, "not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God" (see 2*Cor.* 3:3).'[11]

Also relevant to an understanding of Origen's exegesis of *Rom.* 2:14-5 are his comments regarding the identity of the Gentiles. A prime example can be found at II 5 (vii 6) under the *lemma* for *Rom.* 2:10. Most important to note is that these Gentiles are *not* Christian Gentiles; rather, they are pagans or 'Greeks', 'who are moved by natural reason (*naturale ratione motus*),' even though they

Caroline P. Hammond Bammel, Rufinus' Translation of Origen's Commentary on Romans and the Pelagian Controversy, in: *Storia ed esegesi in Rufino di Concordia*, Antichità Altoadriatiche XXXIX (Udine, 1992), 131-42. See esp. 135: 'It is not unlikely that copies [of Rufinus's translation] would have been brought from Sicily to Africa after Rufinus's death or perhaps even earlier direct from Rome' when Melania the Elder visited Augustine in 407. On 137 she writes: '... I am convinced that Augustine read Rufinus' translation ... during the period when he was producing his earliest anti-Pelagian works.'

[9] See also I 19 (xvi 3); II 4 (iv 4); II 6 (viii 2); II 7 (x 1), which is central for Origen's take on *Rom.* 2:15b-16; III 2 (ii 7); and III 2 (ii 9).

[10] This English trans. is taken from *Origen: Commentary on the Epistle to the Romans Books 1-10*, transl. Thomas P. Scheck, Fathers of the Church 103 and 104 (Washington, D.C., 2001 and 2002, hereafter cited as 'Scheck'). For these particular quotations see 103, 131. For the Latin, see Caroline P. Hammond Bammel, *Der Römerbriefkommentar des Origenes: Kritische Ausgabe der Übersetzung Rufins. Buch 1-10, Vetus Latina*: Die Reste der altlateinischen Bibel. Aus der Geschichte der Lateinischen Bibel, vols. 16, 33 and 34 (Freiburg, 1990, 1997 and 1998, hereafter cited as 'Hammond Bammel'). For these particular lines, see vol. 16, 135. For a 'pre-Hammond Bammel' claim regarding the general reliability of Rufinus's transl., see, *e.g.*, M. Wiles, (1967) 6 (see n. 1 *supra*).

[11] Scheck, 103, 132. Cf. Hammond Bammel, 16, 136.

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have 'not believed in Christ' and, consequently, 'cannot enter into the kingdom of heaven.'[12] It would seem that Origen was convinced that although pagans knew enough and were capable enough to live exemplary moral lives, this natural righteousness would still let them down on the Day of Judgment since 'however much the law of nature may offer testimony about good and evil according to the judgment of conscience, nevertheless it cannot be put on the same level (*exaequari*) as the law of faith, by which Abraham believed God and merited (*meruit*) to be justified and to be named a friend of God' (see *Jas.* 2:23).[13]

Rom. *2:14-5 in Hilary of Poitiers's* Commentary on Psalm 118(119)

Hilary's most interesting use of our verses comes from his comments on the 'Samech' portion of his *Tractatus on Psalm 118(119)*, i.e., on verses 113-120. The most relevant lines come from Hilary's comments on verse 119, which in his version reads: 'Praeuaricantes deputaui omnes peccatores terrae, ideo dilexi iustitias tuas ...' His comment runs as follows:

> The word of the prophet always expands itself far away and beyond the ordinary sense of the words. For we understand 'sinners (*peccatores*)' to be those who are forsaking their received faith and their acquired knowledge of God, those who have promised one thing and now are doing something else. But these 'sinners' are understood as all the sinners of the earth; the title 'sinner' is ascribed to all people generally, no one is excepted. For the law is, apparently, [a law] of nature: to do injury to no one, to surreptitiously take nothing belonging to another, to abstain from fraud and perjury, to not plot against the marriage of another. The Apostle also acknowledged (*nouit*) this law of nature by saying: 'For when the nations, who do not have the law, naturally do things according to the law, such people [while] not having the law are a law unto themselves, they are showing that the work of the law has been written on their hearts.' Therefore we understand these 'sinners' to be those that are forsaking the law they are receiving from nature. The one who is discovered to be a thief or an adulterer or murderer is accused (*arguet*) by the law of nature. But if he is engaging in these things, he is also a 'sinner' [against] the law.[14]

[12] Scheck, 103, 125. Cf. Hammond Bammel, 16, 128.

[13] Scheck, 103, 253. Cf. Hammond Bammel, 33, 292.

[14] This transl. is my own. For the Latin, see SC 347, 168-71: 'Semper prophetae sermo longe se et ultra communem sensum extendit. Nos enim praevaricatores eos existimamus, qui susceptam fidem et cognitionem Dei adeptam reliquunt, aliud pollicitos et aliud nunc agentes. Sed his praevaricatores existimantur omnes paccatores terrae; nullus excipitur, generaliter ad omnes praevaricationis nomen refertur. Lex enim ueluti naturalis est, inuriam nemini adferre, nihil alienum praeripere, fraude ac periurio abstinere, alieno coniugio non insidiari. Nouit et hanc naturae apostolus legem dicens: "cum enim nationes, quae legem non habent, naturaliter secundum legem faciunt, tales homines legem non habentes sibi ipsi sunt lex, qui ostendunt opus legis scriptum in cordibus suis." Ergo praevaricatores existimantur qui quod a natura legis accipiunt derelinquunt. Furem quis deprehensum aut adulterum aut homicidam arguet lege naturae. Sed si in his ipse uersetur, praevaricator est legis.'

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Here, Hilary, much like (and probably thanks to) Origen, seems to have assumed both that some system of Natural Law exists and that *Rom.* 2:14-5 refers to that assumed system. Indeed, despite the presence of the 'apparently (*ueluti*)' here, the existence of a Natural Law is never questioned. On the contrary, it seems that Hilary has, at least to some degree, conflated or intentionally combined the Law of Moses with the Natural Law that he assumes to exist. This is especially apparent when he notes that the thief, the adulterer, and the murderer 'is also a "sinner" [against] the law.'

It is also clear that Hilary has here taken the 'Gentiles' of 2:14 as a reference to all human beings (see 'to all people generally') whether Jew, Gentile Christian or Gentile pagan since, in his view, all human beings are included in the group this Psalm refers to as 'sinners.'

Finally, note that the idea guiding his exegesis seems to be the presupposition that everyone has sinned (see, e.g., *Rom.* 3:23): in other words, Hilary seems to have assumed that everyone has at least to some degree forsaken whatever knowledge of the Natural Law that they might have possessed or inherited. Connected to this is the fact that, in addition to knowledge of the 'Golden Rule' (see 'do injury to no one ...'), Hilary seems to have taken it for granted that all people everywhere somehow intuitively know that theft, dishonesty, and adultery are wrong and, hence, are activities that always render their practitioners liable to judgment.

Rom. *2:14-5 in Ambrosiaster's* Romans Commentary

In his commentary under the *lemma* of *Rom.* 2:14, Ambrosiaster begins by making it clear whom Paul was referring to as he wrote to the Christians of Rome:

> Paul is speaking about Christian Gentiles, because he is the Teacher of the Gentiles (see *1Tim.* 2:7), just as he said in another place: 'For I say to you Gentiles (see *Rom.* 11:13), who are uncircumcised, observing neither new moon celebrations, nor the Sabbath, nor the law regarding ceremonial food' (see *Col.* 2:16) and who, by nature's leading, believe in God and in Christ, that is in the Father and the Son. For this is to observe the law: to acknowledge the God of the law. For the first part of wisdom is this: to fear God the Father (see *Ps.* 111:10; *Pr.* 1:7; 9:10), from whom are all things, and the Lord Jesus his Son, through whom are all things (see *1Cor.* 8:6). Therefore, nature itself acknowledges its Creator by its own judgment, not through the law, but through the natural reasoning faculty. For the work perceives [its] Creator within itself.[15]

[15] This transl. is my own. For the Latin, see CSEL 81/1,75: 'Gentes Christianos dicit, quia Magister gentium est, sicut dicit alio loco: vobis enim dico gentibus, qui incircumcisi neque neomenias neque sabbatum neque escarum legem servant et duce natura credunt in Deum et Christum, id est in Patrem et in Filium. Hoc est enim legem servare, Deum legis agnoscere. Prima enim sapientiae pars haec est: timere Deum Patrem, ex quo sunt omnia, et Dominum Iesum Filium eius, per quem sunt omnia. Ipsa ergo natura proprio iudicio creatorem suum agnoscit, non per legem, sed per rationem naturae; opus enim Opificem cernit in sese.'

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For Ambrosiaster, the 'Gentiles' of *Rom.* 2:14 are not pre-Advent pagans; they are simply non-Jews who have come to believe in Christ. Equally interesting is the means by which these Gentiles have come to faith: they have not been converted through the direct agency of the Holy Spirit as they responded to the Gospel; rather, they have come to faith in Christ simply 'by nature's leading (*duce natura*).' Also noteworthy – though less explicit – is that this natural 'leading' is, at least in part 'through the natural reasoning faculty (*per rationem naturae*)' and not, as one might expect, a result of the convert's ability to downplay or ignore the reasoning part of their mind in favor of other aspects of their being.

Rom. *2:14-5 in Ambrose of Milan*[16]

Of those commenting on or writing about Paul during the period 365-411,[17] few were as influential on the participants in the Pelagian Controversies as Ambrose of Milan.[18]

One of his clearest and most detailed discussions of our verses is found in his *Epistula* 63.[19] In it, Ambrose is gently correcting Irenaeus, a friend who had concluded that the Mosaic Law must have been neither good nor necessary since it only brought about God's wrath and only increased humanity's awareness of its moral wretchedness. While giving prominence to the words of *Rom.* 4:15 – 'For the law works wrath; for where there is no law, neither is there transgression'[20] – Ambrose's comments take a broad *heilsgeschichtlichen*

[16] In addition to *Ep.* 63, Ambrose references our verses in the following locations: *Exp. eu. Luc.* VII 152 (1447C-D) (see CSEL 32/4, 350); *Expl. ps. xii* I 31 (see CSEL 64, 26), where, interestingly, Ambrose does apply, albeit through an allusion, *Rom.* 2:14 to the Law of Moses and not to the Natural Law *per se*; *ibid.*, I. 51 (see CSEL 64, 44), where he applies *Rom.* 2:15-6 to all believers including himself; *ibid.*, XXXVI 69 (see CSEL 64, 128-9); *ibid.*, XXXIX 22 (see CSEL 64, 227-8); *Exp. ps. 118*, V 21 (see CSEL 62, 93); *Ep.* 7.18 and 32 (see CSEL 82/1, 52 and 58); *De paradiso* VIII 39 (see CSEL 32/1, 296); *De fuga saeculi* III 15 (see CSEL 32/2, 175), where in affirming the goodness of Natural Law Ambrose notes that 'Primum natura ipsa boni operis magistra est'; and *De Iacob et uita beata* I 6.20 (see CSEl 32/2,17).

[17] While the place to begin for the West's '(re-) discovery of Paul' is still Alexander Souter, *The Earliest Latin Commentaries on the Epistles of Paul* (Oxford, 1927), more recent general analyses include Maria Grazia Mara, Il significato storico-esegetico dei commentary al corpus paolino dal IV al V seculo: *Annali di storia dell'esegesi* 1 (1984) 59-74 and K. Froehlich (1996) (see n. 1 *supra*).

[18] Ambrose's impact on Augustine is amply discussed by Augustine himself in both the *Conf.* (cf. esp. Bk. VI *passim*) and the *C. Jul.* (cf. esp. Bks. I, II, and III *passim*). For a relatively recent discussion, see J. Patout Burns, Ambrose Preaching to Augustine: The Shaping of Faith, in: Joseph Schnaubelt and Frederick Van Fleteren (eds.), *Collectanea Augustiniana: Augustine: 'Second Founder of the Faith'* (New York, 1990), 373-86 as well as A.A.R. Bastiaensen (1987) esp. 30-4 (see n. 1 *supra*).

[19] In numbering this as 'Letter 63,' I am following the CSEL critical edition. The Maurists knew this as 'Letter 73'; the English transl. in the FOTC series (see next n. *infra*), has it as 'Letter 83'.

[20] This transl. is that found in FOTC 26, 464-8, by Mary M. Beyenka. The Latin (see CSEL 82/2, 142-8) is: 'Lex enim iram operatur; ubi autem non est lex, nec praevaricatio.'

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approach toward God's dealings with humanity generally and his revelation of the law specifically. Indeed, Ambrose assumes both the existence of a code of Natural Law that has been implanted by God within all people[21] and that this phenomenon is exactly what Paul had in mind as he penned *Rom.* 2:14-5:

> ... it is certain that the Law given to Moses was not necessary. For, if men had been able to keep the natural law which God the Creator planted in the breast of each one, there would have been no need of that Law, which, written on stone tablets, rather (*magis*) enmeshed and entangled the infirmity of the human race (*humani generis infirmitatem*)[22] than freed and liberated it. Moreover, that there is a natural law written in our hearts the Apostle also teaches when he writes that for the most part (*plerumque*): 'The Gentiles do by nature what the Law prescribes, and since they do not read (*legerint*) the Law, they yet have the work of the Law written in their hearts.'[23]

Interesting is the qualifying '*plerumque*' that Ambrose adds to his introduction of *Rom.* 2:14. While this could indicate that he knew that Greek text of *Rom.* 2 contained an anarthrous 'ἔθνη,' it seems at least as likely to be an admission that the Natural Law he has assumed to exist has lost much of its power and that the influence it now works within human hearts is something less than fully compelling.

Also important here is Ambrose's claim about the human race's inability to keep the Natural Law. While one could argue for such simply on the basis of empirical observation, Ambrose believes that the situation is significantly more complex: for him, Adam's failure was a failure against the Natural Law just as surely as it was against God's direct command (see *Gen.* 2:16-7). For him, Adam was the first to make a significant contribution to silencing the Natural Law and, by extension, retarding its ability to function for humanity as it was originally intended:

[21] In fact, in the lines following the passage cited here Ambrose notes that this Natural Law is '... not written, but inborn; it is not acquired by reading, but springs up in each one as from the flowing font of nature, and men's minds drink from it.' Moreover, this Natural Law 'is in itself holy, guileless, without craftiness, the companion of justice free from wickedness,' a description reminiscent of Paul's take on the Mosaic Law as found in *Rom.* 7:7-25. For the English, see FOTC 26, 464-5; for the Latin, see CSEL 82/2, 143-4: '... lex non scribitur sed innascitur nec aliqua percipitur lectione, sed profluo quodam naturae fonte in singulis exprimitur et humanis ingeniis hauritur. [...] sancta, sine versuita, sine fraude, consors iustitiae, expers iniquitatis.'

[22] Beyenka's translation (see n. 20 *supra*) of '*humani generis infirmitatem*' with 'weakness of human nature,' while perhaps defensible given the context, has been replaced with the more literal (and more theologically pregnant) 'infirmity of the human race.'

[23] FOTC 26, 464; see CSEL 82/2, 143: '... certum est non fuisse legem necessariam quae per Moysen data est. Nam si naturalem legem, quam Deus Creator infudit singulorum pectoribus, homines servare potuissent, non fuerat opus ea lege, quae in tabulis scripta lapideis implicavit atque innodavit magis humani generis infirmitatem quam elaqueavit atque absolvit. Esse autem legem naturalem in cordibus nostris etiam Apostolus docet, qui scribit quia plerumque et Gentes naturaliter ea quae legis sunt faciunt, et cum legem non legerint, opus tamen legis scriptum habent in cordibus suis.'

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This law Adam broke (*solvit*), seeking to take for himself what he had not received, so that he might be like his own Creator and Maker, so that he might claim divine honor. [...] Had he not broken the command (*imperium*) and had he been obedient to the heavenly precepts (*mandatis caelestibus*), he would have preserved for his heirs the prerogative of nature (*praerogatiuam naturae*) and of innocence which was his from birth. But because the authority of the Natural Law was corrupted and blotted out by disobedience, the written law was determined necessary.[24]

Rom. *2:14-5 in Pelagius*

Pelagius has left us ample means for accessing his views on our verses. Indeed, by comparing what he writes in his *Pauline Commentary* with the more extensive discussion that occurs in his rhetorically charged *Letter to Demetrias*,[25] a complex and apparently evolving picture emerges.

Under the *lemma* of *Rom.* 2:13-5 in his *Pauline Commentary*,[26] Pelagius clearly takes the 'Gentiles' of *Rom.* 2 as a reference to non-Christian pagans and not to pagan converts to Christianity. He does this by setting the 'Gentiles' in opposition to himself and his Christian community via first-person plural forms and differentiating prepositional phrases such as 'along with'. He writes: '[Paul] explains why Jews are not better than the Gentiles. *We* too should fear, therefore, lest *we*, hearing the law but not doing it (see *Rom.* 2:13), perish *along with the Gentiles*, as he himself says elsewhere: "Lest we be damned along with this world" (see 1*Cor.* 11:32; all italics added).'[27] In fact, though Pelagius does tacitly accept two different views regarding these 'Gentiles' precise identity under this *lemma*, he never retracts the claim that they should not be

[24] *Ibid.*, 465; see CSEL 82/2, 144: 'Solvit hanc legem Adam, qui voluit sibi arrogare quod non acceperat, ut esset sicut Creator et Conditor suus et divinum honorem affectaret. [...] Qui si non rupisset imperium et oboediens fuisset mandatis caelestibus, praerogativam naturae atque ingenitae sibi innocentiae heredibus propriis reservavisset. Ergo quia per inoboedientiam praerogativa naturalis legis corrupta atque interlita est, ideo scriptum legis aestimatum est necessarium, ...'

[25] As there is very little that is germane within the extant portions of Pelagius's *De Natura* (see, however, *nat. et gr.* 2,2 (CSEL 60, 234-5), which does mention the 'law of nature (*lege naturae*),' that work's date and provenance need not concern us here. For more on this, see Yves-Marie Duval, La date du 'De Natura' de Pélage: Les premières étapes de la controverse sur la nature de la grâce: *RÉA* 36 (1990) 257-83, esp. 274.

[26] Interesting is Gathercole's conclusion that in this section of the commentary 'Pelagius ... is not particularly Pelagian.' See Simon J. Gathercole, A Conversion of Augustine: From Natural Law to Restored Nature in Romans 2:13-16, in: Daniel Patte and Eugene TeSelle (eds.), *Engaging Augustine on Romans: Self, Context, and Theology in Interpretation*, Romans through History and Culture Series (Harrisburg, PA, 2002), 147-72, esp. 158-9.

[27] This English transl. is from Theodore De Bruyn, *Pelagius's Commentary on St Paul's Epistle to the Romans* (Oxford, 1993), 72. For the Latin, see Alexander Souter, *Pelagius's Expositions of Thirteen Epistles of St Paul*, Texts and Studies 9/2 (Cambridge, 1926), 23: 'Reddit rationem quare non sint gentibus meliores; unde et nobis timendum est ne audientes legem et non facientes, cum gentibus pereamus, secundum quod ipse alibi dicit: "ne cum hoc mundo damnemur."'

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regarded as Christians: they are either '... those who were by nature (*naturaliter*) righteous in the period before the law,' or 'those who even now (*etiam nunc*) do some good.'[28]

Like many of his contemporaries, Pelagius never seems to question the existence of Natural Law, though he is quite clear that possessing it is not the same as having made good use of it. Indeed, in keeping with what is surely Paul's larger concern in *Rom.* 1-3, Pelagius is clear that these non-Christian Gentiles have not been blessed by the Natural Law; in fact, it has only served to incriminate them: '[Paul] demonstrates that they do not lack a law, so as to leave the Gentiles no excuse and to divest the Jews of the glory owing to the possession of the law.'[29]

Unlike many of his contemporaries, however, the Pelagius of the *Romans Commentary* views the 'conscience' as at least somewhat trustworthy for all three of his sub-groups of humanity: Jews, Christian Gentiles, and pagan Gentiles.[30] His position is again made clear through a judicious use of the first person plural: '[Paul] asserts that there is a mental debate when we decide by lengthy deliberation what we ought to do and what we ought not to do, and that we should be judged according to this on the day of the Lord, because it proves that we were not ignorant of good and evil.'[31]

As noted above, Pelagius's most extensive use of our verses occurs in the *Letter to Demetrias*, a text normally dated to 414.

Pelagius quickly introduces the issue of the capacities of human nature: in fact, they occur immediately after his salutation.[32] And, a mere two paragraphs later, i.e., in the second half of Chapter 3, he begins his defense of the innate or natural capacity of all members of the human race – including pagans – to perform morally good deeds.

[28] T. De Bruyn (1993), 73; see A. Souter (1926), 23.

[29] T. De Bruyn (1993), 73; see A. Souter (1926), 23: 'Ostendit illos non esse sine lege, ut et gentes inexcusabiles faciat et Iudaeis de proprietate legis gloriam tollat.'

[30] This is not to deny or obscure the fact that elsewhere Pelagius claims that the conscience of all 'natural-born' human beings (and especially those of his own day), have deteriorated to the point that most of them have 'forgotten (*obliti*)' (or 'almost forgotten [*paene ... in obliuionem*] what the race one clearly knew to be the Natural Law of God. See, *e.g.*, his comments under *Rom.* 7:8. Also helpful here are the comments of J. Patout Burns, The Interpretation of Romans in the Pelagian Controversy: *Augustinian Studies* 10 (1979) 49.

[31] T. De Bruyn (1993), 73; see A. Souter (1926), 23: 'Dicit altercationes cogitationum esse, cum quid faciendum uel non faciendum diutina deliberatione decernimus, et secundum hoc nos in die domini iudicandos quia bonum malumue non ignorasse conuincimur.'

[32] Note that a mere fifteen lines into Chapter 1 Pelagius has proclaimed that Demetrias's choice for the veil is actually the direct result of her employing the 'sword of the faith (*fidei gladio*)' and that she has done so 'of her own free will (*uoluntate*).' See B.R. Rees, To Demetrias, in: *The Letters of Pelagius and His Followers* (Woodbridge, Suffolk, U.K., 1998), 36; note that this translation was accessed by me via the reprint found in the volume entitled *Pelagius: Life and Letters*. See PL 30, 15 for the Latin. Very similar (if not stronger) sentiments are also found in 2.1; 2.2; and 3.1.

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Section 3,3 begins by noting that those who critique the human race's inborn and God-given abilities to choose freely between good and evil do so 'from lack of faith as much as of knowledge ... (... *impie, non minus quam imperite*).'[33] For Pelagius, the existence of virtuous pagans offers all the proof he needs: the good of human nature 'has been so universally (*generaliter*) established in all [human beings] that it sometimes reveals itself and brings itself to notice even in pagans who do not worship God.'[34] After noting that the source of this goodness must be from 'the good of nature (*de naturae bono*),' Pelagius concludes the chapter by noting that, comparatively speaking, all Christians are obligated to exceed whatever degree of righteousness these good pagans have obtained since the 'nature and life [of Christians] have been instructed for the better by Christ' and since they 'are assisted (*iuuantur*) by the aid of divine grace as well.'[35] This, in turn, pushes Pelagius to discuss the conscience and Natural Law in Chapter 4, a section which culminates in his most elaborate exegesis of our verses.

In 4,2, Pelagius mentions the 'certain natural sanctity (*naturalis quaedam sanctitas*)' that exists 'in our minds (*in animis nostris*)' and notes that, by working 'on the evidence [provided by] our conscience (*ad conscientiae testimonium*),' it helps us all to judge between what is good and what is evil. According to Pelagius, this 'natural sanctity' works by 'a kind of inner law (*domestica quadam lege*),' and it was exactly this 'inner law' that Paul was talking about in *Rom.* 2:14-5:

> This is the law which the apostle recalls (*meminit*) when he writes to the Romans, testifying that it is implanted in all men and written as it were on the tables of the heart: ... [Pelagius quotes *Rom.* 2:14-5 *in toto*]. It is this law that all have used whom scripture records as having lived in sanctity and having pleased God between the time of Adam and that of Moses: some of these must be set before you as examples, so that you may not find it difficult to understand *how great is the good of nature (quantum sit naturae bonum)*, when once you have satisfied yourself that *it has replaced the law in the task of teaching righteousness* (... *eam legis uice docuisse iustitiam*; italics added).[36]

[33] Note, however, that a few chapters later, i.e., in 8.1, Pelagius goes to significant lengths to clarify exactly what he means by the 'good of nature.' Here he is adamant that he is not claiming that we are incapable of doing evil. Rather, his chief concern is to refute those who think we are 'forced to do evil through a fault in our nature (*ne eius uitio ad malum ... impelli*).' For this, see B.R. Rees (1998), 43 and see PL 30, 22.

[34] See B.R. Rees (1998), 39 and see PL 30, 18: '... generaliter cunctis institutum est, ut in gentilibus quoque hominibus, qui sine ullo cultu Dei sunt, se nonnumquam ostendat, ac proferat.'

[35] See B.R. Rees (1998), *ibid.* and see PL 30, *ibid.*: '... in melius per Christum natura et uita instructa est: et ... diuinae quoque gratiae iuuantur auxilio.'

[36] See B.R. Rees (1998), 40 and see PL 30, 19: 'Huius legis, scribens ad Romanos, meminit Apostolus: quam omnibus hominibus insitam uelut in quibusdam tabulis cordis scriptum esse, testator: ... Hac lege usi sunt omnes, quos inter Adam atque Moysen sancta uixisse, atque placuisse Deo, Scriptura commemorat. Quorum tibi, exempli causa, aliqui proponendi sunt: ut facile intelligas, quantum sit naturae bonum, cum eam legis uice docuisse iustitiam probaueris.'

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Here, and in what is clearly a shift from the position he took in the *Romans Commentary*, Pelagius takes the 'Gentiles' of 2:14 as referring to all human beings regardless of religious or ethnic identity. Also interesting is how the 'law' of *Rom.* 2:14-5 here refers to the precepts by which all 'pre-Mosaic' persons who pleased God must have lived. And, while Pelagius's complete list probably includes Adam, Cain, Noah, and Abraham – to name just a few – it is only Joseph (see *Gen.* 39), because he instinctively knew that adultery was wrong and exercised his willpower to avoid it, who is discussed in detail (see 5,4).

Most interesting is Pelagius's apparent claim that, in the post-advent Church Age, the human race has actually returned in some sense to the 'pre-Mosaic' dispensation since all properly instructed Christians can again rely on a resurgent 'Natural Sanctity' since it 'has replaced the law in the task of teaching righteousness (... *eam legis uice docuisse iustitiam*).' In other words, it seems that Pelagius's conception of the Trinity's activities in the world includes the restoration of the sensitivity to the Natural Law that human beings, thanks to the cumulative effect of the sins of each successive generation, gradually lost over the course of the last few millennia.

Summary and Conclusions

The foregoing examples have shown that the exegesis of *Rom.* 2:14-5 in the Latin West of the period (ca.) 365-(ca.) 411 was anything but consistent or uniform. In fact, they have shown that there was sometimes substantial variation even within the thought of a single author: many of these exegetes were quite comfortable with adapting – if not outright altering – their opinions on these verses in order to make them more nearly applicable to a given context or more closely conformable to the conventions of the genre they were producing.

Most obvious in this regard is the question of whether or not the 'Gentiles' of *Rom.* 2:14 were Christian or pagan. Some, like Ambrosiaster, seemed to think they are better seen as Christians; others seem to have taken it for granted that they are pagans – though some did take them to be strictly the pagans of the period before Christ's first advent.

That this amount of latitude or, perhaps, uncertainty, existed in the Latin exegesis of this period is especially significant when one encounters the oft-noted fact that Augustine altered his views on these verses once he became enmeshed in the first phase of the Pelagian Controversy. That he could find some well-respected churchmen who (at least sometimes) understood these 'Gentiles' to be 'Gentile Christians', makes it plain that Augustine did not inaugurate this view all on his own. On the contrary, it seems more accurate to say that, in switching, he merely exchanged one more-or-less traditional view in favor of another that was also more-or-less traditional.

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This is not, however, meant to imply that no elements of the exegesis of these verses were handed on from one author to another: indeed, all these authors seem to have taken the existence of Natural Law for granted and, by extension, to have been more than a little eager to find it within the Scriptures. At the same time, at least some of them explicitly rejected the idea that adherence to the principles of Natural Law could be ultimately salvific or justificatory. Those who rejected Natural Law's power to achieve and to maintain a solid and healthy relationship with God are also those who apparently 'got' the overall argument of *Rom.* 1-3 and, moreover, took that argument more seriously than they did any (potential) exceptions that they might have sensed within the words of *Rom.* 2:14-5.

Also seemingly traditional are the links these authors made between the so-called Golden Rule and the tenets of Natural Law. Especially conspicuous was the appearance of a negative form of the Golden Rule, much like that found in *Tobit* 4:15, in contexts that also contained discussions of Natural Law and/or *Rom.* 2:14-5. While more research into this particular question remains to be done, it does not seem wholly unwarranted to regard this particular link as a possible *topos* of the Latin exegesis of the period prior to the outbreak of the first phase of the Pelagian Controversy.

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Romans 13 in Early Christian Exegesis

Marco Rizzi, Milan

Recently, many scholars and opinion-makers have supported the idea that Christianity contains in itself the seed of modern laicism, i.e. the separation between religion and political authority, church and state. In their view, such a distinction rests on the famous saying of Jesus: 'Render unto Cesar the things which are Cesar's and unto God the things that are God's' (*Matth.* 22:21 and parallels). Here, I remember only Bernard Lewis or Maurice Sachot, but also theologians like Joseph Ratzinger (before becoming Pope) have expressed this view.[1] Of course, none of them tries to deny what has been clarified in two thousand years of Christian history, that is in Bernard Lewis's words: 'Something of the pre-christian function of religion survives or reappears in the Christian world, where, at times, priests ruled secular power and kings evocated divine rights even over the Church. But these were diversions from Christian norms ...'.[2] Apart from human errors and historical *defaillances*, a decisive principle was so established and it marked the difference between Christianity and the other monotheistic faiths or other religions in general. In this view, the tribute episode of the Gospel would have always constituted the polar star for Christian theology and praxis in defining the political relation between sacred and secular.

However, such an assertion seems to be not only too simplistic and apologetic, but it also erases from the discussion another New Testament text which shaped in a deeper way Christians's attitude towards politics and state during the centuries: Paul's Epistle to the Romans, chapter thirteen, verses one to seven, with the commandment to submit oneself to the *sublimiores potestates*, to obey them and to pay taxes. Of course, it's a well known and now much debated text,[3] but it's worth noting that the tendency to lessen its importance

[1] See Bernard Lewis, *What went wrong* (Oxford and New York, 2002); Maurice Sachot, *L'invention du Christ: Genèse d'une religion* (Paris, 1998); *e.g.*, Joseph Ratzinger, *Christliche Orientierung in der pluralistichen Demokratie? Über die Unverzichtbarkeit des Christentums in der modernen Welt*, in: Herbert Schambeck (ed.), *Pro fide et iustitia: Fs. Kard. Casaroli* (Berlin, 1984), 747-61.

[2] B. Lewis, *What went wrong* (2002), 196.

[3] For a first survey of the debate, see Juan V. Picca, *Romanos 13,1-7: Un texto discutido. Prolegomena para su interpretacion* (Rome, 1981), 25-113. Still of value the remarks of Raymond Deniel, Omnis potestas a Deo: L'origine du pouvoir civil et sa relation à l'église: *RSR* 56 (1968) 43-85.

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in front of passages such as *Matth.* 22:21 became dominant only after World War II – and *pour cause*, as first Eric Vögelin observed.[4] Actually, early Christian exegesis of the tribute episode focused more on the necessity of reconstituting God's image in man in opposition to Caesar's on the coin, or on the Pharisees's hypocrisy in tempting Jesus than on political issues; Christians's duty to pay taxes and to be submitted to political authority is by no means under discussion. In my opinion this is clear evidence that Paul's statement was quietly accepted and, more relevant, set the framework in which Jesus's tribute saying was to be understood. On the reverse, *Matth.* 22:21 plays a specific political role when Romans thirteen is the exegetical focus of early Christian writers. So, re-examining the early exegesis of Paul's statement can help to understand the way in which it became so central in Christian thought to function as a sort of *basso continuo* for developing the thinking on political topics and on the relationship between sacred and secular.[5]

The ancient exegesis of Romans thirteen follows two main directions: first, it tends to universalize an assertion which instead was thought by Paul as a concrete enforcement to limited and historically determined situations, that were expected to change deeply in a short time;[6] second, it tries to set a proper boundary for those authorities whose legitimacy is fully accepted only on the secular level and within this remit.

Maybe, Paul's statement in Romans thirteen echoes an element of Jesus' teaching, possibly reflected in the very saying of Matthew's Gospel, even if is difficult to determine exactly what Christ's words actually meant; in any case, it seems that Paul was also involved in his own urging concerns, stressing the duty to pay taxes to legal power instead of limiting Caesar's demands just to it[7]. Paul went a step further, generalizing the meaning of such a payment in the sense of a loyal submission to secular authorities, to which Paul grants not only the right to solicit tax payments, but also a providential role in administrating human justice (verse four). Early Christian exegetes were aware of the reasons for Paul's position, not only those who lived before Constantine such as Justin or Origen, but also writers like John Chrysostom or Theodoretus of Cyrus who lived in a Christian empire. In their exegesis, Paul's request of loyalty is clearly

[4] Eric Voegelin, Hitler and the Germans, in: *id.*, *Complete works*, vol. 31 (Columbia, 1999).

[5] Here, I summarize a part of a more general survey of the exegesis of *Rom.* 13 and *Matth.* 22:21: Marco Rizzi, *Cesare e Dio: Potere spirituale e potere secolare in Occidente* (Bologna, 2009), especially 59-106 for the Patristic authors here taken into consideration. See also Marco Rizzi, Teologia politica: il potere della rappresentazione e la rappresentazione del potere, in: Paolo Bettiolo and Giovanni Filoramo (eds.), *Il dio mortale: Teologie politiche tra antico e contemporaneo* (Brescia, 2002), 267-99; *id.*, Le teologie politiche, in: Giuseppe Alberigo, Giuseppe Ruggeri, and Roberto Rusconi (eds.), *Il cristianesimo: Grande atlante* (Torino, 2005), III 1045-60.

[6] Of course, this is one the main point of debate among last fifty years scholars, but ancient exegesis confirms such a trend, as I shortly summarize *infra*.

[7] I've discussed in details this problematic issue in M. Rizzi, *Cesare e Dio* (2009), 36-53.

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ascribed to the historical situation in which the Apostle wrote, when Christian were under suspicion of political sedition. So, Justin or the anonymous redactor of the *Acta martyrum scillitanorum* could quote or hint at Paul to show their attitude in paying the duty and consequently their loyalty towards the Empire.[8] However, they are not interested in a general principle, but only in their actual situation. Post-Constantinian exegetes were also aware of the historical context in which Paul wrote. Just to quote only a few Greek examples, in his twenty-third homily on Romans John Chrysostom affirms that in this way Paul wanted to silence those who imprisoned Christians, because at his time rumours against Christians were widespread, charging them of subversion, troubling public order and transgression of established laws. In this way, Chrysostom says, Paul could explain the contents of the true faith with more confidence, having stopped false incriminations.[9] Apollinaris of Laodicea is even more historically precise, or so pretends, attributing to Paul the will to prevent Christians from imitating the bad example of Judas the Galilee, who started a riot that brought along great mourning, as recorded in *Acts* 5:37.[10] But in the same text quoted above, John Chrysostom doesn't hesitate to affirm that Paul is not speaking of a particular ruler; instead, he's speaking of the problem of power itself. In John's exegesis, the Apostle was illustrating the way in which Christ taught his disciples how to improve human living; it has been planned by divine providence that somebody commands and others obey, to maintain order in human affairs and not to let them slip away as weaves in the sea.[11] Also according to Theodoretus, Paul is not speaking of a specific ruler or king, but in general; and more generally, he adds that not the power of unjust rulers, but the very ordering principle of authority has its place in God's power.[12] Of course, such a reflexion is deeply marked by the reality of the Christian Empire, along with the necessity to justify also the possibility of bad Christian rulers. But, in my opinion, it is much more heavily determined by the inner logic of any process of text canonization, that is to say the trend to extend their significance from the particular context in which they were written to an absolute and universal meaning. Even against his original intention, Paul's growing authority made his statement normative also out of the boundaries within which he elaborated it. In our case, however, such a tendency is partially balanced by a second direction taken by the early exegesis of Romans thirteen.

The first author who gave a wide interpretation of Paul's text, explicitly touching upon political issues, is Origen. In his *Commentary on Romans*, which

[8] Justin, *1Apol.* 17.1-4; *Acta martyrum Scilitanorum* 6; 9; 12.

[9] Joh. Chrys., *Homiliae in Romanos* 23.1.

[10] Apol. Laod., in: *Catena Graeca in Pauli epistulas* (78 Staab).

[11] Joh. Chrysostom, *Homiliae in Romanos* 23.1.

[12] Theod. Cyr., *Commentarius in Romanos* 13.1. For the West, see *e.g.* Pelagius, *Commentarius in Romanos* 13.1.

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we posses in Rufin's translation, Origen develops the exegesis of chapter thirteen starting from his own anthropological doctrine. He observes that Paul affirms that the soul must submit itself to the *sublimiores potestates*; but in Origen's anthropology the soul is the medium layer of the triple compound that constitutes human subject (*pneuma*, *psyche*, *sarx*). Man's free will is located in the *psyche* and it can direct itself towards pneumatic realities or fleshly ones, so that only men whose soul is completely devoted to their upper element can exempt themselves from submission to secular authorities. All other people must obey authorities, as long as they are engaged in worldly activities. At this point, Origen quotes *Matth.* 22:21 in order to legitimate and, at the same time, to limit the impact of such an assertion: 'If we are not yet such (i.e. entirely pneumatic), but the soul within us is a common one so that it owns something of this world and it is linked to it for some aspects, for this soul the Apostle establishes precepts and command that it must be submitted to this world authority, because the Lord too has told that those who hold on themselves Caesar's inscription must render to Caesar the things which are Caesar's'.[13] It is worthy noting that Origen transfers the very idea of the *imago Caesaris* from the coin of the tribute to man's soul, revolving in this place the more common exegesis which stresses, on the contrary, the necessity to rebuild God's image in men.[14] In Origen's view, to give Caesar what is Caesar's, constitutes a mere consequence of being within the realm of the sensible world. If even Christ, who in no way bore on himself Caesar's image, wanted to pay the tribute on behalf of Peter and himself, as shown by the Gospel episode of the Temple tax in Capharnaum (*Matth.* 17:24), how much more necessary will it be for us, who fully deal within this fleshy world – concludes Origen![15] In this way, he creates an exegetical chain by linking Romans thirteen, Matthew twenty-two and Matthew seventeen around the ideas of tribute and image; such an exegesis remains the same in all his works.

Having established the legitimacy of secular power, Origen goes on examining the case in which political authorities persecuted Christians. Commenting Paul's key statement (*omnis potestas a Deo*), Origen compares worldly *potestas* to the five senses which everybody can use for good or bad sake. Political rulers too must use responsibly their power in order to afford the last judgement: both submission and *potestas* are located in the exercise of human free will and so they pertain to the sphere of men's souls. But Origen goes a step further, operating with an exegetical audacity which will have no equal for long. Indeed, Origen determines a realm of specific jurisdiction for the political *potestas*, when he observes that authority is God's servant (*Rom.* 13:4) because the Apostles have set only religious duties in the synod of Jerusalem (*Acts* 15), without

[13] Orig., *Commentarius in Romanos* IX 26.
[14] See also Orig., *Homiliae in Lucam* 39.4-5.
[15] Orig., *Commentarius in Romanos* IX 30.

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any specific prohibition of theft, murder or any other crime, because these were and are already punished by human laws. Therefore, Origen assigns to secular power the specific function to assure respect of the *lex naturae*, inscribed into the worldly realm, while Christian revelation with its duty pertains only to the spiritual and intelligible religious world.[16] With such a radical separation, Origen prevents the question that will trouble western Christianity from Augustine onwards: which is the actual *ordo potestatum*?[17]

In the West, Ambrose is the direct heir of Origen's political exegesis. Facing the contradiction between Paul's statement *omnis potestas a Deo* and the second temptation of Jesus in the desert (*Luke* 4:6), in which the devil affirms to have in his hands all the power and the glory of this world, Ambrose reduces the demonic stigmata of political power to the sole human *ambitio* that follows it, because this world and its logic are posed under Devil's sign. Again, man's free will is at stake: there is no guilt in power itself, but in those who wield it and by no means God's order is incorrect, but only the conduct of those who administrate it.[18] But Ambrose's key text on this matter is his *Sermo contra Auxentium*, in which he explains his position in the Basilicas's conflict of 386. Facing the emperor's claims to acquire control over some churches by virtue of his authority, Ambrose evokes *Matth.* 22:21 and rhetorically asks whether the emperor could exhibit a coin of Caesar to pay for the basilicas which belong to the church. But in the church – Ambrose answers – there is only an imagine, i.e. the *imago* of the invisible God, of which God said 'Let us make man in our image, after our likeness' (*Gen.* 2:26).[19] We can understand the exact meaning of such a statement by observing that just few years before the so called Ambrosiaster had introduced in the exegesis of Romans thirteen a note which would have changed the course of western political theology: 'The Apostle calls *principes* (*Rom.* 13:3) those rulers who are created to improve human life and to prohibit the contrary, bearing in themselves the image of God, so that all the people be submitted to one'.[20] First Eusebius had attributed the *status* of divine icons (more exactly of icons of the same Logos) to emperors and bishops, so modifying the traditional Alexandrian theology which envisaged every man as created *kat'eikona* of God.[21] For Eusebius, the two icons had historically

[16] Origen, *Commentarius in Romanos* IX 28.

[17] On this topic, see *e.g.* Janet Coleman, The two Jurisdiction: Theological and Legal Justifications of Church Property in the Thirteenth Century, in: William J. Sheils and Diana Wood (eds.), *The Church and Wealth* (Oxford, 1987), 75-111; Jürgen Miethke, Die Legitimität der politischen Ordnung im Spätmittelalter: Theorie des frühen 14. Jahrhunderts, in: Burkhard Mojsisch and Olaf Pluta (eds.), *Historia Philosophiae Medii Aevii* (Amsterdam and Philadelphia, 1991), 643-74.

[18] Ambr., *Expositio in Lucam* IV 29.

[19] Ambr., *Sermo contra Auxentium* 31-2.

[20] Ambrosiaster, *Commentarius in Romanos* 13.3.

[21] On this topic see M. Rizzi, *Teologia politica* (2002), 284-91; Raffaello Farina, *L'impero e l'imperatore cristiano in Eusebio di Cesarea: La prima teologia politica del cristianesimo*

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coincided in Constantine, but in Eusebius's thought and in the successive Byzantine political theology the Origenian heritage determines their respective boundaries, so that the two authorities have more reasons to cooperate than to conflict – at least on a theoretical level. But Ambrosiaster moves a step aside from Eusebius. He affirms that the king bears God's image and the bishop Christ's one, so that the former could be defined *vicarius Dei*, and the latter *vicarius Christi*:[22] here we can grasp the very fist hint to the dualistic form of power which will characterize the following western political theology. But Ambrosiaster doesn't elaborate on such a couple, nor on the relationship between emperor and bishops in the mirror of God's and Logos' one, so that the full implication of his *formula* will be fully developed only in subsequent centuries[23].

In this framework[24], Ambrose rescues the original Alexandrian theology of the *imago* and affirms that emperors bear no special imagine within the church, because the icon of the God-man Christ is the only legitimate icon in the church.[25] Once more, the absolute power of political authority stated by Romans thirteen is restricted by the interpretation of *Matth.* 22:21; but at variance with Origen, Ambrose wrote in a Christian empire, so that his use of the Gospel saying tries to legitimate an exemption from that power, instead of legitimating a specific sphere for its exercise. The two New Testament texts are mutually inclusive and complementary. In Ambrosiaster's exegesis, on the contrary, to assign a specific iconic role to the emperor reverses the relation between Romans thirteen and Matthew twenty-two: in Origen and Ambrose the latter limits the former and attenuates its political theological claims on both sides (i.e. on the religious side in Origen and on the political one in Ambrose); in Ambrosiaster, Matthew twenty-two is logically subordinated to Romans thirteen and functions as a reinforcement of it, confirming the direct dependence of political authority from God, without any ethical or jurisdictional limitation: 'The Apostle commands to pay tributes in order to demonstrate submission and to understand not to be free, but to live under authority which comes from God. They must submit themselves to their ruler, who acts in the place of God, as prophet Daniel says: "The Most High gives the kingdom to whom he will" (*Dan.* 4:22, 29; 5:21); in the same way also the Lord: "Render unto Caesar...". So, they must submit to their ruler as to God: and the proof of their submission

(Zürich, 1966); Gilbert Dagron, *Emperor et prêtre: Étude sur le 'cesaropapisme' bizantin* (Paris, 1995), 145-53.

[22] Ambrosiaster, *Quaestiones veteris et novi Testamenti* 35.

[23] As noted also by Sophie Lunn-Rockliffe, *Ambrosiaster's Political Theology* (Oxford, 2007) 117-9. For subsequent developments, see M. Rizzi, *Cesare e Dio* (2009), 112-22.

[24] Since the difficulty to define the exact chronology of Ambrosiaster's works, it's impossible to say whether Ambrose was reacting directly to them. But it is sure that his education took place in the same context of Christian Rome from which also Abrosiaster's works sprung up.

[25] Ambr., *Sermo c. Aux.* 31-32.

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consists in paying taxes'.[26] Ambrosiaster's harsh literalism destroys Origen's refined exegesis, which survives for the last time in the West thanks to Ambrose. In Ambrosiaster we have no hint at the role of man's free will; moreover, connecting directly God and the *princeps* without any theological articulation opens the way to make of him the absolute Christian ruler.

Augustine marks the end of the Origenian exegetical tradition of Romans thirteen. At first sight, he does not seem to have moved too far away, especially on the practical side; he uses again the text of *Matth.* 22:21 to limit the demands of the *sublimiores potestates* of *Rom.* 13:1 and to establish what is owed by man to his earthly condition regarding that which pertains to future life in heaven; Augustine affirms that man must respect the limits posed by our Lord when He said to give to Caesar what is Caesar's and to God what is God's. Even if man is called to enter the heavenly kingdom, where the authorities of this world will have no place, he must endure to suffer with patience his condition and submit himself to the established order for human things, as long as he is in this life and not yet in heaven, where every power and authority will be set apart.[27] The submission Augustine requires, then, is limited to what pertains to earthly life, without touching in any way upon questions of faith. But Augustine inserts this traditional view into a different anthropological structure from that of Origen and the Greek theological tradition in general. By renouncing to Paul's and Origen's trichotonomic anthropology and accepting a dualistic scheme made of soul and body, Augustine compresses the place of man's free will within the political realm: the soul is no more a medium between *sarx* (to which politics pertain) and *pneuma* (to which heavenly realities pertain), but the realm of the *res temporales* which is theologically and ontologically subordinated to the *res spirituales*, to which only the soul really pertains. 'Since we are made of soul and body and as long as we are in this secular life, we must submit ourselves to authorities for what pertains to this present life, it means to those who rule human things taking honour from it. On the contrary, because we believe in God and we are called to His Kingdom, in this respect we must not be submitted to anybody, especially if he pretends to subvert what God has given us graciously for the sake of eternal life. So, a Christian would be deeply wrong if he thinks not to pay taxes or not to tribute honours because him being a Christian. But it would be a deeper error if he would think to submit himself to the authorities (which occupy an eminent place in order to administrate secular things) to the point that he acknowledges them the power over his own faith'.[28]

Diverging from Eusebius and Ambrose, Augustine was never so close to power and to its exercise to experiment directly the way in which his theological

[26] Ambrosiaster, *Commentarius in Romanos* 13.3.
[27] Aug., *Expositio quarundam propositionum ex epistula ad Rom*anos 64.72.
[28] *Ibid.*

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speculations would concretely interact with the political theological confrontation between political and ecclesiastical authorities which was started by Constantine. Even from these few words, it is easy to foresee the jurisdictional claim that will be invoked by the religious power over and against the political one, by virtue of the supremacy of heaven on earth, or of the soul on the body, to use a formula that will become canonical from Gelasius's rescript onward. Moreover, the political consequences of Augustine's dualistic anthropology will be strengthened by the ambiguities and the misunderstandings of his theory of the two cities, summed up in the so called political Augustinianism of the early middle age.[29] This development and the persistence of Ambrosiaster's two *vicarii* are the fuel that ignited the theological political debate in Western medieval Christianity, centred on the issue of the *ordo potestatum* and their reciprocal jurisdictions.[30] But at this point of the story, the exegetical focus will be centred no more on Romans thirteen or Matthew twenty-two, by this time taken for granted, but on the image of the two swords of *Luke* 22:38.[31]

At the beginning of the sixteenth century, Erasmus and the Reformation will re-actualise the reflection on the exegetical relation between Romans thirteen and the tribute episode. But for a very short time: once again, the Pauline statement *omnis potestas a Deo* will soon take the central place. Only after World War II Romans thirteen will begin to lose its primacy in favour of a new reading of *Matth.* 22:21: thus, the legend of an original separation of politics and religion within Christianity has begun spreading. Indeed, ancient Christian exegetes tell a different and more interesting story.

[29] See, *e.g.*, Eric L. Saak, *High Way to Heaven: The Augustinian Platform between Reform and Reformation, 1292-1524* (Leiden, 2002), 15-159.

[30] J. Coleman, *The Two Jurisdiction* (1987), 78-82.

[31] See Gerard Caspary, *Politics and Exegesis: Origen and the Two Swords* (Berkeley, 1979).

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A Letter 'Weighty and Powerful': The Importance of 1*Corinthians* in the Early Church

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Introduction

Among Paul's letters to early Christian communities, 1*Corinthians* is the most rooted in the concrete here and now of a particular historical situation, and it gives us a fascinating glimpse of the life of one group of early Christians and Paul's interactions with them. Written to a church Paul knows especially well, in response to a letter from the Corinthians asking him for guidance (7:1), it gives advice on such matters as how to heal factions in the community, how to conduct common worship, and how to live out the Christian life in the everyday world. The letter begins with a powerful presentation of the cross of Christ as the paradoxical revelation of God's wisdom and power (1:17-25) and concludes with an extended discussion of the general resurrection of the dead and God's final triumph over evil (15:1-58). It includes a long discussion of marriage and sexual relations (7:1-40) and the earliest version we have of the words of institution of the Eucharist (11:23-25). The patristic commentary on 1*Cor.* is a vast treasure house. Verse-by-verse comment, in commentaries and series of sermons, began in the third century with the homilies of Origen, substantial fragments of which remain.[1] From the Greek Fathers our most important source for sustained commentary is the forty-four homilies on 1*Cor.* preached by John Chrysostom in Antioch.[2] We also have complete versions of the commentaries by Theodoret of Cyrus and John of Damascus.[3] The fragments from the commentaries of Severian of Gabala, Didymus the Blind, Theodore of Mopsuestia, Oecumenius of Tricca, and Photius are unfortunately quite sparse.[4] More substantial fragments survive from the commentary of Cyril of Alexandria.[5] From

[1] *Homilies on 1 Corinthians*, Claude Jenkins (ed.): *JTS* 9 (1908) 232-47, 353-72, 500-14; *JTS* 10 (1909) 29-51.

[2] PG 6, 7-382.

[3] Theodoret (PG 82, 225-376); John of Damascus (PG 95, 569-705).

[4] Karl Staab (ed.), *Pauluskommentar aus der griechischen Kirche aus Katenenhandschriften gesammelt* (Münster, 1933), 6-14 (Didymus); 225-77 (Severian); 172-96 (Theodore); 432-43 (Oecumenius); 544-85 (Photius).

[5] Philip Edward Pusey (ed.), in: *Cyril of Alexandria, D. Joannis evangelium* (Brussels, 1965), III 249-318.

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the Latin Fathers we have succinct commentaries by Ambrosiaster, Pelagius, and Cassiodorus.[6]

To form an accurate picture of how 1*Cor.* figured in early Christian thought and practice we must also look beyond the commentary tradition, to comments in theological treatises, polemical writings, monastic rules, letters, liturgies, and sermons on other parts of Scripture. The sermons of Augustine, for example, contain many discussions of texts from 1*Cor.*, as do Origen's *On First Principles* and *Commentary on John*. In countless patristic works Paul's words are brought to bear on the pastoral issues and the theological controversies of a later day. The Fathers' commentary on 1*Cor.* refers frequently to figures such as Marcion, Arius, Eunomius, Mani, and Donatus, whose views provoked much reflection.

Apart from its opening and closing salutations (1:1-9 and 16:1-12) 1*Cor.* can be divided into five parts. I will I go through the letter section by section, first summarizing the content and then sketching out some of the main lines of patristic exegesis.[7]

Part I: 1*Cor.* 1-4

Chapters 1-4 have two main themes: (1) the problem of divisions within the fledling Christian community in Corinth and (2) the cross of Christ as the demonstration of God's wisdom (1:17-2:16). Confronting the scandal of the cross head-on, Paul presents Christ as the paradoxical demonstration of God's power and wisdom (1:24.30). In chapters 3-4 he then uses himself as an example of imitation of Christ: he does not seek his own glory but is content to seem foolish and weak.

I will mention two examples of how this section of the letter figures in patristic discussions. In chapter 1 Paul describes his preaching of the cross as 'foolishness' but then in 2:6-16 he claims that he *does* speak wisdom among the 'perfect', a wisdom that is understood by those who are 'spiritual' not by those who are *psychikos* ('unspiritual'). In 3:1-3 Paul says that he did not impart this hidden wisdom to the Corinthians because they were still 'babes' in Christ; he gave them 'milk' not 'solid food'. The followers of the gnostic Valentinus claimed to be the 'spiritual' people of whom Paul speaks and that ordinary Christians were the *psychikoi* whom Paul describes as unable to receive the superior wisdom. Such claims were disputed by Clement and Origen who argue

[6] Ambrosiaster (CSEL 81, 2, 3-194); Pelagius, in: Alexander Souter (ed.), *Expositions of Thirteen Epistles of St. Paul* (Cambridge, 1922), II 126-230; Cassiodorus (PL 68, 505-54).

[7] For other texts see Judith L. Kovacs. *1 Corinthians: The Church's Bible* (Grand Rapids, Mich., 2005). There is a considerable secondary literature on patristic exegesis of verses from 1*Cor.*; for reasons of space I am able to cite here only a few titles.

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that the 'solid food' refers not to superior teaching available only to the gnostics but to a higher understanding of the church's teaching.[8]

In patristic discussions of christology three passages from 1*Cor.* received particular attention: 1:30, 8:6 and 15:24-8. The first of these reads: 'You are from him [God] in Christ Jesus, whom God made our wisdom, our righteousness and sanctification and redemption'.[9] Severian of Gabala comments:

'You are from him in Christ Jesus.' All interpreters alike say that these words refer to salvation, not to creation, as it says elsewhere: 'Who were born, not of blood nor of the will of the flesh... but of God' (*John* 1:13). If therefore 'You are from him', how should we boast in our own accomplishments? (*Commentary on 1 Corinthians*, 230-1 Staab)

Ambrosiaster explains that the four epithets given to Christ in this verse are different ways of expressing his salvific work:

No one redeems something unless it is his own. Whether therefore because we have been redeemed or because we have been sanctified (i.e. cleansed from the works of the flesh and the impurity of idols) or because we have been made just – for it is just to worship the creator and scorn other things – or because we have become wise by learning that worldly men are ignorant, all these benefits given by God come through Christ. 'Our redemption', however, consists in this: Christ offered himself to the devil, when the devil demanded, in order that he might take upon himself the cancelling of sin and thus rescue those held captive by the devil. (*Commentary on 1 Corinthians*, CSEL 81/2, 20-1)

Origen's exegesis of 1:30 was to have wide influence. He often cites it together with 1*Cor.* 1:24, where Paul calls Christ the 'power' and 'wisdom' of God.[10] Arguing that the five terms found in these two verses – power, wisdom, righteousness, sanctification and redemption – refer in their absolute sense only to Christ, he adds: 'Everyone, however, who has become conformed to his resurrection receives the power to live unto God from his life, since Jesus, "in that he lives, lives unto God" (*Rom.* 6:10).'[11] The goal of the Christian life is to participate fully in Christ, and one becomes 'wise' or 'righteous' only by participating in Christ who is wisdom and righteousness:

Each of the wise participates in Christ to the extent that he has the capacity for wisdom, insofar as Christ is wisdom, just as each one who possesses power has obtained greater power to the extent that he has shared in Christ, insofar as Christ is power. We must also consider sanctification and redemption, in the same way.... And each of us is sanctified by that sanctification and redeemed in relation to that redemption. For we must pay attention to the apostle's purpose in adding 'for us' when he says, 'Who

[8] See J.L. Kovacs, Echoes of Valentinian Exegesis in Clement of Alexandria and Origen, in: Lorenzo Perrone (ed.), *Origeniana Octava* (Leuven, 2004), 317-29.

[9] Except for this verse, I cite all biblical texts in the Revised Standard Version translation. All translations from the Greek Fathers are my own. Translations from Latin Fathers are by P. David Kovacs, in: J.L. Kovacs, *1 Corinthians* (2005).

[10] See, *e.g.*, *De principiis* I 2.1; II 9.4.

[11] *Comm. in Io.* I 59.

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became for us wisdom from God, and righteousness, and sanctification, and redemption.' (*Comm. Io.* I 246-8)

This verse also stimulated Gregory's of Nyssa reflections on the spiritual life. By linking Christ as 'righteousness' with the blessing of those who 'hunger and thirst after righteousness' in *Matth.* 5:6 he portrays Christ as the ultimate end of the soul's longing.

'Blessed', Christ says, 'are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they shall be satisfied' (*Matth.* 5:6).... It seems to me that in this teaching about virtue and righteousness what the Lord offers to his hearers as the object of their desire is himself, he 'whom God made our wisdom, our righteousness and sanctification and redemption'.... For in truth, the one who has tasted the Lord (*Ps.* 34:8), as the Psalm says – that is, who has received God into himself – will be full of that for which he hungered and thirsted. (*De beatitudinibus* 4, GNO VII 2, 122)

This tradition of interpretation is also evident in Gregory of Nazianus[12] and Maximus the Confessor who says:

Now it is clear that the Word of God is the substance of the virtue that each person possesses. For our Lord Jesus Christ is himself the substance of all the virtues, as it is written: 'whom God made our wisdom, our righteousness and sanctification and redemption'. Of course these words apply to him in an absolute sense, since he is wisdom itself and likewise righteousness and sanctification. These things are not merely attributed to him, as they are in our case, as for example when one speaks of a 'wise person' or a 'just person'. (*Ambiguum* 7, PG 91, 1081-4)

Part II: 1*Cor.* 5-7

In chapters 5-7 Paul turns to issues of sexual morality. One man was sleeping with his stepmother (5:1-8), while others saw Paul's message of freedom in Christ as license to consort with prostitutes (6:12-20). In chapter 7, a long discussion of marriage, Paul's perspective is ambivalent. He begins by saying: 'It is good for a man not to touch a woman.' (7:1),[13] but then instructs married couples to have regular sexual relations, abstaining only for limited periods 'for the sake of prayer' (7:5). He gives the unwed and widows permission to marry (7:9, 28), but says that the celibate life is better (7:38) and pictures married persons as anxious about affairs of the world and distracted from single-minded devotion to God (1*Cor.* 7:32-5).

As the only extended treatment of marriage in the New Testament, this chapter received much attention from the Fathers. The many interpretations of this

[12] *Oration* 30, 16-20 (SC 250, 260-70).

[13] A view current among New Testament scholars is that in 7:1 Paul is quoting a Corinthian slogan, with which he does not entirely agree; see, *e.g.*, Anthony Thiselton, *The First Epistle to the Corinthians* (Grand Rapids, Mich., 2000), 498-501.

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text have been surveyed by Elizabeth Clark[14] and David Hunter.[15] Hunter argues that 1*Cor.* 7 was at the center of attempts to define orthodoxy on marriage and celibacy from the second century on. He traces three stages in this process. First is the response to radical encratism in the Pastorals, Irenaeus, and Clement of Alexandria, who devotes a whole book of his *Miscellanies* to marriage. The second phase is the moderate encratism of Tertullian and Origen, who do not forbid marriage but describe marital intercourse in negative terms, thus laying the foundation for an ascetic hierarchy. Origen particularly emphasizes 1*Cor.* 7:5, where Paul allows married couples to abstain temporarily from sex 'that you may devote yourselves to prayer'. To Origen this indicates the incompatibility of sexual intercourse with participation in the Eucharist.

In the fourth century the Roman monk Jovinian aroused Jerome's ire by arguing that married and celibate Christians have equal merit, a position he supports by quoting 1*Cor.* 7:39: 'A wife is bound to her husband as long as he lives. If the husband dies, she is free to be married to whom she wishes, only in the Lord.' Jerome responds with an exegesis of 1*Cor.* 7 that is indebted to Tertullian and Origen but takes an even more negative view of marriage. He argues that if Paul says in 7:1 that 'it is good for a man not to touch a woman' then touching a woman, i.e. marrying, must be bad. Hunter traces a third stage in the development of the orthodox position on marriage at this point, as the extreme views of both Jerome and Jovinian are rejected. This is evident in the writings of Pelagius, the anonymous author of *Consultationes Zacchaei et Apollonii*, and Augustine, which champion the celibate life but maintain the essential goodness of marriage. In treatises on virginity by Athanasius, Ambrose, John Chrysostom, and Gregory of Nyssa, 1*Cor.* 7 plays a prominent role, in paricular verse 38 where Paul says that marriage is 'good' but remaining single is 'better'.

Part III: 1*Cor.* 8-10

In chapters 8-10 Paul discusses how to live in a non-Christian world, in particular whether Christians may eat meat that has been sacrificed to Greek gods or attend dinners held in the precincts of their temples (8:10; 10:27). Instead of laying down down a firm law, Paul advises the Corinthians to act in such a way as to 'build up' the whole community (8:1; 10:23). In Chapter 9 he again uses

[14] *Reading Renunciation: Asceticism and Scripture in Early Christianity* (Princeton, 1999), 259-329.

[15] The Reception and Interpretation of Paul in Late Antiquity: 1 Corinthians 7 and the Ascetic Debates, in: Lorenzo DiTommaso and Lucien Turescu (eds.), *The Reception and Interpretation of the Bible in Late Antiquity:* Proceedings of the Montreal Colloquium in Honour of Charles Kannengiesser, 11-13 October 2006 (Leiden, 2008), 163-91.

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himself as example, describing how he has waived his right to financial support in order to foster the good of the community (9:1-26).

Patristic views on whether Paul allows or forbids the eating of food dedicated to pagan gods are discussed in an article by Riemer Roukema in the present volume.[16] I will focus on three other motifs from this section of Paul's letter. The first is an interesting example of how Paul's words were brought to bear on a new situation, quite different from the original context. A *leitmotif* of this section of 1*Cor.* is *oikodome* – 'building up' the Christian community, which Paul says is a greater good than exercizing one's freedom or demonstrating one's knowledge (in this case knowledge that idols have 'no real existence', 1*Cor.* 8:4). Gregory of Nyssa sees an analogy to this in a situation faced by his brother Basil, whom Eunomius had accused of inconsistency concerning whether God the Father was to be called 'ungenerated' (*agennetos*). Gregory defends Basil by appealing to Paul's example:

> And what does Paul, the 'imitator of Christ' (1*Cor.* 11:1), say?... although he pronounces all things good and says that 'nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving' (1*Tim.* 4:4), sometimes, on account of a conscience that is weak (1*Cor.* 8:10) he takes back something that he had approved and orders us to avoid it. For he says, if 'my brother' comes to grief on account of food, 'I will never eat meat' (8:13). This, then, is what Basil, the imitator of Paul, does as well. He saw that in the wicked usage of the heretics the word 'ungenerated' made more persuasive the deceitful teaching of those who maintain that the Son is dissimilar to the Father. Therefore while counseling us to keep the pious understanding of the 'ungenerated' Father in our hearts, he bids us not to be overzealous about using this word since 'for those who are perishing' (1*Cor.* 1:18) it had provided support to sin. (*Contra Eunomium* III 8, GNO I 184)

A second motif in 1*Cor.* 8 that figured in fourth century Trinitarian debates is the confession of faith verses 5-6:

> For although there may be so-called gods in heaven or on earth – as indeed there are many 'gods' and many 'lords' – yet for us there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things and for whom we exist, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things and through whom we exist.

Contemporary New Testament scholars, interested in the origins of this confession, suggest that it is an expansion of the central Jewish prayer, the *Shema,* which begins: 'Hear O Israel: The Lord is our God, the Lord is one' (*Deut.* 6:4-5).[17] The question that most concerned the Fathers was what this text implies about the Son. Theodoret, John Chrysostom, and Gregory of Nyssa all seek to combat the view that Paul here denies the divinity of the Son. For example Theodoret writes:

[16] Paul's Admonitions on Idol Offerings (1*Cor.* 8 and 10) in Patristic Interpretation, in: *SP* 44 (2010) 249-58.

[17] See, *e.g.*, A. Thiselton, *The First Epistle to the Corinthians* (2000), 636-8.

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Now if the followers of Arius and Eunomius should say that the phrase '[there is] one God' excludes the Son from the divinity of the Father, let them hear what follows: 'and one Lord'. Now if it were true that, because the Father is 'one God', the Son is not God, then neither would the Father be Lord, since '[there is] one Lord Jesus Christ'. But let this blasphemous idea be turned back upon their own heads. For the divine apostle shows the equality of Father and Son, by using the word 'one' for Father and Son alike and also by showing that 'Lord' is the equivalent of 'God'. (*Comm. 1 Cor.*, PG 82, 289)

John Chrysostom makes a similar argument and then goes on to anticipate a possible question: why does Paul not include the Holy Spirit? He answers by adducing 1*Cor.* 12:4-6, in which Paul refers to God, Lord, and Spirit together, and to the Trinitarian blessing in 2*Cor.* 13:14.[18]

Chapter 8 verse 6 also figured in debates between Eunomius and the Cappadocians. Gregory of Nyssa reports that Eunomius had quoted from this verse in a criticism of Basil's exegesis of *Acts* 2:36, which says of Jesus that 'God made him both Lord and Christ'. Basil had claimed that the text from *Acts* refers to the incarnate rather than the preexistent one. Eunomius counters that this interpretation amounts to proclaiming that there are two Lords, and he uses words from 1*Cor.* 8:6 to support his own christology:

Even if Basil and his faithless followers should proclaim, erroneously, that there are two Lords and two Christs 'for us there is one Lord and Christ, by whom all things are made' (1*Cor.* 8:6). (*apud* Gregory of Nyssa, *Contra Eunomium* III 3; GNO II 116)[19]

In another section of his *Against Eunomius* Gregory turns the words of this verse against Eunomius. Against the claim of Eunomius that the Son was a 'servant' ruled by God and thus not equal to God, Gregory argues:

If Eunomius bases this on the Scriptures, let him only adduce such a statement from the holy texts, and we will be silent. I hear Paul crying out: '[There is] one Lord, Jesus Christ.' But Eunomius shouts back at Paul that Christ is a servant. (*Contra Eunomium* III 8; GNO II 255)

Gregory goes on to connect 1*Cor.* 8:6 with *John* 13:13, where Jesus calls himself 'Master' and 'Lord', and then sums up his argument with a rhetorical flourish:

Caught between these voices, then, to whom shall we listen? On the one hand the Lord himself and also Paul, who has Christ speaking in him (1*Cor.* 2:16), command us not to consider Christ a servant, but to honor him in the same way as the Father is honored. Eunomius, on the other hand, accuses the Lord of being a servant and claims that the One on whom the rule of the universe rests is subject to rule. Is there any doubt which we should choose?... Am I to scoff at the counsel of Paul, O Eunomius? (*Contra Eunomium* III 5; GNO II 255-6)

[18] *Hom. 1 Cor.* 20 (PG 61, 162-5).

[19] The teaching of Basil that Eunomius quotes is found in Basil's *Contra Eunomium* II (PG 29, 576D-577A).

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A third passage from this section, 1*Cor.* 10:1-11, had considerable importance for patristic interpretation of the Old Testament. Here Paul buttresses his advice about idol meat through an allegorical interpretation of texts from Exodus and Numbers. Claiming that events of the exodus and the Israelites' wanderings in the wilderness happened 'as figures [*typoi*] for us' (10:6) 'written down for our edification' (10:11), Paul relates these stories to the experience of Christians in the present time. The crossing of the sea (*Ex.* 14-5) is a type of baptism and the eating of manna (*Ex.* 16) a type of the Eucharist. In a homily on Exodus, Origen says that Paul 'has taught the church... how she ought to interpret the books of the law.'[20] The Fathers see this chapter as a model for interpreting the Jewish Scriptures, in that it points to a spiritual meaning that transcends the letter. In book 4 of *On First Principles* Origen mentions 1*Cor.* 10 as a warrant for spiritual exegesis, along with two other texts from 1*Cor.*: the discussion of 'hidden wisdom' in 2:10-6 and 9:9-10 where Paul applies the commandment not to muzzle an ox to his own situation.[21] Augustine makes similar use of 1*Cor.* 10, arguing that the apostle 'by explaining one passage gives the key to the others.'[22] 'No Christian', Augustine claims, 'would dare to maintain that [an Old Testament] narrative is not to be taken in a figurative sense, since the apostle Paul says, "Now these things happened to them as figures (1*Cor.* 10:6)."'[23]

Part IV. 1*Cor.* 11-14

In chapters 11-14 Paul turns to issues that relate to Christian worship: the dress of women who prophesy (11:2-16), how to celebrate the Lord's Supper (11:17-34), the exercise of 'spiritual gifts' such as prophecy and speaking in tongues (12:1-14:40), and whether women are allowed to speak in the assemblies (14:33-6). Here again he appeals to the principle of 'building up': the Corinthians are to use spiritual gifts such as ecstatic speech to edify, rather than divide, the community. To illustrate his point he uses a striking image, presenting the church as the 'body of Christ'. In chapter 13 Paul rises to unusual poetic and rhetorical heights in a description of *agape*, self-giving love.

From the rich patristic reflection on these chapters I will mention five themes. First the words of institution of the Eucharist in 11:23-26 provided the basis for liturgies such as *The Liturgy of St James* and for much theological reflection. Gregory of Nyssa, for example, explains how the eating and drinking of bread and wine brings about the sanctification of the Christian's body, and Ambrose relates the Eucharist to Old Testament precedents and argues that it is the words

[20] *Homilies on Exodus* 5 (SC 321, 148-50).
[21] *De princ.* IV 2, 5-6.
[22] *Contra Faustum* 12.29 (PL 42, 260-1).
[23] *De Genesi ad litteram* I 1.1 (PL 34, 247).

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of our Lord spoken over the elements that make them become his body and blood.[24]

Secondly, a verse that finds particular resonance is 1*Cor.* 13:12: 'For now we see in a mirror in an enigma, but then face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall understand fully, even as I have been fully understood.' This is frequently cited to describe the ultimate goal of Christian life, the beatific vision of God, often quoted together with 1*Cor.* 2:9: 'What no eye has seen, nor ear heard, nor the heart of man conceived, what God has prepared for those who love him.'[25]

Other verses from 1*Cor.* 11-14 figured in controversies. I will mention two examples. Paul's words about women prophets in 11:3-16 were drawn into debates about the Montanist movement, in which women prophets played prominent roles. In *The Dialogue of a Montanist with an Orthodox Christian* the Montanist argues:

> Why do you reject the holy women Maximilla and Priscilla and say that women are not allowed to prophesy? Did not Philipp also have four daughters who prophesied (*Acts* 21:9)? And was Deborah not a prophetess (*Judg.* 4:4)? And if it is not lawful for women to prophesy or pray, would the apostle say: 'any woman who prays or prophesies with her head unveiled' (1*Cor.* 11:5)? But if women pray, let them also prophesy.[26]

The Orthodox speaker, who gets the last word in this dialogue, responds with another text from 1*Cor.*, the command that women keep silent in 14:34. He also offers a symbolic exegesis of 11:5, where Paul forbids women to prophesy with unveiled heads, which he interprets as a proscription of publishing books in their own names, an action that would dishonor their 'heads' i.e. their husbands (see 11:3). Paul's command that women be silent in 1*Cor.* 14:34-5 is also cited by Origen to discredit the Montanist movement.[27]

Texts from this section of 1*Cor.* also played a role in patristic debates about the Holy Spirit. Paul's discussion of spiritual gifts in 1*Cor.* 12-14 contains several verses that were cited as arguments for the Spirit's divinity.[28] Athanasius, in a *Letter to Serapion*, notes how in 12:4-6 Paul names all three persons of the Trinity as givers of the spiritual gifts:

[24] Greg. Nys., *Oratio catechetica magna* 37 (GNO III 4, 93-4; 96-9); Ambr., *De mysteriis* 47-8, 50-2, 54-5 (FC III 240-8).

[25] See for example, Aug., *Sermon* 53.7, 16 (PL 38, 366-67, 371-72) and *id.*, *Sermon* 362.29 (PL 39, 1632-3). On the use 1*Cor.* 13:12 by Gregory of Nyssa see Lucas Mateo-Seco, 1 Cor 13.12 in Gregory of Nyssa's Theological Thinking: *SP* 2 (1957) 153-62.

[26] *Dialogue of a Montanist and an Orthodox Christian*, in: Gerhard Ficker, Widerlegung eines Montanisten: *ZKG* 26 (1905) 447-63, 456.

[27] *Hom. 1 Cor.*: *JTS* 10 (1909) 29-51, 41-2. For other patristic texts that reflect this debate see Caroline Bammel, Die Prophetie in der Patristischen Exegese zum Ersten Korintherbrief: *Aug.* 29 (1989) 157-69.

[28] In addition to the verses discussed here, other texts from 1*Cor.* cited include: 2:10-2; 3:16-7 and 8:6. For further discussion see Michael Haykin, *The Spirit of God: The Exegesis of 1 and 2 Corinthians in the Pneumatomachian Controversy of the Fourth Century* (Leiden, 1994).

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The blessed Paul... does not divide the Trinity... rather he teaches its unity when he writes to the Corinthians about spiritual gifts. He presents God the Father as the source of them all, saying: 'Now there are varieties of gifts, but the same Spirit; and there are varieties of service, but the same Lord; and there are varieties of working, but it is the same God who inspires them all in every one.' What the Spirit gives to each individual is furnished by the Father through the Word. (*Ad Serapionem* I 30; PG 26, 597-600)

Athanasius also calls attention to the phrase 'one and the same Spirit' in 12:11, which he says indicates that the Spirit is a unity, like the Son and the Father and unlike creatures, who are many.[29] In 12:13 Paul says 'we were all made to drink of one Spirit', which suggests to Athanasius an image for the three persons of the Trinity as fountain, river, and drink:

And again, since the Father is called a 'fountain' (*Jer.* 2:13; *Bar.* 3:10-2) and the Son a 'river' (*Ps.* 65:9), we are said to 'drink' the Spirit. For it is written: 'we all were made to drink of one Spirit'. And being 'made to drink' the Spirit, we drink Christ. 'For they drank from the supernatural Rock which followed them, and the Rock was Christ (1*Cor.* 10:4).' (*Ad Serapionem* I 19; PG 26, 573-6)

In his treatise *On the Holy Spirit* Basil of Caesarea cites these same texts[30] as well as others from 1*Cor.*, including 12:3: 'no one can say "Jesus is Lord" except in the Holy Spirit.' Basil argues: 'If anyone rejects the Spirit, his faith in the Father and the Son will turn out to be "in vain" (1*Cor.* 15:14).'[31] He also appeals to 1*Cor.* 14:24-5, where Paul says that an unbeliever hearing a prophet speak will 'declare that God is really among you.' Since prophets speak by the Spirit, Basil argues, this text shows clearly that the Spirit is God.[32] Theodoret makes a similar point in his *Commentary on 1 Corinthians*.[33]

The fifth theme I want to highlight in patristic interpretation of 1*Cor.* 11-4 is the image of the church as the 'body of Christ' in chapter 12. To the divided community in Corinth Paul says that individual Christians are like the parts of a body; though they have different functions all are necessary for the health of the whole body (12:12-30). Augustine's sermons illustrate the versatility of this image, as he uses it to give pastoral advice for several quite varied situations. In one sermon it serves to remind celibates not to scorn married Christians – whom Augustine compares to the 'weaker members' Paul mentions in 12:22. In another sermon he uses Paul's image to correct Donatists who wanted to exclude from the body of Christ weaker Christians who were not faithful in times of persecution. A third sermon, delivered on the feast day of the martyrs Perpetua and Felicity, focuses on the 'more presentable'

[29] *Ad Serapionem* III 3-4 (PG 26, 629).
[30] Basil cites 1*Cor.* 12:4-6 and 11 in *De Spiritu Sancto* 24.55-7 (SC 17, 450-4).
[31] *De Spiritu Sancto* 11.27 (SC 17, 342).
[32] *De Spiritu Sancto* 16.37 (SC 17, 374-6).
[33] PG 82, 344.

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members of Christ's body (12:24), using Paul's image to encourage reverence for the martyrs.[34]

Part V: 1*Cor.* 15

In chapter 15 Paul argues that belief in Christ's resurrection necessarily implies faith that *all* the dead will be raised. This will take place at Christ's second coming when he will complete his victory over evil and death and usher in God's kingdom, so that God may be 'all in all' (15:28). In the resurrection the present body will be transformed into a 'spiritual body' (15:44).

In the second century some gnostic Christians gave a purely spiritual interpretation of the future life promised by Paul, emphasizing 15:50: 'Flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God.'[35] This exegesis called forth strong opposition from Fathers such as Irenaeus and Tertullian, who use the chapter to argue that the flesh is included in the promised future life.[36]

This chapter also proved important in discussions of soteriology and christology. Verses 24-28, which describe Christ's complete victory over all the enemies of God including death, end with these words: 'When all things are subjected to him, then the Son himself will also be subjected to him who put all things under him, that God may be all in all.' This verse was a favorite of Origen's, who saw here a promise that ultimately all evil will be eradicated and all rational beings restored to the contemplation of God.[37] Gregory of Nyssa devoted a whole treatise to this verse,[38] in which he follows Origen in seeing it as a promise that *all* will be saved – the teaching of the *apokatastasis*.[39] Gregory also considers the verse's christological implications, arguing against

[34] *Sermon* 354.3-5 (PL 39, 1564-5); *Sermon* 162A.4-5, 6-7 (=19 Denis, MA 1, 103-4); *Sermon* 280.1, 6 (PL 38, 1281-4). For interpretations of the 'body of Christ' image by Valentinian gnostics and Clement of Alexandria, see J.L. Kovacs, Clement of Alexandria and Valentinian Exegesis in the *Excerpts from Theodotus*: *SP* 41 (2006) 187-200.

[35] For gnostic interpretations of 1*Cor.* 15 see, e.g., the *Gospel of Philipp*, NHC II 3 (56.27-57.23); *Treatise on the Resurrection*, NHC I:4 *passim*; Irenaeus, *Adversus haereses* V 31.1.

[36] Irenaeus, *Adv. haer.* V 31.1; Tertullian, *De resurrectione carnis* 16.1-2. On Origen's exegesis, see Riemer Roukema, La résurrection des morts dans l'interprétation origénienne de 1 Corinthiens 15, in: Jean-Marc Prieur (ed.), *La résurrection chez les Pères*, CBiPa 7 (Strasbourg, 2003), 161-77.

[37] Origen cites this verse many times; see, e.g., *De princ.* I 6.4; I 7.5; II 3.5; III 5.7-8; III 3.6.1-9; *id.*, *Comm. in Io.* I 225, 235, 253; VI 296; XX 48.

[38] *In Illud: tunc et ipse filius* (GNO III 2, 3-28).

[39] See the following works of I Ramelli: *Gregorio di Nissa: Sull'anima e la resurrezione* (Milan, 2007); La coerenza della soteriologia origeniana: dalla polemica contro il determinismo gnostico all'universale restaurazione escatologica, in: *Pagani e cristiani alla ricerca della salvezza*: *Aug.* 46 (2006) 661-88; Christian Soteriology and Christian Platonism: Origen, Gregory of Nyssa and the Biblical and Philosophical Basis of the Doctrine of Apokatastasis: *VigChr* 61 (2007) 313-56; *Apocatastasi* (Milan, forthcoming).

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those who saw this text as proof of the subordinate status of the Son. Gregory responds with an interpretation that draws on other parts of 1*Cor.*[40]:

> When every evil 'authority and power' (1*Cor.* 15:24) in us is destroyed and no passion has any power over our nature, then it necessarily follows – since there is no other ruler – that everything will be subject to the ruler of all. Subjection to God means the complete removal of evil. Therefore when, by imitation of Christ the 'first fruits' (1*Cor.* 15:20), we all become separated from evil, then the whole of our nature's 'lump of dough' (1*Cor.* 5:6), mixed with the 'first fruits' and having become 'one body' (1*Cor.* 12:12-20) in its closeness to Christ, will accept the rulership of the one who alone is good (*Matth.* 19:17). Thus, when the whole 'body' of our nature has been folded into the pure divine nature, what Paul calls the subjection of the Son will take place through us.... When all creation has become 'one body' and all are united with each other in him through obedience, then Christ speaks of the subjection of his 'body' to the Father as the subjection of himself. (*In illud, Tunc et Ipse Filius*; GNO III 2, 16, 20)

To Gregory the subjection of the Son refers to the subjection of his body, the church – an entity that eventually will grow to encompass all of humanity. He develops this view by drawing on the image of the 'body of Christ' from 1*Cor.* 12 and its elaboration is in *Eph.* 2 and 4.[41] This interpretation is facilitated by the LXX version of *Ps.* 61:2 – 'Will not my soul be subjected to God?' – which Gregory quotes at the beginning of this treatise to show that 'subjection' means 'salvation'.[42] As to 1*Cor.* 15:25 – 'For [Christ] must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet.' – Gregory proposes that it be interpreted in a way that is 'befitting of God.' Against the view that Christ's rule will have limited duration, he argues that 'reigning' means 'excelling in battle'. So Christ delivers the reign to God when he 'brings all to the Father'.[43]

Conclusion

Much more could be said about patristic reflection on 1*Corinthians*. This brief overview has illustrated two main points. First is the importance of this letter for early Christian discussions of such central topics as Trinitarian theology, the Eucharist, marriage, Scriptural interpretation and the resurrection of the dead. Second is the versatility of Paul's words, how verses from his letter take on new life as the Fathers bring them to bear on new situations. I have focused

[40] Other verses from 1*Cor.* that Gregory cites are the image of dough in 5:8, 11:1 and 4:7 on Paul's imitation of Christ, and Paul's statement that 'all things are yours' in 1*Cor.* 3:21.

[41] Particularly suggestive to Gregory is *Eph.* 4:13. See, e.g., GNO III 2, 19: 'And Christ will stop building himself up when the growth and perfection of his body reaches its proper "measure", and the body is no longer in need of this building-up. This will happen... when "we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to mature manhood, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ" (*Eph.* 4:13).'

[42] GNO III 2, 5.

[43] GNO III 2, 27-8.

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mainly on the *extent* of patristic commentary and its *content*. In conclusion I want to make two quick points about its *manner*, the methods of patristic exegesis. The first is that the Fathers anticipate in many ways the work of modern scholars in posing historical questions, in the close philological analysis of Paul's words, including attention to textual variants, and in analyzing Paul's use of rhetoric.[44] The second point is the enduring value of the Fathers' canonical exegesis. This approach was of course necessary for the construction of a coherent Christian doctrine. What I want to highlight here is something different – the way this canonical exegesis serves to unpack and make vivid the many images Paul uses to convey his message. So John Chrysostom expands on the image of Christ as 'foundation' in 3:9-11 by comparing other biblical images that express the intimate connection between Christ and the believer.[45] Paul's general command in 1*Cor.* 4:16 to 'imitate me' takes on more specific meaning when Augustine cites several texts that illustrate what qualities of Paul are to be imitated.[46] Cyril of Alexandria unpacks Paul's enigmatic statement 'we were all given one Spirit to drink' (12:13) by bringing to mind the 'river of God' in *Ps.* 65:9 and Jesus' promise of the Spirit as 'rivers of living water' in *John* 7:38-9.[47]

The Fathers encourage their readers to savor the words and images of Scripture and meditate upon them, to pause and let them sink in. There has been no time for such savoring in my quick sampling of treasures from the patristic storehouse. I can only offer an invitation, in words borrowed from Saint Augustine. Commenting on 1*Cor.* 2:2 – 'I decided to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ and him crucified'– Augustine urges his hears to take time to unwrap the treasure:

> 'Christ crucified', Paul says. What great things does that treasure contain?... Stay, do not pass on, do not despise, do not insult. Wait, examine. There may be something within that will give you much delight. You may find 'what no eye has seen, nor ear heard, nor the heart of man conceived' (1*Cor.* 2:9).[48]

[44] On this point see R. Roukema, Idol Offering (*SP* 44, 249-58), and Margaret M. Mitchell, *The Heavenly Trumpet: John Chrysostom and the Art of Pauline Interpretation* (Tübingen: 2000).

[45] *Hom. 1 Cor.* 8 (PG 61, 70-1).

[46] *Sermon* 51.2 (PL 38, 333).

[47] *Comm. 1 Cor.* (290-91 Pusey).

[48] *Sermon* 160.1-5 (PL 38, 874-5).

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Paul's Admonitions on Idol Offerings (1*Cor.* 8 and 10) in Patristic Interpretation

Riemer ROUKEMA, Zwolle

One of the exegetical problems of Paul's first epistle to the Corinthians occurs in its eighth chapter. It appears there that some Corinthian Christians felt free to participate in meals and other ceremonies in which food was offered to the pagan gods, whom Paul and Christians in general considered as idols; therefore they called them εἰδωλόθυτα. The enlightened 'strong' Christians who did not even refrain from meals in pagan temples apparently did not want to cut the social bonds that tied them to the society of which they were members before and after their conversion. According to Paul, they justified their behaviour by appealing to *gnosis* (1*Cor.* 8:1-2, 7, 11). This knowledge implied that 'no idol in the world really exists', since 'there is no God but one' (1*Cor.* 8:4).[1] If idols do not really exist, why should it be a problem to participate in ceremonies to their honour? In his response to this opinion that was communicated to him,[2] Paul initially seems to agree with these Corinthians. The only reason why he yet strongly dissuades them from participating in idol offerings seems that a 'weak' Christian might be encouraged to do the same; and since a 'weak' Christian still considers the offered food as contaminated by the idols – idols whom he considers as real demons – he might become afraid of falling under demonic influence once again. So the weak brother might lose the certainty of his salvation by Christ, and get lost. It seems that only for this practical reason Paul reacts that a 'strong' Christian who participates in an idol ceremony sins against Christ, whereas basically the apostle seems to agree with these 'strong' Christians.

So far there is no exegetical problem, but to our surprise Paul seems to take a rather different stance in 1*Cor.* 10. After a discourse on the basic freedom he had as Christ's apostle (1*Cor.* 9), in the tenth chapter he repeatedly admonishes his readers to shun the worship of idols. He reminds them of those Israelites who became idolaters and were destroyed because of this (1*Cor.* 10:6-13). The culmination of his argument is that those who participate in the blood and the body of Christ cannot also partake of the table of the demons. As in 1*Cor.* 8:4, Paul denies that an idol or food offered to an idol is anything (1*Cor.* 10:19), but

[1] According to the New Revised Standard Version, which is the translation I will usually quote in this paper.

[2] See 1*Cor.* 1:11.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 249-258.
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at the same time he says that what pagans sacrifice they offer to demons and not to God, and that he does not want the Corinthian Christians to be partners with demons (1*Cor.* 10:20). He says: 'You cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons. You cannot partake of the table of the Lord and the table of demons' (1*Cor.* 10:21). Here Paul is very stringent in his prohibition of participation in idol offerings. The only concession he makes is that it is not necessary to ask whether meat sold in the market has been offered to idols – for 'the earth and it fullness belong to the Lord' (*Ps.* 24:1). But if an non-Christian invites a Christian to dinner and someone says that the food has been offered in sacrifice (is ἱερόθυτον), the Christian should abstain from it for the sake of the conscience of the one who informed him, although this decision does not affect the Christian's freedom (1*Cor.* 10:23-30).

Paul's overall argument appears twisty, since on the one hand he seems to agree with the 'strong' Christians who felt free to participate in idol offerings, whereas on the other hand he is very strict in his interdiction of partaking of the table of demons. Of course, modern commentators have noted the tension in Paul's argument. In 1910 Johannes Weiss advocated the view that Paul's severe discussion of the question in 1*Cor.* 10 actually stemmed from his very first epistle to the Corinthians to which he refers in 1*Cor.* 5:9, an epistle that is now lost. Replying to the reaction that his severe standpoint entailed that Christians would then have to go out of the world (1*Cor.* 5:10) he later admitted that those who appealed to their *gnosis* were basically right, but that love towards the weaker brethren was more important than sticking to one's knowledge; for 'knowledge puffs up, but love builds up' (1*Cor.* 8:1).[3] So Weiss could only reconcile the chapters 8 and 10 in the canonical text of 1*Cor.* by supposing a development in Paul's policy. Exegetes like Jean Héring and Hans-Joachim Klauck followed this interpretation.[4] There are also exegetes who do not adhere to Weiss's partition hypothesis, but who are still convinced that Paul basically agreed with the 'strong' Christians.[5] Other New Testament scholars argue that Paul was not as inconsistent as he appears to be, but before referring to their

[3] Johannes Weiss, *Der erste Korintherbrief*, KEKNT (Göttingen, 1910), 210-3.

[4] Jean Héring, *La première épître de Saint Paul aux Corinthiens*, CNT 7 (Neuchâtel, Paris, 1949), 11, 89; Hans-Joachim Klauck, *Herrenmahl und hellenistischer Kult: Eine religionsgeschichtliche Untersuchung zum ersten Korintherbrief*, NTA NF 15 (Münster 1982), 279-80, 283-4.

[5] E.g., Charles Kingsley Barrett, Things Sacrificed to Idols: *NTS* 11 (1964), 138-53; *id.*, *A Commentary on the First Epistle to the Corinthians*, BNTC (London 1971²), 195; Frederick Fyvie Bruce, *1 and 2 Corinthians*, NCeB (London, 1971), 78-9, 81-2; Jerome Murphy O'Connor, Freedom or Ghetto (1 Cor., VIII, 1-13; X, 23-XI, 1): *RB* 85 (1978) 543-74 (556-7, 570); Hans Conzelmann, *Der erste Brief an die Korinther*, KEK (Göttingen, 1981²), 184. Wolfgang Schrage, *Der erste Brief an die Korinther* 2, EKK (Solothurn etc., 1995), 431, explains the apparent difference between the two chapters by saying that 1*Cor.* 8:10 is not about real participation in pagan worship ('regelrechte Teilnahme an heidnischem Kult') whereas 1*Cor.* 10:14-22 is (see pp. 263, 268-9, and 447-8). In my opinion this view of the situation sketched in 1*Cor.* 8:10 is erroneous.

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publications I will first proceed to the interpretation of these chapters in early Christianity in its broad sense.[6]

In passing I would like to remark that on the one hand Paul's strict standpoint towards idol offerings is shared by several other early Christian texts, that, however, do not appeal to Paul. One might refer to the *Apostolic Decree* in the canonical *Acts*, the *Didache*, Aristides' *Apology*, and Justin's *Dialogue with Trypho*.[7] On the other hand there are testimonies of Christians who shared Paul's apparently liberal stance in 1*Cor.* 8. According to *Rev.* 2:14 and 20 such Christians were members of the churches in Pergamum and Thyatira. Justin Martyr and Irenaeus inform us that 'heretics' like Basilides, Valentinus, Satornilus, and their disciples saw no problem in participating in idol offerings.[8] These Gnostics may have appealed to 1*Cor.* 8, but we have no testimonies to this appeal.[9]

Clement of Alexandria is the first author who explicitly draws on Paul's admonitions on idol offerings. He instructs newly baptised Christians that they should abstain from food offered to idols, since this food is polluted and abominable. He then quotes 1*Cor.* 10:20, where Paul writes, 'I do not want you to be partners with demons.' Clement explains that Christians should abstain from this food not for fear of the demons, for demons have no power, but for the following three reasons: 1. because their conscience is holy; 2. because the demons to which the food is offered are abominable; and 3. because of fellow Christians whose weak conscience is defiled by the idol offerings.[10] He says: 'The natural use of food is indifferent. "For if we eat we are no better off", it is said, "and if we do not eat, we are no worse off' (1*Cor.* 8:8).[11] But it is inconsistent with reason, for those who have been made worthy to share divine and spiritual food, "to partake of the table of demons" (see 1*Cor.* 10:21).'[12]

Next, Clement deals with the question what a Christian may eat if an unbeliever invites him and he decides to accept the invitation. Quoting Paul, Clement says that in such a situation a Christian is allowed to eat 'whatever is

[6] See also Riemer Roukema, *De uitleg van Paulus' eerste brief aan de Corinthiërs in de tweede en derde eeuw* (Kampen, 1996), 129-37; 153-62.

[7] *Acts* 15:20, 28-29; 21:25; *Did* 6.3 (SC 248bis, 168-9); Aristides, *Apology* 15.4 (SC 470, 236-7 = *Apology* 15.5; 20 Goodspeed); Justin, *Dialogue with Trypho* 34.8 (130 Goodspeed).

[8] Justin, *Dialogue with Trypho* 35.1-6 (130-1 Goodspeed); Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* I 6.3; 24.5; 26.3; 28.2 (SC 264, 94-7; 328-9; 348-9; 356-7); also Euseb. Caes., *Hist. Eccl.* IV 7.7 (LCL 153, 316-7).

[9] Elaine H. Pagels, *The Gnostic Paul: Gnostic Exegesis of the Pauline Letters* (Philadelphia, 1975), 71-4, does not give any precise reference to Gnostic interpretations of 1*Cor.* 8 and 10 with regard to idol offerings.

[10] Clem. Alex., *Paed.* II 8.3-4 (SC 108, 24-5).

[11] The order of Clement's text of 1*Cor.* 8:8bc coincides with Codex Sinaiticus, the corrected text of Codex Alexandrinus, Origen, and the Majority text. In modern editions and translations preference is given to the different order of P^{46} and Codex Vaticanus.

[12] Clem. Alex., *Paed.* II 9.1 (SC 108, 24-7). For the translation see ANF II, 239.

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set before him', 'without raising any question on the ground of conscience' (1*Cor.* 10:27).[13] A Christian should only avoid gluttony, Clement adds. Quoting Paul freely, he writes that 'if such food causes a brother to stumble, I will never eat it anymore, lest I cause my brother to fall' (see 1*Cor.* 8:13). For although Paul has the right to eat and to drink (1*Cor.* 9:4) and knows that an idol is nothing (1*Cor.* 8:4), he also says that if a weak brother, for whom Christ died, perishes through your knowledge, you sin against Christ (1*Cor.* 8:11-2).[14] We see that in case of a private meal with an unbeliever Clement allows Christians, like Paul does, to eat whatever is set before them without asking questions on the provenance of the food. But also in this situation Clement wants them to take account of weaker brethren, who might imitate their behaviour and be polluted by the demons to whom the food might have been consecrated.

In his *Stromateis* Clement is even more reluctant in his concession of the Christian's freedom to eat food that may have been sacrificed to idols. However, he rejects the interpretation of Christians who read 1*Cor.* 10:25 as a question: 'Should one eat whatever is sold in the market without raising any question?', as if the answer should be 'no'. In their interpretation Paul meant that one should raise the question of the provenance of the food. Clement explains that Paul meant: 'All *other things* buy at the market, without raising any question', except for the things mentioned in the *Apostolic Decree* as formulated in *Acts* 15:29, which held that one should abstain from food offered to idols, blood, whatever has been strangled, and fornication. He quotes Paul who said in the previous chapter that he had the right to eat and to drink, and to be accompanied by a believing wife, as did the other apostles and the brothers of the Lord and Cephas, but that he had not made use of this right, lest he put a stumbling block to the Gospel of Christ (1*Cor.* 9:4-5, 12).[15] Clement concludes that for the sake of conscience one should abstain from idol offerings, and explains that he does not mean one's own 'gnostic conscience', but that of the other, lest the weak brother imitate in ignorance what he does not understand.[16] In these notes Clement sticks to the basic freedom a Christian has, but as Paul said, he should do everything to the glory of God (1*Cor.* 10:29-31). 'Everything' comprises, for Clement, what has been commanded by the rule of faith (κανὼν τῆς πίστεως), which includes the *Apostolic Decree*.[17]

We see that as far as idol offerings are concerned, Clement sees no difference between the purport of 1*Cor.* 8 and 10. From both chapters – and also from the intermediate chapter 9 – he distils the message that a Christian should always abstain from idol offerings.

[13] Clem. Alex., *Paed.* II 10.1 (SC 108, 28-9).

[14] Clem. Alex., *Paed.* II 10.2-5 (SC 108, 28-31).

[15] Clem. Alex., *Stromateis* IV 97.2-4 (SC 463, 218-9).

[16] Clem. Alex., *Stromateis* IV 98.1-2 (SC 463, 220-1). His term 'gnostic conscience' is inspired by 1*Cor.* 8:1, 7; 10:25, 27, 29.

[17] Clem. Alex., *Stromateis* IV 98.3 (SC 463, 220-1).

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Origen of Alexandria shares Clement's judgment on idol offerings in reference to 1*Cor.* 8 and 10. He considers Paul's instruction that the Corinthians 'should not eat idol offerings' as part of the 'milk for children', which is the teaching for those who begin to live as Christians.[18] But this characteristic does not imply that in Origen's view advanced Christians are allowed to partake of idol offerings. According to Origen, Paul meant that partaking of food offered to idols is no less serious than murder, for a Christian who does so destroys his brethren for whom Christ died (1*Cor.* 8:11). Since these offerings are offered to demons, those who partake of the table of demons become partners of the demons, and it is impossible to partake of the table of the Lord and the table of the demons (1*Cor.* 10:20-1). Even if idols are nothing (1*Cor.* 8:4), it is horrible for a Christian to take part in the high festival of the idols.[19] This interdiction applies also in case of persecution, when Christians are forced to deny their Christian identity and to eat idol offerings, even though they think this will not harm them.[20] Origen admits that he is amazed about the situation sketched in 1*Cor.* 8:10, that someone was eating in the temple of an idol, and that Paul seems to say that this is not bad in itself, but only because this may be seen by someone who is inclined to imitate the example without having the same knowledge. Origen suggests that this passage should also be interpreted allegorically, in the sense that those Christians were very interested in Greek literature and philosophy. This might not harm those who had a knowledge of the truth, but if less advanced Christians imitated them, they might be seduced by the doctrines of these books. Therefore one should take care not to put a stumbling block to those who see us.[21] Origen explains that one who eats idol offerings is defiled by the demons to whom they have been sacrificed, whereas one who is not sure whether the food he eats has been sacrificed to demons is defiled by his doubt. The food itself is not harmful, Origen adds, but it is harmful because of the beliefs (δόγματα) and the meaning (λόγος) given to it, for 'food does not bring us close to God; for we are no better off when we eat, and we are no worse off when we do not eat' (1*Cor.* 8:8).[22] For his instruction he also refers to the *Apostolic Decree* in *Acts* 15:20, 29.[23]

In his extant works Origen does not comment on Paul's final concession that one may buy meat in the market without asking where it came from. This means that for Origen there is no exception concerning food offered to idols:

[18] Orig., *Homilies on Ezekiel* 7.10 (SC 352, 270-3); see 1*Cor.* 3:1-2.

[19] *Against Celsus* VIII 24; VIII 28-32 (SC 150, 226-9; 234-45); *Fragments on 1 Corinthians* 40.14-19 (*JThS* 9 [1908], 510-1).

[20] *Commentariorum Series in Matthaeum* 45 (GCS 38, 92.15-20).

[21] *Homilies on Numbers* 20.3.1-2 (SC 461, 34-7).

[22] *Commentary on Matthew* XI 12 (SC 162, 330-3). For Origen's text of 1*Cor.* 8:8bc, see note 11.

[23] *Commentary on Matthew* XI 12 (SC 162, 332-3); *Against Celsus* VIII 29-30 (SC 150, 236-9).

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Christians should always shun it. For this standpoint he quotes texts from both 1*Cor.* 8 and 10.

This interpretation of Paul's stance toward idol offerings is confirmed by three running commentaries on 1*Cor.* from the fourth and fifth centuries. In the anonymous commentary from Rome ascribed to 'Ambrosiaster', from the period when Damasus was bishop of Rome (366-384 CE), 1*Cor.* 8 is interpreted as a severe prohibition of eating idol offerings. The author explains that the knowledge of those who felt free to partake of idol offerings held that an idol (*idolum*) is nothing, so that they could not be contaminated by it. But for Ambrosiaster – as for Paul – this knowledge is opposed to love, since this display of freedom may induce less advanced (*inperiti*) brethren who do not have the same knowledge to imitate this behaviour, thinking that eating an idol offering brings about some advantage (*aliquam gratiam*; *aliquid gratiae*), since an idol is a divine being (*aliqua ... divinitas*). Thus a weak brother would deny his faith in the one God and lose his salvation.[24] In his comment on the tenth chapter the author says that a statue (*simulacrum*) is nothing since it is the image of something dead, but he adds that under cover of the idol statues the devil is worshipped. When someone is seen in the temple of an idol (1*Cor.* 8:10), he implicitly denies his faith in the one God, so Satan causes the corruption of his faith in one God.[25] As for Paul's concession that one may buy whatever food is sold in the market without raising any question on the ground of conscience (1*Cor.* 10:25), Ambrosiaster confirms that one's conscience is free. Even when a Christian by accident buys something offered to an idol, he should feel no scruples and is not guilty towards God. But when an advanced (*perfectus*) Christian, who knows that an idol is nothing, is invited by an unbeliever who points out to him that the food consists of idol offerings, he should not eat it. Otherwise the idolater will be proud that he made the Christian eat the offerings, as if he worshipped the idols (1*Cor.* 10:27-9). By this behaviour of the advanced Christian the idolater would be confirmed in his wrong conviction, and the Christian would give a wrong example to his brethren.[26] So we see that Ambrosiaster refuses very definitely that Christians might eat idol offerings, either in a pagan temple or in a private house. Only when a Christian consumes such food unwittingly, since he bought it in the market, it does no harm. This implies that Ambrosiaster does not consider the food itself as contaminated by demons; his prohibition is inspired by the abhorrence of idolatry as worship of the devil, and by the intention not to give a bad example to weak Christians.

The most magnificent and lucid ancient commentary on 1*Cor.* is authored by John Chrysostom, at that time priest in Antioch. It consists of the homilies he held there around 390. In his homily on 1*Cor.* 8 he carefully dissects Paul's

[24] *Commentary on 1 Corinthians* 8, esp. 8.1.3; 8.7; 8.10 (CSEL 81, 92; 94-5).
[25] *Commentary on 1 Corinthians* 10.19-22 (CSEL 81, 114-6).
[26] *Commentary on 1 Corinthians* 10.25-31 (CSEL 81, 116-8).

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rhetorical strategy not to injure the 'strong' Corinthian Christians who appealed to their knowledge. This knowledge implied that an idol is nothing, so that they could partake of the idols's tables without running any spiritual risk. As far as we can see, John Chrysostom is the first commentator who explicitly points to the ambivalence of Paul's argument. He says:

> He [Paul] wants to argue two different points: that it is necessary to refrain from such a meal but also that it cannot harm those who partake of it. These things do not fit together easily. For if the Corinthians learned that the meal was harmless, they would be prone to treat it lightly, as if it were a matter of indifference. On the other hand, if they were prohibited from touching such food, they would suspect that they were forbidden something that could do them harm.[27]

John Chrysostom confirms that an idol is nothing, which means that idols do not have any power, since their statues consist of stones and demons. He explains that Paul presents this as common knowledge and not as an insight that only the strong Christians have. However, the strong Christians have to learn that love is more important than knowledge. This love they should apply to the weak Christians who might be caused to stumble when they imitate the behaviour of the strong Christians who feel free to partake of idol offerings. For John, the purport of Paul's argument in 1*Cor.* 8 is that Christians should abstain from such meals altogether.[28]

In his homily on 1*Cor.* 10:13-24 John Chrysostom underlines Paul's admonitions, as we may expect, that Christians should abstain from the tables of idol offerings. He says that even the advanced (τέλειοι) Christians did not know that the result of these sacrifices is often a certain communion and friendship with devils.[29] He explains that the intention (σκοπός) of those who sacrifice and of those who receive the food make it unclean.[30] John Chrysostom exclaims: '"How, then", Paul asks the Corinthians, "is it not a contradiction when you thank God for delivering you from idols but then run back to their tables?"'[31]

Because Paul appears to express his standpoint on idol offerings more clearly and sharply in 1*Cor.* 10 than in chapter 8, John also addresses the question, 'Why did Paul not establish these points at the outset, since they would have been especially effective in bringing them around?' His answer is, that

> Paul's practice is to employ several different arguments to achieve his purpose, and to put the strongest points last and produce more arguments than he needs to win the day. This is why he started off with lesser points and then progressed to the more serious

[27] *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 20.2 (PG 61, 162-3); translation Judith L. Kovacs, *1 Corinthians Interpreted by Early Christian Commentators*, The Church's Bible (Grand Rapids, 2005), 135.

[28] *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 20.1-2, 4-5 (PG 61, 160-2; 165-8)

[29] *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 24.2 (PG 61, 201).

[30] *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 24.3 (PG 61, 202).

[31] *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 24.2 (PG 61, 199); translation Kovacs, *1 Corinthians*, 168.

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of their troubles. For this made it easier for them to accept what he says, since their minds had been prepared by his previous arguments.[32]

In his homily on 1*Cor.* 10:25-11:1 John explains that Paul's consent to eat whatever is sold in the market (1*Cor.* 10:25) shows that in spite of his admonitions he did not want to frighten the Corinthians. Instead, Paul wanted to prevent them from being too scrupulous and suspicious. So it is not necessary to search and enquire whether something is an idol offering, for these things are not evil in their essence (φύσει), but they are unclean through man's intention (διανοία).[33] However, when an unbeliever informs his Christian guest that the food set before him has been offered in sacrifice, the Christian should abstain from it, Paul says (1*Cor.* 10:27-8). John explains that otherwise the Gentile might say to himself: 'Christianity is a fable; they abstain from the idols, they shun demons, and yet they cleave to the things offered to them: great is their gluttony.'[34] In his comment on Paul's admonition that one should give no offence to Jews or to Greeks or to the church of God (1*Cor.* 10:32) John says that 'the Greeks are stunned when they see us reverting to such things'.[35] He enumerates the many reasons Paul gives to abstain from food sacrificed to idols: 'It is unprofitable; it is unnecessary; it causes injury to the brother, blasphemy among the Jews, and slander among the Greeks. One must not have fellowship with demons. And the activity itself is a form of idolatry.'[36]

In comparison with John Chrysostom's homilies, Theodoret's of Cyrus commentaries on the Pauline epistles are relatively concise. They were probably written in the mid-440s.[37] Theodoret explains that Paul's clause 'we know that all of us possess knowledge' (1*Cor.* 8:1) was meant ironically, for Paul says in 1*Cor.* 8:7 that this knowledge is not in everyone.[38] According to Theodoret, Paul wanted to bring to an end the abuse of some Corinthians, who held that with their knowledge they could eat in an idol's temple. Paul did not give evidence against their knowledge, Theodoret says, but against their scorn of weaker brothers who would lose their salvation by imitating them.[39] In his view, Paul 'shows that the indiscriminate partaking of food sacrificed to idols in no way differs from the worship of idols'.[40] For that reason Paul 'had absolutely

[32] *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 24.3 (PG 61, 202); translation Kovacs, *1 Corinthians*, 170.

[33] *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 25.1 (PG 61, 205).

[34] *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 25.1 (PG 61, 207); translation Talbot W. Chambers, NPNF I, XII, 145.

[35] *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 25.2 (PG 61, 208); translation Kovacs, *1 Corinthians*, 173.

[36] *Homilies on 1 Corinthians* 25.2 (PG 61, 208); translation Kovacs, *1 Corinthians*, 173-4.

[37] Theodoret of Cyrus, *Commentary on the Letters of St. Paul* I. Translated with Introduction by Robert Charles Hill (Brookline, Massachusetts, 2001), 2.

[38] *Commentary on 1 Corinthians* 8.1; 8.7; 8.11 (PG 82, 285D; 289D; 292B).

[39] *Commentary on 1 Corinthians* 8.8-13 (PG 82, 292A-D).

[40] *Commentary on 1 Corinthians* 10.14 (PG 82, 305A); translation Hill, *Commentary* I, 200.

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forbidden partaking of the food sacrificed to idols'.[41] In the case of the unbelieving host who points out to a Christian that the food had been sacrificed to idols (1*Cor.* 10:27-30), Theodoret explains that a Christian should abstain from it even though he scorns the impotence of the idols; but the host 'is in thrall to error and takes harm from it, believing you are partaking of meat sacrificed to idols.' 'It is not right, he [Paul] is saying, for someone else to be corrupted through my maturity (τελειότης).'[42]

Our conclusion from this survey of the patristic interpretation of 1*Cor.* 8 and 10 is that in spite of minor divergences the Church Fathers, from Clement of Alexandria to Theodoret of Cyrus, were unanimous in their interpretation of Paul's overall purpose. As they saw it, Paul wanted to convince the Christians to shun the food sacrificed to idols on all occasions. Only when it was unclear whether food sold in the market was sacrificed to idols, they were free to eat it.

The critical question is, whether the Fathers's overall interpretation was in line with Paul's original intention. Theoretically it is possible, of course, that a liberal standpoint taken by Paul was fully isolated in early Christianity and has been suppressed in the early Church, whereas the Christian Gnostics preserved this element of Paul's heritage.[43] The other possibility is that the Church Fathers correctly interpreted Paul's admonitions and correctly understood that his remark that a 'strong' Christian could in principle participate in an idol offering but should refrain from it only for the sake of the weak, was not a licence to the 'strong' but only a tactical, concessive start of his argument. In 2000 a monograph about these chapters has been published by Joop F.M. Smit. Without any reference to the patristic interpretations he gives a rhetorical analysis of 1*Cor.* 8:1-11:1 and reaches the same conclusions as the Church Fathers, namely that Paul wanted to prohibit any participation in idol offerings, with the exception of food sold in the market.[44] Smit is not the only exegete who concludes that according to Paul Christians should always refrain from food that is identified as an idol offering.[45]

[41] *Commentary on 1 Corinthians* 10.24 (PG 82, 308A); translation Hill, *Commentary* I, 202.

[42] *Commentary on 1 Corinthians* 10.28-30 (PG 82, 308C-D); translation Hill, *Commentary* I, 202.

[43] Thus John C. Brunt, Rejected, Ignored or Misunderstood? The Fate of Paul's Approach to the Food offered to Idols in Early Christianity: *NTS* 31 (1985) 113-24.

[44] Joop F.M. Smit, *'About the Idol Offerings:' Rhetoric, Social Context and Theology of Paul's Discourse in First Corinthians 8:1-11:1*, CBETh 27, (Leuven etc., 2000), 67-98, 121-47.

[45] See, *e.g.*, Frédéric Louis Godet, *Commentaire sur la première épître aux Corinthiens* II (Neuchâtel, 1887), 119; Archibald Robertson and Alfred Plummer, *A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the First Epistle of St Paul to the Corinthians*, ICC (Edinburgh, 1914), 171-4; Gordon D. Fee, *The First Epistle to the Corinthians*, NICNT (Grand Rapids, 1987), 357-92; Peter D. Gooch, *Dangerous Food: 1 Corinthians 8-10 in its Context*, Studies in Christianity and Judaism 5 (Waterloo, Ontario, 1993); Alex T. Cheung, *Idol Food in Corinth: Jewish Background and Pauline Legacy*, JSNT.S 176 (Sheffield, 1999).

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In Western Christianity this standpoint may appear to be out of date, but Christians from other backgrounds immediately recognize its relevance. A Protestant student from India told me that the course of behaviour in his church is not to accept the food that is distributed after the ceremony in a Hindu temple, since it has been consecrated to the Hindu gods – the gods that their grandparents and other converts had renounced. As for this paper, its purpose is not to convince the readers that Paul's strict guidelines should be followed – for its purport is not theological or hermeneutical – but to maintain that from an historical, exegetical point of view his guidelines on idol offerings have to be interpreted strictly, and that the Church Fathers understood this better than many a Western exegete.

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In Illud: Tunc et ipse Filius...: Gregory of Nyssa's Exegesis, its Derivations from Origen, and Early Patristic Interpretations Related to Origen's

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1*Cor.* 15:28, announcing all creatures' eventual submission to Christ and Christ's submission to God, who will be 'all in all', is a biblical pillar for Origen's doctrine of *apokatastasis*: 'der entscheidende Schriftbeweis für seine Lehre von der Apokatastasis'.[1] Gregory of Nyssa too, who is deeply indebted to Origen, used it, in *De Anima et Resurrectione* and *In Illud: Tunc et Ipse Filius*,[2] closely following Origen, even with verbal correspondences, to support the *apokatastasis*.

Exactly as Origen did in *De Principiis* III 5.7 against a subordinationistic interpretation of 1*Cor.* 15:28, Gregory, against its 'Arian' subordinationistic interpretation,[3] explains that Paul's statement indicates, not the Son's inferiority to the Father, but all humans' salvific submission.[4] For both Origen and Gregory, Paul's eschatological predictions were weighty: Origen mentions his rapture (2*Cor.* 12:2) with emphasis;[5] Gregory (*In Illud* 3) claims that his words are authoritative because he was initiated into the knowledge of the ineffable and Christ spoke in him (2*Cor.* 13:3).[6] This is why both Origen and Gregory rely not only on philosophical arguments for the *apokatastasis*, but also, constantly, on Scripture, especially Paul. In his exegesis of 1*Cor.* 15:28, the title of *In Illud*, Gregory displays striking similarities with Origen.

[1] Werner van Laak, *Allversöhnung* (Sinzig, 1990), 88. On 1*Cor.* 15:28 in Origen e.g. Riemer Roukema, La résurrection des morts dans l'interprétation origénienne de 1Corinthiens 15, in: *La résurrection chez les Pères* (Strasbourg, 2003), 161-77, 166-9; my: Christian Soteriology and Christian Platonism: *VChr* 61 (2007) 313-56.

[2] GNO III 2, 3-28: all references will be to these pages and lines. From now on: *In Illud*, on which: Casimir MacCambley, When (the Father) Will Subject All Things to (the Son): *GOThR* 28 (1983) 1-15.

[3] Lewis Ayres, *The Nycaean Legacy* (Oxford, 2006), calls to caution in using the 'Arianism' category. I am essentially concerned with subordinationism.

[4] See Peter Gorday, Paulus Origenianus, in: W.S. Babcock (ed.), *Paul and the Legacies of Paul* (Dallas, 1990), 141-63 on the economic interpretation of Paul in Origen and Nyssen, and my essay and commentary on *In Illud* in: *Ead., Gregorio di Nissa: Sull'anima e la resurrezione* (Milan, 2007).

[5] See Riemer Roukema, Paul's Rapture to Paradise in Early Christian Literature, in: A. Hilhorst – G.H. van Kooten (eds.), *The Wisdom of Egypt* (Leiden, 2005), 267-83, 275-7.

[6] See *Contra Eunomium*, GNO I 2, 118.2; *Homiliae in Canticum*, GNO VI 85.21.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 259-274.
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The core thesis of *In Illud*, that universal submission (1*Cor.* 15:27-8) is voluntary and means universal salvation, is drawn directly from Origen,[7] even with appeal to the same *Ps.* 61:2, used by Gregory in the selfsame connection also in *Refutatio*, GNO 2, 396-7. Gregory insists that not even the submission of God's enemies will be forced, but will be their σωτηρία (GNO III 2, 26). Adopting Paul's terminology, Gregory states that all enemies will submit (ὑποταγήσεσθαι) and what will be annihilated (καταργηθήσεσθαι) is death and its root, sin. The same distinction was drawn by Origen in *De Princ.* III 6.5: the enemy, sin, and death (derived from sin) will be annihilated, whereas the devil, a creature, will submit, like all sinners, and be restored.[8] Origen says so precisely in interpreting 1*Cor.* 15:26,[9] here commented on by Gregory. Gregory declares that the empire of evil will be entirely destroyed (εἰς τὸ παντελὲς ἐξαργηθήσεται), as Origen did e.g. in *Hom. Ier.* 1.16 saying that the empire of evil will be utterly destroyed (ἐκ βάθρων ἐκριζωθῆναι... τὴν οἰκοδομὴν τῆς κακίας καταναλωθῆναι) and, when evil vanishes, the sufferings of the punished will cease (τέλος λάβῃ διὰ τοῦ ἀφανισμοῦ τῶν κακῶν τὰ τῆς κολάσεως τῶν παθόντων, 1.16.6).

In fact, the *apokatastasis*, τὸ πέρας τῶν ἐλπιζομένων, 'the culmination of our hopes', is caused by the eviction of evil (13.17ff.), maintained by Gregory also elsewhere and, in his view, revealed in 1*Cor.* 15:25-8. Already Origen in *De Princ.* III 6.2 deduced the vanishing of evil from 1*Cor.* 15:28: since God will be all in all and cannot be in evil, evil will necessarily disappear in the *apokatastasis*. The eschatological advance (πρόοδος) of the Good will reach the πέρας of evil, and will make it completely vanish (ἐξαφανίζω), and with it death, its consequence (*Rom.* 5:12). So, after the disappearance of evil and death, only the Good, i.e. God, will remain, and divine life will extend 'through all' (διὰ πάντων, 16.1-8). Annihilation of evil is the τέλος of our hopes (*Col.* 1:5) and coincides with the *apokatastasis*.

The final vanishing of evil was already the main ontological pillar of Origen's argument for *apokatastasis*.[10] We can even trace verbal derivations from Origen in 17.13-21, where Gregory states that 1*Cor.* 15:28 demonstrates 'the non-substantiality [τὸ ἀνύπαρκτον] of evil', since 'God will be all in all' when in all beings there will remain μηδὲν κακόν, for God cannot be in evil. Here Gregory follows *ad verbum* Origen, *De Princ.* III 6.2-3, who interprets 1*Cor.* 15:28 likewise, with the same arguments and words, in support of the same theory of the eventual vanishing of evil and *apokatastasis*.

[7] Origen, *Commentarium in Ioannem*, VI 295-6; *De Principiis*, I 1.6; III 5.6-7. See my: Origen's interpretation of *Hebrews* 10:13, the eventual elimination of evil and the *apokatastasis*: *Augustinianum* 47,1 (2007) 85-93.

[8] Documentation in my: La coerenza della soteriologia origeniana, in: *Pagani e cristiani alla ricerca della salvezza* (Roma, 2006), 661-88 and my: Christian Soteriology (2007).

[9] Quoted also in *Comm. Matth.* XII 33; *Hom. Jos.* 8.4; *Hom. Lev.* 9.11; *Hom. Ier.* 18.3.

[10] See my: Christian Soteriology (2007).

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Also, in *In Illud*, 18.1-18, and in *De anima* 104, Gregory interprets God's being 'all in all' (1*Cor.* 15:28) as Origen did: according to the Neoplatonic motive of return to unity,[11] he states that God alone will take the place of all we need and desire, and will be food, garment, beauty, wisdom ... all goods, for all. The same notion of God being all goods for all is expressed by Origen (*De Princ.* III 6.2-3), who adds that this will mean the total exclusion of evil, the same as Gregory asserts (16.12-3): everyone's eventual submission to God will be the complete alienation from evil. After all (πάντες) have achieved this, then 'the whole mass of human nature' (ὅλον τὸ φύραμα τῆς φύσεως: see 1*Cor.* 5:6; *Gal.* 5:9),[12] 'the entire body of our nature' (πᾶν τὸ τῆς φύσεως ἡμῶν σῶμα), will submit to the Good, i.e. God.

For the Son's submission to the Father will be the submission of his body, i.e. all humanity, since all humans will constitute Christ's body (1*Cor.* 10:17) through participation (19.19-20.7). Now, Christ's body is the Church (*Col.* 1:24-5), which thus coincides with the entire humankind. For 'all' will contribute to the construction of Christ's body; 'all' (οἱ πάντες) will reach unity of faith and knowledge and make up Christ in perfect wholeness. Gregory here relies on 1*Cor.* 12:27, *Eph.* 4:5-16, 2:20, 4:13, already used by Origen in *De Princ.* I 1.6 likewise in support of the *apokatastasis*. In his Commentary on *Ephesians*, on which Jerome depends for his own, Origen identified the Church, Christ's body, with all humans and angels, the same creatures depicted by Gregory toward the end of *De Anima* as participating in the heavenly feast symbolizing the *apokatastasis*.[13] Origen affirms that the whole body of Christ will rise at all humans' resurrection: the bones will be reassembled, 'as attested in Psalm 21' (*Comm. Io.* 10.35-36); then, commenting on *Ez.* 37:1-11 (also related by Gregory in *De anima* to the resurrection): 'When the resurrection of *Christ's true and most perfect body* will occur, Christ's limbs and bones, now dry ... will be reassembled, up to the perfect *anthropos* [*Eph.* 4:13] ... All limbs, which are many, will *become one body* ... Then, rather than now, will God grant more honour to those who are more bereft of it, so that there will be *absolutely no division in the body*, but the limbs will have the same reciprocal care'. For the Logos refuses to receive his glory without us, all humans, who constitute his limbs: he wishes to be our *logos*, the superior faculty living in us (*Lev.* 26:12). Christ will collect the bones 'scattered in hell' to reconstitute the Logos's body in its wholeness (*Hom. Lev.* 7.2.10-12). He will have finished his work (*John* 17:4) once, in the eschaton, he has made even the worst sinner just

[11] See my: Emanatismo, in: V. Melchiorre (dir.), *Enciclopedia Filosofica* (Milan, 2006), 3319-22; for Neoplatonism in Gregory's thought see my: *Gregorio* (2007), second Integrative Essay; in Origen's thought see my: Origen, Patristic Philosophy, and Christian Platonism: *VigChr* 63 (2009) 217-63.

[12] Johannes Zachhuber, Phyrama, in *Diccionario de san Gregorio de Nisa*, ed. L.F. Mateo-Seco and G. Maspero (Burgos, 2006), 733-7.

[13] See commentary in my: *Gregorio* (2007).

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and perfect: till even one rational creature remains outside the submission to Christ, Christ will not be able to submit to the Father, as foretold in 1*Cor.* 15:25-8. In the whole of humanity, made perfect by him, Christ 'will accomplish the task assigned him by God. Thus, God will be "all in all"' (7.2.6), when Christ has obtained the salvation of those affected by the death of sin, since Christ's body is constituted by us humans (Origen cites 1*Cor.* 12:27) and his submission to the Father is our submission and salvation. This notion is applied by Origen to his interpretation of 1*Cor.* 15:28, which Gregory borrows in *In Illud.*

Origen also assimilates Christ's body as all humanity to the heavenly Jerusalem and the Temple of precious living stones, the rational beings (*C. Cels.* VIII 19-20), according to *John* 2:21, commented on in *Comm. Io.* 10.42, where Origen foresees universal resurrection as 'the great resurrection of Christ's body, his holy Church' and the construction of the Temple of Christ's body: 'Those who now are in captivity once were inside the Temple, and will return inside: once restored, they will be the most precious stones. For, also in John's Revelation [3:12], one is promised that, after prevailing [over evil], he will be a pillar in God's Temple, which will not go out [μὴ ἐξελευσόμενος ἔξω]'.

Thus, Gregory took his equation 'Christ's body = Church = all humankind' from Origen.

Christ, assuming all humanity, τὰ ἡμέτερα οἰκειοῦται πάντα, 'appropriates all that is ours' (20.8-24): Gregory uses the terminology of Stoic οἰκείωσις ('appropriation')[14] as Origen frequently did.[15] He also associates it to that of ὁμοφωνία: 'the entire creation' will be 'in harmony with itself' and, according to *Phil.* 2:10-11, to which Gregory refers, every knee will bend, in heaven, on earth, and in the underworld, and all will proclaim that Christ is the Lord, i.e., all will believe and be saved: 'the whole creation' (πᾶσα ἡ κτίσις, *Rom.* 8:22), will become 'one body' (ἓν σῶμα). Again, Gregory heavily depends on Origen, *De Princ.* IV 6.2, where *Phil.* 2:10-1 is already quoted in this connection, and the submission of all to Christ in heaven, on earth, and in the underworld, is understood as salvation of all, angels, humans and demons.

Gregory reflects (21) that, if submission means salvation, according to Origen's equation and as *Ps.* 61:2 suggests, and if 'every being' (πᾶν) that is in Christ is saved, then, since all will be in Christ's body, 'no being will remain outside the saved' (μηδὲν ἔξω τῶν σῳζομένων). This explicit conclusion coincides with Origen's thought. Gregory presents a similar argument soon after: if the Father loves the Son (*John* 17:23), in whom all humans are, then the

[14] Troels Engberg-Pedersen, *The Stoic Theory of Oikeiosis* (Aarhus, 1990); Roberto Radice, *Oikeiosis* (Milano, 2000); Robert Bees, *Die Oikeiosislehre der Stoa* (Würzburg, 2004). Stoicism in Gregory: Igor Pochoshajew, Estoicismo, in: *Diccionario* (2006), 382-3.

[15] See my: Christian Soteriology (2007), n. 53. Stoicism in Origen: Panayiotis Tzamalikos, *Origen: Cosmology and Ontology of Time* (Leiden, 2006), *passim*; *id.*, *Origen: Philosophy of History and Eschatology* (Leiden, 2007), 44-8, and *passim.*

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Father loves all humans as the Son's body, and the Son's submission to the Father means the salvation of all human nature, as in Origen's view.

Gregory's argument (*ibid.*) depends on Origen entirely: the complete elimination of death will have as a consequence that 'all' (πάντες) will be in life, because all will be in Christ, who is life (*John* 11:25). Likewise, Origen proclaimed the *apokatastasis* to be eternal life excluding eternal death altogether (*Comm. Rom.* V 7),[16] for they are incompatible and one must be eliminated: 1*Cor.* 15:25 reveals that this 'one' will be death.

Gregory also discusses the order (1*Cor.* 15:22) in which each one will reject evil, receive the Good, and attain restoration: it will be based on each one's merits (15-16). In this gradation: the perfect will come first, then those who are more and more alienated from the Good, but all will return to it. This is another conception taken from Origen, who already commented on 1*Cor.* 15:22 as a description of the order in the return to God, according to each one's merits, in *De Princ.* I 7.5, quoting 1*Cor.* 15:24.28; *ibid.* III 6.6, quoting 1*Cor.* 15:26.28 (cf. III 1.17; 5.8) and in *Comm. Io.* XXXII 26-39, quoting 1*Cor.* 15:22.

Gregory fully relies on Origen, for both his argument and the Biblical passages he quotes, also when he insists on the unity characterizing the *apokatastasis* (21.22ff.): Christ 'unifies all [πάντας]' in himself and to the Father; all become ἕν with Christ and God who are one, through Christ who is in all. Quoting *John* 17:21, Gregory explains that Christ, being in the Father, by joining us to himself in unity (ἑνῶσας), accomplishes our union with the Father. Now, unity is a core trait of *apokatastasis* in Origen, *De Princ.* I 6; III 3.5; 6.1, and 6.6, where *John* 17:21 is repeatedly evoked in support of the same interpretation.

Moreover, this unity, according to Gregory (21-22), will be effected by the Spirit, which will restore all humans to unity among themselves and with God, after separation due to sin. Now, already Origen assigned to the Spirit an essential role in all humans' return to unity in God.[17]

Another point Gregory derives from Origen is his use of 1*Cor.* 15:9 (see *Gal.* 1:13), concerning Paul's conversion from persecutor to Christ's apostle, in support of the *apokatastasis*. Paul's conversion was already mentioned by Origen in *Hom. Ier.* 1.15-16 as an example of transformation effected by God from death to life.[18] Likewise, Gregory sees Paul's change as a paradigm for all humanity: in the end, 'all', πάντες, will reject the old man (*Col.* 3:9; *Eph.* 4:22) and receive the Lord in new life (24.18ff.).

[16] *Aeternum aeterno contrarium non erit, sed idem. Nunc autem certum est mortem vitae esse contrarium: certum est ergo quod, si vita aeterna est, mors esse non possit aeterna ... mors animae, quae est novissimus inimicus, fuerit destructa ... regnum mortis pariter cum morte destructum erit.*

[17] See Maureen B. Moser, *Teacher of Holiness* (Piscataway, 2005).

[18] God will kill Paul the persecutor and make him live as Apostle. See my: Origen's Exegesis of Jeremiah: Resurrection Announced throughout the Bible and its Twofold Conception: *Augustinianum* 48 (2008) 59-78.

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Another major conception Gregory draws from Origen to delineate the *apokatastasis* at the end of *In Illud* is the 'theology of the image'. Quoting 1*Cor.* 15:25, repeatedly used by Origen in support of the *apokatastasis*, Gregory affirms that Christ during his reign will subject his enemies, and, once he has unified all beings, will hand over all to the Father. Those who were enemies will become a stool for his feet (*Ps.* 109:1, another key-passage in Origen's argument for the *apokatastasis*!),[19] receiving God's footprint (ἴχνος), a reference to God's εἰκών in everyone, according to the 'theology of the image', fundamental in both Gregory and Origen.[20]

The background provided by Origen for Gregory's *In Illud* is evident in every passage of this work and in its theoretical and exegetical structure, from the pillars of his theory to the details of exegesis.

Before Origen, few interpreted 1*Cor.* 15:28.[21] Clement refers to it in *Stromateis* I 59.6: 'the Lord, who receives those who believe in Him', is like Plato's king ruling over agreeing persons. 'For *God has trusted all and submitted all to Christ our king*; so in the name of Jesus every knee will bend...': Origen too links *Phil.* 2:10-1 to 1*Cor.* 15:28 in support of the *apokatastasis* of all, angels, humans, and demons (*De Princ.* IV 6.2), and so will Gregory. Also the idea of Christ's rule over agreeing subjects will be emphasized by them.

Irenaeus, who insists on universal ἀνακεφαλαίωσις, 'recapitulation', albeit not explicitly identified with eventual universal salvation, in *Adversus Haereses* III 6 interprets 1*Cor.* 15:27 as all enemies' subjection to the Son, and in IV 6.7 uses it to affirm, like Gregory in *In Illud*, the identity of nature between Father and Son, '*the Father making all things subject to him.* He received testimony that he was truly man and truly God from all ... angels, creation itself, humans, apostate spirits and demons, the enemy, and, *finally, death*', the last that will be defeated (1*Cor.* 15:26), a notion essential to Origen's and Gregory's *apokatastasis.* Above all, V 36.2 depicts the eschaton through 1*Cor.* 15:28: speaking of the final restoration of humans into an incorruptible state, Irenaeus remarks that there will be a gradation in beatitude: each one will be provided by God 'with a suitable dwelling-place... according as each is, *or shall be*, worthy'. 'Shall be' suggests eschatological improvement (admitted by Origen), as the continuation confirms: 'the saved *advance* through steps of this nature and *ascend* through the Spirit to the Son, and through the Son to the Father ... "For he must reign until he has put *all enemies under his feet. The last enemy will*

[19] See my: Hebrews (2007).

[20] For this conception in Origen and Gregory see my *Gregorio* (2007), philosophical essay.

[21] *Biblia Patristica* (Paris, 1975), I 469, lists Irenaeus' and Clement's passages, which I cite, and Tertullian, *Adv. Pr.* 4.2.4; 17.3; Anon. Apoc., *Apoc.* 10; Melito, *De Fide*, 240,8. *Biblia Patristica* (Paris, 1977), II 390, lists Hippolytus' passages, which I report, and Victorinus of Pettau, *Iustin.* 16. All occurrences of Origen are in *Biblia Patristica* (Paris, 1980), III 404-5.

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be destroyed: death[22]... then the Son himself shall submit to him who put all under him, that God may be *all in all*"'. In 36.3 Irenaeus refers this to the restoration of the human *factura* to 'the image and likeness of God': Nyssen will conclude his *De Anima* precisely on the restoration of 'the image of God, i.e. human nature'.

Ps.-Hippolytus in *Contra Noetum* 6.3,[23] showing that the Father and the Son are different Persons, recalls Paul's statement that the Son will be entrusted with all, and conflates Pauline eschatological statements, principally 1*Cor.* 15:25-8. He concentrates on universal submission to Christ and God, but, differently from Origen, admits of a forced confession in submission (ἀνάγκην ἔχει *καὶ μὴ θέλων* ὁμολογεῖν, 8.1).[24] In *Refutationes*[25] V 7.33-4 Hippolytus cites a passage joining an Eleusinian invocation to Paul's prediction that all will be submitted to Christ, who is in all as Logos (ὁ ἐν πᾶσι ... τοῖς γενητοῖς υἱὸς ἀνθρώπου, ὁ ... Λόγος).

Hilarius deepened his knowledge of Origen's writings in Phrygia; his exegesis of 1*Cor.* 15:28 suggests the *apokatastasis*. Humanity will entirely participate in God's glory, when Christ has handed all to the Father; in *De Trin.* XI 40-9 Hilarius comments on 1*Cor.* 15:27-8 as Gregory does to support the *apokatastasis*: Christ's final submission to the Father is that of all humanity, which is Christ's body. Hilarius strongly insists on Christ's glory, because the 'Arians' used 1*Cor.* 15:28 to demonstrate Christ's inferiority:[26] Gregory in *In Illud* has the same anti-subordinationistic purpose.

Origen's exegesis of 1*Cor.* 15:28 was taken up by Didymus and Evagrius, both supporters of the *apokatastasis*, and by Gregory of Nazianzus. Here I can only refer to the chapters devoted to them in my *Apocatastasi*, where I argue that Nazianzen too supported the *apokatastasis*. I shall focus, instead, on Eusebius.

Eusebius admired Origen, and precisely for this, I think, he cautiously avoided discussing eschatology: for, if one accepts Origen's thought, it is difficult to separate out the *apokatastasis*, which is integral to it. However, Eusebius does comment on 1*Cor.* 15:27-8 in few passages, where it seems to me that

[22] For this understanding see my 1Cor 15:24-26: Submission of Enemies and Annihilation of Evil and Death: *SMSR* 74 (2008) 241-58.

[23] Ed. R. Butterworth (London, 1977), 43-93.

[24] A further reference to everyone's submission to Christ is in 8.10: ᾧ πάντα ὑπέταξεν Πατήρ. In *Commentary on Daniel* (ed. M. Lefèvre, SC 14 [Paris, 1947], 70-386), 4.11.4-5, Hippolytus, conflating 1*Cor.* 15:28 with *Phil.* 2:10, foresees the submission of all (πάντα ὑποτάξας) to Christ, who will be 'in all' (ἐν πᾶσιν) and manifested 'through all' (διὰ πάντων). Soon after, Hippolytus takes up the Adam-Christ connection of 1*Cor.* 15:22-3 and *Rom.* 5:18-9: Christ 'recreates [ἀναπλάσσων] in himself the first-created Adam'.

[25] Ed. M. Marcovich (Berlin, 1986), 53-417.

[26] See Gilles Pelland, La *subiectio* du Christ chez St. Hilaire: *Gregorianum* 64 (1983) 423-52; Michael Durst, *Die Eschatologie des Hilarius von Poitiers* (Bonn, 1987).

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he shows conspicuous traces of Origen's influence, not generally admitted by scholars as for the *apokatastasis*.[27]

In *Contra Marcellum* II 4,[28] both Eusebius and Marcellus of Ancyra (whom Eusebius quotes and whose exegesis of 1*Cor.* 15:28 probably influenced Nyssen),[29] take Origen as an authority. The submission of all to Christ and the eventual destruction of evil is announced, mainly through 1*Cor.* 15:25-8. God, who assumed humanity, will reign, and thus the ἄνθρωπος, deceived by the devil, now constituted king by the Logos, will destroy all the devil's power (πᾶσαν ἀρχὴν τοῦ διαβόλου καὶ δύναμιν καὶ ἐξουσίαν καταργήσει), for 'he must reign until he has put all enemies under his feet' (II 4.1). Paul 'says that the aim of Christ's kingdom is that all be submitted to his feet, and when all will finally be subjected to Christ... he will submit to him who has subjected all to him' (*ibid.*).[30] Eusebius continues, quoting Marcellus quoting Paul; in the Judgment the Logos will maintain his flesh (II 4.5), for people 'will see him whom they wounded' (*Zach.* 12; *Rev.* 1:7). Marcellus maintained that the Logos took human flesh so that the latter, understood as all humanity, might attain immortality through communion with the Logos; Eusebius remarks that, if the flesh is useless to the Logos, he should not allow it to remain with himself in the future aeons (ἐν τοῖς μέλλουσιν αἰῶσιν, II 4.6). Commenting on *Ps.* 109:1 quoted in 1*Cor.* 15:25, Eusebius observes that the distinction of two Lords is due to the flesh assumed by the Son; thus it seems that the Son will sit on the Father's right only 'at a certain time' (ῥητόν τινα χρόνον), when the submission of all enemies occurs, during Christ's reign, and that the human

[27] See e.g. Robert M. Grant, Eusebius and His Church History, in: *Essays M.S. Ensslin* (Valley Forge, 1972), 233-47; Manlio Simonetti, Eusebio e Origene: *Augustinianum* 26 (1986) 323-34; Frank Thielman, Another Look at the Eschatology of Eusebius of Caesarea: *VChr* 41 (1987) 226-37; Wolfram Kinzig, *Novitas Christiana* (Göttingen, 1994); Anthony Grafton and Megan Williams, *Christianity and the Transformation of the Book* (Cambridge, 2006), 133-232; my: *Apocatastasi* (Milan, forthcoming), and my: *The Christian History of Apokatastasis: From the Origin to Eriugena* (forthcoming). His silence on eschatology was attributed to scarce interest (Francesco Trisoglio, Eusebio di Cesarea e l'escatologia: *Augustinianum* 18 [1978], 173-82) or to realized perfection under Constantine (Jean Sirinelli, *Les vues historiques d'Eusèbe de Césarée* [Dakar, 1961], 480-1).

[28] Georg Christian Hansen and Erich Klostermann, GCS 14 (Berlin, 1972²), 1-58; now Markus Vinzent, *Markell von Ankyra: Die Fragmente* (Leiden, 1997), 135ff. On eschatology in Marcellus and others till the fourth century see Eckhard Schendel, *Herrschaft und Unterwerfung Christi* (Tübingen, 1971), 127-9, according to whom Marcellus supported Origen's *apokatastasis*; Joseph Lienhard, The Exegesis of 1Cor. 15:28 from Marcellus of Ancyra to Theodoret of Cyrus: *VChr* 37 (1983) 340-59.

[29] See Reinhard Hübner, Gregor von Nyssa und Markell von Ankyra, in: M. Harl (ed.), *Écriture et culture philosophique dans la pensée de Grégoire de Nysse* (Leiden, 1971), 199-229; Id., *Die Einheit des Leibes Christi bei Gregor von Nyssa* (Leiden, 1974), 29-66; 283-90.

[30] Χριστοῦ βασιλείας τοῦτο τέλος εἶναι ... τὸ πάντα ὑποταγῆναι ...· πάντων γὰρ ἐν τῷ καιρῷ *τοῦ τέλους* ὑποτάσσεσθαι μελλόντων τῷ Χριστῷ ... αὐτὸς ὑποταγήσεται τῷ ὑποτάξαντι αὐτῷ τὰ πάντα.

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form assumed by the Logos for the salvific economy will be taken off at the end of his reign (ὅρον τινὰ ἔχειν δοκεῖ ἡ κατὰ ἄνθρωπον αὐτοῦ οἰκονομία τε καὶ βασιλεία, II 4.7-8).

Eusebius, like Origen, sees a further step in the eschaton, at the end of all aeons and of Christ's reign,[31] when no more enemy is opposed and Christ's dominion is universal: then comes the *apokatastasis*. This is Eusebius's own view, for in II 4.9-10 he goes on to say that when Christ has submitted all, 'he will no more need this partial reign, because he will be king of absolutely all [πάντων καθόλου]', with God the Father. Then, 'the ἄνθρωπος, once deceived by the devil, thanks to the Logos's power will be king and ... finally defeat the devil'.

Now, Eusebius verbally describes this as 'the *apokatastasis*'. Restoration of humanity and defeat of evil will take place in 'the times of universal *apokatastasis*', that *Acts* 3:20-1, to which Eusebius openly refers, proclaims, presenting the times of 'consolation' (ἀνάψυξις) as the χρόνοι ἀποκαταστάσεως πάντων. Notably, already Origen had referred *Acts* 3:20-1 to the eventual *apokatastasis* in *Hom. Jer.* 14.18 and *Comm. Matth.* XVII 19.

That will be when humanity attains unity with the Logos (τὴν κατὰ ἄνθρωπον οἰκονομίαν ἡνῶσθαι τῷ Λόγῳ) and in the future aeon all will receive complete restoration: Eusebius uses again '*apokatastasis*', thrice, to affirm that 'the *apokatastasis* of all' will be when all pass from captivity to the freedom of God's children's glory (*Rom.* 8:21): Τὸ *Ἄχρι χρόνων ἀποκαταστάσεως ... αἰῶνα μέλλοντα* ἡμῖν σημαίνειν, ἐν ᾧ δεῖ *πάντα τῆς τελείας τυχεῖν ἀποκαταστάσεως ... ἐν τῷ καιρῷ τῆς ἀποκαταστάσεως ἁπάντων* καὶ αὐτὴν τὴν κτίσιν... μεταβληθήσεσθαι ... ἀπὸ τῆς δουλείας τῆς φθορᾶς εἰς τὴν ἐλευθερίαν τῆς δόξης τῶν τέκνων τοῦ Θεοῦ (II 4.11).

Most remarkably, *Rom.* 8:21 was likewise used by Origen to describe the *apokatastasis* in *Ex. Mart.* 13: God will reveal his treasures 'when the whole creation is delivered from the bondage of the enemy into the glorious liberty of God's children'. Eusebius is likely to be inspired by Origen.

It is impossible that the Logos may keep the fleshly form of servant he had during a short time among past and future aeons (ἐν βραχεῖ τινι χρόνῳ τῶν τε παρεληλυθότων καὶ τῶν μελλόντων αἰώνων), but will not maintain it after all aeons, in the τέλος: Eusebius and Marcellus use Origen's terminology. The τέλος (1*Cor.* 15:24) will be after the submission of all enemies and elimination of evil, when Christ hands his kingdom to the Father (II 4.12): ταύτην ὥσπερ ἀρχὴν οὕτως καὶ τέλος ἔξειν ...: Εἶτα *τὸ τέλος*, ὅταν παραδιδῷ τὴν βασιλείαν τῷ Θεῷ. After all aeons comes the *apokatastasis*, the τέλος, as in Origen's conception.[32] This τέλος, after the Judgment, will be according

[31] Henri Crouzel, Origène a-t-il tenu que le règne du Christ prendrait fin?: *Augustinianum* 26 (1986) 51-61.

[32] P. Tzamalikos, *Cosmology* (2006), 272-309; my: Αἰώνιος and Αἰών in Origen and Gregory of Nyssa: *SP* 47 (2010) 57-62.

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to God's providence: πάντα δὲ τὰ καθ' ἡμᾶς τῇ αὐτοῦ προνοίᾳ καὶ ἐνεργείᾳ ἐν τῷ καιρῷ τῆς κρίσεως τέλους τεύξεται.

Eusebius discusses Marcellus's views (II 4.13-14), blaming him for asserting that the Logos will lose human flesh after the Judgment, universal διόρθωσις and the vanishing of all opposing powers (μετὰ δὲ τὸν καιρὸν τῆς κρίσεως καὶ *τὴν τῶν ἁπάντων διόρθωσιν καὶ τὸν ἀφανισμὸν τῆς ἀντικειμένης ἁπάσης ἐνεργείας* τότε αὐτὸς ὑποταγήσεται τῷ ὑποτάξαντι αὐτῷ τὰ πάντα). Eusebius does not criticize the idea of the elimination of evil and final universal διόρθωσις, which undoubtedly is the *apokatastasis*, but only the investigation of a time when Christ is supposed to put off humanity. Marcellus denied that Christ is God and only spoke of him as Logos: Eusebius's refutation concerns Christology, not eschatology (II 4.18-22), as is clear from the subsequent section, where discussion is Christological. When Marcellus speaks of universal restoration, Eusebius has no objection and describes as the *apokatastasis* the situation foretold in 1*Cor.* 15:24-8. And in II 4.28 he calls Christ 'the common saviour of absolutely all', κοινὸς ἁπάντων σωτήρ.

In *De Ecclesiastica Theologia*, II 8, Eusebius again opposes Marcellus, who rejected the begetting of the Son, but he has no objection to the final restoration. After the judgment there will be the 'setting right of all things' and 'the vanishing of any opposing power' (τὸν καιρὸν τῆς κρίσεως καὶ τὴν *τῶν ἁπάντων διόρθωσιν* καὶ τὸν ἀφανισμὸν τῆς ἀντικειμένης ἁπάσης ἐνεργείας), then the Son will submit to the Father, 'so that the Logos will be in God, as it was before the world existed' (ἵν' οὕτως ᾖ ἐν τῷ Θεῷ ὁ Λόγος, ὥσπερ καὶ πρότερον ἦν πρὸ τοῦ τὸν κόσμον εἶναι). After the end of his action, the Logos will be one with God (μετὰ τὸ τέλος τῆς πράξεως αὖθις, ὡς Λόγος, ἑνωθῇ τῷ Θεῷ), so that God will be 'all in all': 1*Cor.* 15:28 is quoted. This is Origen's conception of the *apokatastasis* as unity, which Eusebius does not attack; he only criticizes Marcellus's view that for a while the Logos was not with God.

Eusebius returns in III 14-16, 18-20 to 1*Cor.* 15:28. In III 14 he opposes Marcellus's conception of the Son and his interpretation of two crucial passages: *Ps.* 109:1 quoted in 1*Cor.* 15:25 and *Acts* 3:21 (ὃν δεῖ οὐρανὸν μὲν δέξασθαι ἄχρι χρόνων *ἀποκαταστάσεως*). Again, he explicitly refers 'the times of the *apokatastasis*' to the submission of all to Christ. He links it to the 'time of perfection and accomplishment of all' alluded to in 1*Thess.* 4:16,[33] which will be forever:

ὡς μέλλοντος κατὰ *τὸν τῆς συντελείας καιρὸν* διανίστασθαι ἀπὸ τοῦ θρόνου τοῦ πατρικοῦ καὶ δευτέραν ποιεῖσθαι κάθοδον ... περὶ ἧς ὁ ἀπόστολος διδάσκει λέγων ὅτι αὐτὸς ὁ Κύριος ... καταβήσεται ἀπ' οὐρανοῦ, καὶ οἱ νεκροὶ ἐν Χριστῷ ἀναστήσονται πρῶτοι, ἔπειτα ἡμεῖς οἱ ζῶντες ... *πάντοτε* σὺν Κυρίῳ ἐσόμεθα.

[33] See Ilaria Ramelli and David Konstan, The Syntax of ἐν Χριστῷ in 1Thess. 4:16: *JBL* 126 (2007) 579-93.

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δεῖ τοίνυν τὸν Σωτῆρα μένειν ἐν οὐρανῷ ... ἕως τῆς *συντελείας*, κατὰ δὲ *αὐτὴν τὴν συντέλειαν τοῦ παντὸς* τὴν ἔνδοξον καὶ δευτέραν αὐτοῦ παρουσίαν ποιησάμενος τοὺς ἁγίους αὐτοῦ παραλήψεται εἰς τὸ *πάντοτε* αὐτῷ συνεῖναι ... *εἰς ἄπειρον αἰῶνα.*

Eusebius quotes 1*Cor.* 15:25-8 *in extenso*, claiming that Marcellus misinterpreted it, confusing the Son's eschatological submission to the Father with the Logos's eternal union with God (ἀϊδίως).

Eusebius faces here (III 15) the first problem addressed by Gregory some decades later: does the Son's final submission to the Father mean his inferiority? Eusebius illustrates this submission in 1*Cor.* 15:28 and insists on its correct understanding, which Marcellus missed, interpreting it as a complete union of all in the Son, whereas God is said to be 'all' not 'in the Son' but 'in all', when there will be 'communion and unity of all' (ἔδοξεν ἂν *συνάφειάν τινα πάντων καὶ ἕνωσιν σημαίνειν*, εἰ πάντα μέλλοι ὁ Θεὸς ἐν πᾶσιν εἶναι), which is Origen's interpretation of 1*Cor.* 15:28 in reference to the *apokatastasis.*

Eusebius stresses that 1*Cor.* 15:28 must not be understood as a transformation of all into the Son, where no creature would have a life of its own (ἰδίαν): Paul did not foretell universal confusion (σύγχυσιν τῶν ὅλων) where all creatures, the Son and God become 'one and the same thing', but *voluntary* submission of all, according to Origen's exegesis of 1*Cor.* 15:24-8 that universal submission is voluntary and means universal salvation. Likewise, Eusebius affirms that in 1*Cor.* 15:26-8 everyone's submission to Christ means, not becoming one (ἕνωσις) with the Son, but voluntary adhesion and salvation: Christ is given glory by all as 'saviour of *absolutely all*' (τῶν ὅλων is strongly inclusive), just as the Son submits to the Father voluntarily; he will save *all* because he will render *all* (τοὺς πάντας) worthy of God:

οὐχ ἕνωσιν ὁ ἀπόστολος ἐδήλου λέγων ὑποταγήσεσθαι τῷ Υἱῷ τὰ πάντα, ἀλλὰ *τὴν ἐξ αὐθεκουσίου προαιρέσεως ὑπακοὴν* καὶ τὴν δόξαν ... ἣν ἀποδώσει αὐτῷ τὰ πάντα οἷα *σωτῆρι καὶ βασιλεῖ τῶν ὅλων*, τὸν αὐτὸν τρόπον καὶ τὸ αὐτὸν ὑποταγήσεσθαι τῷ Πατρὶ οὐδὲν ἕτερον σημαίνοι ἂν ἢ ... τὴν *αὐθεκούσιον ὑπακοήν*, ἣν καὶ αὐτὸς ἀποδώσει τῷ Θεῷ καὶ Πατρί, *ἐπειδὰν τοὺς πάντας ἀξίους τῆς πατρικῆς θεότητος εἶναι παρασκευάσῃ.*

Christ is 'the common saviour of absolutely all', Eusebius repeats: during his reign he will set right what is imperfect and heal those who need therapy (as *Christus Medicus*, another conception already developed by Origen, who found in it a basis for the *apokatastasis*[34]): ὅτε οὐκ ἄξιοι ταύτης εἰσίν, προλαβὼν αὐτὸς οἷά τις *κοινὸς ἁπάντων σωτὴρ διορθωτικὴν* τῶν ἀτελῶν καὶ *θεραπευτικὴν* τῶν θεραπείας δεομένων βασιλείαν, βασιλεύει τοὺς τῆς βασιλείας ἐχθροὺς ὑπάγων τοῖς αὐτοῦ ποσίν. During Christ's healing and purifying reign, the evil powers will be submitted, and death destroyed, and

[34] See Samuel Fernández, *Cristo médico, según Orígenes* (Roma, 1999).

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those who need healing will be healed, and those who are still imperfect will become perfect; thus, there will be eternal life for 'those who are worthy of the Kingdom', i.e. all, since Christ will 'render all worthy' of it. Once Christ has set right those who needed it (ὧν ὧδε εὐτρεπισθέντων), all will submit to God in a 'salvific submission', as in Origen (τῷ Υἱῷ τοῦ Θεοῦ *σωτήριον ὑποταγὴν* πάντες οἱ ἅγιοι ὑποταγήσονται, 'all saints' meaning all humans, who will have been rendered saints by Christ). All will participate in Christ's faculties, including divinity, according to the ideal of θέωσις, deeply rooted in Origen and Gregory.[35]

Eusebius then relates the eschatological picture of 1*Cor.* 15 to *Phil.* 3:20-1[36] where everyone's submission to Christ is foreseen, and the transformation of our body into the glory of his body and the swallowing of mortality by life.[37] Eusebius repeats (III 15-6), echoing Origen, that this universal submission is salvation (ὑποτάξει ἑαυτῷ *τὰ πάντα*· καὶ τοιαύτην τινὰ τὴν *σωτήριον ὑποταγὴν* χρὴ νοεῖν) and, if submission involves all, salvation will be of all together (*τοὺς* ὑπ' αὐτοῦ *πάντας* χοροῦ δίκην περιστοιχισάμενος τῷ Θεῷ ... προσάξει), and Christ will be the source of all goods, πάντων τῶν ἀγαθῶν, for all: Eusebius interprets 1*Cor.* 15:28 like Origen and Gregory: God will be all goods for all. This will be the perfect accomplishment (τὸ συμπέρασμα τῆς ἀποστολικῆς διδασκαλίας *τέλους* τεύξεται φῆσαν· *ἵνα ᾖ ὁ Θεὸς τὰ πάντα ἐν πᾶσιν*), foretold by an Old-Testament passage (like Origen, Eusebius quotes both the Old and the New Testament to buttress his arguments),[38] according to which God will inhabit not, as now, a few who are worthy (βραχεῖς τοὺς ἀξίους), but 'all', who will then have become worthy of the Kingdom: μετὰ δὲ τὴν *συντέλειαν τοῦ παντὸς* ἐπιστάντος τοῦ νέου αἰῶνος, οὐκέτ' ἐν βραχέσιν τισὶν ἐνοικήσει, ἀλλ' ἐν *ἅπασιν*, τοῖς τότε τῆς τῶν οὐρανῶν βασιλείας ἀξίοις. In the end God will be all in all, offering himself to all according to each one's receptivity (another idea derived from Origen and present in Gregory[39]): ἔσται πάντα ἐν πᾶσιν ... τῷ *πᾶσιν ἑαυτὸν παρέχειν*, καθ' ὃ ἡ ἑκάστου δύναμις χωρεῖ τῆς αὐτοῦ θεότητος μεταλαγχάνειν.

As Gregory, *In Illud* 13, calls the *apokatastasis* τὸ πέρας τῶν ἐλπιζομένων, Eusebius, quoting Paul, calls it 'the most blessed hope' and identifies it with the τέλος, when God will be 'all *in all*' and fill *all*, and the Son will rejoice in God's salvific action, in his never ending reign: Τῆς *τρισμακαρίας ἐλπίδος* καὶ τῆς ἀτελευτήτου καὶ ἀφθάρτου ζωῆς ἐν τούτῳ καταστησομένης *τῷ*

[35] Τῶν λοιπῶν ἐν αὐτῷ δυνάμεων μεθέξουσιν οἱ αὐτῷ ὑποταγησόμενοι ... ἐπεὶ δὲ καὶ Θεὸς ἦν ὁ Λόγος, *οὐδὲ τῆς θεότητος αὐτοῖς φθονήσει*.

[36] See my: 'Nostra autem conversatio in caelis est' (Phil. 3.20): *Sileno* 31 (2005) 139-58.

[37] Τῷ δύνασθαι αὐτὸν *ὑποτάξαι αὐτῷ τὰ πάντα* καὶ τοῦ σώματος τοῦ ἡμετέρου μετασχηματισμὸν ποιήσει εἰς τὸ σύμμορφον τῷ σώματι τῆς δόξης αὐτοῦ ... *τὸ ἡμέτερον καταποθήσεται ὑπὸ τῆς ζωῆς*.

[38] See my: Origen and the Stoic Allegorical Tradition: *InvLuc* 28 (2006) 195-226.

[39] See the philosophical essay in my: *Gregorio* (2007).

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τέλει, ἐν ᾧ ὁ μὲν Θεὸς ἔσται πάντα *ἐν πᾶσιν* ... ἐμπιπλῶν *τοὺς πάντας*, ὁ δὲ Υἱὸς ἐναγαλλόμενος καὶ *χαίρων τῷ κατορθώματι* ... ἀτελεύτητον διατελέσει βασιλείαν.

The Son will give back to the Father 'all' his subjects (τοὺς ὑπ' αὐτῷ βασιλευομένους *πάντας*), constituting the whole kingdom he was entrusted with: τὴν βασιλείαν, δηλαδὴ τοὺς ὑπ' αὐτῷ βασιλευομένους. Christ will give back 'all' after making them perfect (*τελειωθέντας* ὑπ' αὐτῷ *τοὺς πάντας*), saved and completely healed (*σώαν* καὶ κατὰ πάντα ἐρρωμένην τὴν παραθήκην ... παραδώσει τῷ Θεῷ), after having sanctified them all as high priest (a reminiscence of Origen's interpretation of *Hebrews*),[40] so that they may enjoy the Father's ineffable goods: this situation, again, is equated by Eusebius, as by Origen, with 'God's being all in all'.[41] The perfect unity in the *apokatastasis* of all, brought to perfection by the Son and handed, saved, to the Father, is described by Eusebius immediately afterwards: ἔσται τότε καὶ *ἐν πᾶσιν, τοῖς ὑπὸ τῷ Υἱῷ τελειωθεῖσιν* ... τὸν μὲν Υἱὸν τῷ Θεῷ ... τὴν βασιλείαν παραδώσειν, *σώαν* τὴν παραθήκην καὶ πρὸς τὴν τοῦ Πατρὸς λατρείαν τε καὶ ἱερωσύνην ἐπαρκοῦσαν ἐνδεικνύμενον, τὸν δὲ Θεὸν ἔσεσθαι *πάντα ἐν πᾶσιν* ... πάντα αὐτοῖς γινόμενον.

Eusebius again calls the *apokatastasis*, God's being all in all, 'the culmination of the most blessed hope' (τέλος τῆς τρισμακαρίας ἐλπίδος), both at the end of our passage, where it involves the Son and 'all the others' (λοιποῖς ἅπασιν), and in III 18: τὸ τρισμακάριον τέλος will be when ὁ ἐπὶ πάντων Θεός ... τὸ πάντων ἀνώτατον ἀγαθόν, αὐτὸς ἑαυτὸν τοῖς ὑπὸ τῷ Υἱῷ βασιλευομένοις δωρήσεται, πάντα ἐν πᾶσιν γιγνόμενος. Eusebius has affirmed that Christ will render worthy of blessedness, during his reign, those who will be found unworthy: so, when God will be all in all, he will be in those made worthy of it. This blessedness in the *apokatastasis* is again described, soon after, as unity, according to Jesus's prayer (*John* 17) that all be τετελειωμένοι εἰς τὸ ἕν.

Eusebius, like Origen, insists on unity, with quotations from *John*. All humanity's unity with God in the *apokatastasis* will be not of substance, but of perfect virtue, to which 'all' will be brought: ποιῶν ἡμᾶς ἓν *τοὺς πάντας*, ἵνα μηκέτι ὦμεν πολλοὶ ἀλλ' *οἱ πάντες* εἷς, *ἑνωθέντες* αὐτοῦ τῇ θεότητι ... οὐ κατὰ συναλοιφὴν μιᾶς οὐσίας κατὰ δὲ τελείωσιν τῆς εἰς ἄκρον ἀρετῆς ... *τέλειοι κατεργασθέντες*. All (οἱ πάντες) will achieve unity with God. As the Son is one with the Father, so will 'all' imitate this oneness: *πάντας* ἡμᾶς κατὰ τὴν αὐτοῦ μίμησιν τῆς ἑνότητος.

[40] See my: The Universal and Eternal Validity of Jesus's Priestly Sacrifice: The Epistle to the Hebrews in Support of Origen's Theory of Apokatastasis, in: *A Cloud of Witnesses: The Theology of Hebrews in Its Ancient Contexts*, eds. R.J. Bauckham, D.R. Driver, T.A. Hart, and N. MacDonald, Library of New Testament Studies 387 (London, 2008), 210-21.

[41] Ἀρχιερέως δίκην τοὺς ὑπ' αὐτῷ *ἱερουμένους πάντας* ... ἵνα τῶν τοῦ πατρὸς ἀρρήτων ἀγαθῶν ἐμπιπλῶνται· οὕτω γὰρ ἔσται ... ὁ Θεὸς πάντα ἐν πᾶσιν.

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After refuting interpretations by Marcellus and the Sabellians (III 19-20), Eusebius interprets other Old- and New-Testament passages as referring to the *apokatastasis* (e.g. *Acts* 17:28) and concludes with an anti-heretical statement: unity does not mean mixing up Father and Son in their ὑποστάσεις, nor humanity and divinity in their οὐσίαι. Thus, like Origen and Gregory, Eusebius supports the *apokatastasis* in a context of defence of orthodoxy.

Also in *Commentarium in Isaiam* 1.85 Eusebius describes the *apokatastasis*, τὸ τῶν ἀγαθῶν τέλος, 'the culmination of the goods' foreseen by the prophets (*Acts* 3:20ff.), the ἀρχαία βουλή established before creation and described in Paul's terms as the submission of all enemies and destruction of evil and death, when God will be 'all in all' at the end of all aeons: τὰ προωρισμένα μὲν πρὸ καταβολῆς κόσμου, *ἐπὶ συντελείᾳ δὲ τῶν αἰώνων* πληρωθησόμενα ... *πάσης κακίας ἐκποδὼν* ἀρθείσης καὶ τοῦ ἐσχάτου ἐχθροῦ τοῦ θανάτου καταργηθέντος, ὁ μὲν Θεὸς ἔσται πάντα ἐν πᾶσιν. The annihilation of evil is in Eusebius, as in Origen and Gregory, a powerful argument for the *apokatastasis*. And καταβολή notoriously was a crucial term in Origen's reflection on creation,[42] just as the end of the αἰῶνες with universal restoration.

Eusebius foretells punishment for sinners (destruction of their cities in *Is.* 25:2)[43] but also predicts that the inhabitants will be saved and escape from ruin (*διασωθέντες* ἐξ αὐτῶν ἐκείνων). He exalts Jesus as helper and defender (βοηθὸς καὶ σκέπη), and, still commenting on Isaiah, even says that Jesus will save the pagans, although idolaters: they would be ἀνέλπιστα, 'hopeless', so *Is.* (25:8) says that death swallowed them (κατέπιεν ὁ θάνατος), but the 'Saviour of all' frees them from error and spiritual death and dries out tears from all faces: ὁ φιλάνθρωπος *τῶν ὅλων Σωτήρ*, ῥυσάμενος τοῦ θανάτου τὰς τῶν ἀνθρώπων ψυχάς ... ἀφεῖλε πᾶν δάκρυον ἀπὸ παντὸς προσώπου ... διὰ φιλανθρωπίαν τὴν τῶν τοσούτων ψυχῶν ἀποκλασμένων ἀπώλειαν.

Eusebius interprets *Is.* 25:8 as announcing the eventual eviction of death foretold in 1*Cor.* 15:27: *Καταποθῆναι ποιήσει καὶ ἀφανὲς γενέσθαι* τὸ πρόσωπον τοῦ ἐξουσιάσαντος πάντων ... *τοῦ θανάτου*. Death, destroyer of all humans, will be destroyed.[44] Origen conceived of death as both physical and spiritual,[45] and so does Eusebius, who says that it will be eliminated thanks to Christ's salvific action for all,[46] who will achieve eternal life, once liberated from evil and made worthy of God's promises by Christ: τῆς δὲ τοῦ Χριστοῦ βασιλείας ἐν αἰωνίῳ ζωῇ διαλαμπούσης, ἀπολαύσουσιν οἱ ἐξ ἁπάντων

[42] Mark J. Edwards, *Origen against Plato* (Aldershot, 2002), 87-122.

[43] Περὶ δὲ *τῶν παρεληλυθότων ἐν τῷ θνητῷ βίῳ* ἐπιλέγει· ὅτι ἔθηκας πόλεις εἰς χῶμα ... τῶν ἀσεβῶν πόλις εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα οὐ μὴ οἰκοδομηθῇ.

[44] Καταποντιεῖ ὁ ... Κύριος ὡς μηκέτι φαίνεσθαί που αὐτόν ... ἐπεὶ τοίνυν ἔσχατος ἐχθρὸς καταργεῖται ὁ θάνατος ... ὁ θάνατος ὁ πάλαι καταπίνων τοὺς πάντας καταποθήσεται.

[45] See my: Origen's Exegesis (2008).

[46] Thanks to ἡ χρῖσις ἡ κεχρισμένη εἰς *πάντα τὰ ἔθνη* (= faith, like in Origen, *Pasch.* 25!)... οὐκέτ' ὑποχείριοι γενήσονται θανάτῳ, *ἀθανασίας δὲ καὶ ζωῆς αἰωνίου* μετασχόντες.

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τῶν ἐθνῶν, τῶν μὲν προτέρων *ἠλευθερωμένοι κακῶν*, τῶν δ' ἐπαγγελιῶν τοῦ Θεοῦ *καταξιωθησόμενοι*. It is liberation not only from physical death, but from evil, and justification.

Eusebius opposes to blessedness Moab's punishment (*Is.* 16; *Jer.* 31): now, Moab does not represent a portion of humanity, but evil powers; what is referred to Moab concerns the opposing powers.[47] Eusebius stresses the final destruction of death and adverse powers (*τοῦ θανάτου τὸ τέλος* κατὰ τὸν τῆς κρίσεως καιρὸν καὶ *τῶν λοιπῶν ἀντικειμένων δυνάμεων ... τὴν ἀπώλειαν*), in contrast with the humans' salvation; he mentions no destruction or eternal damnation of humans. When he speaks of humans worthy of the promises (τῶν ἐπαγγελιῶν ἄξιοι) he indicates those who will have been rendered worthy by Christ. They will inhabit Jerusalem, i.e. Christ, who will be 'all' (πάντα) for all them, with further reference to 1*Cor.* 15:28.

Eusebius depends on Origen's interpretation of 1*Cor.* 15:28 and inclines to his conception of *apokatastasis*, also using this very term.

Epiphanius comments on 1*Cor.* 15:25-8 in *Panarion*[48] II 69.76-77: the whole Trinity reveals the definitive victory over death, which, 'destroyed, will be trodden' and 'no more exist' (οὐδὲ ἔτι ὑπάρχων). Like Gregory, Epiphanius demonstrates that the Son's final submission does not mean that he 'should be listed among the subjected' but refers to his humanity: humanity's submission will unite it to God (τῇ θεότητι ... τὸ σαρκικὸν εἰς μίαν ἕνωσιν συνηνωμένον, 225.77). Epiphanius deals further (225-226) with 1*Cor.* 15:28: 'God will be all in all', identified by both Origen and Gregory with perfect unity in *apokatastasis*. Epiphanius too insists on unity and perfection, which begins with Jesus's resurrection,[49] and will culminate in the end: πάντων τελειωθέντων καὶ *μηδενὸς ἔτι πρὸς πλήρωσιν ὑπολειπομένου* τῶν ἐπὶ τὴν αὐτοῦ θεότητα † ἀναφέρειν ... *ὁ θεὸς τὰ πάντα ἐν πᾶσιν* ... ἵνα μὴ εἴη διαίρεσις. This unity is that of the Trinity, where the Son does not submit as a slave but has the same nature as the Father, and of all submitting humanity. The Son will elevate all creation to it and to one honour during his eternal reign with the Father, and will teach his Church (which seems to coincide with the abovementioned creation, as in Gregory), so that God may be all in all: εἰς μίαν ἑνότητα καὶ εἰς ἓν γέρας τιμῆς ἀνάγων *τὴν πᾶσαν κτίσιν* καὶ διδάσκων *αὐτοῦ τὴν ἐκκλησίαν*, ἵνα ᾖ ὁ Θεὸς τὰ πάντα ἐν πᾶσιν.

Epiphanius, like Nyssen, opposed Eunomius: it comes as no surprise that, in spite of some opposition to Origen[50] and his 'Asian' anthropology[51] (but he

[47] Μωὰβ λέγεσθαι *τὸν πονηρὸν δαίμονα καὶ τὴν ἀντικειμένην δύναμιν* ... ἐξ ἑνὸς παραδείγματος ἡμῖν καταλείπων νοεῖν καὶ τὰ *ταῖς λοιπαῖς ἀντικειμέναις δυνάμεσιν* ἐπελευσόμενα.

[48] Ed. Karl Holl, GCS 25,31,37 (Leipzig, 1915; 1922; 1933).

[49] Ἐξότε μὲν ἀνέστη, ἀρχὴν ἔλαβεν τὸ *ἵνα ᾖ ὁ θεὸς τὰ πάντα ἐν πᾶσι*· συνήνωται γὰρ ὁμοῦ εἰς μίαν τὴν αὐτοῦ θεότητα πνευματικῶς τὸ σαρκικόν.

[50] Elizabeth A. Clark, *The Origenist Controversy* (Princeton, 1992), 86-103.

[51] Emanuela Prinzivalli, The Controversy about Origen, in: *Origeniana Septima* (Leuven, 1999), 194-213, 197-200.

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didn't criticise human *apokatastasis*, and appreciated Origen's *Hexapla*), he interprets 1*Cor.* 15:27-8 like Gregory in *In Illud*, where he argues for the *apokatastasis*. His association of πᾶσα κτίσις with πάντες and πάντα suggests universal inclusiveness.

Cyril of Jerusalem, who knew Origen and Gregory, interprets 1*Cor.* 15:28 (*Baptismal Catecheses* 10.9[52]) also quoting 1*Cor.* 15:25 = *Ps.* 109:1, concerning all enemies' submission to the Son. Like Eusebius, Cyril denies that the Son's submission means his resolution (ἀναλύεσθαι) into the Father: for it would be impossible that all should submit to the Son. As Gregory in *In Illud*, Cyril insists that Christ is the Lord of all, who lovingly keeps all that the Father entrusted him with. His submission does not indicate inferiority: he obeys not as a slave, by force (ἀνάγκη), but willingly and out of love (προαιρέσει καὶ φιλοστοργίᾳ).

Theodore of Mopsuestia, who supported the *apokatastasis*[53] and interprets 1*Cor.* 15:27-8 in Commentary on *Ps.* 8,[54] roughly contemporary with Gregory's *In Illud*, is similarly concerned with the danger that the Son's submission may be seen to support subordinationism, whereas it applies to his human nature, which Gregory identifies with all humanity.

Epiphanius (with Hilarius, Cyril, and Theodore) interprets 1*Cor.* 15:27-8 like Nyssen, focussing on the meaning of the Son's submission, which Gregory stressed for polemical reasons, but indeed Gregory's and Origen's exegesis of 1*Cor.* 15:27-8 is identical; Eusebius (with Irenaeus) interprets it similarly to Origen; Clement shows hints developed by Origen. These Fathers' discussions are less philosophical than Origen's and Gregory's: e.g. most of them do not develop the metaphysical argument concerning evil, which was taken up by Evagrius and Eusebius, who also seems to follow Origen's interpretation. Eusebius was a disciple of Pamphilus, who wrote the Apology for Origen and enormously admired him; his exegesis of 1*Cor.* 15:27-8, to which he was forced by polemics, reveals an inclination to the *apokatastasis* that is evident in Gregory's exegesis of this passage in *In Illud*, where he closely depends on Origen, in arguments (non-substantiality of evil, humanity as Christ's body, unity...) and exegesis: choice of the same passages supporting the *apokatastasis* (especially *Phil.* 2:10-11, linked to 1*Cor.* 15:28 also by Clement and Hippolytus; *Rom.* 8:21, related to 1*Cor.* 15:28 also by Eusebius) and same interpretation. Eusebius too, who deeply esteemed Origen and was much influenced by his thought, probably embraced the conception that was the heart of Origen's reflection.

[52] Ed. W.C. Reischl and J. Rupp (Munich, 1:1848; 2:1860; repr. Hildesheim, 1967), 1:28-320; 2:2-342.

[53] See section on him in my: *Apocatastasi* (forthcoming).

[54] Robert C. Hill, Theodore of Mopsuestia, *Commentary on Psalms 1-81* (Atlanta, 2006), 94-6 (Latin translation, the only extant here), and 95-7 (English).

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Scenting the Aroma of Christ: 2*Cor.* 2:15-6 in Origen's Interpretation

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In 2*Cor.* 2:14-6, the passage which by most contemporary commentators is regarded as opening a new section of the letter, St. Paul uses a striking and complex metaphor to defend his missionary activity. Modern exegetes are not unanimous on how to interpret the lavish olfactory imagery and many concentrate not on the notion of scent, which pervades the entire passage, but on the image of triumph introduced at the beginning of v. 14.[2] This is in marked contrast to how this passage was read in patristic literature. In this paper I propose to focus on one early Christian writer, Origen, whose use of Paul's olfactory metaphor was quite novel as compared to his predecessors. In his writings, 2*Cor.* 2:15 became *the* proof text for the existence of the spiritual sense of smell, and it thus entered the stock of scriptural passages used to illustrate the respective spiritual senses, on which later authors will draw extensively.

Before Origen Paul's olfactory metaphor was rarely quoted or even alluded to. In addition, the emphases of earlier authors were quite different, as they more often commented on or exploited the elements that would later be neglected by Origen. A possible allusion to 2*Cor.* 2:14 occurs already in *Evangelium Veritatis*, where 'the children of the Father' are presented as 'his fragrance', and it is explained that 'the Father loves his fragrance, and manifests it in every place'.[3] While we cannot be sure that this indeed is an allusion to the Pauline passage, the similarities are noteworthy. Irenaeus of Lyon quotes 2*Cor.* 2:15-6a *verbatim*, yet it is notable that he is not interested in scent as much as in the notion of judgment.[4] In the *Letter of the Churches of Vienne and Lyons*, as preserved by Eusebius, there is a possible allusion to the metaphor of triumph of 2*Cor.* 2:14 in the account of Pothinus' martyrdom.[5] The fact that further in the same text the martyrs are reported to 'breathe the fragrance

[1] Fund for Scientific Research – Flanders, Belgium.

[2] Jan Lambrecht, The Defeated Paul, Aroma of Christ: *LouvSt* 20 (1995) 170-86, is a good example.

[3] *Ev. Ver.* 34, 3-5; Jacqueline A. Williams, *Biblical Interpretation in the Gnostic Gospel of Truth from Nag Hammadi*, SBL DS 79 (Atlanta, 1988), 138-40, deems the allusion to 2*Cor.* 2:14 in this passage 'probable'.

[4] *Adv. Haer.* IV 28, 3.

[5] *Hist. Eccl.* V 1, 29.

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of Christ',[6] attests that *2Cor.* 2:15 could be applied to martyrdom. Clement of Alexandria refers to the Pauline passage twice in the chapter on the use of ointments and crowns in his *Paedagogus*. He first quotes *2Cor.* 2:14-6a in its entirety to illustrate his claim that 'the passion of the Lord has filled us with sweet fragrance, and the Hebrews with guilt'.[7] A little later he alludes to v. 15 in a piece of moralizing advice offered to women.[8] One more reference, this time to the 'the aroma of knowledge' of v. 14 is found in Clement's *Stromateis*.[9]

This brief survey has shown that before Origen there was no established tradition of interpreting *2Cor.* 2:14-6. While some authors occasionally used certain elements of the metaphor to support their arguments, the potential of the olfactory imagery was apparently not explored to any significant extent. In Origen's extant works we all of a sudden come across around twenty quotations, and a number of allusions to the passage, which can most of the time be easily identified.

As the subtitle of the present paper already indicates, in Origen we should talk about the interpretation of *2Cor.* 2:*15*-6, rather than 2:*14*-6, for even though v. 14 forms an integral part of the passage, it is virtually absent from Origen's extant writings. The majority of his quotations are of v. 15a. The only phrase of v. 14 that is used is ἐν παντὶ τόπῳ, which he several times inserts at the end of v. 15a.[10] The idea of ubiquity of the aroma appears thus to be the only aspect of v. 14 that attracted Origen. There are no significant differences between the texts quoted, except for some minor stylistic variations, pertaining mostly to the word order. Verse 15b is frequently omitted when v. 15a is conflated with 16a,[11] and even when 15b is not omitted, it does not receive any additional comment.[12] From the text-critical point of view we may note that in v. 16a Origen clearly attests the reading including ἐκ both before θανάτου and ζωῆς.

In *De Principiis*, the earliest text which is usually listed as attesting Origen's 'doctrine' of the spiritual senses, sense of smell is not even explicitly mentioned. John Dillon points out that in this work Origen's thought concerning the spiritual senses is not yet fully developed. According to him, in *De Principiis* I 1, 9 Origen claims merely 'that many expressions which appear to refer

[6] *Hist. Eccl.* V 1, 35.

[7] *Paed.* II 63, 3.

[8] *Paed.* II 65, 2.

[9] *Strom.* IV 100, 1.

[10] See *Cat. Gen.*; *Com. Jn.* 20, 415; *Com. Cant.* I 4, 2; III 14, 25; IV 1, 11; IV 1, 22; *Hom. Cant.* I 2; I 22; *Dial. Her.* 18. The reference to *Cat. Gen.* (PG 12, 124B2) in *Biblia Patristica* is misleading.

[11] *Hom. Ex.* III 3; *Com. Cant.* I 4, 2; I 4.21.

[12] *Com. Jn.* 20, 415; *Com. Cant.* III 14, 25; *Hom. Cant.* II 2; *Dial. Her.* 18. It is noteworthy that the two places where the entire 15-6a is quoted are in the writings extant in Greek, so it cannot be excluded that in some other cases the shortening of the text was due to the translators.

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to activities of our sense-organs really refer to operations of the mind or soul'.[13] It is not surprising that prominence is given to sight, the sense traditionally considered the most 'rational' of all the five senses. Henri Crouzel asserts that among the spiritual senses 'la vue ou l'ouïe n'expriment guère que le contact de l'intelligence avec le mystère, les sens plus affectifs, odorat ou goût, y ajoutent l'idée des délices du connaître'.[14] It is therefore noteworthy that in one of the first texts where 2*Cor.* 2:15-6a is quoted, not the positive, but the *negative* aspect of olfactory knowledge comes to the fore. In *Com. Jn.* XX 413-6, while discussing *John* 8:51, Origen embarks on a lengthy excursus discussing the possibility of experiencing death with all the five senses. He finds scriptural arguments mainly in the (mostly reversed) passages that will later become standard proof texts for the respective spiritual senses. With regard to the sense of smell, 2*Cor.* 2:16a readily provided the association of smell with death. The problem is, however, that for Paul it was the same *positive* smell that could be differently interpreted and have thus varying consequences. Having initially associated the smell of death with sin, in the following passage Origen goes on to explain that as for the 'noetic' smell of death or smell of life (περὶ τῆς νοητῆς ὀσμῆς θανάτου ἢ ὀσμῆς ζωῆς), the text of the Apostle should be noted. He then quotes the Pauline text at length (2*Cor.* 2:15-6a) and as a good exegete he feels a need to comment on how the same, basically *good* odour of Christ, could be misconceived by some because of vice preceding it, and as a result lead them to death. Origen returns to this ambiguity several times in his writings, most extensively in Book One of his Commentary on the Song of Songs.[15] In *Com. Cant.* I 4, 21 2*Cor.* 2:16a serves as an illustration of the need for the exercise of the senses[16] (both physical and spiritual). As Origen explains, the sense of smell, as long as it is healthy and in good shape, having once perceived Christ, will lead 'from life to life'. If however, it is not healthy, it will lead 'from death to death'. Further in the same chapter the focus is on those who oppose spiritual interpretation of the Scriptures. Here Paul's metaphor comes in handy in Origen's polemics. He observes that the same life-giving or lethal effect applies to the spiritual explanation of the Song of Songs, for

[13] John M. Dillon, Aisthêsis Noêtê: A Doctrine of Spiritual Senses in Origen and in Plotinus, in: A. Caquot, M. Hadas-Lebel, and J. Riaud (eds.), *Hellenica et Judaica: Hommage à Valentin Nikiprowetzky* (Leuven, 1986), 443-55, 447. See *De Princ.* I 1, 9: *Frequenter namque sensibilium membrorum nomina ad animam referuntur ita, ut oculis cordis videre dicatur, id est virtute intelligentiae aliquid intellectuale conicere.* Dillon is to my mind right to note the development in Origen's thought in this matter, yet I would argue that there are too many inconsistencies in the texts from various periods to allow us to claim that Origen ever reached a unified 'doctrine' of the spiritual senses.

[14] Henri Crouzel, *Origène et la «connaissance mystique»* (Bruges, 1961), 506.

[15] One more interesting passage where Origen exploits the ambiguity of Pauline imagery, without mentioning the spiritual senses, though, is *Hom. Ex.* III 3.

[16] The notion of 'exercised senses', αἰσθητήρια γεγυμνασμένα, is taken from *Heb.* 5:14, one of the most fundamental texts, beside *Prov.* 2:5, for Origen's notion of the spiritual senses.

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animalis qui dicitur homo will not grasp what is of the Spirit of God. For such people the scent of the Song becomes the smell from death unto death, that is from death of infidelity unto death of judgment and condemnation. Blindness as well as other blocked spiritual senses are caused by the vice of jealousy and vain glory. In *Com. Cant.* I 4, 26 *odor Christi* is identified with the scent of the bridegroom's perfume after which the maidens run.

There are a number of other passages in Origen's works where *2Cor.* 2:15(-16a) is quoted or alluded to in association with the spiritual senses, yet in most of them the passage receives only cursory attention and the negative aspect of the 'aroma of Christ' is not commented on.[17] It is thus not surprising that Gregory of Nyssa, who seems to have accepted from Origen the entire set of the proof texts for the spiritual senses, and who was more interested in philosophy than in exegesis, will restrict his interest in the Pauline metaphor almost exclusively to the unambiguously positive aspect.

Why did Origen choose *2Cor.* 2:15 as his proof text for the spiritual sense of smell?[18] This is after all not the only biblical passage to employ olfactory imagery.[19] It is, however, quite exceptional, not least due to its ambiguity. *2Cor.* 2:15-6 is unparalleled in that the notion of the aroma of Christ is *the* focus of the passage. Most importantly, this text is unique in the extent to which it plays on the distinctive qualities of smell, such as its pervasiveness and transmissibility. This allows for the most exceptional intermingling of the divine and human, so that Paul may not only manifest the aroma of Christ's knowledge, but even become the scent of Christ himself.

Origen's use of Paul's olfactory metaphor, however, is not limited to the texts in which he discusses the spiritual senses. The 'doctrine' of the internal senses seems to have been mostly intended for those who were more advanced, that is probably why it rarely occurs in Origen's homilies.[20] Most conspicuous is its

[17] See *Hom. Lev.* III 7; *Cat. Fragm. Ps.* 118; *Com. Rom.* IV 5; *P. Pasc.* 1.18 (?); *Dial. Her.* 18; *Ser. Mat.* 64; *C. Cels.* I 48.

[18] Next to *2Cor.* 2:15, another important text for the notion of the spiritual sense of smell in Origen is *Cant.* 1:3.

[19] In Pauline literature two other passages are *Phil.* 4:18 and *Eph.* 5:2. Origen refers to *Phil.* 4:18 occasionally, yet the fact that the 'good odour' denotes in this passage the gift that Paul had received from the Philippians, not Christ, makes it less attractive for Origen. In addition the emphasis is on the aspect of sacrifice rather than on scent as such. The latter applies to an even more significant extent to *Eph.* 5:2, which is clearly of more interest to Origen, yet he tends to focus on Christ's sacrifice. Outside of Pauline literature the most remarkable text is *John* 12:3. While this passage is not used in the accounts of the five spiritual senses, it is interesting that in *Com. Cant.* II 9.6 it is associated with *2Cor.* 2:15. There is no difference according to Origen between the bride pouring forth the ointment on the bridegroom in the Song of Songs, and the disciple Mary doing that with her master Christ, in the hope that he returns through this ointment the fragrance of the Word and the pleasant aroma of Christ, so that she might herself say 'we are a good odour for God'. It is noteworthy that Origen puts Paul's words (*Bonus odor sumus Deo*) in Mary's mouth.

[20] There are some exceptions, most notably *Hom. Lev.* III 7 and *Hom. Ezech.* XI 1 (the latter does not include any reference to *2Cor.* 2:15).

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apparent absence from the Homilies on the Song of Songs.[21] This not to say that 2*Cor.* 2:15 is not quoted or alluded to in various homilies. The interpretation assigned to it, however, is usually quite different. In line with the character of homilies, meant as more didactic and edifying, the 'good odour of Christ' is frequently associated with good deeds/virtues in general[22] or more specifically, with justice and mercy,[23] and it is contrasted with the repulsive odour of sin/vice. In addition, the didactic nature of the homilies prompts the change of perspective: rather than focussing on the excellence of the divine aroma that can be perceived by the believers, Origen encourages his listeners to strive to become the 'good aroma' themselves,[24] which those who still smell of putrefaction and sin cannot yet claim, for only virtue exhales perfume.

To conclude, in contrast to the early Christian writings preceding Origen, the Alexandrian exegete displays a marked interest in St. Paul's olfactory metaphor. The number of quotations and more or less explicit allusions to verse 15a, as well as less frequent but not inconsequential, references to verse 16a, is notable. Origen was the first one to realize the potential of Paul's multifaceted imagery, applying different interpretations to the passage, depending on the context and the genre of a given work. It is significant that the metaphor of triumph, which so kindled the minds of exegetes in the second half of the 20th century, apparently failed to capture Origen's imagination. One could perhaps argue that the notion of the Bridegroom's perfume as doctrine spread throughout resembles the idea expressed by Paul in 2*Cor.* 2:14, so even though the verse is never quoted, it cannot be said with confidence that Origen does not attach any significance to another important theme put forward in v. 14, that is the idea of the manifestation of the fragrance of the knowledge of Christ. Yet strikingly, except for inserting the phrase 'in every place' in some of his quotations of v. 15a, Origen fails to use the terminology of v. 14.

[21] Note, however, the reference to the 'spiritual nard' in *Hom. Cant.* II 2.

[22] See *Hom. Cant.* I 2; II 2. Interestingly, when the association of the 'aroma of Christ' with virtues is found in the Commentary (see *Com. Cant.* IV 1.11), it is within the context of allegorical interpretation and the imagery is more sophisticated than in the Homilies.

[23] See *Hom. Gen.* III 6; XI 1.

[24] See *Hom. Ex.* IX 4; *Hom. Lev.* II 2; *Hom. Iud.* III 2; *Hom. Cant.* I 2; II 2.

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Exegetical Curricula in Origen, Didymus, and Evagrius: Pedagogical Agenda and the Case for Neoplatonist Influence

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Introduction

Possibly the most-neglected aspect of the study of patristic exegesis is the social context in which it was practiced, that is, its pedagogical application among the groups of students and teachers who engaged in exegesis as part of curricula dedicated to higher philosophical study and spiritual formation. And possibly the most-repeated assessment of patristic exegesis is that influence from Neoplatonism both characterises it and explains those elements of it most foreign to modern hermeneutics. In the following, both of these points are treated by taking an examination of the educational context of noetic exegesis as an example on the basis of which the relationship of Origen, Didymus, and Evagrius's exegetical practice to that of known Neoplatonist teachers in the same general region and milieu.[1] In pursuing these questions, I am concerned firstly with these three Fathers's use of noetic exegesis within a curriculum whose components and aims should be investigated in their own right, rather than with a view to proving or disproving the legitimacy of their use by Christian thinkers. The curricula in which these three Fathers's exegesis was embedded provides a valuable source for the system of beliefs which motivated and oriented the teaching and study of biblical texts. With regard to the second question investigated here, my aim is to suggest an alternative model of the type of interaction which characterises the relationship between Neoplatonism and Christianity, at least as it applies to educational practice and known exegetical curricula, beyond the standard model of influence and borrowing.

I proceed by addressing the textual basis of the curriculum for spiritual development, the steps in the curriculum itself, and the goal of the curriculum

[1] The term 'noetic exegesis' has also been used by Eric Osborn in his 1998 article Philo and Clement: Quiet Conversion and Noetic Exegesis: *Studia Philonica* 10 (1998) 108-24. He does not offer an explicit definition, but associates it with the process of *diaresis* and characterises noetic exegesis as a tradition of biblical interpretation to which both Clement and Philo belonged and which aims at finding the hidden *nous* in Scripture by using the human *nous*. My own usage does not contradict this characterisation but arises out of a need for a more precise term than 'allegorical interpretation' and as an attempt to reflect the relevant exegetes's beliefs that the higher interpretation of Scripture required the application of the *nous* to the text in order to perceive the intelligible truths contained within it.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 281-294.
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in Origen, Didymus, and Evagrius in turn, finally assessing the relationship of this curriculum with those of Neoplatonist teachers who, like Origen, Didymus and Evagrius, were all in some manner involved in education in or around Alexandria, namely Plotinus, Porphyry, and Hypatia, as well as the teachers of the later Alexandrian Neoplatonic school, namely Hermeias, Ammonius Hermeiou, and Olympiodorus.

Origen's Exegetical Curriculum

While all of Origen's exegesis reflects a concern with the spiritual development of the reader or hearer, Origen also attaches his curriculum to specific series of books of the Bible, though, in the prologue to his *Commentary on the Song of Songs*, he sets down several alternatives. These include an explicit identification of the order of three particular books with the three phases of what he describes as the traditional Greek curriculum: *Proverbs* corresponds to ethics or moral wisdom, *Ecclesiastes* to physics or natural wisdom, and the *Song of Songs* to enoptics or inspective wisdom.[2] Further on in the same passage, Origen also considers it possible 'that this threefold structure of divine philosophy was prefigured in those holy and blessed men' Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Here Abraham corresponds to the life of obedience or moral philosophy, Isaac 'is an exponent of natural philosophy, when he digs wells and searches out the roots of things. And Jacob practices the inspective science, in that he earned the name of Israel from his contemplation of the things of God.'[3] Alternatively, Origen claims that Christians have taken over the Jewish tradition 'that all the Scriptures should be delivered to boys by teachers and wise men, while at the same time the four that they call *deuteroseis* – that is to say, the beginning of *Genesis*, in which the creation of the world is described; the first chapters of *Ezechiel*, which tell about the cherubim; the end of that same, which contains the building of the Temple; and this book of *Song of Songs* should be reserved for study till the last.' On this account, the curriculum is based on the Scriptures generally, then the *deuteroseis*, which culminates in the study of *Song of Songs*.[4]

Generalising on this basis, Origen sees advancement in spiritual life as a matter of pursuing a curriculum beginning with moral philosophy, ethics, and virtues like obedience, progressing to learning about the created, natural world, which he also calls physics or natural philosophy, and then moving on to the highest phase, described as inspective wisdom or contemplation of the things of God. This curriculum may be put into practice in connection with different

[2] Orig., *The Song of Songs, Commentary and Homilies*, Richard P. Lawson (transl., and ed.), Ancient Christian Writers (New York, 1957), 39f.

[3] *Ibid.* 44f.

[4] *Ibid.* 23.

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series of books or groups of books, but what is key is the explicit attachment of this curriculum to the study of biblical texts, such that noetic exegesis becomes a medium by which this curriculum is realised.

Without rehearsing the entire discussion on Origen's teaching activity in Alexandria, two points are particularly relevant here.[5] Firstly, we should note the inclusion of subjects like geometry and arithmetic as studies about which Origen is said by Eusebius to have claimed that his students 'would receive no small advantage from them in understanding the Holy Scriptures.' (HE VI 18.3-4).[6] This is consistent with an assumption on Origen's part that the student whose ambition is to perceive the noetic content of Scripture should first complete preliminary studies in what he would term natural philosophy. Also, on the vexed question of the so-called Catechetical School, it should be noted that the term catechesis, in late antiquity, also existed outside of a specifically Christian context and meant learning through imitation, a kind of learning in which the student was expected to internalize what was demonstrated by the teacher. Thus catechesis may have included, but was not by definition limited to, instruction in Christian doctrine. This usage is exemplified as late as Simplicius, the pagan philosophical teacher of the sixth century, in his discussion of a similar curriculum constructed from the Platonic dialogues, a context which, if the argumentation of this essay is correct, should be unsurprising.[7]

Gregory Thaumaturgus supplies us with first-hand testimony on the practical application of Origen's curriculum. Although, because of his verbosity, it is unclear from the account in his *Panegyric on Origen* (8.109-14) in which order Gregory was taught what, he does relate having been taught geometry and astronomy, and knowledge about creation which fits in with the second step of Origen's stated curriculum.[8] He also holds forth about how Origen conveyed to his students 'the divine virtues concerning how to act, which bring the soul's impulses to a calm and steady condition' (9.115-119) which sounds like the first step of the curriculum, the attainment of inner order and the practical virtues.[9] Gregory also describes Origen engaging in noetic exegesis of the Scriptures as

[5] Two valuable but untranslated contributions to clarifying this question are Manfred Hornschuh, Das Leben des Origenes und die Entstehung der alexandrinischen Schule: *Zeitschrift für Kirchengeschichte* 71 (1960) 1-25, and 193-214, and Clemens Scholten, Die Alexandrinische Katechetenschule: *Jahrbuch für Antike und Christentum* 38 (1989) 25-46.

[6] Euseb., *Ecclesiastical History*, C.F. Cruse (transl., and ed.) (Peabody [MA], 1998), 207-8.

[7] Richard Sorabji documents this usage in Simp., *In Cat.* 5.23-6.5 (sixth century AD) in *The Philosophy of the Commentators 200-600 AD: A Sourcebook*, vol. 1: Psychology (with Ethics and Religion) (London and Ithaca [NY], 2005), 322. – Other usages of the term in this sense can be outlined as follows from Liddell and Scott, s. v. *katékhesis*: def. 'instruction by word of mouth: generally, instruction' from fifth century BC; s. v. *katekhéo:* amongst others the definition 'teach by word of mouth: hence generally, instruct'.

[8] St. Gregory Thaumaturgus, *Life and Works*, Michael Slusser (transl., and ed.), The Fathers of the Church, vol. 98 (Washington [D.C.], 1998), 109.

[9] *Ibid.* 110.

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part of his lectures, and how 'he himself expounded and clarified the dark and enigmatic places, of which there are many in the sacred words', so that we see the actual practice of noetic exegesis used in teaching advanced students.

Origen's understanding of the goal of this curriculum, which is at the same time the goal of the spiritual life, namely union with God through perfect noetic apprehension, is fairly familiar. One passage from the *De Principiis* uses a metaphor from education to describe what Origen thinks happens to the souls of the saints after death. He thinks 'paradise' is: 'a lecture room or school for souls [...] If anyone is "pure in heart" and of unpolluted mind and well-trained understanding he will make swifter progress and quickly ascend.' After outlining the steps in this upward progress and the posthumous curriculum which the souls work through to achieve it, Origen describes the end of the journey thus: 'And so the rational being, growing at each successive stage, not as it grew when in this life in the flesh or body and in the soul, but increasing in mind and intelligence, advances as a mind already perfect to perfect knowledge, no longer hindered by its former carnal senses, but developing in intellectual power, ever approaching the pure and gazing "face to face", if I may so speak, on the causes of things' (*De Princ.* II 11.6).[10] So for Origen, the aim of his higher spiritual or philosophical curriculum is to make the student pure in heart, of unpolluted mind and well-trained understanding, so that after death he will be able to readily advance to perfect knowledge. This process of mental and moral purification, culminating in perfect knowledge of ultimate reality, is a pattern so familiar from Neoplatonism that modern scholars have expressed doubt about whether Origen should be characterised as a Christian theologian or an only partially-converted philosopher.

Didymus the Blind's Exegetical Curriculum

Didymus the Blind, who is known primarily as the teacher of a group of urban ascetics participating in exegetical lessons, represents a clear-cut case of noetic exegesis functioning as part of a curriculum of advanced spiritual development. Among the texts by Didymus in the Tura Papyri are a collection of commentaries including stenographic transcripts of twice-daily lessons on *Psalms* and *Ecclesiastes*, as well as a more finished text on *Job*, in which Job is interpreted as an example of ascetic and contemplative perfection.[11] In the case of the commentaries on *Psalms* and *Ecclesiastes*, it is clear from the status of the texts as direct transcripts, including spontaneous and often unhelpful questions from students, that the exegesis of these texts were part of actual lessons.

[10] Origen, *On First Principles: Being Koetschau's Text of the 'De Principiis'*, G.W. Butterworth (transl., and ed.), Henry de Lubac (intr.) (Gloucester [MA], 1985), 152.

[11] Richard A. Layton, *Didymus the Blind and His Circle in Late-Antique Alexandria: Virtue and Narrative in Biblical Scholarship* (Chicago, 2004), 3.

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Unfortunately, we do not know whether these books were studied in sequence as part of a three-step curriculum, possibly beginning with *Psalms*, progressing through the more philosophical subject-matter of *Ecclesiastes*, and culminating in the study of *Job*, who Didymus takes to be an example of ascetic and contemplative sainthood, or whether Didymus interpreted Scripture with his students in any particular order at all. So while a construction of these commentaries in a trilogy parallel to that of Origen must remain conjectural, what is important is that Didymus teaches and forms his students by performing noetic exegesis.

The interpretation of biblical texts manifests examples of instruction on all levels of the spiritual curriculum we saw in Origen and which Origen claims to be traditional. Numerous interpretations which generate teachings on the attainment of virtue or what, on Origen's scheme, would be called 'moral philosophy', can be found. When *Ps.* 21:4 speaks of 'length of days for all eternity' Didymus interprets this as a reference to the virtues in the midst of a digression on various reasons for wanting a long life and how the term 'day' should be understood:[12]

A praiseworthy day is also each single practical virtue which is exercised. Just as the knowledge which is partial here is followed by a perfect and complete knowledge, so also in the practical virtues those people who are later proved righteous in the practical virtues will be virtuous in another manner.

Also in his *Commentary on Job*, Didymus sees the text as referring to the virtues:

"Houses" in the plural must be understood as the plurality of virtues. Prudence is a house, courage is a house, gentleness and the other virtues, as it is written: "The fear of the Lord is a refuge for the righteous"; and so also justice. Over and against these houses are the houses which the Lord tears down, for "the houses of the wicked the Lord tears down, but he protects the home of the widow".[13]

Didymus is even able to find teachings on the life of virtue in the brief notes at the beginning of *Ps.* 35, 'in view of the goal':

The ultimate goal worthy of our striving is perfect virtue, beyond which one need seek no other goal. We have laws for the sake of virtue; the giving of the laws is not the goal. We obey the warnings and rulings of the teacher of ethics; all this however is done for the sake of something else. Only the perfect, unsurpassable virtue, which is only achieved with progress, is the goal. This is what any servant of God pursues.[14]

[12] *Ibid.* 51.

[13] Didymos der Blinde, *Kommentar zu Hiob Kapitel 12.1-16.8 a: Einleitung, Text, Übersetzung*, Ursula Hagedorn, Dieter Hagedorn, and Ludwig Koenen (transl., and ed.), vol. 4.1 of *Kommentar zu Hiob (Tura Papyrus)*, Papyrologische Texte und Abhandlungen, vol. 33.1 (Bonn, 1985), 47, on *Jb.* 12:5-6.

[14] Didymos der Blinde, *Kommentar zu Psalm 35-39*, Michael Gronewald (transl., and ed.), vol. 4 of *Psalmenkommentar (Tura-Papyrus)*, Papyrologische Texte und Abhandlungen, vol. 6 (Bonn, 1969), 1, on *Ps.* 35:1-2.

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While specific lessons on natural philosophy, if this is understood, as in Origen, to indicate subjects like astronomy and mathematics, are not typical of Didymus's commentaries, his exegesis does include numerous references to non-theological and, modern scholars would say, non-biblical subjects. These could constitute points belonging to natural philosophy or to a second step in the curriculum, if Didymus understands this as something like 'secular learning' or 'general education'.[15] For example, in the *Commentary on Psalms*, Didymus reviews the conceptual categorisation of attributes and terminology based on Euclid and Aristotle,[16] and also teaches informal logic and the proper use of syllogisms.[17] In the *Commentary on Job*, Didymus works through the different categories of friendship passed down from Aristotle.[18]

Didymus also manifests a concern for explaining contemplation, the highest level of the curriculum, to his students. He understands contemplation to be a matter of freeing the mind from material impediments and attachments: 'For sometimes the human melts and the material falls away from thought and from the heart, so that the mind *(nous)* no longer has any attachments, but is completely immaterial, as it was in the beginning.'[19] Didymus puts forward 'the wise man' as a contemplative who is able to perceive intelligible things: 'The wise man has a mind *(nous)* which thinks in the right manner, he has insight *(synesis)* into intelligible things. The heart of the fool however is left, it occupies itself only with the material.'[20]

Similarly, a *nous* properly employed allows one to know the Creator through the 'greatness and beauty' of the creation with the mind: 'We have a twofold capacity for knowledge. Knowledge of the truth exists when it takes up into itself the idea of each known thing. There are visible and invisible things created by

[15] These texts are discussed also in: Blossom Stefaniw, Reading Revelation: Allegorical Exegesis in Late Antique Alexandria: *Revue de l'histoire des religions* 224 (2007) 231-51.

[16] Didymos der Blinde, *Kommentar zu Psalm 20-21*, Louis Doutreleau, Adolphe Gesché, and Michael Gronewald (transl. and ed.), vol. 1 of *Psalmenkommentar (Tura-Papyrus)*, Papyrologische Texte und Abhandlungen, vol. 7 (Bonn, 1969), 103, on *Ps.* 21:2. Didymus here refers to Gel., *N. A.* 1.20.9, Arist., *Top.* 143b 11, and S. E. *M.* 3.37.

[17] *Ibid.* 207, on *Ps.* 21.27, referring to Arist., *SE* 169b 20ff.,171b 6ff., *Top.* 100a 27ff., 100a 30ff., 100b 6ff., and 100b 23ff. See also: Didymos der Blinde, *Kommentar zu Psalm 29-34*, Adolphe Gesché, and Michael Gronewald (transl., and ed.), vol. 3 of *Psalmenkommentar (Tura-Papyrus)*, Papyrologische Texte und Abhandlungen, vol. 8 (Bonn, 1969), 247, on *Ps.* 38:12, for discussion of how to prove contraries.

[18] Didymos der Blinde, *Kommentar zu Hiob Kapitel 7:20c-11*, Ursula Hagedorn, Dieter Hagedorn, and Ludwig Koenen (transl., and ed.), vol. 3 of *Kommentar zu Hiob (Tura Papyrus)*, Papyrologische Texte und Abhandlungen, vol. 3 (Bonn, 1968), 169, and note 120. – Didymus uses the classification of different types of friendship drawn from Aristotle, as in Arist. *EE* 236a 16ff., *MM* 1209a 5ff., and *EN* 1156a 7ff.

[19] Didymos der Blinde, *Psalmenkommentar*, vol. 1 (see no. 16), 143.

[20] Didymos der Blinde, *Kommentar zu Psalm 40-44:4*, Michael Gronewald (transl. and ed.), vol. 5 of *Psalmenkommentar (Tura-Papyrus)*, Papyrologische Texte und Abhandlungen, vol. 12 (Bonn, 1970), 113, on *Ps.* 43:3-4.

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God. And their creator is seen from their greatness and beauty. The eye however which sees invisible things is our mind, the pure heart, which also sees God.'[21]

The extemporaneous commentaries as a whole contain strikingly infrequent teaching on Christian doctrine, focussing instead on a standard ascetical and philosophical agenda, praising the life of virtue, setting out Biblical characters as contemplative heroes, and encouraging the students to orient their minds to the intelligible rather than the material. Didymus's concerns focus on control of the body, gaining spiritual knowledge, and contemplation and are set out together in the interpretation of *Ps.* 26:6:

'I will sing and make hymns to the Lord.' We said about the previous Psalms that 'singing' means contemplation *(theoria)*, when one sends praise up without instruments. So both, he says, are given to me, I will make hymns and sing. I will sing, in that I contemplate the truth. Whoever concerns himself with the doctrines of piety and considers them in knowledge and wisdom, sings. But whoever also treats his body as an instrument, as a cithara and psalter, by striking all of his appetites and passions, which are in a sense strings, is able to bring forth a melodious Psalm, makes hymns.[22]

In three brief passages, Didymus reveals his understanding of the goals of the spiritual or philosophical curriculum which he is teaching.

Firstly, in his *Commentary on the Psalms* (25:6-7), Didymus says: '[...] virtue must not stop at praxis but must go on to theory and to the prize, to knowledge of the good itself, of the truth.' Secondly, Didymus gives the following response to a student's request for the spiritual interpretation of *Eccl.* 5:19: 'Real and true life consists in living according to philosophy and virtue.' And thirdly, in the *Commentary on Job* (11:8-9), Didymus describes the knowledge available to those who have achieved sainthood: 'For because the philosophers do not participate in the Holy Spirit, they do not have any precise knowledge of these things, whereas the saints walk upon the earth and have their citizenship in heaven at the same time. Thus they can say "God gave me uncorrupted knowledge of that which is, to know the construction of the world and the effects of the elements, the beginning, the end, and the middle of the times."'[23]

These passages reflect a picture of the goal of education and the spiritual life which most of us have been taught to consider typically Neoplatonic. For Didymus, the prize of virtue, the virtue which is developed through the advanced

[21] Didymos der Blinde, *Kommentar zu Psalm 22-26:10*, Michael Gronewald (transl., and ed.), vol. 2 of *Psalmenkommentar (Tura-Papyrus)*, Papyrologische Texte und Abhandlungen, vol. 4 (Bonn, 1968), 121, on *Ps.* 24:15.

[22] *Ibid.* 215, on *Ps.* 26:6.

[23] *Ps.* 25:6-7 see Didymos der Blinde, *Kommentar zu Psalm 22-26:10* (see no. 21); *Eccl.* 5:19 see Didymos der Blinde, *Kommentar zu Ecclesiastes, Kapitel 5 und 6*, Johannes Kramer, and Ludwig Koenen (transl., and ed.), vol. 3 of *Kommentar zum Ecclesiastes (Tura-Papyrus)*, Papyrologische Texte und Abhandlungen, vol. 13 (Bonn, 1970); *Jb.* 11:8-9 see Didymos der Blinde, *Kommentar zu Hiob Kapitel 7:20c-11* (see no. 18), 201.

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curriculum of which noetic exegesis is a part, is knowledge of the good and of the truth. True life is life according to virtue and philosophy, a statement which any late antique Stoic or Platonist teacher could also have subscribed to. And the saints are superior to the philosophers not because the Holy Spirit identifies them as Christians, but because the Holy Spirit provides privileged access to the same goal as the philosophers, namely knowledge of that which is.

Evagrius of Pontus' Exegetical Curriculum

Exegetical works on three books of the Bible, namely *Proverbs*, *Psalms* and *Ecclesiastes* survive from Evagrius. The exegetical agenda pursued by Evagrius is the application of the text to the progress of the monk and development in the spiritual life. As with Didymus, we cannot know whether and what the order in which these books were taught was. Evagrius does subscribe to a set trilogy, but the trilogy he sets out in theory consists of books other than those upon which we have surviving works by him. Like Origen, Evagrius connects books of the Bible to the educational stages of ethics, physics, and theology, and maps these disciplines onto *Proverbs*, *Ecclesiastes*, and *Song of Songs*.[24] The equivocation and inconsistency of all three of these Fathers on this point suggests that while the books of Solomon had a privileged position, all books of the Bible were considered a potential basis for spiritual instruction.

In his teaching practice, Evagrius works with a three-step course of spiritual formation consisting of *praktike*, *theoria physike*, and *theoria theologike*. *Praktike* is a synonym for ethics or moral philosophy, which to Evagrius means asceticism. *Theoria physike*, Evagrius's version of natural philosophy, means for him the contemplation of the natural world and of the Scriptures, by means of which the monk was to apply his *nous*, which had been rehabilitated by asceticism, to the divine wisdom which Evagrius held to have been deposited in the Scripture and in creation. *Theoria theologike* is the highest step, and indicates the perfect immediate contemplation of the Holy Trinity, free from images or concepts.[25] This scheme of progress in the spiritual life is explicated in the *Praktikos*, *Gnostikos*, *Kephalaia Gnostica*, and *Chapters on Prayer*.

As with Didymus, Evagrius's application of the text to the spiritual development of the student on all levels of the curriculum is manifested throughout his exegesis and his pedagogical writings. Unwitting testimony in one chapter from the *Kephalaia Gnostika* (1.67) reflects the psychology on the basis of which this curriculum is constructed: 'Who can know the structure of the world and

[24] Evagr. Pont., *Schol. Prov.* 247. See Evagrius, *Scholies aux Proverbes: Introduction, texte critique, traduction, notes, appendices et index*, Paul Géhin (transl., and ed.), SC 340 (Paris, 1987), 343.

[25] On the need for perfect contemplation to be free of images, see: Blossom Stefaniw, Evagrius Ponticus on Image and Material: *Cistercian Studies Quarterly* 42 (2007) 125-35.

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the activity of the elements? And who can understand the composition of this organ of the soul? And who can investigate how one is joined to the other, in what their empire consists, and how they participate with one another in such a way that the *praktike* becomes a chariot for the reasoning soul, which strives to attain the knowledge of God?'

Evagrius sees attainment of passionlessness and the virtues *(praktike)* as enabling the reasoning soul, which in turn seeks the knowledge of God. The questions composing this chapter all belong to the category of natural philosophy, so that Evagrius's inclusion of them as worthy and desirable objects of knowledge indicates that he does consider this type of knowledge appropriate for monks. In another chapter, biblical locations transversed by the Hebrews are interpreted allegorically as representing steps in spiritual development: 'Egypt signifies vice, the desert the *praktike,* the land of Juda the contemplation of bodies, Jerusalem [contemplation] of the incorporeal, and Zion is the symbol of the Trinity.'[26]

Vice, the state of the soul before engaging in this course of development, is followed by ascetic discipline represented by the desert. The promised land and its capital represent natural contemplation (of bodies and the incorporeal), while Zion is the ultimate goal of the soul, union with the Trinity.

As far as Evagrius's teaching practice is concerned, it would be an abuse of words to claim that he led a school analogous to that of Origen or Didymus, but to a certain degree monastic formation did take place in social structures similar to those of philosophical schools, with an abba teaching a group of novice monks, and the monks being expected to learn by imitation and internalisation the way of life demonstrated by the abba. We have no evidence for monks learning geometry and astronomy as in Origen's school or being put through basic rhetorical and logical exercises as with Didymus, although individuals already in possession of a rhetorical education were not uncommon among the monks. The second phase of the curriculum for Evagrius is still natural philosophy, but to him that means contemplation which is within the natural capacities of the human mind and is concerned with perceiving revelation within the natural world and the Scriptures.[27]

Beyond the definition of the goal of the curriculum which is apparent from putting *theoria theologike* at its summit, Evagrius also reveals his understanding of the purpose of the monastic life in a letter: 'Our struggle is for the contemplation of that which is and of the Holy Trinity, and the demons wage a great war against us to hinder us from knowing.'[28] So once again, the ultimate

[26] Evagr. Pont., *Kephalaia Gnostica* 6.49.

[27] On *Theoria Physike* see: Blossom Stefaniw, *Recognising Creation: Toward an Analytical Definition of Theoria Physike in Evagrius Ponticus*, unpublished MTh dissertation, University of Wales (Lampeter, 2003).

[28] Evagr. Pont., *Ep.* 58.2.

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goal, the contemplation of that which is, is a goal that any number of other teachers of advanced spiritual philosophy would also have subscribed to. While there is variation among these three Fathers, the same pattern of mental and moral purification culminating in perfect knowledge can be observed consistently.

The Exegetical Curriculum in Neoplatonist Teachers

Finally, the question remains as to how these curricula relate to those used by Neoplatonic teachers and what manner of interaction that relationship represents.

If we briefly survey the relevant thinkers involved in education in Alexandria, of course Plotinus is too early and too young to have realistically been a source for Origen. There is also reason to doubt that Plotinus and Origen were both among the inner circle of students of Ammonius Saccas.[29] On the other hand, Plotinus as the founder of Neoplatonism does write on a sort of scale of virtues moving from the political to the purificatory, and is clearly concerned with the moral and mental cultivation of his students.[30]

Porphyry is placed better chronologically, and we know that Didymus was at least familiar with Porphyry's polemic against Christian exegesis because he quotes it. On the other hand, it is only with a very generous use of terms that Porphyry can be said to have been involved in education in Alexandria, having recorded the teachings of Plotinus who himself had left Alexandria after his student years. While Porphyry does not explicate a curriculum based on a series of texts which is analogous to the one we have been examining, following Plotinus, he also expounds a scale of virtues progressing from the political to the purificatory to the theoretical and ending in the paradigmatic.[31] As Mark Edwards has shown, his interpretation of *The Cave of the Nymphs* is based on assumptions very similar to those I have outlined to define noetic exegesis.[32] Thus we can observe in Porphyry at least some manner of assent to the need for moral and mental purification, and his view of the culmination of the philosophical or spiritual life is not dissimilar to what we have observed in the patristic sources above.

Serious Neoplatonism in Alexandria begins with Hypatia. According to the testimony of Synesius, the aim of her teaching was to develop and perfect the

[29] Mark Edwards, Ammonius, Teacher of Origen: *Journal of Ecclesiastical History* 44 (1993) 169-81.

[30] Plot., *Enn.* 1 2. See Dominic J. O'Meara, *Platonopolis: Platonic Political Philosophy in Late Antiquity* (Oxford, 2003), 40, and 51.

[31] Porph., *Sent.* 32. See D.J. O'Meara, *Platonopolis* (2003), 44.

[32] Mark Edwards, Porphyry's Cave of the Nymphs and the Gnostic Controversy: *Hermes* 124 (1996) 88-100.

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minds and souls of her students and something like pure knowledge was seen as the highest ideal. The subject-matter of the curriculum initially appears to contain only topics that fit into the second phase of 'natural wisdom'. Hypatia's own commentaries were on mathematical treatises although Damascius also claims that she lectured on Plato and Aristotle.[33] However, Synesius's of Cyrene account of his education with Hypatia reveals an overall program of moral and mental cultivation which included an intensely religious-philosophical element. Synesius (*Ep.* 5) calls Hypatia 'that most holy and revered philosopher' and refers to her lessons as 'oracular utterances'. Maria Dzielska has summarized Synesius's description of the aims pursued in his education with Hypatia as follows:

> The spark of wisdom kindled by the 'divine guide', that 'hidden spark which loves to conceal itself', turns into a large flame of cognition (*Ep.* 139), thus concluding the journey of the soul which Plotinus termed *anagoge*, the ascension toward heaven, toward divinity. The goal of philosophizing is achieved; the mind is in a state of revelation, contemplation, *theoria* (*Ep.* 140; *Dion.* 6-9). This is the consummate experience, incontrovertible, for it touches on prime being, true reality, the original cause of temporal reality. This indeed is the most important realm in human life: 'to be given over to the things above and entirely to the contemplation of Reality and the origin of mortal things' (*Ep.* 140).[34]

So, Hypatia also teaches with a view to the mental perfection of her students, who are ultimately to become capable of comprehending reality, although her curriculum cannot properly be described as exegetical.

The later Platonic school in Alexandria does present something more clearly analogous to the noetic curriculum seen in Origen, Evagrius and Didymus: Hermeias, Ammonius and Olympiodorus teach Aristotle propaedeutically and then go on to the Platonic dialogues set out in a series, beginning with ethics and ending with theology, with logic, physics, and mathematics sometimes included in some order or other as well. We have Hermeias's notes from exegetical lectures on the *Phaedrus* and Olympiodorus's commentaries on *1 Alcibiades* and the *Gorgias* which reflect a similar concern with the moral and mental cultivation of the student. Hermeias considers perceiving the deeper meaning of Platonic myths a means of salvation:

> As a matter of custom one usually said after relating the myths, as a sort of postscript: 'And so the myth has been saved and it will save us, if we follow it', as he says at the end of the *Politeia*, or also 'and so the myth was lost', where this saying shows that we, if we follow the appearance of the myth [the literal interpretation], we will be lost just as appearances themselves are lost and have no definite being, but that we, if we follow the hidden vision [the allegorical interpretation] which the myth mysteriously indicates,

[33] Maria Dzielska, *Hypatia of Alexandria*, F. Lyra (transl.), Revealing Antiquity, vol. 8 (Cambridge [MA], 1995), 56-7.

[34] M. Dzielska, *Hypatia* (1995), 48-9.

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will be saved, in that we rise up to the thought of the mythmaker himself and not just the myth.[35]

Hermeias's son, Ammonius, also manifests not only the use of a curriculum which includes physics and theology as do those of the three Fathers examined above, but also the belief that the mind can and should be trained to think without reference to material bodies, which also is evidenced in Origen, Didymus, and Evagrius:

> Mathematics is between (physics and theology) with good reason. For since we cannot be led up immediately from natural to divine things and from what is altogether inseparable from matter to what is altogether separable, we travel by way of mathematicals which are in one respect separable, another inseparable. They are actually called mathematicals *(mathemata)* because it is by learning *(mathein)* them and by getting used to thinking without reference to bodies that we have to be led up to divine things.[36]

Olympiodorus teaches from the Platonic dialogues set out in a series, beginning with ethics and ending with theology, and since we have his commentaries from the dialogues assigned to the first step in the curriculum which is concerned with the attainment of virtue and which sees 'becoming intellect' as the ultimate goal of philosophy, the curriculum seems very similar.[37] In his *Prolegomena* on philosophy (8.29-9.12), Olympiodorus advocates ordering the reading of Aristotle's treatises such that the students begin with ethics, because: 'One must first set in order one's own ethical character, and then begin the other studies', and 'one must put ethics before the rest because it gives us the right rhythm and sets our ethical character in order.'[38] Here we must be aware that the term translated 'ethics' in the case of Olympiodorus and 'asceticism' in the case of Evagrius is *praktike*, in both instances. In fact the term indicates something like applied philosophy, and while Evagrius and Olympiodorus may have disagreed in the particulars of what applied, practical philosophy consists of, they do agree that it is the basis for the philosophical life. Unfortunately for the case for influence, Evagrius had been dead for about forty years before Hermeias, the first teacher of a clearly recognizable Alexandrian Neoplatonic school, was born.

In sum, a comparison with contemporary Alexandrian Neoplatonist teachers does supply some evidence for similar curricula and a recurring pattern of beliefs about the manner in which the student's mind can be prepared to meet its goal and what that goal consists of as those we have just examined in Origen,

[35] Herm., *In Phdr.* 241e 8, transl. by Hildegund Bernard in: Hermeias of Alexandria, *Kommentar zu Platons 'Phaidros'*, Hildegund Bernard (transl., and ed.), Philosophische Untersuchungen, vol. 1 (Tübingen, 1997), 63. (Parenthetical statements are Bernard's).

[36] Ammon. Hermeiou, *In Porph., Isag.* 12.20-13.7.

[37] Olymp., *In Phd.* 8.1-20.

[38] Translation of Olymp., *Proll.* 8.29-9.12 by Richard Sorabji: *The Philosophy of the Commentators 200-600 AD* (2005, see no. 7), 324.

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Didymus, and Evagrius. On the other hand, this similarity is rather loose and vague, and not at all what we would expect to see if we were dealing with a relationship of influence or borrowing. There are also serious chronological and geographical difficulties. The largest difficulty is that, if one wants to establish a case for influence, one must not only observe similarity between ideas and practices present among two groups of thinkers, but must also demonstrate which ideas or practices were moved from which thinker to which other, and make a plausible case not only for how and where this could have happened, but also for the need of the 'receiving' thinker to draw the given idea or practice from the 'giving' thinker rather than developing it independently or appropriating it from elsewhere.

Due to such methodological and chronological problems, the best case that can be made for exegetical curricula being a result of non-Christian influence will not come from mere similarities observable when these are compared with the curricula of Neoplatonist teachers. However, if we take earlier educational culture as a point of comparison, we do find something more consistently comparable: we can see a textual basis for the curriculum in the Platonic dialogues and/or noetic exegesis of Homer, set out the curriculum as a similar series of progress beginning with attainment of the virtues, progressing to higher levels of abstract thought cultivated by learning astronomy and geometry and so on, and ending finally in contemplation of the One, with the goal of perfect knowledge. This curriculum was standard and traditional, and indeed the identification of a source for patristic exegesis in the methods of the schools is well accepted. Informative comparisons have been made between philosophical prologues and Origen's introduction to the *Commentary on John*, and Karen Torjesen has connected the structure and content of the *De Principiis* to the concerns of traditional educational culture, so that a relationship between patristic exegetical curricula and inherited pedagogy is undeniable.[39] So perhaps earlier educational culture is the actual source for these three fathers's exegetical curricula, with simply a few levers in the system shifted to the 'Christian' rather than the 'pagan' position.

Conclusions

That of course is the standard view of the situation, and of course Christian Fathers did use ideas and practices familiar from the culture of *paideia*. Standard or not, however, this model of the interaction beween pagan philosophical

[39] See Ronald E. Heine, The Introduction to Origen's Commentary on John compared with the Introductions to the Ancient Philosophical Commentaries on Aristotle, in: *Origeniana Sexta: Origène et la Bible: Actes du Colloquium Origenianum Sextum, Chantilly, 1993*, Gilles Dorival, and Alain Le Boulluec (eds.) (Leuven, 1995), 3-12, and Karen Jo Torjesen, Hermeneutics and Soteriology in Origen's Peri Archon: *SP* 21 (1989) 333-48.

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tradition and early Christian thought is not coherent. Christian thinkers cannot and should not be said to have 'borrowed' or 'taken over' pagan educational tradition, because saying so makes several problematic assumptions. Firstly, it procedes on the assumption that Christians had some other options, but chose from a neutral vantage point to integrate traditional ideas into their separate independent systems. Secondly, it fails to differentiate between ideas and practices which – for contemporary Christians – were religiously marked as pagan and those which were simply culturally obvious. And finally, it constructs a false dichotomy between Christians as members of a *religion*, conceived of as if it existed separate from culture, and pagans as members of a *culture*, so that any appearance of known elements of contemporary culture in Christian writings is perceived as something pagan invading from outside.

If we briefly compare the educational culture we have just assessed in the Fathers and in their contemporary teaching colleagues *both* with the tradition of *paideia*, it is apparent that they *both* have the same sort of undeniable but loose relationship with it. One does not find a Christian *nor a Neoplatonist* teacher in late antiquity who has simply taken on a traditional curriculum wholesale. And even within the ranks of Christians or Neoplatonists, as we have seen, there is a great deal of individual variety within the same broad framework. The ideas and practices just examined could appear completely obvious and natural to both Neoplatonists and Christians precisely because they were not religiously marked: they are not dependent on Christian doctrine nor on adherence to any particular school of philosophy. Thinkers we today categorise as Christian were just as much a part of their culture as anybody else, and so the alacrity with which they set forth means and ends of the educational endeavor which we also find in Neoplatonist teachers and in earlier pagan tradition is perfectly explicable on the grounds of common culture. Thus the broad similarity we can observe between the curricula pursued by Christian and Neoplatonist teachers does not represent a type of interaction we could legitimately label 'influence' or 'borrowing'. Rather, it is what should be a completely unsurprising case of people who are users of the same discourse, members of the same broad social milieu, and who procede from similar assumptions, reaching similar conclusions about the goal of education and the appropriate means of reaching that goal.[40]

[40] This characterisation of the relationship between Neoplatonism and early Christian thought has been expressed similarly by Mark Edwards on the relationship between Origen's thought and Platonism in general, see Mark Edwards, *Origen Against Plato* (Aldershot, and Burlington [VT], 2002). Social interaction between pagans and Christians in the schools, including pagans studying with Christian teachers and vice versa, also confirms the status of this curriculum as common coin. See Markus Vinzent, ‚Oxbridge' in der ausgehenden Spätantike: *Zeitschrift für Antike und Christentum* 4 (2000) 49-82, 69ff.

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V. Theologica, Philosophica, Ethica

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'Dieu jaloux': Embarras et controverses autour d'un nom divin dans la littérature patristique

Marie-Odile Boulnois, Paris

Un Dieu transcendant peut-il éprouver des sentiments et qui plus est un sentiment considéré comme aussi négatif que la jalousie? Les Pères des premiers siècles, qui avaient baigné dans la culture philosophique grecque, ne devaient-ils pas approuver des formules platoniciennes comme celle du *Timée* 29a déclarant à propos du démiurge: 'Il était bon, et en ce qui est bon, nulle envie ne naît jamais à nul sujet'? Leur était-il possible de ne pas souscrire à ce que déclarait Saloustios, un proche de l'empereur Julien: 'Communes sont les notions sur lesquelles tous les hommes, si on les interroge correctement, tomberont d'accord; par exemple que tout Dieu est bon, qu'il est impassible, qu'il est immuable'?[1] Et pourtant, dans la Bible, Dieu se présente lui-même en déclarant: 'Moi je suis le Seigneur, ton Dieu, Dieu jaloux (θεὸς ζηλωτής) qui reporte les péchés des pères sur les enfants jusqu'à la troisième et la quatrième génération pour ceux qui me haïssent.' (*Ex.* 20: 5) Cette dénomination 'Dieu jaloux' est ici d'autant plus remarquable que non seulement c'est Dieu qui s'applique lui-même ce nom, mais qu'il s'agit d'un texte fondateur, le Décalogue, puisque cette déclaration appartient au deuxième commandement qui interdit toute forme d'idolâtrie.[2] Ce qualificatif ζηλωτής est appliqué à Dieu à cinq autres reprises dans la Septante (*Ex.* 34:14; *Deut.* 4:24; 5:9; 6:15; *Na.* 1:2). D'après les références de *Biblia Patristica*, une première recherche sur ces cinq occurrences montre que ce terme a pour le moins suscité la perplexité des auteurs chrétiens des premiers siècles, puisque aucun d'eux ne le commente.[3] À la récurrence de ce terme dans la Septante, répond donc un quasi silence de la part des Pères. J'ai donc cherché à savoir si la même réticence s'étend au texte du Décalogue. Je m'en tiendrai ici au nom 'Dieu jaloux' en laissant de côté la dernière partie du verset, souvent citée à part, qui pose d'autres questions sur la rétribution de la faute[4].

[1] Saloustios, *Des dieux et du monde* I 2, G. Rochefort (Paris, 1960), 4.

[2] Origène, *Homélie sur l'Exode* VIII 2 (SC 321, 244-5) réfute ceux qui pensent qu'*Ex.* 20:1-5 forment un seul commandement.

[3] En dehors des auteurs recensés par *Biblia Patristica*, on peut signaler les commentaires de Théodoret (PG 81, 1789) et Cyrille d'Alexandrie (*In XII prophetas*, Pusey, 2, p. 4) sur *Nahum* 1:2.

[4] Marie-Odile Boulnois, Le Décalogue contient-il une formule scandaleuse? 'Dieu qui reporte les fautes des pères sur les enfants' (Ex 20, 5): *Le décalogue au miroir des Pères*, R. Gounelle; J.M. Prieur (Strasbourg, 2008), 243-59.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 297-313.
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J'ai tenté de mener une recherche, aussi exhaustive que possible, sur les auteurs chrétiens des cinq premiers siècles. Le résultat confirme en partie la première constatation: même quand ces auteurs citent *Ex.* 20:5, ils ne s'arrêtent guère sur l'adjectif 'jaloux'. Il est à cet égard symptomatique qu'un juif hellénisé comme Philon d'Alexandrie observe un silence total sur ce nom, y compris dans son traité *Sur le Décalogue*.[5] Parmi les œuvres antérieures au troisième siècle, je ne l'ai rencontré que dans un texte apocryphe, les *Actes de Paul*. Il s'agit d'un passage où Paul, sommé de rendre compte de son enseignement, présente Dieu sous différents noms: 'Le Dieu vivant, le Dieu des châtiments, le Dieu jaloux, le Dieu qui se suffit à lui-même, mais qui désire le salut des hommes, m'a envoyé afin que je les arrache à la corruption, à l'impureté, à tout désir et à la mort, afin qu'ils ne pèchent plus.'[6] Si on considère le contexte scripturaire des deux noms 'Dieu vivant' (*Ac.* 14:15) et 'Dieu des châtiments' (*Ps.* 93:1), on s'aperçoit que l'un et l'autre sont liés à la condamnation du culte idolâtrique, tout comme l'expression 'Dieu jaloux'. Cependant ce passage des *Actes de Paul* ne développe aucune interprétation de ce nom, et l'on ne peut guère qu'en conclure que la jalousie et les châtiments sont vus comme des moyens de sauver l'homme de la perdition en le détournant de son impiété.

À côté de la rareté des occurrences anciennes de ce nom 'Dieu jaloux', on ne sera pas étonné de découvrir en revanche que cette formule constitue un sujet de controverses abondantes, que ce soit chez les chrétiens ou chez les païens. Et puisque c'est chronologiquement dans Marcion et les textes gnostiques que se trouvent les premières exégèses de ce nom divin, c'est par là que je commencerai, d'autant que parmi les Pères dits 'orthodoxes' qui se penchent sur ce nom problématique, une majorité le fait pour répondre soit à des argumentations marcionites, gnostiques, ou manichéennes soit à des objections païennes semblables. L'exégèse de la jalousie divine est donc pour une large part suscitée par des contextes polémiques.[7]

[5] Philon, *De Decalogo* 65-81. La dernière partie du verset sur le report des fautes n'est, elle-même, abordée que dans le *De Sobrietate* 48 où elle reçoit une interprétation allégorique, sans commentaire sur 'Dieu jaloux'. Plus généralement, Philon n'utilise jamais l'expression θεὸς ζηλωτής.

[6] *Actes de Paul et de Thècle* III 17, R.A. Lipsius; M. Bonnet, *Acta Apostolorum Apocrypha* (Darmstadt, 1959). L'apparat critique signale que tous les manuscrits ne sont pas unanimes sur la présence de ce nom divin (omis par deux manuscrits grecs sur les onze recensés, par la version syriaque, et remplacé par deux autres expressions dans deux versions latines). Ce nom 'Dieu jaloux' est absente de la traduction de W. Rordof in F. Bovon et P. Geoltrain (eds.), *Ecrits apocryphes chrétiens* (Paris, 1997), I 1134. Il est possible que W. Rordof ait prévu dans l'édition qu'il prépare de ce texte de ne pas retenir cette leçon.

[7] Sur le scandale de la violence divine, voir Giovanna Bondavalli; Daniele Gianotti, La 'violenza di Dio' nell'esegesi patristica fra II e III secolo: *PSV* 37 (1998) 215-29.

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I. Utilisations polémiques: marcionites, gnostiques et païennes

De fait, c'est pour montrer l'antinomie entre jalousie et bonté que Marcion utilise *Ex.* 20:5, du moins d'après les témoignages indirects d'Origène et de Tertullien. Dans son *Traité des Principes*, Origène rapporte que certains, qui sont très vraisemblablement des marcionites, s'appuyaient sur des passages vétéro-testamentaires qui parlent de la colère ou du repentir de Dieu en pensant y trouver matière à confondre la saine doctrine. Ces hérétiques attribuent des expressions comme 'Dieu jaloux' au Dieu démiurge qui est seulement juste, pour le distinguer du Dieu bon, plus parfait, annoncé par le Sauveur.[8] Or cette insistance sur la justice est, d'après Tertullien, le trait caractéristique de la doctrine marcionite sur le Dieu créateur.[9]

Même si la doctrine des textes gnostiques de Nag Hammadi est différente de celle de Marcion, *Ex.* 20:5 est aussi invoqué comme preuve d'une distinction à opérer entre le créateur et le véritable Père. Dans le *Témoignage véritable*, redigé entre 180 et 215, la citation d'*Ex.* 20:5 conclut un long réquisitoire contre le Dieu créateur, à partir du récit de la tentation de *Gen.* 3, qui conduit l'auteur à s'écrier: 'Il s'est révélé lui-même comme méchant et envieux, alors quelle sorte de Dieu est-ce là?'[10] De fait, ce Dieu est accusé de malveillance et d'envie pour avoir empêché Adam de manger de l'arbre de vie, méchanceté que n'ont pas su voir les Chrétiens de la grande Église, alors même que cette jalousie était professée explicitement par le Dieu de l'Ancien Testament, lorsqu'il déclare: 'Je suis le Dieu jaloux, je reporterai les péchés des pères sur les fils jusqu'à la troisième et quatrième génération'.[11] Face à un tel aveu, l'aveuglement de ceux qui n'ont pas reconnu son infériorité apparaît d'autant plus grand.

C'est aussi cet aveuglement que dénonce le *Deuxième traité du grand Seth*, afin de montrer que tout l'Ancien Testament est une fausse prophétie, une dérision. En effet, les hommes de l'Ancien Testament n'ont pas compris qui était le véritable Père et ont cru aux affirmations de l'Archonte qui prétend être le seul

[8] Origène, *Traité des Principes* IV 2.1, M. Harl; G. Dorival; A. Le Boulluec, Etudes Augustiniennes (Paris, 1976), 217-8: 'Quant aux hérétiques, lisant ce qui est écrit dans la Loi "un feu brûle dans ma colère" (*Jér.* 15:14) et "je suis un dieu jaloux, qui reporte les péchés des pères sur les fils jusqu'à la troisième et la quatrième génération" (...) (ils) n'ont pas osé, il est vrai, dire que ces Ecritures n'étaient pas de Dieu, mais ont pensé néanmoins qu'elles appartenaient à ce Dieu démiurge, auquel les juifs rendaient un culte, et furent de l'avis, suivant: il fallait croire que ce Dieu était seulement juste, et non pas bon, et que le sauveur était venu pour nous annoncer un Dieu plus parfait', et II 4.4.

[9] Ekkehart Mühlenberg, Marcion's jealous God, in: *Disciplina nostra: Essays in memory of Robert F. Evans* (Cambridge, Mass., 1979), 93-113, montre que le fait de caractériser le créateur par la justice et la loi, en lien avec l'*aemulatio*, est propre à Marcion et ne se trouve pas chez les autres gnostiques; il suggère aussi que le système théologique de Marcion reflète la tradition carnéadienne de critique de la justice et de la loi.

[10] *Témoignage véritable* (NH IX 3) 47-8 (Québec et Louvain, 1996), 113-5.

[11] *Ibid.*

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'Père et Seigneur'. Une telle usurpation est vivement dénoncée par le Sauveur qui déclare: 'Quelle dérision, en effet, que l'Archonte, quand il a dit: "Je suis Dieu et nul n'est plus grand que moi", "Moi seul suis le Père et le Seigneur et il n'y en a aucun en dehors de moi", "Je suis un Dieu jaloux qui reporte les péchés des pères sur les fils jusqu'à la troisième et la quatrième génération"'.[12] La revendication de cette jalousie par l'Archonte va de pair avec l'affirmation forte de son unicité (selon *Is.* 45:5-6). Ainsi sont dénoncées la vaine gloire dont il ose se prévaloir et la naïveté de ceux qui le croient unique. Semblablement, l'*Apocryphe de Jean* dénonce la jalousie de Yaldabaoth, le créateur, qui se surestime en déclarant: 'Je suis un Dieu jaloux et il n'y a pas d'autre dieu en dehors de moi'. La même combinaison de ces deux textes bibliques, formant désormais une unité, montre que la jalousie est étroitement liée à la négation des autres dieux, ce qui est assez conforme au texte de l'Exode puisque le second commandement interdit l'idolâtrie en même temps qu'il proclame ce nom 'Dieu jaloux'. Mais l'*Apocryphe de Jean* souligne précisément la contradiction entre ces deux affirmations, puisque sa jalousie est bien la preuve qu'il existe d'autres dieux, 'car s'il n'y en avait pas d'autre, de qui serait-il jaloux?'[13]

Par ces exemples, on voit qu'en dépit des caractères propres à chaque texte, *Ex.* 20:5 est toujours invoqué pour tourner en dérision le créateur qui prononce cette phrase en croyant être le seul Dieu et en avouant par là même sa méchanceté et son arrogante ignorance. Cette interprétation était connue d'Irénée qui en parle dans sa notice sur les Barbéliotes. Pour eux, le Protarchonte, une fois que sa Mère Sagesse s'est retirée, se croit seul et déclare: 'Je suis un Dieu jaloux et en dehors de moi il n'est pas de Dieu'.[14] Pourtant, Irénée ne reviendra à aucun moment sur cette citation d'*Ex.* 20:5 pour en contester l'exégèse et je n'ai trouvé aucun autre auteur qui réponde à ces textes gnostiques du corpus de Nag Hammadi, alors qu'on a conservé des réfutations de l'utilisation qu'en faisait Marcion.

Sans qu'il soit possible de déterminer les liens exacts entre ces arguments gnostiques et la polémique païenne, on constate une proximité entre le *Témoignage véritable* et l'argumentation que développe l'empereur Julien pour ridiculiser le Dieu des Hébreux dans son *Contre les Galiléens*.[15] En effet, l'un et

[12] *Deuxième traité du grand Seth* (NH VII 2) 64 (Québec, 1982), 59.

[13] *Apocryphe de Jean* 13, 5-13. Voir aussi l'*Evangile des Egyptiens en copte* (NH III) in Yvonne Janssens, *Evangiles gnostiques* (Louvain la Neuve, 1991), 267. Alastair H. B. Logan, The Jealousy of God: *Studia Biblica* I (1978) 197-203 rapporte une question posée par un philosophe à un Rabbi: y a-t-il un pouvoir dans l'idolâtrie capable de rendre Dieu jaloux d'elle? Ce débat atteste d'une discussion autour du sens de la jalousie divine: signifie-t-elle que d'autres dieux existent?

[14] Irénée, *Adv. Haer.* I 29.4.

[15] Voir Norbert Brox, Gnostische Argumente bei Julianus Apostata: *JAC* 10 (1967) 181-6 et Klaus Koschorke, *Die Polemik der Gnostiker gegen das kirchliche Christentum* (Leiden, 1978), 150-1. Giancarlo Rinaldi, Tracce di controversie tra pagani e cristiani nella letteratura patristica delle 'quaestiones et responsiones': *ASE* 6 (1989) 99-124 suggère que les polémistes païens ont pu trouver dans l'argumentaire gnostique des matériaux contre l'Écriture.

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l'autre utilisent conjointement *Gen.* 3 et *Ex.* 20:5. Sans entrer dans le détail des objections de Julien,[16] un certain nombre de points communs avec les thèses gnostiques apparaissent: les accusations d'envie et d'ignorance contre le créateur, la présentation du serpent comme celui par qui arrive la connaissance et donc le salut de l'homme, et la citation d'*Ex.* 20:5. Malgré la transformation que Julien fait subir à ces motifs, la ressemblance est frappante et semble montrer que tous deux ont puisé à un fonds commun de *topoi* polémiques antibibliques. Chez Julien, le but est de prouver l'absurdité de la représentation biblique de Dieu et son infériorité par rapport à la conception grecque. Ainsi raille-t-il: 'Alors quoi! un homme qui est jaloux et malveillant te paraît mériter un blâme, mais si c'est Dieu qui est dit jaloux, tu considères cela comme divin!'[17] Le Dieu biblique est donc un Dieu bien peu transcendant, puisque lui manquent deux attributs essentiels: l'impassibilité et la bonté. Présenter une divinité sujette à la jalousie et à la colère est non seulement blasphématoire, mais a des conséquences éthiques, puisque la philosophie ordonne d'imiter les dieux autant que possible.[18] Pour Julien, l'épisode de *Nombres* 25, dans lequel Phinees tue de ses mains un couple qui s'était initié à Beelphégor, faisant ainsi cesser l'emportement de Dieu, prouve l'absurdité de la foi des Hébreux. En effet, Moïse fait dire à Dieu: 'Phinees a fait cesser mon emportement et l'a détourné des fils d'Israël en étant jaloux de ma jalousie parmi eux et je n'ai pas exterminé jusqu'au dernier les fils d'Israël dans ma jalousie.' (*Nb.* 25:11) Plus encore que les textes de la *Genèse* ou de l'*Exode*, cette citation des *Nombres* montre la connaissance approfondie que Julien avait de la Bible, car il ne s'agit pas là d'un lieu commun de la polémique païenne. D'une manière plus générale, les exégètes chrétiens de ce passage ne commentent guère que le rôle positif de la colère (Origène), l'utilité des passions (Grégoire de Nysse) ou encore l'infériorité du zèle de Phinees, qui apaise la colère de Dieu en tuant, par rapport au zèle de Jésus qui, lui, ne tue pas (Cyrille de Jérusalem), mais sans jamais traiter du motif de la jalousie divine. De cet épisode, Julien tire plusieurs critiques: non seulement il témoigne d'attitudes incompatibles avec le statut divin, comme la colère ou l'injustice, mais il incite aussi l'homme à imiter cette violence, en prenant sur lui la jalousie divine. Cela démontre l'infériorité de la doctrine mosaïque sur celle de Platon pour qui Dieu est 'le Bien en lui-même'.[19] Or précisément,

[16] M.-O. Boulnois, Dieu peut-il être envieux ou jaloux? Un débat sur les attributs divins entre l'empereur Julien et Cyrille d'Alexandrie, in: *Culture classique et christianisme. Mélanges offerts à Jean Bouffartigue*, Textes réunis par D. Auger et E. Wolff, Picard (Paris, 2008), 13-25.

[17] Julien, *Contre les Galiléens, frg.* 30, Emmanuela Masaracchia, *Giuliano Imperatore – Contra Galilaeos* (Rome, 1990), 126. Il est cité par Cyrille d'Alexandrie, *Contre Julien* V (PG 76, 737C).

[18] Platon, *Théétète* 176b. Julien, lui aussi, fait dire à Marc-Aurèle que le but d'une vie noble est 'l'imitation des dieux' (*Les Césars*, 34, 333C).

[19] Julien, *Contre les Galiléens*, 32 (Masaracchia 128). Il ne s'agit pas d'une citation expresse de Julien mais d'un argument résumé cité par Cyrille d'Alexandrie, *CJ* V (PG 76, 745A-B).

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cette bonté est contradictoire avec le monothéisme exclusif que prétend imposer le Dieu biblique. De surcroît, si Dieu est jaloux que d'autres dieux soient adorés, c'est bien la preuve qu'il en existe d'autres. Or, puisqu'il serait impie de supposer que Dieu n'a pas le pouvoir d'empêcher cet état de fait, c'est donc qu'il le veut bien. L'idée que l'adoration rendue à d'autres divinités ne peut chagriner Dieu se trouve déjà invoquée par des prédécesseurs de Julien pour dénoncer la prétention au monothéisme. Celse montre ainsi qu'il est 'absurde d'éviter de rendre un culte à plusieurs dieux, car Dieu ne peut subir de tort ni de chagrin, d'autant que l'honneur rendu à des dieux qui appartiennent au grand Dieu ne peut le chagriner puisqu'ils sont tous à lui.'[20] Quant à l'adversaire que réfute Macarios de Magnésie dans le *Monogénès*, il soutient lui aussi que Dieu ne peut s'irriter que d'autres soient appelés dieux, car ce serait faire preuve d'une plus grande mesquinerie que celle des hommes, qui acceptent que leurs sujets portent le même nom qu'eux.[21] À leur suite, Julien défend l'idée que Dieu n'a pas voulu empêcher que les autres dieux soient adorés. Pour lui, *Ex.* 20:5 est donc la preuve que le Dieu des Hébreux n'est pas le Dieu suprême, n'étant ni impassible ni bon, mais qu'il est l'un des dieux ethnarques, au même titre qu'Arès ou Athéna, chacun étant chargé d'une nation qu'il administre selon ses traits de caractère propres. Sans faire d'assimilation abusive, on peut comparer ce type de conclusion à celle que Marcion tire du même texte, en distinguant un Dieu juste d'un Dieu bon.

II. Exégèse chrétienne du nom 'Dieu jaloux': de la réticence à la revendication

Un tel faisceau convergent d'accusations explique combien il était à la fois difficile et fondamental pour les exégètes chrétiens de proposer une défense de ce nom divin.

1) *Un nom mensonger*

Une première attitude consiste à traiter ce texte au sein de l'ensemble plus vaste des anthropomorphismes bibliques; dans cette perspective, l'accent est mis sur l'inadéquation de ces expressions pour parler convenablement de Dieu. La distance prise peut aller jusqu'à considérer ces passages comme mensongers, ainsi qu'on le lit dans les *Homélies pseudo-clémentines*. Voulant réfuter par avance les arguments de son adversaire Simon le Mage, Pierre explique au jeune Clément que les textes blasphématoires que Simon va invoquer contre Dieu sont

[20] Origène, *Contre Celse* VIII 2 (SC 150, 183) et VIII 21 (221): Si Dieu ignore l'envie, il ne peut voir d'un mauvais œil que ceux qui lui sont dévoués prennent part aux fêtes publiques.

[21] Macarios de Magnésie, *Le Monogénès* IV 23.3, Richard Goulet (Paris, 2003), 315.

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en fait de fausses péricopes bibliques, ayant pour but de 'dénoncer les audacieux qui écoutent avec plaisir ce qui est écrit contre Dieu'[22] et de mettre à l'épreuve la foi des vrais croyants. Ainsi, lorsqu'il est dit que Dieu est jaloux, qu'il se repent ou qu'il endurcit les cœurs, il s'agit de textes mensongers. Les *Homélies pseudo-clémentines* résolvent donc le problème des anthropomorphismes en révoquant comme diaboliques les passages bibliques qui conduisent le lecteur à incriminer le créateur et à professer un dualisme comme le faisaient les gnostiques.

Sans aller jusqu'à cette thèse extrême et au rejet de ces péricopes, Eusèbe de Césarée les présente lui aussi comme mensongères, mais dans une tout autre optique. Dans un contexte apologétique, il veut montrer l'accord entre Platon et la Bible, en illustrant la théorie platonicienne du mensonge utile par l'exemple des anthropomorphismes bibliques.[23] Pour Eusèbe, ces assertions n'ont d'autre fonction que d'être 'un remède au service de ceux qui ont besoin d'un tel procédé'.[24] Cette position est, dans ses grandes lignes, celle que l'on retrouve chez la majorité des exégètes qui soulignent à la fois l'utilité des anthropomorphismes pour parler de Dieu et leur inadéquation, voire leur fausseté.

2) *Un nom revendiqué comme une preuve de justice*

À l'inverse de cette prudence, voire réticence extrême, la deuxième attitude est celle de Tertullien qui, non content de réfuter l'interprétation de Marcion, va jusqu'à reprendre à son compte cette formule *deus zelotes*[25] dans ses derniers ouvrages marqués par le rigorisme moral. Dans le *Voile des vierges*, la jalousie divine est vue comme le signe que Dieu ne laisse aucune faute voilée et impunie, et dans son traité sur *La pudicité,* il soutient que Dieu, malgré sa bonté, sait aussi être juste.[26] Ce refus d'opposer justice et bonté est au principe de sa réfutation de Marcion, qui faisait du nom 'Dieu jaloux' un de ses arguments principaux pour stigmatiser la justice punitive du créateur et l'opposer à la bonté d'un autre Dieu. Or, de manière remarquable et originale, Tertullien, loin d'esquiver ce nom divin, le reprend comme un leitmotiv dans son *Contre Marcion.* Alors que la tradition chrétienne était remarquablement discrète sur cette question, Tertullien n'hésite pas à aller à contre-courant de cette tradition, en donnant une place centrale à cette notion qui fait l'objet de son débat avec Marcion. Il en fait d'abord un usage sarcastique destiné à établir les contradictions de son

[22] *Homélies pseudo-clémentines* II 43.2, *Ecrits apocryphes chrétiens* II, Bibliothèque de la Pléiade (Paris, 2005). Même si *Ex.* 20:5 n'est pas explicitement mentionné, l'utilisation du verbe ζηλόω soulève la question de l'attribution de la jalousie à Dieu.

[23] Eusèbe de Césarée, *Praep. Ev.* XII 31.2 (SC 307, 137) cite Platon, *Lois* II, 663d 6-e 4.

[24] *Praep. Ev.* XII 31 (SC 307, 137).

[25] René Braun, *Deus christianorum: Recherches sur le vocabulaire doctrinal de Tertullien* (Paris, 1977), 118-9 montre que Tertullien atteste une double tradition: celle de l'emprunt de *zelotes* (14 emplois) et celle de la transposition latine *aemulator* (2 emplois).

[26] Tertullien, *Le voile des vierges* 14.5 (SC 424, 175); *La pudicité* 2.7 (SC 394, 155).

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adversaire. Si le Dieu bon doit recourir au feu du créateur pour punir les pécheurs, il se pourrait bien que le créateur, en 'Dieu jaloux', cherche à se venger de son rival, le Dieu bon, et du même coup épargne les hommes qui ont manifesté leur rébellion envers ce Dieu bon.[27] La jalousie du créateur le conduirait ainsi à refuser de châtier les hommes pour se venger du Dieu bon, manifestant ainsi paradoxalement une plus grande mansuétude que lui. 'Quelle absurdité ce sera que (le créateur) punisse le pécheur de son rival plutôt que de le choyer au contraire, lui qui est le "Dieu jaloux"'.[28] Puisque Marcion tirait de ce nom la preuve d'une opposition entre le créateur et le Christ, Tertullien reprend également l'expression 'Dieu jaloux' dans un deuxième type d'argumentation pour prouver que loin de s'opposer, le Christ et le 'Dieu jaloux' manifestent leur accord total.[29] Mais Tertullien ne se limite pas à la rétorsion d'arguments, il n'hésite pas à revendiquer le statut positif de cette jalousie divine et à assumer ce nom 'Dieu jaloux' pour son Dieu.[30] En réalité, la bonté est inséparable d'une activité de jugement[31] qui suppose à son tour la jalousie, comprise comme le souci que Dieu prend du salut de l'homme. Cette idée que Dieu prend soin (*curare*) de sa créature est centrale chez Tertullien pour expliquer le sens de la jalousie. Ce soin est illustré tantôt par une métaphore agricole: Dieu prend soin de la maturation de ses plants par une volonté jalouse,[32] tantôt par la célèbre métaphore médicale abondamment utilisée par les Pères[33] et les philosophes de tradition platonicienne.[34] Comme un médecin, Dieu doit parfois couper et amputer pour le bien du malade. Néanmoins, Tertullien y recourt de manière originale en faisant de la jalousie et de la colère, autrement dit des mouvements et sentiments au moyen desquels Dieu juge, les instruments de chirurgie que le malade n'a pas à accuser sous prétexte qu'ils font mal.

Que dirais-tu si l'on affirmait la nécessité du médecin tout en accusant ses instruments parce qu'ils coupent, brûlent, amputent, étreignent, alors que l'existence du médecin

[27] Tertullien, *Contre Marcion* I 28.1 (SC 365, 237). Pour d'autres sarcasmes fondés sur *deus zelotes*, voir III 23.7 (SC 399, 201).

[28] *C. Marc.* V 7.13 (SC 483, 177).

[29] *C. Marc.* IV 21.10 (SC 456, 271-273). En II 18.1 Tertullien fait allusion aux critiques de Marcion sur la loi du talion. Pour un autre parallélisme entre le Christ et le Dieu jaloux, voir IV 27.8 (SC 456, 353). Origène, *Traité des Principes* II 5.2 (Etudes Augustiniennes, 103) propose le même type de réponse.

[30] *C. Marc.* II 29.4 (SC 368, 175).

[31] *C. Marc.* II 16.1 (SC 368, 101): 'La sévérité aussi est bonne parce que juste, si le juge est bon, c'est-à-dire juste.'

[32] *C. Marc.* II 29.4 (175).

[33] Clément d'Alexandrie, *Stromates* I 27.171, 1-2 (SC 30, 169) utilise la métaphore du traitement médical pour établir que la loi, loin d'être un signe de jalousie ou de malveillance, est une preuve de bonté, puisque c'est pour le bien des parties saines que le médecin peut être amené à amputer des parties malades. Origène, *Traité des Principes* II 5.3 (Etudes Augustiniennes, 105).

[34] Platon, *Gorgias* 525b-c; Plutarque, *De sera numinis vindicta* 549-550; Porphyre, *A Nemertius* 279 (A. Smith, Teubner 1993, 315-316) in Cyrille d'Alexandrie, *CJ* V (PG 76, 753D-56B).

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serait impossible sans l'outillage de son art? (...) Il en va de même lorsque, tout en admettant, certes, que Dieu est juge, tu détruis les mouvements et les sentiments au moyen desquels il juge. Sur Dieu, notre instruction vient des prophètes et du Christ et non des philosophes ni d'Épicure![35]

Si Dieu est bon, il est jalousement concerné par le souci d'écarter l'homme du mal. La jalousie est ainsi justifiée comme un instrument thérapeutique nécessaire au bien de l'homme, au point que son absence reviendrait à la conception épicurienne de Dieu. De fait, pour Tertullien, la doctrine de Marcion puise ses racines dans celle d'Épicure[36] pour qui la divinité est caractérisée par l'absence de souci. Mais une telle inaction est incompatible avec la bonté qui est inséparable de la sévérité. Il reste que ces sentiments ne doivent pas être compris de manière anthropomorphique. Ainsi, ce n'est pas parce que l'on utilise les mêmes mots pour désigner des parties du corps ou des sentiments à propos de Dieu et de l'homme que tous deux auront une substance identique. Si une passion corrompt l'homme, le même mouvement en Dieu n'aura pas le même statut, puisqu'il est incorruptible. 'Il se mettra en colère, mais sans trouble.'[37] Dieu éprouve des sentiments, mais il ne subit pas de passion.

3) *La jalousie comme preuve d'amour*

Après avoir vu comment le nom 'Dieu jaloux' pouvait être tantôt mis à distance tantôt revendiqué, mais sans que les textes étudiés considèrent le contexte d'*Ex.* 20:5, c'est-à-dire le rejet de l'idolâtrie, abordons les auteurs qui en ont proposé une exégèse contextuelle. On la rencontre soit chez des auteurs répondant à des objections, Cyrille d'Alexandrie face aux critiques de l'empereur Julien ou Augustin face à celles du manichéen Adimante, soit chez des auteurs commentant spécifiquement ce texte: Origène et Théodoret de Cyr; enfin quelques rares développements d'Origène et Jean Chrysostome abordent spontanément l'explication de la jalousie divine.

– Origène

Nous commencerons par Origène chez qui sont élaborées les thématiques majeures reprises par ses successeurs. Tout d'abord, avec une visée polémique

[35] *C. Marc.* II 16.1-2 (SC 368, 101).

[36] *C. Marc.* I 25.3 (SC 365, 223). Voir John G. Gager, Marcion and philosophy: *VigChr* 26 (1972) 53-9: si Tertullien accuse Marcion d'être épicurien, ce n'est pas seulement dans l'intention polémique habituelle d'assimiler un hérétique à un philosophe, car dans le *C. Marc.* II 5.1-2 (SC 368, 43), Tertullien rapporte un argument marcionite que l'on retrouve chez Lactance attribué à Épicure. R. Braun (SC 368, 42) souligne cependant que Marcion a au moins élargi l'argument d'Épicure. Par ailleurs Gager n'évoque pas notre passage dans lequel Tertullien reproche à Marcion d'avoir puisé chez Épicure sa conception d'un Dieu qui, sans souci des hommes, n'a pas non plus à exercer sa justice.

[37] *C. Marc.* II 16.7 (SC 368, 107).

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anti-gnostique, Origène insiste, comme Tertullien, sur l'identité entre le Christ et le Dieu de l'Ancien Testament, lorsqu'il explique l'épisode des marchands chassés du Temple. L'évangéliste lui-même souligne que le Christ accomplit dans ce geste le *Ps.* 68:22: 'Le souci jaloux pour ta maison me dévorera'. Or selon Origène, cette attitude se justifie par le fait que le Christ est 'le Fils du Dieu jaloux'.[38] Ainsi, la jalousie, qu'il s'agisse de l'Ancien ou du Nouveau Testament, apparaît comme un caractère propre de Dieu, même si, comme Origène le précise, il s'agit d'une métaphore empruntée aux réalités humaines pour signifier que 'Dieu veut que rien d'étranger ne vienne se mêler à l'âme des hommes'. On voit poindre, ici, un thème qui revient ailleurs comme un leitmotiv: la jalousie divine est profondément liée au rejet de l'idolâtrie qui est la pire souillure possible.[39] Dans l'*Homélie sur le Psaume* 36 et l'*Exhortation au martyre*, *Ex.* 20:5 est ainsi rapproché de *Deut.* 32:21: 'Eux-mêmes m'ont amené à la jalousie par ce qui n'est pas Dieu et m'ont exaspéré par leurs idoles', texte qui conjoint aussi la jalousie et la condamnation du culte idolâtrique.[40] Or dans ces deux ouvrages, de même que dans son *Homélie sur l'Exode*, c'est immédiatement la métaphore conjugale qui est invoquée pour justifier *Ex.* 20:5.[41]

> On dit d'ordinaire un mari jaloux de son épouse quand il prend soin (*curat*) de sa pureté de manière très attentive et très vigilante, et qu'il ne souffre pas que soit souillée la chasteté de son épouse. D'où logiquement, celui qui pèche contre Dieu, que l'on dit 'jaloux', l'incite à la jalousie et l'irrite.[42]

La jalousie est donc suscitée en Dieu par la souillure de l'homme qui pèche, mais la comparaison permet de comprendre qu'elle provient du souci et de l'attention à l'être aimé.[43] Il est clair qu'une telle expression est à entendre de Dieu en un sens figuré et qu'il s'agit d'un emploi abusif. Pour éviter qu'on n'applique trop vite à Dieu des passions, Origène suggère même que le mari peut feindre la jalousie. Un époux qui veut inciter son épouse à la vie chaste et éviter à tout prix qu'elle ne se jette dans les bras d'un autre va feindre la jalousie et utiliser cette feinte comme un remède. De la même manière, Dieu déclare

[38] Origène, *Commentaire sur Jean* X 221 (SC 157, 515). Jérôme, *Lettre à Eustochius* XXII (J. Labourt, I 135) utilise lui aussi, de manière fugitive, l'expression *deus zelotes* en lien avec l'épisode des marchands du Temple.

[39] Origène, *Exhortation au martyre* 10 (GCS 2 Koetschau, 10): 'Quelle souillure peux-tu concevoir de pire pour une âme que de proclamer de quelque manière que ce soit un autre dieu et de ne pas confesser celui qui est véritablement le seul et unique Seigneur?'

[40] Origène, *Homélies sur les psaumes* 36.1 (SC 411, 57) et *Exhortation au martyre* 9 (GCS).

[41] La question de savoir si le sens originel de ζηλωτής doit être compris comme la jalousie maritale est discutée par les biblistes: Bernard Renaud, *Je suis un Dieu jaloux: Evolution sémantique et signification théologique du quin ' ah*, lectio divina 36 (Paris, 1963). On constate cependant que c'est ainsi que l'ont très largement compris les Pères.

[42] *Homélies sur les psaumes* 36.1 (SC 411, 57).

[43] *Commentaire sur Matthieu* (latin), series 68, (GCS 38 Klostermann 1933, 160): à propos de la parabole des talents (*Mt* 25, 24-27), on ne peut reprocher à Dieu d'être dur sous prétexte qu'il se soucie des péchés des hommes, car ce souci jaloux est précisément la preuve de sa bonté.

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à l'âme qui est son épouse qu'il est un Dieu jaloux pour la détourner de tout adultère avec les démons.[44] Deux points sont remarquables dans ce passage de l'*Exhortation au martyre*: parler de feinte du mari permet de préparer le deuxième terme de la comparaison dans la mesure où l'époux est impassible. D'autre part, la jalousie est présentée comme un remède, ce qui rapproche sur ce point Origène de Tertullien. L'alexandrin poursuit en effet en précisant que ce n'est pas pour lui-même que l'époux détourne son épouse de toute flétrissure, mais dans son intérêt à elle, pour la guérir, indique-t-il encore en filant la métaphore médicale. Dans son *Homélie sur l'Exode*, l'affirmation de la jalousie divine est même d'emblée présentée comme la preuve de sa bonté.

Vois la bonté de Dieu: pour nous instruire et nous rendre parfaits, il ne refuse pas la faiblesse des passions humaines. Qui, en effet, à entendre parler d'un 'Dieu jaloux', ne s'étonnerait aussitôt et ne croirait à un vice de l'humaine faiblesse? Mais c'est pour nous que Dieu fait et souffre tout et, pour que nous puissions être instruits, il parle de passions qui nous sont connues et familières[45].

Origène dépasse ici l'habituelle mise en garde contre l'inadéquation des anthropomorphismes: la jalousie prouve que l'amour divin va jusqu'à ne pas refuser la faiblesse des passions humaines.[46] Certes, le contexte est pédagogique puisque l'assomption de cette passion a pour but de nous instruire; néanmoins on ne peut pas ne pas le rapprocher de la sixième *Homélie sur Ezéchiel*:

Le Père lui-même, Dieu de l'univers, 'plein d'indulgence, de miséricorde' (*Ps.* 10:8) et de pitié, n'est-il pas vrai qu'il souffre en quelque manière? Ou bien ignores-tu que, lorsqu'il s'occupe des affaires humaines, il éprouve une passion humaine? (...) Le Père lui-même n'est pas impassible. Si on le prie, il a pitié, il compatit, il éprouve une passion de charité, et il se met dans une condition incompatible avec la grandeur de sa nature et pour nous prend sur lui les passions humaines.[47]

Même si ce texte va plus loin que l'*Homélie sur l'Exode*, tous deux se rejoignent pour dire que c'est pour nous que Dieu le Père assume les passions humaines.

Dans le cas de la jalousie, de nombreux textes bibliques permettaient à Origène de fonder scripturairement la métaphore conjugale.[48] Deux passages permettent de prouver *a contrario* l'idée que la jalousie est un bienfait. *Ez.* 16:42: 'Ma jalousie s'écartera de toi, je ne m'irriterai plus contre toi' et *Os.* 4:14: 'C'est pourquoi je ne visiterai pas vos filles quand elles se prostitueront, ni vos brus

[44] *Exhortation au martyre* 9 (GCS 2, 9-10)

[45] *Homélie sur l'Exode* VIII 5 (SC 321, 261).

[46] Voir aussi Clément d'Alexandrie, *Pédagogue* I 8.74.4 (SC 70, 243): 'Et même l'accès de colère de Dieu – s'il faut appeler vraiment colère les reproches qu'il nous adresse – est un signe de sa bonté pour l'homme; c'est Dieu qui condescend à prendre les sentiments humains, à cause de l'homme pour qui aussi le Logos de Dieu s'est fait homme.'

[47] Origène, *Homélie sur Ezéchiel* VI 6 (SC 352, 231).

[48] L'*Homélie sur l'Exode* VIII, 5 cite 2*Cor.* 11:2; *Matth.* 22:2; *Is.* 50:1; *Jér.* 3:1; *Jér.* 3:6-7; *Ez.* 16:42; *Os.* 4:14.

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quand elles commettront l'adultère.' En effet, mieux vaut être traité comme une femme légitime dont l'époux se soucie plutôt que d'être considéré comme une courtisane envers qui on ne s'irrite pas si elle a d'autres amants. La tendresse de Dieu se manifeste donc quand il s'indigne et s'irrite, autrement dit, quand il considère qu'il existe encore un espoir de salut, car 'il flagelle tout fils qu'il accueille' (*Hébr.* 12:6); au contraire, l'homme peut craindre le pire quand la jalousie s'écarte de lui et qu'il n'est plus admonesté pour ses péchés. 'Quand nous dépassons la mesure dans le péché, "Dieu jaloux" détourne de nous sa jalousie, comme il l'a dit plus haut: "Ma jalousie s'écartera de toi, je ne m'irriterai plus contre toi" (*Ez.* 16:42)'.[49] Non seulement la jalousie est une preuve de bonté, mais l'absence de jalousie serait le signe bien plus terrible d'un abandon.

– Jean Chrysostome et Théodoret de Cyr

Les différents éléments de cette exégèse origénienne se retrouvent chez deux antiochiens, Jean Chrysostome et Théodoret de Cyr. Tous deux soulignent que l'expression 'Dieu jaloux' est empruntée à la terminologie des passions humaines, avec un but pédagogique, afin de manifester l'intensité de l'amour de Dieu pour l'homme. Chez Théodoret, ce commentaire se lit dans ses *Questions sur l'Exode*: Dieu utilise des mots humains qui doivent être compris à la lumière de l'amour conjugal et sa jalousie est le signe de sa tendresse, puisque l'amour implique la jalousie.

Voilà pourquoi il se nomme lui-même 'Dieu jaloux' (...) En effet, de même qu'un mari qui a une femme légère l'avertit en ces termes: 'Je suis jaloux, je ne supporte pas de te voir t'entretenir avec un autre homme', de même Dieu le Maître voulant détourner (les hommes) de la superstition, s'est appelé non seulement 'jaloux', mais 'feu dévorant' (*Deut.* 4:24). Une telle jalousie est signe de tendresse (φιλοστοργίας).[50]

Comme Origène, il invoque *Ez.* 16:42 et *Os.* 4:14 pour expliquer que subir la jalousie vaut encore mieux que d'être rejeté par Dieu. Parce qu'il commente l'*Exode*, Théodoret interprète cette jalousie dans son contexte, comme un moyen pour Dieu de détourner l'homme de l'idolâtrie.

Au contraire, Jean Chrysostome, qui recourt spontanément à *Ex.* 20:5 indépendamment d'une contrainte extérieure, n'associe pas la jalousie à la lutte contre l'idolâtrie. Dans son *Homélie sur l'épître aux Romains*, il cite cette déclaration divine pour prouver que Dieu punit parce qu'il aime et non par vengeance. 'Voilà pourquoi Dieu ne refuse pas de s'abaisser à des expressions épaisses, de s'exprimer en termes de passions humaines et de se donner le nom de jaloux, il dit en effet "Je suis un Dieu jaloux", pour que tu apprennes

[49] *Homélie sur l'Exode* VIII 5 (SC 321, 267).

[50] Théodoret, *Quaestiones In Exodum* 39; F. Marcos, N. Saenz-Badillos (Madrid, 1979), 128, 15-22.

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l'intensité de son amour.'[51] Comme chez Origène sont convoquées à la fois la métaphore conjugale et *Ez.* 16:42 où Dieu menace d'une punition bien pire s'il retire sa jalousie. Dieu est même prêt à tout pour être aimé des hommes, comme en témoigne *Rom.* 8:32: 'Il n'a pas épargné son propre Fils'. C'est avec le même souci d'exalter l'amour divin qu'il recourt à *Ex.* 20:5 dans son traité sur la virginité pour souligner la solidarité intrinsèque entre jalousie et amour. Aussi terrible que soit cette parole que Moïse répète sans cesse dans l'Ancien Testament: 'Dieu est un Dieu jaloux', elle est encore plus douce que terrible.

Car il n'y aurait pas de jalousie s'il n'y avait pas sous-jacent un ardent et fervent amour, si bien qu'elle est une preuve de l'amour véhément et enflammé de Dieu. De fait, dans le cas de Dieu la jalousie n'est point désir sensuel (πόθος), mais c'est parce qu'il veut faire comprendre sa tendresse (φιλοστοργία) ineffable qu'il s'est souvent servi de cette expression abusive.[52]

La jalousie est ici présentée sous sa forme la plus positive, fortement ancrée dans la sphère de l'amour, et ce n'est que fugitivement qu'il est précisé que dans le cas de Dieu elle n'implique pas de désir. On perçoit là, mais de manière moins aiguë que chez Origène, la tension entre la nécessité de préserver l'impassibilité divine, et l'attribution à Dieu de sentiments qui s'apparentent à des passions humaines.

– Cyrille d'Alexandrie et Augustin

Un tel paradoxe est précisément celui qu'affrontent Cyrille d'Alexandrie et Augustin, dans leurs controverses respectives avec le païen Julien et le manichéen Adimante. Comme on l'a vu, c'est pour prouver l'infériorité du Dieu biblique, soumis aux passions, que l'empereur Julien recourt à *Ex.* 20:5, si bien que dans sa réfutation, Cyrille doit à la fois défendre l'impassibilité divine et justifier un deuxième attribut divin, la bonté, elle aussi mise en péril selon Julien par le nom 'Dieu jaloux'. La réfutation commence par un argument *ad hominem.* Comment, en effet, Julien peut-il se targuer de l'impassibilité de ses dieux, alors même que les auteurs grecs ne les présentent pas pour des modèles de douceur et de mansuétude? Il suffit pour s'en convaincre de citer les épithètes homériques des dieux[53] ou un extrait des *Troyennes* 65-71 d'Euripide que Cyrille compare à l'épisode de Phinees.[54] Dans cette tragédie, Athéna apparaît changer d'avis brusquement à l'égard des Troyens qu'elle veut rendre heureux

[51] Jean Chrysostome, *Homélie 23 sur l'épître aux Romains* (PG 60, 621, 33-6).

[52] Jean Chrysostome, *Comment observer la virginité* 6, traduction légèrement modifiée de J. Dumortier (Paris, 1955), 116-7. L'éditeur a choisi la leçon πόθος, mais certains manuscrits ont πάθος.

[53] Cyrille d'Alexandrie, CJ V (PG 76, 765C): Arès "homicide, fléau des mortels, tueur sanguinaire", Athéna, "mouche à chiens, toujours en train d'exciter les dieux à la querelle".

[54] Cette citation semble particulièrement originale dans la mesure où ce texte n'est jamais cité dans le reste de la littérature grecque d'après une recherche sur le TLG.

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pour se venger des Achéens qui ont fait violence à Cassandre. Cyrille tire de ce passage deux arguments: d'une part, Athéna, elle aussi, comme Dieu change d'avis brusquement; mais surtout, l'attitude de Phinees apparaît bien supérieure à celle des Grecs. En effet, si un Grec avait châtié celui qui avait fait violence à Cassandre, Athéna n'aurait pas eu à se déchaîner contre l'armée grecque. Le comportement de Phinees qui a puni le seul couple fautif, détournant ainsi la colère de Dieu, se trouve ainsi justifié par comparaison[55].

En dehors de cette réponse *ad hominem*, Cyrille est conduit, sur le terrain de son adversaire, à réaffirmer l'impassibilité divine en lien avec sa transcendance. Or c'est précisément en raison de cette transcendance que le langage humain se révèle déficient et contraint de recourir à des impropriétés. La mention de la jalousie est donc un exemple de catachrèse parmi d'autres. Néanmoins, loin de révoquer ces énoncés comme mensongers, Cyrille souligne qu'ils sont signifiants, malgré leur impropriété, et nous disent quelque chose de Dieu. Ainsi, parler du pied ou de l'œil de Dieu est une manière d'exprimer de façon oblique certaines des propriétés divines. Qu'en est-il de la jalousie? C'est en fait la conséquence nécessaire de la bonté divine, puisque ce qui caractérise un Dieu vraiment bon n'est pas l'indifférence, mais le souci de garantir le salut de l'homme. 'En quoi le créateur de toutes choses est-il entièrement bon s'il n'a pas le souci de ses créatures?'[56] Dieu, s'il est bon, ne peut rester sans rien faire devant le risque pour sa créature de se perdre dans le polythéisme, alors que son salut passe forcément par la reconnaissance de celui qui est le vrai Dieu[57]. La jalousie, que Cyrille compare à un 'rempart' interdisant le chemin de la perdition, est donc une façon d'exprimer la haine de Dieu pour le mal.[58] Cependant à la différence des autres auteurs, Cyrille n'emploie jamais la métaphore conjugale, mais d'autres exemples humains qui ont tous pour point commun d'illustrer que les responsables, qu'ils soient généraux, bergers, parents ou maîtres, ne peuvent négliger leur rôle de guide envers ceux sur lesquels ils ont chargés de veiller. En revanche, il recourt comme Tertullien à la comparaison médicale, en invoquant contre son adversaire le témoignage de l'un des siens, Porphyre dans son traité *A Nemertius*[59]. De même qu'on ne fait pas grief au médecin de cautériser ou d'amputer une partie du corps pour le bien de l'ensemble, de même il faut accorder à Dieu le droit de soigner comme il juge bon, en l'occurrence de protéger par la crainte ceux qui risqueraient de tomber dans l'apostasie. Néanmoins, par-delà un accord entre chrétiens et platoniciens sur

[55] Cyrille d'Alexandrie, CJ V, (PG 76, 768Asq).

[56] Cyrille d'Alexandrie, *CJ* V (PG 76, 748B).

[57] Voir aussi *In Ioannem* IV, 6 (Jn 7, 24) (Pusey 1, 618): après avoir cité *Ex.* 20:5 Cyrille déclare que la connaissance de Dieu est la racine de toute vertu. L'enjeu du rejet des idoles est non seulement gnoséologique, mais éthique. Si Dieu punit ceux qui s'écartent de la vérité ce n'est ni par envie ni par méchanceté, mais parce que c'est une question de vie éternelle.

[58] *CJ* V (PG 76, 741D).

[59] Porphyre, *A Nemertius* 279 cité en *CJ* V (PG 76, 753D-756B)

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les attributs divins de bonté et de providence, cette discussion sur la jalousie montre combien ils peuvent se séparer sur la question de savoir si la providence implique que Dieu puisse intervenir directement dans l'histoire humaine et même être affecté par elle, sans perdre son impassibilité. Or c'est précisément en raison de sa bonté que Dieu est, en quelque sorte, conduit à s'écarter de son impassibilité. Malgré le cadre apologétique de son œuvre, Cyrille ne se laisse pas enfermer par Julien dans la définition de Dieu comme impassible et, par-delà les réponses traditionnelles sur le rôle pédagogique de la punition,[60] il va jusqu'à avancer que Dieu n'est pas 'sans souffrir'. 'Dieu est donc jaloux, s'il faut employer un vocabulaire humain, au sens où il n'est pas sans souffrir (ἀναλγήτως), lorsqu'il voit certains de ceux qu'il a créés se perdre misérablement'.[61] Peu de Pères, hormis Origène, ont osé affirmer qu'il existe une souffrance en Dieu malgré son impassibilité. Le même adverbe ἀναλγήτως est repris au sein d'un raisonnement où Cyrille retourne à Julien la question de savoir si ses dieux se mettraient eux-mêmes en colère contre ceux qui refuseraient leur tutelle ou s'ils resteraient 'sans souffrir' devant ce comportement. Dans le cas où ils refuseraient de s'en affliger, Julien devrait les imiter et ne pas s'en prendre à ceux qui se convertissent au christianisme. Cyrille veut ainsi conduire son interlocuteur à avouer que si ses dieux se soucient d'éviter que des hommes passent à une autre religion, ils sont eux aussi jaloux.

Cyrille tente donc de maintenir que Dieu est au-delà de toute passion, puisqu'il dépasse tout ce qui est humain,[62] mais aussi de rendre raison de la lettre du texte biblique. Parler d'un 'Dieu jaloux' s'explique, du côté de l'homme, par le rôle de cette jalousie comme rempart pédagogique destiné à préserver son salut et, du côté de Dieu, comme la preuve qu'il n'est pas insensible et qu'en raison même de sa tendresse, il est paradoxalement capable de souffrir.

C'est aussi autour de la bonté divine que se joue l'affrontement entre Augustin et Adimante. Pour répondre à ce dernier qui opposait, comme Marcion, la rigueur des déclarations vétéro-testamentaires à la miséricorde du Nouveau, Augustin commence par citer des passages du Nouveau Testament (2*Cor.* 11:2 et *Jn.* 2:17) qui attribuent eux aussi à Dieu ce sentiment de jalousie. Il prouve ainsi qu'il n'existe aucune contradiction entre la jalousie et la bonté, mais une totale concordance entre les deux Testaments.[63] Mais le principal de son argumentation consiste à reprocher aux manichéens de n'avoir pas compris l'incapacité foncière du langage humain à parler proprement du Dieu ineffable. C'est donc faute de pouvoir rien dire qui soit digne de Dieu que l'Écriture recourt à des métaphores. De surcroît, cette condescendance divine qui s'abaisse jusqu'au

[60] *He.* 12:6 est cité en *CJ* V (PG 76, 748C comme dans l'*Homélie sur l'Exode* VIII, 5 d'Origène.

[61] *CJ* III (PG 76, 673A).

[62] *CJ* V (PG 76, 748B).

[63] Augustin, *Contre Adimante* VII 4 (BA 17, 249). Et *CA* XI 267 qui cite 2*Co.* 11:2 et *Jn.* 2:17.

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langage humain est aussi une anticipation de l'abaissement plus radical de la majesté divine dans un corps humain.[64]

Par quel mot sinon par 'jalousie de Dieu' pourrait-on mieux faire entendre que nous sommes appelés à l'union avec Dieu et qu'il ne veut pas que nous nous laissions corrompre par de honteuses amours, qu'il punit notre impudicité et qu'il aime notre chasteté? Ce n'est donc pas sans raison qu'on dit: sans jalousie, pas d'amour.[65]

Une fois encore la métaphore conjugale sert à illustrer le fait que la providence divine se soucie d'éviter à l'âme d'être impunément infidèle; comme Jean Chrysostome, Augustin n'hésite pas à souligner l'intrication mutuelle entre jalousie et amour.[66] L'enjeu est grand, puisque 'tout l'espoir de notre salut consiste dans la jalousie de Dieu'.[67] Il est donc capital de dénoncer l'intention cachée des manichéens qui, sous prétexte d'attaquer les Écritures au sujet d'une passion indigne de Dieu, revendiquent en réalité le droit à adorer des dieux étrangers et cherchent ainsi à se concilier la bienveillance des païens.[68] Cependant, aussi loin qu'aille Augustin dans cet éloge de la jalousie pour décrire l'amour divin, il lui fait subir une correction importante. 'La jalousie de Dieu n'est pas ce tourment du cœur dont le mari est torturé pour sa femme et la femme pour son mari, mais une justice parfaitement paisible et pure qui ne permet pas qu'une âme soit heureuse quand elle est corrompue et, si l'on peut dire, grosse de passions mauvaises.'[69] Augustin semble ici plus soucieux que Cyrille d'éviter toute idée de douleur ou de trouble. À condition de comprendre que ce terme signifie non un tourment du cœur, mais la pure volonté de préserver la chasteté de l'âme, nous pouvons parler de la jalousie de Dieu sans craindre d'y impliquer souillure ou tourment et 'nous pouvons assumer les conditions du langage humain pour aborder au silence divin.'[70]

C'est sur ce silence que je conclurai cette fresque qui montre combien le nom 'Dieu jaloux' a suscité controverses et embarras dans la première littérature chrétienne. Il a été jugé incompatible avec la bonté du vrai Dieu par Marcion et du Dieu suprême par les gnostiques qui en ont tiré une confirmation de l'infériorité du créateur se croyant à tort l'unique Dieu. Il a servi d'argument aux païens pour dénoncer l'absurdité du monothéisme et établir la supériorité de leur conception d'un Dieu suprême impassible sur le Dieu des Hébreux ravalé au rang de dieu ethnarque. Ainsi, c'est parce que Marcion, les gnostiques et les païens considéraient la jalousie comme antinomique avec les attributs

[64] *CA* XIII 2, 281.

[65] *CA* XIII 2, 283.

[66] *CA* XI (263). Voir aussi VII 4, 249: 'Car de même que c'est par un sentiment de jalousie que les maris veillent à la pudeur de leurs épouses, ainsi les Écritures ont-elles nommé jalousie divine la puissance de la loi par laquelle Dieu ne permet pas que l'âme fornique impunément.'

[67] *CA* XI (263).

[68] *CA* XI (261) et XIII 1 (279-81).

[69] *CA* XI (263) et XIII 2 (281).

[70] *CA* XI (265).

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divins de bonté et d'impassibilité qu'ils ont utilisé ce nom 'Dieu jaloux' pour réduire le Dieu biblique au rang d'une divinité inférieure, voire mythologique, car trop anthropomorphique. L'enjeu était donc grand pour les Pères, mais la difficulté de l'exégèse était non moins grande, ce qui les a conduit à adopter différentes attitudes allant de la révocation de ce terme comme mensonger à sa revendication par Tertullien comme une formulation adéquate de la justice divine. À partir d'Origène, puis chez Jean Chrysostome, Théodoret et Augustin, c'est à travers la métaphore conjugale que la jalousie est apparue comme la preuve de la providence divine soucieuse que l'homme ne se perde pas dans le culte idolâtrique.

Si tous s'accordent pour mettre en garde contre l'impropriété des anthropomorphismes, il reste que ce nom divin conduit à s'interroger sur la compatibilité entre la transcendance absolue d'un Dieu impassible et la providence d'un Dieu qui s'occupe des affaires humaines sans recourir à des intermédiaires auxquels on peut plus aisément attribuer la mutabilité et les passions. Tout en affirmant l'impassibilité divine d'une manière qui trahit souvent des influences philosophiques, les Pères qui ont commenté ce nom divin ont aussi eu à cœur de rendre compte du texte biblique et ainsi apporté des correctifs importants à la notion grecque d'*apatheia* divine. De fait, ce nom 'Dieu jaloux' ouvre un débat périlleux sur la question de savoir si l'on peut aller jusqu'à attribuer à Dieu une certaine souffrance, comme le font Origène et Cyrille d'Alexandrie ou si, comme le soutient Augustin, la jalousie divine ne peut impliquer aucun trouble.

Le concept de jalousie constitue donc la pierre de touche du sens donné aux attributs divins, que ce soit dans la philosophie païenne, chez les gnostiques ou chez les Pères grecs et latins.

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Christ the Revealer: Patristic Views of the Mediation of Christ in the Old Testament

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One of the stranger forms of patristic exegesis, at least to modern ears, is the identification of Christ with the literal or historical meaning of Old Testament narratives. Certainly patristic exegesis is christological, but usually it relies upon a figurative, typological, or allegorical sense of the narratives. However, when authors say that the Son appeared to and spoke with Abraham, Hagar, and Moses, even though the text nowhere provides an explicit christological reference, they make what seems to contemporary readers like an audacious hermeneutical leap. For these ancient exegetes, who generally were attentive to the smallest of textual details, such a leap is all the more striking, and even dangerous, for its supersessionist consequences, particularly in Justin's anti-Jewish interpretation in the *Dialogue with Trypho*.[1]

What motivated early Christians to make such an interpretation? While modern critics have seen these passages as evidence of naïve eisegesis, I suggest that early patristic authors interpreted these narratives creatively – that is, in genuinely new ways – for the purpose of overcoming discontinuities posed by competing monarchian christologies, such as those of Marcion.[2] In particular, the interpretations of Justin and Novatian attend to puzzling textual ambiguities, and they rely upon belief in Christ as a mediator of revelation to claim the continuous identity of God in both the history of Israel and in Christian belief.

The shape of literal christological exegesis

Early patristic authors, especially before the Council of Nicea, typically read the theophany narratives of Genesis and Exodus as manifestations of the Son. These narratives – including the burning bush, the three visitors to Abraham

[1] See, for example, objections raised by David Rokeah, *Justin Martyr and the Jews* (Leiden, 2002), 133-4.

[2] See also the study of second-century antignostic monarchian theology, particularly of Noetus of Smyrna, in Reinhard M. Hübner and Markus Vinzent, *Der Paradox Eine*, SVigChr 50 (Leiden, 1999).

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and Sarah at Mamre, God's descent to the tower of Babel, and others – are inherently difficult to interpret, since they contain ambiguities and contradictions. For example, in *Ex.* 33, can Moses speak with God face to face (33:11) or must he be shielded from God's face, lest he die (33:20)? In *Gen.* 18, does the Lord appear to Abraham and Sarah at Mamre, or is it three angels? The narratives do not resolve these questions, leaving the interpreter to do so.

Justin Martyr and Novatian exemplify this kind of literal christological interpretation, although certainly it was widespread in ante-Nicene exegesis. Both authors wrote in the midst of doctrinal controversies, and both contributed significantly to the development of ante-Nicene christology. Justin's second-century *Dialogue with Trypho* presents an argument against Jewish interpretation of the scriptures by asserting the Logos's pre-incarnate activity. The Roman presbyter and later counter bishop Novatian, writing *De Trinitate* in the mid-third century, interprets the Rule of Faith against Marcionite, Sabellian, Docetic, and Adoptionist views.[3] Thus, while the two works emerge in different contexts, they share an exegetical purpose of establishing a coherent, unified vision of the revelation of God to Israel and the revelation of God in Jesus.

First, the grounding of their interpretation emphasizes the Son's role as the mediator of revelation. For Novatian, the Son's proper activity of mediation is rooted in his incarnation and extends forward and backward through time. He writes that 'The Son ... is accustomed both to descend and to be seen, because he has descended'.[4] Therefore, he reasons, the Son's incarnation determines his proper role of appearing visibly in the world, even prior to his incarnation. Further, the Son, who is the image of the invisible God, takes on this role in order to reveal God gradually to 'frail' and 'limited' human beings, strengthening their vision so that one day they will be able to see God the Father (*De Trin.* 18.3). Using New Testament verses that the Son makes the Father known (*John* 1:18; *Col.* 1:15), Novatian argues that the Son acts as an angel or messenger for the Father, exercising an angel's 'proper mediocrity' (*De Trin.* 18.13) by mediating the presence of the Father, who is properly invisible.[5] Thus for Novatian, according to his proper role of mediation the Son 'descends' and interacts visibly with human beings, while the Father does not.

Justin likewise employs angel Christology, claiming that the God who appears to Abraham at the oak of Mamre (*Gen.* 18) is called an angel because 'He proclaims to human beings ... whatever the Creator of the world ... wishes

[3] For an interpretation of Novatian's objective, and the misleading title *De trinitate*, see Geoffrey D. Dunn, The Diversity and Unity of God in Novatian's *De Trinitate*: *Ephemerides Theologicae Lovanienses* 78 (2002) 385-409.

[4] *De Trin.* 18.2: 'Ex quo intellegi potest quod non Pater visus sit, qui numquam visus est, sed Filius, qui et descendere solitus est et videri, quia descenderit.'

[5] *De Trin.* 18.13: 'Nisi quoniam, ut Deo Patri invisibilitas propria reddatur et angelo propria mediocritas remittatur, non nisi Dei Filius, qui et Deus est, Abrahae visus et hospitio receptus esse credetur.'

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to reveal to them' (*Dial.* 56).[6] Here Justin relies upon the biblical narrative's reference to an angel to assert the Logos' mediation;[7] further, he asserts that the Son is a mediator because he was begotten by the Father's will for the purpose of performing the Father's will (*Dial.* 61). In terms of revelation, then, according to Justin the Logos acts like an angel who 'communicates to human beings the discourses [ὁμιλία] of the Father' (*Dial.* 128); yet he is also called God because his power and existence is inseparable from the Father (*Dial.* 128).[8]

Second, while both Justin and Novatian emphasize the Son's role as mediator, their interpretation is equally grounded in their beliefs about the identity of God the Father as revealed and yet hidden. Justin describes to Trypho that God the Creator and Father of all is one who 'ever abides in the super-celestial sphere, who has never been seen by any man, and with whom no man has ever conversed' (*Dial.* 56).[9] Later, in commenting on the burning bush narrative, Justin writes that 'no one with even the slightest intelligence would dare to assert that the Creator and Father of all things left His super-celestial realms to make Himself visible in a little spot on earth' (*Dial.* 60).[10] Similarly, Novatian argues that the Father is above all things, found everywhere, not circumscribed by a body (*De Trin.* 1-5), and therefore, contra the Sabellians, cannot be said to come from one place to another, as if 'enclosed by space and contained within the limits of some abode' (*De Trin.* 12.7). For both authors, the problem is not that the Creator is limited to the super-celestial realms, but rather that the Creator cannot be limited spatially. Narratives that imply spatial movement and location, such as God's descent at Babel, cannot be attributed to the Father. Thus their assertions about the Son's mediation and revelation derive from their

[6] See also *Dial.* 56.1: Μωσῆς οὖν, ὁ μακάριος καὶ πιστὸς θεράπων θεοῦ, μηνύων ὅτι θεός ἐστιν ὁ ὀφθεὶς τῷ Ἀβραὰμ πρὸς τῇ δρυῒ τῇ Μαμβρῆ θεὸς σὺν τοῖς ἅμα αὐτῷ ἐπὶ τὴν Σοδόμων κρίσιν πεμφθεῖσι δύο ἀγγέλοις ὑπὸ ἄλλου, τοῦ ἐν τοῖς ὑπερουρανίοις ἀεὶ μένοντος καὶ οὐδενὶ ὀφθέντος ἢ ὁμιλήσαντος δι' ἑαυτοῦ ποτε, ὃν ποιητὴν τῶν ὅλων καὶ πατέρα νοοῦμεν; English translation from *Writings of Justin Martyr,* transl. Thomas B. Falls, Fathers of the Church (New York, 1948), 232.

[7] For scholarly debate on Philo's influence upon Justin's theology of the Logos, see David Runia, *Philo in Early Christian Literature* (Assen and Minneapolis, 1993), 97-105. On the theophanies, Oscar Skarsaune argues that 'if there is any influence from Philo on Justin's treatment of the theophanies, it is at best distant, and mainly operative in some general modes of argument rather than in concrete exegesis of texts. In the latter respect, Justin exhibits a marked independence of Philo, often directly contradicting or ignoring Philonic exegesis' (*ibid.*, 103). Perhaps Justin's 'direct contradicting' of Philo on theophany exegesis is evidence of his familiarity with Philonic interpretation in the *Dialogue with Trypho,* his most extensive theophany exegesis.

[8] *Dial.* 128: καὶ Λόγον δὲ αὐτὴν καλοῦσιν, ἐπειδὴ καὶ τὰς παρὰ τοῦ πατρὸς ὁμιλίας φέρει τοῖς ἀνθρώποις. For further study of Justin's understanding of revelation and mediation, see Craig D. Allert, *Revelation, Truth, Canon, and Interpretation: Studies in Justin Martyr's Dialogue with Trypho,* SVigChr 64 (Leiden, 2002).

[9] See note 6.

[10] *Dial.* 60.2: οὐ τὸν ποιητὴν τῶν ὅλων καὶ πατέρα, καταλιπόντα τὰ ὑπὲρ οὐρανὸν ἅπαντα, ἐν ὀλίγῳ γῆς μορίῳ πεφάνθαι πᾶς ὁστισοῦν κἂν μικρὸν νοῦν.

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beliefs about the Creator and Father of all, who is found everywhere but not located anywhere, who is present but who also needs to be mediated in particular times and places for the sake of human understanding.[11]

Bridging discontinuities

In addressing mediation and revelation, these authors bring attention to the gap between the divine and the human, responding to the more monarchian Christian-Jewish view of God. They choose narratives in which this gap is particularly evident, in which a divine encounter is described with puzzling ambiguity about who the subject is (Lord, God, angel, man?) as well as differing claims whether the human subjects could truly see God (see *Ex.* 24:33). Literal christological exegesis is generally found in a small number of narratives that are inherently ambiguous and difficult to interpret. Such narratives provide fruit for thinking through the mediation required to bridge the divine-human gap.

Yet this is not the only gap or discontinuity that the authors bridge in their interpretation; they are equally concerned about crafting a unified and coherent view of the revelations of God in history, harmonizing the different traditions of the Old and the emerging New Testaments. In particular, the radical discontinuity between the Creator and Jesus posed by Marcion threatened how early Christians understood the scriptures and, ultimately, the identity of God. Justin addresses this discontinuity by debating with Trypho that belief in Christ is compatible with the Jewish scriptures. While scholars debate whether Justin's work was actually intended for the conversion of Jews, certainly part of its purpose was to persuade Christians of the continuity between the Jewish scriptures and Christian beliefs, rejecting the more radical anti-Jewish stance of Marcion.[12] One century later, Novatian asserts a via media between two extremes, the radical Marcionite discontinuity and the absolute Sabellian continuity between Father and Son. Through exegesis, both authors establish a continuity of God's actions as mediated by Christ, in the face of competing Christian claims that either separate or collapse the distinctive revelations of God in history.

[11] C. Allert, *Revelation, Truth, Canon, and Interpretation* (2002), 63.

[12] D. Rokeah cites a seminar by L. Gaston (see notes on pp. 6-7) on anti-Judaism in early Christianity: 'Gaston concludes by saying that ancient anti-Judaism does not stem from opposition to, or hatred of, the Jews but, rather, from the attempt to solve the internal problem created by the crisis of Marcion and the "Judaizers." The use of the Hebrew Bible in the *Adversus Judaeos* literature was not intended to prove Christ's divine nature to the Jews, but to convince Christians that the Jews' sacred writings were compatible with the belief in Christ.' While I do not wish to minimize early Christian attacks against Jews, I interpret part of Justin's purpose as addressing an intra-Christian problem. O. Skarsaune likewise argues that Justin's real opponents are Marcionites and perhaps adoptionists; see *id.*, *The Proof from Prophecy: A Study in Justin Martyr's Proof-Text Tradition* (Leiden, 1987), 210, 431.

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Biblical scholarship such as Donald Juel's *Messianic Exegesis* has illuminated how early Christians read the Hebrew scriptures creatively but organically to articulate their christological beliefs.[13] In a related manner, Walter Brueggemann argues that Christianity and Judaism have historically used daring and imaginative acts of interpretation to overcome problems of discontinuity.[14] Discontinuities occur when the community experiences a serious disruption, such as the Babylonian Exile or the Roman destruction of the Second Temple; when it incorporates different sources of tradition, such as the New Testament for Christians or the creation of the Midrashim, the Halakha, and the Talmudim for Jews; and, discontinuities occur when the community adapts itself to genuinely new circumstances. These discontinuities threaten to splinter the faith unless overcome by an imaginative act of interpretation grounded in ancient texts. Brueggemann writes,

> That work of interpretive imagination ... is not made up on the spot but is characteristically grounded in old tradition, in old texts, as though the new interpretive claims voice what was always present in the old text, though not voiced until now and not available, seen, or articulated until this belated moment of an interpretive leap. Thus, the text is read afresh in interpretive imagination, but it is read afresh in a way that the community finds completely credible; consequently, the threat of discontinuity, while still acknowledged and taken seriously, is managed through the large claims of continuity now authoritatively imagined.[15]

In other words, the discontinuity is bridged by a creative and genuinely new act of exegesis that must be grounded in ancient traditions for it to be authoritative to the community of faith. While Brueggemann makes his argument regarding biblical disruptions such as the Babylonian exile and the Pauline mission to the Gentiles, it sheds light upon the kind of interpretation used by Justin and Novatian. Justin overcomes the discontinuity between the faith of ancient Israel and faith in Jesus as the Christ by asserting the Logos's angelic activity of mediating revelation from the Father, and he thereby creates continuity between the ancient narratives of divine revelation to Israel and Christian belief in Jesus as the Logos. Likewise, Novatian argues that Christ is divine and yet distinct from the Father. Faced with two opposing views – that Christ is not divine or that Christ is identical to the Father, either total discontinuity or total continuity – Novatian locates himself in the middle through exegesis of ancient, pre-Christian narratives. By asserting the continuity of revelation, Novatian authoritatively grounds his view that before his incarnation Christ mediates revelation from the Father. Both authors thus claim to be presenting

[13] Donald Juel, *Messianic Exegesis: Christological Interpretation of the Old Testament in Early Christianity* (Philadelphia, 1988).

[14] Walter Brueggemann, Dialogue Between Incommensurate Partners: Prospects for Common Testimony: *Journal of Ecumenical Studies* 38 (2001) 383-98.

[15] W. Brueggemann, Dialogue Between Incommensurate Partners (2001), section III.

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an ancient, continuous tradition while asserting something genuinely new, and the continuity is rooted in their belief in the mediation of divine revelation into human experience.

Conclusion

Early patristic authors used literal christological exegesis of Old Testament narratives in order to create a unified, coherent view of divine revelation in the face of discontinuities presented by competing Christian beliefs. They asserted their christological beliefs via the ancient traditions of the scriptures, presenting a continuous yet distinctive identity of the Son. Further, they turned to narratives that virtually required imaginative interpretation of the ambiguities present in the texts.

In doing so, they created a new form of interpretation that solved one problem but added others. While Brueggemann's thesis illuminates why and how these exegetes interpreted as they did, it does not mean that their interpretations were of the enduring quality of the post-exilic scriptures or the Pauline letters. Part of the problem was that, like Sabellian interpretation, these authors solved the discontinuity problem all too well, not leaving adequate room for the distinctiveness of the revelations to the patriarchs. Reading Christ in the narratives historically became a means of displacing the narratives from their original context, thereby weakening their literal meaning. Further, the literal christological interpretation suggested the subordinate role of Christ as the mediator. In the fourth century, Homoians promoted this interpretation while pro-Nicene authors like Hilary and Augustine countered by asserting the inseparable work of the Trinity. Yet, it remains that the literal christological reading, creative as it was, proceeded from both attention to textual ambiguities and a confidence in the coherence of divine revelation mediated by the Son.

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Monastic Attitudes toward Philosophy and Philosophers

Columba STEWART, Collegeville

The etiology of monasticism echoes broader debates about the distinctiveness of Christianity vis-à-vis other religious and cultural movements, the place of asceticism within Christianity, and the place of the intellectual life within monasticism.[1] Each of these is a complex problem in itself, often fraught with anxieties and littered with well-ground axes.

The emergence of monasticism as a self-conscious, easily recognizable, ascetic movement around the year 300 involved an array of definitional moves. Some of these were deliberate, others were more inevitable then deliberate, explicable as part of the natural development of a distinctive subculture. The *distinctive characteristics* of early Christian monasticism in its Egyptian ('classic') form represent a fusion of elements derived from two principal sources.

First is the Christian tradition, primarily in its biblical and emerging ascetic aspects. From Christian tradition one finds characteristic practices such as fasting, times and styles of prayer, an emphasis on sexual renunciation, and a demonology useful for ascetic training.

Second is the Hellenistic philosophical tradition, broadly understood in both its intellectual and behavioral, or more aptly, *theoretical and practical* – aspects. Echoing the practices of Greek philosophical schools are elements such as the notion of dedicating one's life to contemplative pursuits, distinctive vesture, an interest in psychology, and the use of certain pedagogical techniques.

Of course, these were not utterly distinct, hermetically-sealed alternatives: the biblical Wisdom tradition, beloved of monastic Christians, has many points of thematic affinity with Greek philosophy, and its later texts certainly show signs of interaction with the principal currents of Hellenistic philosophy. We know that the great crucible of classical Christian theology, Alexandria, was rife with movements of all kinds, with varying degrees of connection with what later commentators could identify as Catholic Christianity. And, of course, monasticism received much of its philosophical inheritance indirectly, by way of figures such as Origen.

In sum, what Egyptian monasticism learned from philosophy was how to create a distinctive way of life dedicated to the pursuit of virtue, knowledge,

[1] I explore some of these themes in: The Encounter of the Early Church with the Greek and Roman World: A View from Monastic Theology, in: *Proceedings of the Catholic Theological Society of America* 65 (2006) 1-13.

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and wisdom. As we have been reminded most vividly by Pierre Hadot, ancient philosophy was indeed 'a way of living' (*une manière de vivre*), and its schools and less formal groupings functioned as places of ethical and intellectual formation meant to provide adherents with an understanding of the world, visible and invisible, and their place in it. Philosophy and Christian monasticism occupied the same market sector, in a manner akin to, but even more intense than, the general competition between Christianity and the other religious/intellectual interpretations of human experience so abundant in late antiquity. Philosophy was *most like* monasticism and therefore *most competitive* with it for the attention of the spiritually or intellectually-inclined.

The textual evidence demonstrates the knotty relationship between philosophy and monasticism. First, there are obvious, though perhaps unconscious, borrowings of terminology and concepts. Second, there are contests between monastic heroes and philosophers. The latter are sometimes depicted as foolishly arrogant, sometimes as genuine seekers after wisdom, sometimes as taunting the unsophisticated rustic monks. The philosophers, of course, always leave dazzled by the unexpected brilliance of their monastic interlocutor. Third, the later history of monasticism demonstrates an enduring uneasiness about the appropriate scope of intellectual pursuits within the monastic life, an uneasiness that would express itself in the re-use of anti-philosophical polemics.

The striking parallels between Christian monasticism and Greek philosophical movements also explain at least some of the monastic urgency to find biblical justification and even historical antecedents for that form of Christian life. This is done briefly but magnificently in the opening chapter of the Coptic Life of Pachomius, which sweeps from its first sentence, 'The word of God came to Abraham', through the whole of salvation history, culminating in the martyrdom of Bishop Peter of Alexandria and the birth of Pachomius himself.[2] The point is clear. So too the use by the Pachomian movement of the Greek word *koinonia* with its reminiscence of the apostolic community in Jerusalem. This tendency culminates in the energetic historiography of Cassian, who asserts a directly apostolic origin for cenobitic monasticism.[3]

Within the foundational texts of the Greek and Latin monastic traditions there are different approaches taken toward philosophy and philosophers. Although the extant textual evidence is only partial, we know that the very survival of certain texts testifies to the normative character they acquire through recommendation, copying, and translation. I have selected three examples related to the classic Egyptian monastic tradition, spanning approximately 75 years of monastic literature, from the 350s to the 420s. Those were busy decades for

[2] Most easily consulted in Armand Veilleux's E.T., *Pachomian Koinonia I: The Life of Saint Pachomius*, Cistercian Studies 45 (Kalamazoo, MI, 1980), 23-4.

[3] *Conlationes* 18.5, ed. Michael Petschenig, CSEL 13 (Vienna, 1886), 509-11; subsequent references are to this edition.

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emerging monasticism. The first example, Antony the Great, must be included in any survey, even the most cursory, for his sheer dominance in both monastic imagination and literature. The second, Evagrius Ponticus, is widely regarded as the most philosophically inclined of the fourth-century Desert Fathers. The third, John Cassian, mediated the Egyptian tradition to the Latin west and provides an example of how the slightly later tradition, already distant from live debates between Christian ascetics and non-Christian philosophers, echoed earlier attitudes. One could undertake the same exercise with evidence from other corners of the early monastic world such as Cappadocia and Palestine, but here the focus will remain on monastic Egypt and one of its heirs.

The Traditions of Antony the Great

First there is Athanasius's Antony.[4] Study of this literary portrait has demonstrated Athanasius's own theological and broader religious intentions in emphasizing an unlettered Antony who is wise through grace and knowledge of the Scriptures rather than by way of literature and philosophy. Despite the deliberate minimizing by Athanasius of Antony's own learning, the marks of philosophy are abundant in the teaching of Antony even as presented in the *Life*. Scholars since the early 20th century have noted Athanasius's use of the *Life of Pythagoras* and other philosophical exempla in creating his portrait of the monastic hero.[5]

Thus, Athanasius portrays even his *agrammatos* Antony effortlessly using a number of philosophical terms and concepts: the Stoic theme of indwelling virtue used first to explicate the Lucan logion of Jesus that the "kingdom of God is within you" (*Luke* 17:21) and then to take a swipe at the 'Greeks' who cross the seas in pursuit of learning[6]; Platonic anthropology with its two irrational parts of the soul, *thumos* and *epithumia*[7]; and a recommendation of Pythagorean examination of conscience and writing down 'actions and movements of the soul.'[8] Antony's supposed encounters with philosophers depict him in refutation of specific points of metaphysics, with his acumen and persuasiveness attributed entirely to God.[9]

As a check on Athanasius's version, there is also *Antony's* Antony, the author of the extant *Letters*, addressing an exclusively monastic audience, and making

[4] References are to the edition of G.J.M. Bartelink, *Athanase d'Alexandrie, Vie d'Antoine*, SC 400 (Paris, 1994).

[5] As was pointed out most recently in a paper by Samuel Rubenson, Antony or Pythagoras: Rival Claims to Holiness?, presented at the North American Patristics Society, Chicago, May 2006.

[6] *V. Ant.* 20.4-5, Gerhardus Johannes Marinus Bartelink (ed.), SC 400 (Paris, 1994), 188-90.

[7] *V. Ant.* 21.1 (SC 400, 192)

[8] *V. Ant.* 55.7-13 (SC 400, 284-86).

[9] *V. Ant.* 72-80 (SC 400, 320-40).

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similar use of common philosophical terms and concepts in service of his predominating theme of self-knowledge, though without the anti-philosophical polemic of the *Life*.[10]

The question of audience is crucial. As Samuel Rubenson has noted, Athanasius, leader of a beleaguered Christian party, was fighting on various fronts both within and beyond Christianity. He was keenly aware of the philosophical and religious competition and the battle not just for hearts, but for minds as well. His need to establish a clear edge on the competition through a champion drives his *Life of Antony*. Antony himself, concerned less with external threats to Christianity, and more with forming *both* the hearts *and* the minds of his disciples, manifests little need to show up the philosophers or to use them as a foil.

Evagrius

Evagrius was perhaps the best educated in philosophy of all the early monks.[11] Despite this, or because of it, he makes little explicit reference to 'philosophy' as such in his writings, though one finds a pervasive emphasis on the acquisition of 'knowledge' through the development of stable virtues. He offers none of the cartoonish depictions of supercilious philosophers found in other texts, with one curious exception to be noted below. Evagrius's use of philosophical terminology and concepts shows his theological debt to Origen and his Cappadocian masters, though in his ascetic doctrine he relies much more heavily on Hellenistic philosophical anthropology than did they. This is famously evident in *Praktikos* 89, where Evagrius reworks a commonplace pop-psychology text and then substitutes for its usual attribution to Plato an adscription to 'our wise teacher', meaning, however improbably, Gregory Nazianzen.[12]

Evagrius is concerned about 'false knowledge', by which he means errors about the nature of the universe, free will, and various doctrinal points disputed with Gnostics and others, including philosophers. He contrasts 'knowledge from outside', gained by human effort through the study of texts and rhetoric, with the knowledge granted by divine grace through spiritual insight and contemplation.[13] In this context we can place his one depiction of a monastic-philosophical

[10] See Samuel Rubenson, *The Letters of St. Antony: Monasticism and the Making of a Saint* (Minneapolis, 1995), especially *ibid.* 143 on viewing Antony as 'a disciple of wandering ascetics teaching a philosophically speculative theology following various schools of Alexandria, including the Origenist tradition.'

[11] See Antoine Guillaumont, *Un philosophe au desert: Évagre le Pontique*, Textes et traditions 8 (Paris, 2004), 31-2, 163.

[12] Greek text, with references to the sources, in Antoine and Claire Guillaumont, *Évagre le Pontique, Traité pratique ou Le Moine*, SC 171 (Paris, 1971), 680-9.

[13] *Gnostikos* 4, ed. Antoine and Claire Guillaumont, *Évagre le Pontique, Le Gnostique*, SC 365 (Paris, 1989), 92-3.

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encounter, supposedly between Antony and one of the 'wise men', who asks the monk how he manages to survive unsupported by the consolation of books. Antony replies, in a decidedly Evagrian tone, 'My book, O philosopher, is the nature of beings, and it is there whenever I want to read the words of God.'[14] This is of course Evagrius himself speaking, the same person who had once referred to Creation as 'God's letters written to us', so that 'one who looks upon creation with understanding, perceives the hand and the finger of its Creator, as well as his intention.'[15] Such contemplative 'reading' requires insight honed by discipline and rooted in self-knowledge.

Evagrius's insistence upon the preeminence of contemplative knowledge is thus not so much a rejection of all 'knowledge from outside', as it is a concern about proper ascetic pedagogy and development. He knew that *theoria* could become 'theoretical' in the modern English sense, an escape from mundane attention to the passions, and a purely intellectual substitute for the more theological virtue of hope that ascetic struggle would bear fruit in knowledge and peace.[16]

John Cassian

Evagrius's concern becomes central to the teaching of his disciple, John Cassian. Cassian's work does not exhibit the philosophical sophistication of Evagrius's writings, and its philosophical and theological content is clearly derivative of both Origen and Evagrius, even when turned to the issues of Cassian's own time and place. Cassian's ascetic doctrine is relentlessly *practical*, intended as it was for a monastic setting very different from Evagrius's bright circle of the Egyptian desert. Cassian's monks were even farther from the philosophical and religious marketplace of Alexandria than were the anchorites of Kellia and Scetis. Cassian worried about young, overly-eager, ascetic athletes who would

[14] *Prakt.* 92 (SC 171, 694-5).

[15] *Letter to Melania.* Syriac text in: Wilhelm Frankenberg, *Euagrius Ponticus*, Abhandlungen der Königlichen Gesellschaft der Wissenschaften zu Göttingen, Philologisch-historische Klasse, N.F. 13.2 (Berlin, 1912), 612, 22-30. E. T. in Martin Parmentier, Evagrius of Pontus' 'Letter to Melania' I: *Bijdragen, tijdschrift voor filosofie en theologie* 46 (1985) 2-38, 8-9, ll. 35-47.

[16] *Gnost.* 25 (SC 365, 128-9): 'Those who argue without knowledge are to be brought to the truth not by starting at the end, but from the beginning. To young people you must not speak of things pertaining to Knowledge, nor permit them to handle books of that kind [e.g., Origen's *On First Principles* or Evagrius's own *Kephalaia Gnostika*] for they cannot avoid the pitfalls that such contemplation entails. That is why you should not speak words of peace to those who are battling the passions. Tell them instead about how they will conquer their foes: for, says the Ecclesiast, "there is no desisting in the day of war" (*Eccl.* 8:8). When the soul is fiercely assaulted by the passions, it wants to taste the sweet honey [of knowledge of God], but those who are assaulted by the passions and examine the *logoi* of corporeal and incorporeal things are like sick people discoursing about health.'

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bypass or scorn the patient attentiveness to self and the waiting upon God's grace that bring true perfection. He echoed some of the tropes about worldly knowledge and caricatures of philosophy found in Athanasius's *Life of Antony* or the *apophthegmata*, with an overriding emphasis on the successful pursuit of virtue through a moderate asceticism and proper understanding of the limits of purely human effort.

It is in Cassian's treatment of chastity that the contrast between monasticism and philosophy becomes most acute.[17] Echoing the ancient Christian contempt for the alleged licentiousness of paganism, Cassian places philosopher and monk in the balance scales of lust. On the side of the philosophers are Socrates and Diogenes the Cynic. Quoting otherwise unknown comments by both, Cassian derides Diogenes's supposed flippancy about satisfaction of sexual appetites, but his real target is Socrates. In a version of a story also found in Cicero, Cassian's Socrates responds to the accusation of pederasty by declaiming, 'So I am: but I restrain myself.'[18] For Cassian, Socrates's restraint is the best that can be expected of a philosopher deprived of the Christian God's definitive intervention. Socrates can fight his desires to a stalemate, but he cannot, simply through human effort, banish them from his heart. He will never attain the interior purity of mind or the enduring purity of body that is the ultimate stage of monastic chastity.

On the other side stands the quasi-angelic figure of the aptly-named Abba Serenus, who threw himself on the mercy of God with a prayer for purity of heart. When that inner peace was granted, he then dared to ask for freedom even from the natural bodily responses to inadvertent stimulation.[19] In a vision he sees a 'fiery mass' being removed from his belly by a surgical angel and his wish thereby fulfilled. Cassian knew better than to suggest that Serenus's experience was typical, just as Athanasius never suggested that Antony's virtue was attainable for the great herd of monks. But in both cases the monastic exemplar defined a horizon of possibility, however distant from common experience, attainable only through prayer to the Christian God. That horizon of possibility, a *theological* horizon, conditioned the whole array of monastic practices, many of them shared with the devotés of philosophy, who, in Cassian's view, were hindered from seeing that all-important horizon.

Conclusion

In the 75 years and many miles that passed between Athanasius's *Life of Antony* and Cassian's monastic project in Gaul, much changed in the relationship between Christianity and non-Christian philosophers. As time passed, the polemical

[17] On Cassian's understanding of monastic chastity, see Columba Stewart, *Cassian the Monk* (New York, 1998), 62-4.

[18] *Conl.* 13.5.3 (CSEL 13, 366).

[19] *Conl.* 7.2 (CSEL 13, 180-81).

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imperative faded. By the time of Cassian's *Conferences*, philosophy as a living alternative to monasticism seems quite remote. Throughout the literature of early monasticism, sampled only briefly in this paper, it is unsurprising that the most significant monastic affinity with philosophy, as well as the most intense monastic critique of philosophy's ultimate value, is where they competed most keenly, in the cultivation of virtue.

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From Gorgias to Gregory of Nazianzus – a Platonic Formula Revisited*

Jennifer NIMMO SMITH, Edinburgh

Timaeus' statement in his *Proœmium* to 'the probable story' (τὸν εἰκότα μῦθον) about the origin of the cosmic system: τὸν μὲν οὖν ποιητὴν καὶ πατέρα τοῦδε τοῦ παντὸς εὑρεῖν τε ἔργον καὶ εὑρόντα εἰς πάντας ἀδύνατον λέγειν ('It is a hard task to find the maker and father of this universe, and having found him it would be impossible <for anyone> to declare him to all mankind') had a deep resonance in later Platonic and Christian thought amongst Greeks and Romans alike.[1] The Peripatetics, Stoics and Neoplatonists looked to the nature of the maker of the world, and that of the world itself.[2] For Christians it combined confirmation of the Book of Genesis, proof that the pagans also had knowledge of the one true God, and that his nature, if understood, should not be revealed to everyone.[3] Gregory of Nazianzus used the passage twice, in *Or.* 28.4 and 32.14. The more striking allusion[4] is in *Or.* 28.4: Ἀρκτέον οὖν οὕτω πάλιν. θεὸν νοῆσαι μὲν χαλεπόν, φράσαι δὲ ἀδύνατον, ὥς τις τῶν παρ' Ἕλλησι θεολόγων ἐφιλοσόφησεν ('So we must begin again with this in mind. To know God is hard, to describe him impossible, as one of the theologians among the Hellenes taught').[5] This is explicitly signalled as Platonic in one set of early scholia on the sermons.[6] The other set refers to Hermes

* I should like to thank Mr. J.G.C. Strachan of the University of Edinburgh for his helpful comments on this paper.

[1] *Tim.* 29d 2, and 28c 3-5; see Francis M. Cornford, *Plato's Cosmology* (London 1937, repr. *ibid.* 2000), 22.

[2] M.R. Wright, *Cosmology in Antiquity* (London, 1995), 176-82; David T. Runia, *Philo of Alexandria and the* Timaios *of Plato* (Leiden, 1986), 104.

[3] David Runia (1986), 111-3; Christopher Stead, *Philosophy in Christian Antiqiuity* (Cambridge, 1994), 26-7, 66-8, 104-5; Jaroslav Pelikan, *What has Athens to do with Jerusalem?* (Ann Arbor, 1997), 24, 117-8, n. 53; Rowan Williams, *Arius Heresy and Tradition*[2] (London, 2001), 181-4.

[4] Jaroslav Pelikan, *Christianity and Classical Culture* (New Haven, London, 1993), 20; *id.* (1997), 24; Aug., *De Civ. Dei* VIII 11.

[5] PG 36, 23C; *Grégoire de Nazianze Discours 27-31*, Paul Gallay and Maurice Jourjon (eds.), SC 250 (Paris, 1978), 109, n. 1; transl. Frederick Williams and Lionel Wickham, *St Gregory of Nazianzus On God and Christ* (New York, 2002), 39. In *Or.* 32.14 (SC 318, 115; PG 36, 189C), Gregory extends the difficulty of understanding God, and describing him, to finding a worthy hearer.

[6] Πλάτωνός ἐστι τοῦτο ... Aeneas Piccolomini, Estratti inediti dai codici Greci della biblioteca Mediceo-Laurenziana: *Annali delle Unviversità Toscane* 16 (Pisa, 1879), 1-XLII, 229-275, 257.

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Trismegistos.[7] The first identification was upheld in the Benedictine edition of Gregory's text reprinted by J.-P. Migne, and is regarded by later commentators on this sermon and in discussions of Gregory's 'Christian Platonism' as underlying the other reference.[8]

Gregory's 'Christian Platonism' is a good servant with a good master.[9] All his surviving works, composed before, during and after his time in Constantinople, were re-edited or composed with a wide public in mind. Given his well-known self-imposed mission to turn Greek learning to the service of the Church, he made no secret of his long training in rhetorical, philosophical and religious studies away from home, nor of his enjoyment of it, in Athens in particular. His writings are not merely embellished with pagan and Christian allusions:[10] they are imbued with reminiscences of pagan literature, as is clear from the *scholia* on his works.[11] These, though only as yet for the most part printed in selections, identify many of Gregory's allusions to classical literature, as for the passage in *Or.* 28.4 discussed above. Their contents were compiled and added to by later commentators and scholiasts, such as Elias of Crete (9-10c. or 12c. C.E.), who is the first to combine both sources for this passage.[12]

It is not surprising then that reflections of the language of Plato and Aristotle should be found in the sermons Gregory delivered in Constantinople to defend Nicene orthodoxy against the Eunomians.[13]

The beginnings of rhetoric lay, we know, in the rise of democracies in Sicily and Athens in the fifth century B.C.E, and the teachings of the rhetors and sophists gave the democrats success in lawcourts and peoples's assemblies. The

[7] Ἑρμοῦ Τρισμεγίστου. See Paul A. Bruckmayr, *Untersuchungen über die Randscholien der 28 Reden des hl. Gregorius von Nazianz im cod. th. gr. 74 der Wiener Nationalbibliothek* (Vienna, 1940), L 11, 103, mentioning Plato, *Tim.* 28c, Elias of Crete, *R. E.* 12, 825.

[8] PG 36, 29, n. 5; see Claudio Moreschini, *Filosofia e letterature in Gregorio di Nazianzo* (Milan, 1997), 36-8, 103.

[9] Endre von Ivanka, *Plato Christianus* (Einsiedeln, 1964), 378-9; J. Pelikan, *What has Athens to do with Jerusalem?* (1997), 8, with Georges Florovsky, *Collected Works* VII (Vaduz, 1972), 119.

[10] Kristoffel Demoen, *Pagan and Biblical Exempla in Gregory Nazianzen: A Study in Rhetoric and Hermeneutics* (Turnhout, 1996); Neil McLynn, Word Games in Late Antique Cappadocia, in: T. Nishimura, N. Takahashi (eds.), *Vocabulary and Style in Classical Antiquity* (Tokyo, 2000), 35-58.

[11] Johannes Sajdak, Historia critica scholiastarum et commentatorum Gregorii Nazianzeni I: *Meletemata Patristica* I (Cracow, 1914), 1-306, Francesco Trisoglio, Mentalità ed attegiamenti degli scholiasti di fronte agli scritti di S. Gregorio di Nazianzo, in: *Il Symposium Nazianzenum*, ed. J. Mossay (Paderborn, 1981), 186-251; J. Nimmo Smith, The Early Scholia on the Sermons of Gregory of Nazianzus, in: *Studia Nazianzenica* I, CChr.SG 41, Corpus Nazianzenum 8 (Turnhout, 2000), 69-146.

[12] Iohannes Leunclavius, *Gregorius Nazianzenus: Operum tomi tres. Aucti nunc primum Caesareii, ... Eliae Cretensis, Episcopi...* (Basileae, 1571), 22; Frederick W. Norris, *Faith gives Fullness to Reasoning: The Five Theological Orations of Gregory of Nazianzen* (Leiden, 1991), 110.

[13] George A. Kennedy, *Greek Rhetoric under Christian Emperors* (Princeton, 1983), 215-39; F. Norris, *Faith gives Fullness to Reasoning* (1991), 25-39.

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sophists and their arguments throve in the intellectual ferment of those years, and made an indelible, if not always favourable, impression on Socrates and Plato. The stimulus they gave the Platonic dialogues is undeniable, and despite the criticism of their ethos and methods, their techniques are there transmuted into dialectic.[14]

While Protagoras has to admit defeat in the *Protagoras*, and his statement, 'man is the measure of all things' is tested in the *Theaetetus*, and flatly contradicted in the *Laws*,[15] there is more interaction with Gorgias' thought. Although the latter takes his dialectical defeat in 'a dignified silence' in the *Gorgias* and his arguments of probability are attacked in the *Phaedrus*,[16] both he and Socrates acknowledge that rhetoric (in Socrates's case) and the power of speech (in that of Gorgias) affect the soul.[17] Interesting parallels have also been drawn by some between Gorgias' *Defence of Palamedes* and Plato's *Apology*.[18]

Nor is it only the *Palamedes* of which Plato can be thought to have had knowledge. Gorgias' treatise, *On Non-Being or on Nature* (*ONB*) was dated to early in his career.[19] That scholarly reaction to it has long ranged from contempt to appreciation needs no discussion.[20] One paraphrase of it is by Sextus Empiricus (2nd c. C.E.) in *Adversus Mathematicos*, 7. 65.1- 87;[21] the other, the last part of *On Melissus, Xenophanes, Gorgias*, (*MXG*) is attributed to Aristotle, *Opera*, 979a 12-980b 21, but of unknown date.[22] As both appear to have drawn separately on the original, most recent scholars treat the arguments in each text where they differ separately. The three headings to both works, however, are broadly similar, and I quote those from *MXG*: Οὐκ εἶναί φησιν οὐδέν: εἰ δ' ἔστιν, ἄγνωστον εἶναι: εἰ δὲ καὶ ἔστι καὶ γνωστόν, ἀλλ' οὐ δηλωτὸν ἄλλοις ('He says that nothing exists, if it did exist it would be unknowable, even if it did exist and was knowable, it could not be communicated to others').[23]

[14] Elizabeth Asmis, Plato on poetic creativity, in: *Cambridge Companion to Plato*, ed. Richard Kraut (Cambridge, 1992), 33-364, 340; Paul Woodruff, Rhetoric and Relativism: Protagoras and Gorgias, in: *Cambridge Companion to Early Greek Philosophy*, ed. A.A. Long (Cambridge, 1999), 290-310, 291.

[15] Protagoras, *Frg.* 80B1, in: Hermann Diels, *Fragmente der Vorsokratiker*, ed. Walther Kranz, hencefoward DK (Berlin, 1952), II, 262-3; Plato, *Leg.* 716c-d.

[16] See Eric R. Dodds, *Plato Gorgias* (Oxford, 1959), 9-10 on *Gorg.* 267a 1-b 5, and D.G. Spatharas, Patterns of Argumentation in Gorgias: *Mnemosyne* LIV (2001) 393-408, on *Phaedr.* 267a 6.

[17] Gorgias, *Encomium Helenae* 14 (and 13); Plato, *Phaedr.* 261a 7-8.

[18] Paul Woodruff, Rhetoric and Relativism (1999), 298-9 and n. 8, on *Palamedes*; James A. Coulter, The Relation of the *Apology of Socrates* to Gorgias' *Defence of Palamedes* and Plato's critique of Gorgianic Rhetoric: *HSCP* 68 (1964) 269-303.

[19] *Frg.* 82A10, DK (1952) II, 275.

[20] Scott Consigny, *Gorgias: Sophist and Artist* (New York, 2001), 1-32.

[21] *Frg.* 82B3, DK (1952) II, 279 -283.

[22] Ed. Thomas Buchheim, *Gorgias von Leontinoi, Reden, Fragmente und Testimonien, mit Übersetzung und Kommentar* (Hamburg, 1989).

[23] T. Buchheim, *Gorgias von Leontinoi* (1989), *Frg.* 3, 979a12, transl. John Dillon and Tania Gergel, *The Greek Sophists* (London, 2003), 67.

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This introduces what has been described as the 'Charybdis of Presocratic philosophy',[24] for if its arguments are convincing the whole exercise fails. It is generally accepted as an attack on Parmenides, and direct reflections of its thought have been traced in Plato's *Parmenides* and the *Sophist*.[25] Even if the primary targets of Gorgias' treatise are changed from Parmenides to the Eleatics, or to Protagoras (as recently argued[26]), the three-fold structure of its introduction is clearly an adaptation of the statements of Parmenides' goddess.[27] In this passage she declares of one of the ways of enquiry 'that it is, and there is an impossibility for it not to be' and of the other, 'that it is not' and 'there is a necessity for it not to be', which is 'a path completely unknowable', 'for you could not know what does not exist (for it can't be done), nor could you speak of it.'[28] Gorgias modifies his first statement 'nothing exists', to 'but if it did', which he qualifies 'it would be unknowable' from Parmenides, which is then qualified by 'but if it were known', and finally dealt with by 'you could not speak of it to others'.

I would argue that Plato takes up Gorgias' premises in the *Timaeus* as well as in the *Parmenides*. Just as Protagoras' dictum is re-applied to god in *Laws* 716 (as noted above), Gorgias' first premise ('nothing exists') is rejected in the *Timaeus* by the argument that the world of being <'really'> exists and the transient one of becoming does not <possess 'real being'>, but must have a cause.[29] The cause is personified as 'the maker and father of this universe'.[30] Timaeus continues: 'It is a hard task to find (him)', and returns to the formula, 'and, if found, would be impossible to declare to everyone'. Similar *formulae* are found in the *Laws*, the first in *Laws* 933a 5-7, where, although the verb 'to know' is substituted for the verb 'to find' the construction is much the same: ταῦτ' οὖν καὶ περὶ τὰ τοιαῦτα σύμπαντα οὔτε ῥᾴδιον ὅπως ποτὲ πέφυκεν γιγνώσκειν, οὔτ' εἴ τις γνοίη, πείθειν εὐπετὲς ἑτέρους ('It is not easy to know the truth about these and similar practices, and even if one were to find

[24] Victor Caston, Gorgias on Thought and its Objects, in: Victor Caston and D.W. Graham (eds.), *Presocratic Philosophy: Essays in Honour of Alexander Mourelatos* (Aldershot, 2002), 205-32, 205.

[25] Steve Hays, On the skeptical influence of Gorgias' *On Non-Being*: *Journal of the History of Philosophy* 28 (1990) 327-38, and Gisela Striker, *Essays on Hellenistic Epistemology and Ethics* (Cambridge, 1996), 14, on *Parm.* 135a-b (with n. 17 on *Soph.* 263a); James A. Palmer, *Plato's Reception of Parmenides* (Oxford, 1999), 108-17.

[26] V. Caston, Gorgias on Thought and its Objects (2002), 216-8.

[27] *Fr.* 28B2, DK (1952) I, 231; D.G. Spatharas, Patterns of Argumentation in Gorgias (2001), 399; V. Caston, Gorgias on Thought and its Objects (2002), 209, nn. 18, 19.

[28] Translated by M.R. Wright, *The Presocratics*: *The main fragments in Greek* ... (Bristol, 1985), 79.

[29] *Tim.* 27d 4-28c 4; M.R. Wright, Myth, science and reason in the *Timaeus*, in: *Reason and necessity: Essays on Plato's* Timaeus, ed. *id.* (London, 2000), 1-23, 14-17.

[30] F.M. Cornford, *Plato's Cosmology* (1937 = 2000), *ad loc.*

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out, it would be difficult to convince others').[31] Here, Plato notes that it is not worth the effort for those who are not completely convinced themselves about superstition to try to persuade people who actually see wax images in doorways, or on their parents' graves, to ignore them. Another, *Laws* 968d 3-4, is noted by T.A. Szlezák[32] as a parallel construction to *Timaeus* 28c, which describes the necessity of working out what the new guardians would have to learn: Μετὰ δὲ τοῦτο, ἃ δεῖ μανθάνειν οὔτε εὑρεῖν ῥᾴδιον οὔτε ηὑρηκότος ἄλλου μαθητὴν γενέσθαι ('Next, it is difficult to find this out for oneself, and it is not easy either to discover somebody else who has already done so or to learn from him.'). *Timaeus* 28c is interpreted by Szlezák as referring to higher principles which cannot be communicated 'to everyone', that is through writing;[33] in *Laws* 968d, Plato explains why the guardians will have to be provided with a course of instruction rather than finding things out for themselves. All three passages depend on a positive previous statement, the first that the world has come into being, the result of a cause; the second that both the practitioners of 'magic and enchantments' themselves and their victims are convinced of the efficacy of their spells; and the third that information has to be provided for the guardians; then describe the difficulty of the initial assertion, and how, once it has been investigated, the findings are either impossible to be passed on to all, or difficult to learn from someone else, or to pass on to others.

Plato is thus shown, if this theory is viable, to have adapted Gorgias' apparently simplistic premises in *ONB* to promote both the 'probable story' of his cosmology, and the need for the guardians to have their own course of instruction. His use of it in reference to common beliefs about witchcraft and superstition shows a grim awareness of the strength of public opinion.

Whatever its origins in Plato's thought, the memorable formula recurs in his work. Gregory, however, is not satisfied with it. He says, to continue the passage cited above from *Or.* 28.4: οὐκ ἀτέχνως ἐμοὶ δοκεῖν, ἵνα καὶ κατειληφέναι δόξῃ τῷ χαλεπὸν εἰπεῖν, καὶ διαφύγῃ τῷ ἀνεκφράστῳ τὸν ἔλεγχον. ἄλλα φράσαι μὲν ἀδύνατον, ὡς ὁ ἐμὸς λόγος, νοῆσαι δὲ ἀδυνατώτερον ('... subtly suggesting, I think, by the word "hard" his own apprehension, yet avoiding our test of it by claiming it was impossible to describe'). According to some commentators, though not all,[34] these words

[31] Translation from T.J. Saunders, *Plato The Laws* (Aylesbury, 1986), 479.

[32] Über die Art und Weise der Erörterung der Prinzipien im *Timaios*, in: *Interpreting the Timaeus-Critias: Proceedings of the IV Symposium Platonicum*, ed. by Tomas Calvo Martinez, Luc Brisson (Sankt Augustin, 1997), 195-203, 197.

[33] *Reading Plato* (London and New York, 1999) (transl. of *Platon Lesen*, Stuttgart, 1993), 64, 106.

[34] As Elias of Crete, *R. E.* 12, 22 and F. Norris, *Faith gives Fullness to Reasoning* (1991), 110. The Florentine scholiast notes Gregory's criticism of even the claim of a possibility of a description of God from one who perceived him: πανσοφῶς ἐκόλασεν, ὡς ἐνδεχομένου τυχὸν καὶ

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imply that Gregory thought the pagan philosopher was concealing his own lack of knowledge. He certainly rejects his words: 'To tell of God is not possible, so my argument runs, but to know him is even less possible.' This criticism is a crushing dismissal of the Eunomians' definitions of the divine and refines the catchphrase for Christian thought.

τοῦ νοηθέντος ἰσχύι λόγων ἐκφράζεσθαι, Aen. Piccolomini, Estratti inediti dai codici Greci della biblioteca Mediceo-Laurenziana: *Annali delle Unviversità Toscane* 16 (Pisa, 1879), 257. Cl. Moreschini, *Filosofia e letterature in Gregorio di Nazianzo* (1997), 36, however, translates οὐκ ἀτέχνως as 'affermazione non da ignorante'.

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Creation and Human Being: The Forging of a Distinct Christian Discourse

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My principal interest on this occasion is to explore what it meant to become conscious of oneself, of humanity in general, the universe as a whole, including the spiritual world, as being essentially creatures of the one true God, Maker of heaven and earth. To put it another way, I propose to trace the way in which the otherwise Platonic discourse of key fourth century Fathers, Eastern and Western, was transformed by the doctrine of *creatio ex nihilo*, and a distinctive Christian spirituality was forged. I shall suggest that it was the process of teasing out the implications of this very unhellenic view of the origins of the universe which contributed substantially to the articulation of Christian doctrine, including its anthropology; and by focussing on this aspect, I shall incidentally make some observations about the conceptual models we scholars use in constructing a history of doctrinal formation.

The Confessions of St. Augustine

I take as my starting-point Augustine's *Confessions*, a work whose climax is a discussion of creation. Otherwise the work is plausibly described as the first autobiography – roughly two-thirds being a work of profound self-consciousness, telling the story of Augustine's childhood and youth, education and intellectual development, up to his conversion to the faith of his mother, and his mother's death. Puzzlingly, however, this is followed by lengthy philosophical explorations of memory, time and eternity, and creation, the final book providing an exposition of *Genesis* chapter 1. Can we give an account of the *Confessions*, which explains the presence of those final four books?

This is not the first time I have attempted to address the problem of the genre of the *Confessions*. In the 1998 St. Augustine lecture at Villanova,[1] I discussed possible ancient precedents and parallels to its autobiographical character. There my conclusion was this:

[1] Frances Young, *The Confessions* of St. Augustine: What is the Genre of this Work?: *Augustinian Studies* 30 (1999) 1-16.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 335-348.
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Consciously or unconsciously, alongside apologetic interest, Augustine's purpose in *The Confessions* is typological. He constructs his own life according to the biblically-shaped pattern by which he has come to understand the weakness of the human quest for God and the power of divine providence and grace, so as to provide a didactic 'type' or exemplar from which others will benefit by coming to an understanding of their own lives. The particular is understood by reference to the universal and *vice versa*. Scripture provides the models after which each human story may be sculpted.

Thus it was that I then hoped to provide an integrated view of the whole work. I accepted the parallels with Neoplatonic ideas of Fall and Return,[2] but suggested that a more significant contribution was made by Augustine's reading of Paul and the over-arching story of Fall and Redemption whereby the wider Church read the Bible as a whole. Augustine's own life becomes a 'type' demonstrating the outworking of God's providence and grace, anticipating in individual terms the agenda worked out on the plane of history in *The City of God*, namely, reorientation from self-love to love of God. Now, however, I want to retain those insights but integrate them into a new perspective: Augustine, I suggest, is working out the implications for human being of *creatio ex nihilo*, and it is this which more than anything else shifts his earlier Platonic assumptions.

The opening words of the *Confessions* suggest a re-reading of the first book in terms of a reflection on creatureliness. God is to be praised, and humanity, described twice within the opening lines as 'a little piece of your creation', is stirred to praise, 'because you have made us for yourself, and our heart is restless until it rests in you'. Chadwick notes[3] that 'For Plotinus (VI 7.23.4) the soul finds rest only in the One'; but, to adapt Mark Edwards' words,[4] 'Unlike the God of Origen [or for that matter Augustine], the One can make no choices; it causes without creating, presides without governing, superabounds without love.' The context focuses on creation, and Augustine invokes a God who causes, but does so as Lord of heaven and earth:

> You are God and Lord of all you have created. In you are the constant causes of inconstant things (I.vi(9)); Lord, I must give thanks to you, the most excellent and supremely good Creator and Governor of the universe, my God... (I.xx(31)).

Augustine tells of his own birth and early years as a way of celebrating his existence and the gifts given him by God:

> I thank you for your gifts. Keep them for me, for in that way you will keep me. The talents you have given will increase and be perfected, and I will be with you since it was your gift to me that I exist (I.xx(31)).

[2] See *e.g.* the introduction and notes to Henry Chadwick's translation in the World's Classics (Oxford, 1992); all quotations are taken from this ET.

[3] Chadwick (1992), 3.

[4] Mark Edwards, *Origen against Plato* (Aldershot, 2002), 61.

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Indeed, the first book may be read as a meditation on the miracle of existence, and the paradox of a God who is 'deeply hidden yet most intimately present', without whom nothing would exist (I.4(4)).

The striking thing is that themes from Book I are taken up in the opening words of Book XIII:

> You made me and, when I forgot you, you did not forget me. I call you into my soul, which you are preparing to receive you through the longing which you have inspired in it.

What Augustine has shown is the way in which God has exerted pressure on him, and continues to do so, constantly calling him further on the journey towards the divine self. 'To you I owe my being and the goodness of my being', he affirms; 'your creation has its being from the fullness of your goodness.' And this utter dependence on God for existence is reinforced by the reflection that neither physical matter nor the spiritual creation would exist unless God had made it; nothing has any claim on God. The climax of the whole work affirms explicitly *creatio ex nihilo*:

> Your works praise you that we may love, and we love you that your works may praise you. They have a beginning and an end in time, a rise and a fall, a start and a finish, beauty and the loss of it. They have in succession an evening and a morning, in part hidden, in part evident. They are made out of nothing by you, not from you, not from some matter not of your making or previously existing, but from matter created by you together with its form – that is simultaneously ... You made matter from absolutely nothing, but the beauty of the world from formless matter – and both simultaneously so that the form followed the matter without pause or delay (XIII. xxxiii(48)).

This being made from nothing is precisely what produces instability and restlessness. Augustine may seem to distinguish in classic Platonic style between what is changeable and what is changeless:

> ... it was clear to me and certain that what is corruptible is inferior to that which cannot be corrupted; what is immune from injury I unhesitatingly put above that which is not immune; what suffers no change is better than what can change (VII.i(1)).

However, he has shifted the thrust of this. A creature is inherently changeable because it has changed from nothingness into something – the really important thing is that that change goes on in the right direction. His story, like that of the whole human race, is one of restless wandering from the right path, and being brought back on track by God's providential promptings. So the story of creation is also the story of redemption. While according to *Sir.* 18:1 God created everything at once, Genesis records things in a particular order, so revealing the hidden plan whereby order emerges from chaos, and saints from sinners. It is this process that justifies the figural reading of Genesis 1 in terms of new creation in Christ – creation is not just a one-off event, but something that happens within time and in response to God's loving providence. Without the

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Word creation is inchoate and unformed, and needs to be converted, conformed to the Word 'by whom it was made, more and more to live by the fount of life, to see light in his light, and to become perfect, radiant with light and in complete happiness' (XIII. ii(3) – iii(5)). Augustine has moved on from his Platonist position, substantially because he understands himself as a creature, brought into being by the Creator God to whom he prays, and sees himself as integrally part of what Rowan Williams describes as 'a living system destined to grow toward beauty and order, even if this beauty and order is not at any given moment apparent'.[5] This acceptance of vulnerability and mutability, in the context of a creation with a beginning and an end, and in response to the creative and providential action of a God who freely loves, distinguishes Augustine's self-understanding from the intellectual mysticism of Neoplatonism, for all its surface similarities.

Those surface similarities he acknowledges by telling the story of his intellectual formation, and his struggles with the great problem of evil. The books of the Platonists rescue him from the Manichaean position (VII. ix(13) – xx(26)). He discovers that evil is not a substance – as long as things exist they remain good (VII. xii(18)). So evil cannot really exist; rather it is privation of good. Sounding rather like a Platonist, he can write (as usual, addressing God), 'the further away from you things are, the more unlike you they become' (XII. vii(7); xi(11)); heaven is 'close to you', while the 'earth' is 'close to being nothing' (XII. vii(9)). But the implicit correlation of evil with nothingness confirms that for Augustine the creative power of God is constantly at work bringing things out of nothingness into existence, and bringing order out of chaos, and good out of evil, redeeming what wanders restlessly and gets corrupted because of its inherent changeability – it is all of a piece. Things, which are liable to corruption because they are created out of nothing, are nevertheless good – even heaven is created and liable to lapse because of its createdness, yet contemplation of God checks its mutability (XII. ix(9); xv(20-1)); so creatureliness and corruptibility do not exclude goodness, and the totality of creation is good (VII. xii(18) – xiii(19)), though finite, time-bound and in need of grace (VII. xv(21)), indeed in need of the completion offered by the incarnation. The incarnation is what Augustine famously confessed he did not find in the Platonists, and the incarnation is indispensable to God's creative purpose because the cause of things is not descent from the One, but ascent from nothingness by the power of God's creative Word.

There is, then, a deep connection between Augustine's reassessment of the problem of evil and his discovery of what it means to be created; that connection lies in the 'nothingness' from which God brought things into being. The doctrine of creation 'out of nothing' is thus fundamental to both Augustine's

[5] Rowan Williams, Creation, in: Allan D. Fitzgerald (ed.), *Augustine through the Ages: An Encyclopedia* (Grand Rapids, 1999), 251-4, 252.

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rejection of Manichaeism and his journey beyond Platonism. The *Confessions* may tell the story of this intellectual journey, but the point of the story is to celebrate what it means to be a creature in the process of being formed according to the will of the Creator. The presence of the final three books simply confirms that assessment. The work as a whole is about knowing God, as also being known by God (1*Cor.* 13:12), being naked before God, who is also the physician of one's most intimate self, and responding to a God of mercy and grace over the course of one's life and in one's day to day existence. That is the subject of Book X, which is by far the longest and has justifiably been called a 'microcosm of the whole work'.[6] Augustine has developed a distinctive spirituality which is rooted in creatureliness. He has reached a clear if contestable philosophical position: the Trinitarian God alone transcends the created, time-bound, changeable but perfectible order, which is as it is because created out of nothing. Creation out of nothing lies at the heart of what it means to live a human life, and so shapes the subject of Augustine's reflections in the *Confessions*.

Second century arguments about creation

To appreciate the significance of this, it is important to realise just how extraordinary the whole notion of creation out of nothing was in the context of ancient philosophical thinking:[7] 'nothing comes from nothing' was a Greek commonplace, and implied that anything coming from nothing is a sham![8] Something must have been there for creation to happen at all. Typical is the view of Plutarch:[9]

> For creation does not take place out of what does not exist at all but rather out of what is in an improper or unfulfilled state ... [This] may be characterised as 'lack of order' (*akosmia*); and this 'lack of order' ... possessed a corporeal nature which was formless and inconstant, and a power of motion which was frantic and irrational.

Everything comes from something, and nothing comes from nothing. So where did this distinctly unhellenic notion of creation out of nothing come from?

Perhaps unexpectedly, it does not seem to have already been an established Jewish idea, simply taken over by Christians. The reasons for rejecting this assumption are, in summary, as follows:

[6] Frederick van Fleteren, *Confessiones*, in A.D. Fitzgerald (1999), 227-232, 231.

[7] What follows is adapted from Frances Young, 'Creatio ex nihilo': a context for the emergence of the Christian doctrine of creation: *Scottish Journal of Theology* 44 (1991) 139-51.

[8] Arnold Ehrhardt, *The Beginning: A study in the Greek philosophical approach to the concept of Creation from Anaximander to St. John* (Manchester, 1968), 166.

[9] *On the Creation of the Soul in the Timaeus* 1014B; quoted by John Dillon, *The Middle Platonists* (London, 1977), 207.

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* The general lack of interest in *creatio ex nihilo* in Jewish tradition prior to the Middle Ages: the Rabbis condemn speculation about creation as much as about the chariot-throne of God![10]
* The sparsity of reference to the doctrine in relevant Jewish texts, and the ambiguity of texts which might seem to anticipate this doctrine.
* The apparently contrary evidence of the Wisdom of Solomon and the works of Philo, confirmed by early Christian writers such as Justin, Athenagoras, Hermogenes and Clement of Alexandria. All seem to adopt without question the Platonic view of an active and passive element, namely God plus matter.[11]
* The lack of emphasis on the idea in Christian literature of the 1st and 2nd centuries, contrasted with its general acceptance from the beginning of the 3rd century, and its increasing impact on other doctrines such as Christology.
* The consistency with which the earliest references to the doctrine, whether Jewish or Christian, appear in the context of debate with philosophy, notably Platonism. Indeed it was clearly on the basis of argument that the doctrine of *creatio ex nihilo* was established.

The classic arguments Augustine rehearses in his own way:

> You made heaven and earth not out of your own self, or it would be equal to your only-Begotten Son and therefore to yourself ... Moreover there was nothing apart from you out of which you could make them ... That is why you made heaven and earth out of nothing (XII. vii(7)).

Tertullian provides the first clear statement of these alternatives: God did not create out of the divine self, nor out of eternal co-existing matter; so if it was neither out of God's self nor out of some-thing, it must have been out of no-thing. The alternatives had been set up and answered differently, it seems, by Hermogenes, a second century Christian described as Platonist, and against whom Tertullian was writing (*Adversus Hermogenem*). Theophilus had reached a similar conclusion somewhat earlier: in *Ad Autolycum* II 4, he criticizes Plato for regarding matter as uncreated, and therefore equal to God, arguing for God's *monarchia*; the word is, of course, ambiguous – it might mean 'sole sovereignty', but could also imply 'sole first principle'. A human artisan creates out of pre-existent material, suggests Theophilus; so there is nothing remarkable about God doing likewise. The power of God is evident in the creation of whatever he wants *ex ouk ontōn*, out of the non-existent. Statements of that kind clearly emerge in debate with Greek philosophy, or with Christians adopting philosophical arguments.

There are, however, verbal anticipations of the formula *ex ouk ontōn*. The question is what did they imply? Is the first reference to creation out of nothing to be found in 2*Macc*. 7:28?

[10] Gerhard May, *Creatio ex Nihilo: The Doctrine of Creation out of Nothing in Early Christian Thought* (ET A. S. Worrall; Edinburgh, 1994; German original, 1978), 23, notes its presence uniquely in Gamaliel II's discussion with a philosopher, recorded in Midrash Genesis Rabbah.

[11] Philo can speak of things being created *ex ouk ontōn*; but this only shows that such an expression was consistent with the view that matter pre-existed.

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I implore you, my child, to look to the heavens and the earth; ... realise that God did not create them from what already existed (*ex ouk ontōn*), and that a human being similarly comes into existence.

Commenting on this and other such passages, Arnold Ehrhardt[12] noted that martyr literature, Jewish and Christian, tended to regard the world as a sham, so implying that the words here follow the Greek assumption that since 'nothing comes from nothing', everything is unreal. More convincing is Gerhard May's exposition:[13] this is a paraenetic reference to God's power, implying no more than that the world came into existence when it previously was not there; it cannot be characterised as a critical move away from the doctrine of God fashioning the world out of eternal matter. Biblical images dominate and the statement is compatible with the human creation 'out of clay' found in *Genesis* 2. The context in *2Maccabees* is God's power to bring life out of death; birth is called in as a parallel mystery:

The Creator of the universe, who designed the beginning of humanity and devised the origin of all, will in his mercy give you back again breath and life ... (*2Macc.* 7:23)

Here there is no 'theory' of creation out of nothing – indeed the wording is not the usual later formula, *ex ouk ontōn*, but rather *ouk ex ontōn*. Similar observations can be made about the earliest Christian references in the New Testament, Hermas, Justin and Irenaeus. Even Origen is ambivalent.

So the dogma 'out of nothing' would seem to be a self-conscious rejection of the craftsman analogy presupposed by a Platonism that took the *Timaeus* as literally speaking of an initial act of creation by the Demiurge. In passing we should note that most Platonists did not so read the *Timaeus*, seeing the model, or as Plato calls it the 'myth', as a description of how things eternally are as they are. It was attractive to both Jewish and Christian philosophers, however, to correlate the *Timaeus* with Genesis, and it seems that Philo could take for granted the notion of unformed, unstable matter while using phrases just like those under discussion: God could conceivably bring into existence things which did not exist before, without such language excluding pre-existent stuff. Even Augustine still distinguishes between the creation of matter out of no-thing and the creation of some-thing out of matter by the imposition of form, though asserting that God did both simultaneously.

The dogma arose, then, in the second century, when not only was the apologetic enterprise engaging with philosophy, but cosmogony was a key element in the debate with gnosticism. The nature of the Demiurge was the prime issue. It was in this situation that the very unhellenic idea of creation out of nothing was forged. It would have a profound effect on the whole of Christian theology, but it took time for its implications to be teased out.

[12] A. Ehrhardt, *The Beginning* (1968), 167.
[13] G. May, *Creatio ex Nihilo* (1994), 6ff.

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The forging of a distinct Christian discourse

At this point I digress from my immediate subject to place my approach in the context of debates about the history of Christian doctrine. I belong to the generation that grew up with courses and textbooks on 'the development of Christian doctrine'. That developed Christian doctrine was not to be found in the scriptures read historico-critically, that one could trace a history in which the major doctrines evolved, was an unquestioned assumption. But might this not be an unquestioned cultural presupposition of modernity rather as Platonism was for the Fathers? Evolution is built into the way we think, affecting our understanding of everything – it is an idea easily transferred from biology and genetics to history and society. Constitutional monarchy developed from a system based on the divine right of kings, just as *homo erectus* evolved from their ape-ancestors. Of course I over-simplify, but it is in order to pose the question: is 'development' or 'evolution' applicable to the realm of ideas?

Recently there has been a reaction against this model, notably in the work of John Behr,[14] who makes a good case for the history of Christian doctrine being the gradual articulation of what was there all the time, from the beginning. Thus he is more in tune with the thinking of the Fathers themselves: patristic prejudice was against novelty and originality, and they would not have been flattered, rather horrified, by our tendency to identify creativity in the thinking of particular individuals. Their instinct was to argue from precedent, appeal to tradition and find the truths they were defending written into the very foundation documents of the Church. As is well known, Athanasius had to defend the use of non-scriptural language in the Arian controversy.

But that fact in itself alerts us to the reality on the ground: new issues demanded new linguistic statements, new discourse, which was forged in the fires of controversy. There is no automatic development or evolution in the realm of ideas, but there is change – there is definition, modification, rejection, construction, as the to-and-fro of debate leads to refinement of language, or change of conviction, or the recognition that consistency demands fresh conception. In the case of Christian doctrine, heresy or different opinion is vital to the story. *Creatio ex nihilo* was not simply inherited from Judaism – it was articulated in the second century struggle to produce an acceptable theological account of cosmogony. I concede to John Behr's approach the fact that the Biblical affirmation of the power and sovereignty of the one true God was a driving force there from the beginning, as was the affirmation that creation arose from God's will to create; but I maintain that the implication of that *monarchia*, namely that God is the 'sole first principle', and its specific consequence, that what has come into being other than God can only be attributed to a divine creativity that produced existent things out of no-thing, was only

[14] John Behr, *Formation of Christian Theology* (2 vols., Crestwood, NY, 2001, 2004).

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articulated in the face of argument with philosophy in a context where gnosticism posed a threat.

Argument produces discourse; which then becomes agreed and accepted as the appropriate statement of doctrine (i.e. what is to be taught). That social acceptance of the right way of putting things is a second key element in the process of formation, for it then acts as a catalyst, setting up the conditions for the new statement or formula to raise questions about other accepted statements or formulae. The Arian controversy was to a large extent driven by the need to correlate the doctrine of *creatio ex nihilo* with Christology. Scripture did not straightforwardly offer a simple answer to what was essentially a new question.

So, debate, both with external and with internal parties, drove doctrines into relationship with one another, demanding that they form a coherent cluster by assimilation to one another. But because this was not simply an intellectual process analogous to individuals arguing with one another in the (post-) modern academy, but rather a social and cultural process, the impact of the acceptance of a new way of expressing a doctrine took time to have effect. *Creatio ex nihilo* seems to have been argued at the turn of the second-third centuries, and then gradually accepted. The Christological consequences became an issue a century later. What I am suggesting here is that it was later still that theologians began to reflect on the consequences of 'creation out of nothing' for a distinctive Christian anthropology and spirituality. So back to my principal subject.

Towards a Christian understanding of Human Being

The Cappadocians first made moves similar to those traced in Augustine's *Confessions*. Gregory of Nyssa in his *De Opificio Hominis* states (XVI 10, 12) that God brings humanity into being for no other reason than that God is good, and that it is from nothing that humanity is created. He insists on the distinction between God who is uncreated and everything else that has come into being, a point highlighted during the course of the Arian controversy. This means that God is immutable, but created nature cannot exist without change – for its very passage from non-existence to existence is a kind of motion and change. But this mutability is not to be understood simply as negative (XXIII 5-XXVff.): if God's power is sufficient to bring things into existence from nothing, then the transformation of that creation is also within divine power. To press this point Gregory challenges first those who suggest matter is co-eternal with God, then those who deny the resurrection. It is well known that Gregory's spirituality expresses itself in terms of eternal *epektasis* and progress. He has indeed taken mutability positively in a way that is arguably unprecedented. Scholarship has tended to relate this to his positive evaluation of God's

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infinity;[15] the *De Opificio Hominis* suggests that 'creation out of nothing' was an equally important driver, as we saw it to be in Augustine.

For Gregory, however, the radical nature of creatureliness is somewhat offset by other aspects of human nature received from scripture and tradition. He affirms our nature as two-fold (XVI 8-10): on the one hand, like to God, on the other, differentiated from God. That two-fold-ness, he believes, is enshrined in the Genesis text, which speaks both of God creating humanity in God's own image, and also of creating them male and female: that second comment differentiates human creatures from the divine, to whom it is inappropriate to attribute maleness or femaleness. So humanity is the mean between two extremes, the divine and the animal. It is true that this leads him to reflect on human being in terms of a psychosomatic whole, and also to envisage the new creation in the resurrection as embodied; but it also keeps in play the Origenist notion of the intellect's kinship to the divine. The challenge for humanity is to make the choice to follow the angelic or divine aspect of human nature and reject the bestial or irrational tendency which arises from the other side of our nature. So Gregory's perception of human creatureliness appears less radical than the position of Augustine in the *Confessions*. This impression is reinforced by Gregory's affirmation of the position of humanity as the crown or 'king' of creation. It is important not to forget that his work is conceived as the continuation of Basil's *Hexaemeron*. For Gregory humanity represents God within the created order, and is given a kind of delegated sovereignty. But humanity is also set in the context of a creation that God calls good so as to enjoy and appreciate it (II). This was a central theme of Basil's work.

So *creatio ex nihilo* not only shifted perspective on human being itself, but also on the natural world. It stimulated wonder and rejoicing in the beauty and harmony of the created order. We cannot deny Robin Lane Fox's observation[16] that fanatical monks cut down sacred groves of trees as nature was de-sacralised, but that destruction is not the whole of the story. It has been argued that empirical science was made possible by a combination of that de-sacralisation and the urge to understand the mind of the one who created such marvels;[17] and that is anticipated in Basil's work. For the really striking thing about the *Hexaemeron* is its general tone of sheer wonder at creation, its affirmation that nothing is superfluous or wrong or out of place, everything contributes to the rich tapestry of the created order and its beauty (*e.g. Hexaemeron* I 11; III 10; VII *passim*; *etc.*). The development of this creation spirituality is grounded in the assertion that God is the sole source: a dualism with matter, or indeed with

[15] *E.g.* Ekkehard Mühlenberg, *Die Unendlichkeit Gottes bei Gregor von Nyssa* (Göttingen, 1966); Ronald E. Heine, *Perfection in the Virtuous Life* (Philadelphia, 1975).

[16] Robin Lane Fox, *Pagans and Christians* (London, 1986), 43-4.

[17] Stanley L. Jaki, *Creator and Cosmos* (Edinburgh, 1980); T.F. Torrance, *Divine and Contingent Order* (Oxford, 1981).

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evil, is absolutely ruled out (II). Creation out of nothing means that this wonderful reality is finite, its beginning implies its end (I 3); but none of it was conceived by chance or without reason (I 6) – it must be looked at *sub specie aeternitatis*, Basil implies. The God who creates and judges is providentially at work in the whole process. The problem with philosophy is precisely its inherent atheism – its failure to rise to knowledge of God through its much ado about explaining nature (I 2). Of Basil's work Gregory Nazianzen affirmed (*Oration* 43.67):

> Whenever I take his *Hexaemeron* in hand and quote its words, I am brought face to face with my Creator; I begin to understand the rationale of creation; I feel more awe than ever I did before...

We conclude by returning to Augustine – for we are left with several questions:

* What about Augustine's response to the natural world as God's creation?
* How far can we treat the *Confessions* as typical, and was his view of human creatureliness really more radical than that of Gregory?
* Wasn't Augustine's anthropology ultimately shaped less by *creatio ex nihilo*, more by original sin?

Prior to writing the *Confessions* Augustine had already addressed the question of creation more than once. Clearly creation was as much a major intellectual issue for him as the problem of evil. In *De Genesi adversus Manichaeos*, written at Thagaste and one of his earliest works, he tackled Manichaean objections to Genesis and offered a spiritualised account of creation. Within five years, and after his ordination as priest in Hippo, he tried to tackle it again by offering a so-called 'literal' exegesis of Genesis, but gave up. After completing the *Confessions*, from 401 to 415 he worked on the 12 books *De Genesi ad litteram*. He returned to creation again in the *City of God*, and again around 420 in a work against an anonymous heretic who attributed the creation of the world to an evil demon. Clearly the treatment in the *Confessions* lies on a trajectory of development in his thinking on the subject. Taking all this into account can we respond to the questions raised?

Augustine rarely celebrates creation in the way Basil does. In his works on Genesis he tends to focus on philosophical and ethical problems; but awkward questions about creation sometimes provoke parallel claims about the beauty and harmony of the whole. In his earliest work refuting the Manichees he faces their challenge concerning the creation of so many animals, many of them pernicious and fearful. He simply asserts that the objectors fail to understand how such creatures are beautiful to their Maker, and that there is a use for them in the management of the universe as a whole. He confesses that he has no idea himself why mice and frogs, flies and worms were created; yet he can see they are all beautiful in their own way. Reflection, he is sure, will reveal how everything is fitted together in harmony: you might find 'more genuine satisfaction when you praise God in the tiny little ant down on the ground, than when you

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are crossing a river high up on an elephant' (I 25(16)-26).[18] To turn to the *City of God*, here Augustine certainly celebrates the natural world, though so much ground is covered that relevant passages get a little submerged. In his long discussions of the faults of paganism, he suddenly affirms (VII 26):[19]

> As for us, what we are looking for is a soul which puts its trust in the true religion and does not worship the world as god, but praises the world as the work of God, and for the sake of God,

namely, the God who made the world. Later (XII 4, 5) he claims that the nature of things in itself, without regard to our convenience or inconvenience, gives glory to the Creator; all nature's substances are good, because they exist, have their own mode of being, and peace and harmony among themselves, a point developed at greater length in his long discussion of what peace is (XIX 12-14). And in his final celebration of the divine generosity in Book XXII, the sheer beauty and utility of the natural creation figures, as well as the wonderful fashioning of the human body.

So to the second question: how typical is the *Confessions*? If we look across the trajectory of Augustine's works, there is much in the earliest reflection on Genesis against the Manichaeans that anticipates what we found in that work: besides figural interpretation of the creation-story, insistence on 'out of nothing' was important to refute Manichaean objections, as was rejection of the craftsman analogy (*e.g.* I 10(6); II 43(29)); and even more significant is the importance of the soul and spirit not being part of God, but made by God (II 10(8); II 43(29)). But Genesis was a challenge for Augustine, and in his *Unfinished Literal Commentary on Genesis*, he asserts at the start that these obscure mysteries mean that questions are more appropriate than affirmations. He kept returning to the fundamental question what really happened – that is what he means by speaking of a literal, as distinct from a prophetic, figural or allegorical, interpretation. His focus is on ensuring that the text is understood in a way appropriate to the eternal, transcendent God. So, for example, in the completed *Literal Commentary on Genesis*, he concludes that the first account of creation, despite its organisation in six days, 'tells of the first moment of creation, in which a single creative act of God called all things into existence in an inchoative state', while 'the second account no longer describes an event on the threshold between time and eternity, but an event within time'.[20] Yet occasionally we do find the same kind of 'programme' as in the *Confessions*: the Word calls back to himself the imperfection of creation, so that it should not be formless but formed;

[18] ET Edmund Hill in: *On Genesis*, The Works of Saint Augustine I.13 (New York, 2002), 57, who confesses that 'elephant' replaces 'beast of burden' to bring out the contrast implied; though, I suggest, it does perhaps emphasise size at the cost of obscuring the point about 'usefulness'.

[19] ET quoted by Henry Bettenson (Harmondsworth, 1972), 287.

[20] E. Hill, Introduction to ET of the *Literal Meaning of Genesis* in (2002), 160.

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and creation imitates the form of the Word, unless it turns away from the Creator and remains formless, imperfect and incomplete (I. ix(4)). Human beings, in particular, are not the sort of things that, once made and left to themselves, could do well by themselves – their good activity is simply to turn to him by whom they were made (VIII 25(12)). Then it is possible for the Creator to form them fully.

But was this sense of creatureliness more radical than that of Gregory Nyssen? Like Gregory, Augustine can speak of human nature as the mean between angels and beasts (*City of God* XII 22), and relate the bodily difference between animals and humans, namely the fact that humankind stands erect (*On Genesis: A Refutation of the Manichees* I 28 (17); *Unfinished Literal Commentary on Genesis* 60; *Literal Meaning of Genesis* VI 22 (12)), to the call to be upright in mind, the intellect being the thing that differentiates human beings from animals and makes them in the image and likeness of God. Augustine, however, speaks of humanity as the mean specifically in relation to Adam – the rest of humanity cannot escape the consequences of Adam's choice. So, in Augustine's mature anthropology, has the Fall replaced the radical sense of creatureliness we observed in the *Confessions*?

The completed *Literal Meaning of Genesis* covers Genesis 1-3 and so engages in depth with the story of Adam and the Fall. This work and the Pelagian controversy undoubtedly brought the later Augustine to focus more on Adam's disobedience; but does this entirely overshadow the importance of creation out of nothing? After all, the story of Adam is only possible because of the mutability of a creature made out of nothing. I want to suggest briefly that there are three features of the *City of God* which show that *creatio ex nihilo* remains a foundational impetus to Augustine's thinking about human being.

The first is the focus on worship; as in the case of the *Confessions*, prayer and praise are fundamental. The true God is to be worshipped rather than false gods, and often Augustine justifies this on the grounds that this God is the Creator of all that is, indeed the Creator of the soul itself (IV 30; V 11; VII 5, 28, 30). That Platonists do not confine worship to the Creator of all, that they do not recognise the createdness of the soul, and that they have wrong ideas about mediation, for Augustine vitiates their otherwise remarkable perception of the truth about the way thing are (VIII *passim*; X 3ff., 20, 24, 31). Giving thanks for existence and life (VII 31), celebrating the good things in human life, appreciating the wonders of the human body and of nature as a motive for praise, recognising the blessings God bestows through creating and transforming human creatures – all this reaches its climax in the final picture of eternal felicity, rest and peace in the city of God (XXII 24, 30).

The second feature I would point to lies in the implicit parallels between the *Confessions'* story of the individual and the *City of God's* history of the whole human race as it unfolds in time. Images of wandering, of exile and of pilgrimage are pervasive, reflecting the restlessness depicted in the *Confessions*. 'There

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is only one unchanging Good,' writes Augustine; 'that is the one, true, blessed God. The things he made are good because they were made by him; but they are subject to change, because they were made not out of his being but out of nothing' (XII 1). Failure to adhere to God is a perversion in the rational nature – for, though changeable, it was created to obtain blessedness by adherence to the unchangeable God. The long history of the two cities illustrates the two tendencies: to turn away from God to self-love, and to allow God's grace to renew and transform.

The third is the eschatology. The very fact of creation out of nothing is the guarantee that God's promises will be fulfilled (*e.g.* XXI 7, 8; XXII 11). All the problems of conceiving a resurrection of the body are answered by reference to the resources of the one who created out of nothing in first place: all things are possible to God – including restoration to the full maturity and completeness of each body, whether one died in infancy, lost stature in old age or limbs in war (XXII 5, 11–7). What is needed is not escape from the body but an imperishable body (XXII 26). The removal of defects will 'arouse the praises of God for his wisdom and compassion, in that he not only created out of nothing but freed from corruption that which he created' (XXII 17). 'We cannot keep silent about the joy of our hope, because of the praise due to God ...' (XXII 21).

I submit then that the doctrine of *creatio ex nihilo* was an important factor in shaping the anthropology of the *Cappadocians* and of Augustine. I am not necessarily implying direct influence, though there is a debate to be had there, and one should not overlook the possible mediating influence of Ambrose, who like Basil composed a *Hexaemeron*. What I do affirm is that coincidence in ideas can occur when the time is ripe, a classic example being the moment when Darwin discovered that Alfred Russel Wallace had independently come up with exactly the same theory of the origin of species as he had. *Creatio ex nihilo*, the great gulf between the Trinity and the created order, the positive potential of mutability, these were ideas that, after the Arian controversy, were seeping into deeper consciousness among Christians of both East and West and affecting the way they thought, not just about Christology, but about human nature. The doctrine of creation was thus a crucial factor in forging a distinctively Christian discourse, reflecting a distinctively Christian sensibility in relation to nature, and a distinctively Christian spirituality in relation to God.

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Soul and Body in Early Christian Thought: A Unified Duality?

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I.

What early Christians thought about body and soul, their origin and destiny has been a thorny subject in recent scholarship. The modern view upon early Christian centuries and the Bible itself is that they paint a monistic and, what is fashionable to call 'holistic' picture of the human person. Frequently the hypothetical anti-dualistic anthropology has been termed 'Biblical' and 'Hebraic'. The reason behind such modern hermeneutic of ancient Christian texts, not least the Bible, which continues to be authoritative for the entire spectrum of modern Christian denominations, all too often appears to be modern anti-otherworldliness and materialist ontology.

The first explicit conciliar formulation, relevant to the relationship between soul and body, and their origin and destiny, appeared in 553, Constantinople II, in some of the 15 anathematismata of the council. These are the anathemas 1, 4, and 11[1]:

'1. If anyone asserts the mythical pre-existence of souls and the monstrous restoration that follows from it, let him be anathema.'

'4. If anyone shall say that the rational beings became cold in divine love and have been bound to dense bodies such as ours and have been called men, while those that have attained the lowest degree of wickedness have shared cold and dark bodies and have become and are called demons and evil spirits: let him be anathema.'

'11. If anyone shall say that the coming judgment means the annihilation of all bodies and that the end of the story will be the immaterial nature and in the future nothing of matter will continue to exist, but only the pure *nous*: let him be anathema.'

Inasmuch as they deny the doctrine of two creations, the first of the bodiless minds and the second of bodies for the fallen minds, as well as the eschatological separation of minds from their bodies, these propositions can rightly be considered as affirming the inseparability of the body and soul. However, it remains to be seen:

[1] *ACO* IV.1, 248-9. The Greek text and a German translation is in Görgemanns-Karpp, *Origenes*, 824-30 (text) and 825-31 (translation). Also Franz Diekamp, *Die Origenistischen Streitigkeiten im sechsten Jahrhundert und das fünfte allegemeine Concil* (Münster, 1899), 93, 23-34.

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1. whether there *was* a wholly consistent doctrine of soul and body in Christian centuries preceding 553; and
2. to what extent early Christian views can be considered anti-dualistic in the sense that they affirmed strictly one entity within humans beings.

Consequently, my task is to investigate how far the modern position of anti-dualism is helpful in understanding early Christian (pre-553) anthropological conceptions with regard to the origin, destiny and the role in this present life of soul and body in human beings.

II. The Origin of Souls and Bodies

Since the Bible was the inspiration and starting point for Christian writers of the centuries that scholars have, in many ways misleadingly, called 'patristic' and its doctrines were binding for all patristic writers, it is to the Bible, and especially the New Testament, that one has to turn first.

In the New Testament the terms 'soul', 'mind', 'spirit', 'heart', 'body' and 'flesh' recur. The diversity of terms points to a conceptual distinction between matter and spirit in the New Testament, so that conceptually at least one cannot keep body and soul entirely together as one entity. There is moreover a clear hierarchy of entities: the spiritual holds the pre-eminence over the physical.

The Origin of Rational Creation

An important angle from which the relationship between the soul and body can be assessed is the manner of their coming into existence.

The Bible contains no explicit teaching on this subject, except that *all* creation was made 'out of nothing', ἐξ οὐκ ὄντων (2*Macc.* 7:28). Many of the ideas that patristic writers developed about the origin of rational creation are based on this passage, as well as the laconic *Gen.* 1:1: 'In the beginning God made the heaven and the earth'.

Different Fathers interpreted this verse in different ways. Thus, Basil of Caesarea maintained that perhaps there were two creative acts: the first, timeless, of the bodiless invisible minds, the angels, which preceded the second, of the embodied minds, that is, humans:

> 'There was some state [of things] older (πρεσβυτέρα) than the birth of the world which is proper to the supercelestial powers (ταῖς ὑπερκοσμίοις δυνάμεσι): the one above time, eternal, invisible ...' (*First Homily on Hexaemeron* 5).

This is a dualistic account, in which some intellects are maintained to be earlier and bodiless, while others posterior and embodied.

Not in an obvious connection with *Gen.* 1.1, the fourth-century author of the Macarian corpus has this to say about the origin of the human soul:

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'... The soul is some great, wondrous and divine work. And it seems [God] created her even before He fashioned the body' (*Coll.* III 26, 7, 9-12).

Here one is confronted with another dualistic model of the soul-body relationship: the better and more divine element of the human composition, the soul precedes the body in its origin and is thus logically independent of it.

Gregory of Nyssa appears to uphold one creative act only. Analogously with Basil, however, Gregory thinks that the angels 'received from the first an immaterial life', whilst humans exist as the soul's 'union with the flesh'. Gregory therefore distinguishes between the intellects that are immaterial and of a higher order of being – and humans, whose souls are embodied. The possibility of a spiritual existence independent of the material order, then, is maintained (See *On the Soul and the Resurrection*, NPNF V 444).

Evagrius Ponticus asserts strictly two separate creative acts: first, the simultaneous creation of all the intellects, followed by the equally instantaneous fashioning of the bodies for them, once the intellects have transgressed. Even though of these, the angelic and demonic bodies were 'spiritual', while the stellar, human and animal ones were 'practical', they *all* sprang into existence simultaneously. Thus we have in *Keph. Gnost.* III 45:

'As one cannot say that any one intellect is older than another, neither are the spiritual bodies older than the practical bodies.'

Evagrius's is a more radical position than those hitherto explored, in that it not only distinguishes between the mind and the body but also explicitly traces the origin of matter and the bodies to a primordial transgression.[2]

By contrast with these representations, Epiphanius of Salamis, in his *Against Heresies* 65.5 (PG 42,20), in what appears to be an anti-Origenist attack, opines that the phrase 'in the beginning' simply means that nothing was created before heaven and earth and that, consequently, there was *one only* creative act, in which the minds and their bodies were fashioned simultaneously.

Thus all but one of these accounts postulate a soul-body or mind-matter duality of some kind which pertains to the origin of the immaterial and material rational creation. The monistic theory of early Christian anthropology founders on those texts that imply the existence of mind irrespective of body. As suggested by Watt[3], the majority of early Christian Greek and Latin views on the origin of the soul allow for the possibility of such existence.[4]

[2] The *Kephalaia Gnostica* is the crucial port of call for this Evagrius's belief. See my argument for this in *Evagrius Ponticus: the Making of the Gnostic* (Ashgate, 2009), Chapter 5.

[3] J.W. Watt, The Syriac Adapter of Evagrius's Centuries: *SP* 17 (1982) 1388-95, esp. 1390. See also his Philoxenus and the Old Syriac Version on Evagrius' Centuries: *Oriens Christianus* 64 (1980) 65-81.

[4] In his defense of Origen, Martyr Pamphilus maintains that, at the time of Origen, the doctrine of the soul's origin had not been finalized: *Defense of Origen*, IX (*PG* 17, 604C-607A). See also Origen, *De Princ.*, Praef. 5.

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III. The Intermediate State: the immediate resurrection theory

As recently pointed out by J. Cooper[5], personal death and resurrection are germane to the problem of early Christian anthropology. In the New Testament and the Fathers there is what appears to be a teaching that presupposes the life of the soul in the so-called intermediate state, after death and prior to the general resurrection. The obvious New Testament passage, on which several patristic writers commented, is *Luke* 24:37-39, the story of the rich man and Lazarus. Upon their demise, their personal and conscious existence continued in Hades, clearly apart from their bodies. It is precisely in this sense that Gregory of Nyssa interpreted the parable in *On the Soul and the Resurrection*, pointing out that both Lazarus and the rich man continued to exist after death 'in their souls' only (NPNF V 444). Both the Gospel text and Gregory's interpretation of it offer a clear endorsement of an anthropology that distinguishes the soul from the body and affirms the pre-eminence of the soul. It is in this sense (and this only) that this anthropology can be termed 'dualistic'.

IV. Eschatology

As far as the eschatological destiny of humankind is concerned, 'eschatological' passages in the New Testament such as 1*Cor.* 15:35 embrace the general bodily resurrection at the end of times. This will come about on the second coming of Christ. 1*Cor.* 15:35ff. treats of the manner in which the bodily resurrection will come to pass and is a text extensively elaborated upon, or at least presupposed, in many a patristic account of the *eschaton*. According to 1*Cor.* 15, the body of the resurrection, while maintaining its numerical identity, will differ from the present physical body in that it will be spiritual and immortal:

15:42-4: 'So also is the resurrection of the dead. ... It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body. There is a natural body and there is a spiritual body.'

Although a clear-cut conclusion about this Pauline model of soul and body at the End of times is elusive, its *prima facie* meaning is that the dead will rise and remain forever *in their bodies*, albeit bodies that are spiritualised and deified. Despite being holistic, this account of the persons of the resurrection also maintains the duality of soul and body: the resurrected bodies are specifically conceptualised as distinct entities. A great number of early interpretations of this text and more general accounts of the resurrection maintain this sense: that the human body, although transformed, is not abolished but enters the glory of the resurrection. To cite just a few theologians of the fourth century, so fertile

[5] John Cooper, Biblical Anthropology and the Body-Soul Problem, in: *Soul Body and Survival: Essays on the Metaphysics of Human Persons*, ed. K. Corcoran (New York, 2001), 218-28.

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in theological and anthropological thinking, such was the opinion of Eusebius of Caesarea (*Ecclesiastical History* V 1, 61, see the account of the Gallic martyrs); Basil of Caesarea; Gregory of Nyssa and Gregory of Nazianzus.

The author of the Macarian corpus may appear to strike a slightly different note when he wonders whether 'in the age to come a release from the bodies (λύσις σωμάτων) will come to pass' (*Coll.* III 3, 1, 4-5). Here he seems to come close to the position of quasi monism, abjured by the 553 propositions. This speculation, however, is balanced out by Macarius's theology of the deified bodies of the saints in the Kingdom and of the glorious body of the Lord on Mount Thabor (*Coll.* II 15, 38; *Matth.* 17:1-8; *Mark* 9:1-10):

'As the body of the Lord, when he went up onto the mountain, was glorified and transfigured into the divine glory and infinite light, so also are the bodies of the saints glorified and resplendent. For just as the inner glory of Christ covered his body and shone forth, so, in the same way, on that day, the power of Christ which the saints [now] have within, will be poured out upon their bodies.'

This latter account of the resurrection contrasts with some of the statements obtained in the *Kephalaia Gnostica* of Evagrius Ponticus. Thus:

'As the first trumpet announced the birth of bodies, so the last trumpet will announce the destruction of bodies.' (*Keph. Gnost.* III 66; see 1*Cor.* 15:52-3)

In this *kephalaion*, Evagrius appears to solve the dilemma of the incorruptibility and immortality of the resurrection by actually removing what he construes as the direct consequence of sin and the prerequisite of corruption: the body itself. Consequently, Evagrian hermeneutic of 1*Cor.* 15:52-3 above jars with the overall consensus and in truth probably *was* the target of the 553 *anathemata*. It is noteworthy, however, that Evagrius's is the only eschatological model that approaches anything like monism: the eschatological body proceeds to become spiritualised to such a degree as to disappear altogether.

V. This Present Life

A final consideration relates to anthropological models and theories of what constitutes *eudemonia* in this present life. I shall argue that a holistic duality in anthropological representations is clearly attested in early Christian writings. Thus the author of the *Macariana* portrays being in terms of the form-content dualism: the visible present realities (τὰ παρόντα) correspond but also differ from the invisible realities of the age to come (τὰ μέλλοντα): I 52, 2, 2-3; III 6, 3, 2. The invisible and spiritual will eventually supersede the visible and physical (II 52, 1, 1-4).

Most early Christian anthropological accounts contain a conceptual duality between the mind and the body, the former holding pre-eminence over the latter. To cite but one name, Gregory of Nyssa avers that the mind is superior

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to 'our material part' (*On the Making of Man* XI 11), because the body is held together and receives its beauty not from itself but from nature. By contrast, the mind '*itself* ... has its power of being beautiful and good' (XI 11).

A number of New Testament texts themselves embraced a similar hierarchical duality. In the Apostle Paul, the contrast between, on the one hand, the true self, and on the other hand, the body, may be interpreted in terms of a distinction between the immortal soul and the body that is subject to decay and is an outward manifestation of the fallenness of the human race: 'Who will deliver me from the body of this death?' exclaims the Apostle rhetorically (*Rom.* 7:24). The analogous rhetoric of a flight and deliverance from the body while still in this life was popular in many Christian ascetic writers. The names of Origen, Gregory the Nazianzen and Evagrius Ponticus spring to mind.

Finally, the very principle of distinguishing between the person – and the bodily organism that *belongs* to the person is in one form or another present in major Late Antique writers and is a dual principle. The all-important Chalcedonian doctrine of the Christological union is based on this juxtaposition.

Conclusion

In response to modern critics in quest of monism in early Christianity, the answer is that it is hard to come by. Can the monk-bishop or the ascetic theologian seriously be blamed for advocating the mortification of the flesh as well as soul and the flight of both from the pleasures of this world? More generally, polarities are inherent in the beliefs about God and the world, matter and spirit, vice and virtue, and fall and salvation. Inasmuch as all ascetic discourse embraces the idea of the progress from the lower pole to the higher, a dualism is involved that is not to the taste of the modern mind. To be sure, this dualism is holistic. Nevertheless, that this dualism was normative in antiquity is demonstrated by conciliar condemnations of those writings that experimented with theories of the body's radical eschatological absorption into the higher principle.

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How the Early Christians Discovered the Soul

Stefanie FROST, Göttingen

The title contains two informations: In my paper, I am going to say something about the early Christians, and I am going to speak about the soul. More precisely: My general idea is to examine the Christians up to the turn of the second to the third century, particularly in regard to their anthropology, which is concentrated in the concept of the soul.

The soul understood as the entirety of all mental capacities or forces probably goes back to Pindar in the 6th century; but definitely since Plato and Aristotle the soul is understood as the totality of mental activities and abilities – and then not as a conglomerate notion for different capacities, but rather as a unifying entity. That this unity can be thought of in a differentiated way, is easy to see in the famous tri-partition of the soul by Plato in λογιστικόν, θυμοειδές and ἐπιθυμητικόν, e.g. in the *Politeia* (439d-441b). What Plato had said, first of all in the *Timaios*, but also in the *Phaidros* and *Phaidon*, about the genesis of both the World soul and the individual soul, was taken by the so called middle Platonists as authoritative. They tried to harmonize the discrepancies, which they found in the writings of Plato – for example, in *Phaidros* (246a) the soul is described as ingenerate (ἀγένητον), in *Timaios*[1] as generate.

Analysing this debate, Werner Deuse found two central questions: First, what is the relation between soul and *nous*, and second, how is it possible to talk about rational and irrational parts of the soul, when the soul is one unity?[2]

Now let us have a look at the Christians of the second century. In the Bible the notion of the 'soul' turns up only marginally. When it turns up, ψυχή predominantly has the meaning of 'life', as 'soul' does not seem to mean man himself as in spirit and mind, but as entirety of all that the human being is. This would correspond to the thesis that the Bible refers to the monistic understanding of man, going back to Hebrew thinking as it can be found in the Old Testament, even in its later parts and also in the New Testament. But there are a few passages which can be seen as more or less Hellenistic – that is to say, dualistic, as far as anthropology is concerned. An example for this is 1*Peter* 1:9. There one can find the phrase σωτηρίαν ψυχῶν. Does 'soul' here mean the

[1] In 34c, Plato first describes the genesis of the World soul, and then, 41d, how the individual soul is made in the same way.

[2] See Werner Deuse, *Untersuchungen zur mittelplatonischen und neuplatonischen Seelenlehre* (Mainz, 1983), 3.

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human being as it is by itself over and against God ('das menschliche Selbst im Gegenüber zu Gott'[3]), which would then lead one to think of elements of Hellenistic anthropology – and this means dualistic conceptions – in Christian thinking? Already Schweizer called 1*Peter* 2:11 the most Hellenistic ψυχῆ-passage in the NT.[4]

These remarks highlight two notions, which in modern languages can be called 'philosophy' and 'theology'. In the language of the early Christians, one would have to look for other terms. But whatever these are, the question of the relation of the two notions arises. To be clear: I am not concerned with the question as to which topics of doctrine the Christians thought compatible with contemporary philosophy and therefore tried to express them in proper philosophical language. Rather I want to ask, if and how issues concerning the Christian faith were in fact initialized by and grew out of the early Christian discussion with the philosophy of that time.

Speaking about the soul there is one question which must be considered: Is the soul regarded as the highest entity in the human being?[5] Is the soul alone seen as the highest entity, involving or being constituted by mental activities, or whether there is another mental ability separate from and in addition to it – called νοῦς or πνεῦμα? Therefore one can ask the question, whether man is understood by way of a dichotomy or a trichotomy. My question is: What do these two models of division of man mean for the conception of the soul?

If one supposes that there is something higher (or beyond) the soul, then a new problem arises – both in the Christian and the pagan debate: Firstly the question, to what extent this is thought of as human or as divine,[6] and furthermore the question of the relationship between νοῦς and πνεῦμα or between *animus* or *mens* and *spiritus* respectively. In this paper, I cannot talk about similarities or differences between νοῦς and πνεῦμα, but the problem of human *versus* divine shall be mentioned at the end.

Let us look at Aristotle as a prominent position in the pagan debate. In his analysis of the soul he talks about the νοῦς, describing it as part of the soul

[3] See Reinhard Feldmeier, *Der erste Brief des Petrus* (Leipzig, 2005), 61.

[4] See Eduard Schweizer, *ThWNT* IX (1973), 635-57, 653: '[...] am stärksten hellenisierte ψυχῆ-Stelle des Neuen Testaments'.

[5] I am not talking about the soul-body-relationship here. One can consult Cicero to get an idea of the discussions regarding the relationship between soul and body. See Cicero, *Tusculanae* I §18: *sunt enim qui discessum animi a corpore putent esse mortem; sunt qui nullum censeant fieri discessum, sed una animum et corpus occidere, animumque in corpore extingui. qui discedere animum censent, alii statim dissipari, alii diu permanere, alii semper. quid sit porro ipse animus aut ubi aut unde, magna dissensio est.*

[6] Literature: Wolf-Dieter Hauschild, *Gottes Geist und der Geist des Menschen: Studien zur frühchristlichen Pneumatologie* (München, 1972); W.-D. Hauschild / Volker Henning Drecoll, *Pneumatologie in der Alten Kirche*, Traditio Christiana XII (Bern, 2004); Franz Dünzl, *Pneuma: Funktionen des theologischen Begriffs in frühchristlicher Literatur*, Jahrbuch für Antike und Christentum, Ergänzungsband 30 (Münster, 2000).

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(μόριον)[7]. In *De anima* III 5 he asks, if and to what extent the mind can be thought of as separate from the body, and he describes the νοῦς ποιητικός as separate (χωριστός). Already in *De anima* I 4, Aristotle has described the mind as impassible and divine – in this first book 'mind' is yet undifferentiated. The Aristotle-commentator Alexander of Aphrodisias, about 200,[8] has elaborated on this idea. He distinguishes between several types of νοῦς (δυνάμει νοῦς – καθ' ἕξιν νοῦς – νοῦς ποιητικός), and he declares the νοῦς ποιητικός divine and of exterior provenience within the human mind (νοῦς θύραθεν).[9] In support of this there is the famous passage from *De generatione animalium* (736b 27f.), where Aristotle describes the intellect as νοῦς θύραθεν.

Let us now turn to Tertullian. In his book *De anima* he makes it clear that he does not like to think of an impassible and divine intellect as being separate; rather, in chapter 12 he criticizes the separation of an active principle, which takes effect in the human being. Against Aristotle he defines the intellect (*animus*) as passible and as a function (*officium*) of the soul. He has a lively interest to conserve the unity of soul and mental abilities. As a consequence of accepting faith the soul – through baptism – marries the Holy Spirit (ch. 41).[10] Tertullian therefore defines the human being as composed of body and soul (including *animus*), with the *spiritus* being joined later, see his chapter 11.6.

Needless to say that Tertullian's interest in the unity of the soul is directed not only against Aristotle, but also against Valentinus. In ch. 21 he rejects the tri-partition of the soul of man (not only of classes of human beings)[11] in a material, a psychic and a spiritual part (*materiale, animale, spiritale*) – because, he argues, there is no tri-partition of the soul in Adam, with material and spiritual activities appearing later. Against Valentinus rather than Aristotle, Tertullian contrasts divine grace and nature, describing grace as more powerful than nature (ch. 21.6). But in order to describe the human being not as a helpless victim of higher powers, he brings in free will, the *libera potestas arbitrii* or the αὐτεξούσιον. Free will is the natural partner of grace.

[7] *E.g. De anima* III 4 429a 10.

[8] Alexander taught peripatetic philosophy in Athens 198-211.

[9] See Paul Moraux, *Der Aristotelismus bei den Griechen von Andronikos bis Alexander von Aphrodisias. Bd. 3: Alexander von Aphrodisias* (Berlin / New York, 2001), 346-53, 375-85.

[10] The metaphor of marriage makes clear, that Tertullian wants to assume the whole person as saved. See *De anima* 41,4, ed. Jan Hendrik Waszink, (Amsterdam, 1947), 57,34-58,1: *Sequitur animam nubentem spiritui caro, ut dotale mancipium, et iam non animae famula, sed spiritus.*

[11] This is how J.H. Waszink interprets Tertullian, *De anima* 21,1, ed. J.H. Waszink (Amsterdam, 1947), 29,21-4: *Quodsi uniformis natura animae ab initio in Adam ante tot ingenia, ergo non multiformis, quia uniformis, per tot ingenia, nec triformis, ut adhuc trinitas Valentiniana caedatur, quae nec ipsa in Adam recognoscitur.* Thereto J.H. Waszink (Amsterdam, 1947), 292: 'The first sentence becomes clear only, if we keep in mind the end of the preceding chapter. When contending that the nature of the soul "is not multiform", Tert. means to say that of all existing souls there are no different classes; he does not attack the view that a single soul may be multiform (for the rest, this view would be still more unacceptable to him).'

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This reasoning is in this passage, however, not in itself conclusive, because after having separated the spirit from the nature of the soul of man, Tertullian cannot explain, how the free will as part of human nature is able to turn itself to what is higher. For an explanation of the existence of a natural free will, Tertullian refers here (ch. 21.6) to other writings.

A combination of Valentinian anthropology and a discussion of the free will can also be found in Irenaeus, *Adversus haereses* I 6.1.[12] Irenaeus here reports on the gnosis of Ptolemaeus, a pupil of Valentinus, concerning the material, the psychic and the pneumatic. The psychic, so Irenaeus tells us, is supposed to tend into the direction of the pneumatic – because it is αὐτεξούσιον. He then explains (I 6.2) that the followers of Ptolemaeus call the 'Church people' psychics, while they call themselves pneumatics. Through this, it becomes clear that the distinction Irenaeus made in the beginning, is a distinction into differentiated classes of men rather than a distinction within the human self.

Let me sum up, so far: While here, where he is, according to his statement, merely reporting about Valentinian positions, Irenaeus speaks of a tri-partition of different classes of men in material, psychic and pneumatic;[13] instead, in V 6.1 and V 9.1, where he gives his own position, he speaks about the individual human being as consisting of flesh, soul and spirit (*caro, anima, spiritus*), who will be saved in his entirety.

While Irenaeus sees natural man as consisting of body and soul, every human being is destined to be connected with the spirit. Therefore it is the soul, which according to Irenaeus decides the fate of man; for if the soul follows the spirit as its leader (*subsequens spiritum*), man will be saved, but if the soul tends towards the flesh, man will be entangled by the passions (V 9.1).[14]

Let me conclude: Both Tertullian and Irenaeus are interested in free choice – the so called αὐτεξούσιον. As far as Tertullian is concerned, it does not quite fit with his arguments, because he is strongly interested in both – in the unity of soul and in the separation of the spirit. Seeing man, however, from the perspective of a trichotomy with the soul in the middle position, the soul can easily be described as the decisive entity between the categories of spirit and matter.

[12] See Irenaeus, *Adv. haer.* I 6.1, ed. Norbert Brox, Fontes Christiani 8/1 (Freiburg, 1993), 162.

[13] It is still debated, whether the so called Gnostics, or at least some of them really assumed different classes of men, as formulations like διὰ τὸ φύσει of Irenaeus (I 6.2) or Clement (*Strom.* 2.3; 2.20; 4.13; 5.1) suggest, or if there is the possibility for every person to be saved. Therefore, see Jens Holzhausen, Zur Seelenlehre des Gnostikers Herakleon, in: Jens Holzhausen (ed.), *Psyche – Seele – anima: Festschrift für Karin Alt* (Stuttgart/Leipzig, 1998), 279-300, 280.

[14] *Adv. haer.* V 9.1, ed. Norbert Brox, Fontes Christiani 8/5 (Freiburg, 2001), 74, 12-8: *Perfectus homo constat, carne, anima et spiritu, et altero quidem salvante et figurante, qui est Spiritus, altero quod salvatur et formatur, quod est caro, altero quod inter haec est duo, quod est anima: quae aliquando quidem subsequens Spiritum, elevatur ab eo; aliquando autem consentiens carni, decidit in terrenas concupiscentias.*

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There is only time for a short remark regarding the question, whether the spirit (πνεῦμα) is something which belongs to the human being from creation, or whether it appears only later – with baptism.

When talking about Irenaeus, I have underscored the middle position of the soul. This is true for the complete and perfect being (τέλειος, *perfectus*). There are passages, where he describes the human being as composed of body and soul. For example II 13.3: *compositi natura et ex corpore et anima subsistentes*,[15] yet man is destined to be connected with the spirit. Therefore he quotes 1*Thess.* 5:23: 'may your spirit and soul and body (τὸ πνεῦμα καὶ ἡ ψυχὴ καὶ τὸ σῶμα) be preserved in entirety' – a verse on whose exegesis there is still disagreement, since we are generally not ready to attribute to Paul an understanding of man in terms of a trichotomy. On the basis of this verse, Irenaeus describes the complete human being as someone, in whom the spirit dwells and remains (V 6.1).

While it certainly can be called a commonplace in early Christian tradition that the spirit is being conferred through baptism, one can find passages, there as well as in the New Testament, where πνεῦμα means an anthropological entity, and not only breath. The essential question here is not, whether the spirit lives in the human being from creation or from baptism, but rather the question, how the soul is to be understood. What I wanted to show is, that from the viewpoint of a trichotomy, it is the soul which, because of its intermediary position is the decisive entity to ascertain the state of the whole human being.

[15] See *Adv. haer.* III 22.1; V 8.2.

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Graeco-Roman Origins of the Idea of Moral Conscience

Richard SORABJI, Oxford

1. Prospectus

The idea of conscience[1] started in ancient Greek thought as the idea of awareness of one's own fault or weakness, then of one's own faultlessness and even, especially in Roman texts, of one's own merit. The expression used for conscience also covered the idea of awareness of the fault, faultlessness, or merit of another person. But it was still the idea of *individual* fault, faultlessness, or merit. Although there was an idea of right or wrong in general, and indeed of a natural law of right or wrong, it was not directly connected with expressions for conscience. Saint Paul was innovating, then, when he connected an expression for conscience closely with the idea of a general *law* of right and wrong. It has been held that the idea of conscience presupposes the idea of law,[2] and that the idea of moral right and wrong presupposes the idea of a lawgiver.[3] But examples are given as early as the playwrights of the fifth century BCE of awareness of wrong in oneself, where the wrong seems to include a moral element and where the words used are those that later meant conscience. This is inspite of the fact that the examples are not connected with the idea of divine or natural law, even though that idea was already available. I am not saying that the wrong is distinguished by these writers as moral, but that it would be hard for us to write off the feelings portrayed as wholly non-moral. I shall come shortly to the illustrative examples of Jason, Orestes and others.

Paul's innovation of connecting an expression for conscience with *law* did nonetheless make a big difference in two ways. The first was by connecting the words for conscience with a more *general* knowledge of right and wrong instead of with *individual* fault or faultlessness. The second, which sprang from that, expanded the roles that the words for conscience could play. The idea of *acting*

[1] This is a first contribution towards work on a projected book on changing ideas of moral conscience through the ages. The writings I have found most useful on antiquity are C.A. Pierce, *Conscience in the New Testament* (London, 1955) and above all Henry Chadwick, *Studies on Ancient Christianity* (Aldershot, 2006), Chapter XX = the original English text, with revisions, of art. Gewissen: *Reallexikon für Antike und Christentum* 7 (Bonn, 1969), 663-711. I have had very helpful discussions with Charles Kahn and Phillip Mitsis. Other acknowledgements will be made below.

[2] M. Waldemann, Synteresis oder syneidesis?: *Theologische Quartalschrift* 119 (1938) 332-71.

[3] G.E.M. Anscombe, Modern moral philosophy: *Philosophy* 33 (1958) 1-19.

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from conscience was found as early as the fifth century playwright Sophocles, when he made Antigone appeal to divine laws (*nomima*) of unknown origin that are not of today or yesterday, like the king's proclamation, but are eternal and require her to bury her brother against that edict.[4] Here conscience is not merely *punishing* or *averting* wrong action, because Antigone was never tempted to wrong action; it is positively *directing* to right action. But although she speaks of *laws*, the words for awareness of possible or actual fault were not yet extended to cover Antigone's awareness of the right action to which, as we would say, her conscience was directing her. Saint Paul's connexion between the standard words for conscience and *law* grouped such direction towards the right along with punishment of, or aversion from, the wrong as a further function of conscience.

Paul also had other important things to say about conscience. But he still did not have occasion to say very much, and there was even less in the Old Testament. The Hebrew does not speak of conscience at all, and it is only the Greek version which substitutes the word for 'conscience' in place of 'heart' at *Job* 27:6, when the Hebrew says 'My heart does not reproach me', and in the apocryphal *Wisdom of Solomon* 1.7.11. It was sometimes the Latin versions which substituted 'conscience' for 'heart'.[5] 'Heart' was the Hebrew word for the seat of many psychological states, and 'conscience' was superimposed on the Hebrew or Greek to make the reference more precise. A major theme will be that given the comparative shortage of explicit Biblical reference to conscience, the Church Fathers had to fill in the gaps left in Scripture perhaps more than usual by drawing on Graeco-Roman thought.

The words that became standard in Christianity for conscience were appropriate because they already had the connexion with *some* functions of conscience: awareness of one's own fault or faultlessness. But in the Graeco-Roman tradition they could only sometimes be translated in terms of conscience, for several reasons. First, the fault or weakness recognised was only sometimes a moral one, secondly the fault was sometimes recognised as being in someone *else*, and thirdly when the reflexive pronoun 'oneself' was not explicit, the awareness did not necessarily have to be of a fault, faultlessness, or merit at all.

2. The construction of terms for conscience in Greek and Latin

Homer did not yet use the terms that became standard for conscience, but he often illustrates awareness of fault. His is commonly called a culture of shame,

[4] Soph., *Antigone* 450-7.

[5] This happens when Thomas Aquinas, *On Truth*, Q.17, a.1 difficulties, first series, 7 and Q. 17, a. 3, to the contrary 1, reads the Latin 'conscientia' in place of the Hebrew 'heart' at *Eccl.* 7:22, and Rufinus' Latin translation of Origen in 2.9 of his *Commentary on Romans* 2.14-5 (PG 14, 893) substitues 'conscience' for the Greek 'heart' in the quotation of 1*John* 3:21.

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not guilt, and the difference has been explained in one account by saying[6] that the person who is ashamed is thinking about what sort of person he is, typically in relation to the imagined contempt of others concerning his deficiencies, but sometimes, as I think the account agrees, in relation to his own self-image. The deficiencies include non-moral ones like poverty. The person who feels guilt, by contrast, is typically thinking more narrowly about a victim and justified recrimination. So far this account in terms of a victim omits the idea of a divine lawgiver, and it is true that the generality of a law is not needed for moral guilt. But another source of guilt, I believe, is thought about violation of divine command or will and divine disapproval, whether or not there is a victim. I agree with a further claim in this account that, although the Greeks do not distinguish guilt from shame, the situations which provoke shame in the Greek portrayals in some cases provoke also the attitudes which we distinguish as guilt. Later interest in guilt never entirely displaced interest in shame, because even a Christian may be led by guilt to feel that he or she is a bad person and may expect to be judged as such at the Last Judgement.

The verb that was used for conscience in Greek of the fifth century BCE meant literally: to share knowledge with *oneself*, *syneidenai heautôi*, of a fault or weakness. The idea is an unexpected one, that one is split into two people, one of whom knows the defect or weakness and has had to share it with the other. Conjectures have been made, which I believe to be mistaken, that the original meaning in the Greek, or in the Latin equivalent, must have been a simpler one of sharing knowledge with *another*, for example of God's sharing someone *else's* guilty knowledge as a witness, or even, as Thomas Aquinas suggested,[7] of applying one's general knowledge of right and wrong to something *else*, namely, to a particular situation. The meaning of witnessing another's failing, we shall see, did come to be common later. But it is not the meaning when reference to *oneself* is explicit, or clearly understood, as it already is in plays of the fifth century BCE. It is used by the comic playwright Aristophanes three times, with the reference to oneself explicit, and by the tragedian Euripides twice, with the reference to self understood.[8] In Aristophanes, people share knowledge with themselves of infidelity after three days of marriage, and of having set a defendant free by giving the wrong vote, and an ironical suggestion is made that someone will not succeed in politics if he shares knowledge with himself of having done anything good. In Euripides the knowledge shared with self is Orestes' self-knowledge (described as a sickness) of murder and Jason's (insisted on by Medea) of his breaking his marriage oath to her.

[6] B. Williams, *Shame and Necessity* (Berkeley, 1993), 88-94 and Appendix 1.

[7] Thomas Aquinas, *STh*, Ia, Q.79, a.13, Reply. See Douglas Langston, *Conscience and Other Virtues* (Philadelphia, 2001), 8, 92.

[8] Aristoph., *Wasps* 999-1002; *Thesmophoriazousae* 477; *Knights* 184 (where 'good' is ironical for 'bad'); Eurip., *Medea* 495; *Orestes* 395-6.

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It is here that I see moral guilt as included along with shame. Jason's breaking his marital oath, Orestes' murder of his mother, Aristophanes' case of marital infidelity after three days all involve a victim, and one at least invites divine disapproval. Jason has violated his oath to the gods, who side with Medea. Moreover, even if the divine Furies that pursue Orestes are presented by Euripides as mere delusions of a man sick with knowledge of his misdeed, we may have a phenomenon to which attention has been drawn in a discussion cited above,[9] that a feeling about moral wrong can linger even after the theological backing for it has disappeared.

Euripides also distinguishes good and bad shame (*aidôs*). The good shame should avert one's wrongdoing, the bad torments one for it. But Phaedra is made to lament that the occasion for acting on the good shame is not clear.[10] If one fancies one's step son, so we might illustrate her complaint, the good shame should warn one not to enter his bedroom to tell him that breakfast is ready. Good shame (*aidôs*) and the virtue of heeding good shame (*aidêmosynê*) become a prominent subject in the Stoic Epictetus in the first century AD.[11]

In all nine cases where Plato uses the full expression 'to share knowledge with oneself', he is referring to knowledge of one's own fault or weakness, although the faults are less connected with guilt than in the playwrights.[12] Socrates shares knowledge with himself of his own ignorance, Alcibiades of self-neglect and disobeying Socrates, Cephalus of faultlessness: of *not* having committed injustice, others of being seduced by poetry, of being unduly hasty or precipitate, of speaking well only of Homer and of their feeble attempts in childhood to distinguish letters from each other. Four times Plato speaks of sharing knowledge with *another* person usually about their bad actions, but once about their talents, and once about whether they will take the course of action that has just been praised as the only acceptable one.[13] In one of these cases in *The Laws*, Plato uses the reflexive pronoun 'themselves', presumably

[9] G.E.M. Anscombe (1958).

[10] Eurip., *Hippolytus* 380-7, as analysed by B. Williams, *Shame and Necessity* (Berkeley, 1993), 95.

[11] Rachana Kamtekar, *Aidôs* in Epictetus: *Classical Philology* (1998) 136-60: Epict., *Discourses* 1.5.3-5; 2.8.23; 3.7.27; 4.5.22-3; *frg.* 14, with Diog. Laert., *Lives* 7.116; Stob., *Eclogae* 2.61 (Wachsmuth), 10-11; Ps.-Andron., *On Emotions*, in: H. Von Arnim (ed.), *Stoicorum Veterum Fragmenta* 3.432.

[12] Plato, *Apology* 21B 4 and 22D 1 (Socrates' claim to know nothing in the second passage supports my interpretation of the first as expressing awareness of not being wise, rather than mere non-awareness of being wise. I thank Christopher Taylor for the query); *Phaedrus* 235C 7 (aware of own ignorance in all three passages so far); *Symposium* 216A 3; B 3 (aware of self-neglect and mistaken disobedience to Socrates); *Republic* 331A 2 (aware of no injustice in self); *Republic* 607C 6 (aware that seduced by poetry [reading: *hautois*]); *Laws* 773B 1 (aware that unduly hasty and precipitate); *Ion* 553C 5 (aware that others say I speak well only about Homer); *Theaetetus* 206A 2 (aware of youthful attempts to distinguish letters [a weakness, not a fault]).

[13] Plato, *Laws* 870D 2; *Apology* 34B 5; *Euthyphro* 4C; *Symposium* 193E 4; *Protagoras* 348B 7.

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to emphasise that the person with whom one shares the guilty knowledge shares it also with himself.

Surprisingly, the construction is reproduced in Latin through the adjective *conscius* – sharing knowledge with. One can say that a person *is* sharing-knowledge-with *himself*. Very early on, the Roman comic playwrights, Plautus in the third century BCE and Terence in the second, speak in Latin of sharing knowledge. Terence has a character say, 'I am sharing knowledge with myself that this fault (*culpa*) is far from me'. Plautus speaks of sharing knowledge of guilt with *another* person picked out by the reflexive pronoun: 'Beware that they do not share knowledge with yourself (*ipsi*) of your wrongdoing'.

The Latin tradition is continued by Cicero in the first century BCE and by the Stoic Seneca in the first century CE. Each speaks of sharing knowledge with oneself of a fault or of its absence,[14] although the reflexive pronoun is not always explicit. Each also speaks of sharing knowledge of guilt with *another* party, and here they do not use the reflexive pronoun. The other party may be gods or humans, and, if humans, may be an accomplice, a confidant or a witness, and even inanimate room walls are imagined as being witnesses.[15] Seneca can use the full reflexive expression 'sharing knowledge with myself' in regard to desires of his that he approves, and the version without reflexive for his wife's sharing knowledge of his approved custom of self-interrogation.[16]

A useful collection has been made to illustrate the usage of Cicero and Seneca by Dr Hebing.[17] He finds the use of *conscius* to refer to *another* party is rare in Seneca, but common in Cicero. I am not sure that the proportion of references to *another* in Seneca[18] is much different from that in Plato, Aristotle's corpus (one at Ps.-Aristotle, *Magna Moralia* 1.25, 1192a 26 against three references of the verb to self in genuine Aristotle)[19], or the Latin comic playwrights. But for the undoubted frequency in Cicero I think there is a reason: he was a lawyer and so was for ever having to discuss whether *another* party was guilty or innocent. Nonetheless, he often enough refers, even without the reflexive pronoun 'oneself', to sharing knowledge with oneself of fault or faultlessness, when he talks about averting or deterring bad conduct and about clear, joyful or bad conscience.

[14] *E.g.* Cicero, *On Duties* 3.18.73; Seneca, *On Anger* 1.20.3.

[15] Witness, *e.g.* Cicero, *Pro Caelio* 60 (room walls); Seneca, *frg.* 14; *accomplice e.g.* Cicero, *Tusculan Disputations* 2.13.31; 2.22.52; Seneca, *On Mercy* 1.9.2; *On Anger* 2.23.1; *Confidant*, Cicero, *Letters to Atticus* 1.18.1; gods, Cicero, *On Ends* 1.16.51.

[16] Seneca, *Letters* 71.76; *On Anger* 3.36.3.

[17] J. Hebing, Ueber conscientia und conservatio im philosophischen Sinne bei den Römern von Cicero bis Hieronymus: *Philosophisches Jahrbuch* 35 (1922) 136-52, 215-31, 298-326. I am grateful to J. Wisse, for first advising me on Cicero.

[18] To Hebing's Seneca, *On Mercy* 1.9.2, *On Anger* 2.23.1, I would add *frg.* 14.

[19] Aristotle, *History of Animals* 9.29, 618a 26; *Nicomachean Ethics* 1.4, 1095a 25; *Rhetoric* 2.5, 1382b 6.

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More ambiguous is the noun in Greek and Latin, because it cannot combine with the reflexive pronoun 'oneself'. The Greek (*syneidêsis, to syneidos*) can mean conscience, but can also refer to consciousness of quite neutral things, while *synesis* can simply mean understanding. A fourth noun used for conscience, *syngnôsis* occurs only once. The Latin noun *conscientia* has the same ambiguities.

3. Uses of conscience

The uses of conscience are very various. There is the *punishment* of a tormenting conscience, aversion of bad conduct in oneself, or deterrence in another. Conscience can produce repentance and hence reform, or reunion with God, or on a Christian view, remission of sin. Opposed to bad conscience was the satisfaction of a clear conscience, or even the joy of a good conscience.

Punishment was a particular interest of the Greek comic and tragic playwrights of the fifth century BCE, mentioned above. It will recur below in the discussion of Epicurus' philosophy and of the reinterpretation of the Furies and Hell as the torments of conscience. Another role is that of *aversion* of bad conduct. Aversion through shame featured above in Euripides' presentation of Phaedra, although the words for conscience were not used. Cicero describes the Aristotelian school as valuing conscience because of the 'bites' by which it averts bad conduct, and the 'bites' of conscience are discussed by Plutarch, although in a more severe form for someone who has already done wrong.[20] Bites of conscience are repeatedly taken up by Christians and still mentioned by Kant.[21] Deterrence of bad conduct in others is supposed, on one interpretation of Epicurus which will be encountered below, to work through something more savage than 'bites', the evildoers' fear of torments from their own conscience.

Aversion is a negative function, and one might expect conscience to play also the positive function of *directing* people to certain actions. I have already said, however, that Antigone is indeed directed in Sophocles' play of that name to bury her brother in defiance of the king's command, but the words for conscience are not used there. The emphasis on averting rather than directing may provide a parallel with what Socrates says in Plato's *Apology* 31D-32A about his guardian spirit or daemon, that it only opposes actions and does not command them.

Seneca approves Epicurus for saying that recognition of sin (*notitia peccati*) is the beginning of salvation. Seneca regards it as leading to a desire for *correction* and *reform* (*emendare*).[22] A similar valuation of *repentance* is attributed,

[20] Cicero, *Tusc.* 4.45; Plutarch, *On Tranquillity* 476F-477A.
[21] I. Kant, *Lectures recorded by Vigilantius on Metaphysics of Morals*, Works of Kant, 27. 618.
[22] Seneca, *Letter* 28, 9-10.

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rightly or wrongly, to Epicurus' forbear Democritus in the fifth century BCE: 'Repenting of shameful deeds is the salvation of life'.[23] But Cicero is quoted by the Christian Lactantius, writing in the third century CE in his *Divine Institutes*,[24] as not thinking repentance (*paenitere*) to be an effective route to reform (*corrigere errorem*). Lactantius disagrees. We think that chidren who repent are reformed (*correcti*). Moreover, those who have been corrected and have reformed themselves (*correctus, se reformare*) will have abolished their past stain (*labem abolere*). Lactantius stresses God's role in this, with his great indulgence (*indulgentissimus*) and mercy (*clementia*), he can be appeased (*placari*). For such people God will remit, obliterate, and condone sins (Latin: *remittere, obliterare, condonare*). In another work, *On the Anger of God* (*De Ira Dei*) 21, Lactantius insists that God can be angry (*irascitur*), but we can give him satisfaction (*satisfactio*) and he can be appeased (*placabilis, placatur*). Moreover, his anger is not an emotional disturbance like ours. Against unrepentant sinners it is eternal. But, he concludes, 'God is appeased not by incense, not by a sacrificial victim, not by precious gifts, which are all perishable things, but by a reformed way of life (*morum emendatione*)'.

In these two works, Lactantius allows that in *some* sense there is such a thing as God's anger, appeasement and the remission of sins, even though God is too impassive for his responses to be emotional disturbances like ours. Lactantius shares with some pagan philosophers, Stoics and Neoplatonists, the desire to present God as impassive, but he does not go so far in making God impassive as his pagan contemporary, the Neoplatonist Iamblichus. Iamblichus was a devotee of Egyptian religion, who addressed a probing question about divine impassivity from his teacher Porphyry. Porphyry had asked: do not invocations (*klêseis*) to the gods imply that they can be swayed by emotion (*empatheis*)? Iamblichus allows that the gods are benevolent, loving and sollicitous (*eumeneis, philia, kêdemonia*), but he replies that invocations work by allowing priests to gain union with the gods and that the divine nature has so little to do with emotion that the union actually purifies the priests from emotion (*katharsis pathôn*). As regards our appeasing (*exhilasis*) God's wrath (*mênis*), Iamblichus uses the analogy of our stepping out of the light.[25] Appeasement is not to be seen in a conventional way. It is our stepping back into the light. Simplicius, the Neoplatonist of the sixth century CE, goes even further. He asks why it is thought that God is persuaded to change his mind (*metapeithesthai*) and to pardon those who go astray (*sunginôskein hamartanousin*) by means of gifts, votive offerings, prayers, benefactions, and supplications. Simplicius denies that this is what happens. God is not even angry (*orgizetai*), nor does he turn away

[23] Ps.-Democritus, *frg.* B43 (Diels-Kranz).

[24] Lactantius, *Divine Institutes* VI 24, 1-10.

[25] Iamblichus, *Mysteries of the Egyptians* 1.12-13, pp. 40,16-43,15, Des Places, replying to Porphyry's fragmentary *Letter to Anebo* (quoted here and ed. Sodano).

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from us when we go astray, or turn back when we repent (*metamelomenôn*). Rather it is we who have turned away. The analogy is with a man who allows his boat to slip away from the rock to which it had been tethered. Acts of repentance help to bring him back again to the rock, and assimilation to God (ideally even union) was the Platonist ideal. But the rock is meanwhile unmoved. The goal of our repentance is to be purified (*katharsis*) and embrace virtue. Those who are genuinely repentant are corrected more quickly because of the sharp wounds of conscience (*to suneidos*).[26]

Conscience is mentioned explicitly by Lactantius and Simplicius, and, insofar as it leads to repentance, and repentance to reform, the value of that may lie in different things. Lactantius sees God as immune from emotional disturbance, but looks to him for remission of past sins. Simplicius actually denies that God's role is to pardon. The Platonists look rather to our being re-assimilated to a benevolent, but impassive God.

The satisfaction of a *clear* conscience is connected with another function, exoneration, mentioned by Paul in the *Letter to Romans* 2:15. Clear conscience is referred to as early as Plato's *Republic* in the fourth century BC.[27] At a very much later date, the Stoic Roman Emperor Marcus Aurelius has a special word, *eusyneidêtos*, for having a good conscience.[28] But a different phenomenon was a positively *joyful* conscience. Aristotle, without talking of conscience, favours self-love when it takes the form of the joyful harmony found in a good person.[29] Seneca, it will be seen below, finds joy in the calm that springs from interrogating himself about his conduct at the end of each day, though there too conscience is not mentioned. But in Seneca and Cicero there is talk of a joyful conscience, resulting from unpublicised deeds that are positively good. This stems from awareness not merely of faultlessness, but of actual *merit*. Seneca has particular occasion to refer to this in his treatise on the ethics of bestowing benefits.[30] Positively joyful conscience is not so much mentioned in the Church Fathers, but it crops up in John Chrysostom (347-407 CE) in connexion with the martyr, whose conscience makes him joyful in adversity.[31] However, a joyful conscience was the very antithesis of the repentance for which the Christian Church often called and of the despairing conscience of Luther from which he sought a merciful redemption in the promise of Christ's Gospel.

[26] Simplicius, *Commentary on Epictetus' Handbook*, Ch. 38, Lines 674-703 in I Hadot = Ch. 31, 107, 15-22, Dübner.

[27] Plato, *Republic* 331A 2.

[28] Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* VI 30.

[29] Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics* 9.4.

[30] *E.g.* Cicero, *Tusc.* 2.64; Seneca, *On Benefits* 2.33.2-3; 4.11.3; 4.12.4.

[31] Henry Chadwick cites four of his texts in 'Conscience in ancient thought', in his *Studies on Ancient Christianity* (Aldershot, 2006), Chapter XX = the original English text, with revisions, of 'Gewissen': *Reallexikon für Antike und Christentum* 7 (1969), col. 1091 = 55 of the English.

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Lactantius may be right that Cicero does not see reform as a function of conscience, and his treatment is distinctive in other ways too. I have mentioned his legal interest in the accomplice's or witness' sharing of *another's* guilty knowledge. Hebing further claims[32] that conscience in Cicero is retrospective, not prospective, with only one example of aversion in Cicero and none in Seneca. But whatever may be true of Cicero, Seneca treats conscience as averting wrong conduct quite a few times[33] and also sees it as producing reform,[34] and he thinks the same about the practice of self-interrogation.[35]

4. Graeco-Roman concepts other than conscience

So far I have focused on the construction of the Greek and Latin terms for conscience and the uses of the idea. But when the Christians wanted to fill out their own concept they drew on other Graeco-Roman ideas besides that of conscience, and I will now outline seven of these related ideas.

(i) *Self-interrogation in Seneca and others*

The Stoic Seneca says that he learnt from the Pythagorean Sextius the practice of interrogating himself every night on whether his actions during the day had been right. Sextius summoned his mind (*animus*) every day to give an account of itself: 'What defect of yours have you cured today? What vice have you resisted? In what respect are you better?' Anger recedes if it knows it will have to appear before a judge every day. From Seneca's account, we get a picture of his and his wife's domestic life.

> What sleep follows this self-examination, how tranquil, deep and free, when the mind is either praised or admonished and the self-investigator and secret critic has recognised its own habits. I use this facility and every day I render an account to myself. When the light is removed from sight and my wife has fallen silent, conscious (*conscia*) in advance of my habit, I scrutinise the whole of my day and I reassess everything I did and said. I hide nothing from myself and I pass over nothing, for why should I be afraid of any of my mistakes when I can say: 'See that you do not do that again. For now I pardon you. In that dispute you spoke too aggressively. In future do not engage with inexperienced people. Those who have never learnt do not want to learn. Him you admonished more freely than you ought, so that you did not reform, but offended him. For the future, see not only whether what you say is true, but whether the man to whom

[32] J. Hebing (1922).

[33] Seneca, *Letters* 105,7-8; 117,1; *frg.* 14 Haase (= 81 Vottero) from Lactantius *Divine Institutes* 6.24.16-17 (a guardian: *custos*, see Epictetus *phulakê*, *phulassein*, *Discourses* 1.14.11-15 and uncertain frg 97).

[34] Seneca, *Letters* 28, 9-10.

[35] Seneca, *On Anger* 3.36; *Letters* 41,1-2; 83,1-2.

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it is said can take the truth. A good person rejoices in being admonished. All the worst people take their corrector very badly'.[36]

Seneca finds the practice calming, perhaps because he is a little lenient with himself. His younger Stoic contemporary Epictetus advocates the same practice conducted every morning as well as evening,[37] and the practice was taken over by the Christian Origen in the third century CE, who ascribes it to the Pythagoreans. But he connects the practice with a shameful recital (*aoidêmon rhêseidion*), 'bites' (*dakneisthai*) of conscience and compunction (*katanussein*), although he is attracted by the idea of substituting calmness (*hêsukhasate*) for compunction, which would make Origen more like Seneca. Origen and Epictetus cite the same questions to ask, drawn from the Pythagorean book, *Golden Verses*: 'Where did I go astray? What have I done? What duty has been left undone?'[38]

(ii) *Watching*

Self-interrogation is a form of self-watching. But there was also interest in the idea of being watched by God, or a daemon, by the public, by an imagined mentor, or an appointed critic. There was discussion in the Stoics, Seneca and Epictetus, of being watched by God, and occasionally this latter, unlike self-interrogation, is connected with the terms for conscience. In Seneca, one's conscience is open to God, and one has God within as an observer of bad and good. In a single letter, Seneca asks us to live as if someone (presumably someone human) were observing us, then points out that in fact nothing is hidden from God, and as a result Seneca determines that he will watch himself, thus bringing in three different types of watcher.[39] Seneca speaks of fearing or not fearing the *conscientia* of other people, and of their sharing knowledge of your secrets, and says that if your own conscience (*conscientia*) is good, it will welcome the crowds.[40] In passages preserved by Lactantius of Seneca's lost *Exhortations*, Seneca describes God as perceiving and knowing the entire person. However much we close our conscience, it is open to God. We may seek to be rid of human witnesses (*arbitros*), but how does it help to have no human sharing our guilty knowledge (*conscius*), if we have our own conscience (*conscientia*).[41] The conscience here not only shares our knowledge, it is also

[36] Seneca, *On Anger* 3.36; cf. *Letters* 28,9-10; 41,1-2; 83,1-2.

[37] Epictetus, 4.6.35.

[38] Orig., *frg.* On Psalms IV from René Cadiou, *Commentaires inédits des Psaumes* (Paris, 1936), 74; Orig., *Selections on the Psalms* IV (PG 12, 1144B-45B), drawing on the Pythagorean *Golden Verses*, lines 40-4.

[39] Seneca, *On Benefits* 7.1.7; frg. 24 Haase (=Vottero 89) from Lactantius *Divine Institutes* 6. 24. 12; *Letters* 41,1-2; 83,1-2.

[40] Seneca, *Letters* 3.4; 43,4-5; *On Tranquillity* 7.3.

[41] Lactantius, *Divine Institutes* 6. 24. 12-7, a passage which provides frgs 12 and 24 of Seneca cited above and adjacent to the one against Cicero on reform and remission of sins.

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described as a guardian (*custos*), which reminds us of Socrates' daemon. Seneca here gives a watching role both to God and to conscience, as does his younger fellow-Stoic Epictetus, when he says that God (Zeus) has installed a daemon within us to watch us and is within us himself.[42]

Cicero anticipates Seneca, when in a single passage he reports Epicurus as connecting *conscientia* with three types of watcher: there is the *conscientia* of *humans* sharing knowledge of your secrets, the *conscientia* about you of *gods* and your *own* bad conscience.[43] It has been said, however, that Cicero became sceptical of the value of public opinion,[44] and it was for the same reason that Adam Smith was to emphasise that his account of conscience envisaged only an *imagined* impartial observer of one's conduct.[45]

Epicurus, according to Seneca, and Seneca himself both recommend the practice of imagining an admired person watching you – in the case of Epicurus it is to be himself.[46] The great doctor Galen, an independent thinker though attracted by Platonism in the later second century CE, gives a reason why self-inspection is inferior to persuading someone else to watch and criticise you, and that is that we are notoriously bad at noticing our own faults, and Ps.-Aristotle in the *Magna Moralia* gives this self-blindness as a reason for having friends.[47]

In the exercises of self-interrogation or persuading a critic, neither reputation nor self-image is at stake. On the contrary, shame would prevent one from getting criticism, especially when the critic, as Galen says, needs to be pressed to criticise, and shame would prevent Seneca from feeling calmed. The interest is in really improving character, not in appearing to. Shame and guilt, we are told, make one close off inspection by others. It is only in the exercise of imagining an admired watcher that shame may be used as a tool towards improvement.

(iii) *Preconceptions of good and bad*

The early Stoic Chrysippus spoke of our having natural preconceptions (*emphytoi prolêpseis*) of good and evil.[48] And Cicero makes his Stoic spokesman, Balbus, describe as natural (*innatum*) and as it were engraved in the mind the belief that there are gods as innate. But we gather that the early Stoics are unlikely to have meant the word translated 'natural' to carry the more obvious meaning of *innate*, because another text tells us that we are born with our

[42] Epictetus, 1.14.11-15.

[43] Cicero, *On Ends* 1.16.51.

[44] Shadi Bartsch, *The Mirror of the Self* (Chicago, 2006), 204.

[45] D.D. Raphael, *The Impartial Spectator: Adam Smith's Moral Philosophy* (Oxford, 2007), 34-52.

[46] Seneca, *Letters* 11,8-10; 32,1; Epicurus (reported with approval), in Seneca, *Letter* 25,5.

[47] Galen, *On the Errors and Passions of the Soul*, *Scripta minora* vol. 1 (Marquardt), Ch. 2, 4.11-5.2; Ch. 3, 6.17-7.1, Ps.-Aristotle, *Magna Moralia* 2.15, 1213a13-26.

[48] Plutarch, *On Stoic Self-contradictions* 1041E.

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reason like a blank sheet of paper and our conceptions (*ennoiai*) are written onto it. (We shall find the writing metaphor later in Christianity).The preconceptions (*prolêpseis*) are the ones that get written in by nature without further thought on our part,[49] but evidently not from birth. It does, however, look as if in the later Stoic, Epictetus, certain moral preconceptions have become innate.[50] Cicero explains that for Plato such conceptions of good and evil are pre-nate inheritances from an earlier life.[51] As a follower of Plato himself, Cicero can in his own person speak of certain ideas as innate. He describes us as having formed from the very first shadowy understandings (*adumbratae intelligentiae*) that we get from the God-given divine element within us. Again in one of his forensic speeches, he claims that the right to self-defence is a law not written but born (*nata*) with us, for which we are not instructed but made, with which we are not indoctrinated but imbued.[52] Self-defence is perhaps an example of a natural human right, which I have elsewhere suggested was missing from the Stoics.[53]

Among Christians the question would later arise whether the law written in men's hearts was innate. Origen's view seems to be that it is sown by God into the hearts of men, but that when we are still growing up, we do not hear it.[54] The metaphor of sowing may suggest that the seed is there from birth. Augustine's remark is ambiguous, that the natural law in our hearts only appears (*apparet*) at the age of reason, but he has the idea that people may have the law in their hearts and in their conscience but be unwilling to read it.[55]

(iv) *Socrates' daemon*

Plato presents Socrates as frequently being warned by a daemon, acting as a guardian spirit. According to Plato, the daemon is a voice which opposes some of Socrates' intentions, but never proposes.[56] When Xenophon allows that the daemon may tell Socrates to do things as well as not to do them,[57] he need not

[49] Aëtius, 4.11.1-4, *Doxographici Graeci* (Diels). David Konstan has supplied clear examples from Plautus and Terence where the meaning of *innatus* can hardly be 'innate'. On the meaning of *innata* as applied to preconceptions in Epicureanism at Cicero *On the nature of the gods* 1.44-5 see the controversy between David Sedley 'Epicurus' theological innatism' and David Konstan, 'Epicurus on the gods', both in Jeffrey Fish and Kirk Sanders, eds., *Epicurus and the Epicurean Tradition*, Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, forthcoming.

[50] Epictetus, 2.11.1-15 and Ps.-Epictetus, *frg.* 97.

[51] Cicero, *Tusc.* 1.24.57.

[52] Cicero, *On laws* 1.22.59; *On the nature of the gods* 2.4.12; *Pro Milone* 10.

[53] Richard Sorabji, *Animal minds and human morals* (London and Ithaca NY, 1993), Ch. 11.

[54] Origen, *Against Celsus* I 4; *On Romans* VI 8 (PG 14, 1080A-81A).

[55] Augustine, *Letters* 157.15 (PL 33, 681); *Enarratio in Psalmos* 57.1 (PL 36, 673).

[56] Plato, *Apology* 31D-32A (a voice, only opposes); *Apology* 40A-C; *Phaedrus* 242B-C (opposition).

[57] Xenophon, *Recollections of Socrates* 1.1.4 (orders to do or not to do). Vlastos sees Xenophon's account as differing in this from Plato's, in his *Socrates, ironist and moral philosopher* (Ithaca NY, 1991).

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be disagreeing, since whether a command to change one's intention is formulated in terms of staying or not going, it can equally be negative in the sense of forbidding an intention to leave. Socrates treats the warnings as indubitable, and it is made explicit by Xenophon that they are indubitable.[58] We shall see below that it was not the standard Christian view that the deliverances of conscience are indubitable. But among the exceptions who treat conscience that way was Gandhi, who imported the idea to India from the West. There are many examples of his treating the deliverances of his conscience as indubitable. And I have suggested elsewhere that he may have been influenced in his interpretation by having translated Plato's *Apology* into Gujerati,[59] another sign of which is his treating conscience, like Socrates' daemon, as a *voice*.

A connexion was made among the Greeks between conscience and Socrates' daemon. Nine hundred years after Plato, the last pagan Neoplatonist professor in the Philosophy school at Alexandria, Olympiodorus, speaking for the benefit of his Christian pupils, actually identifies Socrates' daemon with conscience.[60] Four centuries after Plato, the Platonist Plutarch wrote a treatise on Socrates' daemon, and included a speech which again reminds us of conscience. A daemon is compared with a buoy in the water. It is identified with intellect (*nous*) and is in contact with the head, but it holds up with a tether the irrational parts of the soul submerged in the water. Through this tether it inflicts on the irrational parts of the soul repentance and shame (*metameleia*, *aiskhynê*),[61] a function given by others to conscience. If Socrates' daemon is his intellect, this implies that what the daemon says is not news to Socrates, but something that he himself knows, and that has been argued to be exactly Plato's view.[62] On the other hand, Plutarch diverges from Plato when he adds to the function of warning the further functions of causing repentance and shame. In Plato, Socrates' daemon does not shame him, nor for that matter is it described as refuting him – *elenkhein*, the word later used for one's conscience *convicting* one. It is Socrates and his intellect which do the refuting of *other* people.

(v) *The daemon's mental language*

Although Plato calls Socrates' daemon a voice, Plutarch reports the interpretation that there is no speech, or voice, or striking of the air (*phthongos*, *phônê*,

[58] Xenophon, *Recollections* 1.3.4.

[59] Mohandas Gandhi, *An autobiography: the story of my experiments with truth* (Ahmedabad, 1929), passim; *Bombay Chronicle* 16 Sep 1927; Rajmohan Gandhi, *Mohandas* (Delhi, 2006), 267. 291. R. Sorabji, Morality and self: cross-cultural perspectives: *India International Centre Quarterly* 34 (2007) 52-64, and in a fuller version in Giuseppe Cambiano (ed.), *Antiquorum Philosophia* 2 (2009) 13-24.

[60] Olympiodorus, *On Plato's First Alcibiades* 23, 2-7 (Westerink).

[61] Plutarch, *On the daemon of Socrates* 591E-592B.

[62] Roslyn Weiss, *Socrates dissatisfied* (Oxford, 1998), 17-23.

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plêgê). Rather, as in sleep, the thought of the statement (*logou noêsis*) contacts one, and one grasps the beliefs and thoughts (*doxai*, *noêseis*) in the statements, merely thinking that one hears them. The statement contacts one merely through what is indicated (*to dêloumenon*) by the thinker and by what is thought (*to noêthen*). The air signals (*ensêmainetai*) the statement by means of what is thought (*to noêthen*). These thoughts do not need verbs or nouns. Rather, like light, they produce a reflection in the receiver.[63] Later Platonists agree. Calcidius in the fourth century CE says that in dreams, when we think we hear voice and speech, there is in fact only meaning (*significatio*) doing the duty of voice, and that is how, when awake, Socrates divined the presence of the daemon, by the token of a vivid sign.[64] Both authors suggest that the daemon communicates pure meaning (*to dêloumenon*, *to noêthen*, *significatio*), although the meaning is not yet said itself to be a language. Proclus in the fifth century returns to the analogy of light, saying that light is received in the tenuous material (not flesh) that provides a vehicle for our souls, and by that route reaches the fleshly sense organs and is recognised by self-perception (*synaisthêsis*).[65]

Augustine, who could have had access to Calcidius' Latin, discussed how God speaks to us and denied that the process involves figures appearing (this is all he meant by denying the comparison with dreams). On the other hand, there is no ordinary hearing either. Rather, God speaks to those who can hear with the mind (*mens*) by means of the truth itself (*ipsa veritate*).[66] Truth here does the work of meaning in Plutarch and Calcidius.

In a later work, Augustine turns from God to humans and talks of our thought as the word that we speak in our heart that is neither Greek nor Latin nor of any other language. This inner word is more deserving of the description 'word'. By describing it as a *word*, he seems to imply that it belongs to a language of the mind. Speech is used as a sign of it and an analogy is that, as our word is made sound, so the Word of God was made flesh.[67]

So far Theology has been the source of ideas about how the divine world communicates without voice and how we think in words of no natural language. But the last may have received support from the direction of logic, when Porphyry around 300 CE interpreted Aristotle as thinking that there are three kinds of verbs and names, one written, one spoken and one exercised in the quiet of the mind.[68]

[63] Plutarch, *On the daemon* 588B-589D.

[64] Calcidius, *Commentary on Plato's Timaeus* Ch. 255, p. 288.

[65] Proclus, *Commentary on Plato's First Alcibiades* 80.

[66] Augustine, *City of God* 11.2. I thank David Robertson for first drawing my attention to this discussion.

[67] Augustine, *On the Trinity* 15, chs. 10-11.

[68] Porphyry, ap. Boethius, *Commentary on Aristotle's De Interpretatione* 29,29-30,10.

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(vi) *Natural law*

Divine law is already discussed in the fifth century BCE. The philosopher Heraclitus says that all human laws are fed by the one divine law.[69] Aristotle drew attention to two other examples from the same century. In Sophocles' play of that name, Antigone accepts that the king's law (*nomos*) forbids her to bury her brother. But she insists that there is a law (*nomimon*) not of today or yesterday but of all times which requires her to bury him.[70] Aristotle calls it a natural law (*nomos kata physin*) and naturally just (*physei*). His second example is the philosopher Empedocles, who spoke in the same century of a law (*nomimon*) that obtained everywhere that one should not kill sentient beings, animal or human.[71] Aristotle gives a third example from the next century, his own, of Alcidamas, who declared, contrary to Aristotle's own view, that no slavery is natural. Cicero ascribes to Zeno who founded Stoicism in 300 BCE belief that natural law (*naturalis lex*) is divine and commands what is right and forbids the opposite.[72] Elsewhere he describes the law more fully.[73] God gave the law, but it also comes from nature. Cicero emphasises that it holds at all times and places, which would not originally have been obvious, since what struck the Greeks about human law was that it differed from place to place and from time to time. Our choice of the metaphor of law for universal regularities would have needed explanation.

The bold step that is found in Cicero, whether or not he is following Zeno, is the internalisation of natural law. Such law is the same as reason, that is, correct reason not wrong reason, in the human mind, and we all have right reason – even those who go against it. A similar idea is found in the first century CE in Philo of Alexandria in a passage part of which is treated as a Stoic fragment, but the reference to the human mind as immortal suggests to me that this part of the passage comes from Platonism. Right reason is a law (*nomos*) that is never wrong (*apseudês*) imprinted by immortal nature in the immortal mind.[74]

(vii) *Confession*

Confession was practised in the Epicurean school in the second century before the birth of Christ, and it was said to encourage the cultivation of conscience. In the first century CE, the Platonist Plutarch regards confession as a route to reform and a sign of moral progress.[75] But the Epicurean discussion of conscience

[69] Heraclitus, *frg.* 114 (Diels-Kranz).
[70] Sophocles, *Antigone* 450-57.
[71] Aristotle, *Rhetoric* 1.13, 1373b 4-17.
[72] Cicero, *On the nature of the gods* 1.14. 36.
[73] Cicero, *On laws* 1.6.18; 1.7.23; 1.12.33; 2.4.8; *On the Republic* 3.22.33.
[74] Philo, *Every good man is free* 46, included in *Stoicorum Veterum Fragmenta* 3.360 (von Arnim).
[75] Plutarch, *Progress in virtue* 82A-B.

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and of confession is more extensive and before I come to St Paul, the Epicurean school requires a space to itself, alongside the other pagan Greeks and Romans I have mentioned.

5. Epicurean school

Epicurus founded his school in Athens in 307 BCE, seven years before the Stoic school was founded there, and his view of justice was very much the opposite of theirs. For the Stoics justice to all humans would be the natural outcome of the natural sociability of humans. For Epicurus what everyone seeks naturally is his own pleasure, and justice is an artificial contract designed to alleviate the harshness of this situation.[76] Its validity and any claim it can make to naturalness last only so long as it remains advantageous. Where is there room for conscience in this picture? I am not aware of the surviving texts of Epicurus discussing it. But Cicero and Seneca ascribe to Epicurus a view of conscience as fear of detection and punishment.[77] Cicero finds this an unsettling form of conscience and complains that Epicurus rejects the steady conscience that he believes in.[78] But Epicurus had another idea, already mentioned and closer to our idea of conscience, that members of the school should imagine that he was watching them.[79]

Lucretius' exposition of Epicurus in Latin verse in the first century BC does use the standard word for conscience, when it says that the mind which shares knowledge with itself (*sibi conscia*) of bad deeds torments itself with fears about the Furies and punishment after death in Tartarus, even though punishment cannot come from supernatural sources, nor after death, when our atoms will have dispersed.[80] We have already seen Euripides in the fifth century BC turning the Furies into a delusion suffered by a bad conscience, and the same reinterpretation of supernatural punishment as bad conscience is found in a good many authors, Greek and Latin, and repeated by the Christian Origen for the fires of Hell.[81]

Particularly interesting for Christianity is one of the Epicurean works from about 100 BC excavated from the library of the Greek Epicurean Philodemus, which was covered in volcanic lava and carbonised in the eruption of Vesuvius in 79 CE. Philodemus was attracted to move with his library from Athens to

[76] Epicurus, *Key doctrines* 31-5; Lucretius, *On the nature of things* 5.1145-57.

[77] Seneca, *Letters* 97,15-16; Cicero, *On ends* 2.16.53.

[78] Cicero, *On ends* 2.22.71.

[79] Seneca, *Letters* 11.8; 25.5. I thank Mark Alfano for drawing my attention to the contrast.

[80] Lucretius, 3.1010-1024.

[81] Ps.-Democritus, *frg.* 297; Cicero, *Pro Roscio Amerino* 24.67; Diodorus Siculus (Greek historian of first century BCE), *Bibliotheca historica* 4.65; Orig., *De Princ.* II 10.4.

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the household of Julius Caesar's father-in-law, Piso, after the Roman general Sulla sacked Athens in 89 BCE. His books, badly charred, finished up in a villa in Herculaneum in the Bay of Naples. The fragments, increasingly readable each year through new technology, mention conscience four times. The *Rhetoric* describes people who because of a guilty conscience (*syneidêsis*) engage in law suits until they are convicted and ruined.[82] *On death* provides the only use in Greek of another word for conscience when it speaks of a (good) conscience (*syngnôsis*) and irreproachable life.[83] But most interesting for our purposes is the treatise *On frank criticism* about the practices in the residential school in Athens two hundred years after Epicurus, which included confession by students and even teachers more than a hundred years before the birth of Christ.[84] One fragment declares: 'Even the servants share his (guilty) knowledge (*synoidasin*)'.[85] Another fragment, on the standard reading, says that if the professor quickly turns away from assisting the student who is slipping up, the student's swelling (*synoidêsis*) will subside.[86] Why should professorial neglect make a *swelling* subside? This makes no sense, and an emendation suggested a long time ago by C. J. Vooys should be accepted. *Syneidêsis* (conscience) differs from *synoidêsis* (swelling) by only the one letter 'e', which, in Greek as in English, looks very like an 'o'. Moreover four short lines later the related verb *syneidenai* appears. It makes perfect sense that the student's conscience will become less intense, if the professor does not attend to criticism and help of the right sort, and this gives us a picture of the Epicurean school in Athens at the time of Philodemus' teacher, Zeno of Tarsus, in the second century BCE, wanting to develop the consciences of its students through a process of confession and carefully tailored, but frank, criticism.

I doubt that the Philodemus' strong interest in conscience was what introduced the Romans to the subject, when he moved to Italy, since we have found it long before in the Latin comic playwrights Plautus and Terence, and very soon after Philodemus' move, there are innumerable references in the speeches of Cicero, as if the concept was already at home in the world of Roman law. Before that it was at home, though on a smaller scale, in speeches in fourth century Greek law courts.[87] But Philodemus may have emphasised the concept still more because of the Roman interest.

[82] Philodemus, *Rhetoric* II, *frg.* 11, lines 1-9 (Sudhaus), 139-40.

[83] Philodemus, *De morte* 34. 35 (Kuyper). I thank David Armstrong and Benjamin Henry for showing me this text and the latest emendations of it.

[84] Philodemus, *On frank criticism*, *frg.* 41.

[85] Philodemus, *On frank criticism*, col. XIIa, line 5.

[86] Philodemus, *On frank criticism*, *frg.* 67. I thank David Sider for showing me the emendation.

[87] Examples are given, *e.g.*, by Kenneth J. Dover, *Greek Popular Morality in the Time of Plato and Aristotle* (Berkeley and Los Angeles, 1974), 220-3; Don E. Marietta, Conscience in Greek Stoicism: *Numen* 7 (1970) 176-87.

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6. Saint Paul

Saint Paul's first letter to the Corinthians addresses Greek Christians who claim to have a clear conscience in eating meat sacrificed to idols, because they are sophisticated people who know that the belief in idols is a delusion. Paul replies that if they are seen eating sacrificed meat they may corrupt the conscience of their less sophisticated brethren.[88] The message that a clear conscience is not a sure guide is reaffirmed, without the word conscience, in the same letter when Paul says that his own unawareness of fault does not acquit him, since God is the judge.[89] Elsewhere in the same letter, Paul advises Christians to eat and ask no questions when they are served meat by an unbeliever, a piece of advice which seems admirable in a multicultural society, but if someone tells them that it has been sacrificed, to decline it for the sake of their informant's conscience.[90]

Animal sacrifice is also the context of a statement in the letter to the Hebrews, whether or not that is by Paul, that unconverted Jews need to sacrifice because of anxieties of conscience, but Christians do not, because the sacrifice has been made once and for all through Christ.[91] It is noteworthy that Christian conscience, like Jewish written law, is concerned not only with laws like the Ten Commandments, but also prominently with matters of eating, but in order to differentiate Christianity from pagan beliefs about gods. The original scruples about kinds of meat would not have gone back to the vegetarian days when the law was first imprinted in Adam's heart.

C.A. Pierce suggests that it may be the Corinthians, not Paul, who first raised the question of conscience in their correspondence.[92] But by the time of the letter to the Romans Paul has something new and important to say about conscience. He refers to the written law of God by which the Jews distinguished themselves, and which would include the Ten Commandments delivered by God to Moses, and he contrasts the written law with the law written in men's hearts:[93]

> When Gentiles who have not the law do by nature what the law requires, they are a law to themselves, even though they do not have the law. They show that what the law requires is written in their hearts, while their conscience also bears witness and their conflicting thoughts accuse or perhaps excuse them on that day when, according to my gospel, God judges the secrets of men by Christ Jesus.

[88] 1*Cor.* 8:7-13.
[89] 1*Cor.* 4:4.
[90] 1*Cor.* 10:23-30.
[91] *Hebr.* 13:18.
[92] C.A. Pierce, *Conscience in the New Testament* (1955).
[93] *Rom.* 2:14-5.

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The law written in men's hearts was already referred to in the Hebrew scriptures.[94] What is new is to connect it so closely with conscience. Paul describes it as something that co-witnesses (*symmartyrei*). Paul does not say that conscience is *identical* with the law written in the hearts of men. But he licenses the Church Fathers to make extremely close connexions between conscience and that inner law. The only one I am aware of who may assert an actual *identity* is John of Damascus in the seventh to eighth centuries CE, and even his remark is ambiguous when he speaks of conscience *or* the law of my intellect.[95] Thomas Aquinas finds the identification uncomfortably close and glosses John as intending something looser, such as that conscience is a judgment of reason *derived from* natural law.[96]

As for the relation between the written law of God and the law written in men's hearts, the view set out by Origen and ascribed to Augustine by his opponent Bishop Julian of Eclanum is that the law was written in men's hearts at the time of the Fall of Adam in the Garden of Eden, when he ate of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. The written law was given by God to Moses at a much later date.[97] Before the Fall, Adam presumably felt that he should not eat the apple from the tree because of his filial relation to God who had forbidden it, but this will have fallen short of a knowledge of good and evil.

Paul's connexion with law, as I have said, connects conscience with a very *general* knowledge of right and wrong, and adds an extra role to conscience, that of directing towards the right without having to oppose an intention towards the wrong. This is an expansion, but at the same time, with Christianity there is a contraction in the scope of the words for conscience. Discarded are the consciousness of one's own merit in Cicero and Seneca and the consciousness of non-moral faults and weaknesses. Further, one is said to have a conscience only about one's own faults.

Saint Paul's introduction of God as giver of the moral law was not a departure from Graeco-Roman thought, although his God was a more personal one. But in the Graeco-Roman development of the idea of natural law described above, God or the gods were always given a role. Conscience is also often described as given by God, for example by Cicero, who mentions only one sceptical separation of conscience from God's design.[98] So the central role of God in the Christian account of conscience is not what introduces guilt.

[94] *Is.* 51:7a; *Jer.* 38:33 (LXX). I thank Josef Lössl for the references.

[95] John of Damascus, *On orthodox faith* 4.22.

[96] Thomas Aquinas, *On Truth*, Q.17, a.1,1st difficulties to the contrary, 1, and answers to them 1.

[97] Orig., *Commentary on Romans* 6.8 (PG 14, 1080A-81A); Augustine, *Incomplete work against Julian*, Ch. 228 (PL 45, 1244).

[98] Cicero, *On Duties* 3.10.44 (where Cicero's 'mind' – *mens* – is interpreted by Lactantius *Div. Inst.* 6. 24. 18 as conscience); *Pro Cluentio* 159, although Cicero has Cotta, as representing a sceptical phase of the Platonist Academy, to entertain the idea that there is no divine intervention behind conscience, *On the nature of the gods* 3.35.85.

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Saint Paul's insistence on our fallibility as regards conscience was important. This was to be the mainstream view in Christianity, but it was also largely in line with Greco-Roman thought. Of course the law written in our hearts would not be mistaken, and Philo already says this of the internalised law,[99] but Origen and Augustine stress that we may fail to read it. The claim in Seneca that our conscience is never deceived about us is exceptional.[100] We saw above the frequent warnings issued in the Graeco-Roman tradition, such as Epictetus' of the difficulty of applying preconceptions, or Phaedra's in Euripides *Hippolytus* about the difficulty of knowing the right time to heed shame, and again the comment in Ps.-Aristotle *Magna Moralia* and in Galen about the difficulty of knowing one's own faults.

7. Convergence in Lactantius and Origen

There was now plenty of scope for convergence between the Graeco-Roman tradition on conscience and that of Saint Paul. Writing in Latin in the third century CE, the Christian Lactantius claims Cicero's support, even if not verbally exact, for saying that we should purify our consciences (*conscientia* explicit in Lactantius, not Cicero) by opening them to God, who can make us pure. The true sacrifice is not that of animals, but that of a purified conscience. The true ritual is to place that purity on the altar in the heart, and that ritual is Cicero's god-given law of God that requires what is right and forbids the opposite.[101] Lactantius goes on to find the sacrifice of purity advocated in the corpus of Hermes Trismegistus, a Greek compilation of Egyptian wisdom from the early centuries CE.[102] This may represent a further convergence, since the pagan Neoplatonist Porphyry may have drawn from Hermes Trismegistus when he too advocated the sacrifice of a pure intellect and heart.[103] Lactantius also praises Seneca's appeal to God and our conscience as both watching us, without any possibility of our closing our conscience to God. Like his pagan contemporary Iamblichus, he seeks to describe the appeasement of God's anger in a way that leaves God impassive, but he looks to God for the remission of sins, whereas the later Neoplatonist Simplicius denies that God is ever angry or that his role is to pardon: it is up to us to reassimilate ourselves to God.

We have found convergence also in Origen writing in Greek in the first half of the same century, the third. It is he who compares the law written in our hearts with Stoic common conceptions,[104] and it no doubt helps the comparison

[99] Philo, *Every good man is free* 46.
[100] Seneca, *On the shortness of life* 10,3.
[101] Lactantius, *Divine Institutes* VI 24.20-29.
[102] Lactantius, *Divine Institutes* VI 25.10-11.
[103] Porphyry, *On abstinence from killing animals* II 61.1.
[104] Origen, *Against Celsus* I 4.

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that the Stoics also use the metaphor of writing to describe how the conceptions get into our minds. Like the Stoics too, we saw him saying that the law is not known while we are still growing up.[105] We saw Origen adopting the Pythagorean (and Stoic) practice of self-interrogation, with reference to 'bites' of conscience. We saw him reinterpreting hell fire in terms of tormented conscience, just as the Epicurean Lucretius did for other aspects of hell.[106]

8. Synterêsis: Origen and Jerome

But Origen had, perhaps by accident, an even greater influence on the history of the idea of conscience. He describes Ezechiel's vision of an animal made up of four living creatures, a human, a lion, a calf and an eagle. The first three remind Origen of Plato's human, lion and many-headed beast, which in Plato's *Republic* represent the three parts of the soul, reason, irascibility and appetite.[107] But what is the fourth part, the eagle? It is the human's spirit presiding over the other three.[108]

Jerome, writing in Latin in the late fourth century CE is probably drawing on Origen and those who followed him, when he says that 'most people' refer the three parts to Plato's three parts of the soul, but refer the eagle to a fourth part, for which the Greeks have a name, and which is the 'spark of conscience' by which we recognise that we are sinning. The Greek word was read in the twelfth to fourteenth centuries as *suntêrêsis*, or in Latin *sunteresis* or *sunderesis*, a word whose Greek meaning can be guessed, although it is not found in any extant Greek texts. Since Jerome went on later in the passage to use the standard word for conscience, in Latin *conscientia*, theologians from the 12th to the 14th centuries believed that there were two different things to discuss, conscience and the spark of conscience (*sunderesis*). They therefore had to divide into two all such questions as whether conscience can be mistaken and whether that is what Jerome meant by its falling. This now had to be asked separately for conscience and for *synderesis*. However, in an arresting article, a French scholar, Jacques de Blic, claimed that this word (and all the subsequent distinctions based on it) was first introduced in the twelfth century CE.[109] The Greek word in 26 manuscripts of Jerome, 24 of them earlier than the 12th century, and in a parallel passage of Gregory of Nazianzus is the standard Greek word for conscience, *suneidêsis*. Before the 12th century no *ms* of Jerome, and only

[105] Origen, *Commentary on Romans* VI 8 (PG 14, 1080A-81A).

[106] Lucretius, *On the Nature of Things* 3. 1011-1024; Origen, *On First Principles* 2.10.4.

[107] Plato, *Republic* 9, 588C-589A.

[108] Origen, *On Ezechiel*, homily 1.16 (PG 13, 681).

[109] Jacques de Blic, Conscience ou syndérèse?: *Revue d'ascétique et de mystique* 25 (1949) 146-57.

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one Latin commentary on Ezechiel, gives the other word. Nor do the extant works of Origen ever use it, whereas they do speak of *suneidêsis* and *to suneidos*. Admittedly, Origen's 25-book commentary on Ezechiel is lost, but a Greek fragment of his first homily on Ezechiel identifies the eagle simply with spirit (*pneuma*) and with the Stoic rational command centre (*hêgemonikon*), and Origen elsewhere, in Rufinus' Latin translation of him, identifies spirit with conscience (*conscientia*).[110] Jerome's remark that most people (*plerique*) identify the eagle with something the Greeks call *suntêrêsis* hardly makes sense in relation to a non-occurring Greek word. Whether the word was introduced simply by a scribal error or deliberately, it seems to have caused a diversion, though not necessarily an unfruitful one, for two centuries in theological thought. If it was introduced deliberately, an ingenious suggestion has been that the word referred to the *safeguarding* function of conscience, but this has been convincingly criticised.[111] I would suggest that the word seems closest to the Stoic Epictetus' use of the word *paratêrêsis* for the watchful self-inspection which he recommends,[112] and of which Origen may well have known. But Epictetus' watchful self-inspection is carried out by reason, so the appeal to something higher would be an innovation. Whatever the origin and motive of the reference to *syntêrêsis*, it was big with consequences for future discussion of the subject, but that takes us beyond the Church Fathers.

9. What is conscience?

We have found very different conceptions of what conscience is. It started off as a knowledge of the faults or faultlessness, and later the merits, of *individuals*, before Saint Paul connected it with a more *general* knowledge. A very useful point made by Thomas Aquinas is that knowledge is an ambiguous term, since it can be applied to the possession of knowledge or to the thing known. Application to the thing known makes it possible, he says, to talk of revealing one's conscience,[113] as if it were a ledger of the sins of which one was aware. It could be added that this might facilitate John of Damascus' identification, if identification it was, of conscience with the law of his intellect, which is also a thing known. The recognition of knowledge as both possession of knowledge and thing known may also help us to capture what many people in antiquity thought conscience to be. It was often seen as a knowledge, in one sense or the other, of what one ought to do, and/or of what one was tempted to do or did do.

[110] Fragment on Ezechiel (PG 13, 681); Rufinus' Latin of Origen's commentary on Romans 2.15 (PG 14, 893A-B).

[111] So J. Hebing (1922), who is answered by M. Waldemann (1938).

[112] Epictetus, *Discourses* 3.6.15.

[113] Thomas Aquinas, *On truth*, Q. 17, a.1, reply.

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The stress on anything as rational as knowledge might seem to leave out the motivating power of conscience But rational knowledge of evaluative propositions can itself be motivating, for example if I know that some action to which I am tempted or which I have performed is *bad*. There were, however, to be many other attempts after the time of the Church Fathers to accommodate motivation as well as rational knowledge. The connexion of conscience with rationality is not ubiquitous, but is already found in the Graeco-Roman period, since the Stoics identify most psychological functions with reason, and we saw Plutarch identify the Socratic daemon in its role of reprover and admonisher with the human intellect. Jerome was an exception when he placed conscience, or its spark, still higher *above* reason.

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Human Freedom According to the Earliest Latin Commentaries on Paul's Letters

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While human freedom is not a central theme in the earliest Latin commentaries on Paul's letters, the subject is however dealt with. The aim of this paper is to present some variants of the motif in the commentaries of Marius Victorinus, Ambrosiaster and Jerome.

Perfection gained through decision

In his commentary on *Ephesians* 1:4, Victorinus explains the *mystery of* how the world was made, how souls that already existed before the world have been sent into the world and have again been freed from the world.[1] As Victorinus explained in *Adversus Arium I*, the souls' descent has two stages. In the first step, the soul separates from the Logos and it cannot truly decide in favour of separation or not. The second step – the descent into the sensitive world – already depends on free decision of the soul.[2]

Victorinus' commentary on *Ephesians* focuses on the second step and describes the circumstances of the soul's decision. If a soul comports itself perfectly, that is, recognises itself, knows God, repudiates things alien to it, is aware of what causes mistakes, what lies and deceives and flees from it, then it rightly becomes perfect, receives the full knowledge of the whole, becomes spiritual and perfected in Christ. However, if a soul mistakes understanding for sense perception, which imitates understanding, and falls into it, then it slips from an understanding of what is true into true images and from true images into false ones.[3]

[1] See Marius Victorinus, *In epistolam ad Ephesios* I 1.4 (CSEL 83/2, 6-7.11-7).

[2] See Marius Victorinus, *Adversus Arium* I 61 (CSEL 83/1, 162.21). See also Ernst Benz, *Marius Victorinus und die Entwicklung der abendländischen Willensmetaphysik* (Stuttgart, 1932), 144-5; Hubert de Leusse, Problème de la préexistence des âmes chez Marius Victorinus Afer: *RSR* 29 (1939) 197-239; Paul Séjourné, Victorinus Afer: *DTC* 15 (1950) 2887-954; Pierre Hadot, *Porphyre et Victorinus* I (Paris, 1968), 178-86 and 342-3; Werner Erdt, *Marius Victorinus Afer, der erste lateinische Pauluskommentator* (Frankfurt, 1980), 129-38; Werner Steinmann, *Die Seelenmetaphysik des Marius Victorinus* (Hamburg, 1990), 28-64.

[3] See Marius Victorinus, *In Eph.* I 1.4 (CSEL 83/2, 8.54-76, 10.126-31).

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According to Victorinus, the soul is 'to recognise' (what the senses are and how much they are worth), 'to discern and separate out' (what is foreign); 'to know' (Christ, the world, sensible things), and 'to cast off' (the bodily stains).[4] This process of decision and choice is based on the contrast between understanding, capable of discerning right and wrong, and the senses trying to deceive it. The 'fall' into the sensible is not necessary; there is a choice. Souls were not created corrupted or predestined to fall, although in a sense they were 'sent' into the world.[5]

The soul therefore is to prove itself and become perfect. If it did not go through this experience, it would have only a 'lesser kind of perfection,' while if it recognises what is to be pursued and despises the sensible, it becomes perfect.[6] Human perfection is therefore gained by this decision and choice (between God and the senses); without this choice perfection could not be reached.

Divine and human will in good works

For souls captured in the sensible world, there is no hope but Christ, who was sent so that 'through his Mystery and through the bodily death, souls, having been raised up, might return to the heavenly power'.[7] The mystery of Christ's redemption offers help, help requiring a human answer. Everyone can refuse this offer, or accept through faith. What is decisive is faith alone, through which one can receive Christ's help, follow him and establish a new relationship with God.[8] To believe in Christ means 'to perceive spiritually', to turn away from fleshly and material desires, and on the basis of 'a kinship of understanding' (*cognatio intellegendi*) to be united to Christ and God.[9]

Salvation is not based on one's work; what is required is *faith alone*.[10] Is this faith a strictly human act, or is it also God's gift? In some passages, it seems that it is fully up to human decision, like in his commentary on *Ephesians* 2:16:

[4] See Marius Victorinus, *In Eph.* I 1.4 (CSEL 83/2, 8.54-9, 9.78-80, 9.90-2, 11.156-9, 12.192-7). See also Stephen Andrew Cooper, *Metaphysics and Morals in Marius Victorinus' Commentary on the Letter to the Ephesians* (Oxford, 1995), 124 and 132.

[5] See Marius Victorinus, *In Eph.* I 1.4 (CSEL 83/2, 6.5-13, 12.185-92).

[6] See Marius Victorinus, *In Eph.* I 1.4 (CSEL 83/2, 8.46-50, 10-1.133-42, 12.192-7).

[7] Marius Victorinus, *In Eph.* I 1.20-23 (CSEL 83/2, 25.72f.): *... per eius mysterium er per corporalem mortem resuscitatae animae ad virtutem caelestem redirent ...*; ET S.A. Cooper, *Metaphysics and Morals* (1995), 60. See also *In Eph.* I 1.4 (CSEL 83/2, 9.81-4, 10.137-9).

[8] See Marius Victorinus, *In Eph.* I 1.4, I 3.12 (CSEL 83/2, 9.93-101, 50.9-15); *In epistolam ad Galatas* I 3.7 (CSEL 83/2, 129.4-8); see W. Steinmann, *Die Seelenmetaphysik* (1990), 51.

[9] Marius Victorinus, *In Eph.* I 1.4 (CSEL 83/2, 9.96-100): *Christum enim credere et in Christum fidem sumere iam spiritaliter sentire est et iam tolli a desideriis carnalibus et materialibus, et ex hoc veluti cognatio intellegendi nos iungit et sociat Christo, et dum Christo sociaverit iungit et deo.*

[10] For *sola fide* in Victorinus see W. Erdt, *Marius Victorinus* (1980), 61-4, 142-5 and 159-64; W. Steinmann, *Die Seelenmetaphysik* (1990), 51-6 and 176; S.A. Cooper, *Marius Victorinus' Commentary on Galatians* (Oxford, 2005), 148-69.

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Our Lord Jesus Christ has somehow overcome, has prevailed in this very struggle of the flesh and world. Now there is hardly anything left for us [to do] except this alone: to believe in him who has prevailed over all things.[11]

On the other hand, Victorinus stresses that salvation is given absolutely by God, as a gift of his grace. The reconciliation of these two emphases is presented in Victorinus' well-known commentary on *Philippians* 2:12-13. 'Work out your salvation', says the apostle, but this working is from God. We work out salvation for ourselves, because the will (*velle*) is our own. Nonetheless, this very will is from God who works in us, ergo we have both working and will (*operationem et voluntatem*) on the basis of God's activity.[12]

Thus both have been mixed, so that we would have the will (*voluntas*) and the will itself would be God's; and because we have the will, the ability to carry it out would be there to fulfill a good will (*pro bona voluntate*).[13]

The 'mixture' of human and divine workings means that human workings are based on one's good will, which is caused by God. Human and divine workings thus meet in 'good will'. This good will is ours, but at the same time God causes it in us. It is impossible 'to have will' without God, and even if someone perhaps should have it, he is not able to fulfil his intention. This is why we should forget the good deeds we may have done.[14]

Two types of death

Ambrosiaster takes a different point of departure. In his commentary a double emphasis may be observed: both on the defence of God's justice and the responsibility of every human being for his or her actions. In his commentary on *Romans* 5:12-21, Ambrosiaster explains the connection between Adam's sin and the whole human race (based on the reading *in quo omnes peccaverunt*).[15] Here he draws a distinction between two types of death. Physical death, the separation of the body from the soul is an immediate consequence of Adam's sin and causes the body to be dissolved, and the soul will suffer, kept by the

[11] *In Eph.* I 2.16 (CSEL 83/2, 38.23-6):... *dominus noster Iesus Christus istam ipsam quodammodo carnis et mundi pugnam vicit, superavit. Nostrum paene iam nihil est, nisi solum credere qui superavit omnia.* ET S.A. Cooper, *Metaphysics and Morals* (1995), 71. See also *In Eph.* I 1.7, II 6.13 (CSEL 83/2, 14.21-4, 87.11-5).

[12] See Marius Victorinus, *In epistolam ad Philippenses* 2.12-3 (CSEL 83/2, 195.19-33).

[13] Marius Victorinus, *In Phil.* 2.12-3 (CSEL 83/2, 195.31-3): *Ita utrumque mixtum est, ut et nos habeamus voluntatem et dei sit ipsa voluntas, et quia habemus voluntatem, adsit efficatia pro bona voluntate.* ET S.A. Cooper, *Marius Victorinus' Commentary on Galatians* (2005), 161.

[14] See Marius Victorinus, *In Phil.* 2.12-3, 3.13-4, 3.15 (CSEL 83/2, 195.37-40, 210.34-7, 211-2.7f).

[15] See Ambrosiaster, *In epistulam ad Romanos* 5.12 (CSEL 81/1, 163.16-7, 165.9-12). See Juan Bautista Valero, Pecar en Adán según Ambrosiaster: *Estudios eclesiásticos* 65 (1990) 147-91.

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Devil.[16] To the contrary, a spiritual or 'second' death is a sentence for our own sins and is reserved only for those who sinned 'in a similar way to Adam'. Ambrosiaster admits that it is 'impossible not to sin' but the gravity of each sin is not the same.[17]

Christ has conquered sin and death, liberated people from the Devil's power and from the sentence for their sins. In Christ's victory, the abundance of grace is clearly shown: through the sin of one, many have fallen for death, but more numerous were those in who grace abounded.[18]

Predestination and prescience

Only he whom God predestined and called can be saved (see *Rom.* 8:28-30). To be predestined and called means – for Ambrosiaster – that God foreknew who will be faithful in the future. God helps those who contemplate faith, and encourages those who he knows will obey. Those who were really called will also persevere in faith, because nothing else can happen than that which God foreknew. Contrariwise, those who do not persevere in faith have never really been called, or have been called only 'temporarily' (*ad tempus*).[19]

There is no injustice, no partiality with God's prescience. Everyone will be condemned or rewarded on the basis of his will and his perseverance. God only foreknows what will happen, does not condemn anyone before he sins nor reward before he reaches the victory.[20] Ambrosiaster explains: 'To believe or not to believe is a matter of will. No one can be compelled to believe what is not manifest, but only invited; not forced, but incited.'[21]

Faith is offered by God and it is up to every individual to determine how he or she will react. Certainly, we have the treasure of faith in earthen vessels (see 2*Cor.* 4:7), an image of the frailty of a human nature (*infirmitas naturae humanae*) not capable of doing anything without God's help.[22]

[16] See Ambrosiaster, *In Rom.* 5.12 (CSEL 81/1, 165.16-167.2). The motiv appears also *In Rom.* 7.4, 8.12 (CSEL 81/1, 215.27, 269.23f.) and *In Col.* 2.15 (CSEL 81/3, 186.23-9); see Alessandra Pollastri, *Ambrosiaster: Commento alla lettera ai Romani* (Aquila, 1977), 115; Jean Rivière, Le droit du démon sur les pécheurs avant saint Augustin: *RTAM* 3 (1931) 113-39, 126.

[17] See Ambrosiaster, *In Rom.* 5.14, 5.15 (CSEL 81/1, 173.3-7, 179.18-181.8).

[18] See Ambrosiaster, *In Rom.* 4.23-5, 5.15, 6.12 (CSEL 81/1, 151.1-4, 179.18-181.3, 199.10-2).

[19] See Ambrosiaster, *In Rom.* 8.28, 8.29, 8.30, 9.11-13 (CSEL 81/1, 289.28-291.2, 292.3-9, 293.3-11, 315.17-317.20); *In Eph.* 1.4 (CSEL 81/3, 73.3-10).

[20] See Ambrosiaster, *In Rom.* 2.3, 2.11, 9.11-3 (CSEL 81/1, 63.17f., 71.19-28, 317.4-11); *In Gal.* 2.3 (CSEL 81/3, 23.1-10).

[21] Ambrosiaster, *In Rom.* 4.4 (CSEL 81/1, 129.25ff.): *Credere autem et non credere voluntatis est. Neque enim quis cogi potest ad id quod manifestum non est, sed invitatur quia non extorquetur, sed suadetur.*

[22] See Ambrosiaster, *In 2 Cor.* 3.17, 4.7 (CSEL 81/2, 219.2-7, 223.24-6).

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God certainly wants 'all men to be saved' (1*Tim.* 2:4), but not against their will. Ambrosiaster compares it to a sick person and a physician: he who does not want to be healed, hardly will be, even if he was given a medicine against his will. So salvation, our spiritual medicine, is given by faith. It helps the pious, but can harm if not accepted by the whole mind.[23]

Thus, according to Ambrosiaster, God has the initiative. It is he who invites us to believe; man first has to decide and then, with God's help, to persevere. '[The apostle] testifies that God supports good deeds. All grace is referred to God, so that the will would be ours, but the perfection is God's.'[24]

Freedom to want or not to want

A similar question is posed by Jerome. He points out that God works 'all things according to the counsel of his will' (*consilio voluntatis suae*, *Eph.* 1:11) and whatever he wants is fulfilled. God wants 'all men to be saved' (1*Tim.* 2:4) but not to be saved necessarily. 'No one is saved apart from his own will', Jerome adds.[25] Why, then, did God not create human beings in such a way that they would necessarily behave well? If they are to be an image of God, answers Jerome (following Origen), they have to behave well from freedom, not from necessity. 'Nothing may be called the good, if it is not voluntary'.[26]

In accordance with this principle, Jerome explains that God's vocation does not impose necessity on human behaviour. 'Different is the work of God, different is the work of man: God calls, man either believes or does not believe.'[27] Man is affected by outside stimuli, but one can nevertheless agree or decline. Even if the apostle says 'you do what you do not want to do' (*Gal.* 5:17), it does not mean that we would be 'deprived of free will' (*non quo proprium nobis tulerit arbitrium*).[28] Similarly, we are saved through faith, which is God's gift, but it does not contradict our free will because our good will also originates from God.[29]

[23] See Ambrosiaster, *In 1 Tim.* 2.1-4 (CSEL 81/3, 260.20-261.10).

[24] Ambrosiaster, *In Phil.* 2.12-13 (CSEL 81/3, 146.5-7): *Deum bonos conatus adiuvare testatur. Omnem enim gratiam semper reportat ad deum, ut nostrum sit velle, perficere vero dei.*

[25] Jerome, *In Eph.* I 1.11 (PL 26, 454C): *Sed, quia nullus absque propria voluntate salvatur (liberi enim arbitrii sumus), vult nos bonum velle, ut cum voluerimus, velit in nobis et ipse suum implere consilium.* ET Ronald Heine, *The Commentaries of Origen and Jerome on St. Paul's Epistle to the Ephesians* (Oxford, 2002), 99.

[26] Jerome, *In Philem.* 14 (CChr.SL 77C, 96.390-97.420): *Nihil quippe bonum dici potest, nisi quod ultroneum est.* See Origen, *Homiliae in Ieremiam* 20.2 (SC 238, 254-6) and *De oratione* 29.15 (GCS 3, 390.23-391.1).

[27] Jerome, *In Gal.* III 5.8 (CChr.SL 77A, 161.11-3): *Aliud quippe Dei opus est, aliud hominum: Dei opus est vocare, hominum vel credere vel non credere.*

[28] See Jerome, *In Gal.* III 5.17 (CChr.SL 77A, 178.3-179.15).

[29] See Jerome, *In Eph.* I 2.8-9 (PL 26, 470A-B), see also *Commentarii in Hiezechielem* 4.16.14 (CChr.SL 75, 180.1398-418).

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Conclusion

The earliest Latin commentators on Paul's letters emphasise both human freedom and the necessity of divine help. In Victorinus, a moment of decision is of ontological value, because through it, souls gain their perfection. Ambrosiaster, when explaining Adam's sin, cannot admit that people would be punished for a sin they did not commit or saved against their will. Also, Jerome stresses that God wants all men to be saved, but not apart from their own will. Thus the debate on human will and divine assistance is open but without posing a sharp contrast or rivalry, as would happen several decades later, between both sides, between human effort and God's help.

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'Tempted as we are': Christology and the Analysis of the Passions

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In his groundbreaking study of Dostoevsky's poetics, Mikhail Bakhtin identified the key to understanding Dostoevsky's novels as what he called the 'menippean' tradition in classical drama and narrative. Menippean satire, which reached a definitive form in the two centuries before the Christian era, though its origins are a good deal older, represents, Bakhtin argues, a genre in which extreme, sometimes fantastical, situations are elaborated in order to provoke narrative development – more particularly narrative development that leads to the unveiling of a truth: 'the issue', writes Bakhtin, 'is precisely the testing of an *idea*, of a *truth*, and not the testing of a particular human character, whether an individual or a social type. The testing of a wise man is a test of his philosophical position in the world, not a test of any other feature of his character independent of that position'.[1] Crucial to the genre is *syncrisis*, the bringing-together of sharply opposed views and personal types in dialogue, as a means of testing what is claimed to be the truth. And Bakhtin argues that this tradition exercises a profound shaping influence on early Christian narrative. The Acts of the Martyrs are closer to *The Golden Ass* than to either Plato or Sophocles, as indeed are substantial tracts of the Gospels themselves; in these texts, 'the classical Christian dialogic syncrises are worked out: that of the tempted (Christ or a righteous man) with the tempter, the believer with the unbeliever, the righteous man with the sinner ...'[2] The narratives are organized around testing and manifestation; the narrative drive is towards the vindication of a truth.

Debate continues about Bakhtin's understanding of the menippean style; but he has undoubtedly put his finger on a feature of early Christian narrative that is at once recognizable. Dialogue uncovers the full implications of a confession of faith; suffering tests its strength and authenticity. And what Bakhtin calls the 'carnivalistic' element of menippean satire appears, as the Christian narrative tradition develops, in the extremity and near absurdity of the trials endured and the over-coloured depiction of evil opponents and of their final humiliations. The major qualification we should have to enter, though, is to do with

[1] Mikhail Bakhtin, *Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics*, ed. and tr. by C. Emerson and intr. by W.C. Booth (Minneapolis, MN, 1984), 114-5.
[2] *Ibid.* 135.

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what is being tested. It is not quite adequate to suggest that all that is at stake in Christian 'menippea' is the testing of an 'idea', the 'truth' being tested is unmistakeably the integrity of a particular person in respect of their *comprehensive* fidelity and obedience to the law of God or the Kingship of Christ (think of the Passion of the Scillitan Martyrs). The hostile probing on the part of circumstance and enemies is designed to vindicate not simply a philosophical point of view but an authority superior to that which is conducting the testing or probing.

ll this by way of preface, chiefly because we need to remember what *peirasmos* does and doesn't mean in antiquity and late antiquity. 'Temptation' in the modern sense – an impulse towards an act that is compromising or forbidden – is essentially a Christian invention, and one that takes centuries to develop; and this modern sense is confusing at best in much of the classical and patristic context because it has completely lost the dimension of something that is directed towards the discovery of an otherwise hidden truth, something that may be the deliberate act of another agent (human or diabolical) or the providential consequence of circumstances. The word is related to the same root as 'empirical',[3] and in classical Greek its primary sense is definitely not psychological; something of the sense of a probation of moral integrity appears here and there in the later classical literature,[4] but it is clearly Septuagintal and Christian Greek that bring to the foreground the connotation of a test of virtue and fidelity. The monastic watchword, 'expect temptations', means simply 'expect to be tested continually on your progress' – both by inner motions of instability and by exterior trials; expect to have your inner life challenged by being made visible in critical decisions. From the late fourth century a literature of considerable sophistication grows up as a diagnostic tool for understanding and resisting both sorts of *peirasmos*, internally and externally generated; and in the process of this refinement, something more like the modern sense of 'temptation' comes gradually into view.

The Christian narrative was from the first one of probation and discovery. The fact that believers were of necessity placed in a position that invited hostility and conflicts over loyalty to the established order gave particular importance to the biblical records of purgative loss and suffering. Jesus in the Gospel endures his own period of *peirasmos* in the desert and speaks of his disciples as sharing in a continuing process of testing (*Luke* 22:28); the prayer he gave his disciples includes a petition to be spared *peirasmos*. The Letter of James has a difficult and easily misunderstood passage in the first chapter (1:13-4),

[3] And – because of the secondary but common meaning of 'assault' – to the root of 'pirate' also.

[4] Liddell and Scott note a line in Apollonius of Rhodes (3.101) which comes close to using the verb in the sense of 'seduce'. The whole issue of the transition from classical to Christian accounts of inner instability is charted brilliantly in Richard Sorabji, *Emotion and Peace of Mind: From Stoic Agitation to Christian Temptation* (Oxford, 2000); chs. 22 and 23 are especially relevant to this paper.

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asserting that God does not 'test' or attack us as he himself is never 'tested', or perhaps 'assaulted', by evil things (or persons?), *apeirastos kakon*; *peirasmos* arises when we give way to our own wrong desires. This is undoubtedly the nearest we come in the New Testament to a straightforward understanding of *peirasmos* as a seduction to wrongdoing, and as such it is untypical; but we should be careful not to assimilate it too rapidly. The sense seems to be that, as God is not put to the test by evil desires, since he is wholly good, we cannot imagine him deliberately stirring up evil desires in us in order to test our fidelity; the test is self-generated. *Peirasmos*, trial, is what happens when we give way to wicked promptings, a time of testing suffering that we have brought upon ourselves. As we shall see, this anticipates distinctions drawn much later about internal and external testings. But whatever the exact meaning of these verses, it is clear that the Christian believer lives in an imaginative climate in which his or her inner disposition constantly has to be made manifest by events that probe its depth and reality. Instability within and suffering from without provide the means by which truth will be made plain.

But if Jesus is subject to 'testing', if indeed he is 'tested in every way as we are' (*Hebr.* 3:15), does this mean that we are to ascribe to him some sort of inner instability? Of course he is 'tried' by his sufferings; but is he also, like us, tested by any internal mobility or uncertainty of desire? In this lecture, I want to look briefly at how the significance of Christ's *peirasmoi* is dealt with by one early Christian tradition of thought, and how this clarifies both a Christological and an anthropological point, in a way which ultimately carries some lasting significance for the Christian imagination. The truth is that the correlation between Jesus' temptations and ours is one that is dealt with in a number of places but seldom in any great depth before the early fifth century.[5] The simple point made by Tertullian in *De baptismo* and *De jejunio*, that we should fast because Jesus did, or the recommendation of Chrysostom (*Hom. in Matt.* 12) to look on Christ's resistance under temptation as a good example – these do not represent a particularly detailed or sophisticated treatment of the issue; for this we need to look elsewhere. What we shall be examining is the process by which a mixture of Origen's exegesis and Evagrius' anthropology eventually produces, in Cassian's *Conferences*, an ingenious and fruitful handling of the connection. But its origins are still further back.

Irenaeus's famous passage on 'recapitulation' in the fifth book of *Adversus haereses* (22.2) is the starting point. Christ as the Second Adam reproduces the history of the First Adam but with a life-giving, not a death-dealing result; and among the aspects of Jesus' history that is significant in this regard, the experience of *peirasmos* is crucial. Adam was tested by hunger and gave way, eating the fatal fruit; Christ was likewise tested by hunger in the desert and by Satan's

[5] Maurice Steiner, *La tentation de Jesus dans l'interpretation patristique de Saint Justin à Origène* (Paris, 1962), gives a survey of the material.

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invitation to turn stones into bread, and he refused. And it is this idea of an 'Adamic' temptation that allows later theologians to clarify what Christ may be said to have endured and what was alien to him. As we shall see, the 'tested as we are' of the Letter to the Hebrews is interpreted not as a statement that Jesus endured *every kind* of testing we have to undergo; as the Letter of James already implies, some sorts of testing are our own silly fault, and we are fortunate if we emerge from them without serious damage. But Jesus is tested yet 'without sin', says Hebrews; so his *peirasmoi* cannot be the result of prior errors on his part. We can begin to see the attractiveness of the reference to Adam, because Adam's testing antedates sin; whatever Adam has to endure must be from a source other than his own will or his corrupt desire.

But this does not all emerge at once. Origen is clearly aware of the Adamic reading of the narratives of Jesus' temptations in the wilderness, and we find him using it in surviving catena fragments of the Matthew[6] and Luke[7] commentaries, though it is not explicit in the longest continuous treatment that survives in the homilies on Luke.[8] There is also a parallel drawn in the Matthew fragments[9] with the sufferings of Job: hidden virtue has to be made visible through the process of testing, and the destruction of what Job possesses makes clear the difference between true (disinterested) virtue and false. The reversal of Adam's failure is evidently a catechetical tradition which Origen inherits; there is little likelihood of its coming from Irenaeus directly, which suggests in turn that the trope may not be original or unique to Irenaeus. And it can reasonably be said that the Lucan homilies discussion presupposes the idea that Jesus' resistance to *peirasmos* is an aspect of the renovation of Adamic liberty in human nature. *Tentatur autem ob id, ut nos quoque illo vincente vincamus* says the Latin[10] (though this is missing in the corresponding Greek text). If this is authentic, the victory of Jesus specifically makes possible victory for the believer, rather than being simply an example of good practice. We should not complain in the face of testing, since the incarnate Son has endured the same, and his victorious future can be ours.[11] 'We shall be like him', as we are assured in 1*John* 3:2. The pattern assumed seems to be that as he has become like us in submitting to trials, so we shall be conformed to his likeness. It would be hard not to see an implicit allusion here to one of the most important Adam – Christ texts, 1*Cor.* 15:45-9.

It is not, of course, the eternal Son who is directly tested but the human being 'assumed' by the Son, which is why the reply to the first temptation is

[6] GCS 41, 40, *frg.* 62.
[7] GCS 39, 265, *frg.* 96.
[8] 29-31, GCS 49, 167-80.
[9] *Loc. cit.*
[10] GCS 49, *hom.* 29, 168, 21-3.
[11] *Ibid.* 171,7ff.

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that *man* does not live by bread alone but by the Word:[12] *this* human being lives simply and solely by the indwelling Word, and thus is uniquely placed to speak of how the wellspring of the spiritual life of human beings lies in the divine Logos. The impassibility of the Word must be upheld; but the created *nous* uniquely bound to the life of the Word which constitutes the inner life of Jesus is in theory vulnerable, like every *nous*, to that change of place or condition which comes as a result of turning away from contemplation: allied as it now is with the *psyche*, the level of feeling, instinct and reaction in the life of incarnated beings, it is capable of entertaining the possibility of change, as it is capable of being aware of the beginnings, the 'first motions' of grief or fear, a point Origen addresses in a slightly different context in the Commentary on Matthew.[13] However, since it is *de facto* immutable,[14] there is no possible mental image or proposal that could make it actually depart from the Logos to whom it has been united since before the foundation of the world we know. And this explains why Origen can say with such assurance that Jesus endures not only the temptations we face but more than all the world could bear.[15] He experiences in his humanity every *peirasmos* that human beings will ever know,[16] and so can say to Satan, *duc quo vis, tenta ut placet.*[17]

The *de facto* impassibility and immutability of Jesus' spirit is thus what makes his victory secure; and, as part of his whole saving work on earth, his triumphant emergence from Satan's testing helps to release our spiritual intellects from their bondage to the flesh. It is clear to Origen that, in one sense, no form of *peirasmos* is unthinkable for Jesus (as if there were temptations he couldn't manage); but, if we put together the homiletic material with the more speculative treatment elsewhere in his work of Jesus' mental life, we should have to say that any temptation resulting from prior weakness could not have a role in the *nous* and *psyche* of Jesus. Were the devil to approach Jesus with the kind of temptation that does derive from such weakness, it would be refused without the remotest hint of struggle. Yet there are matters that impinge a little more directly, where even the pure *nous* of Christ acknowledges the factors that in a weaker person would cause instability; hence the concessions about Jesus feeling the first stirrings of the passion of grief or fear. It is this question about the kinds of weakness that create 'trying' situations irrespective of our will or our level of spiritual maturity that awaits fuller treatment by a later generation and appears as a significant theme in Evagrius.

[12] *Ibid.* 170,5ff.

[13] GCS 11, 206-7; see also Richard Sorabji (2000), 346-51, and Rowan D. Williams, 'Origen on the Soul of Jesus', *Origeniana Tertia*, ed. Richard Hanson and Henri Crouzel (Rome, 1985), 131-7, on how Origen conceives the coexistence of passible and impassible in the inner life of Jesus.

[14] *De princ.*, II 6, 5 – *longi usus affecta iam versus sit in naturam.*

[15] 167, 21-168, 5.

[16] *Ibid.* 168, 18ff.

[17] *Hom.* 31, 175, 10.

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Right at the beginning of his treatise on *Thoughts*, *logismoi* (long preserved – at least in substantial part – under the name of Nilus of Sinai), Evagrius proposes that we should think of three primary areas in which mental distortion is possible – greed, acquisitiveness and vainglory;[18] and these are the three passions that are put before Christ by the devil in the wilderness.[19] To put this in a wider context: his definition of *peirasmos* in the *Gnostikos* (chapter 42) is centred upon false knowledge: 'testing for the Gnostic is by way of a false impression in relation to the *nous* – an impression that presents what exists as if it did not exist, what doesn't exist as if it did, or what exists as it existed in a way different from the way it actually does'.[20] And in the treatise on *logismoi*[21] he has more to say about how such false impressions work; they represent the triumph of 'demonic' thinking, the devilish reasoning that presents reality to us simply in terms of its desirability in order to gain pleasure or power. This is opposed both to human thinking, which establishes whether things exist, and angelic, which discloses the real meaning of what exists.

The devil cannot do us any physical harm, according to Evagrius, as he is an intellectual being only (which of course also implies that externally generated *peirasmoi* are not his work); all he can do is prompt us to misread and misunderstand the physical order by seeking to manipulate our own intellectual equipment.[22] Thus the three passions from which others derive greed, acquisitiveness and vainglory, are the three fundamental ways in which we can misjudge our relation with the material world, three forms of seeing physical reality in terms of pleasure or power – the direct absorption of matter in order to please the stomach, the accumulation of wealth of whatever kind to create false security, reliance on worldly rather than heavenly strength, and the use of other people's opinions to guarantee one's own sense of worth. It is interesting, and will be significant for the next part of our story, that sexual passion and the testings that relate to this are seen as derivative of the three basic passions. It is also worth noting that these are clearly understood as endemic to the state of embodiedness, life in a material body among material bodies. There is an obvious sense in which the fundamental spiritual challenge for an embodied *nous* is the seduction of a kind of false spiritualism – seeing the otherness of the material world only in terms of the state of your own mind – without considering what the 'angelic' logos has to tell you about the God-given meaning of what you see (the Evagrian *physike theoria* is just this process of assimilation to the

[18] *Gastrimargia, philarguria* and 'the things that press us in the direction of human *doxa*'; *Sur les pensées*, ed. Paul Gehin, Claire Guillaumont and Antoine Guillaumont, SC 438 (Paris, 1998), 148ff.

[19] *Ibid.* 152, 17ff.

[20] Antoine Guillaumont and Claire Guillaumont (eds.), *La gnostique*, SC 356 (Paris, 1989), 170f.

[21] ch. 8, 176f.

[22] e.g., *Thoughts*, chs. 2 and 4.

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angelic logos, since it is the deciphering of God's order and purpose in the things of the material world). In the twenty-fifth chapter of the treatise on *logismoi*,[23] Evagrius takes this further by describing what happens when we give way under *peirasmos* in terms of the *nous* seizing upon material images of possible actions, creating a fictional world and fictional relationships. The mind that is undergoing testing is one in which, he says, our normal modes of perception are skewed. Usually we 'see' our own bodies but not our faces, while we see others clearly and completely; when in the throes of *peirasmos*, this is impossible.[24] There can only be 'imperfect' mental images of bodily relation.[25] The other whom we normally see whole evaporates, to be replaced by our fantasies; there is nothing real with which we are engaging, yet we elaborate detailed physical scenarios. And it is often only by arousing contrary passions and images that we can expel diabolically-induced fantasy – an echo of the Poseidonian tactics suggested by other Christian writers like Gregory of Nyssa,[26] but going rather further in suggesting that deliberate use of images in this way can persuade us that all objects of desire are interchangeable for the distorted mind and therefore irrational. When we see that the object of distorted desire or demonic thinking is really no object at all, we can be set free from that irrational desire.

The whole complex question of the point at which culpability enters when we are faced with 'testing' emotions or images is dealt with more fully by others, notably Mark the Ascetic and Hesychius. Evagrius assumes that the point of surrender is when we entertain specific images of ourselves doing what the mind has conceived as possible or attractive; Hesychius expresses this in terms of the move from *probole* to *homilia*, a discursive consideration of what it would be like to do something in which, as he puts it, human *logos* is mixed up with diabolical.[27] Culpability is thus not in the mere recognition that such and such a course of action is possible or even in some sense desirable;[28] it is in the self-identification of the believer with an imagined narrative, as we might put it. The use of the imagination in this context becomes a capitulation to that 'demonic' mindset in which the actual world is absorbed into the self's desire for pleasure or control.

Evagrius touches only fairly briefly on the temptations of Christ; but it is clear that his analysis provides possible tools for a reworking of the exegetical

[23] *Ed. cit.* 240-5.

[24] 242, 38ff.

[25] 244, 50ff.

[26] As, for example, in the *De anima et resurrectione*.

[27] 'On Watchfulness and Holiness', 46 in the *Philokalia* text; see vol. I of the translation by Gerald E.H. Palmer, Philip Sherrard, and Kallistos Ware (London, 1979), 170f.

[28] In the treatise *On the Virtues and the Vices*, ascribed to John Damascene, this is put in terms of a simple presence in the mind of the prompting, 'Do this!' – and this is identified as the nature of the provocation experienced by Jesus in the wilderness; see p. 338 of vol. II of the *Philokalia* (London, 1981).

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tradition connected with Origen. This reworking is carried through by Cassian, in the fifth of the Conferences (Abba Serapion on the eight principal faults):[29] it is a laboured exposition, but a serious attempt to do justice both to the 'tempted as we are' text of Hebrews and to the carefully differentiated anthropology and psychology of the Evagrian heritage. Although Godin[30] has said that it stresses the discontinuity between the temptations of Jesus and our own, this overlooks the significant relation between this discussion and the whole ascetic schema of Evagrius and others. The concentration on the Adamic tradition is not, in this connection, a way of distancing Jesus' temptations from those of others, nor even just part of an anti-Pelagian strategy (though Godin is right to note that this is an important element in the background). As we shall see, Cassian is clear that the resistance of Christ under *peirasmos* is an example for us, and that the 'Adamic' analysis of passion tells us a good deal about how we are to understand our internal life.

Abba Serapion begins by listing the eight faults in their Evagrian order, beginning with gluttony, and then offers an initial distinction between those thoughts which are 'natural' to us and those which are not based on natural need, followed by another, fourfold classification – thoughts that require a fleshly act to realise them, thoughts that need no bodily correlate, thoughts that are stirred by outside stimulus, and thoughts that are self-generated. Gluttony and fornication are 'natural', in that they arise without deliberate mental decision, and both are necessarily bound up with bodily actions and external things. The examples given are those of the First and the Second Adams: 'the First Adam could not have fallen a victim to gluttony unless he had had material food at hand, and had used it wrongly, nor could the Second Adam be tempted without the enticement of some object, when it was said to him: 'If thou art the Son of God ...' (V 4, 232). Hence the passions of gluttony and unchastity are to be dealt with by bodily as well as spiritual discipline, and particularly by simple physical removal from provoking objects or environments.

The allusion to the First and Second Adams triggers two chapters on the *peirasmoi* of Jesus, beginning with a clear denial that Jesus could have been subject to illicit sexual promptings. Although these happen in us without initial consent (and the mere presence of lustful impulse is thus not *ipso facto* sinful), their effect is corrupting; Jesus, who is without qualification holy, as the angel promises to Mary, cannot be open to this 'infection', in spite of being 'tempted as we are'. This sets up an obvious problem that the sixth chapter attempts to unravel; and it does so by utilising a version of Evagrius' typology of the passions, combined with a theological argument about the Second Adam that has notable echoes of Irenaeus once again. Christ is perfectly in the image of God, and thus it is right for him to experience the trials of the First Adam which

[29] SC 42, 192-5.

[30] André Godin, *Dictionnaire de Spiritualité*, XV (1988), 226.

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came upon him while he still retained the divine image unspoiled. These trials are the promptings of gluttony, *kenodoxia* and pride – gluttony through the seduction of the forbidden fruit, vainglory through the promise that 'Your eyes shall be opened', pride in relation to 'Ye shall be as gods' (239). The three gospel temptations, in their Matthaean order, correspond to these primordial encounters with passion. Jesus' response is an example to us; but more importantly the victory over these trials is part of the liberation of humanity; it does not simply set an example, it makes possible a different kind of response. And in passing we have an allusion to the creation from virgin earth/conception from virgin Mary parallelism used by Irenaeus, to reinforce the Adam typology.

Here, then, is Origen's exegetical theme developed with what might best be called at this point a sub-Evagrian diagnostic of the passions – sub-Evagrian because the three basic passions of Evagrius' treatise are not at first reproduced exactly. It is clear that the radical character of gluttony is the hinge connecting the two; more particularly in this context it allows Cassian to explain that indulgence in gluttony is what opens the door to lust; without the former, the latter would have no power (241). The rest of the argument is less clear, since less is at stake. But Cassian is sensitive to the possible reproach that we are somehow impugning the full humanity of Jesus by exempting him from fleshly desire; and he adds a curious passage, deploying, as do other patristic authors in similar tight corners, the useful Pauline phrase in *Rom.* 8:3 about the '*likeness* of sinful flesh': there is no ambiguity, says Cassian, about the reality of Christ's human bodiliness, but so far as the consequence of the Fall in our bodies is concerned, he can only have the appearance of this. He has no experience of the impulses of fleshly lust, yet his sharing of our nature means that he experiences or understands something of what we undergo in this respect and in all appearances shares our condition. This is a confusing section, but I suspect it means that Jesus behaves with the same physical modesty and avoidance of 'occasions of sin' that we are bound to practise, and that have just been commended in the fourth chapter. The main point, though, is that if Jesus can overcome gluttony, there is no point in Satan testing him with sexual passion. He must try something else.

Here the difference between the Matthaean and Lucan narrative orders allows Cassian to try out a different interpretation and to return to a closer (though not quite complete) correspondence with Evagrius. Although he has begun with Matthew, doubtless reflecting the usual liturgical preference for the first gospel, he now turns to Luke, noting that the third evangelist places the offer of the kingdoms of the world second, and the invitation to jump from the pinnacle of the Temple last. Clearly the Temple temptation represents pride, which appropriately comes last, since, when other passions are overcome, this can remain, and – as Satan above all should know – can be experienced by disembodied angelic spirits. But this means that the vision of the kingdoms of the world has to be related to *covetousness*, which is *radix omnium malorum*

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as Scripture tells us (242). Acquisitiveness does not arise from gluttony; we have seen already that it has a different kind of origin, not being simply a natural propensity of embodied beings; so it is perfectly sensible of Satan to move straight from gluttony to acquisitiveness, and then to conclude with incitement to pride. Thus, Cassian concludes, the Lucan order gives us a precise correspondence with the downfall of Adam: the serpent promises Adam that his eyes will be opened, and Jesus is taken to a mountain where he can see all the kingdoms of the world; the serpent tells Adam that 'Ye shall be as gods', and Satan begins his temptation with 'If thou art the Son of God' (243).

So from the first, Matthaean sequence – gluttony, *kenodoxia*, pride – we have moved to a sequence more obviously indebted to Evagrius, though replacing *kenodoxia* with pride, *superbia*. The conflict of interpretations is a little disconcerting in a relatively short passage, but it is evident that the main interest is in establishing the priority of gluttony and in charting the advance of passion and incitement from the unavoidable consequence of living in the flesh to the wholly internal, the passions that 'can be consummated without any assistance from the body', as the heading of chapter seven puts it. The story of Christ in the desert thus provides not only an example, not only a manifestation of the new Adam restoring human nature, but the confirmation of a particular diagnosis of the relations between the passions. As Serapion is careful to warn his hearers at the end of the fifth Conference (chapter 27), we should not think in terms of a tidy progression, combating and defeating the passions one by one: in actuality, they appear in different ways and with different degrees of force, depending on the character and circumstance of each person, so that we need self-knowledge to fight back adequately. But this does not mean that we can dispense with an understanding of the connections between the passions; for Cassian no less than Evagrius, the *logismoi* that trouble us and test our fidelity are not a disconnected assemblage of regrettable tendencies, but a complex pattern of moral vulnerability. The list of the eight passions or thoughts is less of a catalogue than a genealogy, beginning from the most elementary impulse to misuse the material world we inhabit, and traced through to the most sophisticated of self-delusions.

What are the longer-reach implications of this for the development of theology and spirituality? Cassian's scheme takes it for granted, as does Evagrius, that to live in the material and temporal world is to be vulnerable to the impact of unstable circumstances; and it is how we deal with those circumstances that will bring to light who and what we actually are. Ideally, this is not just – as perhaps for Origen – a revelation of the degree of individual virtue we have privately attained, or even (to take up a very characteristic Origenian theme) of the essential liberty and power of the *nous*, but the fundamental fact of our being, as mortal and material creatures, in the image of God, and destined for the full realisation of that image. The testing of God's Son in the desert uncovers

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his status as the new Adam, as someone who is free from the *inner* consequences of Adam's Fall; but at the same time, this *peirasmos* clearly tells us that the full and unobscured presence of the divine image does not rule out the presence of 'destabilising' elements, elements that are unavoidable side-effects of life in the body and in human society. The reality of a needy or hungry body means that there is always the impulse to exceed what is really necessary; the presence of others means that there is always an impulse to seek the means of power over them; the nature of the self-reflecting mind means that there is always the possibility of fantasies of self-sufficiency, the *autotes* or self-absorption which pride generates. The reality of the divine image consists not in the definitive removal of the conditions that allow these 'testing' elements to persist, but in our confident reliance on the grace of the new Adam working with our good will to control them.

'However far we have advanced, we cannot help being what we were born,' says Serapion in the nineteenth chapter of the same Conference (273). Gluttony is never a possibility we can put behind us, because we always have to think about our bodily needs and nourishment. Conversely (chapter 26), an ascesis that concentrates on bodily discipline alone will fail because it does not reckon with the interconnection of physical impulse with spiritual disorder. Thus the long-standing catechetical association of Jesus' temptations with the testing of Adam in respect of bodily greed has been woven into a general thesis and prescription about the self-understanding of the Christian ascetic, part of an implicit caution against the idea that physical ascesis is either an end in itself or a programme designed to remove us from the material sphere altogether. As Peter Brown and others have long since pointed out, there is in the ascetical tradition a strong but paradoxical valuation of the body: it is where divine meaning is 'inscribed' by the policies of the ascetic, the necessary theatre for realising the life of the image. And what Christ delivers us from is not bodily circumstance, contingency or instability (any more than he delivers us from pride by taking away our intelligence or self-awareness), but from the habits of mind and heart that make of this environment only a theatre for our private obsessions to be staged and our lust for control to be exercised.

The fact that Christ is tested in the way the gospels describe is therefore an affirmation of the inevitability of testing: the image can only emerge credibly if we are ready to face a process of probation that will never stop ('expect *peirasmoi* till your last breath'). To be thus involved in the world of trial is not itself about sin, let alone the inevitability of sin: Christ, the perfect image, undergoes a testing that is like ours in every way – not in the mechanical sense that he experiences every impulse we do and has to battle against faulty desire, but simply in that he begins where we begin, with the central, undramatic, down-to-earth impulse to feed and its possible distortions. Get this wrong (as Adam did) and everything else follows in the way of moral catastrophe; get it right (as Jesus does) and the rest of the spiritual path becomes clear.

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Here too is the root of what is undoubtedly a difficult and controversial feature of Eastern Christology, the conviction given clearer shape by Maximus, for example, that the humanity assumed by the Word is 'unfallen' humanity. But once again, we must be careful to clarify what this does and doesn't mean. As Cassian says, there can be no doubt of the fact that Jesus endured ordinary fleshly experience (though Cassian does not commit himself on whether the humanity of Jesus would have been naturally mortal, which is where later debate often focuses); what he does not have is the 'legacy' of sin. His history is part of the actual history of passible and fallible humankind, but it is also the beginning of a new history: what Adam's choices made possible for him (the rest of the eight diseased passions) are only abstract possibilities for Jesus, since he has not consented to the primary error of Adam. He lives in that – for us – unimaginable place where instability is always real yet always contained, on the threshold between freedom and self-enslavement; and, living there, he promises the Christian ascetic no more and no less, not a disembodied security or a state where no decision and self-examination are needed, but the same liminal condition in which every choice and every change of circumstance take on significance.

A full treatment of all this would, of course, have to include a discussion of how successive teachers deal with the petition in the Lord's Prayer for deliverance from temptation.[31] Cassian himself in the ninth Conference (Abba Isaac on prayer) observes that we can hardly pray not to be put to the proof; it must mean that we pray not to be overcome. 'Job was tempted, but was not led into temptation' (535); he does not give in to what the tempter wants. It is a fairly common way of reading the petition, a reading given clear shape in Origen's *De oratione*. Basil the Great's sixth homily sketches out the beginnings of a distinction between two kinds of temptations, one category that we may ask to be spared, while the other represents what is unavoidable. But the classical statement of this is in Maximus' *De oratione dominica* (paralleled in Centuries III 90-4): Maximus follows Evagrius and Cassian in separating 'natural' tests and trials from issues about which we have a choice (PG 90, 904CD-5A), and develops it a little further by associating 'willed' situations of testing with pleasure and involuntary or natural trials with sorrow (908B). The former have to do with the diversion of love and desire from their proper objects, in search of imagined pleasures (Evagrius is obviously in the background here), and so constitute a *hamartias gennetor*; it is these against which we pray in the Lord's Prayer, while the inevitable trials that are bound up with our earthly condition – the trials of which the Letter of James speaks – must be accepted. In other words, although Maximus does not make the association directly, the *peirasmoi* from which we pray for deliverance are those to which Jesus, on Cassian's

[31] There is some valuable introductory material in Kenneth W. Stevenson, *The Lord's Prayer: A text in Tradition* (London, 2004).

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account, was immune; those we must accept are those he also underwent, those whose presence is not incompatible with the realising of the divine image.

The entire development of a diagnostic and a therapy of passion in Christian ascetic literature from the fourth century onwards, especially in the East, is part of that complex process by which Christianity assisted, remotely and not-so-remotely, in the invention of the 'modern' self – that is, of a conception of human identity in which narrative, uncertainty, choice and self-questioning are focal elements. What we have been examining is one of those strands – there are several – in the history of the Christian tradition that may at first sight appear both to privilege a static understanding of spiritual perfection and to compromise the full humanity of Christ, yet prove on closer examination to invite a more complex and (borrowing from Bakhtin again) 'polyphonic' reading. The testing of Christ by Satan is a process in which Christ's status as Second Adam is made manifest – that is, a process in which the divine image in human form is uncovered in the decisions of this particular human being. Thus the divine image in its human embodiment is shown to be something that necessarily involves intelligent choices made in uncertain circumstances – and not once and for all but as a habit of life. So long as this life lasts – and we should be aware that Cassian will speak earnestly of the need to hasten through it – holiness is not a state beyond uncertainty and trial, and any rhetoric that hints at the attainability of such a state is illusory – a favourite theme for the Desert Fathers, of course. The *apatheia* that flows from a long habit of self-denial and love is indeed a restoration of the primitive stability of the *nous* or *pneuma*, but it is not a self-contained, self-sustaining stability; it has to be exercised and renewed, and will not cease to be probed by contingent circumstances. And it is Christ's status as Second Adam that makes it idle to speculate about which of our specific temptations he faced or to worry about whether or not he really experienced the full range of what we endure in such specifics. He begins where we begin, in the body; and his refusal to misuse the body and its needs means that he has no legacy of weakness or error to carry over into the encounter with other, derivative, trials.

For the contemporary reader, there will still be uncertainty or unease about aspects of Cassian's argument. It is obvious that he assumes that beginning with the body means treating the basic and primitive nature of bodily desire as the genderless need for nourishment; a post-Freudian consciousness will be less content with such an assumption. Equally though, a consciousness that is post-Kleinian as well as post-Freudian might just recognise that Cassian has a point: the inseparability in early infant awareness of the need for nourishment and all other desire, including infant sexuality, suggests that it would indeed be a mistake, as Cassian believed, to treat sexual impulse as independent of a more encompassing set of relationships – even though Cassian's explicit aim is undoubtedly to avoid the embarrassment of attributing any sexual or gendered feeling to Christ. But these are intriguing details for reflection in other contexts.

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The main argument I have been advancing is that Cassian's fusion of Origen and Evagrius in his treatment of Christ's temptation in the desert is a great deal more than a doubtfully consistent marginal speculation. It represents the highly significant crossover point between thinking about the incarnate Word and thinking about the incarnate human spirit which is somewhere in the background of a lot of fourth- and fifth-century writing on the struggle with the passions; it brings together the 'liminal' position of Jesus, eternally poised between absolute stability and the trials to which bodily, social and historical life is vulnerable, and points the ascetic towards that same place, challenging any illusory hopes for a completely secure interiority this side of the grave.

To conclude with another glance at Bakhtin: one of his most interesting recent interpreters, Alexandar Mihailovic, writing about the theological resonance of Bakhtin's criticism, says that 'What really interests Bakhtin in the figure of Christ is his interstitiality and liminality'.[32] Christ stands on the frontier between conjunction and separation, on the frontier between worlds, holding them in both union and otherness. The discussion we have been following of his standing in relation to the passions of the soul is precisely an illustration of that location on the frontier of worlds, in the place of *syncrisis* not just between persons, states of life or systems of thought but between the world itself and its source.

[32] Alexander Mihailovic, *Corporeal Words: Mikhail Bakhtin's Theology of Discourse* (Evanston, IL, 1997), 80.

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The Sinful Subject: Doing Penance in Rome

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Introduction

The philosopher Seneca the Younger wrote his treatise *De Clementia* for Nero in AD 56. Pliny urged the young emperor to rule with mercy, especially in Rome, where even the best of his subjects were guilty of something. 'We all have sinned', Seneca confessed, 'some heavily, others lightly ... against our will and although we held on, we have lost our innocence.'[1] Seneca reminded Nero just how many people 'we all' included:[2] Rome swelled with crowds that could surge through the broadest streets like flash floods, fill every seat in Rome's three great theaters all at once, and devour whatever was grown anywhere in the world. But, if some harsh and tireless judge ever were to wash the streets clean of sinners, whether they were diehards or repentant, they all would be gone, leaving only a void.[3] Any ruler, who did not wish to rule over a ghost town, had practical reason to show mercy.

If Seneca had lived four hundred years later, in the fifth or sixth century, he might have enjoyed life in Rome, when it was easier to find empty seats at the theater, although maybe harder to see a good show; when food still arrived to fill empty bellies, except when the city was under siege; when some of the crowds might have dispersed toward the periphery – the walls and the cemeteries beyond, where temples had been built for a new religion; and when Seneca might have chosen retirement with his books in a southern monastery, rather than suicide, once his emperor turned out to be not very merciful.

[1] Seneca, *De clementia* 1.6.3: Peccavimus omnes, alii gravia, alii leviora, alii ex destinato, alii forte impulsi aut aliena nequitia ablati; alii in bonis consiliis parum fortiter stetimus et innocentiam inviti ac retinentes perdidimus; nec deliquimus tantum, sed usque ad extremum aevi delinquemus. See Brad Inwood, *Reading Seneca: Stoic Philosophy at Rome* (Oxford, 2005), 205-8.

[2] It did not include Nero who, unlike Octavian Augustus, did not need to regret violent acts: Seneca, *De clementia*, 1.11.2 ('haec est, Caesar, clementia vera, quam tu praestas, quae non saevitiae paenitentia coepit'). This is the only instance of *paenitentia* in this treatise, though Seneca used it elsewhere, especially in the *Epistulae morales ad Lucilium*.

[3] Seneca, *De clementia*, 1.6.1: Cogitato, in hac civitate, in qua turba per latissima itinera sine intermissione defluens eliditur, quotiens aliquid obstitit, quod cursum eius velut torrentis rapidi moraretur, in qua tribus eodem tempore theatris caveae postulantur, in qua consumitur quicquid terris omnibus aratur, quanta solitudo ac vastitas futura sit, si nihil relinquitur, nisi quod iudex severus absolverit.

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Seneca also would have found a city whose people still hoped for a merciful judge, one who agreed that even the innocent have fallen, a judge whom heartfelt penance could persuade to be forgiving. But the emperors did not show themselves in Rome often any longer. Now, were Seneca to try and move a ruler to mercy on behalf of a city full of sinners, he well might address the Christian bishop of Rome, who in turn represented a God who was both the harshest and the most merciful judge of all.

Christians were not the first to confess their shortcomings, to say they were sorry, and to hope for forgiveness. Repentance (*paenitentia*) was an ancient emotion.[4] To Roman historians and philosophers, a penitent person was one who knew he had fallen short of his potential but still had it in him to recover. Penance was a process of regret, bound up with self-awareness. Robert Kaster has written that Christianity fundamentally changed what penance meant to ancient people. Actually, we may not know what penance meant to Christians well enough to accept this claim as fact.[5] However familiar penance may be to Romans, Christians, and modern scholars alike, the history of penance still needs work, nowhere more so than in the city of Rome during Late Antiquity.

Why penance?

The history of penance between antiquity and the Reformation is in the process of major revision. Most of the revision stems from new ideas rather than new evidence. Two hypotheses emerged from twentieth-century scholarship and debate, both of them lucid, compelling, and, it now seems, misleading. The first hypothesis has to do with the sacramental nature of penance. According to this hypothesis, early penance was fundamentally public, ending in forgiveness only when a bishop formally reconciled the penitent. Private forms of penance or confession, where they appear to have existed during Late Antiquity, were

[4] Robert A. Kaster, *Emotion, Restraint, and Community in Ancient Rome* (Oxford, 2005), ch. 3: 'The Structure of *Paenitentia* and the Egoism of Regret.' Kaster does not treat *paenitentia* in Seneca, but also see Marcus Wilson, The Subjugation of Grief in Seneca's 'Epistles', in: *The Passions in Roman Thought and Literature*, ed. by Susanna Morton Braund and Christopher Gill (Cambridge, 1997), 48-67; Melissa Barden Dowling, *Clemency and Cruelty in the Roman World* (Ann Arbor, MI, 2006), esp. 194-203. See now Natlie Brigit Molineaux, *Medici et Medicamenta: The Medicine of Penance in Late Antiquity* (Lanham, MD, 2009), 137-71, on 'Penance in Pre-Christian Antiquity'.

[5] Indeed, it may be possible to suggest the opposite. Celsus, for one, appears to have been underwhelmed by the alleged novelty of Christian forgiveness, e.g. Lucio Troiani, A proposito del perdono cristiano, in: *id., Il perdono cristiano e altri studi sul cristianesimo delle origini*, Studi biblici 123 (Brescia, 1999), 95-109. Kaster makes a concession in a footnote (179-80 n. 36), where he writes that James O'Donnell alerted him to Augustine's use of *paenitentia* in the classical sense at *c. adv. leg. et proph.* 1.20.40; otherwise, see Kaster, *Emotion, Restraint, and Community* (2005), 10-12, 81-3.

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either illicit rivals or not true penance at all. The second hypothesis was that public penance may have worked in a predominantly pagan world, but it never worked in Christendom. Once the emperors had thrown the church doors wide open and forced everyone inside, according to many historians, the heart went out of Christian repentance. Lay people simply were not up to the task, and their bishops were unwilling to dumb penance down to suit them, so penance rapidly declined in practice. Some of the late antique evidence seems to support these two hypotheses, some seems to contradict them, but most of it, in fact, seems hardly to bear on the sacramental nature or alleged decline of penance at all.

Instead, those topics represent the concerns of medieval reformers and it is on them that most revisionist work on penance has focused, rather than on Late Antiquity.[6] There are exceptions, including Eric Rebillard's first book, *In hora mortis*, and Peter Brown's revised *Rise of Western Christendom*, which both treat penance extensively. Rebillard looks for changes in the way bishops in the fifth century prepared Christians for death and final reckoning, while Brown argues for thinking about late antique penance in terms of political ideology – a God who is moved to mercy in ways similar to a late Roman emperor, one more comfortable with his authority than the ideal ruler Seneca cherished.[7] But we have not yet found a way to write the history of late antique penance on its own terms, without imposing the shape of medieval penance, so familiar from later centuries.

Why Rome?

We well might doubt whether Rome is the place to focus a new study of late antique penance. Of all the churches in the early Christian world, surely Rome's

[6] See esp. Mayke de Jong, Transformations of Penance, in: *Rituals of Power from Late Antiquity to the Early Middle Ages*, ed. Frans Theuws and Janet L. Nelson (Leiden, 2000), 185-224; Rob Meens, The Frequency and Nature of Early Medieval Penance, in: *Handling Sin: Confession in the Middle Ages*, ed. Peter Biller and A.J. Minnis (Woodbridge, U.K., 1998), 35-61; Sarah Hamilton, *The Practice of Penance, 900–1050* (Woodbridge, U.K., 2001); Mary C. Mansfield, *Humiliation of Sinners: Public Penance in Thirteenth Century France* (Ithaca, NY, 1995).

[7] Éric Rebillard, *In hora mortis: Évolution de la pastorale chrétienne de la mort aux IVe et Ve siècles dans l'occident latin* (Rome, 1994); Peter Brown, *The Rise of Western Christendom: Triumph and Diversity, A.D. 200–1000*, 2nd ed. (Oxford, 2003); also *id.*, Vers la naissance du Purgatoire: Amnistie et pénitence dans le christianisme occidental de l'Antiquité tardive au Haut Moyen Âge: *Annales HSS* 52 (1997) 1247-61; *id.*, The Decline of the Empire of God: Amnesty, Penance, and the Afterlife from Late Antiquity to the Middle Ages, in: *Last Things: Death and the Apocalypse in the Middle Ages*, ed. by Caroline Walker Bynum and Paul Freedman (Philadelphia, PA, 2000), 41-59. Among other good studies on late antique penance, see especially Allan Fitzgerald, *Conversion through Penance in the Italian Church of the Fourth and Fifth Centuries: New Approaches to the Experience of Conversion from Sin* (New York, 1988), which indeed offered new approaches that seem to have found few followers, an unfortunate result, perhaps, of not directly engaging the topic within the familiar terms of the scholarly debate.

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must be the most exhaustively studied in every regard, including penance. It has earned the attention. After all, the first bishop of Rome, Peter, was said to have turned thousands of Jews into tearful penitents – a miracle one fifth-century bishop of Rome recalled in a Palm Sunday sermon.[8] That was just the beginning of Rome's shared history with penance. Few topics are so central to church history as the idea of papal primacy, at whose core we find the apostolic keys, which gave bishops the power to reward penance with forgiveness.[9] Many of our best-known documents for early penance emanated from Rome, while pilgrims who journeyed there expected forgiveness for their labors.[10] Finally, Rome and its church were so different from everywhere else in the contemporary Christian world that we worry, rightly, whether anything we discover there can be meaningfully applied elsewhere. Nevertheless, however drastically we may revise the history of penance, the church of Rome and its bishops doubtlessly will remain a major component of the story.

Rome will remain but it will not look the same. New evidence and new ideas both are changing how we think about the city and its topography, its economy and its elite, and the religious, artistic, and social lives of its visitors, residents, and rulers.[11] Old evidence is getting new attention, as, for example, the thousands of Christian inscriptions still being edited and indexed, and the martyrs' passions, carefully treated as historical evidence rather than dismissed as pious fiction.[12]

[8] Leo I, *Serm.* 62.3 (Palm Sunday 452): 'multorum ad paenitentiam corda conuerteret'; see *Acts* 2:37-47. Leo also addressed Jews directly in the present tense, telling them that penance was available to them but not to Judas: *Serm.* 52.5, 54.3.

[9] E.g. Julius Gross, Die Schlüsselgewalt nach Haimo von Auxerre: *Zeitschrift für Religions- und Geistesgeschichte* 9 (1957) 30-41; Kenneth Hein, *Eucharist and Excommunication: A Study in Early Christian Doctrine and Discipline*, European University Papers Series 23, Theology 19 (Bern and Frankfurt, 1973), 69-77.

[10] Many pilgrims described themselves as *peccator* in the graffiti, but the practice may be later than the sixth century. See e.g. Victor Saxer, Pilgerwesen in Italien und Rom im späten Altertum und Frühmittelalter, in: *Akten des XII. Internationalen Kongresses für christliche Archäologie, Bonn, 22.-28. September 1991*, ed. by Ernst Dassmann and Josef Engemann, Studi di antichità cristiana 52 = Jahrbuch für Antike und Christentum, Ergänzungsband 20:1, 2 vols. (Münster, 1994), 36-57.

[11] Important collections include Kate Cooper and Julia Hillner (eds.), *Religion, Dynasty, and Patronage in a Christian Capital: Rome, c. 300-900* (Cambridge, UK, 2007); *Roma fra Oriente e Occidente*, Settimane di Studio del Centro Italiano di Studi sull'Alto Medioevo 49, 2 vols. (Spoleto, 2002); *Christiana Loca: lo spazio cristiano nella Roma del primo millennio* [*Christian Space in Rome during the first Millennium*], 2 vols. (Rome, 2002); Federico Guidobaldi and Alessandra Guiglia Guidobaldi (eds.), *Ecclesiae Urbis*, Studi di Antichità Cristiana 59, 3 vols. (Vatican City, 2002); *Roma nell'alto medioevo*, Settimane di Studio del Centro Italiano di Studi sull'Alto Medioevo 48, 2 vols. (Spoleto, 2001); Letizia Pani Ermini and Paolo Siniscalco (eds.), *La comunità cristiana a Roma: La sua vita e la sua cultura dalle origini all'alto Medio Evo*, Atti e Documenti 9 (Vatican City, 2000); Lidia Paroli and Paolo Delogu (eds.), *La Storia economica di Roma nell'alto Medioevo alla luce dei recenti scavi archeologici*, Biblioteca di archeologia medievale 10 (Florence, 1993).

[12] See below. Along with the ongoing *Inscriptiones Christianae Vrbis Romae, nova series* (Rome, 1922-), online databases are very important but still incomplete: Epigraphic Database Roma (http://www.edr-edr.it/index_it.html), along with Epigraphische Datenbank Heidelberg

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Ongoing excavations offer new evidence for building patterns and economic activity, while scrutiny of literary evidence and archival materials has improved our understanding of well-known sites.[13] As I will suggest later, there is new evidence here even for historians of penance, if we choose to look beyond treatises, councils, and papal registers.[14]

As for new ideas, recent scholarship on Rome has emphasized its diversity and the competition for patronage and power that its bishops faced well into the sixth century. The city's elites, for example, seem to have entered Christian life largely on their own terms, continuing to run their households their own way, even when it came to religion, and controlling wealth no individual bishop could yet rival.[15] In terms of diversity, the development of Rome's stational liturgy is known to most historians of the church, but does not tell us how forgiveness was handled in the city's various basilicas, numerous parish churches, martyrs' shrines, family graves, and domestic chapels.[16] These were places where

(http://www.uni-heidelberg.de/institute/sonst/adw/edh/) and Epigraphic Database Bari (http://www.edb.uniba.it/).

[13] Robert Coates-Stephens has been especially productive in synthesizing literary, archival, and archaeological materials, *e.g.* The Walls and Aqueducts of Rome in the Early Middle Ages, A.D. 500-1000: *Journal of Roman Studies* 88 (1998) 166-78. Sible de Blaauw, *Cultus et Decor: Liturgia e Architettura nella Roma Tardoantica e Medievale* (Vatican City, 1994), and his subsequent work draw on literature as well as liturgical texts. Also Vincenzo Fiocchi Nicolai, Elementi di trasformazione dello spazio funerario tra tarda antichità ed altomedioevo, in: *Uomo e spazio nell'Alto Medioevo*, Settimane di Studi del Centro italiano di Studi sull'alto medioevo 50, 2 vols. (Spoleto, 2003), 921-69; Kate Cooper, J. Hillner, Conrad Leyser, Dark Age Rome: Towards an Interactive Topography, in: *Social and Political Life in Late Antiquity*, ed. by William Bowden, Adam Gutteridge, Carlos Machado, Late Antique Archaeology 3.1 (Leiden and Boston, 2006), 311-37.

[14] Patrick Saint-Roch, *La pénitence dans les conciles et les lettres des papes des origines à la mort de Gregoire le Grand* (Vatican City, 1991), which depends mostly on councils, occasionally on papal letters, and also on sacramentaries that survive only from later centuries, enjoys frequent citation. Other studies of Roman bishops on penance not cited below include Joseph Tixeront, La doctrine pénitentielle de S. Grégoire le Grand: *Bulletin d'ancienne littérature et d'archéologie chrétiennes* 2 (1912) 241-58, repr. in *id.*, *Mélanges de patrologie et d'histoire des dogmes* (Paris, 1921), 237-60; Peter J. Riga, Penance in St. Leo the Great: *Eglise et théologie* 5 (1974) 5-32; Claude Dagens, La prédiction de la penitence chez S. Grégoire le Grand, in: *Mens concordet voci* (Paris, 1983), 471-83.

[15] E.g. Michele Renee Salzman, The Christianization of Sacred Time and Sacred Space, in: *The Transformation of Vrbs Roma in Late Antiquity*, ed. by William V. Harris (Portsmouth, RI: Journal of Roman Archaeology, 1999), 123-34; *ead.*, Competing Claims to 'Nobilitas' in the Western Empire of the Fourth and Fifth Centuries: *Journal of Early Christian Studies* 9 (2001) 359-85; Kate Cooper, Poverty, Obligation, and Inheritance: Roman Heiresses and the Varieties of Senatorial Christianity in Fifth-Century Rome, in: *Religion, Dynasty, and Patronage*, 165-89; *ead.*, The Martyr, the *Matrona* and the Bishop: the Matron Lucina and the Politics of Martyr Cult in Fifth- and Sixth-century Rome: *Early Medieval Europe* 8 (1999) 297-317; K. Sessa, Domestic Conversions: Households and Bishops in the Late Antique Papal Legends, in: *Dynasty, Patronage, and Authority*, 79-114.

[16] John F. Baldovin, *The urban character of Christian worship: the origins, development, and meaning of stational liturgy* (Rome, 1987); see Éric Palazzo, L'espace et le sacré dans l'antiquité et le haut Moyen Age: les autels portatifs, in: *Cristianità d'Occidente e cristianità d'Oriente*

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lay people prayed, fasted, and gave alms – all penitential acts, whether or not we consider them historically significant to the development of penance. At the very least, our current understanding of penance needs calibrating in order to fit this environment of diversity and competition.

'Peter' was a penitent

Peter, in the memory of some fourth and fifth-century Italian preachers, before converting thousands of Jews and long before becoming the first bishop of Rome, was a penitent.[17] We cannot study penance or Rome's church without addressing the power of its bishops, but episcopal authority, like penance, looks different depending on our evidence. Leo the Great, for example, spoke often about penance when he preached to his fellow Romans, and not in the same way as when he weighed in on debates over penance in other dioceses or provinces as supreme pontiff. Take a Palm Sunday sermon from 445, in which Leo moved on from talking about Judas (one Jew whom penance could not save) to describing how Peter became an authority on penance. We might expect to hear about Peter, the bedrock of the church, accepting the power to bind and loosen sinners. Instead, Leo offered up a man Seneca would have recognized among the people of Rome in his day, one of the 'we all' who aspire to virtue but come up short. Peter had denied knowing Jesus because Peter was frightened and lacked backbone. Leo reasoned that 'he was allowed to hesitate, it seems, so that the remedy of penance could be founded in the prince of the church, and so that no one would dare trust in his own virtue, when not even blessed Peter had been able to escape the danger of inconstancy.'[18]

A bishop's own need for mercy was bound up with his power to forgive his followers' sins. Gregory the Great shared Leo's concern over human fallibility and what it meant for successful pastoral care. To some modern interpreters, especially of his homilies, when Gregory spoke of himself as if he were as fallible as Seneca's Romans or Leo's Peter, his 'rhetoric of vulnerability' was a sincere expression of pastoral anxiety; to other interpreters, though, it was a sly stratagem for impressing other powerful people.[19] However, for preachers

(secoli VI-XI), Settimane di studio della Fondazione Centro italiano di studi sull'alto medioevo 51, 2 vols. (Spoleto, 2003), II 1117-58, 1142-6.

[17] A. Fitzgerald, *Conversion through Penance* (1988), 99-130, 489-90; *id.*, Christ, Peter and the Rooster: *Augustinianum* 41 (2001) 409-23; Kevin Uhalde, Pope Leo I on Power and Failure: *Catholic Historical Review* 95 (2009) 671-88 at 674, 677-8.

[18] Leo I, *Serm.* 60.4, CChr.SL 138A, 367-8: '[P]etrus ... ancilla sacerdotis calumniante perterritus, infirmitatem negationis incurrit, ob hoc, sicut apparet, haesitare permissus, ut in Ecclesiae principe remedium paenitentiae conderetur, et nemo auderet de sua uirtute confidere, quando mutabilitatis periculum nec beatus Petrus potuisset euadere.'

[19] Fabrizio Martello, Il pubblico del predicatore nelle *Homiliae in Hiezechihelem* di Gregorio Magno, in: *L'eredità spirituale di Gregorio Magno tra Occidente e Oriente*, ed. G.I. Gargano

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of penance, confessing their own weakness and counting themselves among 'we all' sinners was not only a form of *captatio benevolentiae*, which changed the admonishing relationship of preacher and audience to a shared experience. Professing their common vulnerability was part of the inescapable process of repentance and mercy – first, to know personally how it felt to be in need of forgiveness and, second, to be a familiar face to the judge they wished to move to mercy. Gregory the Great advised bishops to 'always keep running back to penance on [their] own behalf (*apud se*),' otherwise they might allow themselves to harden into the strict sort of judge whose purge would leave the streets of Rome empty.[20]

Entering personally into the penitential fray did not make the bishops of Rome exceptional among other bishops. Caesarius of Arles, for example, preached that 'a bishop who does penance every day can pray for me, but one who presumes upon his dignity and sanctity, refusing to do penance, will have to find someone to pray for him'; Gregory the Great probably read this sermon.[21] Gregory of Tours declared not only all bishops but even Jesus Christ to be 'preachers of penance.' In this bishop's *Histories*, which record Mamertus and Avitus of Vienne's innovative penitential processions, a Roman bishop, Gregory the Great, was the showstopper, parading his people through plague-ridden streets, trying to stave off the annihilation Seneca had feared so long ago, even as some of his penitents dropped dead.[22] Preachers of penance were aware of each other, emulated and influenced each other, even if they did not always agree or share the same experiences. Papal letters, canon law collections, and later liturgical manuscripts all are amply studied. But writing the history of penance means looking for still more connections between Rome and the rest of the late antique world.[23]

(S. Pietro in Cariano (Verona), 2005), 201-28, who refers often to C. Leyser, 'Let me speak, Let me speak': Vulnerability and Authority in Gregory the Great's *Homilies on Ezekiel*, in: *Gregorio Magno e il suo tempo* (Rome, 1991), 169-82; also see C. Leyser, Vulnerability and Power: The Early Christian Rhetoric of Masculine Autority, in: *Bulletin of the John Rylands University Library of Manchester* 80 (1998) 159-73, 168-9.

[20] Gregory I, *Reg. past.* 2.10: 'Vnde necesse est ut exasperatus rector, cum subditorum mentem plus se quam debuit percusisse considerat, apud se semper ad paenitentiam recurrat; ut per lamenta ueniam in conspectu Veritatis obtineat, ex eo etiam quod per zeli eius studium peccat.'

[21] Caesarius, *Serm.* 61.1, CChrSL 103, 267, transl. Mary Magdeleine Mueller, FOC 31 (1956), 300. Bruno Judic, in: *Grégoire le Grand: Règle pastorale*, intro. and notes by B. Judic, ed. by Floribert Rommel, transl. by Charles Morel, 2 vols., SC 381-2 (Paris, 1992), I 56-60 suggests Gregory read this and others of Caesarius' sermons.

[22] Geoffrey Nathan, Rogation ceremonies in Late Antique Gaul: *Classica et Medievalia* 21 (1998) 276-303.

[23] Instead, conflict is a common theme in scholarship on penance generally, e.g. James Dallen, *The Reconciling Community: The Rite of Penance* (1991), 31: 'Ancient penance was shaped by controversy,' with Christine Trevett, 'I Have Heard from Some Teachers': The Second-Century Struggle for Forgiveness and Reconciliation, in: *Retribution, Repentance, and Reconciliation*, ed. K. Cooper and Jeremy Gregory (Suffolk, 2004), 5-28, 23.

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What existing scholarship on penance has to offer historians of Rome

Paying attention to the similarities and differences between the way Roman bishops handled penance at home and the way they handled it abroad will help us understand penance better, if we treat the differences evenly.[24] Erwin Göller published the most thorough and nuanced study dedicated to the history of penance in late antique Rome in 1931. The thirty-four pages he dedicated to Leo, to take one example, include six pages analyzing his sermons on seasonal devotions, while the rest cover his often-cited letters to various bishops on problems related to penance.[25] Like most historians of penance writing about Rome, Göller favored the letters to the sermons – the extroverted pontiff to the introverted pastor.[26] The 'ideas expressed mainly in his sermons', Göller wrote, 'form the background to Leo's penitential theory', but hard evidence for the 'institution' of penance had to be found elsewhere.[27] Even in the best scholarship, the pastor and his thoughts tend to provide 'background' to the pontiff and the institution. The same preference prevails in studies on the history of 'Petrine' supremacy, a topic George Demacopoulos treats with nuance in these proceedings. Yet Göller's study stands, not only as the most thorough study to date, but as a suggestive model for a different sort of study, one no one has attempted: an intellectual history of penance.

A comprehensive intellectual history of penance would trace textual influences and continuity with the past, unlike a sacramental history that prefers doctrinal conflicts and progress toward the future. The work is already begun, with the study of ancient emotions, Göller's partial but suggestive analysis of influences across papal authors, and comments here and there on what are some of the best known and most richly studied texts from Late Antiquity. Bruno Judic, for example, points to similarities between Gregory and Seneca in the way they wrote about remorse, and Kristina Sessa demonstrates Seneca

[24] Herbert Schneider, Rom und die liturgische Vielfalt, in: *Roma fra Oriente e Occidente*, Settimane di studio del Centro italiano di studi sull'alto medioevo 49, 2 vols. (Spoleto, 2002), II 1101-40, tries to discern difference in the way popes treated liturgical matters in the case of nearby versus remote dioceses, following a suggestion by Cyrille Vogel, *Medieval Liturgy: An Introduction to the Sources* (Washington, DC, 1986), 372 n. 31.

[25] Emil Göller, Papsttum und Bussgewalt in spätrömischer und frühmittelalterlicher Zeit: *Römische Quartalschrift* 39-40 (1931-2) 71-267, at 219-342, 119-53. Leo's famous penitential letters are *Ep.* 108 (to Theodore of Fréjus) with Göller, 125-9, 144-6; *Ep.* 159 (to Nicetas of Aquileia) with Göller, 142; *Ep.* 167 (to Rusticus of Narbonne) with Göller, 135-8, 146-51; and *Ep.* 168 (to the bishops of Campania, Samnium, and Picenum) with Göller, 129-32.

[26] Soon after Göller's article, Paul Galtier's own two-part article cited it and made use of Leo's sermons and letters: A propos de la pénitence primitive: Méthodes et conclusions: *Revue d'histoire ecclésiastique* 30 (1934) 517-57, 797-846, 523-8. The case is different for Gregory the Great, whose treatises were so influential, but see Salvatore Pappalardo, *Communio* e disciplina penitenziale nel *Registrum epistolarum* di san Gregorio Magno: *Synaxis* 4 (1986) 77-122.

[27] E. Göller, Papsttum und Bussgewalt (1931-2), 124: 'Diese zumeist in seinen Predigten ausgesprochenen Gedanken bilden den Untergrund der Bußtheorie Leos, ohne daß jedoch dabei das Institut der Buße stärker in die Erscheinung tritt.'

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and Leo, along with other Christian writers, modeling virtuous personal conduct on good household management.[28] Even in metaphors and images, we find evidence for continuity, such as an ancient gesture of grief (a woman holding her chin and supporting one arm with the other) that became a personification of David's penance, as illustrated in the famous Paris and Bristol Psalters.[29] We may as well test the assumption that Christianity dramatically and irrevocably changed the way people felt sorry for their sins.

An intellectul history does not need to be confined to famous intellectuals or doctrinal texts. In fact, the older scholarship on penance suggests new ways we might approach penance in Rome. For example, no one took a harder line than Cyrille Vogel on the decline of late antique penance, which left what he called 'a complete "penitential void"', where a Seneca or Gregory would have despaired of finding repentant sinners or merciful rulers.[30] But Vogel took under consideration evidence few other historians of penance have, especially from Gallic saints' lives and Latin inscriptions.[31] His interpretation suffered from forcing the evidence to fit his 'penitential void'. So, for example, when a sixth-century tombstone referred to the deceased as a penitent, Vogel insisted that 'penitent' must mean something other than a person who performed penance. But Vogel also lacked superior tools and editions that scholars have at their disposal today. Thus, his dossier of penitential inscriptions included only a dozen (none from Rome), while Mark Handley recently referred to eighteen and I count roughly thirty, including at least three from Rome.[32] Some people, at least, were repentant and expected forgiveness.

Not just for intellectuals

If the inscriptions, at best, offer tangible but laconic testimony, Rome's hagiographical literature is still more promising. The *Gesta martyrum*, many of whose

[28] B. Judic, in *Grégoire le Grand: Règle pastorale*, I 35-6; K. Sessa kindly shared a draft of the first chapter of her book manuscript.

[29] Hugo Buchthal, *The Miniatures of the Paris Psalter: A Study in Middle Byzantine Paintings* (London, 1938), 27-30 with *figs.* 8, 54; Bristol Psalter, Brit. Lib. Add. 40731, f.82v; Anthony Cutler, *Oxford Dictionary of Byzantium*, ed. Alexander P. Kazhdan *et. al.* (Oxford, 1991), *s.v.* 'Metanoia.'

[30] Cyrille Vogel, art. Penance, in: *Encyclopedia of the Early Church*, ed. Angelo Di Berardino, transl. by Adrian Walford, 2 vols. (Oxford, 1992), 667.

[31] Cyrille Vogel, La discipline pénitentielle en Gaule des origines au IX[e] siècle: Le dossier hagiographique: *Revue des sciences religieuses* 30 (1956) 1-26, 157-86; *id.*, La discipline pénitentielle dans les inscriptions paléochrétiennes: *Rivista di Archeologia Cristiana* 42 (1966) 317-25. Both essays are reprinted in *ead.*, *En rémission des péchés: recherches sur les systèmes pénitentiels dans l'Eglise latine*, ed. Alexandre Faivre (Aldershot, 1994).

[32] Mark A. Handley, *Death, Society and Culture: Inscriptions and Epitaphs in Gaul and Spain, AD 300-750*, BAR International Series 1135 (Oxford, 2003), 10 n. 26: note that his *ICI* VIII 12a is a mistake for *ICI* VII, 12a, that *ERBC* 31 and *ICERV* 57 are the same inscription, and that Handley does not cite Vogel's study.

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constituent passions were written in the fifth and sixth centuries, include evidence for penance in most of its forms, including formal absolution, penitential acts like alms and fasting, and penance as a part of conversion. In the passion of Aurea, Censurinus, and their companions in Ostia, for example, pagan soldiers and a pagan shoemaker perform penance prior to their baptism, much like the Jews whom Peter converted (in this case, Emperor Claudius plays Judas Iscariot's obstinate role, by refusing Aurea's advice to pour ashes on his head, lay on the ground, and do penance).[33] We know that early Christians thought of penance as a second baptism; but here and elsewhere in the hagiographical literature, it is rather baptism that looks like first penance.[34]

An intellectual history of penance, finally, will need to follow Christians home, because penance was never meant for the church alone. Some men and women in the martyr texts took over control of their own penitential devotion. Vogel, no doubt, would have responded that this sort of penance is not true penance. But in fact it fits quite well with what preachers of penance like Leo the Great asked of their followers: carry on penance in their daily lives. Gregory the Great, like Robert Kaster, always emphasized that true repentance was a long process, but that it carried with it a virtue all its own.[35]

Historians of Rome must always take caution, that they do not mistake the exceptional for the normal: there was no city and no church like Rome in Late Antiquity. Historians of penance maybe should err on the other side and treat Christian remorse as something less special, less full of importance for the future Church and its discontents, and, even, less momentous in the history of emotions. It would be enough to know whether it was Christianity that changed what penance meant to ancient people, or the other way around – that is, whether ancient ideas and forms of repentance shaped Christianity.

[33] *Passio Aureae seu Chryses, Censurini et sociorum*, AASS, *Aug.*, 4, 757-61, chs. 1.2 (Claudius), 1.9 (soldiers), and 2.10 (shoemaker).

[34] E.g. *Passio Donati et Hilariani* (*BHL* 2289; *CPL*[3] 2183), ed. Boninus Mombritius, *Sanctuarium seu Vitae Sanctorum* (Paris, 1910), I 416-8, at 417 lines 18-25: 'Tunc beatus Saturius episcopus ... iussit duci ad se Syramiam [a blind pagan woman who has now given up her idols], cui ita dixit: "Filia crede domino et illuminaberis", quae respondit: "credo", et dixit ad eam: "humiliare in cinere et cylicio. Et cum humiliata fuisset imposuit ei manus et cathetizauit eam coram Hilariauo et Donato et baptizauit eam in nomine patris et filii et spiritusancti [sic] in remissionem peccatorum. Et lauata chrismate et aperti sunt oculi Syramiae.'

[35] Gregory demonstrates this point in his interpretation of Lazarus' resurrection, for example: B. Judic, Pénitence publique, pénitence privée et aveu chez Grégoire le Grand (590-604), in: *Pratiques de la confession: Des Pères du désert à Vatican II. Quinze études d'histoire* (Paris, 1983), 41-51, 44-5, with Gregory I, *Hom. Ev.* 26.5-6 and *id.*, *Hom. Ez.* 2.9.20. Judic observes that two scholars each used this same evidence to demonstrate, respectively, the existence of private penance and the persistence of public penance.

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The Church Fathers on Pity

Hennie STANDER, Pretoria

1. Introduction

David Konstan[1] wrote an excellent book on pity. In his study he shows how pity was understood in the ancient Greek and Roman world over a period of more than a thousand years, from the archaic age of Greece to the emergence of Christianity. He shows that pity was not a uniform concept throughout classical antiquity, and it also varied from one context (e.g. religion, the courtroom) or social group (women, soldiers) to another. Pity is a complex issue.[2] The ancient Greeks and Romans were sometimes very cruel towards slaves, but would simultaneously boast of their humanity towards the afflicted.

Unfortunately Konstan's discussion of pity in the Christian era is not as thorough as his discussion of the preceding period of time. It is only Lactantius who is not merely mentioned, but who does receive somewhat attention. The aim of this paper is to focus on what the Church Fathers really said on pity, since it differed substantially from the classical point of view.[3]

2. Pity and humanity

Zeno (fl. c. 460 B.C.), a Stoic philosopher, placed pity among vices and diseases. By doing this, Lactantius[4] argues, Zeno deprives us of an affection which involves the whole course of human life. There were also people who believed that a wise man should never pity somebody, but Lactantius[5] regards this behaviour as shameless. For him pity is similar to humanity (*humanitas*), and he says that we use this affection to mutually protect each other. In this respect, we differ from animals. Without this affection there can be no society among men. Elsewhere Lactantius[6] again emphasizes that anyone who despises this affection of pity, reduces us to the life of the beasts (see also Lactantius[7]).

[1] D. Konstan, *Pity Transformed* (London, 2001).
[2] D. Konstan, *Pity Transformed* (2001), 24.
[3] D. Konstan, *Pity Transformed* (2001), 69.
[4] *Div. Inst.* III 23 (PL 6, 423A).
[5] *Div. Inst.* VI 11 (PL 6, 671B).
[6] *Epitom. Div. Inst.* XXXVIII (PL 6, 1046A).
[7] *Epitom. Div. Inst.* LXV (PL 6, 1077B-9A).

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God has implanted pity in our nature.[8] That is why fathers and mothers pity their children, and children their parents. Even brutes have pity. This proves how cruel the Jews were when they crucified Jesus: While others lamented over that which was done to Jesus, the Jews were not moved either by pity or by fear.[9] Chrysostom[10] also says that to show pity is a beautiful trait of the human nature. He says that this is why there are public executioners whose task it is to execute punishment. It is the task of the judge to pronounce the sentence, but then somebody else must be asked to execute the sentence, because 'it requires another sort of person to inflict punishment'.

Chrysostom[11] says that we have many good natural affections (πολλὰ φυσικὰ ἀγαθά) which lead to virtue. The best of all these things is our ability to pity. To pity lies deep in our nature, even though one may be fierce (ὠμός) and ungentle (ἀπηνής). That is why we melt by tears, and we even pity beasts, 'such a superabundance of pity lies deep in us'. It touches us when we see the whelp of a lion, or those who are maimed.

A just person will always show pity (*justus miseretur*).[12] Women are even more inclined to pity than men.[13] Gregory of Nazianzen[14] says that he has learnt the meaning of pity and compassion by the things which he suffered. It is normal for any person who is in a difficult situation, to appreciate the pity (*miserabilis*) of other.[15]

Elsewhere Chrysostom[16] again says that 'human nature is disposed to sympathy, and the affections of others move us to pity' (ἔχει γὰρ πῶς φύσει τὸ συμπαθές). But Chrysostom adds that he knows that there are not feelings such as pity in hell. There will be no consolation for a father who sees his son suffering, or for a husband who sees his wife suffering. When the last days arrive, people will not even pity an infant or an old man.[17]

3. Divine pity

Aristotle[18] defines pity (ἔλεος) as 'a kind of pain excited by the sight of evil, deadly or painful, which befalls me who does not deserve it; an evil which one might expect to come upon himself or one of his friends...' Since pity then was seen as a response to misfortunes to which one believes oneself vulnerable, it

[8] Chrysostom, *Hom. in Mt.* LII 6 (PG 58, 524B-C)
[9] Chrysostom, *Hom. in Mt.* LXXXVIII (PG 58, 777D).
[10] *Hom. in Acta* XLIII (PG 60, 306D).
[11] *Hom. in Phil.* IV (PG 62, 210B).
[12] Ambrose, *De officiis ministrorum* 1.25 (PL 16, 63B).
[13] Chrysostom, *Hom. in Joh.* LXXXVI 1 (PG 59, 467).
[14] *Ep.* CXLIII (P. Gallay).
[15] Lactantius, *Epitom. Div. Inst.* XXXVIII (PL 6, 1046A).
[16] *Hom. in ITim.* X (PG 62, 552C).
[17] Lactantius, *Epitom. Div. Inst.* LXXI (PL 6, 1088C).
[18] *Rhetoric* II 8.2.

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is obvious that pity would not be a feature of gods. Dover[19] says that the Greeks in classical antiquity 'did not expect gods to be merciful.' There are cases where gods did experience pity, but it was not a quality on which human beings could rely. Apart from the fact that gods were invulnerable to human misfortune, there was another reason why gods were considered undisposed to feel pity: it was believed that gods were not subject to psychological suffering.[20] In general, the gods took no notice at all of human affairs, although especially in Neo-Platonism, as for example in Plotinus and Proclos, the divine One is freely sharing itself without jealousy, and Proclos even introduced the term "caring eros" for the divine, an eros that works downwards into the creation and integrates the mythological Greek motive of Gods loving their creatures into philosophy.[21] Like the Neo-Platonists, the Church Fathers disagreed with the notion of a distant and disinterested deity. They believed that God has pity on all that call upon his Name.[22] He pities richly since He is good.[23]

Clement of Alexandria[24] also addresses the question on how we are to explain the passages of Scripture which ascribe to God human affections. He says that there are cavillers (οἱ κατήγοροι) who say that both joy and pain are passions of the soul (χαρὰν καὶ λύπην πάθη ψυχῆς). These mockers define joy as a rational exultation, and pity as pain for one who suffers undeservedly (τὸ δὲ ἔλεος λύπην ἐπὶ ἀναξίως κακοπαθοῦντι). They then add that such affections are merely moods and passions of the soul (τροπὰς δὲ εἶναι ψυχῆς καὶ πάθη τὰ τοιαῦτα). The intention of these people is to disparage God and to ascribe to Him human traits. But Clement argues that we should not interpret the Scriptures literally when it speaks of these emotions. God merely tries to accommodate us by using concepts which are comprehensible to us, and we cannot transfer our emotions to God. God appropriates our emotions without really having these emotions Himself. He Himself says: 'For I was hungry and you gave me something to eat, I was thirsty and you gave me something to drink... "I tell you the truth, whatever you did for one of the least of these brothers of mine, you did for me"' (*Matth.* 25:35.40).

Clement[25] says that the greater pities the less. If the greater pities the less, it is God alone that will pity us. The implication is, of course, that we cannot pity God, since He is greater than us. But Chrysostom, on the contrary, says that it

[19] Kenneth Dover, *Greek popular morality in the time of Plato and Aristotle* (Indianapolis, 1994), quoted by D. Konstan, *Pity Transformed* (2001), 105.

[20] D. Konstan, *Pity Transformed* (2001), 112.

[21] Werner Beierwaltes, *Denken des Einen: Studien zur neuplatonischen Philosophie und ihrer Wirkungsgeshcihte* (Frankfurt a.M., 1985), 18-20, 24-26.

[22] *Pastor Hermae,* Sim 3.14; Clement of Alexandria, *Strom.* II 13 (GCS).

[23] Clement of Alexandria, *Protrep.* I (SC 2); *Strom.* II 16 (GCS); Theophilus, *Ad Autolyc.* II 29 (R.M. Grant); Chrysostom, *Hom. in Philem. I* (PG 62, 708); *Hom. in Rom.* XVI (PG 60, 560D); Lactantius, *Epitom. Div. Inst.* LX (PL 6, 1069C-70A).

[24] *Strom.* II 16 (GCS).

[25] *Strom.* II 16 (GCS).

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is remarkable that God is not only having pity for us, but He is even pitied by us. He[26] says that Jesus adopts a pitiable character (τὸ ἐλεενὸν τοῦ αἰτοῦντος) when He becomes the poor man. Like Clement above, Chrysostom then also refers to *Matth.* 25:35ff.: 'For I was hungry and you gave me something to eat, I was thirsty and you gave me something to drink...' This, then, is a case where Jesus was indeed pitied by us.

Lactantius[27] gives another example where Jesus was pitied by us. He says that since Jesus was wounded for our transgressions, and bruised for our offences, He became an object of pity. It was, of course, very dishonourable to become an object of pity. To be pitied was thus part of the humiliation that Christ suffered.

We have pity with people because we see that Christ too had pity with people.[28] The pity of Christians is therefore in imitation of Christ. We resemble God when we show mercy and pity [τῷ ἐλεεῖν καὶ οἰκτείρειν].[29] Chrysostom adds that if we have not this quality, we are devoid of all good. To pity all men is to obey a command of God. One should never insult people in need, nor should one suspect them of cheating. Even in the latter case, we must still pity them.[30]

4. Pity and jealousy (envy)

It is very interesting to note that pity and fear were seen as opposites.[31] Konstan[32] ascribes this to the influence of the Stoics who explained it with a neat formula: pity is pain at another person's ill fortune, while envy is pain at another's good fortune.

Numerous Church Fathers also referred to *pity* and *envy* as two opposite emotions. Chrysostom,[33] for example, admonishes his congregation for being *envious* while all other people show *pity*. He also accuses the Jews of *envying* those whom they should actually have *pitied*.[34] The consequence of this is that they now fail to find salvation, because they pine at the blessings of others, while these blessings were not at their own expense.

Chrysostom[35] explains that *envy* springs from the fact that we still cleave to things present. Instead of *envying* the rich, we should rather have *pity* with

[26] *Hom. in Mt.* LXXIX (PG 58, 718B).
[27] *Div. Inst.* IV 16 (PL 6, 498D).
[28] Chrysostom, *Intro. Hom. in Phil.* (PG 62, 181A).
[29] Chrysostom, *Hom. in 2Tim.* VI (PG 62, 634A).
[30] Chrysostom, *Hom. in Joh.* LXXVII 4 (PG 59, 418D).
[31] Aristotle, *Rhetoric* II 9, see II 10; Pindar, *Pythians* I 85; Lysias, *Funeral Oration* II 67; Lysias, *On the refusal of a pension to the invalid* XXIV 2.
[32] D. Konstan, *Pity Transformed* (2001), 46.
[33] *Hom. in Mt.* XL 3 (PG 57, 442B-C).
[34] *Hom. in Joh.* IX 2 (PG 59, 72A).
[35] *Hom. in Phil.* II (PG 62, 195A).

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them. We should not *envy* people who are praised, but should rather have *pity* with them, since their glory is like 'the flower of grass'.[36]

5. Pity and hatred

Pity and hatred were also seen as opposites, since pity was associated with love. That is why Chrysostom[37] urges his congregation not to *hate* those who plot against them, but rather to *pity* them. Jesus should be their model, since He was prepared to even kiss his traitor.

Origen[38] also says that *pity* and *hatred* are opposites. 'Everyone will admit that he who is the object of *pity* is not at the same moment an object of *hatred*, and that he who is the object of *hatred* is not at the same time a subject of *pity*.'

6. Desire and pity

Chrysostom[39] regards desire (ἐπιθυμία) and pity (ἔλεος) as the two most tyrannical passions (δύο τὰ τυραννικώτατα πάθη). But of these two passions, pity is the strongest. And to prove his point, Chrysostom refers to Joseph. The wife of Potiphar tried to seduce Joseph, but he managed to overcome desire and refrained from listening to the woman. Yet, when he saw his brothers who had wronged him, he was 'all on fire with that passion' (ἐνεπρήσθη τῷ πάθει) and quickly cast off his mask. Joseph, then, who had overcome desire, could not suppress his pity.

7. Pity and the law

Konstan[40] says that 'one of the more conspicuous differences between ancient and modern trial procedures is the admissibility, in the courts of classical Greece as well as Rome, of appeals to pity – the so-called *argumentum ad misericordiam*.' Konstan says that it was permitted to arouse the pity of judges. Modern legal practice, however, believes that emotions such as pity serve only as a distraction from rational argument. But Konstan's argument is not true of Chrysostom. Chrysostom advises judges to give no heed to persons, whether poor or rich. He says that one should neither favour the rich person, nor the poor. And Chrysostom bases his point of view on *Ex.* 23:3 (LXX): 'Thou shalt not pity (ἐλεήσεις) the poor in judgment.'

[36] Chrysostom, *Hom. in 2Cor.* XXIV (PG 61, 568C).
[37] *Hom. in Rom.* XXI (PG 60, 607D).
[38] *Contra Cels.* IV 53 (SC 136).
[39] *Hom. in Mt.* XXXIII 8 (PG 57, 397A).
[40] D. Konstan, *Pity Transformed* (2001), 27.

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8. Pity and the poor/rich

Human nature is prone to pity and sympathize with the poor.[41] But it is praiseworthy when poor people also have pity.[42] But we should rather pity rich people 'who strut in the marketplace' than those who beg on the streets, since the latter at least do praise God.[43]

On the other hand, Chrysostom says that it is not necessarily the rich who should be pitied, but rather people who are without pity (οἱ ἀνελεήμονες).[44] He then refers to the parable of the rich man and Lazarus (*Luke* 16:19-31). Chrysostom then points out that the rich man was not punished because he was rich, but because he did not have pity with the beggar. He then concludes that it is quite possible for a rich man 'to meet with every good' (τυχεῖν παντὸς ἀγαθοῦ) if he is pitiful despite of his riches.

One should not think that the rich are the people who do wrong.[45] Sometimes poor people do more damage because of their envy, than a rich person, since one would sometimes find that a rich person does have pity with the poor people.

9. When pity is not needed

But not all people are objects of pity. People who bring upon themselves shame, for example, are not pitied. Chrysostom[46] says that people who live in luxury often indulge in sin. While we have pity even for demoniacs, we do not have pity for these people. This is because it is their self-chosen madness which caused their distress. But people who are not responsible for their errors, should be pitied.[47] That is also why we will not be pitied if we waste our time and neglect our talents, instead of using them and 'helping on our salvation'.[48]

Conclusions

Pity has indeed been transformed radically. In the classical world it was placed amongst vices, but the early Christian theologians eulogised this emotion. Formerly it was believed that gods were pitiless, but the early Christians regarded God as full of pity. In imitation of God's pity, every believer should also have pity with people suffering hardship. Pity has become a virtuous emotion!

[41] Athanasius, *Historia Arianorum* VII 62 (Opitz).
[42] Chrysostom, *Hom. in 2Cor.* XVI (PG 61, 513B).
[43] Chrysostom, *Hom. in 1Cor.* XIII (PG 61, 113B).
[44] *Hom. in Phil.* II (PG 62, 196B).
[45] Chrysostom, *Hom. in Phil.* II (PG 62, 198A).
[46] *Hom. in Mt.* LVII 5 (PG 58, 564A).
[47] Chrysostom, *Hom. in Mt.* LIX 2 (PG 58, 557C).
[48] Chrysostom, *Hom. in Mt.* LXXVIII 3 (PG 58, 714C).

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Spectaculum naturae as 'Theatrical' Experience: New Uses of an Old Comparison

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The earliest attempts at a definition of the best way of life, which is, in classical antiquity, the philosophical life, concentrate on the practice of contemplation (θεωρία). Diogenes Laertius reports that when Anaxagoras was asked what the purpose of his existence was, he answered: 'the contemplation of the sun and the moon and heaven' (ἐρωτηθείς ποτε εἰς τί γεγέννηται, 'εἰς θεωρίαν' ἔφη 'ἡλίου καὶ σελήνης καὶ οὐρανοῦ').[1]

In order better to explain what kind of practice this philosophical contemplation was, various authors used the theater as a model. In Plato's *Republic* book 5, Glaucon compares the philosophers to the spectators at the festival of the Dionysia and concludes that the former are superior to the latter; they are not just curious and in search of entertainment, but really want to see the truth.[2] Aristotle too compares the contemplation of the universe to the watching of the spectacles of the Dionysia (*Protreptic* B 44 Düring),[3] and a similar comparison is ascribed to Pythagoras in a well-known passage from Cicero's *Tusculans* (5.9). The objects of philosophical contemplation thus described are 'the truth', 'the universe', or 'the nature of things'. In Plato the comparison with the festival of the Dionysia also involves a judgement: the object of philosophical contemplation is worthier than public spectacles. Perhaps this was also the line of argument in a fragmentary passage from Cicero's *Hortensius* (*Fr.* 83 Grilli), which reads: 'He (presumably the philosopher) *rather* watches the admirable order and inexhaustible beauty of the heavenly bodies.'[4]

[1] D.L. 2.10 (translations are mine if not otherwise indicated). See also Arist., *Protr.* B18-19 Düring = Iambl., *Protr.* 51,6-15 Pistelli (on Pythagoras and Anaxagoras). For the cultural presuppositions and philosophical development of *theoria* see Andrea W. Nightingale, *Spectacles of Truth in Classical Greek Philosophy.* Theoria *in its Cultural Context* (Cambridge, 2004), here 193; Christoph Riedweg, *Zum Ursprung des Wortes 'Philosophie' oder Pythagoras von Samos als Wortschöpfer*, in: Anton Bierl *et al.* (eds.), *Antike Literatur in neuer Deutung* (München/ Leipzig, 2004), 147-81.

[2] *R.* 5.475e4: τῆς ἀληθείας φιλοθεάμονας. See A.W. Nightingale (2004), 78.

[3] *Protr.* B 44 Düring: '(...) and as we view the Dionysia not in order to gain anything from the actors (indeed we spend money on them),... so too the contemplation of the universe is to be honoured above all the things that are thought useful.' (Transl. Ingemar Düring, *Aristotle's* Protrepticus. *An Attempt at Reconstruction* [Göteborg, 1961], 67). See A.W. Nightingale (2004), 191-7.

[4] M. Tulli Ciceronis *Hortensius*, ed. Alberto Grilli (Milano / Varese, 1962), 43: *caeli signorum admirabilem ordinem insatiabilemque pulchritudinem magis spectat.*

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We don't know what the term of comparison is (a comparison is implied in *magis*), but given that the text is heavily influenced by Aristotle's *Protreptic*, perhaps it is again the theater (and it might be noteworthy that *Hortensius* was presumably well known among Christian authors, as quotations by Lactantius and Augustine suggest).

In early Christianity too, the ideal of a contemplative life is strongly advocated. Christian authors are therefore not unfamiliar with the ancient motif of the contemplation of the universe. But in what follows I would like to show that they adapt the motif for a completely new purpose, namely the polemic against the theater. Furthermore, I will offer a possible explanation for the appearance of new objects of contemplation, beyond the upper realm and the heavenly bodies.

In the endeavor to build a new, Christian community, early Christian writers have to rethink the city and its institutions. Inevitably they also need to deal with the theater, which is one of the most prominent targets of their polemic. In the context of this polemic, Christian authors revive the traditional comparison between the theater and the contemplation of the universe, but with new accents. First of all, what was simply a comparison for the sake of illustration, becomes now an opposition or alternative, combined with a recommendation: Christians are urged *not* to attend theatrical shows, but to engage *instead* in the contemplation of the universe. Presumably the first one to alter the argument in this sense is Tertullian. In his treatise *On the shows* 29.3, he proposes alternative pleasures to the theater, pleasures that the Christians can indulge in legitimately. Among these he lists the contemplation of the heavenly bodies, in which he finds the same elements that constitute athletic contests: *hae voluptates, haec spectacula Christianorum, sancta, perpetua, gratuita. In his tibi ludos circenses interpretare: cursus saeculi intuere, tempora labentia dinumera, metas consummationis expecta*, etc.[5]

Secondly, and more importantly, Christian authors reshape the motif by adding new objects of contemplation. Not just the upper realm, nor the abstract notions of truth or *rerum natura*, but the more palpable elements of the created world are now part of the picture too: the sea, the earth, the mountains, rivers, and the animals that inhabit these places. An example of this innovation can be found in Novatian's treatise *On the shows*. Drawing no doubt on Tertullian, Novatian adds more details of the natural world as objects of contemplation. The Christian does not need, he argues, the entertainments of the theater, for, apart from the heavenly bodies, the seasons, etc., which he mentions too, he has *istam mundi pulchritudinem quam uideat atque miretur:... terrae molem*

[5] SC 332, 310,12-312,16: 'These are the pleasures, the spectacles of Christians, holy, eternal, and free. Here find your games of the circus, – watch the race of time, the seasons slipping by, count the circuits, look for the goal of the great consummation, etc.' (transl. Terrot R. Glover in: Tertullian, *Apology, De spectaculis* [London and Cambridge, Ma., 1953], 297).

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libratam cum montibus et profusa flumina cum suis fontibus, extensa maria cum suis fluctibus atque littoribus.[6] Novatian goes on to mention the animals inhabiting each of these parts of the natural world, birds in the air, fish in the water, and man on the earth, and he finally compares man-made theaters to the vaster, grander and more beautiful 'theater' of the created world.[7]

Similar, if less detailed, is a passage from Ambrose's *Explanation of Psalm 118* 5.29. In commenting on the Psalmist's words 'Turn away mine eyes from beholding vanity' (*Ps.* 119:37), Ambrose invites the audience to shun the theater and other 'secular pomp' in order to contemplate instead God's creation, not only the stars and the planets, but also the sea and the earth, and finally the animals and the human beings. Interestingly, he develops the argument into a poignant contrast between this kind of 'natural' spectacle and the spectacles of the city: 'What charm even in the shapes of the animals, how much beauty in the human beings, how much beauty in the birds! Contemplate these, and you won't see the injustice and contradiction in the city!'[8]

Augustine in turn creates an opposition between the theater and 'this great spectacle of nature' in the context of a scrutiny of different kinds of pleasure: both the theater and the sight of the natural world give pleasure, but the former legitimate, the latter illegitimate (*s.* 159.2).[9]

The inclusion of other parts of the natural world than just the heavenly bodies as objects of contemplation may partly be due to a Stoic influence. In the Stoa, the orderliness and harmony of the universe and its single parts is used as evidence for divine providence. A good example is Cicero, *De natura deorum* 2.155f. Here the designation of the universe as a 'spectacle' (*spectaculum*) and the following description of the earth and its vegetation no doubt facilitates

[6] CChr.SL 4, 177,1-177,12: 'The Christian... has that beauty of the world to look upon and admire. He may gaze upon... the heavy mass of the earth balanced by the mountains, and the flowing rivers with their sources; the expanse of seas, with their waves and shores' (transl. Ernest Wallis in: *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts / James Donaldson, vol. 5 [New York, 1903], 578).

[7] CChr.SL 4, 178,16-20: *... et in omnibus istis incolas proprios, in aere auem, in aquis piscem, in terra hominem. Haec, inquam, et alia item opera diuina sint christianis fidelibus spectacula. Quod theatrum humanis manibus extructum istis operibus poterit comparari?*

[8] CSEL 62, 97,26-98,7: *ad hunc* (sc. *Christum*) *dirige oculos tuos, auerte ab spectaculis, auerte ab omni saeculari pompa. sicubi populares cognoueris plausus, auerte ab his oculos tuos, inflecte, deprime et serua eos, ut erigas melioribus. erige ad caelum; uel nocte stellarum monilia, orbem lunae decorum, uel die solem aspice. specta mare, terram circumspice, ut opere facta diuino omnis creatura te pascat. quae formarum gratia in ipsis bestiis, quantus decor in hominibus, quanta in auibus pulchritudo! haec intuere, et non uidebis iniquitatem et contradictionem in ciuitate; haec uide, et non introibit mors per fenestras oculorum tuorum.*

[9] PL 38, 868D: *Delectant enim quaedam naturaliter infirmitatem nostram,... ut nos delectat haec lux, quae de coelo funditur sole exorto, vel quae de sideribus et luna fulget... Delectant enim, ut dixi, oculos spectacula ista magna naturae: sed delectant oculos etiam spectacula theatrorum. Haec licita, illa illicita.*

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the comparison or contrast between the theater and the natural world we find in Christian writers:

Iam vero circumitus solis et lunae reliquorumque siderum, quamquam etiam ad mundi cohaerentiam pertinent, tamen et spectaculum hominibus praebent... Terra vero feta frugibus et vario leguminum genere, quae cum maxuma largitate fundit, ea ferarumne an hominum causa gignere videtur? quid de vitibus olivetisque dicam, quarum uberrumi laetissumique fructus nihil omnino ad bestias pertinent, etc.[10]

However, apart from the fact that no explicit mention of the (man-made) theater is made in this passage, Cicero's main point here is not to praise nature as an object of contemplation, but rather as a material basis of survival that provides *fruges, legumina, vites*, etc. It is primarily nature's practical usefulness that he emphasises.

Another Stoic passage that recommends the beauty of the nocturnal sky (*insignum spectaculum noctium*) as worthier to look at and enjoy than the man-made luxury of expensive bedrooms is conventional insofar as it limits the natural spectacle to the heavenly bodies (Seneca, *Ep.* 90.41f.).[11] It is interesting insofar as it anticipates the Christian use of the motif for a polemical purpose; however the target is not the theater, but human artefacts in a broader sense. Finally, as for the popular dramatic simile of life, although one of its variations is the comparison of the world as a whole to the theater, the emphasis usually lies on the action that takes place on the 'stage' of the world, not on the 'stage' itself.[12]

Therefore, if Christian authors adapt the ideal of the contemplation of the universe for their polemic against the theater, they do not simply take up a Stoic motif, as others have argued.[13] Instead, they are presumably influenced by the much closer model of the Platonic and Aristotelian comparison between the theater and philosophical contemplation. A hierarchy between the theater and philosophical contemplation is, as far as we can see, anticipated only in Plato's *Republic*, where the theater is not a neutral term of comparison, but has a negative connotation. Although the purpose of the comparison in Plato is illustration, not polemic, the material for the new rhetorical use the Christians make of the motif is already there. Furthermore, if the Christians add more parts of

[10] 'Again, the revolutions of sun, moon, and other heavenly bodies admittedly form part of the organic structure of the universe, but they also offer a spectacle to the human race.... The earth again teems with grain and with a huge array of vegetables, which it pours out in the greatest profusion; I ask you, is it for the beasts or for humans that she is seen to produce them? Need I mention vines and olives, seeing that their most fertile and abundant fruits are of no interest whatever to beasts?' (Cic., *De nat. deor.* 2.155f., transl. P.G. Walsh, Cicero, *The Nature of the Gods* [Oxford, 1997], 103f.).

[11] This passage is probably hinted at in Lact., *De div. inst.* IV 20.6-8.

[12] See Minos Kokolakis, *The Dramatic Simile of Life* (Athens, 1960).

[13] Werner Weismann, *Kirche und Schauspiele* (Würzburg, 1972), 109.

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the created world as objects of contemplation, this might not just reflect Stoic illustrations of God's providence. Instead it is perhaps an essential part of the rhetorical purpose.

One passage that stands out particularly within the Christian uses of the comparison between the theater and the 'spectacle of nature' might illustrate this point. In a homily by John Chrysostom, the small and confined space of a *locus amoenus* is presented as an alternative to theatrical spectacles. John urges his congregation to avoid the theater, and he recommends instead: 'If you want to be entertained, go to the orchards, to the river that flows nearby and the ponds, meditate the gardens, listen to the cicadas' (*Hom. in Matt.* 37.7).[14]

Here, the landscape of the pleasance is presented as an object of contemplation. This variation of the contemplation of the universe represents an important further development of the motif. It finally departs from the Platonic and Pythagorean contemplation of the universe, as well as from the Stoic praise of the orderliness of the world and its parts, in order to advocate the more modest and simple pleasure that can be found in spending some time in the countryside, in a *locus amoenus*. The heavenly bodies, the rivers, mountains and the infinite number of animals give way to an orchard, a creek and a few cicadas, and what is at stake is not the description of philosophical practice or God's providence, but the pastoral task of keeping the congregation out of the theater by providing a viable, alternative pas-time.

So the choice of alternative objects of contemplation might depend most of all on the actual context in which the motif is now used. Rather than making a statement about contemplation as such or about the beauty and expediency of nature, Christian authors want to offer practical advice as to how to resist the attractions of theatrical spectacles. In this context, the upper realm or the created world as a whole might be less relevant than a simple opposition between the spectacles of the city and those of the countryside, as it can be found in Ambrose, or the beauty of a landscape as praised by John Chrysostom. The latter's invitation to replace the pleasures of the theater with the enjoyment of a *locus amoenus* is particularly remarkable, since in other early Christian authors like Cyprian and Gregory of Nazianzus, the pleasance is explicitly excluded as an object of perception, let alone contemplation, and thus is denied a helpful role in the human search for spiritual well-being.[15]

[14] PG 57, 428A: Τίς οὖν ἡμῖν ἔσται ἀπολογία λοιπόν, ὅταν ἡμεῖς οἱ τῶν οὐρανῶν πολῖται, καὶ τῶν Χερουβὶμ συγχορευταί, καὶ τῶν ἀγγέλων κοινωνοί, καὶ τῶν βαρβάρων χείρους ταύτῃ γινώμεθα, καὶ ταῦτα ἐξὸν μυρίας ἑτέρας τούτων βελτίους τέρψεις εὑρεῖν; Εἰ γὰρ βούλει ψυχαγωγεῖσθαι, βάδιζε εἰς παραδείσους, ἐπὶ παραῤῥέοντα ποταμὸν καὶ λίμνας· καταμάνθανε κήπους, ἄκουε τεττίγων ᾀδόντων, ἐπιχωρίαζε σηκοῖς μαρτύρων, ὅπου σώματος ὑγεία καὶ ψυχῆς ὠφέλεια κτλ.

[15] See Karin Schlapbach, *The Pleasance, Solitude, and Literary Production: Observations on the* locus amoenus *in Late Antiquity*, JbAC 50 (2007) 34-50, here 47-9.

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In sum, early Christian authors are aware of the traditional comparison between philosophical contemplation and the theater, and they adapt it in creative ways for a new purpose, the polemic against the theater. While in the older Greek and Latin tradition the objects of contemplation are the upper realm or truth itself, now a pleasant spot in the countryside can become an object of contemplation in its own right – a variation that responds to a specific pastoral need.

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Transformative Listening: Constructing the Hearer in Early Christianity

Carol HARRISON, Durham

We study early Christian literature as a set of texts but this can belie the fact that a very large proportion of it (probably nearing two-thirds) was actually delivered orally: I am thinking not just of sermons, but of catechetical addresses, creeds, dialogues, debates with heretics, liturgical prayers. These spoken words are now inevitably read (and usually interpreted) by us as written documents, and although some attention has been paid to their oral delivery in rhetorical studies, their aural reception has been largely overlooked. Patristic scholars have shown themselves highly sensitive to the art of speaking but oddly deaf to the art of hearing. Of course, any attempt to examine not just what the early Christians said and how they said it, but what they heard, how they heard, and how their hearing became what we might call 'transformative listening' is fraught with difficulties.

Whilst an impressive array of critical methods and theories are available to the scholar to read, interpret and discuss the historical, cultural, social context of early Christian literature; its rhetorical and theological strategies; its author's intention and even its reader's response, one finds oneself at something of a loss in attempting to identify or analyse the listener's response – to examine how the Christian message was actually 'heard' by the silent, illiterate majority who were often at the other end of the father's rhetorical fireworks; to identify what sparks these fireworks kindled in the ears of their listeners and what effect they had on them. In attempting to enter the inherently elusive, tacit dimension of the participation and response, affectivity and imagination, involved in the interplay between speaker and hearer; to ask what it is that motivates, inspires and involves a hearer not only to hear but to understand, to take to heart, act upon and be transformed by what they have heard, our existing critical tools can seem rather blunt and ineffective.

One starting point, might, I would like to suggest, be found in the texts themselves: they are almost all, in one way or another, written by a hearer; by someone who has been addressed by God, who has in some sense heard Him, attended to Him, responded to Him and acted upon his Word. They are often also attempts to enable their readers or hearers to participate in this hearing and response. I would like to suggest that if we read them with this in mind they might provide us with a direct, first hand account of what we might call

Studia Patristica XLIV, 427-432.
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transformative listening. In making this initial observation, I am aware I am treading on uncertain ground and making rather unscholarly presuppositions about the existence of God, his operation and inspiration, and the role of faith, which would not ordinarily be regarded as firm foundations for a critical interpretation of a text (even if it is an early Christian text, coming from an age when one might count on these presuppositions being more widely shared). To begin to justify my approach, then, I would like to turn, in this paper, to my old friend, Augustine, who prompted these reflections in the first place, in the hope that he might lend them more respectability and weight.

I would like to argue that in numerous contexts Augustine, characteristically, both systematically reflects on the theology of transformative listening and gives us a salient example of it in practice. What I have in mind are not what might seem the obvious texts, such as the fourth book of *On Christian Doctrine*, where he assesses the extent to which the art of rhetoric, or speaking, might be used in Scripture and preaching to teach, move and persuade the hearer, or even his catechetical works and sermons, but rather the last three books of the *Confessions*, and, for the purposes of this paper, especially book 11. In this still rather enigmatic sequel to his account of his conversion Augustine gives us what I think is a unique, but also paradigmatic, account of the art and practice of hearing.

This is first of all because the *Confessions*, as we all know, are primarily addressed not to the reader but to God. When we read them we have no choice but to become hearers, or more precisely, eves-droppers, *overhearing* one side of a conversation being held with someone else: Augustine is responding to, and talking to God. James O'Donnell has put this nicely in reference to the opening line, 'You are great, Lord, and highly to be praised (*Ps.* 47:2): great is your power and your wisdom is immeasurable (*Ps.* 146:5)': 'This opening', he writes, 'can give rise to the disconcerting feeling of coming into a room and chancing upon a man speaking to someone who isn't there. He gestures in our direction and mentions us from time to time, but he *never addresses his readers*'.[1] Of course this has the effect not so much of excluding the reader from the conversation as of drawing him or her into it more effectively and compellingly, the more covert and complicit their involvement. We are drawn into a complicated web of participation and response, affective and imaginative engagement, in order to 'overhear' Augustine's hearing of God, to deduce what God is saying and to appreciate Augustine's response. In the process we learn a great deal about the nature and identity of the silent interlocutor whom we, in turn, hear through Augustine, and even more about the mind and feelings of Augustine, the hearer, and the transformative effect his hearing of God has had upon his life and thinking. Augustine writes not to inform God of anything,

[1] James J. O'Donnell *Augustine: Confessions* 3 vols. (Oxford, 1992), vol. 1, 8-9 (italics are O'Donnell's).

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but to respond to God's Word (often *in* God's word, in the words of Scripture, and especially the Psalms, as we have just seen in the opening line) and to enable others to participate in this response (and thereby also be transformed by it). As he puts it in the opening lines of book 11 in addressing God: 'Why then do I set before you an ordered account of so many things? It is certainly not through me that you know them. But I am stirring up love for you in myself and in those who read this, so that we might all say 'Great is the Lord and highly worthy to be praised' (*Ps.* 47:1) ... I tell my story for love of your love' (*Conf.* XI 1.1).

Having recounted in books 1-10 his faltering, but ultimately dramatic and definitive, response to the one whom he realised had always been battering his senses, calling and crying out to him, but whom he had hitherto failed to hear,[2] Augustine turns in book 11 to describe this God and what our relation to Him is – in other words, how we can (or should) hear Him. He does so, as one might expect any theologian or philosopher of his time to do, by beginning at the beginning and examining creation, the first things – in this instance, the account of creation in *Gen.* 1:1. At this point in the work the covert listener or eves-dropper on the *Confessions* is made uncomfortably aware that their presence has not gone unnoticed and that what they are engaged upon is becoming the central focus of attention, for what Augustine gives us in book 11 is, I think, a profound and closely argued investigation into the first principles of the art of hearing, or, to put this in more familiar terminology: how the eternal, immutable, incorporeal Creator is heard by His temporal, mutable, corporeal creation. In other words, in book 11 Augustine is addressing the most fundamental question of all: how can we apprehend God? It will preoccupy him for the remainder of the *Confessions*.

In the course of his one-sided conversation Augustine has discovered that God is the Creator who has called creation into being from nothing, through his Word; that to hear and respond to his Word is to be formed and given existence; to be deaf to it is to become deformed and fall into non-being. As a Christian he identifies the Creator Word with the Word incarnate, the truth of Scripture, the one who continues to call fallen human beings to conversion and reformation. Augustine's response to God's call in the *Confessions*, is a complex two part fugue: a confession of praise counter posed with a confession of failure; his inability to listen to, or respond to God, as he ought, in heart and mind, without the gift of his Spirit or grace.

What Augustine singles out in book 11 as characteristic of beings created from nothing is their temporality, mutability and corporeality, in contrast to God's eternity, immutability and transcendence. It is across this ontological chasm, as it were, that God addresses us and we hear and respond. As he so often does when faced with a problem of definition, Augustine resorts to a

[2] *Conf.* X 27.38

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linguistic analogy, and attempts to define just what the temporality that defines creatures (and by implication, their mutability and corporeality) is, with the example of speaking and hearing, illustrated in this case by someone speaking or listening to a song,[3] reciting a Psalm,[4] or more specifically, delivering the first line of an Ambrosian hymn, *Deus Creator Omnium*:[5] the line can only be apprehended in time, through movement and succession, and by means of physical, corporeal sound. What turns out to be a long and convoluted attempt to grasp what he ultimately has to admit, with some exasperation, is the intangible, elusive question of time, is, I would argue, in this context, a sustained, theological reflection on the way in which the creature must hear and respond to God's Word. Augustine's resolution of the question of time, if we can speak in terms of resolution, is to describe the way in which we, as creatures, cannot pin time down, so as to offer a definition of it, but can only apprehend it by anticipating what is to come in the future, attending to what is passing in the present, and remembering what has past (*nam et expectat et adtendit et meminit ut id quod expectat per id quod adtendit transeat in id quod meminerit*).[6] This, of course, has obvious resonances with the way in which he describes how the creature apprehends God's providential order and action in salvation history in his early works,[7] and with his later attempts to describe how human beings, created in the image of God, can begin to apprehend, relate to, and be conformed and reformed to the divine Trinity in *De Trinitate*, by remembering, understanding and loving the Divine Trinity as it has been revealed in the temporal, mutable, incarnate Word of God, Christ.

I would like to note three salient features which emerge from Augustine's extended discussion of time in book 11 which directly relate to his underlying concern in the last three books of the *Confessions* to demonstrate how the eternal, immutable, transcendent God is apprehended by his temporal, mutable, corporeal creatures, and which especially relate to the notion of transformative hearing. The first has to do with the role of the creature, and might be summed up as its response to, or participation in, the Word of God; what Augustine in

[3] *Conf.* XI 31.41

[4] *Conf.* XI 28.38 He adds that the analogy 'is also valid of the entire life of an individual person, where all actions are parts of a whole, and of the total history of the 'sons of men' (*Ps.* 30:20) where all human lives are but parts.

[5] *Conf.* XI 27.35

[6] *Ibid.* XI 28.37

[7] *De uera religione* 41-3; *De natura boni* 8; *Enarrationes in Psalmos* 9.7; *De Diuersis Quaestionibus 83* 44 in all of which he uses the analogy of a poem or speech being delivered and heard to describe how the creature is led through the successiveness of God's revelation in time and hearing to apprehend their origin and source: from a poem to the art of poetry; from hearing to understanding; from temporal things to divine providence. This continues in his later thought, e.g. *De ciuitate Dei* 11.18; *Epistulae* 138.5; 183.5. In most cases there is also an aesthetic aspect to what Augustine has to say: the beauty revealed in temporal successiveness leads to divine beauty.

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other contexts will call its 'conversion' or turning towards God. God brings creation into being and gives it form by calling it; creation receives being and form by responding to and participating in God's call. The temporal, mutable, corporeal creature must subsequently continue to listen to God's call, to respond and convert towards God's Word, spoken to it within the temporal realm: in creation, the incarnate Word, Scripture, the preaching, teaching and sacraments of the Church, otherwise it will fall away from being and become deformed. In book 11, what we might describe as this moment of 'transformative listening', the response of the temporal creature to the words of the eternal Creator, and most especially to the Word incarnate, is described as the mind's activity of memory,[8] attention and expectation,[9] which together concentrate and focus the mind (*intentio*), and enable it to overcome what would otherwise be 'a multiplicity of distractions by many things' which fragment, scatter and 'pull it apart' or, as Augustine puts it, distend it (*distentio*),[10] to allow it to apprehend God's Word.[11] The mind is turned, drawn and stretched out towards its Creator through relation to and participation in the Word of God, which addresses it in time, and is thereby formed or transformed by it.[12]

Secondly, I would like to note the role of anticipation (*expectatio*): our experience of time, like our hearing of God's Word, is eschatological, in the sense that it is must always be incomplete, open-ended, unresolved and open to the future; we are always caught up in the tension between past and future.[13] This is simply because, although it ultimately derives from the eternal, immutable God, it is, as we experience it, temporal, mutable and corporeal (an insight which Augustine develops at length in book 12 in discussing the multiplicity of different ways in which the Word of God in Scripture might legitimately be read). We must therefore hear but then listen, continually stretching out towards the eternal God. It is in this sense of attentive, anticipatory response, that

[8] It was commonly agreed in Augustine's day that the hearer became conscious of sound, not so much by the ears, which simply acted as the receptor and transmitter of sound, as by the mind, where the sound could be stored and consciously recollected by the creation of a mental image, engraved upon the mind, or more specifically, the memory.

[9] Augustine interprets this in relation to God's Word, in terms of *Phil.* 3:13: stretching out, or 'extended' towards 'those things that are before' in *Conf.* XI 30.40.

[10] *Conf.* XI 29.39 'not stretched out in distraction (*distentus*) but extended in reach (*extentus*), not by being pulled apart (*distentionem*) but by concentration (*intentionem*)'. See *ibid.*, XI 26.33 on *distentio* and Henry Chadwick's note in *Saint Augustine: Confessions* (Oxford, 1991), 240 n. 27 for possible Plotinian influences in Augustine's coining of this term.

[11] *Conf.* XI 29.39 Augustine quotes *Phil.* 3:12-4: 'I might apprehend him in whom also I am apprehended'.

[12] *Conf.* XI 30.40: 'Then shall I find stability and solidity in you, in your truth which imparts form to me'.

[13] *Conf.* XI 31.41: 'A person singing or listening to a song he knows well suffers a distension or stretching in feeling and in sense-perception from the expectation of future sounds and the memory of past sound. With you it is otherwise. You are unchangeably eternal, that is the truly eternal Creator of minds'.

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Augustine describes his own restless longing, in prayer and praise, in the *Confessions* and borrows the words of Paul in *Phil.* 3:13: 'stretching out towards the things which are before'.[14]

Thirdly, as Augustine makes manifestly clear in book 13, time, or the Word of God which we hear in creation, Incarnation, Scripture and preaching, is a gift of grace, given by the Sprit of God, and is something which we must always receive in reference to the giver.[15] As he observes at the beginning of book 13: 'You made me and, when I forgot you, you did not forget me ... Before I called to you, you were there before me. With mounting frequency by voices of many kinds you put pressure on me, so that from far off I heard and was converted and called upon you as you were calling to me ... I serve and worship you so that from you good may come to me. To you I owe my being and the goodness of my being.' (*Conf.* XIII 1.1).

What, then, might we conclude about the way in which early Christian texts need to be heard, as well as read; about the art of hearing or transformative listening? Augustine's convoluted, and finally inconclusive, ramblings on the nature of time in *Confessions* 11, on exegesis of Scripture in book 12, and on the way in which God's grace is mediated to us in book 13, might seem like an odd place to start, but I think that if we take seriously the fact that in grappling with these intractable problems Augustine is in fact tackling the even more fundamental and difficult problem of the way in which the temporal, mutable, corporeal creature is formed and transformed by hearing and responding to the eternal, immutable, transcendent Creator, what we are given in these texts is a theoretical description of the art of transformative listening: of the way in which the image of God is formed, reformed and transformed within the creature by hearing: by remembering, attending to and anticipating the Word of God as it addresses us. Just as the rules, theory and practice of rhetoric allow us to 'construct the speaker' as it were, and give us the means to analyse the art of speaking, so I think, in presenting us with a theology of listening, both in theory and in practice, Augustine allows us to begin to 'construct the listener', and to analyse the art of hearing, which, for him, is no less than the art of divine formation and transformation, in which hearing becomes transformative listening.

[14] *Conf.* XI 30.40.

[15] *Ibid.*: 'Let them also be "extended" towards "those things which are before" (*Phil.* 3:13), and understand that before all times you are eternal Creator of all time.'

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The Functions of Mary in the Christmas Homilies of Augustine of Hippo

Geoffrey D. DUNN, Brisbane

Utilising Augustine of Hippo's homilies to consider his mariology is fraught with obstacles.[1] Typically, Augustine's mariology is presented thematically, often giving the impression that each theme is equally prominent or important.[2] However, it is valuable to consider not just what he wrote but how frequently he mentioned Mary, in what context, and for what purpose.

With a chronological framework one could consider changes in his thinking and style of presentation over time and the influence of changing circumstances and situations. However, Hubertus Drobner has challenged the prevailing consensus about how to date Augustine's homilies.[3] When it comes to the Christmas homilies in particular, all that Drobner will allow is that *Sermo* 196, with its self-reference to Augustine as bishop, must have a *terminus post quem* of 395/6.[4] All this has serious implications for tracing the development of the cult of Mary in early Christian North Africa. Without a chronology one is left without a logical sequence to establish connections between homilies. Before Drobner began his assault, Peter Brown wrote in his newly composed epilogue to his magisterial biography that '[t]he most elusive element in the reconstruction of a life of Augustine remains the chronology of his sermons.'[5] Now one is left

[1] Of the 72 pages in Georges Gharib et al., *Testi mariani del primo millennio* III: *Padri e altri autori latini* (Rome, 1990), 306-77, concerned with Augustine, 23 of them (just under a third) are devoted to his homilies.

[2] Henri Barré, Le culte marial en Afrique après saint Augustin: *Revue des Études Augustiniennes* 13 (1967) 285-317; Geroges Gharib et al., *Testi mariani* III (Rome, 1990), 306-77; Michael O'Carroll, *Theotokos: A Theological Encyclopedia of the Blessed Virgin Mary* (Wilmington, Del., 1983), 63-6; F. Hofmann, art. Augustinus, in: Remigius Bäumer and Leo Scheffczyk (eds.), *Marienlexikon* I: *AA-Chagall* (St. Ottilien, 1988), 294-98; Michele Pellegrino, *S. Agostino d'Ippona: La vergine Maria* (Milan, 1993 [2nd edn]), 15-40; Bertrand Buby, *Mary of Galilee* III: *The Marian Heritage of the Early Church* (New York, 1997), 170-99; Luigi Gambero, *Mary and the Fathers of the Church: The Blessed Virgin Mary in Patristic Thought*, transl. Thomas Buffer (San Francisco, 1999 [Engl. edn.]), 216-30.

[3] Hubertus R. Drobner, The Chronology of St. Augustine's *Sermones ad populum*: *Augustinian Studies* 31 (2000) 211-8; *id.*, The Chronology of St. Augustine's *Sermones ad populum* II: Sermons 5 to 8: *Augustinian Studies* 34 (2004) 49-66; *id.*, The Chronology of Augustine's *Sermones ad populum* III: On Christmas Day: *Augustinian Studies* 35 (2004) 43-53.

[4] Hubertus R. Drobner, The Chronology of Augustine's *Sermones* III (2004), 52f.

[5] Peter Brown, *Augustine of Hippo: A Biography* (Berkeley, 2000 [rev. edn]), 483.

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to wonder whether the dating of his preaching now has passed forever beyond being merely elusive!

Even without Drobner's demur, Augustine's homiletic collection is something of a mixed bag. While we have well over five hundred of his homilies, this is only a small percentage of the total number.[6] Any conclusions we reach about Augustine based on his homilies must therefore be tentative. Further, we cannot trust that many of the homilies we have are complete, given the number of fuller versions of some that were discovered by François Dolbeau in 1990.[7] How many more of his homilies are only a pastiche of excerpts made by mediaeval monks from an originally longer homily? Next, issues of authenticity hover over a number of the homilies as many preachers in later generations sought to imitate Augustine's style. Further still, the relationship between the homilies that the Maurists collected together as his *Sermones ad populum* and Augustine's other homilies, most notably the *Enarrationes in Psalmos*, is also not entirely clear. With all these problems it is little wonder that work on the homilies is perhaps the most neglected facet of Augustinian studies,[8] yet it is precisely in the general area of early Christian preaching that scholarly interest has been expanding in recent years.[9]

In this paper I shall consider Augustine's comments on Mary in his eighteen homilies for Christmas day as part of the International Early Mariology Project's examination of the development of the cult of Mary in late antiquity.[10] His Christmas homilies are an obvious place to expect such references, given that Mary appears in the nativity stories of Matthew and Luke. My argument

[6] Pierre-Patrick Verbraken, Saint Augustine's Sermons: Why and How to Read Them Today: *Augustinian Heritage* 33 (1987) 105-116, at 106, believes that there could have been as many as 8,000 homilies. Hubertus R. Drobner, The Chronology of St. Augustine's *Sermones ad populum* II (2004), 55, calculates the surviving homilies, on Verbraken's figure, as 7% of the total.

[7] See Henry Chadwick, New Sermons of St Augustine: *JTS N.S.* 47 (1996) 69-91. On the problem of later interference with the integrity of Augustine's homilies see Edmund Hill (transl.), *The Works of Saint Augustine: A Translation for the 21st Century* III: *Sermons*, vol. 11: *Newly Discovered Sermons*, ed. John E. Rotelle (Hyde Park, N.Y., 1997), 16f.

[8] One does not wish to overemphasize this point. See Pierre-Patrick Verbraken, *Études critiques sur les sermons authentiques de Saint Augustin*, Instrumenta Patristica 12 (Steenbrugge, 1976) and Hubertus R. Drobner, *Augustinus von Hippo: Sermones ad populum. Überlieferung und Bestand, Bibliographie, Indices*, SVigChr 49 (Leiden, 2000).

[9] See for example Mary B. Cunningham and Pauline Allen (eds.), *Preacher and Audience: Studies in Early Christian and Byzantine Homiletics*, A New History of the Sermon 1 (Leiden, 1998); O.C. Edwards, *A History of Preaching* (Nashville, 2004).

[10] Augustine, *s.* 140 (NBA 31/1, 334-340); 184 (NBA 32/1, 2-6); 185 (NBA 32/1, 8-10); 186 (NBA 32/1, 12-16); 187 (NBA 32/1, 18-22); 188 (NBA 32/1, 24-28); 189 (NBA 32/1, 30-34) (= Frang. 4); 190 (NBA 32/1, 36-42); 191 (NBA 32/1, 44-48); 192 (NBA 32/1, 50-54); 193 (NBA 32/1, 56-58); 194 (NBA 32/1, 60-64); 195 (NBA 32/1, 66-68); 196 (NBA 32/1, 70-76); 369 (NBA 34, 476-480); 370 (NBA 34, 482-486); 371 (NBA 34, 488-492); 372 (NBA 34, 494-498). Obviously there are Christmas homilies missing. On the project see: Leena Maris Peltomaa, Die berühmteste Marien-Predigt der Spätantike: *Jahrbuch der Österreichischen Byzantinistik* 54 (2004) 77-96 and *ead.*, Towards the Origins of the History of the Cult of Mary: *SP* 40 (2006) 75-86.

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shall be that rather than simply note what Augustine has said about Mary in his homilies one needs to pay attention to the frequency with which ideas occur, the contexts in which they occur, and the purposes they serve. This is precisely the kind of study called for by Emilien Lamirande.[11] The attention to detail will reveal the extent to which Augustine was interested in Mary herself or in what she meant for christology and will indicate any evidence for the emergence of a cult of Mary in Christian North Africa.

Christmas Homilies

We know that the Africans of Augustine's time celebrated Christmas at the end of the year, in the middle of the northern hemisphere's winter, when the short days were beginning to lengthen.[12] Numerous references to sun and light suggest that this liturgy was held as a replacement for or in competition with the pagan *Sol Invictus* festival. While Hill considers that they might have adopted the practice of celebrating the liturgy three times on that day (midnight, dawn, and during the day),[13] Drobner believes that Africa was yet to adopt this Roman custom.[14] If we knew Augustine's lectionary we would be in a better position to resolve this.[15] However, the possibility is that the lectionary was cyclical or the choice of readings left to the presider rather than assigned to different times of Christmas day and so we cannot tell from the readings whether Augustine preached more than once each Christmas day.

Two Births

The divine father and a human mother of Jesus enabled Augustine to employ rhetorical antithesis in order to convey differing points in an elegant and pleasing

[11] Émilien Lamirande, En quell sens peut-on parler de devotion mariale chez Saint Augustin?, in: *De Primordiis Cultus Mariani. Acta Congressus Mariologici-Mariani in Lusitania Anno 1967 Celebrati* III: *De Fundamento Cultus B. V. Mariae in Operibus Sanctorum Patrum et Scriptorum Ecclesiasticorum (post saec. II)* (Rome, 1970), 17f.

[12] Augustine, *s.* 185.2 (NBA 32/1, 8); 186.3 (NBA 32/1, 16); 190.1 (NBA 32/1, 36); 192.3 (NBA 32/1, 54); 194.1 (NBA 32/1, 60); 196.1 (NBA 32/1, 70). In *s.* 196A.3 (NBA 32/1, 82), which appears to be a homily for New Year's Day, there is reference to several short days.

[13] Edmund Hill (transl.), *The Works of Saint Augustine: A Translation for the 21st Century* III: *Sermons*, vol. 6: *(184-229Z) on the Liturgical Seasons*, ed. John E. Rotelle (New Rochelle, N.Y., 1993), 19 nn. 3, 6; 36 n. 10; 51 n. 1; 56 n. 14; 63 n. 2.

[14] Hubertus R. Drobner, *Augustinus von Hippo Predigten zum Weihnachtsfest* (Sermones 184-196). *Einleitung, Text, Übersetzung und Anmerkungen*, Patrologia Beiträge zum Studium der Kirchenväter 11 (Frankfurt am Main, 2003), 38.

[15] On Augustine's lectionary in general see G.G. Willis, *Saint Augustine's Lectionary* (London, 1962), esp. 22. 58-62. On Augustine's explicit references to the Christmas lectionary see Hubertus R. Drobner, *Augustinus von Hippo Predigten zum Weihnachtsfest* (2003), 39. To that must be added, if we accept the authenticity of *s.* 140 (see below) *John* 12:44.

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fashion.[16] In *Sermo* 140, which, despite Drobner's reservations, may be regarded as a Christmas homily,[17] and, if we can trust the preserved title, was directed against Maximin, an Arian bishop who accompanied Sigisvult, the Gothic general sent to Africa in 427 to remove his predecessor, Boniface, as *comes*, we find such an example. The references to Mary are incidental to the argument about the Son's equality with the Father. The birth from the Father was without time while that from the virgin was in time.[18] The question of time was important in the Arian controversy and its treatment here distinguishes it from other homilies where this antithesis about the two births is present, in that time is not a focus in them. The closest parallel to the antithesis about time is found in *Sermo* 187 where Augustine stated that the Word was God before all time and became flesh at the appropriate time.[19]

In the other Christmas homilies where this antithesis is employed the point is made that there was no mother involved in the first birth and there was no (human) father in the second because his mother was a virgin.[20] Yet, in *Sermo* 187 there was no need to refer to Mary at all for the contrast to be made effectively. In other words, the focus is christological rather than mariological.

Sermo 140 has both the temporal and non-temporal antithesis about the two births.[21] As well, this contrast is used to make a soteriological point: after the first birth we were made and after the second we were remade.[22]

There are other examples of rhetorical antithesis in the Christmas homilies where the object was to show the divine and human present together in Christ. These are the most frequent passing references to Mary. We may take *Sermo* 187, mentioned above, as the most developed example, elements of which may be found in other Christmas homilies:

[16] See *Rhet. Her.* 4.15.21; 4.45.58; Cicero, *De or.* 3.54.207; Cicero, *Part. orat.* 6.21; Quintilian, *Inst.* 9.3.81-82).

[17] Hubertus R. Drobner, *Augustinus von Hippo Predigten zum Weihnachtsfest* (2003), 11. The reference in the homily to Christ being born today would seem to be the clearest evidence that it was a Christmas homily. See A. Kunzelmann, Die Chronologie der Sermones des hl. Augustinus, in: *Miscellanea Agostiniana* II: *Studi Agostiniani* (Rome, 1931), 489; and Edmund Hill (transl.), *The Works of Saint Augustine: A Translation for the 21st Century* III: *Sermons*, vol. 4: *(94A-147A) on the New Testament*, ed. John E. Rotelle (New Rochelle, N.Y., 1992), 406, n. 1.

[18] Augustine, *s.* 140.2 (NBA 31/1, 334): ... *quia Deus Pater Deum Filium genuit sine tempore, et fecit ex Virgine in tempore. Natiuitas illa excedit tempora; natiuitas ista illuminat tempora.* This same idea is repeated a sentence or two later: *De Patre natus est sine initio; de matre natus est hodie certo initio.*

[19] Augustine, *s.* 187.1 (NBA 32/1, 18).

[20] Augustine, *s.* 184.3 (NBA 32/1, 6); 187.1 (NBA 32/1, 20); 189.4 (NBA 32/1, 34); 190.2 (NBA 32/1, 38); 194.1 (NBA 32/1, 60); 195.1-2 (NBA 32/1, 66); 196.1 (NBA 32/1, 70); 372.1 (NBA 34, 494).

[21] Augustine, *s.* 140.2 (NBA 31/1, 334): ... *illa sine matre, ista sine patre. Quando genuit Deus Filiu, de se genuit, non de matre; quando genuit mater filium, virgo genuit, non de viro.*

[22] Augustine, *s.* 140.2 (NBA 31/1, 334).

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My mouth shall speak the praise of the Lord (*Ps.* 51:15); of that Lord *through whom all things were made* (*John* 1:3), and who was himself made among all things; who is the revealer of the Father, creator of his mother; the Son of God from the Father without mother, the son of man from his mother without father; great as the day of the angels, little in the day of men; the Word, God before all times, the Word, flesh at the appropriate time; the maker and placer of the sun, made and placed under the sun; marshalling all the ages from the bosom of the Father, consecrating this day from the womb of his mother; remaining there, coming forth from there; producer of heaven and earth, appearing on earth under heaven; unspeakably wise, wisely speechless as an infant; filling the world, lying in a manger; directing the course of the stars, sucking his mother's breasts ...[23]

What was Mary's function in this argument? She functions less theologically and more rhetorically to make an attractive turn of phrase as Augustine displayed his way with words. Mary is really ancillary to the christological points being made. In many of the examples she is included to demonstrate the humanity of her Son. In instances where the comment is made that, in his second birth, Jesus was born of a mother without a (human) father, in other words born of a virgin, the point is that Mary's virginity guarantees Jesus' divinity. In *Sermones* 189 and 190, Jesus' virgin birth pointed to the power of God to do anything.

Mary as Mother

We may consider *Sermo* 184. This homily offers a critique of 'the wise and the prudent' (*Matth.* 11:25; *Luke* 10:21), who 'aim at the loftiness of God without believing in his humble lowliness ...'[24] Can we identify Augustine's targets? They were probably Manichees, since they rejected the notion that it was possible for God to take on flesh.[25] Faustus, Augustine's main Manichaean opponent, did not believe that the Son of God was born from the womb.[26] His docetism aimed at protecting the divinity of Jesus. Augustine's response in this

[23] Augustine, *s.* 187.1 (NBA 32/1, 18): *Laudem Domini loquetur os meum: eius Domini, per quem facta sunt omnia, et qui factus est inter omnia: qui est Patris revelator, matris creator: Filius Dei de Patre sine matre, filius hominis de matre sine patre: magnus dies angelorum, parvus in die dominum: Verbum Deus ante omnia tempora, Verbum caro opportuno tempore: conditor solis, conditus sub sole: cuncta saecula ordinans de sinu Patris, hodiernum diem consecrans de utero matris: ibi manens, hinc procedens: effector caeli et terrae, sub caelo exortus in terra: ineffabiliter sapiens, sapienter infans: mundum implens, in praesepio iacens: sidera regens, ubera lambens* ... English translations for Augustine's homilies are from the volumes by Hill.

[24] Augustine, *s.* 184.1 (NBA 32/1, 2): ... *dum alta Dei quaerunt, et humilia non credunt* ...

[25] Augustine, *s.* 184.1 (NBA 32/1, 4). See Hubertus R. Drobner, *Augustinus von Hippo Predigten zum Weihnachtsfest* (2003), 59.

[26] Augustine, *c. Faust.* 2.1 (CSEL 25, 253-254); 3.1 (CSEL 25, 261-262); 7.1 (CSEL 25, 302-303); 23.1-4 (CSEL 25, 707-710).

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homily, and elsewhere,[27] was to assert that the Son has taken on flesh without losing divinity and without being changed into flesh.[28] Mary's true motherhood of Jesus guaranteed his humanity and the goodness of flesh, which in turn supported the idea of the goodness of all God's creation.

Yet, in presenting an anti-docetic argument in this homily, one would expect Augustine to highlight Mary as mother (with the associated ideas of Jesus truly being born and possessing human flesh), but he seems to focus more attention on Mary as virgin (with the associated idea of Jesus' divinity because God was his father not some male human), even while attempting to give equal regard to Jesus' divinity and humanity.[29] The idea of Mary as the bearer of God, the controversial idea that erupted in Constantinople around the time of Augustine's death, does not feature much in Augustine's homilies, even though he firmly believed that she bore the divine Son of God in her womb.[30]

Ps. 85(86):12 about truth springing from the earth appears a number of times in Augustine's Christmas homilies.[31] In a couple of instances the verse is merely cited, as though its interpretation ought to be obvious. In others, Augustine explained that the reference to earth is a reference to Mary, since Christ is the truth. This gave Augustine the opportunity in *Sermo* 185, where he cited the verse eight times, to point to Christ's humility in that the divine one was carried in a woman's womb and in her arms, suckled at the breast, and laid in a manger.[32] In particular the psalm verse asserted Christ's true humanity in that he was born of flesh or of the virgin. In *Sermo* 189 a more detailed explanation of how the earth can be Mary is made: she came from Adam and he came from the earth.[33] For truth to spring from the earth, the true divinity of one who is truth and the true humanity of one who springs from the earth is preserved by Jesus being born of a virgin.[34] Again, there is a distinctly anti-Manichaean flavour in Augustine emphasising the flesh of Jesus and his descent from Adam while at the same time equating him with the purest of light. Mary functions as mother to guarantee his true flesh and human nature.

[27] Augustine, *s.* 186.1-2 (NBA 32/1, 12-14); 187.1 (NBA 32/1, 18); 187.3-4 (NBA 32/1, 20-22); 192.1 (NBA 32/1, 50)

[28] Augustine, *s.* 184.1 (NBA 32/1, 2).

[29] Augustine, *s.* 184.1 (NBA 32/1, 2-4).

[30] Augustine, *s.* 186.2 (NBA 32/1, 14).

[31] Augustine, *s.* 184.1 (NBA 32/1, 2); 185.1-3 (NBA 32/1, 8-10); 189.2 (NBA 32/1, 32); 191.1.2 (NBA 32/1, 46); 192.1 (NBA 32/1, 50); 192.3 (NBA 32/1, 52-54); 193.2 (NBA 32/1, 58).

[32] Augustine, *s.* 185.1 (NBA 32/1, 8). One should note the use of rhetorical epanaphora (see *Rhet. Her.* 4.13.19; Cicero, *De or.* 3.54.207; Quintilian, *Inst.* 9.1.33; 9.3.30) with *veritas qua.*

[33] Augustine, *s.* 189.2 (NBA 32/1, 32): *Maria unde? ex Adam. Adam unde? de terra. Si Adam de terra, et Maria de Adam, ergo et Maria terra.*

[34] Augustine, *s.* 189.2 (NBA 32/1, 32): *Ergo quia* Veritas de terra orta est, *Dominus noster Iesus Christus de Virgine natus est* ...

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Mary as Bridal Chamber

Psalm 18(19):6 about the bridegroom coming from his chamber appears a number of times in these homilies. We find Augustine offering different interpretations of this verse depending upon his need.[35] While in his exposition of the psalm, dated to 392, the bridal chamber was identified explicitly with the virgin's womb (and the groom with divine nature and the bride with human nature),[36] as it is in his second discourse, dated to winter 411/2,[37] in *Sermones* 187, 188 and 192 the image of the chamber is not developed at all nor is there any mention of Mary, the emphasis being on the marriage of the divine Word with human flesh.[38]

However, in *Sermo* 191, in commenting upon Mary's virginity being preserved *in partu*, when he made his observation that if Jesus could pass through a door to visit the apostles after the resurrection then he could pass through his mother's body in delivery without causing physical damage, Augustine was interested in Mary's womb, although no explicit mention of the psalm verse was made.[39] Such an explicit equation of the chamber with Mary's womb is made in *Sermo* 195. At the same time, in this instance, there is an equal emphasis on the marriage of divine and human natures.[40] This is the same situation with *Sermo* 372, although this is a homily of doubtful authenticity.[41] What is interesting here is that the consorts are not the divine and human natures of Jesus, but Jesus and the Church.[42] In these examples the psalm verse highlights the divinity of Jesus in being delivered from a virgin. The point made in

[35] A. Kunzelmann, Die Chronologie (1931), 504, wanted to date *Sermo* 187 to 411 or 412 because when Augustine used the psalm he did not refer to Mary's virginity, which he did in some other homilies. Like Thomas Comerford Lawler (transl.), *St. Augustine: Sermons for Christmas and Epiphany*, Ancient Christian Writers 15 (New York, 1952), 208, n. 10, I do not believe this is helpful in dating the homily.

[36] Augustine, *en. Ps.* 18/1.6 (CChr.SL 38, 102-103). On the dating see CChr.SL 38, xv; Scholastica Hebgin and Felicitas Corrigan (transl.), *Augustine: On the Psalms* 1, Ancient Christian Writers 29 (New York, 1960), 17.

[37] Augustine, *en. Ps.* 18/2.6 (CChr.SL 38, 109). On the dating see CChr.SL 38, xv; Scholastica Hebgin and Felicitas Corrigan (transl.), *Augustine: On the Psalms* 1 (1960), 18.

[38] Augustine, *s.* 187.4 (NBA 32/1, 22); 188.2 (NBA 32/1, 26); 192.3 (NBA 32/1, 52).

[39] Augustine, *s.* 191.1.2 (NBA 32/1, 46).

[40] Augustine, *s.* 195.3 (NBA 32/1, 68).

[41] The Maurists; Cyrille Lambot, La tradition manuscrite des sermons de saint Augustin pour la Noël et l'Épiphanie: *Revue Bénédictine* 77 (1967) 217-45, 241; Hermann Josef Frede, *Kirchenschriftsteller. Verzeichnis und Sigel*, Vetus Latina. Die Reste der altlateinischen Bibel 1/1 (Freiburg, 1995⁴), 244; Hubertus R. Drobner, *Augustinus von Hippo: Sermones ad populum* (2000), 39, doubt or deny its authenticity. André Wilmart, Easter Sermons of St Augustine: General Evidence: *JTS* 28 (1926-1927) 113-44, 115, and Edmund Hill (transl.), *The Works of Saint Augustine: A Translation for the 21st Century* III: *Sermons*, vol. 10: *(341-400) on Various Subjects*, ed. John E. Rotelle (New Rochelle, N.Y., 1995), 318, n. 1, affirm it. See Pierre-Patrick Verbraken, *Études critiques* (1976), 152.

[42] Augustine, *s.* 372.2 (NBA 34, 494).

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Sermo 194 is that the birth of Jesus, which is the bridegroom coming from his chamber, is an event that can be understood and remembered, unlike his eternal birth from the Father.[43] The focus is on the groom's movement and not on the chamber, so there is no reference to Mary at all, but, with the emphasis here on the normality of his second birth, we have a sole example of the psalm verse highlighting the humanity of Jesus. When references to Mary do occur in the context of this psalm verse, they are for christological reasons.

Mary as Virgin

Just as the motherhood of Mary could be used by Augustine to make the christological point about the true humanity of Jesus, her virginity could be used to make the christological point about his true divinity. In *Sermo* 370, a homily possibly by Caesarius of Arles,[44] we find one of the surprisingly rare usages of *Is.* 7:14 about a virgin conceiving and bearing a son.[45] *Sermo* 184 speaks of this as demonstrating the Son's greatness and highlighting his divinity, in contrast with the Manichees.[46] On other occasions when the word *virgo* is used Augustine employed it as a title without any explanatory comment.

Mary and the Virginal Church

While Mary was both mother and virgin, it is mainly Mary as virgin that was used in some of the Christmas homilies as a role model, specifically for dedicated virgins but for the whole community as well in terms of a spiritual virginity.[47] This is not surprising given that in *Sermo* 188 Augustine praised both marriage and virginity in such a way as to make it plain that virginity was the better condition, for Mary's motherhood did not compromise her virginity.[48]

[43] Augustine, *s.* 194.4 (NBA 32/1, 64).

[44] Edmund Hill III, *Sermons* 10 (1995), 311, n. 1. See André Wilmart, Easter Sermons (1926-1927), 115; C. Lambot, La tradition manuscrite (1967), 220; Réginald Grégoire, *Les homéliaires du Moyen Age: Inventaire et analyse des manuscrits*, Rerum Ecclesiasticarum Documenta Series Maior, Fontes 6 (Rome, 1966), 120f., 146; André Mandouze, *Saint Augustin. L'aventure de la raison et de la grâce*, Collection des Études Augustiniennes Série Antiquitè 31 (Paris, 1968), 600; Anton Zwinggi, Die Wortgottesdienst bei Augustinus (I): *Liturgisches Jahrbuch* 20 (1970) 92-113, 95; Hubertus R. Drobner, The Chronology of Augustine's *Sermones* III (2004), 45; Hubertus R. Drobner, *Augustinus von Hippo Predigten zum Weihnachtsfest* (2003), 43. See Pierre-Patrick Verbraken, *Études critiques* (1976), 152.

[45] Augustine, *s.* 370.3 (NBA 34, 484). The other is in *s.* 187.4 (NBA 32/1, 22).

[46] Augustine, *s.* 184.1 (NBA 32/1, 4).

[47] Maureen A. Tilley, Mary in Roman North Africa: Evidence for her Cultus: *SP* 40 (2006) 121-125, at 123, therefore speaks of Mary as a model for chastity rather than virginity.

[48] Augustine, *s.* 188.3.4 (NBA 32/1, 26-28). We find a similar sentiment in *uirg.* 9.9 (NBA 7/1, 84), except that his comments were only about the whole Christian community rather than Mary.

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The concern is with how the whole Church could spiritually be virginal; the issue of spiritual marriage is not mentioned. Although the link is not made clearly, Mary in this homily is a prototype of the Church as virgin.

In *Sermo* 184 Augustine appealed to male and female virgins, the bulk of attention being given to the former. As Christ was not born as the result of a marital union in order to enter into the spiritual marriage (between his human and divine natures), so the male virgins rejected marital unions in order to love and follow Christ.[49] Christ himself is the role model for male virgins.[50] Female virgins were able spiritually to marry Christ without losing their virginity because a virgin had given birth to him without losing her virginity.[51] Here the idea of spiritual marriage is applied only to them and not to male virgins or the community as a whole.

The extensive references to virgins in *Sermones* 191 and 192 is worthy of a study in its own right. Most of *Sermo* 191 was addressed to the virgins. They were not only spiritually virginal, as the rest of the Church was called to be, but physically virginal. Augustine encouraged them to persevere in their chosen state, comforting them with the idea that Jesus was born of Mary without robbing her of her virginity.[52] Mary is the model for the physical virgins to follow, not in terms of her maternity but her virginity. Only Mary had both gifts. While the virgins could not be Christ's mother (even though he called for the whole Church to be fruitful) they could be his bride and they need not fear for their virginity by having a husband (by this it is obvious that Augustine was addressing female not male virgins): just as Mary as mother had her virginity preserved, the virgins as wives would have their virginity preserved as well. Instead of being fruitful in body they were to be fruitful in mind (thereby imitating Mary's maternal gift in a spiritual not physical sense, something Augustine did not make explicit).[53]

In *Sermones* 192, 196 and 370 we find a more developed presentation of Mary as role model. In fact Mary is assigned to the virgins, while Anna is allotted to the widows and Elizabeth (and Susannah in *Sermo* 196) to the married women.[54] The three women no doubt featured in the Christmas lectionary and hence it was the liturgical season that made the choices obvious. Interestingly, in addressing the virgins in the community in *Sermo* 192 it was Mary as mother

[49] One may note that Augustine did not refer to the male virgins being in a spiritual marriage with Christ.

[50] Augustine, *s.* 370.2 (NBA 34, 482).

[51] Augustine, *s.* 184.3 (NBA 32/1, 4).

[52] Augustine, *s.* 191.2.3 (NBA 32/1, 46).

[53] Augustine, *s.* 191.3.4 (NBA 32/1, 48).

[54] Augustine, *s.* 192.2 (NBA 32/1, 52); 196.2 (NBA 32/1, 72); 370.2 (NBA 34, 482). Here I disagree with Maureen A. Tilley, Mary in Roman North Africa (2006), 124, that Augustine presented Mary as a role model for each category of woman. There is no reference to Mary with regard to widows and married women.

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of Christ that Augustine mentioned, most likely in an effort to console them that they were spiritually maternal in that by obeying his will they were Christ's mothers too.

There is no evidence in the Christmas homilies of devotion to Mary being promoted among ascetical women, but offering her as a role model for them to imitate is surely a step along that path.[55]

Mary as Perpetual Virgin

In *Sermo* 184 we find a reference to Mary being a virgin *post partum*.[56] From this and other examples Drobner, among others, concludes that Augustine believed in the perpetual virginity of Mary.[57] A closer reading of the homilies, however, will reveal that the evidence, while there, is not as overwhelming as Drobner postulates.

With regard to *Sermo* 184, Augustine was referring explicitly to the time immediately after the delivery of Jesus as a parallel with Mary's virginity before and at conception. Mary's preserved virginity is applied only to the events surrounding the birth of Jesus and not to the rest of Mary's life. Augustine referred to Mary conceiving as a virgin and Mary delivering as a virgin, but, despite Buby's claims, nothing is said here about Mary living the rest of her life as a virgin.[58] The same can be said for *Sermones* 191 and 196.[59] In the first, Mary's virginity *post partum* is to prove that she was a virgin *in partu*, and therefore *post partum* refers only to a time immediately after the birth of Jesus.[60] The point is made through the comparison mentioned above about Jesus passing through doors after the resurrection and passing through his mother's body at birth.[61] Even in *Sermo* 188, where Augustine stated that Mary was a virgin before marriage, at the time of the birth of her son, and while nursing him, this too does not amount to a statement about perpetual virginity.[62]

In commenting upon *Luke* 2:14 about the message of the angels to the shepherds in the field in *Sermo* 193, Augustine mentioned that the virgin acted vicariously on behalf of the whole human race in giving birth and that the

[55] See Maureen A. Tilley, Mary in Roman North Africa (2006), 124.

[56] Augustine, *s.* 184.1 (NBA 32/1, 2-4).

[57] Hubertus R. Drobner, *Augustinus von Hippo Predigten zum Weihnachtsfest* (2003), 63: 'Darüber hinaus erläutert er aber in fast allen Weihnachtspredigten die immerwährende Jungfräulichkeit Mariens. Er ist grundsätzlich von Ihrer Jungfräulichkeit vor, während und nach der Geburt überzeugt.'

[58] Augustine, *s.* 189.2 (NBA 32/1, 30). See Bertrand Buby, *Mary of Galilee* (1997), 184f.

[59] Augustine, *s.* 196.1 (NBA 32/1, 72).

[60] Augustine, *s.* 191.1.2 (NBA 32/1, 46).

[61] Augustine, *s.* 191.1.2 (NBA 32/1, 46).

[62] Augustine, *s.* 188.3.4 (NBA 32/1, 28).

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words of the angels are addressed not only to her but to all humanity as well.[63] It is an interesting comment, given that the angels' words were not to Mary but to the shepherds. Immediately, Augustine stated that this mother who had given birth remained a virgin after her child was born,[64] but there is no indication that she remained so for the rest of her life.

This is not to say that Augustine did not believe in Mary's perpetual virginity. *Sermo* 186 is very concerned with adoptionism, by interpreting *Phil.* 2:6-8; *Rom.* 1:1-3 and *Gal.* 4:4 to affirm that it was the Son of God himself who was born, but without any loss of divinity.[65] Kunzelmann wanted to date this homily to Christmas 411 because of parallels with Augustine's letters to Volusianus and Honoratus (*Epistulae* 137 and 140) from that time.[66] It opens with a statement that is as equally mariological as it is christological: the virgin mother made visible for us the one who, as invisible, created her and she made him visible by giving birth to him from her unimpaired womb, for she was a virgin when she conceived him, when she delivered him, and for ever after.[67] This is one of the few occasions, I believe, in all of Augustine's homilies where he referred explicitly to a perpetual *post partum* virginity of Mary. Her virginity enduring *in partu* and *post partum* (in the later theological sense) was proof that the Son endured as God when he was born with flesh.[68] In *Sermo* 195 the Church, like Mary, is both perpetually virginal and sinlessly fruitful, if not in body then in mind.[69] The idea that Mary was for ever a virgin because she had undertaken a vow of virginity, which Augustine mentioned in other writings, is not found in his Christmas homilies.[70]

The point to be made from all this is that while Augustine certainly did believe in the perpetual virginity of Mary, not every reference to Mary's *post partum* virginity is a reference to a perpetual virginity. Rather, although not contrary to or excluding the notion of perpetual virginity, most of the references are in relation to the time just after the birth of Jesus. Only two explicit references to

[63] Augustine, *s.* 193.1 (NBA 32, 56).

[64] Augustine, *s.* 193.1 (NBA 32/1, 56).

[65] Augustine, *s.* 186.3 (NBA 32/1, 14-16).

[66] A. Kunzelmann, Die Chronologie (1931), 502. See Edmund Hill III, *Sermons* 6 (1993), 26, n. 1, who simply dates it to after 400 and Tarcisius-Jan van Bavel, *Recherches sur la Christologie de saint Augustin: L'Humain et le divin dans le Christ d'après saint Augustin*, Paradosis 10 (Fribourg-en-Suisse, 1954), 30f., who says that while the comparison between body-soul and divine-human is found in Augustine in 402-4 it only became common after 410. See Pierre-Patrick Verbraken, *Études critiques* (1976), 98.

[67] Augustine, *s.* 186.1 (NBA 32/1, 12): *... quando eum pro nobis visibilem factum, a quo invisibili et ipsa effudit. Concipiens virgo, pariens virgo, virgo gravida, virgo feta, virgo perpetua.* See Luigi Gambero, *Mary and the Fathers of the Church* (1999), 220.

[68] Augustine, *s.* 186.1 (NBA 32/1, 12): *Quomodo Deus esse desisteret, cum homo esse coepit, qui genitrici suae praestitit ne desisteret virgo esse, cum peperit?*

[69] Augustine, *s.* 195.2 (NBA 32/1, 68).

[70] See Luigi Gambero, *Mary and the Fathers of the Church* (1999), 221.

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Mary's perpetual virginity in more than five hundred homilies hardly makes this a topic of great importance in Augustine's Christmas preaching.

Mary and the Maternal Church

Above we considered the issue of Mary as role model for virgins within the Church and for the whole Church to be spiritually virginal. In *Sermo* 189 Mary is held forth to the congregation as a model for imitation in terms of what believers carry in their hearts and what they give birth to in their lives.[71] This I think is an important point. Here her maternity rather than her virginity is a model for a spiritual maternity in other Christians. The call to imitate Mary in giving birth to the Savior is evidence of the stirrings of cultic regard for Mary in that by such imitation attention is being drawn to her specifically. Indeed, Augustine's reference to virgins in *Sermo* 191 was only possible because it was in the context of the whole Church, in imitation of the Lord's mother, being both mother and virgin.[72] At the end of the homily the whole congregation was called to live in justice and to acknowledge Christ as a way of conceiving and giving birth to him, just as Mary had been his mother, so that they could be not only perseveringly virginal but fruitful as well.[73] In *Sermo* 192 Mary as virgin and mother is compared favourably with the Church (although Mary's virginity is not really present in the explanation).[74] Mary as the mother of the Church is found briefly in *Sermo* 195, together with the idea that the Church is the wife of Christ (stated without any attempted parallel with Mary) and virginal in mind as Mary was in the flesh.[75]

Mary Addressed Directly

In *Sermo* 369 Mary is addressed in the second person rather than the third. It is difficult to assess this information, given that this homily, preached in the

[71] Augustine, *s.* 189.3 (NBA 32/1, 34).

[72] Augustine, *s.* 191.2.3 (NBA 32/1, 46). Interestingly, having just cited 2*Cor.* 11:2 about the Church as both wife and virgin, Augustine choose to speak about the Church as both mother and virgin, for these two were the more useful parallels with Mary, who was not Paul's interest.

[73] Augustine, *s.* 191.3.4 (NBA 32/1, 48).

[74] Augustine, *s.* 192.2 (NBA 32/1, 52). Augustine's parallels do not quite work here. Mary gave birth to Christ the head, while the Church gives birth to the Christian community (implying a distinction between Church and members). The deutero-Pauline idea of Christ as the head of the body, which is the Church (*Eph.* 1:22f.; *Col.* 1:18) is present, but Augustine identifying the Church as Christ's body does not match the idea of Mary as the mother of the Head. The idea of Church as wife is not linked with any notion of Mary as wife.

[75] Augustine, *s.* 195.2 (NBA 32/1, 68).

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Basilica Restituta in Carthage according to the manuscript heading,[76] has not been accepted universally as being authentically Augustine's.[77] The most obvious thing to point out is the presence of personification (*conformatio*) or impersonation (*fictiones personarum*), one of the rhetorical figures of thought.[78] What we find is the preacher addressing Mary directly, as though she were present in the community.[79] Not only that, Jesus too was addressed directly.[80] Even though not frequently employed by Augustine, we do find another instance in *Sermo* 345 where he entered into a dialogue with the rich of man of *Luke* 16:19. Yet, as we see in *Sermones* 350B and 350C, it was not so much the rich man from the Scriptures with whom Augustine was engaged but the rich in his own community. On occasion Augustine puts words into the mouths of his congregation, but addressing a biblical character or a martyr as though they were present before him is rare.[81] One would need a more careful reading of all Augustine's homilies before making definitive statements, but even if it is unlikely that Augustine would have employed such a style, we cannot say he never did.

Second Eve

Mary's motherhood functions to allow Augustine to see how the birth of Christ gives honour both to men and women.[82] This is associated with the idea not only of Christ as the second Adam, but Mary as the second Eve.[83] In *Sermo* 190, Augustine went even further to highlight that, by honouring both men and

[76] Cyrille Lambot, L'authenticité du sermon CCCLXIX de saint Augustin pour la fête de Noël, in: *Colligere Fragmanta* (Beuron, 1952), 103-12, 107, 120f. [= *Revue Bénédictine* 79 (1969) 115-28, 119f.]; Othmar Perler and Jean-Louis Maier, *Les voyages de saint Augustin*, Collection des Études Augustiniennes Série Antiquité 36 (Paris, 1969), 316, want to date the homily to 412, the only year we know Augustine was in Carthage at Christmas.

[77] Those against its authenticity include the Maurists and Edmund Hill III, *Sermons* vol. 10 (1995), 306, n. 1. Those for its authenticity include: André Wilmart, Easter Sermons (1926-1927), 115; Réginald Grégoire, *Les homéliaires du Moyen Age* (1966), 30; André Mandouze, *Saint Augustin* (1968), 600; Antoine Chavasse, *Le sacramentaire gélasien* (Vaticanus Reginesis 316) (Paris, 1958), 212; Henri Barré, Les premières prières mariales de l'Occident: *Marianum* 21 (1959) 128-73; Anton Zwinggi, Die Wortgottesdienst bei Augustinus (I) (1970), 95; Jean-Paul Bouhot, L'homéliaire des *Sancti Catholici Patres*. Reconstitution de sa forme originale: *Revue des Études Augustiniennes* 21 (1975) 145-96, 150; Hubertus R. Drobner, *Augustinus von Hippo: Sermones ad populum* (2000), 21; *id.*, The Chronology of Augustine's *Sermones* III (2004), 52. See Pierre-Patrick Verbraken, *Études critiques* (1976), 151.

[78] *Rhet. Her.* 4.53.66; Quintilian, *Inst.* 9.2.29-37.

[79] Augustine, *s.* 369.1 (NBA 34, 476).

[80] *Ibid.* (NBA 34.478).

[81] See *s.* 373.

[82] Augustine, *s.* 184.2 (NBA 32/1, 4). See also *s.* 190.2 (NBA 32/1, 38).

[83] Augustine, *s.* 184.2 (NBA 32/1, 4). Note that in this instance Eve is not named. Jarislav Pelikan, *Mary Through the Centuries: Her Place in the History of Culture* (New Haven and London, 1996), 39-52, does not mention Augustine in his chapter on Mary as second Eve.

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women through his birth, Christ has made it impossible to lay all the blame for the Fall on the woman alone.[84] Here the mother of Christ (*mater Christi*) functions to counteract misogyny.

In *Sermo* 369 there is a contrast between the corrupted mind of a woman (the unnamed Eve) and the uncorrupted flesh of a woman (the unnamed Mary), which functions to highlight the difference between the deception brought by the devil and the liberation brought by Christ.[85] Perhaps here is the implicit idea of Mary's sinlessness.

Conclusion

Although there are numerous references to her in Augustine's surviving Christmas homilies, for the most part Mary functions most frequently in a christological manner: her maternity guaranteed the true humanity and flesh of Christ (exemplified with *Ps.* 85[86] about truth springing from the earth), and her virginity guaranteed the true divinity of Christ (exemplified with some interpretations of *Ps.* 18[19] about the bridegroom coming from his chamber). The idea of Mary's perpetual virginity was certainly endorsed by Augustine, but not as frequently as some scholars imply, but it was not a major feature of his preaching at Christmas. The idea of Mary as second Eve meant that her role in human redemption was enhanced.

In terms of the development of the cult of Mary, the evidence from Augustine's homilies is intriguingly slight. In several Christmas homilies she is portrayed as a role model for the whole Christian community to imitate her virginity and/or her maternity spiritually. Although the Church and dedicated female virgins could be seen as the wife of Christ it was never in connection with Mary as wife. Dedicated virgins were called to see in Mary one who while virginal was also fruitful, just as they would be, but spiritually rather than physically.

What we find in Augustine is the awakening of a sense of Mary's special role in human redemption, unique by worthy of partial imitation. There is no cult of Mary as yet, but there is a sense that the first steps in that direction have been taken. On the whole, though, there are few references to Mary that are developed to any great extent. She functions, when she is mentioned, in such a way as to help the whole community see something about their own relationship with Christ and the Father.

[84] Augustine, *s.* 190.2 (NBA 32/1, 38).
[85] Augustine, *s.* 369.3 (NBA 34, 480).

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Theological and Cultic Components of Mariology in the Context of Ephesus

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Recent appraisals of the fifth-century *theotokos* controversy at Ephesus have tended to veer in two different directions. On one hand, scholars like Kate Cooper, Vasiliki Limberis, and Steven Benko have argued that popular devotion to Mary precluded any attempts to eliminate her from the life of the church and its theology and forced ecclesiastical authorities to accommodate her worship.[1] An additional corollary to this thesis is seeing Marian piety, 'as the natural outgrowth of the goddess-cults in the ancient world', thus denying Marian theology the uniqueness of its conceptual foundation.[2] On the other, scholars like John McGuckin and Richard Price suggest that the theology of Mary is more or less non-existent before the council of Ephesus and, even at the time of the council, it serves as a theoretical footnote to the larger christological issue.[3] In either case, whether by styling Mary as a pagan goddess or minimizing her impact on the development of incarnational theology, such assessments stop short, I believe, of acknowledging the complexity of the Marian issue. The development of Marian theology and devotion was neither a fast nor a straightforward process. Its end result, Mary's exalted status, should not be seen as the by-product of popular pressure or the formulaic conclusion of a Christological debate whose elaborate terminology is comprehensible only to the expert.

In this paper I argue that in the fifth century there are two separate layers of conceptualization of Mary's role in the Christian tradition. The first concerns Marian veneration (which received its expression in liturgical life and devotional practice)[4], and the second is a theoretical dispute regarding the Virgin's

[1] See Stephen Benko, *The Virgin Goddess: Studies in the Pagan and Christian Roots of Mariology* (Leiden, 1993); Vassiliki Limberis, *Divine Heiress. The Virgin Mary and the Creation of Christian Constantinople* (New York, 1994), and Kate Cooper, Contesting the Nativity: Wives, Virgins, and Pulcheria's *Imitatio Mariae*: *Scottish Journal of Religious Studies* 19 (1998) 31-43.

[2] S. Benko, *The Virgin Goddess* (1993), 4.

[3] See John McGuckin, *St. Cyril of Alexandria: the Christological Controversy, its History, Theology, and Texts* (Leiden, 1994); also Richard Price, The *Theotokos* and the Council of Ephesus, in: *Origins of the Cult of the Virgin Mary*, ed. Chris Maunder (London, 2008).

[4] In a recent book Leena Mari Peltomaa remarks briefly that 'the oldest layer of the cult of Mary ... did not originate in theological discourse, but in the devotion paid to the saints', especially in pleas for their intercession and help; see Leena Mari Peltomaa, *The Image of the Virgin Mary in the Akathistos Hymn* (Leiden, 2001), 75-6.

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role in incarnational theology. These two phenomena complement each other and develop in a relation of mutual enrichment and inter-dependence. The available sources do not permit us to assume that Mary's presumed significance in cultic practice determined the contents of Marian theology; if that was true, the dispute over the title *theotokos*, with its fundamental implications for Christian systematic theology, would be inexplicable. Instead I suggest that, in regards to Mary, we need to reconstruct the possible historical dynamics of the interaction between pious practice and theological perspective. This paper aims to outline their interplay, first, by discussing the popular background against which the Marian issue unfolds in the context of Ephesus and secondly, by commenting on how popular devotion and theoretical conceptualization go hand in hand in liturgical and dogmatic materials from this period.

Contextualizing the Marian Issue: The Popular Background

By 429 Marian themes are already noticeable in Christian culture albeit not in any formalized or definitive way. For the monastic population, for example, the Virgin Mary held special significance as an exemplar of a chaste Christian lifestyle. It is no accident that the first recorded Marian appearance is ascribed to an ascetic, Gregory Thaumaturgus.[5] The Alexandrian tradition is most likely the one that placed most weight on this parallel. Thus Cyril of Alexandria claims in a letter to Pope Celestine that the rejection of the title *theotokos* made Nestorius, the patriarch of Constantinople, to blame for disturbances in the empire's capital; the monks and 'many of the senators', Cyril writes, rose up against Nestorius, refusing him public support.[6] Cyril boasts that the people thanked him for his own defense of Mary even as they shut their ears and ran out of the church during one of Nestorius' inflammatory sermons against Mary the God-bearer.[7] The popular sentiment that Cyril records, if authentic, proves that the congregation in Constantinople was familiar with the Marian question and took active role in its development. The *theotokos* issue was not a matter of abstract theology but of living faith and the practice of the church in which all of its members participated. This particular (and powerful) fusion of doctrine and popular piety is the general background against which mariology evolves.

Cyril's appeal to 'the people' would become an important factor at the council of Ephesus as well. Ephesus happened to be the largest cultic center of Marian veneration in the empire.[8] The *vox populi* supplemented the official

[5] Jean Paul Migne (ed.), *Patrologiae Cursus Completus: Series Graeca* (hereafter PG) vols. 68-77. 1st ed. (Paris 1859; reprint Turnabout, 1991), 46, 1133D-1136B.

[6] See Cyril's *Letter to Celestine*, ed. J. McGuckin, *St. Cyril of Alexandria* (1994), 277.

[7] See Norman Russell, *Cyril of Alexandria: Selections* (New York, 2000), 38; J. McGuckin, *St. Cyril of Alexandria* (1994), 277.

[8] See Kenneth Holum, *Theodosian Empresses* (Berkeley, 1982), 164.

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proceedings of the council and set the tone for homiletic displays of Marian praise in the great church of the city. According to Cyril, 'the entire populace of the city remained from dawn until evening [at the church doors] awaiting the judgment of the holy council.'[9] The Marian question was further related to the responsibility of teaching proper doctrine to the laity. The selection of passages from Nestorius' writings included in his conciliar deposition, ends with a reference to the people who had a 'great piety and a very fervent sense of religion', but were misled by their teachers (i.e. the Nestorians) in pursuing false doctrines.[10] As he reflects on the aftermath of the council in 431, John of Antioch, one of its key participants, stresses the importance of educated guidance for the corporate Christian audience: 'We reject all the doctrines introduced recently either through letters or through pamphlets as confusing the common people.'[11] In sum, a consideration of the popular reception of Mary is one of the major factors supplementing the synodical decision-making and, I would add, a positive one. It shows that the Marian question pertains to the Christian faith as a whole rather than to the academic debates of the intellectual elite.

What is more, not all the bishops who attended the Ephesian council were learned theologians. If the intricacies of the Christological discussions went beyond what some of them could follow with ease, Cyril's appeal to their liturgical experience and Mary's presence in it illustrates well the need of a practical setting for speculative questions.[12] Thus Cyril insists that the acknowledgement of Mary as a God-bearer is integral to the definition of Christ's true presence and its salvific effects in the Eucharist. Partaking of the Eucharist, he says, believers become the church, the whole body of Christ united in worship, hence 'the union of Christ's flesh and the Logos is parallel to the union of the eucharistic bread with Christ's flesh.'[13] Ecclesiastical unity could exist only as predicated on eucharistic unity[14] which in turn is linked to the union of human and divine strata in Christ. This is a position to which both clergy and laity could subscribe regardless of their level of academic expertise.

[9] Cyril of Alexandria, *Epistle 24*, in Eduard Schwartz (ed). *Acta Conciliorum Oecumenicorum, I: Concilium Universale Ephesinum* (5 vols); *II: Concilium Universale Chalcedonense* (6 vols), (Berlin, 1927-1932), hereafter ACO 1.1.1, 117-8, translation in John McEnerney, *St. Cyril of Alexandria: Letters. Fathers of the Church*, 76-77 (Washington, 1987), 1, 107.

[10] J. McGuckin, *St. Cyril of Alexandria* (1994), 377.

[11] J. McEnerney, *St. Cyril of Alexandria* (1987), 2:83.

[12] For an excellent summary of the eucharistic dimension of the controversy see Henry Chadwick's article, Eucharist and Christology in the Nestorian Controversy: *Journal of Theological Studies N.S.* 2 (1951) 145-64.

[13] *Ibid.* 157.

[14] See Lawrence Welch, *Christology and Eucharist in the Early Thought of Cyril of Alexandria* (London, 1994), 99. This idea is already expressed in its mature form in Cyril's *Commentary on John*, which predates the controversy: 'For by one body, that is, his own, blessing through the mystery of the eucharist those who believe on him, he makes us of the same body with himself and with each other'; *Commentary on John*, XI 11, transl. T. Randall, cit. *ibid.*

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At the end of the first conciliar session (June 22, 431) at which Mary's title of *theotokos* received the hierarchs' endorsement, the Ephesian crowd's mood was jubilant. As Cyril relates, 'as we came out of the church, they [the people waiting] preceded us with torches as far as the inn, for the evening was near; and there was much joy and lighting of lights in the city, so that even women carrying censers led the way for us.'[15] This picture of communal celebration is in sharp contrast with the continued disagreements between the bishops, on the question of Mary's doctrinal status: some, Cyril admits, called Mary both Mother of God and mother of Man, others refused to give her the honor.[16]

On July 4, 431 people occupied the Great Church of Constantinople to demonstrate their support for Cyril's party and acclaimed Mary and Pulcheria, the emperor's sister, as victorious: 'Mary the Virgin has deposed Nestorius! ... Many years to Pulcheria! She is the one who has strengthened the faith!'[17] Pulcheria's mention in popular praise fittingly alludes to the universal scope of Marian worship: the *theotokos* was a figure to whom all, rich and poor, noble and low, members of the court or of crowd, could relate. Her appeal proved to be common and widespread, well beyond the narrow confines of the ascetic and clerical groups.

Pulcheria is a useful figure to discuss in the context of the controversy, partially because the evidence does not explain the direct nature of her involvement, but suggests that it was substantial. An augusta who had established a quasi-monastic lifestyle at the court of Constantinople, Pulcheria could be seen as one of Mary's most fervent devotees and thus someone who would have an existential stake in defending her virginity as God-bearing.[18] She sponsored the building of three major churches dedicated to Mary: the Blakhernai, the Hodegoi and the Khalkoprateria, and brought over valuable relics from the East,

[15] Trans. J. McEnerney, *St. Cyril of Alexandria* (1987), 1, 107. Cyril does not mention Mary as the object of this celebration. Holum suggests that the celebrations were in honor of the Virgin *theotokos* and this is the reason why women led the triumphal procession throughout the city. See K. Holum, *Theodosian Empresses* (1982), 166, also L.M. Peltomaa, *The Image of the Virgin Mary* (2001), 58.

[16] *Epistle 27*, ACO 1.1.3, 45-6, transl. J. McEnerney, *St. Cyril of Alexandria* (1987), 1, 113. Cyril's remark refers to the synod of Oriental bishops.

[17] ACO I.1,3, 14; K. Holum, *Theodosian Empresses* (1982), 170.

[18] Sozomen, *Hist. Eccl.* IX 1.3-4 mentions Pulcheria's dedication of an altar in the Great Church of Constantinople which proclaimed her imperial vows to Christian consecration. See Sozomen, *Historia Ecclesiatica, Clavis Patrum Graecorum* 6030, ed. J. Bidez, Neue Folge, 2 (Berlin, 1995). Also see Judith Herrin, *Women in Purple: Rulers of Medieval Byzantium* (London, 2001), and Catia Galatariotou, Holy Women and Witches: Aspects of Byzantine Conceptions of Gender: *Byzantine and Modern Greek Studies* 9 (1984/5) 55-94. Also see an important article by Nicholas Constas, Weaving the Body of God: Proclus of Constantinople, the *Theotokos*, and the Loom of the Flesh: *Journal of Early Christian Studies* 32 (1995) 169-94. For general comments on the role and privileges of imperial women in the Byzantine court, see Barbara Hill, *Imperial Women in Byzantium 1025-1204: Power, Patronage and Ideology* (Edinburgh, 1999), 96-119.

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including the Virgin's girdle.[19] The Syrian historian Barhadbeshabba reports that Pulcheria had her image painted in the Great Church of Constantinople above the altar, a place which would later on traditionally be inscribed with the likeness of the Virgin.[20] She also wanted her dress to serve as an altar cloth and, as court gossip would have it, referred to herself as having given birth to God, while seeking access to the sanctuary to receive the Eucharist with the priests.[21] These material manifestations of Pulcheria's presence in the church show that the Augusta was one of the very few women who had the means to challenge (subtly but visibly) the social constraints of the era and craft a public persona of holiness inspired by Mary. Pulcheria's lavish philanthropy directed at the church, her acquisition of Marian relics, and her involvement with cultic sites in Constantinople, testify to her successful promotion of the *theotokos*. Her active engagement with the councils of Ephesus and Chalcedon marks the culminating point of her efforts.

Vasiliki Limberis argues that 'Pulcheria understood [any] attacks on the *Theotokos* as a personal affront.'[22] She 'had taken the Virgin *Theotokos* as the model of her life'[23] and '[W]hen she claimed that her identity was the Virgin's, suddenly the identity of the *Theotokos* was merged with the imperial power Pulcheria held as Augusta.'[24] In other words, the cult of Mary the *theotokos* is primarily an imperial creation.[25] Yet popular acclaim of Mary as a *theotokos* belies the idea that devotion to Mary was an artificial construct. At the same time, our sources are too meager to permit a solid judgment about the precise nature of the connection between Mary and (female) asceticism of which Pulcheria is a representative. We have no first-hand account of Pulcheria's own understanding of Mary and the nature of her calling to virginity. Thus we should not we succumb to the temptation to overinterpret the existence of shrines dedicated to the Virgin as an evidence for the existence of a full-fledged cult of Mary. Popular as Mary was, the very nature of the dispute between

[19] See K. Holum, *Theodosian Empresses* (1982), 142-3. Peltomaa notes that according to the Byzantine sources, Pulcheria was responsible for building only the Blakhernai; the Khalkoprateia was probably built together with Theodosius II. See L.M. Peltomaa, *The Image of the Virgin Mary* (2001), 76; see Raymond Janin, *La Géographie ecclésiastique de l'empire byzantin I, III: Les Églises et les monastères* (Paris, 1953), 169, 246. It is possible that Pulcheria tried to emulate the example of Constantine I's mother, Helena, who built a splendid church for Mary in Bethlehem.

[20] Barhadbeshabba, *Historia Ecclesiatica*, 27 (PO 9, 565).

[21] See B. Hill, *Imperial Women in Byzantium 1025-1204* (1999), 143.

[22] V. Limberis, *Divine Heiress* (1994), 55.

[23] See K. Holum, *Theodosian Empresses* (1982), 141: 'She [Pulcheria] embraced Mary as a paradigm of her own asceticism, in the belief that by emulating the *Theotokos* she would receive the Divine Word in her own body.' This belief, however, is not attested in Pulcheria's own voice.

[24] V. Limberis, *Divine Heiress* (1994), 59, 60.

[25] See K. Holum, *Theodosian Empresses* (1982), 142: 'Pulcheria was also an Augusta; inevitably, contemporary Mariology entered the ideological framework of her sacred basileia.'

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Cyril and Nestorius indicates that a mature theological explanation – and a proper hierarchical endorsement, – of Marian piety was yet to come.

Based on the shortage of evidence, it seems one-sided to argue that lay piety – of which Pulcheria is a most illustrious representative, – dictated the contents of doctrine and that'we may be wrong to assume that Mariology followed where Christology led.'[26] It overplays and simplifies the evidence to suggest that a study of the period preceding Ephesus would 'ultimately reveal that Mariology developed from a grounding in both tradition and lay piety, and that Christology was adjusted to accommodate it.'[27] Marian devotion was still a questionable phenomenon at its roots. At the same time, the terminological complexity of the dispute at Ephesus and the christological framework in which the Marian question is situated by both Cyril and Nestorius demonstrate that Mary's figure casts a powerful shadow across the contents of both doctrine and tradition. Thus a balanced assessment of the *theotokos* controversy should take into account the significance of popular devotion together with the general demand for it to be situated within an unambiguously orthodox framework.

A compelling illustration of the ways in which piety and intellectual understanding run parallel in early Mariology is found in an episode that occurred at the end of 430. This is when Cyril sent three separate treatises to the imperial court, two of which were meant for the female members of the imperial family and titled *Address to the Princesses* and *Address to the Empresses*. Although three of the presumed recipients have taken vows of virginity,[28] Cyril's argument in this work is not limited to an emphasis on Mary's importance in asceticism and devotional practice. At the core of his work is a sophisticated christological argument, in the context of which the faithful and virginal Mary is depicted as giving birth to the divine Word. Cyril clearly assumes that the readers would be able to follow his logic the thrust of which is that Mary matters not only in terms of devotional practices but because she plays an integral part of a Christ-centered theological message.

Six months later, another participant in the Ephesian council, Theodotus of Ancyra, would similarly describe Mary as an 'archetype of both mothers and virgins'[29] and a suitable model for women who live like her.[30] Mary is a fitting archetype, once again, not only in terms of her obedience and faithfulness, but because she is the one who facilitates the incarnation and underscores the correct interpretation of what God has accomplished 'for us'. This reference to the correct or orthodox interpretation of God's involvement with his creation is very interesting. It indicates that the validity of mariological discourse is seen

[26] For this position see K. Cooper, *Contesting the Nativity* (1998), 31-43, 42.

[27] *Ibid.*

[28] Pulcheria, Arcadia, and Marina, the emperor's sisters.

[29] *Homily Six* (PO 19, 331), transl. Luigi Gambero, *Mary and the Fathers of the Church: The Blessed Virgin Mary in Patristic Thought* (San Francisco, 1999), 261.

[30] See L. Gambero, *Mary and The Fathers of the Church* (1999), 268.

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by both Cyril and Theodotus (Proclus of Constantinople, a supporter of Cyril, would take a similar route) not as merely enhancing the christological argument, but as clarifying and exemplifying its essential meaning. The theology of Mary is understood to be a fundamental component of incarnational theology, complete with its own set of discursive strategies, conceptualizations, and symbolism. A brief discussion of those follows.

Core Themes in Marian Theology in the Context of Ephesus

Homiletic materials from the period the Ephesian controversy illustrate well the fusion of devotional and speculative elements in Mariology. The homilies delivered by Proclus, Cyril and Theodotus show that, while devotion to Mary was becoming paramount to the liturgical idiom of the church, it also had a solid conceptual foundation. They serve the double purpose of encouraging Marian devotion and situating it within a particular Christological framework. Some of the core dialectics of the Marian phenomenon concern her typological depiction as a mediating figure between God and humanity (or God-bearer), the discussion of her motherhood as a guarantee for the reality of the incarnation, and finally the designation of her womb as the locus of salvation itself.

1. *Mary as theotokos*

Presided by Cyril, the conciliar session of June 22, 431 did not publish a new creedal formula, but instead reaffirmed Nicaea and from this vintage point confirmed Alexandrian theology and its defense of the *theotokos* as orthodox. Thus John O'Keefe's conclusion that the controversy was a continuation of the major themes of incarnational theology laid out at Nicaea, is well served.[31] In addition, the Ephesian version of the incarnation served as the basis for the development of a particular form of Marian theology, encapsulated in the dispute over the title *theotokos*.[32]

That the *theotokos* question was integral to the development of any (orthodox) christological argument is shown by the fact that the bishops' evaluation of Nestorius' theology focused on his depiction of Christ as well as his rejection

[31] See John O'Keefe, Impassible Suffering? Divine Passion and Fifith-Century Christology: *Journal of Theological Studies N.S.* 58 (1997) 39-60, 42. O'Keefe explains the shift from 'primarily theological to primary christological' debate in the fifth century with Nicaea's refusal to assign the Son a 'meditorial, subordinate role'; *ibid.* 43. O'Keefe's approach emphasizes the need of discerning how fundamental themes of doctrine which had emerged in previous debates surface anew in 429 and help clarify the diverging versions (Alexandrian or Antiochian) of the participants' common Christian past.

[32] See L.M. Peltomaa, *The Image of the Virgin Mary* (2001), 135.

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of the *theotokos*.[33] In the synodical deposition of Nestorius the denial of the rationale behind the title *theotokos* is well attested. Nestorius promoted Mary, the deposition testifies, not as the mother of God, but as the mother of Christ (*christotokos*), the human being whom God joined by his own initiative.[34] Mary received God, God dwelled in her, and came through her but was not born of her. [35] According to Nestorius, God was never an infant, but always a separate being that did not suffer any transfer of characteristics between its two natures, human or divine.[36]

At Ephesus, Cyril's rejection of this position and subsequent defense of the *theotokos* was based on contrasting Christological premises. In his two dogmatic letters to Nestorius, included in the conciliar records,[37] Cyril argues that Mary's son is God who is 'born of woman in the flesh though owning his existence before the ages and begotten of the Father.'[38] For Cyril an acknowledgment of Mary as *theotokos* is indispensable for a true understanding of Christ's mission in the divine economy. Cyril qualifies his message in several different ways: calling Christ God and Mary *theotokos* does not mean 'that his divine nature originated in the holy Virgin or necessarily required for its own sake a second birth subsequent to that from the Father.'[39] For Cyril the Word makes all human properties, including generation in the flesh, his own. The union between God and humanity is an act of sharing[40] of flesh and blood. This, Cyril affirms is the 'key to the holy fathers' thinking. [T]his is why they dare to call the holy Virgin "mother of God."'[41]

2. *Mary and the reality of the Incarnation*

For theologians like Cyril, Proclus, and Theodotus the acknowledgment of Mary's 'divine motherhood' handed her the 'scepter of orthodoxy' and confirmed the reality of the incarnation.[42] Their perception of the oneness of Christ, as God born in the flesh by the Virgin, was combined with a depiction

[33] ACO 1.2, 45-64, transl. J. McGuckin, *St. Cyril of Alexandria* (1994), 369f.

[34] In Friedrich Loofs, *Nestoriana* (Halle, 1905), 274, 277; transl. J. McGuckin, *St. Cyril of Alexandria* (1994), 369f.

[35] F. Loofs, *Nestoriana* (1905), 277, 287; transl. J. McGuckin, *St. Cyril of Alexandria* (1994), 369. 371.

[36] *Ibid.*

[37] Cyril's *Second and Third Letters to Nestorius*, as they are commonly known; *Ep.* 4 (PG 77, 44-50), ACO 1.1.1., 25-8, and *Ep.* 17 (PG 77, 105-22), ACO 1.1, 33-42. The letters are translated in: J. McGuckin, *St. Cyril of Alexandria* (1994), 262-5. 266-75; and Lionell Wickham, *Cyril of Alexandria: Select Letters* (Oxford, 1983), 2-33.

[38] *Second Letter to Nestorius*, (L. Wickam, *Cyril of Alexandria*, 1983, 7).

[39] *Ibid.*

[40] *Ibid.*, (L. Wickam, *Cyril of Alexandria*, 1983, 9).

[41] *Ibid.*, (L. Wickam, *Cyril of Alexandria*, 1983, 9f.).

[42] Cyril, *Homily Four* (PG 77, 992).

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of the incarnational event as inherently salvific and accomplished 'for us'. The mother of the one Christ occupied a special place in this incarnational vision. For the first time Marian praises in Eastern Christian theology and hymnography affirm the universality of Mary's mission (as a *theotokos*) in such a powerful, detailed, and dogmatically consistent manner.

The Marian themes found most frequently in homiletic materials from this period are structured against a complex grid of biblical allusions and typological insights. Mary is described as a dramatic embodiment of the elemental forces of nature through which God reveals himself. These images, propped by allusions to various Biblical characters and events, are striking with their beauty and intensity: she is a burning bush,[43] a swift cloud, the burning lampstand from the vision of the prophet Zachariah, a 'purest fleece full of heavenly rain',[44] a fertile field which God cultivated 'desiring to unite himself with human nature.'[45] Some of those allusions echo earlier traditions: for example, Irenaeus also describes Mary as virgin earth but in those later works the imagery is developed with loving attention to detail. Compare, for example, a line from one of Theodotus' sermons: 'The first soul was virgin; so is this new soil. In Eden, God decreed that plants should be born; in this Virgin, the Creator himself became a sapling, according to the flesh.'[46]

The reality of the birth in which God had received human form from Mary's own created form (μορφή) is unquestionable, including labor,[47] 'the swelling of pregnancy and the physical changes of the body.'[48] In his *Homily Three*, most likely delivered before 433, Proclus links christological and mariological discourse to underline the genuine character of the birth: 'an enfleshment giving form to the one without shape; an inconceivable birth; a beginning, but not the beginning of the one who was born.'[49] The typology of Mary is not only nature-based but also laden with the dynamic overtones of union and exchange: Mary is described as the workshop (τὸ ἐργαστήριον) of the incarnation, the Word's bridal chamber (ἡ παστάς), the marketplace of salvation (ἡ πανήγυρις τοῦ σωτηρίου, where the exchange between life and death takes place), and a spiritual paradise in which the second Adam dwelled (ὁ λογικὸς τοῦ δευτέρου Ἀδὰμ παράδεισος).

Mary's depiction as the mother of the incarnate Word includes an explicit recognition of the oneness of Christ – the same divine person who has assumed flesh is also the one who suffers and dies on behalf of all humanity. Mary's

[43] See *Exodus* 3:2.

[44] *Judges* 6:38; see Nicholas Constas, *Proclus of Constantinople and the Cult of the Virgin in Late Antiquity* (Leiden, 2003), 133f.

[45] *Ibid.* 269. Same idea occurs in Proclus' *Homily One.*

[46] *Ibid.*

[47] *Homily Two* (N. Constas, *Proclus of Constantinople*, 2003, 167, 169).

[48] *Homily Five* (N. Constas, *Proclus of Constantinople*, 2003, 259).

[49] *Homily Three* (N. Constas, *Proclus of Constantinople*, 2003, 201).

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image is centrally situated at the axis of the union of two essentially different yet aligned realities – the human and divine components of the Savior's being. The incorruptible character of the birth is a testimony to the fact that Christ is God: 'for the child came forth without ruffling the bed-chambers of the womb.'[50] In *Homily Four* Proclus describes the virgin *theotokos* as the 'richly appointed throne' of God – an image that once again, shows her elemental significance for incarnational theology, but carefully underlines the fact that Mary is not the source of Christ's divinity – a theme with which Cyril would also concur.[51]

In Mary God dwells in a 'living temple', yet, as a creator, he is not dishonored by choosing, voluntarily, to descend into his creation. In contrast to Nestorius' sanitized version of the incarnation, which picks up on the idea of God's 'good pleasure' to avoid any mentioning of the flesh-and-blood level of the christic union, Cyril and Proclus' depiction of the relationship between creator and creation focuses on the organic nature of their joining in Christ:

> Clay does not defile the potter who repairs what he himself had fashioned. Neither was the pure one defiled by coming forth from a virgin's womb.[52]

> For a living being is born ... skillfully composed of unlike principles, from two, indeed, but one man results, each principle remaining that which it is, both brought together as if into one natural unity and so joined with each other that each communicates to the other what is proper to itself.[53]

The incarnation is the definitive proof of God's gratuitous love for humankind. Proclus finds the logic of the enfleshment of God to be consistent with God's character as a creator; creation and redemption are linked together as exemplifying the will of a merciful deity for 'all things to be saved': 'So do not be ashamed of the birth pangs, O man! For they were the beginning of our salvation. [...] A master builder is not dishonored if he dwells in the buildings of his own design.'[54] And again, '[t]he loving God was not ashamed of the birth pangs of a woman, for the business at hand was life.'[55] Pursuing the design of salvation, 'the Word became flesh; the natures came together and the union remained unconfused.'[56] The criterion of orthodox Christianity will be to confess both – human and divine – as shaping the reality of the incarnation. To jeopardize their union would lead to one of the two extremes: to be a Jew (denying the divinity) or a Manichee (denying the reality of Christ's body).[57]

[50] *Homily Four* (N. Constas, *Proclus of Constantinople*, 2003, 229).
[51] *Homily Four* (N. Constas, *Proclus of Constantinople*, 2003, 231).
[52] *Homily One* (N. Constas, *Proclus of Constantinople*, 2003, 139).
[53] *Letter to the Monks*, transl. J. McEnerney, *St. Cyril of Alexandria* (1987), 1, 22.
[54] *Homily One* (N. Constas, *Proclus of Constantinople*, 2003, 139).
[55] *Ibid.*
[56] *Ibid.* 145.
[57] *Ibid.*

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Salvation and suffering are brought together as logical correlatives in the incarnational scheme. The incarnation sets out to repair the sickly estate of humanity from the inside; hence Christ is with and of the Virgin Mary; he is not simply a temporary dweller within her body. Since he has a mother and a true human body, he is also a subject to the most human of all things – suffering: 'by what he became he suffered'.[58] His voluntary suffering is redemptive. To cite another example, in his *Second Letter to Nestorius* Cyril clearly situates the theme of Mary's birthgiving in a narrative context where the generation of the divine Word 'according to the flesh' is related to his subsequent suffering and death on the cross.[59]

3. *The Womb of Mary – The Locus of Salvation*

In a recent article Nicholas Constas has called attention to one of the most remarkable metaphors of the incarnation found in Proclus' *Homily One*. It concerns weaving: the weaving of the Word's flesh on the loom of the Virgin's 'unsullied' body:

> [She is] the awesome loom of the divine economy upon which the robe of union was ineffably woven. The loom worker was the Holy Spirit, the woolworker the overshadowing power on high. The wool was the ancient fleece of Adam; the interlocking thread the spotless flesh of the Virgin.[60]

Here Proclus' language is striking on two levels: he discusses the Holy Spirit as the agent of conception, a task which in antiquity is traditionally referred to the male. Yet, at the same time, it makes the Holy Spirit assume the typically female task of weaving, thus bringing gender opposites together, in a possible allusion to the way in which Christ's virginal conception transcends the curse of Adam and Eve's sexual separation. In the course of conception and gestation, Mary is, at least in this sermon, passive.

Weaving out the union of natures means covering God with the 'robe' of union and containing him within its boundaries. Here Proclus affirms Mary's womb as the locus of God's circumscription. The focus and the pathos of this image is christological.' 'Who ever saw, who ever heard, of God in his infinity dwelling in a womb? Heaven cannot contain him, yet a womb did not constrict him.'[61] If, for Nestorius, the image of Mary's womb would function as a prime example of analytical thinking gone astray (the eternal God cannot be contained in a womb), for Proclus and Cyril, the containment of God in the womb, i.e. in the flesh, embodies the best of what the language of Christian soteriology

[58] *Ibid.*
[59] *Second Letter to Nestorius* (L. Wickam, *Cyril of Alexandria*, 1983, 7f.).
[60] *Homily One* (N. Constas, *Proclus of Constantinople*, 2003, 137).
[61] *Ibid.* 139.

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has to offer. Mary's womb is a paradoxical illustration of the en-humanization of the impassible deity and thus the locus of salvation. It is a protected and sanctified space: the space which God enters in the paradoxical reality of the incarnation where what is limitless manifests itself in a circumscribable form, what is incomprehensible becomes available to human faith, and what is immortal becomes subject to death.

This particular understanding of the nature of the incarnation as containment or circumscription is a strong feature of the theology of the Cyrilline party. Cyril's *Third Letter* argues that Christ 'took flesh of the holy Virgin, making it his own from the womb, and underwent our human birth and came forth as man from a woman.'[62] Similarly, the motif of Mary's womb is evident even in homilies which are traditionally dated to the beginning of Proclus' career in Constantinople.[63] For example, in his *Homily Three* Proclus reiterates the significance of Mary's 'womb wider than the heavens'. For Theodotus it is her womb, the 'virginal and fragrant bridal chamber' which localizes the miracle of divine conception.[64] Theodotus indulges in the language of paradoxical appropriation that makes this event possible: unlike the tomb of Christ, which is broken open at the resurrection, Mary's womb remains sealed: 'When he rose from the tomb, he opened tombs; when he was born from a womb, he did not open the womb.'[65] Mary is duly praised:

> For you gave birth to the Beginning who has no beginning, a child who is before all ages, the Virgin's Son, the Eternal who is nurtured in your womb, to him who is older than his Mother yet is nursed by her, to him who nourishes all creatures and who clothes himself in human form ...[66]

Once impregnated by the Holy Spirit, Mary becomes the container of the uncontainable God.[67] This is a phrase that will be underlined with particular forcefulness in the context of Ephesus. Proclus returns persistently to this same idea in a number of texts: 'Come and see the womb of a virgin wider than creation! For the one whom (creation) cannot contain is contained in her without constriction.'[68]

[62] *Third Letter to Nestorius* (L. Wickham, *Cyril of Alexandria: Select Letters*, 1983, 17).

[63] The tentative character of the dating should be kept in mind; N. Constas, *Proclus of Constantinople* (2003), 248 sounds a note of caution in pointing out that *Homily One* is a 'rather unique work and perhaps should not be used to assess the contents of other works composed for the new festival [of the Nativity].' At the time Proclus was a secretary to bishop Atticus.

[64] *Homily Four*, para. 6 (PG 77, 1397), transl. L. Gambero, *Mary and the Fathers of the Church* (1999), 264; see *Homily Six* (PO 19, 331) in which Theodotus speaks of the fruit of Mary's womb as a 'shoot of immortality'.

[65] *Homily Five*, para. 1 (PG 77, 1413-B), transl. L. Gambero, *Mary and the Fathers of the Church* (1999), 265.

[66] *Homily Six*, para. 12 (PO 19, 331), transl. L. Gambero, *Mary and the Fathers of the Church* (1999), 261.

[67] See L. Gambero, *Mary and the Fathers of the Church* (1999), 268.

[68] *Homily Four* (N. Constas, *Proclus of Constantinople*, 2003, 227).

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Finally, Mary's womb is to be compared to the font of baptism in Proclus' *Homilies Three*, *Five*, and *Twelve*.[69] In Theodotus' *Homily Four* we find another encomium of praises which emphasizes Mary's role as a 'most limpid font of the life-giving wave' (*i.e.* baptism) and as the 'rejoicing of the churches'.[70] Cyril's *Homily Four* incorporates corresponding images of Mary as a baptismal font of sanctification, the person who brings people to the orthodox faith, and the leader who unites believers in their worship of God, thus building the church.[71]

In surveying those major themes in Marian theology – describing Mary as a God-bearer, a guarantee for the reality of the Son's incarnation, and her womb as the container of the uncontainable God – I contend that there is a uniquely Christian dimension to Mariology which was played out in full force in the context of Ephesus. By terming it uniquely Christian, I mean to say that the conceptual paradigms which shaped Marian theology stem from a context of scriptural data, theological reflection, and liturgical practice that would be comprehensible only to an audience of Christian believers. They do not necessarily reflect Christian appropriations of pagan religiosity, but come from sources that belong to the church and are thus endemic to its self-definition as a worshipping community.

Conclusion

To summarize, in the context of Ephesus we find an acknowledgement of Mary's indispensable role in three different venues: in the popular acclaim of the corporate Christian community, in the systematic structures of incarnational theology, and in liturgical life as illustrated by the homilies of Cyril, Proclus, and Theodotus of Ancyra.

As Cyril and his supporters argue, if Christ's identity comes from the divine Word, than it is not only proper, but unavoidable to hail Mary as a *theotokos*; not in the sense that she is the origin of the divine Word as such, but because she is God's means of becoming incarnate. This point is worth emphasizing. Far from being an appendix to the major themes of the Nestorian controversy, the Marian issue forced a revision of incarnational theology, its logic, content, and purpose. The impact of such revision is clearly noticeable in the evolution of core theological motifs such as the depiction of Mary as a mediating link between God and humanity, the emphasis on her womb as the place where the

[69] Constas comments on these images in detail; see N. Constas, *Proclus of Constantinople*, 2003, 207.

[70] *Homily Four*, para. 3 (PG 77, 1393B), transl. L. Gambero, *Mary and the Fathers of the Church* (1999), 267.

[71] See L.M. Peltomaa, *The Image of the Virgin Mary* (2001), 68.

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incarnation becomes a concrete reality, and the language of paradoxical appropriation of human and divine properties of which her birthgiving is a prime example. All those conceptualizations are readily adopted in the later Christian tradition.

Simply put, Ephesus proves mariology to be is an essential component of Christian culture. In addition, examining the evolution of Marian imagery and theological motifs suggests that theoretical definitions of Mary's placement in the Christian tradition are inextricably linked with Marian piety and its developing momentum.

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Body, Clothing and Female Identity

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Eusebius of Caesarea in his *Ecclesiastical History* introduces a very interesting document: the *Letter of the Churches of Lyon and Vienne to the Churches of Asia and Phrygia*: this letter describes the persecution in Gaul in the year 177-8.[1] Blandina is the main character of the events the unknown writers refer to. Her conditions could not be worse: she is a weak, little woman, maybe not nice, and besides, a slave. Her own mistress fears for her as she thinks that the poor slave will not be able to face tortures. On the contrary Blandina, showing courage and strength, goes beyond any natural possibility. With her *confessio* she becomes an athlete and the heroine in the group of her brothers and sisters in Christ. She even is spiritual mother for Ponticus, the boy encouraged by her to resist till death: in so doing, she appears like the famous, biblical mother of the Maccabean brothers.[2] Blandina is seen as a sign of redemption. She is the one 'through whom Christ proved that the things that men think cheap, ugly, and contemptuous are deemed worthy of glory before God, by reason of her love for him, which was not merely vaunted in appearance, but demonstrated in achievement'.[3]

The weak, little slave woman faces physical and spiritual trials to the point of defeating the devil, according to the divine promise to Eve. Christ himself appears through her in his suffering and victorious dimension. She 'was hung on a post and exposed as bait for the wild animals that were let loose on her. She seemed to hang there in the form of a cross and by her fervent prayer she aroused intense enthusiasm in those who were undergoing their ordeal, for in their torment, with their physical eyes, they saw in the person of their sister him who was crucified for them, that he might convince all who believe in him

[1] See Eusebius of Caesarea., *Hist. Eccl.* V 1.3 – V 2.8. The text, with the title *The Martyrs of Lyons*, appears in: *The Acts of the Christian Martyrs*, ed. Herbert Musurillo (Oxford, 1972), 62-85. About that persecution see: Robert Turcan-Jean Rouge (eds.), *Les martyrs de Lyon (177)*, Lyon 20-23 septembre 1977, pres. par Amable Audin, concl. par Claude Mondésert (Paris, 1978).

[2] See Marie-Louise Guillaumin, 'Une jeune fille qui s'appelait Blandine'. Aux origines d'une tradition hagiographique, in: Jacques Fontaine et Charles Kannengiesser (eds.), *Epektasis: Mélanges patristiques offerts au card. Jean Daniélou* (Paris, 1972), 93-8; Clementina Mazzucco, *'E fui fatta maschio'. La donna nel cristianesimo primitivo (sec. I-III)* (Firenze, 1989), 115-9.

[3] See *The Martyrs of Lyons* I 17 (66-7 Musurillo).

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that all who suffer for Christ's glory will have eternal fellowship in the living God'.[4] A woman is *figura Christi*: that is something new.

Blandina can win her battle as she had put on Christ, according to *Rom.* 13:14 and *Gal.* 3:27.[5] *Imitatio Christi* leads here the woman to overcome her female nature; she becomes as strong as a man, an athlete, and thanks to her sacrifice she reaches a complete identification with Christ.

'To put on Christ', 'to put on the new man' are expressions from Paul's *Letters*: a figurative language, with clothing as its basis. Clothes, sign of identification in antiquity, become spiritual substance. So a woman may assume a different identity, or even better she may reach a different dimension. To become an athlete, to put on Christ, to identify herself with him: a new perspective opens up for her. In every ancient culture, however, human perfection was a male perfection; Christ himself came into the world as a male. As every Christian believer must be imitator of Christ, women must assimilate themselves to a male model.[6]

Carthage, year 203. A group of Christian prisoners is waiting for the trial sentence. Two autobiographical documents are smuggled out of the prison. An unknown writer puts them together, adding a prologue and a description of the martyrdom of those believers. That is the origin of the *Passio Perpetuae et Felicitatis*.[7] The first of the two documents is a kind of prison diary, the first autobiography ever written by a woman. Her name was Perpetua, aged 22. She was a *matrona*, had a baby; her original family was composed by father, mother, two brothers. In the text there is not a word about her husband. She tries to separate herself completely from natural and secular affections, according to Jesus' words in *Matth.* 10:37: 'No one is worthy of me who cares more for father or mother than for me'. The relationship with her pagan father is a kind of extreme test: the man is described as the devil. Finally she writes about the visions she has.[8] Let us read a part of the fourth vision.

[4] *Ibid.*, I 41 (74-5 Musurillo). See Elena Giannarelli, Prayer and Spirituality in Early Christian Female Martyrdom and Monasticism, in: Pauline Allen, Wendy Mayer, and Lawrence Cross (eds.), *Prayer and Spirituality in the Early Church* (Brisbane, 1999), II 109-26 (114-15).

[5] *The Martyrs of Lyons* I 42 (75 Musurillo): '... for she had put on Christ, that mighty and invincible athlete, and had overcome the Adversary in many contests, and through her conflict had won the crown of immortality.'

[6] About a woman *miles* and/or *athleta Christi*, see E. Giannarelli, *La tipologia femminile nella biografia e nell'autobiografia cristiana del IV secolo* (Roma, 1980), 25-8; always useful the famous work by Adolf von Harnack, *Militia Christi* (Darmstadt, 1963).

[7] See *Passio sanctarum Perpetuae et Felicitatis* in: *The Acts of the Christian Martyrs*, ed. Musurillo (1972), 106-31. Useful critical essays: Eugenio Corsini, *Proposte per una lettura della Passio Perpetuae*, in: *Forma futuri: Studi in onore del card. Michele Pellegrino* (Torino, 1975), 481-541; Teresa Sardella, Strutture temporali e modelli di cultura: rapporti tra antitradizionalismo storico e modello martiriale nella Passio Perpetuae et Felicitatis: *Augustinianum* 30 (1990) 259-78.

[8] See Jacqueline Amat, L'authenticité des songes de la Passion de Perpétue et de Félicité, in: *Sogni, visioni e profezie nell'antico cristianesimo*, XVII Incontro di Studiosi dell'Antichità cristiana (Roma, 1989), 177-91; Giuliana Lanata, Sogni di donne nel primo cristianesimo, in: *Donne sante, sante donne: Esperienza religiosa e storia di genere* (Torino, 1996), 61-98.

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Perpetua pictures herself in the amphitheatre.[9] She looks at the crowd waiting in astonishment: that's the theme of *expectatio*. Against her an Egyptian of vicious appearance: the devil. According to tradition, he is an Egyptian like the Pharaoh, the persecutor of the chosen people. At his service, the demons. Also Perpetua has servants and assistants: angels. The woman writes: 'I was undressed and I was made male'.[10]

Then her servants began to rub her down with oil as they are wont to do before a contest.

Pagan athletes were naked at the moment of their fight; so were Christian athletes, at the moment of their martyrdom.[11] Christ himself was undressed. Perpetua too is undressed as her female clothes have no more meaning: no clothing whatsoever has a meaning at that moment. Perpetua's body is going to acquire the male strength necessary for the fight. She is athlete of Christ and so she changes her dimension. Oil was a real part in the preparation of ancient athletes to a contest, but it may be a symbol of the oil of confirmation. It may also indicate that Christians share in Christ's kingship and priesthood, as well as in his death and resurrection: see *Matth.* 26:12 and *Mark* 14:8. While the Egyptian is rolling in the dust (see the snake and the malediction in *Gen.* 3:14) a man of marvellous stature appears: Christ, the judge of the contest. The two athletes fight; after knocking her enemy down and stepping on his head (another biblical reference), Perpetua wins.

What is important here is not the clothing, but the transformation of the body under it. Martyrial dimension is a very physical one. In this same vision, Perpetua seems to be made male only as far as her fight is concerned: at the moment of her victory, the *lanista* calls her 'daughter'. The description of her death shows a female attitude: she tries to put up her hairs and to cover her lacerated body with her clothes. But here she is described by a man (the unknown writer).[12]

Let us consider the peculiar case of Thekla, the martyr who does not die, and who is also the founder of female monasticism, according to the *Apocryphal Acts of Paul and Thekla*.[13] She is a young and noble girl from Iconium when Paul arrives there. From the window of her house she hears the Apostle preaching the ideals of ἐγκράτεια and virginity. She spends three days and three nights at the window, without leaving it. She does not speak to her mother

[9] *Passio sanctarum Perpetuae et Felicitatis* 10 (116-9 Musurillo).

[10] The Latin text sounds: *Et expoliata sum et facta sum masculus*. I do not agree with Musurillo's translation: 'My clothes were stripped off, and suddenly I was a man' (119 Musurillo). The two verbs are passive and *masculus* is not *vir*.

[11] See Francesca Di Marco, Undressed: The Naked Female Body as a Sign of Holiness in Apocryphal and Hagiographical Literature: *SP* 44 (2010) 499-508.

[12] See *Passio Perpetuae et Felicitatis* 20 (128-29 Musurillo).

[13] For the Greek text, see *Acta Apostolorum Apocrypha*, edd. Richard Adelbert Lipsius and Max Bonnet (Hildesheim, 1959²), I 235-72. For the recent bibliography, see F. Di Marco, Undressed (see n. 11).

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and to her fiancé; she rejects her usual life. When Paul is imprisoned, at night she runs away from home.

'At night Thekla gave to the gate keeper the armlets she had taken off. The door was opened for her and she went to the prison. She gave her silver mirror to the guard and she entered reaching Paul. She set at his feet and heard words about the greatness of God'.[14]

Then she is sentenced to death, but God saves her. So she leaves Iconium in order to join Paul, who is far away. Once with him, she tells him that she is going to have her hair cut and is ready to follow him anywhere (ch. 25). According to 1*Cor.* 11:15 long hair is woman's glory. We face here another sign of Thekla's anomalous will: she renounces her femininity, she will not have a house of her own, but she will live with the Apostle.

Paul does not agree with her; times are bad and Thekla is beautiful. He fears: she is going to undergo trial again and she shall not be able to face it, behaving as a coward man (the significant verb is δειλανδρέω).

After a series of adventures, Thekla faces wild beasts; she baptizes herself when she thinks she runs the risk of dying and she is able to survive a lot of trials. Eventually (ch. 40): 'Thekla missed Paul and she was looking for him, sending messengers everywhere. Finally she came to know that he was in Myros'. Preparing herself for the journey, she converted her clothes girding them up, sewing together underdress and overdress according to the male fashion and then she went to Paul. She joined him and after a long account of her adventures, she revealed her intentions to go back home. And Paul answered: 'Go and teach God's word'.

Here, Thekla seems to dress herself as a man in order to travel, according to a τόπος of Hellenistic novels. In antiquity the best and most widespread praise for a woman was: 'She stayed at home, she span the wool' (*domi mansit, lanam fecit*). The ideal female character lived in a private dimension and it was excluded from a large part of public life. For instance travel as well as war and adventure belonged to men. Therefore, in the Hellenistic novel, the heroine often dresses like a man, in order to search for her lost sweetheart. Only male clothes will save her from the dangers of travelling, from bandits and from those who could attempt at her virtue. After meeting again her fiancé or her husband, the heroine gives up male clothes and lives just like all the other women. In these narrative patterns we find a clear example of disguise, which is aimed at a specific goal: male clothes enable a woman to face every kind of difficulties when she is out of her domestic world, on the road. Male clothes are also able to hide female beauty, which must be revealed only to the beloved man.[15]

[14] See *Acta Pauli et Theklae* 18, with a reference to Mary, Martha's sister (*Luke* 10:39).

[15] See E. Giannarelli, Viaggi di rottura e di confine: Tecla di Seleucia, in: Dinora Corsi (ed.), *Altrove: Viaggi di donne dall'antichità al Novecento* (Roma, 1999), 223-40; *Ead.*, Il pellegrinaggio al femminile nel cristianesimo antico: fra polemica ed esemplarità, in: Maria Luisa Silvestre

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Is Thekla comparable to a heroine of the Hellenistic novel? According to the *Apocryphal Acts* she transforms her clothes after renouncing her female dimension, after acting as a man. And these clothes, at the end of all the hardships and trials, give her the authority and the function of an apostle. By the way, as we read in the *Acta Philippi* 6, ἐπενδύτης is, so to say, the 'uniform' of the apostles. And Thekla uses it.

As we just said, human perfection was a male perfection in classical thought. Woman (γυνή) was marked by her natural, physical and spiritual weakness (ἀσθένεια) while man (ἀνήρ) by virtue and strenght (ἀνδρεία). The Latins connected *mulier* (woman) to *mollities* (weakness, again), while the substanctive *vir* (man) was connected to *virtus* (virtue) and *vis* (strength), of course.[16] For his part, Philo from Alexandria, the Jewish-hellenistic exegete, wrote that man is νοῦς, mind, rationality, and woman is αἴσθησις, sensation.[17]

The Stoics elaborated their theory of 'virile woman', γυνὴ ἀνδρεία or *mulier virilis*: the woman had to become man, just like a child had to become as wise as an old man (*puer senex*). It's the transformation of the so called *infirmi* into their opposite. According to Seneca, Musonius Rufus and many other thinkers, philosophy was necessary to the female human being in order to acquire strength and ataraxy, not to fall into tears and sorrow, to keep away from what was usually defined as γυναικεῖον and δυσγενές typical of women and blameworthy, or *muliebre and puerile*, typical of women and childish. Only the true sage was able to win the struggles of life and the true sage was a man. Clement of Alexandria christianized Musonius' doctrine concerning the equality of sexes, but stressed their different roles in generation.[18] Clement is important in the so called asexual God-likeness and symbolic God-likeness, as Kari E. Boerresen wrote.[19]

So the link between women and philosophy is the central point. With the Cappadocian Fathers, the term 'philosophy' finds a new meaning: Christian faith and asceticism.[20] In the *Life of Macrina* by Gregory of Nyssa,[21] the first biographical writing with a female protagonist, the girl left the secular dimension

e Adriana Valerio (eds.), *Donne in viaggio. Viaggio religioso, politico, metaforico* (Roma e Bari, 1999), 50-63.

[16] See a fragment of Varro saved by Lact., *De Opif. Dei* 12.17 (CSEL 27, 46 Samuel Brandt).

[17] See Richard Arthur Baer, *Philo's use of the categories Male and Female* (Leiden, 1970), 38-41.

[18] See E. Giannarelli, *La tipologia* (1980), 13-25; Umberto Mattioli, *'Ασθένεια e ἀνδρεία. Aspetti della femminilità nella letteratura classica, biblica e cristiana* (Roma, 1983); Kari Vogt, 'Becoming male': a gnostic and early Christian metaphor, in: Kari Elisabeth Boerresen (ed.), *Image of God and gender models in Judaeo-Christian tradition* (Oslo, 1991), 172-87.

[19] See K.E. Boerresen, *God's image, man's image? Patristic interpretation of Gen 1:27 and 1Cor 11:7*, in: *Image of God* (1991), 188-207.

[20] See Anne-Marie Malingrey, *'Philosophia'. Étude d'un groupe de mots dans la littérature grecque, des Présocratiques au IVe siècle aprés J.-C.* (Paris, 1961), 223-35.

[21] See Grégoire de Nysse, *Vie de Sainte Macrine*, ed. Pierre Maraval, SC 178 (Paris, 1971).

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(βίος κοσμικός) and decided to turn to monastic life, the life in the philosophical dimension (βίος φιλόσοφος). Her progress towards holiness was marked by the death of many relatives of hers, a sequence of sorrows she faced like an undefeated athlete, according to Paul. She was able to let reason (λογισμός) prevail against passion (πάθος), she turned to rationality (ch. 10), she became an *exemplum* of patience and fortitude (the Greek word is ἀνδρεία, of course). She became even the spiritually mother of her own mother, διδάσκαλος for her brothers; she was also compared with a male model of patience as great as the biblical Job (ch. 18). She reached the third and final step of the way to perfection, βίος ἀγγελικός, the way of living typical of angels, completely detached from physical needs and desires (ch. 22).

According to Gregory both men and women must go beyond their physical limits in order to reach the angelic way of living. But his choice of writing about a woman needs to be justified. He writes: 'A woman was the object of our speech, if one may refer to her as to a woman: for I do not know if it is right to use that natural designation for one who went beyond nature' (ch. 1).

There is ambiguity in the Greek text: it is not possible to decide whether Macrina went beyond the nature of a woman or of a human being. Maybe she went beyond human limits, sexual distinctions included. This important passage demonstrates Gregory's bewilderment in writing a biography of a woman, that's to say in presenting her as a model. The terms 'nature' and 'woman' offer clues to the interpretation of this passage in which logical construction is deeply influenced by Stoic philosophy.

In the Greek *Life of Melania the Younger*,[22] written at the beginning of the fifth century, the unknown writer describes his protagonist as a γυνὴ ἀνδρεία; he calls her actions ἀνδραγαθήματα,[23] and when she went to the mountains of Nitria 'the very blessed Fathers there welcomed the blessed woman as if she were a man. In fact she went beyond the measure of her sex, and she acquired a male mindedness, or better a heavenly mindedness' (ch. 39).

Here the ascending climax composed by γυναικεῖον μέτρον, φρόνημα ἀνδρεῖον, φρόνημα οὐράνιον has a strictly female perspective; we must notice that the substantive μέτρον 'measure' is defined by the adjective γυναικεῖον, while φρόνημα is used to indicate both a male and a heavenly dimension. Her again the woman must leave her natural negative condition in order to acquire male positive value; then she may reach a dimension beyond human limits.

In *Ep.* XXIX Paulinus of Nola inserts a biographical *excursus* about Melania *senior*, as a literary replay to the *Life of Saint Martin*, written by Sulpicius Severus, to whom that letter was addressed. And Melania may be compared

[22] See *Vie de Sainte Mélanie*, ed. Denys Gorce, SC 90 (Paris, 1962).
[23] See *ibid.*, in the prologue (SC 90, 126).

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with the bishop, monk, thaumaturge of Tours only because she appears *tam viriliter christiana*.[24]

Christian Stoicism may explain this attitude of male Christian writers; I suppose that the exegesis to *Gal.* 3:28 had a large place in it. But once again it is necessary to stress that Christ is the archetype of every perfection and that the followers of Christ must be imitators of him, women included. According to *Eph.* 4:13 'mature manhood' sounds ἀνὴρ τέλειος in Greek. Clothes seem to follow this ideological evolution or involution.

In *Deut.* 22:5 we read: 'No woman may wear an article of man's clothing nor may a man put on woman's dress. For those who do these things are abominable to the Lord your God.' In the Old Testament the cross-dressing is considered as a kind of corruption of truth and reality. No doubt Judith is a virile woman, but she 'arrayed herself in her gayest clothes' when she decided to kill Holophernes.

The distinction between public and private sphere is operating also in Christian thought with regard to women. They transformed their houses into monasteries, they lived in an all female world, so that it was even difficult for them to find a biographer. Inside this closed world women were spiritually free: outside, their female nature obliged them to submission. Their spiritual transformation could be publicly revealed by wearing men's clothes.

Evelyne Patlagean, in her *L'histoire de la femme déguisée en moine* uses the substantive *deguisement*, disguise;[25] John Anson, in his *The female transvestite in Early Monasticism*, writes about transvestism.[26] In my opinion, when a woman wears male clothes or is introduced in male clothes by a writer after a long physical and spiritual training in order to acquire ἀνδρεία, this is not a disguise, as the woman does not pretend to appear what she is not, but it is the way to demonstrate her inner transformation. Spiritual identity is completely detached from the body, gender and sex included, according to *Gal.* 3:28. Clothes indicate a spiritual dimension, they do not dress a body. So the woman dressed in a male fashion belongs to the well known typology of Christian paradox.

Concerning clothes, the Gospel according to *Matth.* 6:28-30 invites the believers not to care about them, following the example of the lilies in the field. Clothes are part of the human and secular dimension, over which spiritual values must prevail. Gender and sex belong to human and secular dimension: spiritual values supersede also these distinctions.

In the ascetic and monastic world the Christian use of paradox reaches its climax. In biographies, in legends, in hagiographical writings, many anomalous

[24] See Paulinus of Nola., *Ep.* XXIX 6.

[25] See Evelyne Patlagean, L'histoire de la femme déguisée en moine et l'évolution de la sainteté feminine à Byzance: *Studi Medievali* 17 (1976) 597-623.

[26] John Anson, The female transvestite in Early Monasticism: the origin and development of a motiv: *Viator* 5 (1974) 1-32.

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episodes may be explained as an exegesis to some biblical verses, an exegesis in a narrative form.

In *Matth.* 19:12 it is written: 'Some are eunuchs because they were born so, or were made so by men, there are others who made themselves eunuchs for the kingdom of heaven. Let those understand who can'. Matthew presents this words in a male perspective, but they could be read also in a female perspective. And the story of Euphrosyne is an example.[27] She is a girl who dresses as a man, takes the identity of the eunuch Smaragdo and lives in a male monastery with the complicity of the abba. Her natural identity is discovered only after her death.

Another exemplum is the *Life of Eugenia*, written in the fifth century.[28] Eugenia is a noble girl who had studied philosophy. She read the book of Paul and Thekla, and she decided to leave everything for Christ. As the bishop did not admit women in his community, she dressed as a man and presented herself as Eugenius. The bishop looked at her and told her: 'You call yourself Eugenius; you are right, for you are acting like a man (*viriliter agis*)'.[29]

And the list may go on with the famous and complicated *Legend of Pelagia-Margarito*,[30] the charming dancer able to corrupt many young men, before being converted. She dressed like a man, taking the identity of eunuch Pelagius and giving herself to a strict asceticism. Beauty and femininity, instruments of sin, were completely destroyed, and only *post mortem* the real nature of the protagonist appeared again.

The necessity for a woman of changing her natural identity, turning into her opposite, is presented by ancient texts as something women themselves were self-conscious of. *Apophthegmata Patrum* – and *Matrum* – give us significant examples: here are two *Apophthegmata* by amma Sarra.

'One day two famous hermits from the country near Pelusion came to visit amma Sarra. During the journey one hermit said to the other: "Let us humiliate this old woman". At their arrival, they said to her: "You must not grow proud thinking: Here are two hermits who have come to visit me, a woman". Amma Sarra answered: "According to my nature I am a woman, but not according to my thought"'.[31]

[27] See BHG 625-6; BHO 288-91; BHL 2722-6; Francesca Rizzo Nervo, Dalle donne travestite al travestimento delle donne: Per una tipologia fra agiografia e letteratura, in: Anna Maria Babbi, Antonio Pioletti, Francesca Rizzo Nervo, and Cristina Stevanoni (eds.), *Medioevo romanzo e orientale. Testi e prospettive storiografiche* (Soveria Mannelli, 1992), 71-90.

[28] See BHL 2666-70; BHG 607-8; BHO 281-4. Latin text in PL 73, 605-20.

[29] See PL 73, 610A. Hippolyte Delehaye, *Étude sur le légendier romain* (Bruxelles, 1936), 171-86.

[30] See Franca Ela Consolino, Usener e l'agiografia: Legenden der Pelagia e Der heilige Tychon, in: Graziano Arrighetti *et alii* (eds.), *Aspetti di Hermann Usener filologo della religione*, Seminario della Scuola Normale Superiore di Pisa, 17-20 febbraio 1982 (Pisa, 1983), 161-80.

[31] See *Apophthegmata Patrum*, Sarra 4 of the Alphabetic Series (PG 65, 420).

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Even more clearly, one day amma Sarra said to her brothers in faith: 'As for me, I am the true man, and as for you, you are women'. The *imitatrix Christi* appears self-conscious of having reached a Christomorfic virility.[32] It would be interesting to go deeper into the Christomorfic state that is overcoming both, the status of being a woman, but also of being a man, and obviously to go beyond the gender boundary. Gregory of Nyssa and his *Περὶ παρθενίας* could be useful in this perspective.

It is impossible to forget what happened to Hypatia of Alexandria, who used to wear the cloak of the philosopher and to teach male disciples.[33] When she was captured, first that cloak was ripped, than her body was torn apart and destroyed by fire. No doubt she symbolizes the contrast, or better, the contradiction between mental activity and female body.[34] She went over her physical dimension thanks to her wisdom and to her education; her murderers called her back to her physical nature: they ripped her cloak which had made her a philosopher, which gave her unusual visibility and authority, placing her out of the role traditionally reserved to women.

In conclusion: in Italy a widespread proverb sounds: 'L'abito non fa il monaco'. I do not know if in English speaking countries something like this exists: 'It is not the cowl that makes the monk', or 'the cowl does not make the monk'. According to ancient texts, in the ancient world the cowl makes the monk and the nun. It does not relate to a body, but it portraits an ideal.

[32] See Coisl. 126 fol. 149^{v} in: Jean-Claude Guy, *Recherches sur la tradition grecque des Apophthegmata Patrum*, Subsidia Hagiographica 36 (Bruxelles, 1984^{2}), 34. See also E. Giannarelli, Gli 'Apophthegmata Patrum et Matrum': fra sentenziosità, esegesi e 'humour apparente', in: Maria Serena Funghi (ed.), *Aspetti di letteratura gnomica nel mondo tardo-antico II*, (Firenze, 2004), 133-56.

[33] See Gemma Beretta, *Ipazia di Alessandria* (Roma, 1993); K. Vogt, *The Hierophant of Philosophy – Hypatia of Alexandria*, in: K.E. Boerresen and K. Vogt (eds.), *Women's Studies of the Christian and Islamic Traditions: Ancient, Medieval and Renaissance Foremothers* (Oslo, 1993), 110-30.

[34] See *supra* note 17 concerning Philo of Alexandria.

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Philosophia and Christian Culture: An Antidote for Female Weakness in Jerome's Letters

Valeria NOVEMBRI, Siena

1. The classical and the Biblical inheritance

Mulier sancta atque venerabilis[1] or *ancilla diaboli*?[2] As anyone of his readers knows, Jerome's opinion on women is truly dualistic, and with no doubt the implacable Christian polemist inherited this double evaluation from the two-sided judgement on women elaborated in the classical world, but he substantiated it, holding it up with a variety of assessments firmly rooted in the Christian thought since its very beginning, through the influence of the Jewish culture. In the Old Testament such text as *Ecclesiastes*,[3] *Sirach*,[4] or *Proverbia*,[5] for instance, expressed a definitely negative evaluation of woman, but it coexisted with as many commendations of positive female models even in the same books.[6] And in the New Testament, the *Corpus Paulinum* in particular reflects a similar situation.[7] Jerome's dualistic thought then was perfectly in line with

[1] *Ep.* 47.2. Jerome uses this definition referring to Desiderium's wife, Serenilla. He calls her *soror*, because the couple was observing continence, living their marriage in chastity: Jerome says that the 'holy and revered woman', true to her name, 'has trodden down the troubled waves of the world, and has passed to Christ's calm haven'. Latin quotations of Jerome's letters are taken from Les Belles Lettres critical edition by Jerome Labourt, in eight volumes. English translations are mine.

[2] *Ep.* 39.3. Jerome is writing to Paula after Blesilla's death and says that pagan women are capable of bearing grief better than her: in other words, a 'servant of the devil' is better than his own.

[3] See, for instance, *Eccl.* 7:26: *Et inveni amariorem morte mulierem quae laqueus venatorum est et sagena cor eius vincula sunt manus illius qui placet Deo effugiet eam qui autem peccator est capietur ab illa.*

[4] *Sir.* 9:3: *Ne respicias mulierem multivolam ne forte incidas in laqueos illius;* and 9:9-10: *Propter speciem mulieris multi perierunt et ex hoc concupiscentia quasi ignis exardescit. Omnis mulier quae est fornicaria quasi stercus in via conculcatur.*

[5] *Prov.* 21:19: *Melius est habitare in terra deserta quam cum muliere rixosa et iracunda*, and 25:24: *Melius est sedere in angulo domatis quam cum muliere litigiosa et in domo communi.*

[6] See for instance *Prov.* 8:22: *Qui invenit mulierem invenit bonum et hauriet iucunditatem a Domino*, and the famous chapter 31:10-31 in prise of the γυνὴ ἀνδρεία. Of course, positive and negative evaluations are there intended from a masculine point of view, in reference to an ideal model that was a barely male – or rather patriarchal – construction.

[7] On Paul's, and deutero-Pauline letters' attitude towards women, see Craig S. Keener, *Paul, Women, and Wives: Marriage and Women's Ministry in the Letters of Paul* (Peabody, MA 1992);

Studia Patristica XLIV, 471-485.
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both these traditions: the classical and the Biblical one. As in his writings we notice a constant mingling of elements taken both from the pagan philosophers and from the Holy Scriptures, even on this matter he relies on the two different sources, both in praise and in blame of female beings.[8]

To express the double perspective on women Jerome often uses the long-established Christian contrast between the two opposite figures of Eve, cause of death and perdition, and Mary, donor of a new life: *Mors per Evam, vita per Mariam*, he writes to Eustochium.[9] As an indefatigable translator and commentator of the Holy Scripture, Jerome couldn't forget Paul's assertions on women: he knows that 'it wasn't Adam to be deceived, but the woman was deceived and became a transgressor' (*1Tim.* 2:14), even if he never quotes this verse. He rather sums up this assessment, saying that women are 'more inclined to fall'.[10] But as a learned man trained in the school of the classical literature, Jerome couldn't totally cut out neither his former cultural background: Paul Antin[11] spoke of 'double loyalisme' for Jerome's attitude towards the pagan classic literature from one side, and towards the Bible and the Christian tradition from the other.[12] Actually it is well known, after Lübeck's, Hagendahl's

Margaret MacDonald, Reading Real Women through the Letters of Paul, in: Ross Shepard Kraemer, Mary Rose D'Angelo (eds.), *Women and Christian Origins* (Oxford and New York, 1999), 199-218; Elizabeth Anne Castelli, Paul on Women and Gender, in: *ibid.* 221-33; Margaret MacDonald, Rereading Paul: Early Interpreters of Paul on Women and Gender, in: *ibid.* 236-53.

[8] The relationship, both intellectual and spiritual, between Jerome and women has been the topic of several studies, among which we should mention at least Marie Turcan, S. Jérôme et les femmes: *BAGB* 61 (1968) 259-72; María del Mar Marcos Sánchez, Caracterización del sexo femenino en la Correspondencia de San Jerónimo, in: *Actas del VII Congreso Español de Estudios Clásicos*, vol. 3 (Madrid, 1989), 211-6, and *ead.*, *Mulier sancta et venerabilis, mulier ancilla diaboli* en la Correspondencia de San Jerónimo: *SHHA* 4-5 (1986-7) 235-44; Barbara Feichtinger, *Apostolae apostolorum: Frauenaskese als Befreiung und Zwang bei Hieronymus* (Frankfurt am Main, 1995). As for the social structure of Jerome's female circle in Rom, see the studies of Silvia Jannacone, Roma, 348: Struttura sociale e spirituale del gruppo geronimiano: *GIF* 19 (1966) 32-48; Stefan Rebenich, *Hieronymus und sein Kreis: Prosopographische und sozialgeschichtliche Untersuchungen* (Stuttgart, 1992), and Christa Krumeich, *Hieronymus und die christlichen feminae clarissimae* (Bonn, 1993).

[9] *Ep.* 22.21. As for the fortune of the opposition Eva-Maria in Early Christianity, see Hugo Koch, *Virgo Eva, Virgo Maria: Neue Untersuchungen über die Lehre von der Jungfrauschaft und der Ehe Mariens in der ältesten Kirche* (Berlin, 1937); Giulia Sfameni Gasparro, La donna nell'esegesi patristica di *Gen* 1-3, in: Umberto Mattioli (ed.), *La donna nel pensiero cristiano antico* (Genova, 1992), 17-50; and Elena Giannarelli, *La tipologia femminile nella biografia e nella autobiografia cristiana del IV secolo* (Roma, 1980), 9-19.

[10] *Comm. in Eccl.* 7.28 (CChr.SL 72, 312): *In hac ruina generis humani, facilior ad casum est mulier.*

[11] Paul Antin, *Recueil sur Saint Jérôme* (Bruxelles, 1968), 48.

[12] For Jerome's 'wondrous ardor for learning', as he defines it (*Ep.* 84.2), see Georg Grützmacher, *Hieronymus: Eine biographische Studie zur alten Kirchengeschichte* (Leipzig and Berlin, 1901-8), I 113-36. As to the ideal of Christian learning in Jerome, it may be interesting to consider the words he writes to Leta, about the education of his little daughter Paula, in his pedagogical *Epistle* 107: there he explicitly contrasts episodes and facts of the pagan history to the Christian

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and Courcelle's studies,[13] that Jerome uses all the instruments of language, the rhetoric devices and the cultural and philosophical grounds and references that could support his purposes and provide a coat of literary elegance to his writings: classical quotations and allusions are present, in different amounts, in all his works, of any literary gender, according to the topic of the works, to the tastes of his addressees and to the general context. Jerome is able to show his polite style and his ability in writing to a cultivated audience, dotting his pages with quotations and allusions to the pagan poets and the classics, but he is also able to hold them back or veil them while speaking towards a public of uncultivated monks. In his letters to the cultured Marcella, he does not hesitate to recommend the reading of Demosthenes and Cicero, 'if eloquence is what we are looking for' (*Ep.* 29.1). And it is perfectly reasonable that in the famous *letter* 22 to Eustochium, in which he would like to point out the incompatibility of pagan literature with Christian way of life, strongly opposing the classics to the Holy Scriptures, we can't find any single line of pagan authors literally quoted: classical reminiscences, deeply rooted in the mind of a man who 'at heart was and remained a rhetor', are just evoked in a disguised form.[14] Even in his exegetical writings we can find quotations, references and exempla taken from the pagan world,[15] and it occurs in women's evaluation too. Furthermore, as for his caustic attitude towards women, Jerome appears as Juvenal's most direct heir: no one, with the exception of Tertullian maybe, had depicted such pitiless female portraits as Jerome did.[16]

Mulier a mollitie: this para-etymology, that connects the female sex with everything that is feeble, frail, powerless, both in a physical and in a psychological

matters. Eventually he even offers to take care of the little children in Bethlehem, if only her mother let her go there, and imagines how he could instruct her, teaching her not about 'a Macedonian king killed by the Babylonian poison, but about a servant and a wife of Christ' (107.13). On Jerome's pedagogical ideals and methods, see Christian Favez, *Saint Jérôme pédagogue*, in: *Mélanges de philologie, de littérature et d'histoire anciennes offerts à J. Marouzeau par ses collegues et élevés étrangers* (Paris, 1948), 173-81, and Vincenza Milazzo, *L'educazione di una vergine: Precetti e modelli in Ambrogio e Girolamo* (Catania, 2002).

[13] Aemilius Lübeck, *Hieronymus quos nouerit scriptores et ex quibus hauserit* (Lipsiae, 1872); Harald Hagendahl, *Latin Fathers and the Classics: A Study on the Apologists, Jerome and other Christian writers* (Göteborg, 1958); Pierre Courcelle, *Lettres Grecques en Occident* (Paris, 1943), 37-115. We may add the interesting enquiry by Rudolf Eiswirth, *Hieronymus' Stellung zur Literatur und Kunst* (Wiesbaden, 1955), which accurately draws a complete description of Jerome's learning.

[14] See Harald Hagendal, *Latin Fathers and the classics* (Göteborg, 1958), 110: 'In the letter to Eustochium no pagan author is mentioned, not a single line quoted... on the other hand there are not a few reminiscences of a less conspicuous nature'. Arthur Stanley Pease, Jerome and Pagan Literature: *TAPA* 50 (1919) 157 tried to demonstrate that after the famous dream about the heaven tribunal accusing him of being a *Ciceronianus*, the frequency of citations from classical literature fades extremely away.

[15] H. Hagendal, *Latin Fathers* (1958), 115-41, 209-46.

[16] See H. Hagendal, *Latin Fathers* (1958), ch. 4: *Women and marriage*, about Jerome's satiric attitude towards women.

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context, was a customary assessment in the Roman world,[17] stated even by law[18] and Jerome seems not to disdain it. In his writings, weakness is regarded as a distinctive feature of the female sex: women are often connected with *imbecillitas*. The *imbecillitas feminea* or *imbecillitas muliebris* (120.5) is a particular and more precarious condition of the general *imbecillitas humana*: to the human infirmity, women have to add the one typical of their sex, and they have to overcome this one at first, in order to reach an equal position with men.[19]

The other attribute constantly used by Jerome to characterize women is *fragilitas*.[20] The *fragilior sexus* (65.1) is strongly contrasted to the *robustior sexus*, on the basis of the opposite para-etymology, according to which *vir* was connected with *vis*, *virtus* and *vigor*.[21] When the brilliant satirist has to praise a woman, he says she is *oblita sexus* and *fragilitatis immemor*, that is to say she forgave her sex and overlooked her weakness, like Fabiola,[22] who consecrated herself to the ascetic life and sought for loneliness, or like Paula,[23] who craved for living with her young companions among the Egyptian monks.

[17] As Lactantius says, this para-etymology came from Varro: *item mulier, ut Varro interpretatur, a mollitie, inmutata et detracta littera, velut mollier* (*De op. Dei* 12.17). The idea of female inferiority was common to all the ancient world: theorized by Aristotle and endorsed by Philo (according to whom men represented the νοῦς, the rational power, and women the sensation, the αἴσθησις), it was well accepted also by Christian authors. But among the Greek philosophers a new perspective, of natural 'equality' as for virtues and intellectual capabilities, began to rise: from Antisthenes to the Stoicism, passing through Diogenes, Musonius Rufus and Seneca, afterwards it flourished also among Christian authors. With E. Giannarelli, *La tipologia* (1980) we could call this view a re-evaluation one. As for the conditions of women in the classical and the Christian world, see, among the many others, Sarah B. Pomeroy, *Goddesses, Whores, Wives, and Slaves: Women in Classical Antiquity* (New York, 1975); Eva Cantarella, *L'ambiguo malanno: Condizione e immagine della donna nell'antichità greca e romana* (Roma, 1981); Umberto Mattioli, *Asthéneia e andreía: Aspetti della femminilità nella letteratura classica, biblica e cristiana* (Roma, 1983) and Georges Duby, Michelle Perot, and Pauline Schmitt Pantel (eds.), *History of Women in the West: From Ancient Goddesses to Christian Saints* (Cambridge, MA, 1994).

[18] We can find several legal references to womanly weakness in Roman laws: Cicero (*Pro Murena* 12.27) remarks 'it was a juridical statement well established in his ancestors' – *maiores* – times. See Joelle Beaucamp, Le vocabulaire de la faiblesse feminine dans les textes juridiques romains du IIIe au VIe siècle: *RHDFE* 54 (1978) 485-508; *ead.*, *Le statut de la femme à Byzance (4e-7e siècle). I. Le droit impérial* (Paris, 1990); Susan Dixon, *Infirmitas sexus*: Womaly Weakness in Roman Law: *Tijdschrift voor Rechtsgeschiedenis* 54 (1984) 343-71; Antti Arjava, *Women and law in Late Antiquity* (Oxford, 1996); Judith Evans Grubbs, *Women and the Law in the Roman Empire* (London and New York, 2002), 51-60.

[19] See E. Giannarelli, *La tipologia* (1980), 13-25 and *passim*.

[20] It is this a common opinion, well attested all along human history and the literary production: it's enough to quote here Hamlet's words: 'Frailty, thy name is woman!' (Shakespeare, *Hamlet*, act I, scene II).

[21] This para-etymology too is attested by Lactantius, *De op. Dei* 12.16 (SC 213, 183), who presents it as a quotation from Varro.

[22] *Ep.* 77.9: *Oblita sexus, fragilitatis inmemor, ac solitudinis tantum cupida, ibi erat, ubi animo morabitur.*

[23] *Ep.* 108.14: *Mirus ardor, et vix in femina credibilis fortitudo! Oblita sexus et fragilitatis corporeae, inter tot milia monachorum cum puellis suis habitare cupiebat.*

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And in fact, Jerome shares the classical opinion according to which women were unreliable, inconstant, always changeable in their minds: *[Feminarum] mutabilis fluctuansque sententia, si suo arbitrio relinquantur*, he says,[24] quoting and varying Hermes' words in *Aeneid* 4.569, where the god warns Aeneas *that varium et mutabile semper femina*, a sentence that in our ears cannot recall but the famous aria sung by the Duke of Mantua in Verdi's Rigoletto: 'La donna è mobile qual piuma al vento' ('woman is fickle'). And in another passage, Jerome literally quotes the same Virgil's sentence to underline the extreme changeableness of female thoughts and attitude: we read it in his *Commentary on Ecclesiastes*, chapter 7.[25]

It is a matter of evidence that the passionate Bible commentator could use the same negative evaluation of women also as an interpretative category in his exegetical works, in contexts that were already deeply influenced by the Jewish 'antifeminism'. In a passage taken from the *Commentarium in Isaiam* warning to escape any occasion for arrogance, we read that people who will exhibit their own success, then will enervate all their virtues and 'loosing their male strength, will be led in female weakness'.[26]

The same idea is present also in the *Commentarium in Amos*:[27] Jerome is speaking of the passions, of the powers of evil, as he interprets the horses of the prophet, then he says that these bad powers cannot prevail over a *virilis animus*, that is a manly strong soul, fortified by God's might, but when they find an effeminate mind, weakened by perfumes and pleasures, and turned to female weakness (*in muliebrem versam mollitiem*), then they can't stop up, are driven insane and act as they want.

Also in the *Commentarium in Naum*[28] we find this contrast between the *imbecillitas mulierum* and the souls who on the contrary are strong, vigorous, manly powerful. Jerome says that the inhabitants of Ninive are so enervates by

[24] *Ep.* 130.17. The whole text sounds: *Solet inter plerosque esse certamen, utrum solitaria, an cum multis vita sit melior: quarum prior praefertur quidem secundae; sed si quidem in viris periculosa est, ne abstracti ab hominum frequentia, sordidis et impiis cogitationibus pateant, et pleni adrogantiae ac supercilii, cunctos despiciant, armentque linguas suas, vel clericis vel aliis monachis detrahendo ... quanto magis in feminis, quarum mutabilis fluctuansque sententia, si suo arbitrio relinquatur, cito ad deteriora delabitur!*

[25] *Comm. in Eccl.* 7.28 (CChr.SL 72, 312): *In hac ruina generis humani, facilior ad casum est mulier. De qua et poeta gentilis:... varium et mutabile semper femina.*

[26] *Comm. in Esaiam* XI 39.3/8 (CChr.SL 73, 453): *Amisso virili robore, in muliebrem redigitur mollitudinem.*

[27] *Comm. in Amos* III 6.12/15 (CChr.SL 76, 311): *Isti equi, id est contrariae fortitudines, qui insaniunt ad feminas, quando virilem viderint animum, et Dei fortitudine roboratum, non audent accedere. Quando vero effeminatam mentem, et unguentis et deliciis enervatam, et in muliebrem versam mollitiem, statim insaniunt, et se tenere non possunt, et gestiunt ad libidinem.*

[28] *Comm. in Naum* 3.13/17 (CChr.SL 76 A, 568): *Populus tuus, o Niniue, homines uidelicet saeculares qui proprie populus uocatur urbis Assyriae, ita passionibus eneruati sunt et uitiis elanguerunt, ut imbecillitati mulierum comparentur; nihil enim in animabus suis forte, nihil robustum possident et uirile.*

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passions and so slackened in vices that it is possible to compare them to female weakness, because in their souls anything is strong, vigorous and virile yet. We find again the same words used in the previous passage. In addition, some lines forward Jerome says that Ninive, or rather, allegorically, the soul, beautiful by her own nature, charmed by the luxury and the pleasures of this world, had got in touch with the female delights, so, loosing his manly vigour, has enervated and changed into a female being.[29]

We have therefore the equivalences female = weak and male = strong, expressed with the same words in different works. But there is something more.

In his allegorical analysis of some passages of the Holy Scriptures, Jerome associates any reference to woman and the weaker sex also with the matter (*materia*), explaining that 'women are next to material things'.[30] In this assertion he seems to share Aristotle's conception of the natural difference between the two sexes, according to which women, weaker and inert, are identified with the matter, men being, on the contrary, form and act, owning the creative power.[31] As everyone knows, from this assessment on the female physical inferiority Aristotle based his theory on women's social and juridical subordination, a very successful model even beyond the boundaries of the ancient world. Jerome instead limits himself to say that 'women reveal the frailty of their gender by the weakness of their soul'.

2. Equality on a spiritual level

Exactly in reason of this weakness connatural to their body and their soul, women need some more effort to reach the condition of virtue and perfect sanctity, as requested to every human creature by God. Jerome in fact can't forget some fundamental assertions, taken nevertheless from the Holy Scriptures, which mitigate the negative view of women seen till now: in the same *Commentarium in Isaiam*, for instance, that even contains the misogynistic accents we have observed, Jerome has to defend himself against his detractors, who criticize his predilection for a female audience, and recalls the presence of female prophets in the Bible, as Deborah, Huldah and Hanna, overlooked by his enemies. Then he concludes that 'in the service of Christ differences of sex

[29] *Comm. in Naum* 3.13/17 (CChr.SL 76 A, 569): *Quis non dicat speciosam Niniuen, animam natura pulchram luxuria et uoluptatibus huius saeculi delinitam, in muliebres delicias peruenisse, et uirilitate perdita, elanguisse in feminam?*

[30] *Comm. in Eccl.* 2.8 (CChr.SL 72, 266): *Ubicumque ergo in Scripturis femina legitur et sexus fragilior, ad materiae intellegentiam transferamus, unde et Pharao non uult masculos uiuificari, sed tantum feminas, quae materiae sunt uicinae.*

[31] See Aristotle, *De generatione animalium* 728a 17ff.

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are not worth, but of mind'.[32] In this very work the same opinion is confirmed at least two other times: the first asserting that 'among proselytes there is no difference, but men and women are equally called to salvation',[33] and the second stating that as for the spiritual gifts there is no difference between the two sexes. Behind all of these passages there is the presence of Paul, and exactly of his Letter to *Galatians* 3:28: 'there is no more man nor woman in Christ Jesus', directly quoted just in the third passage.[34]

Therefore we may conclude that, in spite of all the attacks against female weakness, Jerome is surely less misogynistic than he can appear from the references we have quoted till now: if we have a look to his whole work, we notice that a large number of writings is addressed to women, and this was not common indeed at his time. It is enough to think to the many justifications and excuses that he, and other Fathers like him had to produce in order to discharge from choosing as addressees, or even subjects of their literary works, worthless creatures like women. We can recall the words of Gregory of Nyssa, at the beginning of the *Life of Macrina*: The Cappadocian bishop felt the need of explaining the reason for writing the biography of a woman, being aware of doing something uncommon and new. He has to justify his own choice and it is for this reason that he writes: 'In this case it was a woman who provided us with our subject; if indeed she should be styled woman, for I do not know whether it is fitting to designate by her sex her, who so surpassed her sex'.[35] It is more or less the same feeling of Jerome, while addressing his letters and writings to women. We argue he was probably attacked for this reason by his adversaries: it's enough to read his attempts of defending himself against this criticism in some of his letters and in two of his biblical commentaries, the one on *Zephaniah* and the one on *Isaiah*. We have already seen this second one. The first one is even more interesting, because it presents the typical combination of Biblical and pagan elements, this time just in defence of the cultural role of women:

Before starting with Zephaniah, who is the ninth in the number of the twelve prophets, I have to reply to the ones who want to mock me, because, leaving men apart, I prefer to write to you, Paula and Eustochium. But if they only knew that Huldah made her prophecies, being men silent, and Deborah, as a judge and a prophet at the same time,

[32] *Comm. in Esaiam* XII, prol. (CChr.SL 73 A, 465-6): *Ac nonnullos fore arbitror qui hoc ipsum quod ad te, Eustochium, sermonem facio, obtrectationi patere contendant, non considerantes Holdam et Annam et Debboram, uiris tacentibus, prophetasse. Et in seruitute Christi nequaquam differentiam sexuum ualere, sed mentium.*

[33] *Comm. in Esaiam* XV 56.3 (CChr.SL 73 A, 632): *Et quomodo in proselytis non est ulla diuersitas, sed et uiri et feminae ad salutem pariter uocantur, sic et in eunuchis qui se castrauerunt propter regna caelorum, uterque sexus accipitur.*

[34] *Comm. in Esaiam* XV 56.6 (CChr.SL 73 A, 634): *Neque enim fieri potest, ut in spiritalibus donis sit sexus ulla diuersitas, cum in Christo Iesu non sit uir et mulier* [see *Gal.* 3:28].

[35] Greg. Nyss., *Vita Macr.* 1 (SC 178, 140.14-17). Some years later with almost the same words Paulinus of Nola introduced the portray of Melania in his *letter* 29.6 (CSEL 29, 555): *At quam tandem femina, si femina dici licet et tam viriliter christianam.*

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prevailed over the enemies of Israel, while Barach being full of fear; and if they knew that Judith and Esther, symbols of the Church, killed their enemies and discharged form danger Israel on the way of falling, they would never laugh at me behind my back. I do not mention Annah and Elisabeth, and the other holy women, whom the bright light of Maria obscures like the pale lights of the stars. I will pass to the pagan women, so that they can see even the pagan philosophers used to look at the differences of mind and not at the physical ones.[36]

Then he mentions Aspasia, Sappho, Themistia, Cornelia mother of the Gracchi, a Roman *matrona* who engaged Carneades in philosophical conversations, Cato's daughter, and concludes that 'both the Greek and the Roman history was full of female virtues'. Finally he adds the fact that even Jesus after death choose to appear to women first, appointing them 'apostles to the apostles', and causing men to be ashamed for their lack of interest.

A similar passionate apology of his own work is present also in some letters, the most famous of which is probably the one to Principia: Jerome openly mentions the disapproval he was exposed to for preferring women to men, and replies with a sharp attack against the stronger sex:

I'm fully aware, Principia, my daughter in Christ, of being censured by many people because, in addressing to women, I give my preference to the weaker sex rather than to men. And indeed I have to reply to my detractors at first, and then I will come to the little question you have posed to me. If only men longed for Scriptures, I had not to address to women.[37]

In spite of his harsh tone, Jerome is not speaking against women here: he does not consider them as an underling audience, he has to be content of, failing the masculine interest in matter of faith.[38] Simply, he has to justify all his own

[36] *Commentarium in Sophoniam, prol.* (CChr.SL 76 A, 655): *Antequam Sophoniam aggrediar, qui nonus est in ordine duodecim prophetarum, respondendum uidetur his qui me irridendum aestimant, quod omissis uiris, ad uos scribam potissimum, o Paula et Eustochium. Qui si scirent Oldam, uiris tacentibus, prophetasse, et Debboram iudicem pariter et propheten, hostes Israel, Barac timente, superasse; et Iudith et Esther, in typo ecclesiae, et occidisse aduersarios, et periturum Israel de periculo liberasse; numquam post tergum meum manum curuarent in ciconiam. Taceo de Anna et Elisabeth, et ceteris sanctis mulieribus, quarum uelut siderum igniculos, clarum Mariae lumen abscondit. Ad gentiles feminas ueniam, ut et apud saeculi philosophos uideant animorum differentias quaeri solere non corporum. [...] Plena est historia tam graeca quam latina uirtutibus feminarum, et quae integros libros flagitent. Mihi tantum, quia aliud operis incumbit, in fine prologi dixisse sufficiat, dominum resurgentem primum apparuisse mulieribus, et apostolorum illas fuisse apostolas, ut erubescerent uiri non quaerere, quem iam fragilior sexus inuenerat.*

[37] *Ep.* 65.1: *Scio me, Principia, in Christo filia, a plerisque reprehendi quod interdum scribam ad mulieres, et fragiliorem sexum maribus praeferam. Et idcirco debeo primum obtrectatoribus meis respondere, et sic venire ad disputatiunculam quam rogasti. Si viri de scripturis quaererent, mulieribus non loquerer.*

[38] See the appropriate remarks by Elena Giannarelli, Antiche lettrici della Bibbia: Dame, martiri e pellegrine, in: Claudio Leonardi, Francesco Santi, and Adriana Valerio (eds.), *La Bibbia nell'interpretazione delle donne. Atti del Convegno di studi* (Firenze, 2002), 23-5.

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efforts in spending his time with women and in teaching them as a spiritual father. For this reason he reminds the great female characters of the Old Testament in this letter too: looking at their examples, no woman has to be ashamed of her gender, nor men have to glorify themselves, because it is just in order to reproach them that in the Holy Scriptures women's life is exalted.

The polemic was long-lasting and deeply rooted in the Roman mentality: it is for this reason that Jerome has to insist in apologizing his own attitude. In another letter to Principia he turns back again to this topic, defining women as *mulierculae*, little worthless females in the eyes of his own adversaries:

> The pagan reader may perhaps laugh at me for dwelling so long on the praises of little worthless females; yet, if he remembers how holy women followed our Lord and Saviour and ministered to Him of their goods, and how the three Marys stood before the cross and above all how Mary Magdalen [...] was considered worth of seeing the rising Christ first of all, before the very apostles, he will convict himself of pride sooner than me of silliness, for I judge of people's virtue not by their sex but by their mind.[39]

The final sentence of this passage is the focal point of Jerome's thought and of his attitude towards women. These frail creatures may become saint as well as men and 'worthy of the highest glory', but their behaviour has to be irreproachable, they have to conform themselves to the perfect model of sanctity supported by Jerome: they have to devote themselves to the meditation and to the knowledge of the Holy Scriptures, they have to lead a sober life, made of privations and fasts, without any of those luxuries that the members of the Roman aristocracy loved so much – precious jewels, fashionable clothes, fine make up, and so on. Briefly: they had to embrace the ascetic life.[40] Of course, difficulties and problems people had to afford in following this choice, even though equal for all the human race, were harder to triumph over by the female side, just because of its weakness. According to the traditional opinion women were frivolous creatures, naturally inclined to luxury, devoted to their physical allure, too much concerned with their hairdo, their bodies, their clothes and the make

[39] *Ep.* 127, 5: *Rideat forsitan infidelis lector, me in mulierculorum laudibus inmorari, qui, si recordetur sanctas feminas, comites Domini Salvatoris, quae ministrabant ei de sua substantia, et tres Marias stantes ante crucem, Mariamque proprie "Magdalenen" quae ... prima ante apostolos Christum videre meruit resurgentem, se potius superbiae, quam nos condemnabit ineptiarum, qui virtutes non sexu, se animo iudicamus.*

[40] For the importance of asceticism and the virginal choice in Early Christianity, see the classic works of Elizabeth Ann Clark, *Women in the Early Church* (Collegeville, MN, 1983), ch. 3: *Paradise regained: asceticism in theory and practice*, 115-55; Virginia Burrus, *Chastity as Autonomy: Women in the Stories of the Apocryphal Acts* (Lewiston, 1987); Peter Brown, *The Body and Society: Men, Women, and Sexual Renunciation in Early Christianity* (New York, 1988); Susanna Elm, *Virgins of God: The Making of Asceticism in Late Antiquity*, (New York and Oxford, 1994), and Kate Cooper, *The Virgin and the Bride: Idealized Womanhood in Late Antiquity* (Cambridge, MA, 1996). For asceticism in Jerome see: Christine Steininger, *Die ideale christliche Frau: virgo – vidua – nupta: Eine Studie zum Bild der idealen christlichen Frau bei Hieronymus und Pelagius* (St. Ottilien, 1997) and Barbara Feichtinger, *Apostolae apostolorum* (1995).

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up, and unable to abstain from wine and refined foods. As we read in the first chapter of the *Commentary on Zephaniah*, Jerome defines the concern for elegance and beauty a true foolish obsession typical of women, but that could strike even men, making them effeminate and responsible for their perdition.[41]

The condemnation of luxury and the impudent ostentation of opulence was a common topic among the pagan moralists, and Jerome writes some of his most sharp pages against wealthy women boldly showing their beauty and sensuality, or their glamour. He cruelly mocks them, especially the ones pretending to be devoted to the Christian ideals: he writes impressive cruel portraits of such women, whose wardrobe is full of clothes, whose boxes are full of gold and the books are decked with jewels. The contrast with the Christian ideal is striking, as 'Christ lies at their door naked and dying', he writes.[42] As the studies of David S. Wiesen[43] have pleasantly showed, the *libellus* addressed to Eustochium (*Ep.* 22) is a catalogue of brilliant caricatures of feminine failings, gathered together to enforce their repulsive effect and to exalt the true holiness of Jerome's followers. The denunciation of women's dress and make up is a standard focus in Jerome's writings, as well as the polemic against lasciviousness and immoral luxury. But the living exempla of Paula, Blesilla, Eustochium, Marcella and the others pious ladies could demonstrate that women, and even women of rank, could effectively abandon the dissoluteness and the glamour of secular life: it was a good propaganda for Jerome to contrast their behaviour with the one of the worldly *matronae*. Moreover he was fully aware that his letters were destined to a collective lecture in the houses of some of his own aristocratic followers, and he encouraged this habit.[44]

But how could women overcome their natural weakness and inclination to fall? The key was their special continuous education: a kind of education, whose model Jerome brightly exposes by in several letters, as the number 107 to Leta, on the way of educating her little daughter.

3. Women and culture: a negative view

Besides avoiding any kind of glamorous things (jewels, make-up, earrings, hairdo, rich clothes, etc.), according to Jerome's directions, the little Paula had to keep out from the company of worldly girls, destined to prosperous

[41] *Comm. in Sophoniam* 1.11 (CChr.SL 76 A, 669): *Dignitatibus peribit qui inflatur; peribit qui in fortitudine corporis gloriatur; peribit qui femineo languore mollitus comam nutrit, uellit pilos, cutem polit, et ad speculum comitur, quae proprie passio et insania feminarum est.*

[42] *Ep.* 22.32.

[43] David S. Wiesen, *St. Jerome as a Satirist* (Ithaca, 1964), 119-28.

[44] Jerome, *Ep.* 24.1: 'In my present letter, I mean to give you a brief sketch of the life of our dear Asella. Please do not read it to her... Show it rather to the young girls of your acquaintance, that they may guide themselves by her example, and may take her behaviour as the pattern of a perfect life.'

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marriages. But, above all, the girl had to read every day an average numbers of passages from the Holy Scriptures, and to learn them at heart.[45] This was the focus of Jerome's Christian teaching. This was the interest he managed to raise among his female aristocratic audience in Rome. This was in his thought the mean through which women could raise themselves, overcoming their weakness and their inferiority to men. Jerome's women belonged to the high Roman aristocracy, they had received a distinguished education, and he often commends their knowledge of languages as Greek and Hebrew, their longing for a deeper understanding of the Bible, their sharp questions, so sharp that sometimes could even cause him difficulties in answering straight away. In brief: they were cultivated women. But we know how ambivalent was the couple women and culture in the classical antiquity: cultivated women were usually seen as creatures who exceeded the boundaries of their own nature and tried to shift in a world that was not their one. If we think to the portraits of Clodia by Cicero and Sempronia by Sallust, and especially to the representation of the knowledgeable woman in Juvenal's sixth satire,[46] we can have a quite good idea of the extent of such a prejudice. Martial[47] wished to find a wife not excessively learned, and Seneca the Elder prevented his wife to learn too much, avoiding to have a woman who used culture 'like a precious stone'.[48]

Sometimes Jerome himself seems to endorse exactly this traditional opinion on women. The problem was that females were not only lascivious and vain, in the opinion of their ancient detractors: they were also credulous, and therefore prone to follow any new preacher and prophets. Again Juvenal had censured women's fondness for foreign superstition in his famous sixth satire (*ll.* 511-591), and in the Christian world it was well known that among the followers of heretical sects there was a large number of ladies and young girls.[49] Indeed the

[45] *Ep.* 107.9.

[46] Juven., *Sat.* 6.434-456: 'But most intolerable of all is the woman who as soon as she has sat down to dinner commends Virgil, pardons the dying Dido, and pits the poets against each other, putting Virgil in the one scale and Homer in the other... Let not the wife of your bosom possess a special style of her own; let her not hurl at you in whirling speech the crooked enthymeme! Let he not know all history; let there be some things in her reading which she does not understand...' (transl. by George Gilbert Ramsay).

[47] *Epigrams* II 90.9: *Sit [mihi] non doctissima uxor.*

[48] Seneca, *Ad Helviam matrem* 17.4. For the problematic association women-culture in the classical and Christian world, see Emily Ann Hemelrijk, *Matrona docta: Educated women in the Roman élite from Cornelia to Julia Domna* (London and New York, 1999) and Valeria Novembri, L'educazione delle donne nel cristianesimo antico: fra modelli tradizionali e nuovi paradigmi: *Storia delle donne* 1 (2005) 187-200.

[49] See the convincing article by Virginia Burrus, The Heretical Woman as Symbol in Alexander, Athanasius, Epiphanius, and Jerome: *HTR* 84 (1991) 229-48. As the scholar points out 'the historical study of women in ancient heretical movements is doubly problematic' (230), for all we know about women and heresies comes from orthodox sources written by male authors, and in a similar polemic context, portraits of heretics and heretical women grown contemptuously immoral by means of the authors' rhetorical devices.

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concept of women as 'naturally' inclined towards heresy was the result both of idea of female weakness and the evidence of women presence among heretical groups, like Gnostics and Montanists, as prophetess and preachers, in a period in which the 'Great Church' did not admit it any more. And in fact, as some scholars suggest,[50] this association – women-heresy – had his peak in the fourth century C.E. Jerome himself denounces it, and in representing heretical women he uses the words of the *Second letter to Timothy* (3:6-7): 'women laden with sins, led away with various lusts, ever learning and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth', a sarcastic depiction that returns several times in Jerome's writings. We find it again in the *Epistle* 75.3, for example, in a passage about the Gnostic heresy of Mark, who 'made it his object to seek out the houses of the wealthy, and among them especially the ones of women, concerning whom we are told that they are "led away with various lusts, ever learning and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth"'.[51]

The same negative evaluation of the female gender as to its facility to fall into error is expressed also in the famous *Epistle to Eustochium*, to describe not the followers of heretic preachers, but stupid women who cannot distinguish the true monks from the false ones, men pretending to starve themselves and simulating austerity, while eating by night in order to appear not to break their fasts.[52] It is clear that Jerome wants to distinguish categorically himself from these false Christian preachers, and in doing that he needs to distinguish as well his women from the ones following false monks and heretics: those female followers of unorthodox doctrines cannot be at all considered virgins, but they are prostitutes![53]

In the epistle 133 to Ctesiphon, a follower of his opponent Pelagius, Jerome makes a long list of heresies, remembering all the female partners, followers

[50] V. Burrus, The Heretical Woman (1991) 231-3, 246-8.

[51] *Ep.* 75.3. The full text sounds: *Refert Irenaeus ... quod Marcus quidam de Basilidis gnostici stirpe descendens primum ad Gallias uenerit et eas partes, per quas Rodanus et Garunna fluunt, sua doctrina maculauerit maximeque nobiles feminas quaedam in occulto mysteria repromittens hoc errore seduxerit magicis artibus et secreta corporum uoluptate amorem sui concilians, inde Pirenaeum transiens Spanias occuparit et hoc studii habuerit, ut diuitum domus et in ipsis feminas maxime adpeteret, quae ducuntur uariis desideriis semper discentes et numquam ad scientiam ueritatis peruenientes* [2*Tim.* 3:6-7].

[52] *Ep.* 22.28: *Qui postquam nobilium introierint domos et deceperint mulierculas oneratas peccatis, semper discentes et numquam ad scientiam ueritatis peruenientes* [2*Tim.* 3:6-7], *tristitiam simulant et quasi longa ieiunia furtiuis noctium cibis protrahunt; pudet reliqua dicere, ne uidear inuehi potius quam monere.*

[53] It is what Jerome himself says to Eustochium (*Ep.* 22.38): *Ceterum virgines, quales apud diversas hereses et quales apud inpurissimum Manicheum esse dicuntur, scorta sunt aestimanda, non virgines.* The binomial heresy-sexual immorality was so strong and deeply rooted in Christian orthodox mentality, that any heretic was thought to be fraudulent and vicious, and therefore, translated into female terms, an ashamed harlot. This opinion was so well acquainted that even in Modern times heretic women and 'witches' were thought to be sexually depraved and imagined having sexual relationships with Satan and the demons, during the terrific Sabbath. As for this topic, many are the studies published, especially in the last years. We limit to mention the ones by Hans Peter Broedel, *The Malleus Maleficarum and the Construction of Witchcraft*

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and co-workers of the various 'false prophets'. He portrays 'bands of women' accompanying the 'devisers of all uncleanness'. He remembers that

It was with the help of the prostitute Helen that Simon Magus founded his sect. Bands of women accompanied Nicolas of Antioch, that creator of all contaminations. Marcion sent a woman before him to Rome to prepare minds to be deceived. Apelles had Philumena as a fellow in his doctrines. Montanus, that emissary of an impure spirit, thanks to two rich and high born ladies, Prisca and Maximilla, first corrupted many churches by means of gold and then infected them with heresy.[54]

Even Arius 'began by misleading the Emperor's sister', he continues, and Donatus was helped by Lucilla, Priscillian by Galla, and so on.

4. The ultimate female model: theory and practice

The difference between these women and Jerome's ones is striking. It is enough to read the portray of Marcella (*Ep.* 127.7) to have an idea of it. Jerome commends not only her 'virtue and ability', her 'holiness and purity', her longing for the Christian knowledge and the ability in learning any Jerome's teaching and the reading method to apply to the Scriptures. Her reputation for it had arisen so high that after Jerome's departure from Rome, in case of a dispute arising in Biblical matter, Christians asked her. But Jerome says she was so wise and so deeply aware of her inferior role as a female, that

when she answered questions she gave her own opinion not as her own but as from me [i.e. Jerome himself] or someone else, thus admitting that what she taught she had herself learned from others. For she knew that the apostle had said: 'I suffer not a woman to teach' [1*Tim.* 1:12], and she would not seem to inflict a wrong upon the male sex, many of whom (including sometimes priests) questioned her concerning obscure and doubtful points.[55]

(Manchester, 2003); Giovanni Grado Merlo, *Streghe* (Bologna, 2006); Anna Foa, *Eretici: Storie di streghe, ebrei e convertiti* (Bologna, 2004); Patrizia Castelli (ed.), *Bibliotheca lamiarum: Documenti e immagini della stregoneria dal Medioevo all'età moderna* (Pisa, 1994); Dinora Corsi, Dal sacrificio al maleficio: La donna e il sacro nell'eresia e nella stregoneria: *QMed* 30 (1990) 8-62; and, from a sociological point of view, Nachman Ben Yehuda, The European Witch Craze of the 14th-17th Centuries: A Sociologist's Perspective: *AJS* 86 (1980) 1-31, and Robin Briggs, *Witches and Neighbors: The Social and Cultural Contexts of European Witchcraft* (New York, 1996). As for the Sabbath, see the fascinating book by Carlo Ginzburg, *Ecstasies: Deciphering the Witches' Sabbath* (New York, 1991).

[54] *Ep.* 133.4: *Simon Magus heresin condidit, Helenae meretricis adiutus auxilio. Nicolaus Antiochenus, omnium inmunditiarum repertor, choros duxit femineos. Marcion Romam praemisit mulierem quae deceptarum sibi animos praepararet. Apelles Philumenem suarum comitem habuit doctrinarum. Montanus inmundi spiritus praedicator, multas ecclesias per Priscam et Maximillam, nobiles et opulentas feminas, primum auro corrupit; deinde heresi polluit.*

[55] *Ep.* 127.7: *Et quia ualde prudens erat et nouerat illud, quod appellant philosophi* τὸ πρέπον, *id est decere, quod facias, sic interrogata respondebat, ut etiam sua non sua diceret, sed uel mea uel cuiuslibet alterius, ut et in ipso, quod docebat, se discipulam fateretur – sciebat*

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This was a woman had right to do. This was the perfect synthesis of the traditional pagan ideal for respectable women, the modesty, and the Christian incarnation of the holy woman, learned in the Scriptures, but capable of keeping her place. This was the philosophy Jerome preached to his circle of women, a philosophy strictly connected with everyday life, an ethical conduct and an honest behaviour.[56] This philosophy could help women to be humble and strong at the same time, overcoming the failings typical of their sex. Jerome addressed his letters to a homogenous audience: the members of the highest Roman nobility, converted to Christianity. He offered them concrete models, both in a positive and a negative way, for directing their behaviour toward the Christian perfection. And the best examples were the living ones, the nearest, the best known. Paula and Eustochium for instance. Jerome depicts in a dramatic pièce how the two aristocratic women lived before their conversion: 'They were too dainty to walk in the muddy streets, were carried about in the arms of eunuchs, disliked crossing uneven ground, found a silk dress a burthen and felt sunshine too scorching'. Then he describes their radical change: 'Now squalid and sombre in their dress, they are positive heroines in comparison with what they used to be. They trim lamps, light fires, sweep floors, clean vegetables, put heads of cabbage in the pot to boil, lay tables, hand cups, help dishes and run to and from to care of others'. This, he says, is incredible, 'for considering the weakness of their sex'.[57]

In reading just this passage we could be tempted to sum up Jerome's philosophy in this formula: a way to transform women into Cinderellas... But it would be truly an oversimplification, in the light of all we have read till now. Women had to overcome their own weakness, their passions, their lust for luxury, elegance and ornaments and all the more reason the aristocratic women had to rid themselves of all their comforts: they had to show even in their exterior appearance, in their dress code, their Christian choice. For this reason they had to divest themselves of their rich clothes, and wear poor and sober ones. Gloomy colours (*pullata*, *furva*, *lugubres*) were admitted, but it was important to avoid any excess, because even the ostentation of an affected sobriety could be a form of arrogance and vanity.[58] Moderation and modesty,

enim dictum ab apostolo: docere autem mulieri non permitto [1*Tim.* 1:12] –, *ne uirili sexui et interdum sacerdotibus de obscuris et ambiguis sciscitantibus facere uideretur iniuriam.* On Marcella's role in Roman Christianity, her social status and her Christian qualities, see the excellent book by Silvia Letsch-Brunner, *Marcella – discipula et magistra: Auf den Spuren einer römischen Christin des 4. Jahrhunderts* (Berlin, 1998).

[56] It was right the ideal of philosophy as ascetic life elaborated by Christian authors in the fourth century. For the developments of the idea of philosophy in Christian thought, see Anne Marie Malingrey, *'Philosophia': Étude d'un groupe de mots dans la littérature grecque dès Présocratique au IVe siècle après Jésus-Christ* (Paris, 1961).

[57] *Ep.* 66.13.

[58] On this *topos* about the monastic dress code, see Valeria Novembri, Quando l'abito fa il monaco: Paolino di Nola e l'aspetto dell'*homo Dei*, in: Elena Giannarelli, Carlo Nardi, and Valeria Novembri (eds.), *Caritas Pastoralis: Strenna in onore di Mons. Angiolo Livi* (Firenze, 2007), 47-58.

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and the virtues acquainted through the Christian way of life, the Christian philosophy, have to be evident at the first glance, to come into sight from the exterior look, as Jerome says to Eustochium in the famous *Epitaphium Paulae*: the sobriety of the clothes should be the evidence of a pure mind.[59] This way, Jerome's female friends could really be considered the living proof of this positive behaviour. They were the paradigmatic example of rich cultivated women who, thanks to the Christian education, the authentic *philosophia*, managed to overcome the weakness and the vices connatural to their sex, and potentially increased by their social status.

[59] *Ep.* 108.20: *Sordes vestium candidae mentis indicio sint.*

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Roles and Functions of Mary in the Hymnography of Romanos Melodos

Leena Mari PELTOMAA, Vienna

Romanos Melodos is the great name in Byzantine liturgical poetry, but the significance of his poetry as an historical source, reflecting the mentality or mind of sixth-century people, instead of simply as pieces of literature, has only recently become really apparent in studies on Romanos.[1] This new aspect of Romanos' hymnography recognized by studies dealing with Byzantine intellectual history seems to be fruitful also for studying the early cult of Mary. Within research on Romanos, no study so far has focussed on Mary, based on his whole *œuvre*. Anyhow, his works represent a significant source of evidence with regard to Mary, for she is referred to in thirty-seven of about sixty authentic hymns, nine of them having Mary as their central figure.[2] Thus, the hymnography of Romanos provides extraordinary material for investigating the roles and functions of Mary in Byzantine society from the period of its first greatness, *i.e.*, the era of the emperor Justinian I (527-65).

[1] *E.g.*, Derek Krueger, Romanos the Melodist and the Christian Self in Early Byzantium, in: Elizabeth Jeffreys (ed.), *Proceedings of the 21st International Congress of Byzantine Studies, London, 21-26 August, 2006*, Vol. 1, Plenary Papers (Aldershot, 2006), 255-74; Georgia Frank, Romanos and the Night Vigil in the Sixth Century, in: D. Krueger (ed.), *Byzantine Christianity: A People's History of Christianity* III (Minneapolis, MN, 2006), 59-78; Leena Mari Peltomaa, Herodias in the Poetry of Romanos the Melodist: *JÖB* 56 (2006) 79-99. See also Paul Magdalino, The history of the future and its uses: prophecy, policy and propaganda, in: Roderick Beaton and Charlotte Roueché (eds.), *The Making of Byzantine History* (London, 1993), 3-34, esp. 6-7. 9. 12, where Magdalino uses Romanos' hymns as an evidence of the prevailing eschatological atmosphere in Constantinople during the age of Justinian.

[2] The given numbers are based on the following editions: José Grosdidier de Matons (ed.), *Romanos le Mélode. Hymnes*, 1-66, SC 99. 110. 114. 128. 283 (Paris, 1964-81); Riccardo Maisano, *Romano il Melodo*, I-II (Turin, 2002); Johannes Koder, *Romanos Melodos. Die Hymnen*, I-II, Bibliothek der griechischen Literatur 62. 64 (Stuttgart, 2005-6). In these editions the 'Stichera on the Nativity of Christ', found under the number 83 in Paul Maas and C.A. Trypanis, (eds.), *Sancti Romani Melodi Cantica. Cantica dubia* (Berlin, 1970), is considered as authentic. The Stichera praises Mary as the Theotokos. The Greek text edition, *Sancti Romani Melodi Cantica. Cantica genuina*, by Paul Maas and C.A. Trypanis (Oxford, 1963) (hereafter *Cantica genuina*) includes 59 *kontakia*, eight of them having Mary as the central figure. The English edition by Marjorie Carpenter, *Kontakia of Romanos, Byzantine Melodist*, I-II (Columbia, 1970-3) follows *Cantica genuina*. In this paper Greek citations and the order of the hymns refers to *Cantica genuina*. For the concordance of the numbering between *Cantica genuina* and the French edition, see Riccardo Maisano, *Romano* I (2002), 103, oder Johannes Koder, *Romanos* I (2005), 58-60.

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This paper is a further contribution to the efforts of the team of scholars from around the world working on the International Early Mariology Project.[3] Some of the early results of that research were presented at the previous Oxford conference, including the foundational paper outlining the project's rationale.[4] Let it be said by way of summary that the team is interested in tracing the historical roots of the development of the cult of Mary within Christianity in a scientific manner rather than a confessional and devotional manner. Thus, our work is a contribution to Marian studies, understanding this aim to refer to such objective and historical assessments about the rise of devotion to Mary, rather than an example of mariology, understood as the promotion of a particular type of understanding within a devotional context. It is hoped that such research as our team is undertaking will help us understand, to take one example only, the dynamics of the position of women in Byzantine society in a fresh light.[5] In this paper I will argue that with Romanos, for the first time in Byzantine hymnography, Mary becomes an active subject endowed with emotions, whose perspectives on the life of her son form an important precondition for the development of cultic practices involving her.

Focussing on the stage of development that the cult of Mary had reached in the Eastern-Roman capital by the time Romanos departed from this world (probably before the year 562), one has to mention a legend that is attached to Romanos by the tenth-century Constantinopolitan Synaxar.[6] According to it, the unmusical Romanos received his talent for composing *kontakia* through the intervention of the Theotokos and began his career as *melodos* with the hymn on the Nativity[7] – the work that is still sung at Christmas in Orthodox churches.[8] The legend, a topos as it is, is indicative only of the unusual talents of Romanos and the high esteem in which he was held. Nothing can be said about Romanos' relationship with Mary on the basis of this legend. The so-called facts of his life in the Synaxar tell us that he came from Syria, became *diakonos* in Berytos (today Beirut in Lebanon), went during the time of the emperor Anastasios I

[3] See http://www.cecs.acu.edu.au/research.htm.

[4] Geoffrey Dunn, References to Mary in the Writings of Cyprian of Carthage: *SP* 42 (2006) 369-78; Cornelia Horn, Amazement for the Daughters of the Hebrews: Mary in Aphrahat, Ephraem, and Other Early Syriac Theologians: *SP* 42 (2006) 413-28; Antonia Atanassova, Cyril of Alexandria and His Contribution to Mariology: *SP* 42 (2006) 29-44; Leena Mari Peltomaa, Towards the Origins of the History of the Cult of Mary: *SP* 40 (2006) 75-86.

[5] Leena Mari Peltomaa, Gender and Byzantine Studies from the Viewpoint of Methodology: *Anzeiger der phil.-hist. Klasse der ÖAW* 140/1 (2005) 23-44.

[6] See José Grosdidier de Matons, *Romanos le Mélode et les origines de la poésie réligieuse à Byzance* (Paris, 1977), 162.

[7] Romanos did not know the term 'kontakion' by which later generations called his compositions. Romanos' *kontakia* represent the climax of this genre, see, *e.g.*, Johannes Koder, Christliche liturgische Hymnographie zur Zeit des Romanos Melodos, in: *Romanos* 1 (2005), 14-24.

[8] No. 1, 'On the Nativity' or 'Mary and the Magi', beginning: Ἡ παρθένος σήμερον τὸν ὑπερούσιον τίκτει.

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(491-518) to Constantinople and settled in the Kyros-Foundation, which had a church dedicated to the Theotokos. In this church he was also buried. It is believable that the Marian church, Romanos' working place, provided him with a suitable ambience for contemplating what kind of a personality the mother of Jesus could have had. Among early Christian sources no author created such character for Mary as Romanos did. In part this is due to his genius and in part due to the artistic method he used: he reconstructed imaginatively biblical events involving Mary, composing dialogues and monologues for her.

I shall concentrate in those poems where 'Mary expresses herself'. Sometime, after the year 530, but before the Council of 553 in Constantinople, Justinian supposedly established the celebration of the feast of the Annunciation to be held on 25 March.[9] Romanos' corpus includes only one hymn, composed for this new feast.[10] It characterizes the Virgin as the one who is chosen to give birth to God. Another hymn, also with the title 'On the Annunciation', belongs to the period at which the Commemoration of Mary was an integral part of the Nativity celebrations.[11] In that context the Virgin Mary was considered also as the second Eve. Thus there are two hymns in which Mary's distinctive role as the second Eve in the Nativity scene is apparent. They will be treated before the poems presenting Mary in the role of the mother are discussed. At the end Mary's functions as the intercessor and the Theotokos will be considered.

Mary as the Virgin

It seems justified to suppose that the authentic Annunciation hymn reflects the atmosphere and feelings that, at the time of celebrating the new liturgical feast, surrounded the central figure of the event.[12] The refrain, 'Hail, virgin unwedded', was picked from the Akathistos Hymn.[13] This epithet has its origins in an ascetical milieu, as I have demonstrated in my study on the Akathistos, and is

[9] See R.A. Fletcher, Three Early Byzantine Hymns and Their Place in the Liturgy of the Church of Constantinople: *BZ* 51 (1958) 53-65, 61f.; Johannes Koder, *Romanos* I (2005), 393f.

[10] No. 36, 'On the Annunciation' (I). Seemingly the full version has not come down to us, for the abrupt ending is not typical of Romanos. While the acrostics in known *kontakia* of Romanos commonly show: ΤΟΥ ΤΑΠΕΙΝΟΥ ΡΩΜΑΝΟΥ Ο ΥΜΝΟΣ or ΠΟΙΗΜΑ or ΨΑΛΜΟΣ (24 strophes), this one reads: ΤΟΥ ΤΑΠΕΙΝΟΥ ΡΩΜΑΝΟΥ (18 strophes), see R.A. Fletcher, Three Early Byzantine Hymns (1958), 53-65, esp. 57.

[11] About differing views, see Johannes Koder, *Romanos* I (2005), 369.

[12] Fletcher considers this hymn as evidence for the existence of the festival of the Annunciation on March 25 at Constantinople 'somewhere about the middle of the sixth century', see R.A. Fletcher, Three Early Byzantine Hymns *BZ* 51 (1958) 53-65, esp. 58.

[13] χαῖρε, νύμφη ἀνύμφευτε, see the Greek text in C.A. Trypanis (ed.), The Akathistos Hymn, in: *Fourteen Early Byzantine Cantica*, WBS 5 (Vienna, 1968), 29-39. On the question of the authorship of the hymn, consult chapter 3, 'State of Research', in: Leena Mari Peltomaa, *The Image of the Virgin Mary in the Akathistos Hymn*, The Medieval Mediterranean 35 (Leiden, Boston, and Cologne, 2001).

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not really motivated by Romanos' narration. Why then did Romanos not create a more suitable refrain? Perhaps it was because the application of the Akathistos' refrain was intended to produce an association between the pious kings who once proclaimed Mary as the Theotokos (Akathistos 23.10) and the pious emperor Justinian who now made the dogma more firm.

In any case, the opening strophe gives the impression that this is the first time that Mary appears before the audience having a specific status, for the tone is very official: 'Come, let us accompany the archangel Gabriel to the Virgin Mary, / and let us greet her as mother and nourisher of our life, / for it is not only fitting for the general to salute the queen, / but it is also possible for the humble to see her and address her. / All generations call her blessed as mother of God as they are crying: / Hail, virgin undefiled, hail, maiden called by God ...' and so on, eight times with different epithets.[14] Such a series of salutations is presented only in this first strophe in the whole poem. It is striking too that, although he never employes the epithet of the queen (*basilís*) for Mary,[15] in this passage Romanos uses an ambiguous imagery, which is possible to understand as a compliment paid to the empress Theodora, who is present.[16] The idea that Mary should be greeted 'as mother and nourisher of our life' cannot be taken for a mere rhetorical invention of Romanos.[17] At least the same idea is expressed in another hymn, too.[18] Perhaps in the Constantinopolitan cult of Mary, at the time of the composition of the hymn, the quality of the mother who nourishes citizens' lives was attached to the public image of Mary.

The actual Annunciation story shows the 'private side' of the Virgin, her characteristic features. Romanos elaborates the famous passage of the *Gospel of Luke* and connects it with the *Protevangelium of James*. Striking in Romanos' story is the transfiguration that happens in Mary in consequence of the visit by Gabriel. From the frightened young girl, who bows her head toward the earth and is silent as the archangel addresses her, grows an exalted and luminous figure whose beauty, namely her physical appearance, Romanos dares to praise with Joseph's mouth – a unique moment in his poetry. The realization of the psychological change in Mary can be followed by listening to her dialogue with Gabriel and to her self-reflection on the matter, as well as to the dialogue with Joseph. No scholarly description does justice to Mary's character as it appears in this poem by Romanos. One has to read it by herself. To me, most impressive

[14] No. 36, 1.1-7, transl. from Marjorie Carpenter, *Kontakia* II (1973).

[15] The idea of Mary as the queen, however, is found in the hymn 'On the Nativity' (No.2, 2-3-4). In that passage Mary says: 'For I am the queen of the world / since, bearing your power in my womb, I rule over all (τοῦ γὰρ κόσμου βασιλεύω / ἐπειδὴ κράτος τὸ σὸν ἐβάστασα γαστρί, πάντων κρατῶ).

[16] Provided that this had been the case, the hymn should be dated *ante* 548 (Theodora's death).

[17] No. 36, 1.2: καὶ ταύτην [Μαρίαν] ἀσπασώμεθα ὡς μητέρα καὶ τροφὸν τῆς ζωῆς ἡμῶν.

[18] No. 35, 'Nativity of the Virgin Mary', whose refrain reads: 'The barren woman gives birth to the Theotokos and the nurse of our life (τὴν Θεοτόκον καὶ τροφὸν τῆς ζωῆς ἡμῶν).'

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in this characterization is the making apparent of the Virgin's pure heart. It is evident even though it is not said explicitly. Likewise, it is plain from Mary's attitude towards the messenger and his strange message that she is sensible and able to judge her actions in the position where she finds herself. Mary's emotions and the excitement she feels correspond with the situation in the question. Without saying it, Romanos' story explains why an aura of self-assurance is associated with Mary. She simply *knows* more than any human being because of what she has experienced and that gives her this special self-assurance.

Mary as the second Eve

In his second hymn on the Annunciation, predating the one just discussed, Mary's character differs radically from the 'luminous' virgin.[19] This is due to the framework of *oikonomia* in which this older hymn is written. In *oikonomia*, the divine plan of salvation, or in the history of the Incarnation the distinctive role of the new or second Eve is attributed to Mary.[20] Romanos' audience knew the story about Adam and Eve and their Fall and they also knew how this story was associated with Mary. They knew, because patristic tradition taught that it was foretold in the holy Scriptures that the divine plan for their salvation would be realized in a wondrous way through Mary who was to become the Theotokos.

The story of the Fall that resulted in the Incarnation could be told in many ways. Romanos presents a unique version suggesting that God's motive for his plan was revenge, for God desired 'to wound the one who had wounded Adam'. The enemy is not defeated by war but by deception. The trick is that God disguises himself as a human being. In the Incarnation he assumes a human form and is born without seed, *i.e.*, from a virgin. This is the great mystery of *oikonomia*, 'beyond nature', in which Mary is involved.

This time in her dialogue with the angel Mary presents counter arguments. She sees her human nature as unsuitable. Besides, it seems impossible for her to accept the idea that a 'woman, who first introduced death to mortals, should now produce life'. The angel, however, is steadfast: 'God has planned that the whole of corrupted humanity should be renewed from you.'[21] Mary is predestined for her role. It is remarkable that Mary is given a promise that God will keep her pure after childbirth. This is emphasized also by the refrain: 'A Virgin gives birth, and even after childbirth remains a virgin'.[22]

[19] No. 37, 'On the Annunciation' (II).

[20] On *Oikonomia*, see *ODB* 3, 1516; on the Second Eve, *e.g.*, Leena Mari Peltomaa, *The Image of the Virgin Mary* (2001), 128-34.

[21] No. 37, 12.1, trans. from the 'On the Mother of God' in: Ephrem Lash, *Kontakia. On the Life of Christ. St. Romanos the Melodist* (San Francisco, 1995).

[22] Παρθένος τίκτει καὶ μετὰ τόκον πάλιν μένει παρθένος. My translation.

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In the hymn, 'On the Nativity' (II) or 'Adam and Eve and the Nativity', Mary grasps the state of corruption of those who were cast out of Paradise, her 'parents', and she sympathizes with them – in Romanos words: 'For a tender mother was only fitting for the Merciful One.'[23] Mary promises them: 'I shall become mediator for you in the presence of my son.'[24] Then she entreats her child, who is lying in the cradle: 'Since you, my child, have exalted me through your condescension, / my poor race, through me, now beseeches you. / For Adam, lamenting bitterly, came to me, / and Eve joined him in his complaints. / The serpent is the cause of this, since he bereft them of their honour. / Therefore, they are begging to be covered, as they cry to me, the favoured one.'[25] And her child, God, answers: 'I save them because of you and through you.' Christ has already related that He has come to live on earth only to save Adam and Eve and all humanity. He has revealed to his mother that he will suffer and be crucified. To Mary's wail he replies: 'Cease, Mother, lamenting for things, which you do not understand; / for unless these things are brought to pass, / all of those people for whom you do intercede will be destroyed.'[26]

Mary as the mother

The legendary first hymn 'On the Nativity' (I) or 'Mary and the Magi' was extremely popular in Byzantium.[27] It is the story about the magi, whose visit to Christ is celebrated in the Byzantine rite on 25 December.[28] They come to worship the child whose star has lead them to Joseph's place. Most of the poem takes the form of a dialogue, either between Mary and her newborn child or between Mary and the magi. In the beginning, however, we hear Mary contemplating the mystery of the virgin birth: 'Tell me, my Child, how were you sown, or how were you planted in me?' Of course Mary adores her baby. She also understands her extraordinary social position, wherefore she asks her child whether he loves a cave, or takes pleasure in a manger. As for her, she has not been given even a fox-hole, whereas Sarah was bestowed with a vast land. Like every mother, Mary is proud of her offspring. As she hears the magi approaching she turns to her child and bids him to welcome them that they may see rich

[23] No. 2, 10.6: τῷ γὰρ ἐλεήμονι μήτηρ ἔπρεπεν εὔσπλαγχνος (*PGL*, εὔσπλαγχνος, compassionate, merciful, tender-hearted).

[24] *Ibid.* 10.7-8: Παύσασθε τῶν θρήνων ὑμῶν, / καὶ πρέσβις ὑμῖν γίνομαι πρὸς τὸν ἐξ ἐμοῦ.

[25] *Ibid.* 12.5-11, transl. adapted from M. Carpenter, *Kontakia* I (1970).

[26] *Ibid.* 17.9-11. Intercede, ἱκετεύω.

[27] No. 1, Ἡ παρθένος σήμερον, transl. from the 'On the Nativity', in: Ephrem Lash, *Kontakia* (1995).

[28] The story of this Christmas hymn, which is limited to the scene at Bethlehem and is lacking the complete story of the Infancy of Christ, justifies Fletcher to suggest that the hymn was composed only after the festival of the Annunciation on March 25 had come into existence, see R.A. Fletcher, Three Early Byzantine Hymns: *BZ* 51 (1958) 53-65, esp. 62.

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poverty and precious beggary, and she adds as to confirm herself: 'You I have as glory and pride, therefore I am not ashamed.'

When the magi see that the betrothed is within the Virgin's house they ask her: 'Will people not find fault at Joseph's living with you?' Mary replies that she keeps Joseph in her house to refute all those who slander her. She tells them how she had conceived her child and what Joseph had experienced, his dream, the appearance of the shepherds and the angels. Then Mary, for her part, questions the magi about their journey and expresses astonishment that they eluded Herod. The story of the visit of the magi ends with the worshipping in the manner we know from the Gospel story. Romanos, however, continues his story in three strophes, by which the poem is finished.

These strophes demonstrate that Mary is aware of the prospects that her motherhood places her as the mediator between God and humans (22): 'When the blameless Virgin saw the magi bringing / new and radiant gifts and worshipping, / the star showing him, the shepherds praising him, / she implored the Maker and Creator of all these, saying: / "Accept my Child, a trinity of gifts, grant her who gave you birth three requests."' And then Mary prays for the seasons and for the fruits of the earth and for those who dwell on it. Immediately thereafter she says: 'For I am not simply you mother, compassionate Saviour; / it is not in vain that I suckle the Giver of milk, / but for the sake of all I implore you ... They look to me, those who were cast out / of the Paradise of pleasure, for I bring them back. / May all things understand that, through me, you have been born, a little Child, God before ages. (24) Save the world, O Savior. For this you have come. / Set your whole universe aright. For this you have shone / on me and on the magi and on all creation.' At the very end of the last strophe Mary's sense of reality is also revealed: she thinks in a very practical way that she will need the magis' gifts, since she is about to flee to Egypt.

Perhaps this hymn was really composed during the reign of the emperor Anastasios I (491-518).[29] Anyhow, we can suppose that the image of Mary in this poem is based on generally accepted notions of Mary's position in the *oikonomia* at the time of its composition. Accordingly, it was possible for Romanos to put into words the idea of Mary's mediatory role in such a self-evident manner as it has been done here in the prayer to God by Mary[30] – and it was possible to make Mary say: 'I am not simply your mother.'[31]

In the hymn 'On the Marriage at Cana' Mary is described as a mother with an adult son.[32] From this story about the marriage at Cana we learn that Mary's belief in her son and his ability to perform miracles is full and complete. She

[29] See J. Koder, *Romanos* I (2005), 378f.

[30] Koder points out the connection between Mary's pray and the Christmas Liturgy of Basil the Great, see J. Koder, *Romanos* I (2005), 381.

[31] No. 1, 23.1: Οὐχ ἁπλῶς γὰρ εἰμὶ μήτηρ σου.

[32] No. 7, transl. adapted from M. Carpenter, *Kontakia* I (1970).

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comprehends that he knows all the concerns of her heart. She begs her son to offer wine that has run out and Jesus answers: 'What do you wish, woman, my hour has not come.' Mary wonders: 'How, then, do you await a time for the miracle which I ask of you, who have in wisdom created all things?' Christ gives his mother a 'lecture' of six long strophes (12 to 17 in sixty lines) explaining his divine order: 'At the time when I brought forward Heaven and earth and all things from a state of nonexistence, / I would have been quite able at that time to arrange in order at once all that I had produced: / but I introduced a certain well-regulated order.' Having heard all Mary speaks out to the servants: 'Whatever my son says to you, do it.' In this hymn Mary's function as mediator is evident. The general impression, with regard to Mary's character, is that the poet is portraying a contemporary woman with a strong status consciousness. Motherhood matters, Mary's wish is fulfilled since, as Christ says, 'It is necessary that parents be honored by their children', so he acts, too.

Excursus: Mary as the Church?

In addition to the salient role of the mother in the scene of the celebration of the wedding, at which Mary acts as mediator between her son and the people whose joy had turned into distress, due to the 'tragedy of penury', the poem reflects a function which can be interpreted as 'Mary as the church'.[33] However, this is a question which is so complicated that it would deserve its own paper. The main reason why it is so difficult is that a systematic scholarly presentation of the notions of patristic authorities concerning the theme 'Mary as the church' is lacking. However, I shall in brief illuminate the problem by means of the hymn under consideration.

At no point do editors seem to have paid any special attention to the first strophe of the Cana hymn – that it would reflect Romanos' notion of Mary as the church. Mary has simply been considered as mediator. Therefore, in order to form a proper view as to what Romanos in this poem suggests about the church and Mary, one should, at least, compare the first strophe with the whole text. However, the result would be more reliable if his other hymns with allusions or references to the church were investigated, too. Taking into consideration that the church theme is so central in explaining the development of the cult of Mary in early Byzantine period, the examination of other contemporary authors and especially Syriac texts would also be necessary.[34] Nevertheless, I shall quote the first strophe and give another example just to show the apparent difficulty to be faced:

'God, honoring virginity, inhabited in a virgin's womb, / born of her without seed he did not break the seals of her purity. / He himself has espoused the church, unblemished and virgin. / The mother of Christ, then, is virgin and bride, / He, too, a virgin,

[33] I owe Kristina Alveteg for dealing with this topic (Workshop 'Roles and Function of Mary in Early Christianity', Oxford 08.08.2007).

[34] At least the possible influence of Ephraem the Syrian on Romanos needs to be investigated. The quotations of Ephraem in the paper, 'Mary and the Idea of the Church', by Merja Merras (Workshop 09.08.2007) are highly suggestive.

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and the bridal bed is sacred / for He built heaven of the bridal chamber. / Even though He also was born of a virginal and all-holy womb, / He does not feel disgust at the unions of wedlock, / He who has in wisdom created all things.[35] – There is no doubt about the juxtaposition of Mary with the church, but what Romanos means by it, *that is the question*. For instance, in his hymn 'On the Woman of Samaria' he says: 'For she [the woman] departed in filth [from her village] but [after having met Christ at the spring of Samaria] returned blameless as the image (*typos*) of the church.'[36] Mary was always blameless, but the church not! Thus, today we can only assess that Mary's role as mediator has much to do with her function as the church, but, since we have so far no coherent picture of Romanos' notion of Mary as the church, the relationship 'mediator-church' remains unclear.

In Romanos' poems, Christ fulfills all his mother's wishes and petitions on behalf of humankind, all except one: that she not see her own child sacrificed. Suffering was also part of God's plan. The relationship between righteous God and sinful humanity that required God's dispensation of grace and mercy culminates in the 'economic' sacrifice of the Son. This is the topic of the hymn of 'Mary at the Cross'.[37] It includes dialogues in 16 strophes. The beginning shows us a mother who is worn out with grief. She is aghast at the injustice to which her son has freely submitted. Mary attempts to change his mind recalling all the miracles he performed. Christ exhorts her to be uncomplaining: 'You should not lament, for you were named Full of Grace.' Finally, Christ succeeds in bringing his mother to comprehend what is at stake and calls upon her: 'Run, Mother, announce to all / that "By suffering he strikes the one who hates Adam, / and as victor he is coming, / my Son and my God."' Mary must overcome common human limitations. As she does so, she assumes the character of a heroine and expresses her feelings as a heroine: 'I am conquered, my Child, I am conquered by love, / and truly I cannot bear that I should be in my room, but you on the Tree, / that I should be in my house, but you in a grave. / Let me come with you, for to see you heals me. / I shall look on the monstrous daring of those who honour Moses. / For it is to avenge him, so they say, that these blind men have / come to slay you. / But Moses said this to Israel, "You are going to see life on the Tree." / Life, who is it? It is / my Son and my God.'/

There is no longer misgiving caused by suffering, although she 'as a woman', in Christ's words, may be afraid when she sees all creation being shuddering at the outrage committed against her son. From this point on Mary identifies

[35] No. 7, 1, transl. adapted from M. Carpenter, *Kontakia* I (1970): Τὴν παρθενίαν τιμήσας Θεὸς γαστέραν ᾤκησε παρθενικήν, / τεχθεὶς δὲ ἐξ αὐτῆς ἀσπόρως τῆς ἁγνείας αὐτῆς τὰς σφραγῖδας οὐκ ἔλυσεν· /οὗτος τὴν ἐκκλησίαν ἄμωμον καὶ παρθένον ἑαυτῷ ἐμνηστεύσατο· / ἡ μήτηρ οὖν Χριστοῦ καὶ παρθένος καὶ νύμφη· / παρθένος καὶ αὐτὸς ἡ παστὰς δὲ ἁγία, / οὐρανὸν γὰρ νυμφῶνα εἰργάσατο· / κἂν οὖν ἐτέχθη ἐκ παρθενικῆς καὶ παναγίας γαστρός, / οὐ βδελύττεται ὅμως τὰς τῶν γάμων συζυγίας / ὁ τὰ πάντα ἐν σοφίᾳ ποιήσας.

[36] No. 9, 5-6, transl. adapted from M. Carpenter, *Kontakia* I (1970): Ἐξῆλθε γὰρ ἐν ῥύπῳ, / εἰσῆλθε δὲ ἐν τύπῳ τῆς ἐκκλησίας ἄμωμος.

[37] No. 19, transl. from the 'On the Lament of the Mother of God', in: E. Lash, *Kontakia* (1995).

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with all her heart with the redemptive suffering of her son. She fully understands the divine task he is to fulfil and becomes her son's assistant through her intercessions for humanity. This is why Romanos completes his work proclaiming: 'You granted the honoured Lady the freedom of speech (*parrhesia*) to cry to you, "My Son and my God".'

Mary's functions as the intercessor and the Theotokos

Now we can state that actually all the poems show the intercessory aspect in the image of Mary. In the Greek patristic tradition, which Romanos represents, this aspect has to be seen in the light of the theory of recapitulation, transmitted by Irenaeus' (d. c. 202) *Adversus Haereses*. Romanos reflects clearly the famous Irenaean idea that 'the virgin Mary might become the *advocate* of the virgin Eve'.[38] As a matter of fact, in the angel's phrase, 'God has planned that corrupt men be entirely renewed through you', he puts into words Mary's place in the whole theory. It is, however, quite obvious that Mary's 'personality' serves her intercessory function. The point is that the character Romanos creates for Mary makes her credible in the role of the second Eve. The luminous Virgin as the Birthgiver of God has not yet any experience of the merciless conditions of human life. Therefore Mary, neither in the role of the Virgin nor in that of the Theotokos, can really assume the intercessory role, whereas in the role of mother she can be considered the mediator between God and humans. The reason is clear: only as mother who emotionally and in cooperation responds to everything that is concerned with her child can Mary have the empathic quality that the human mind accepts as a prerequisite for such a role – otherwise all prayers to Mary would be a mere theatre. Of course, in prayers to her Mary can be addressed with all possible names and epithets, but her motherly character is the foundation.

In discussing the development of the Marian cult in Byzantium the question of Mary's intercessory function related to her function as the Theotokos is relevant. The relatively scarce use of the word 'Theotokos' is evident in Romanos' hymnography. Yet this does not mean that his poems would lack the concept of the Theotokos. The concept must be there because the Theotokos is a function that is imposed on Mary as result of christological concensus. As a fact, Romanos' poetry abounds in figurative expressions, like the metaphor of the 'temple and vessel of the Lord', all of which he always presents for testimony of the Theotokos.[39] However, such prefigurations from the Old Testament,

[38] See *Adv. haer.* V 19.1.

[39] No 35, 5.4, No. 37 provides several examples for the epithets having their origins in typological interpretation and reflecting the relationship between Mary and the One to whom she gave birth.

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typologies and prophecies of the Scriptures, or New Testament references attributed to Mary in the form of epithets cannot create an affinity with Mary. The quality which is necessary to foster that affinity is the characteristics of a real mother.

To do justice to Romanos, it must be said that he can give definitions of the Theotokos also from the mouth of Mary the mother, as the hymn 'On the Presentation in the Temple', christologically one of his most important works, dated to around 542, proves.[40] In spite of its length, I shall cite the whole monologue of Mary because it exemplifies finely Romanos' rhetoric. Who would not have understood the point of the kind of christological teaching, upon hearing: (3) 'While the angels sang in praise of the Lover of mankind, / Mary was walking, carrying him her arms, / and pondering how she had become a mother / yet remained a virgin. / Realizing that the birth was beyond nature, she was afraid and trembled. / Reasoning to herself she said, / "What title can I find for you, my Son. / For should I call you, as I see you, man, you are more than man, / who kept my virginity unsullied, / only Lover of mankind. (4) Should I call you perfect man? But I know / your conception was divine. None of humankind is ever / conceived without union and without seed, / as you were, sinless One. / And if I call you God, I marvel as I see you like me in all things, / for you have nothing which differentiates you among humans, / even though without sin you were conceived and born. / Shall I suckle you, or give you glory? For the facts proclaim you God / without time, even though you have become man, / only Lover of mankind." (5) Thus was the Lord brought in, carried with the holocausts / into the temple, as it is written. / And the blessed Symeon received him from his mother's arms.'?[41]

In arguing about the nature of Christ Romanos exploits also Mary's status as mother to support his ideas. In the following context he introduces Mary as the authoritative teacher: 'In the faith we have all we desire – where are we drifting? / The road is straight, lest anyone lead us astray! / Mary has shown us the course, / for she called her son Lord, / her son, really from her, as we have been taught, / incarnated from her and from the Holy Spirit, / the One who has appeared and illumined all things.'[42]

Considering the whole Marian corpus in Romanos, *the* image it transmits is the one of the intercessor, for even numerically most references to Mary are to her intercessory function. Repeatedly, in closing prayers or *prooimia* Mary's position as intercessor between humans and God is described from the supplicant's point of view. This is expressed by the use of the formula 'through/by the intercessions/prayers of the Theotokos/Virgin/your Mother', *e.g.*, 'For you, alone, as Creator of all men, have power / to set us free from sins: we supplicate

[40] See J. Koder, *Romanos* I (2005), 391f.
[41] No. 4, transl. from the 'On the Meeting of Our Lord', in: E. Lash, *Kontakia* (1995).
[42] No. 6, 10.3-10, 'On the Epiphany', transl. adapted from M. Carpenter, *Kontakia* I (1970).

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you, then, grant us help / by the intercessions of the Theotokos, the Virgin Mary, / through whom we all come in your presence invoking aid / crying, 'Have mercy, / O, Lover of man.'[43]

The hymn, 'On the Nativity of the Virgin Mary', confirms what is said before.[44] The topic of this hymn requires an assertion of Mary's meaning related to Christ' saving work. Thus Romanos' presentation must have been in accordance with the contemporary teaching on Mary. The date of the composition is not known. The hymn is based on the *Protevangelium of James* and diverges essentially from the original text in that it considers Mary's intercessory function as an established fact. The refrain reads: 'The barren woman gives birth to the Theotokos and the nurse of our life.' In the Prooimion is found the expression 'your people' (*o laos sou*), referring to people who will be redeemed from their liability of sins through the birth of Mary. At the end of the hymn the poet says: 'Revered one [Anna], your birth giving is entirely holy: you gave birth to the boast of the world / *the acceptable intercession of humans*[45] / for she is a wall, and support, and haven for those who trust in her. / Every Christian has her as protection / and shelter of salvation and hope.'

In conclusion an aspect of Romanos' hymnography which remains literally 'unheard' by us has to be raised for discussion. We have every reason to believe that Constantinopolitans were acquainted with Romanos' image of Mary, for at that time hymnography was a medium of unique effect for addressing the masses. It was literature with which every Christian soul in the Empire came into contact, at least in theory, because it was chanted in church services. Unlike a homily, which was normally heard only once, a hymnographic text was heard again and again, indeed over centuries, if it was included in a liturgical calendar. Recently Johannes Koder has shown the relevance of Romanos' hymnography for Justinian's imperial propaganda.[46] Accordingly, it seems very likely that the image of Mary as mother and intercessor, as transmitted by the poetry of Romanos, was engraved on the minds of the early Byzantine people. From the viewpoint of the research on the early cult of Mary this is significant, for such image of Mary has been considered to be a reflection of a much later development, related to Iconoclasm (715-87 and 813-43). It seems necessary that Romanos' hymnography needs re-evaluation in respect to the Byzantine cult of Mary.

[43] No. 8, 18.5-8, transl. adapted from M. Carpenter, *Kontakia* I (1970).

[44] No. 35, transl. adapted from M. Carpenter, *Kontakia* II (1973).

[45] 10.2: τῶν ἀνθρώπων πρεσβείαν εὐπρόσδεκτον.

[46] Johannes Koder, Imperial Propaganda in the Kontakia of Romanos Melodos, a paper presented in the Colloquium on Romanos, organized by the Dumbarton Oaks and The Catholic University of America, Washington, DC, November 2005 (Forthcoming, *DOP* 62). See also Johannes Koder, Romanos Melodos und sein Publikum: Zur Einbeziehung und Beeinflussung der Zuhörer durch das Kontakion: *Anzeiger der phil.-hist. Klasse der ÖAW* 134 (1999) 63-94.

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Undressed: The Naked Female Body as a Sign of Holiness in Apocryphal and Hagiographical Literature

Francesca Di Marco, Firenze

A new concept of female nudity: the *Acta Pauli et Theclae*

During the 2nd century many writings telling of Jesus, Mary, and the Apostles rose and spread in Christian communities. Aspiring to be included among the holy scriptures, they were, in most cases, rejected from the coming canon of the New Testament, being considered forgeries, when not as the product of heresy by the establishing Church.[1] One of these tales, the *Acta Pauli et Theclae*, stages an unprecedented female character: Thecla.[2] The young girl presumably lived in the beginning of the Christian Era: the tale narrates that she was converted to Christianity while hearing Paul the Apostle preach from a nearby house. Thus, the traditional definition of *protomartyr*: although other *acta* and *passio* perhaps date earlier, the writer presumes Thecla to be the first woman to have translated Christian precepts into her life. This primacy gave her the

[1] See Bart D. Ehrman, *Lost Chistianities: The Battles for Scripture and the Faiths we Never Knew* (Oxford, 2003).

[2] The tale will become part of the wide *corpus* of the *Acta Apostolorum Apocrypha*, a group of writings which recall the Greek Novel and its many vicissitudes and adventures. The interesting apocryphal *corpus* has been drawing the attention of scholars for more than twenty years and boasts an ample bibliography; the work of the AELAC (*Association pour l'Étude de la Littérature Apocryphe Chrétienne*) has been fundamental for interpreting and contextualising these writings; the research group produces essays and critical editions and dedicates a journal, 'Apocrypha', to Christian apocryphal writings. Without claiming here any completeness, see: François Bovon, Michel van Esbroeck, Richard Goulet, Eric Junod (*et al.*), *Les actes apocryphes des apôtres: Christianisme et monde païen* (Genève, 1981); F. Bovon, Elizabeth Ann Graham Brock, Christopher R. Matthews, *The apocryphal acts of the Apostles:* Harvard Divinity School studies (Cambridge Mass., 1999); Virginia Burrus, *Chastity as Autonomy: women in the Stories of the Apocryphal Acts* (Lewiston Queenston, 1987); Jan Nicolas Bremmer, *The Apocryphal Acts of Paul and Thecla* (Kampen, 1996). For the Greek text of the *Acta Pauli et Theclae*, see Ricardus Adalbertus Lipsius, Maximilianus Bonnet (ed.), *Acta Apostolorum Apocrypha* (Hildesheim, $1959^2 = 1891$). About the links between the *Apocryphal Acts* and the ancient novel, see Francesco Corsaro, Elementi romanzeschi e aretalogia negli Atti Apocrifi di Paolo e Tecla. Codici e strutture formali, in: *La narrativa cristiana antica*, SEA 50 (Roma 1995), 77-90; Quintino Cataudella, Vite di santi e romanzo, in: *Letterature comparate, problemi e metodo, Studi in onore di E. Paratore* (Bologna 1981), II 931-52; Judith Perkins, Social Geography in the Apocryphal Acts of the Apostles, in: Michael Paschalis, Frangoulidis Stavros (eds.), *Space in the Ancient Novel* (Groningen, 2002), 118-31.

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strength of a normative character, transforming Thecla into a model, although hardly able to enact female holiness.

The construction of the Thecla-character hinges upon two particular qualities, two *charismata*: first, as we mentioned, she is a *martyr* and, consequently, she can be represented as *figura Christi* by the writer.[3] Second, according to the preaching of Paul which she heard from her window, she refuses her fiancée and marriage and chooses to live in chastity: she is a virgin.

It becomes difficult if not impossible to understand most of the tale, and especially the leading role played by Thecla – the role of a strong and free woman able to 'infect' other women or even female animals with her faith –,[4] without considering the importance of these two *charismata* and their eschatological value as signs of Thecla's proximity to Heaven. Although Thecla lives on Earth, the two martyrdoms and the choice of chastity seem to transform her into a heavenly creature. This particular *status* of the maiden is correlated to the development of a new idea of the female body and its nudity. The occasion for the bareness of the young girl is offered by the martyrdoms: in the first one, in Iconium, she is condemned to the stake, therefore she must be naked as imposed for the victims of this kind of torture.[5] In the second one, in Antiochia, she enters the arena and faces the beasts covered only by a διαζώστρα, a kind of short skirt: the persecutors force her to be naked as an additional punishment.[6] Nevertheless, Thecla never seems to be worried about her nakedness, on the contrary, undressed, she seems perfectly at ease; there is only one moment in the tale when the bareness of the girl seems inproper: during her self-baptism, hence, God covers the virgin with a cloud of fire.[7] At the end of the second martyrdom, this ease turns into explicit claim when the governor tells the girl to dress:

Καὶ ταῦτα ἀκούσας ὁ ἡγεμὼν ἐκέλευσεν ἐνεχθῆναι ἱμάτια καὶ εἶπεν· Ἔνδυσαι τὰ ἱμάτια. Ἡ δὲ εἶπεν· Ὁ ἐνδύσας με γυμνὴν ἐν τοῖς θηρίοις, οὗτος ἐν ἡμέρᾳ κρίσεως ἐνδύσει με σωτηρίαν. Καὶ λαβοῦσα τὰ ἱμάτια ἐνεδύσατο.

[3] At the end of the 2nd century C.E. the first *Acta* and *Passiones* had been written, so the representation of the martyr as *figura Christi* was already a *topos* in Christian literature. In the case of the martyr Thecla, we must notice that the two *martyria* she suffers are quite particular, as she survives both of them. In this way, the young girl seems to carry the characteristics she obtained in the liminal dimension of martyrdom – first of all the identification with Christ and the overcoming of the womanliness – into the *saeculum*.

[4] In Antioch (of Pisidia, most probably), the women of the town explicitly support Thecla claiming against her conviction, then they help the girl during her martyrdom by drugging the beasts with their perfumes and at the end of the trial, they profess the faith in 'The god of Thecla'. Furthermore, when the torture begins, a female lion protects her from the attacks of a female bear and of a male lion. See *Acta Pauli et Theclae* 28-39.

[5] AAPTh 22.

[6] AAPTh 33: Ἡ δὲ Θέκλα [...] ἐξεδύθη καὶ ἔλαβεν διαζώστραν καὶ ἐβλήθη εἰς τὸ στάδιον.

[7] AAPTh 34: καὶ ἦν περὶ αὐτὴν νεφέλη πυρός, ὥστε μήτε τὰ θηρία ἅπτεσθαι αὐτῆς, μήτε θεωρεῖσθαι αὐτὴν γυμνήν.

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And when the governor heard these words, he ordered for the clothes to be brought and said: 'Get dressed'. And she answered: 'He who dressed me when I was naked among the beasts, He will dress me with Salvation in the Last Judgement.' So she took the clothes, and got dressed.[8]

Of course, Thecla's answer refers to Paul's famous metaphors of 'dressing incorruptibility' (1*Cor.* 15:53-4); 'dressing Christ' (*Gal.* 3:27)'; dressing the new man' (*Col.* 3:9-10);[9] all passages in which the verb used for 'dress' is the same ἐνδύω as in the apocryphal tale. This reference helps to understand the specific meaning of Thecla's ease in nakedness and of her impudent reply. Thecla's body is not the weak result of female imperfection, it is no longer the symbol of Eve's sin: martyrdom and the grace of virginity have transformed the naked female body allowing it to prefigure, on Earth, the eschatological body that Christians will dress after the Resurrection. The eschatological dimension which Thecla's body has reached implies her overcoming the original sin, cause of woman's inferiority according to Genesis.[10] If the achievement of an eschatological dimension depends on the two martyrdoms that Thecla has suffered, as Christian witnesses cross the border between *saeculum* and afterworld in the moment the trial begins, the overcoming of Eve's inheritance is strictly linked to the *enkrateia* she embraced. Refusing marriage and motherhood, results of the first sin, and keeping her virginity, Thecla restores an Eden-like body, recovers the condition of woman before the Fall. It is important to stress that in the apocryphal writing the two characteristics, martyrdom and chastity, are both necessary and indispensable for the achievement of this special condition by the heroine.

Thus, the nakedness the persecutors had inflicted upon her as an additional punishment, becomes an element of strength rather than one of weakness, becoming at the same time both sign of Thecla's victory against her persecution, and against the *saeculum* itself. This complex mix of protological and eschatological elements in order to create a woman who can even be named apostle, sets a model which is very difficult to reach, when not impossible, for other women.[11] Of course, if she had been a man, she actually wouldn't have needed a so articulated path, like surviving two martyrdoms. Nevertheless, this model exists: the tale establishes the possibility for women not only to act upon

[8] AAPTh 38.

[9] See also *Rom.* 13:12-4; *Eph.* 4:24; 6:11.14; *Col.* 3:10-2; 1*Thess.* 5:8.

[10] *Gen.* 3. About the importance of protology in the Christian definition of a chastity-theory, see Pier Franco Beatrice, Le tuniche di pelle. Antiche letture di Gen 3,21, in: Umberto Bianchi (ed.), *La tradizione dell'enkrateia: Motivazioni ontologiche e protologiche* (Roma, 1985), 433-82; Giulia Sfameni Gasparro, *Enkrateia e antropologia* (Roma, 1984); *ead.*, Gli Atti apocrifi degli Apostoli e la tradizione dell' enkrateia: Discussione di una recente formula interpretativa: *Augustinianum* 23 (1983) 287-307.

[11] See Elena Giannarelli, Viaggi di rottura e di confine: Tecla di Seleucia, in: Dinora Corsi (ed.), *Altrove: Viaggi di donne dall'antichità al Novecento* (Roma, 1999), 223-40.

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Christian's precepts, but even to overcome that imperfection, that weakness which the Ancient thought defined as 'ontological' for women even by transforming its most material evidence: the body.

As (we have) just seen, a theological conception of the links between the original sin, the *enkrateia*, the body and the Salvation lies behind this apocryphal story. It's not an isolated idea, and it can be found in many writings especially in the East; in the Fourth century Gregory of Nyssa will enucleate it, transforming it into a definite theory which constitutes the main subject of his Περὶ Παρθενίας. This idea implies in *Acta Pauli et Theclae* a new concept of nakedness, even for female body, a concept which hardly agrees with the dictates of morality of the Ancient World –and not only the Ancient. Of course, nudity is first of all seen as a consequence of martyrdom. But during the torture, the virgin and martyr girl can show her naked body because she has overcome her womanliness: the body which lies without clothes in the arena is no longer a female body.

Agnes

Paying now attention to hagiographical literature, it becomes necessary to ask oneself if it is possible to find evidence of this particular concept of female nakedness in other stories of young virgins and martyrs. In spite of what one would believe, examined will be two of the various tales which tell the story of the symbol of modesty in ancient hagiography: Agnes.

It is necessary to take a chronological spring and start from an undated Greek *Passio* which can be found in the appendix of the dossier of Pio Franchi de' Cavalieri on Agnes.[12]

Here Agnes is quite different from the saint described by the various Latin sources. She is a virgin who publicly teaches with *parresia* the value of life in chastity. She preaches openly, as the ancient philosophers did,[13] and many women attend her lessons.[14] Maybe Hagné, the Pure, is not her name, but a nickname due to her lifestyle. The reason why Hagné deserves capital punishment is the same as the one for which Teocleia, Thecla's mother, asks for the

[12] Pio Franchi de' Cavalieri, S. Agnese nella tradizione e nella leggenda: *Studi e Testi* 221 (1962) 292-354, the text here considered is in *Appendice I*, 355-60.

[13] It must be noticed that the verb used to describe the coming of the women to Agnes' lessons is φοιτάω.

[14] The teaching of Agnes has a precedent in Thecla, who teaches in Trifena's house (APTh 39) and receives the apostolic consecration by Paul, who tells her Ὕπαγε καὶ δίδασκε τὸν λόγον τοῦ θεοῦ (APTh 41). Thecla's career as a teacher, although briefly described in the apocryphal tale, is an important element in the characterization of the Christian heroine: Methodius will choose this peculiar wisdom to make Thecla the Socrate of his Christian *Symposium*. See E. Giannarelli, Da Tecla a Santa Tecla: un caso di nemesi agiografica: *Sanctorum* 4 (2007) 47-62.

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death of her daughter: the women of the city are misled by this female model that refuses marriage and motherhood and is for this reason dangerous for (the) society.[15] Questioned by the governor, Agnes claims to be Christian according to a well-known *topos*; then she answers (to) the man who orders her to be publicly undressed:

Οὐ βλάψεις μου τῆς ψυχῆς τὴν εὐγένειαν, οὔτε τοῦ νοῦ τὸν ἀκέραιον· Σώματι σοι παρίσταμαι οἷον μοι ὁ πλαστουργὸς καὶ Θεὸς διέπλασεν, καὶ οὐκ αἰσχύνομαι τὴν γύμνωσιν ταύτην, ἀλλὰ μᾶλλον καυχῶμαι ἐν τοῖς στίγμασιν τοῦ κυρίου μου ἀγαλλιομένη.[16]

You will not damage the nobility of my soul nor the integrity of my mind: I stand in front of you with my body as the Creator and God moulded it and I'm not ashamed of this nakedness, rather I take glory and jubily in the signs of my Lord.

Agnes, the Pure, feels no shame in showing her naked body. Even though the first part of her answer seems to refer to a concept of interior purity, the claim that she is exposing nothing else rather than a divine creation reveals important implications. The 'body as the Creator and God moulded it' explicitly refers to Eden-like body, before Fall and Shame, before the partner of Adam was transformed into Eve, 'mother of all the living'. As in the case of Thecla, the exposure of nudity symbolizes that Agnes has overcome the womanliness and has transformed her body; in a word, sign of Holiness. The concept of body and nudity which emerges in this Greek *Passio* is evidently very close to the idea that has been evidenced in *Acta Pauli et Theclae*. The virgin's body becomes the *medium* for the miracles, acting as the material object through which God expresses his power.[17] In this sense, it is actually 'the Temple of God'.

It is now time to go back and examine one of the most ancient sources of Agnes' story: the epigraph of pope Damase engraved in the second half of the fourth century.[18] In this version Agnes is a very young girl who, in spite of her age and weakness, fearlessly faces persecution and torture. In the testimony of Damase, Agnes is condemned to the stake, like Thecla's first martyrdom and like the *Passio* that has been previously examined. As mentioned, nudity is an obligatory condition for this kind of torture. Here is the text:

[15] See APTh 20.

[16] P. Franchi De Cavalieri, S. Agnese, (1962), 357.

[17] After being exposed naked, the Greek *passio* narrates that Agnes is condemned to stay in a brothel as the governor wants her to be raped. None of the men is able to enter the brothel, until a boy comes, 'full of madness and bitter ardour', who enters and immediately falls down and dies. So, the governor asks Agnes about the death of the young man, and she explains that inside the brothel there was an angel protecting her; then, she resurrects the boy. We must notice that the miracle of resurrection in hagiography is attributed only to men, while alive women normally perform lower-degree miracles only in other women, or in men after death.

[18] The epigraph can be seen in the church of Saint Agnes in the via Nomentana in Rome. It has been edited by Maximilianus Ihm, *Damasi Epigrammata* (Lipsia, 1895), 43-4; Antonio Ferrua, *Epigrammata Damasiana* (Città del Vaticano, 1942), 175-8.

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Fama refert sanctos dudum retulisse parentes
Agnen, cum lugubres cantus tuba concrepuisset,
nutricis gremium subito liquisse puellam,
sponte trucis calcasse minas rabiemque tyranni.
urere cum flammis voluisset nobile corpus,
viribus inmensum parvis superasse timorem,
nudaque profusum crinem per membra dedisse,
ne domini templum facies peritura videret.
o veneranda mihi, sanctum decus, alma, pudoris,
ut Damasi precibus faveas precor, inclyta martyr.

Not being able to comment on the entire *carmen*, in spite of the many suggestions it offers, verses 7-8 will be here analyzed:

[The story tells that Agnes] spread her loose hair over her naked limbs
so that the perishable appearance could not see the Temple of God.

Agnes lets her hair down in order to cover her naked body: in some later *Passiones* this event becomes a miracle and suddenly her hair grows out of all proportion.[19] Of course, according to Paul 1*Cor.* 11:15, hair is the natural covering of women. What can immediately be noticed is the importance of the position of the adjective *nuda*, which is at the beginning of the verse. The next verse offers very interesting clues. The translation presents some difficulties due to the not easy to understand *iunctura facies peritura*. The edition of Ihm doesn't help, as he writes '*i.e. ne corpus nudatum videret*'[20]; Ferrua notices that *facies peritura* must be interpreted as *facies hominis mortalis*, and he quotes as comparison Apul., *Met* IV,30; Hor., *Carm* I, 28,6; II, 3,4; Lucan., II, 524; Sen., *Ep.* 77,12,[21] but none of these passages seem to illuminate the specific sense of the syntagma.

The meaning of the expression can be understood in correlation with the other *iunctura, domini templum,* which is a Pauline quotation from 1*Cor.* 3:16-7; 6:19; 2*Cor.* 6:16. The martyr's body is the Temple of God, its naked limbs are Christ's limbs. As the Temple of God, Agnes' body is projected on the eschatological dimension even before the end of the torture. It is the pure body which will resurrect and constitute the earthly image of that resurrected body. To this eschatological and imperishable Temple-of-God-body, Damasus opposes the *facies peritura*, the perishable appearance of the persecutor or of anyone who watches the torture. Therefore, the word *facies* describes a mutable appearance, an accident that time will erase; quoting again Paul, it is the corruptible which will never 'dress with incorruptibility' (1*Cor.* 15:53-4) and it is possible to suggest that *peritura* actually translates the Pauline φθαρτός. Hence, Agnes covers herself not for virginal modesty, but because impious eyes, perishable bodies

[19] See PG 116, 609-52.
[20] M. Ihm, *Damasi Epigrammata* (1895), 44.
[21] A. Ferrua, *Epigrammata* (1942), 176.

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are not allowed to see the mystery which is fulfilled in the virgin's body. Like the shameless nakedness of Thecla and of Agnes in the Greek *Passio*, even the covering of Damasus' Agnes lies upon eschatological reasons. Going back to the fourth verse:

sponte trucis calcasse minas rabiemque tyranni

[The story tells that Agnes] willingly trampled on the threats and the rage of the tyrant.

The use of the verb *calcare* seems not to be fortuitous. This may refer to the book of *Genesis* 3:15, the prophecy regarding the woman who will crush the head of the serpent which attempts to her heel. The recalling of *Gen.* 3:15 referring to a female martyr is not new: it occurs, for example, in the *Passio Perpetuae* 4.7,[22] when Perpetua tells of a vision she had in prison which prefigures the victory of the Christian woman against the persecutor; the verb is the same *calcare*:

Et desub ipsa scala, [draco] quasi timens me, lente eiecit caput. Et quasi primum gradum calcarem, calcaui illi caput et ascendi.

Slowly, as though he were afraid of me, the dragon stuck his head out from underneath the ladder. Then, using it as my first step, I stepped on his head and climbed. [23]

Again, the verb occurs in the fourth vision when Perpetua sees herself transformed into a male and fighting against an Egyptian man, who, obviously, is *figura diaboli*; at the end of the fight, the woman tramples on the enemy's head and wins:

Et sublata sum in aere et coepi eum sic caedere quasi terram non calcans. At ubi vidi moram fieri, iunxi manus ut digitos in digitos mitterem et apprehendi illi caput; et cecidi in faciem et calcaui illi caput.[24]

Then I was raised up into the air and began to pummel him without as it were touching the ground. Then, when I noticed there was a lull, I put my two hands together linking the fingers of one hand with those of the other hand and thus I got hold of his head. He fell flat on his face and I stepped on his head.[25]

Agnes is a woman and Eve's sin stains her, despite her being a virgin: she must overcome her womanliness and redeem herself. If this interpretation is accepted, we may be ascertained that even in Damasus' *epigramma* the female martyr needs the mention of the overcoming of the original sin to reach the eschatological dimension and to fulfil the body's transformation. If Damasus' Agnes

[22] See Herbert Musurillo, *Acts of the Christian Martyrs*, (Oxford, 1972), 106-31.
[23] H. Musurillo, *Acts* (1972), 111.
[24] *Passio Perpetuae* 10,11.
[25] H. Musurillo, *Acts* (1972), 119.

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does not expose her nudity, it is not because of a different idea of the virgin-martyr's body from the apocryphal tale and from the Greek *passio*. Damasus' attitude towards the transfiguration of the body seems to be rather different, seen as a mystery which must be hidden from the persecutor's eyes.

Nevertheless, it must be noticed that the Pope includes modesty as a fundamental quality in the construction of Agnes-character: in the final invocation, she is called *sanctum decus pudoris*, 'holy dignity of modesty'.

The bishop of Rome was involved in promoting the cult of roman martyrs: Lawrence and Agnes are the saints whom the Christian community chooses as its first ancestors.[26] Therefore, the story of Agnes, like the one of Thecla, intends to play an exemplar role. If Thecla is considered *protomartyr*, on the other hand Agnes represents the paradigmatic martyr of the new capital of Christianity: a great responsibility. Although the bishop of Rome accepts the theological conceptions of the virgin-martyr's body being the earthly sign of the resurrected bodies, the construction of a saint must agree with traditional and consolidated characteristics and values: modesty is the indispensable virtue of a virgin. By reading the *epigramma* it can be evinced that the bishop knew little about Agnes' story, that he was not able to trace any certain information about her life: *fama refert*. For this reason, he was probably in the condition of choosing freely the character of the martyr and selecting the appropriate models. An interesting reference in Ovid, *Met,* 13,479-80 is found in the analysis of the *iunctura decus pudoris*:

tunc quoque cura fuit partes velare tegendas,
cum caderet, castique decus servare pudoris.

In that moment [of the death] she took care to cover those parts that were to be covered as she fell, and to keep the dignity of chaste modesty.

The dying maiden worried about hiding her body from indiscrete eyes and preserving the *decus casti pudoris* until the end is Polyxena. The myth tells that Achilles' ghost wanted her as his bride, therefore she was sacrificed on his grave. The choice of Polyxena as a model is an important element in the characterization of Agnes. The young heroine was a symbol of virginal modesty and, at the same time, of bravery and strength in facing her terrible death, and was a famous character: Euripides, Seneca, Ovid had written about her. This young woman who spontaneously faces sacrifice and claims to prefer death to a life of slavery,[27] must have seemed like a kind of *ante litteram* martyr to the first Christians. Moreover, in Christian thought, any life in *saeculum* is considered as a life of slavery when compared to eternal life, and as Polyxena dies to join a ghost groom, Christian virgins are said to marry an unbodily groom,

[26] See Dennis Trout, Damasus and the Invention of Early Christian Rome: *Journal of Medievel and Early Modern Studies* 33 (2003) 517-36; Marianne Sághy, Scinditur in partes populus: Pope Damasus and the Martyrs of Rome: *Early Medievel Europe* 3 (2000) 273-87.

[27] See Eur., *Hec.* 547ff.

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Christ. Because of these many reasons, she was particularly suitable as a 'source of inspiration' in the construction of female martyr models. Indeed, Damasus' choice is not isolated. The hymn attributed to Ambrose of Milan explicitly recalls Euripides' Polyxena in describing the death of Agnes;[28] again, in his *Epistles*, Ambrose attributed to Pelagia the words of Polyxena.[29] Nevertheless, Damasus' choice changes the characterization of the virgin-martyr as the one who overcame womanliness and transformed her body. The reference to Polyxena, the 'dignity of modesty' designed as a basic quality for the young girl are elements which seem useful in order to 'normalize' the model proposed to the Christian girl. Probably, the ease in nakedness as represented in Thecla's story, with all its eschatological and protological consequences, resulted unpresentable – when not subversive – for Damasus' purpose. That is to create a virgin martyr character as a model for people of Roman Christian community. Moreover, the theological theory which could easily justify that, was little known among the people and too difficult to be explained. So, the damasian *epigramma* reveals great interest, as it tries to balance between nudity and modesty, new eschatology and traditional values, even Roman ones. Agnes is represented naked, as all the stake victims, but she is covered by her hair to hide the mystery of her transformation; she is, however, a model of modesty, as a virgin is requested to be, and Polyxena comes to put her seal on this articulated construction. The 'Agneses' of Ambrosian or pseudo-Ambrosian hymn,[30] of Ambrose's *De Virginibus*, of Prudentius,[31] represent only the model of extreme modesty, and the girl will play the role of the virgin bride of Christ, that is the role of the woman who, as in earthly marriage, subordinates herself to a male authority, even if divine.[32] Ambrose's Agnes does not only share the action of extreme modesty with Polyxena, as she dies in the same way the tragic heroin does: by sword, transfixed or beheaded. The different kind of torture offers an evident advantage: the *decapitatio* or the *iugulatio* does not request a naked victim, as the stake does. This does not want to lead in affirming that Polyxena's model alone made the kind of torture change: the issue of

[28] See Ambroise de Milan, *Hymnes*, ed. Jacques Fontaine (Paris, 1992), 8, 25-8: *Percussa, quam pompam tulit!/ Nam vestem se tota tegens,/ curam pudoris praestitit/ ne quis retectam cerneret*; Euripides, *Hec*, 568-70: [...] ἡ δὲ καὶ θνήσκουσ'ὅμως /πολλὴν πρόνοιαν εἶχεν εὐσχήμως πεσεῖν, /κρύπτουσ'ἃ κρύπτειν ὅμματ'ἀρσένων χρέων; P. Franchi de' Cavalieri, S. Agnese (1962), 299-301.

[29] See Ambr., *Ep.* II 7, 38-40; Eur., *Hec.* 548-51

[30] The version of Agnes' martyrdom that Ambrose gives in *De virginibus* I 2,5-9 is quite different from the one the hymn narrates, so that many scholars consider the hymn as pseudo-Ambrosian. See Ambroise de Milan, *Hymnes* (1992), 363-74.

[31] Prudentius, *Peristephanon*, XIV.

[32] See Leonie Hayne, Thecla and the Church Fathers: *VigChr* 48 (1994) 209-18; Vincenza Milazzo, *Educare una vergine: Precetti e modelli in Ambrogio e Gerolamo* (Catania, 2002), 109f.; V. Burrus, Reading Agnes: the Rhetoric of Gender in Ambrose and Prudentius: *Journal of Early Christian Studies* 3 (1995) 25-46.

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Agnes' testimonies is complex, and seems hard to settle, only considering that two different versions of the martyrdom lie inside the Ambrosian *corpus*. It can however be thought that the stake was actually considered improper as a torture for a girl who should be *exemplum* of modesty: the writer who was in condition of choosing a more convenient death, because of the ambiguity or the poorness of the sources, surely did. Ambrose, however, seems to have few qualms in changing even written sources in the name of modesty. Thus, when he tells the second martyrdom of Thecla in *De Virginibus* II, 19-20, he describes the girl as worried for her nakedness and imagines that even the beasts didn't dare look at the naked virgin.[33] L. Hayne suggests that the model of Agnes was promoted by Ambrose as a virgin-martyr rival of Thecla.[34] Indeed it is an interesting hypothesis: Ambrose does not like the ease of nakedness and therefore 'rewrites' Thecla. However he cannot avoid mentioning her: she was very famous. A different *exemplum* of the virgin-martyr was necessary. Furthermore, we must consider that not only *one* Agnes exists: the Hagné of the Greek *Passio* reveals many similarities with the heroine of the Apocryphal Acts, not only in the concept of nudity. In addition, Damasus' Agnes tries to balance between eschatological theory and requirements of moral edification. The model of modesty-Agnes, the new Polyxena, seems rather to be an answer to versions of Agnes' martyrdom which recalled the apocryphal heroine; perhaps, even an answer to the representation of nakedness as a sign of holiness. This idea, in fact, must have never convinced the *pars occidentis*, whose Church seems to have always been more linked to traditional values.

Hence, the use of nakedness as a category of investigation seems to trace a path through the labyrinth of the many versions of Agnes' martyrdom. Moreover, it helps orientate towards the complex issue of the creation of models in Ancient Christianity. Once again, one faces very different solutions to the same issue in the East and in the West.

[33] 'Thecla doceat immolari, quae copulam fugiens nuptialem et sponsi furore damnata naturam etiam bestiarum virginitatis veneratione mutavit. Namque parata ad feras, cum aspectus quoque declinaret virorum ac vitalia ipsa saevo offerret leoni, fecit ut qui impudicos detulerant oculos pudicos referrent.'

[34] L. Hayne, Thecla (1994), 210.

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Asceticism in the Early Dormition Narratives

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Asceticism is a surprisingly marginal theme in the earliest Dormition narratives. When compared with the various fourth-century efforts to model female virginity after the Blessed Virgin, the relative absence of the ascetic impulse from these early apocrypha is somewhat striking. Beginning it would appear with Athanasius, the church fathers increasingly called female virgins to imitate the model established by the Virgin Mary.[1] Others would follow, including Ambrose and Jerome, as well as Cyril of Jerusalem and Gregory of Nazianzus, all of whom proposed Mary's virginity as the ideal to which Christian women should aspire.[2] Yet this idea is strangely missing from earliest Dormition narratives. Even more peculiar, however, is the manner in which asceticism figures in the earliest Dormition narrative, the *Liber Requiei* (or *Obsequies of the Virgin*), whose treatment of this topic holds important clues for understanding the early history of this text.

This ancient Christian apocryphon survives intact only in an Ethiopic translation, although substantial fragments exist in Syriac, Georgian, and Coptic. The earliest manuscript witness is a Syriac palimpsest from the later fifth century, but internal elements suggest its composition much earlier, probably in the third century.[3] The *Liber Requiei*'s representation of ascetic practice appears to confirm its early origins, almost certainly sometime before Mary became, as it were, the 'poster girl' for female asceticism in the fourth century. This apocryphon

[1] Louis-Théophile Lefort (ed.), *S. Athanase: Lettres festales et pastorales en copte*, 2 vols., CSCO 150-1 (Louvain, 1955), vol. 1, 73-99; David Brakke, *Athanasius and the Politics of Asceticism* (Oxford, 1995), 52-4, 70-3, 276-9.

[2] See Ambrose, *De virg.* 2 (PL 16, 220-2); Jerome, *Adv. Helv.* (PL 23, 183-206); Cyril of Jerusalem, *Catech.* 12.34 (PG 33, 768A-769A); Gregory of Nazaianzus, *Carm.* 1.2.2, 189-208 (PG 37, 537A-538A). See also Jaroslav Pelikan, *Mary through the Centuries* (New Haven, 1996), 113-22; Peter Brown, *The Body and Society* (New York, 1988), 353-6. *Pace* Hans von Campenhausen, *The Virgin Birth in the Theology of the Ancient Church*, trans. Frank Clarke (London, 1964), 63-7.

[3] Stephen J. Shoemaker, *Ancient Traditions of the Virgin Mary's Dormition and Assumption* (Oxford, 2002), 32-46, 205-78. See also Michel van Esbroeck, Bild und Begriff in der Transitus-Literatur, der Palmbaum und der Tempel, in: *Typus, Symbol, Allegorie bei den östlichen Vätern und ihren Parallelen im Mittelalter*, ed. Margot Schmidt (Regensburg, 1982), 333-51; Michel van Esbroeck, Some Earlier Features in the Life of the Virgin: *Marianum* 63 (2001) 297-308; Richard Bauckham, *The Fate of the Dead: Studies on Jewish and Christian Apocalypses* (Leiden, 1998), 344-6.

Studia Patristica XLIV, 509-513.
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not only fails to link Mary clearly with the practice of female continence, but it misses some key opportunities to do so, such as Peter's parables of the virgin and of the two servants.[4] Instead, Mary is here more strongly associated with maternity, bearing such titles as 'mother of the whole world' and 'mother of the Twelve', for instance.[5] Yet far more remarkable are the explicit links forged in this apocryphon between Mary's departure from this world and an unmistakable call for strict moderation of ascetic practice.

The *Liber Requiei*'s critique of extreme asceticism unfolds in a dramatic scene near the end of the apocryphon, witnessed not only by the Ethiopic text and the fifth-century Syriac fragments but also found in the early Irish version, a translation made sometime before 700 CE.[6] The episode begins just after the apostles have placed Mary in her tomb, as they sit outside waiting for Christ to return and take his mother's body, according to his instructions. Paul then asks Peter to share with him the 'great and glorious mystery' that Christ revealed to Peter and the others on the Mount of Olives, since, as Paul explains, he is a recent convert who 'did not meet the master'. Peter replies that while he is pleased Paul has become a Christian, he and the others cannot reveal the mystery to Paul, for it would frighten him. Instead, when Christ returns after three days, they will ask him what to do, and if he allows, they will share their secret knowledge with Paul. A rather garbled passage follows, leading into a story about laughing demons taken from the *Testament of Solomon*, apparently narrated by Paul. When Paul has finished, the apostles propose that he speak further, hoping to distract him so that he would not press them further to reveal the secret mysteries. Paul responds in essence with a question, asking '[since] you are not willing to reveal the greatness of Christ our Savior to me, tell me, when you go forth to preach, what will you teach, so that I will teach from your doctrine.'[7]

Thus begins a conversation among several of the key apostles concerning the practices that they enjoin on their newly made Christian converts.[8] Peter,

[4] *Liber Requiei* 60-5; Victor Arras, *De transitu Mariae apocrypha aethiopice*, 2 vols, CSCO 342-3, 351-2 (Louvain, 1973) I 34-9 (Eth.) and 23-6 (Lat.); transl. S. Shoemaker, *Ancient Traditions* (2002), 322-4. See also Michel van Esbroeck, Apocryphes géorgiens de la Dormition: *AB* 92 (1973) 55-75, 61 (Geor.) and 65 (Lat.).

[5] *Liber Requiei* 40, 43; V. Arras, *De transitu* (1973) I 23, 26 (Eth.) and 15, 17 (Lat.); transl. S. Shoemaker, *Ancient Traditions* (2002), 314, 316.

[6] On the date of the Irish version, see Charles Donahue, *The Testament of Mary: The Gaelic Version of the Dormitio Mariae together with an Irish Latin Version* (New York, 1942), 25-7; Máire Herbert and Martin McNamara, *Irish Biblical Apocrypha* (Edinburgh, 1989), xxi, 184.

[7] *Liber Requiei* 78-84; V. Arras, *De transitu* (1973) I 45-50 (Eth.) and 30-3 (Lat.); transl. S. Shoemaker, *Ancient Traditions* (2002), 332-7; William Wright, *Contributions to the Apocryphal Literature of the New Testament* (London, 1865), ܢ-ܢ (Syr.) and 42-4 (Engl.); C. Donahue, *Testament of Mary* (1942), 40-3.

[8] *Liber Requiei* 85-6; V. Arras, *De transitu* (1973) I 50-1 (Eth.) and 33 (Lat.); transl. S. Shoemaker, *Ancient Traditions* (2002), 337-8; W. Wright, *Contributions* (1865), ܢ-ܢ (Syr.) and 44-5 (Engl.); C. Donahue, *Testament of Mary* (1942), 42f.

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thinking this an excellent idea, begins: 'When I go forth to preach', he says, 'I will say that anyone who does not fast all of his days will not see God.' Peter's answer surprises Paul, who asks almost in disbelief if Peter really preaches such a doctrine, supposing that when the people hear this, 'they will rise up and kill us, because they worship gods and do not believe in God, nor in fasting.' Hoping for a somewhat more realistic response, Paul turns to John, who answers: 'When I go forth to teach and preach, I will say that anyone who is not a virgin all of his days will not be able to see God.' Again Paul is rather astonished by such strict preaching, asking John: 'What are you saying? They will not believe in what you say, because they are people who worship trees and stones. If they hear this from us, they will stone us.' Disappointed with what he has heard from Peter and John, Paul turns hopefully to Andrew: perhaps Peter preaches such a stern message because he is a great bishop, and John because of his own commitment to virginity. Yet Andrew's preaching is even more severe, and he warns his new converts that 'everyone who does not leave father and mother, and brothers and sisters, and children and houses, and everything that he has, and go forth after our Lord, he will not be able to see God.' Paul can hardly believe his ears: 'Andrew, the words of Peter and John are light compared with yours, for you have separated everyone from the earth in a single moment. For who will hear your words at this time and place a heavy burden on himself?'

The three apostles, having suffered Paul's critique, turn the tables, asking Paul what he would have them preach instead. He responds to the encratic preaching of Peter, John, and Andrew with a message of ascetic moderation, focused on marital fidelity (instead of celibacy), almsgiving (as opposed to strict poverty), and only limited periods of fasting.[9] Not surprisingly, the other apostles disagree with Paul's program of moderate asceticism and begin to murmur against him. Then, as the apostles stand outside the Virgin's tomb disputing the value of the ascetic life, Christ suddenly descends from heaven with Michael to claim his mother's body.[10] Quickly bringing the debate to an end, Christ declares Paul the uncontested victor, saying: 'Greetings Paul, the advisor of good things. Truly I say to you, Peter, that your advice was always destructive: yours and Andrew's and John's. But I say to you that you should receive that of Paul, for I see that the whole world will be caught in Paul's net.' Then, after promising to reveal the hidden mysteries to Paul, Christ brings Mary's body to Paradise in the company of the apostles.

[9] *Liber Requiei* 87; V. Arras, *De transitu* (1973) I 51-2 (Eth.) and 34 (Lat.); transl. S. Shoemaker, *Ancient Traditions* (2002), 338f.; W. Wright, *Contributions* (1865), ܕܣ-ܒܠ (Syr.) and 45 (Engl.).

[10] *Liber Requiei* 88; V. Arras, *De transitu* (1973) I 52 (Eth.) and 34 (Lat.); transl. S. Shoemaker, *Ancient Traditions* (2002), 339f.; W. Wright, *Contributions* (1865), ܒܠ (Syr.) and 45f. (Engl.); C. Donahue, *Testament of Mary* (1942), 42-5.

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This episode is remarkable for a number of reasons, only a few of which can be touched on here. For instance, after the second century such ringing endorsements of marriage in the face of a call to celibacy become increasingly rare. As David Hunter notes in his recent monograph (following Peter Brown), the third century saw the rise of a 'moderate encratism', which, while not fully condemning marriage, could not allow its equality in comparison with the celibate life.[11] By the fourth century such ideas could lead to trouble, as Helvidius and Jovinian remind us.[12] All the more striking, however, is to find such moderate views joined to this pivotal moment in the life of the Virgin, as her son arrives dramatically to retrieve her virginal body and takes the occasion to chastise the ascetic extremism of his disciples in favor of Paul's endorsement of marriage and moderation. In comparison with the Mariological and ascetic literature of the fourth century and later, it is quite surprising to find the Virgin's life used here as a platform for ideas of ascetic restraint, seemingly aimed at married householders rather than world-renouncing virgins. This unusual feature certainly suggests the *Liber Requiei*'s composition sometime before this image of the Virgin Mary had become the norm, adding to a list of other anomalies that point toward an early date for this text, probably in the third century.

Likewise, the specific issues addressed in this section indicate something about the particular milieu in which the text first arose. The ideas of Peter, John, and Andrew are redolent of a kind of encratism such as one finds associated with Marcion and Tatian as well as in the apocryphal acts and certain other early Christian apocrypha. The question of whether all Christians must be held to these high standards of practice is a fairly early one, characteristic of the second and third centuries.[13] As Jean Gribomont observes in his brief study of this 'second apostolic council' of Jerusalem, it would appear that this apocryphon had been composed prior to the establishment of monasticism, which essentially resolved the problem by creating two classes of Christians.[14]

Even more telling is the peculiar status of Paul among the apostles in this early Dormition narrative, a feature that strongly suggests its relatively early composition. From his initial appearance, Paul's status as an apostle seems to be in question and is defended vigorously by the *Liber Requiei*. Yet the issues in focus in this controversy over Paul are not observance of the Law, as one might expect, but instead the knowledge of secret mysteries and appropriate

[11] David G. Hunter, *Marriage, Celibacy, and Heresy in Ancient Christianity: The Jovinianist Controversy* (Oxford, 2007), 113-15; P. Brown, *Body and Society* (1988), 138-9.

[12] David G. Hunter, Helvidius, Jovinian, and the Virginity of Mary in Late Fourth-Century Rome: *JECS* 1 (1993) 47-71. See now also D. Hunter, *Marriage* (2007), esp. 130-42.

[13] See, *e.g.*, P. Brown, *Body and Society* (1988), 83-102, 154-9.

[14] Jean Gribomont, Le plus ancien Transitus Marial et l'encratisme: *Aug* 23 (1983) 237-47, 246.

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levels of ascetic practice. When apostles first arrive in Jerusalem, having miraculously flown in on clouds from the ends of the earth, the *Liber Requiei* apologizes for Paul's presence alongside Peter and the others, explaining that Paul too was one of the apostles and held the Christian faith with them.[15] This merely foreshadows, however, the much more dramatic episode to follow outside the Virgin's tomb. Here the issue of Paul's authority is confronted directly, as Paul himself mouths the words of his detractors, acknowledging his inexperience and the fact that he never met nor was taught by the Lord. He admits that he does not know the fullness of the secret mysteries that Christ taught his disciples and pleads with the others to divulge these to him. Yet the other apostles are not certain that Paul has the capacity to receive these mysteries, and consequently they insist on waiting for Christ to return so that he may decide. The apostolic conference on preaching ensues, revealing that the differences between Paul and the others involve more than just a matter of who had followed Christ from Galilee to Jerusalem. Their theological differences are brought into relief as members of 'the Twelve' outline an encratic gospel while Paul urges moderation as a more effective strategy for bringing new souls into the fold.

This confrontation suggests that the *Liber Requiei* arose within a context where there was division between one group of Christians dedicated to a strict asceticism who looked to the authority of the Twelve while rejecting Paul, and another group, with which the *Liber Requiei* is aligned, advocating a more moderate ascetic program and claiming sanction from the apostle Paul. Such a *Sitz im Leben* would appear to belong to the earliest Christian centuries, probably the second or third century, inasmuch as opposition to Paul is largely confined to this era.[16] The closest parallels to the *Liber Requiei*'s defense of Paul in response to encratism occur in book three of Clement of Alexandria's *Stromateis*,[17] and both Origen and Eusebius report encratite groups from this period that rejected Paul's authority.[18] While it is not impossible that the *Liber Requiei* responds to some minor, later group, on the whole the second or third century, and more likely the latter, provides a much more plausible context for this apocryphon.[19]

[15] *Liber Requiei* 46; V. Arras, *De transitu* (1973) I 28 (Eth.) and 18 (Lat.); transl. S. Shoemaker, *Ancient Traditions* (2002), 316.

[16] See Gerd Luedemann, *Opposition to Paul in Jewish Christianity*, transl. M. Eugene Boring (Minneapolis, 1989), esp. 197.

[17] D. Hunter, *Marriage* (2007), 107-10.

[18] Origen, *C. Cels.* V 65 (SC 147, 174-5); Eusebius, *HE* IV 29 (SC 31, 213-14).

[19] Perhaps one should not completely exclude the possibility that this scene was intended to address the Marcionites, by essentially co-opting Paul as an advocate of ascetic moderation and portraying his knowledge of the mysteries as inferior to that of the Twelve. Nevertheless, the absence of larger themes such as dualism or the rejection of Judaism and the Hebrew Bible make this interpretation somewhat unlikely.

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Desire, Longing and Fear in the Narrative of Middle-Byzantine Homiletics

Niki TSIRONIS, Athens

Here, in Oxford, in the late 1980s Ruth Finnegan opened the symposium on orality in medieval and Modern Greek poetry, with an extraordinary critical account of the ways in which orality had been used by researchers until then and set the agenda for a pioneering meeting which, unfortunately, did not have the impact one would have expected.[1] In the field of Byzantine literature, it was Michael and Elizabeth Jeffreys who suggested new ways of applying the theory of orality in all its complexity and diversity to medieval vernacular poetry,[2] and Averil Cameron who addressed a number of complicated issues related to Christian discourse of the Byzantine period.[3] Ten years ago, the project launched by Mary Cunningham and Pauline Allen had an impact on our discipline, addressing as it did the topic of *Preacher and Audience*.[4] As a junior researcher at the time, I was generously given the opportunity to participate in that project which eventually influenced my own approach to the *genre* of homiletics. From the outset I should mention that the theory of orality should not be conceived as a concise and clearly defined theory, as orality itself is a complicated issue that implies more of an epistemological approach than a set of rules that can be applied in order to obtain specific results.[5] As far as homiletics is concerned, it might be more appropriate to refer to oral elements rather than *formulae* as such. The distinct approach of oral-formulaic theories as opposed to performance-orientated ones gives us a hint about the diversity of approaches to orality.[6]

[1] Ruth Finnegan, What is Orality – if Anything?: *BMGS* 14 (1990) 130-49; Peter Mackridge, Orality in Medieval and Modern Greek Poetry: Introduction: *BMGS* 14 (1990) 123-8.

[2] Michael Jeffreys, Formulas in the Chronicle of the Moreas, in: Elizabeth and Michael Jeffreys, *Popular Literature in Late Byzantium* (London, 1983).

[3] Averil Cameron, *Christianity and the Rhetoric of Empire: The Development of Christian Discourse*, Sather Classical Lectures 55 (Berkeley-Los Angeles-Oxford, 1991), *passim* and esp. 79-87.

[4] The results of the project were published by Brill in a collected studies volume edited by Mary Cunningham and Pauline Allen under the title *Preacher and Audience: Studies in Early Christian and Byzantine Homiletics* (Leiden, 1998).

[5] P. Mackridge, Orality in Medieval and Modern Greek Poetry (1990), 125-7.

[6] R. Finnegan, What is Orality (1990), 132-5. As a standard work on the oral-formulaic theory (and bibliography) see the introduction by Gregory Nagy and Stephen Mitchell to the second edition of A. Lord, *The Singer of Tales* (Cambridge Mass., 2000 [1st ed. 1960]) and J.M. Foley, *The Theory of Oral Composition: History and Methodology* (Bloomington and Indianapolis,

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In the past, the frequent use of literary *topoi* as well as the repetitive nature of homilies had discouraged researchers who dismissed the *genre* as devoid of artistry and meaning. As the *genre* refers to timeless reality associated with feasts of the Church, it was thought to have little to say about historical circumstances, with the exception of occasional homilies, best represented by the sermons of Patriarch Photius of Constantinople.[7] The term 'homiletics' suggests in itself an oral *genre* meant to be delivered within a liturgical context, in front of an audience and for a specific purpose. The Cunningham-Allen project provided us, among other things, with material on the way homilies were composed and transmitted. Despite the important contribution of scholars there is as yet no detailed study of the particular characteristics of the genre of homiletics, focusing on the use of *topoi*. I shall now concentrate on one such *topos*, looking at content and function within the narrative.

Desire attracts me but fear repels me ..., is a statement often employed by homilists of the middle-Byzantine period. The topic of desire and longing as contrasted to fear, is such a recurrent antithetical scheme that we may consider it as one of the standard *topoi* of the *genre* of homiletics. By *topos* we mean a set phrase employed in the narrative, with the implication that it does not contain any information worth studying as it represents a blind repetition common to many texts and irrelevant to the context of the discourse. The English translation of *topos* as a 'literary commonplace' betrays exactly the same notion. Among the numerous *topoi* employed in homiletics, such as the image of the heavenly banquet, the participation of nature, etc. I have singled out the antithetical pattern of desire and fear, because as a topic it lends itself to the content analysis of a case study. When homilists of the middle-Byzantine period employ the *topos* in question they intend to evoke the daunting task they are called upon to carry out, that is, to speak about the feast of the day (in most cases linked to the mystery of the Incarnation of the Word and the subsequent salvation of mankind). In some instances, it may be considered as part of the humility *topos* by which the preacher debases himself through extreme humility in order to exalt the significance of the occasion. This is more or less an accepted position of modern scholarship. What has not, however, attracted attention yet is the fact that every single *topos* may be studied as a closed nut that, once properly cracked, affords insight into the anthropological conceptions of the period. It is to this end that I would like to draw your attention to

1988), as well as Foley's previous work, *Oral-Formulaic Theory and Research* (New York, 1985). For the performance approach see E.H. Hymes, Breakthrough into performance, in: Dan Ben-Amos and Kennteth S. Goldstein (eds.), *Folklore: Performance and Communication* (Mouton, 1975), 11-74. For a critical approach to both 'schools' see R. Finnegan, *Literacy and Orality: Studies in the Technology of Communication* (Oxford, 1988) and *ead.*, What is Orality (1990), *passim*.

[7] See the Introduction by Mary Cunningham and Pauline Allen to the volume *Preacher and Audience* (1998), 1-20 and esp. 7.

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the *topos* of desire and fear, exploring first its Biblical background, and second, through select examples, the use of the specific *topos* in the narrative of homiletics. The variants in which the specific *topos* appears in middle-Byzantine literature will be explored on the basis of formulaic theory, as expressed by Parry and Lord (with reference to the composition method of heroic poetry) in the first decades of the twentieth century and elaborated recently by their successors.[8]

Desire and fear occupy an important place in the Bible, where both feelings are directed towards God. Biblical references could by themselves be the topic of an entire paper.[9] For example, in *Genesis*, Adam hides himself upon hearing the voice of God out of fear, for he is aware of the wrong he has done. God endows Adam with desire in order to ensure his survival in the world outside paradise. Fear also appears in the New Testament, where it is presented as the contrary of love: 'There is no fear in love; but perfect love casteth out fear: because fear hath torment. He that feareth is not made perfect in love' (*John* 4:18). The passage is particularly relevant to the topic in question since the two feelings are clearly and acutely juxtaposed, one annulling the other. But this is a context slightly different from the one we encounter in middle-Byzantine homiletics, where both desire and fear are employed in the discourse and narrative.

Desire with its erotic connotations is employed in Christian literature in the most elevated context of divine love.[10] Similarly, the feeling of fear is associated with the awe a person feels before God. In the Divine Liturgy, the celebrating priest bids his flock to receive Holy Communion with the words: μετὰ φόβου Θεοῦ ... προσέλθετε (*in the fear of God ... come forth*). In the context of the relationship between man and God the feeling of fear has the nuance of awe that fills human beings before the concept and the experience of the living God. It denotes the dread and the wonder of approaching the sacred.

It is an impressive fact that the *topos* of desire as distinct from fear is so accurate in terms of modern psychology. The dipole desire/fear associated with the polar opposites of love/hate does not refer to the final result (whether love or hatred) but to their root, i.e. either desire or fear. If we examine the feeling of love or hate we shall see it represents the outcome of a process at the root of which lies either desire or fear: the development of these feelings presupposes stages where the archetypal feelings of attraction-repulsion are nurtured, tested in time and eventually take their final form, as love or hate. We love because we judge the object of our love worthy of our feeling; we hate someone

[8] See, for instance, G. Nagy, *Poetry as Performance: Homer and Beyond* (Cambridge, 1996).

[9] A. Cruden, *Complete Concordance to the Bible* (Cambridge, 1992), s.v. desire, 142-3.

[10] See the contributions in the volume Liz James (ed.), *Desire and Denial in Byzantium* (Aldershot, 1999), esp. Averil Cameron, Desire in Byzantium – the Ought and the Is, 205-13, and Charles Barber, Writing on the body: memory, desire, and the holy in iconoclasm, 111-20.

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or something because it originally threatened us, provoked our fear, anger and eventually this negative feeling was organised into hate. The growing process of feelings is demonstrated in the *Expositio Fidei* of John of Damascus[11] but it is also attested in modern times in the fields of psychiatry and psychology. This suggests that the Byzantine *topos* is valid in terms of process analysis and that it reflects extraordinary insight into reality. John of Damascus, drawing on Aristotelian philosophy, groups fears into six categories according to their cause: fear of action, fear of blame, fear for a shameful act, fear caused by amazement, fear caused by surprise and fear generated by the agony of failure. It is mainly this last category of fear that applies to the *topos* used in homiletics.[12]

In the homily *on the Conception of the Virgin* John of Euboia, combines the *topos* of desire and fear with the humility *topos*: 'Desire (yearning) attracts me but fear repels me',[13] 'tearful I became on account of my unworthiness'[14]. In the first homily *On the Nativity* by Andrew of Crete fear is linked with anxiety over the competence of the preacher and is thus connected to the humility *topos*,[15] whereas in the homily *On the Circumcision of the Lord*, the *topos* reminds us of the account in Genesis as the preacher exclaims: 'I fear and dread how I shall properly address the one who was made human in ineffable manner ... *I hide myself.* And how shall I overcome such a fear?'[16] In the homily *On Lazarus*, Andrew urges his voice not to succumb to fear.[17] In the homily *On the Elevation of the Cross,* the cross itself becomes the source of courage and of the eradication of faint-heartedness.[18] Desire urges speech and provides bravery,[19] says Andrew in his *Homily on the Dormition of the Virgin* while in his homily *On the Apostle Titus*, he states that wherever there is desire, fear cannot stand.[20]

In Germanos of Constantinople, the Apostles show their love for God by 'displaying' their fear of the Almighty.[21] Addressing the Virgin elsewhere, Germanos beseeches her, as she is rightly praised by God, not to cast him aside; him who out of desire approaches her.[22] The same pattern of contrast between fear and desire is to be encountered in other homilies of the period.

[11] John of Damascus, *Expositio Fidei* II 13-22 (B. Kotter [ed.], *Die Schriften des Johannes von Damaskos*, Berlin-New York, 1973, II 12).

[12] *Ib.*, II 15.

[13] John of Euboia, *Sermo in Conceptionem Sanctae Deiparae* (PG 96, 1459-1500), and esp. 1461A: ὁ (*sic*) πόθος ἕλκει με, ὁ (*sic*) φόβος ἀνθέλκει με, καὶ ἡ ἀναξιότης σιγᾷν ἐπιτιμᾷ μοι...

[14] *Ib.*, 1461B: περίδακρυς γέγονα διὰ τὴν ἐμήν ἀναξιότητα.

[15] Andrew of Crete, *In nativitatem S. Mariae I* (PG 97, 821A).

[16] *Id.*, *In Circumcisionem Domini* (PG 97, 917D).

[17] *Id.*, *In Lazarum* (PG 97, 968A-B).

[18] *Id.*, *In Exaltationem S. Crucis I* (PG 97, 1020A).

[19] *Id.*, *In Dormitionem S. Mariae II* (PG 97, 1072B).

[20] *Id.*, *In Apostolum Titum* (PG 97, 1144C).

[21] Germanos of Constantinople, *In Dormitionem B. Mariae III* (PG 98, 369B).

[22] *Id.*, *In S. Mariae Zonam* (PG 98, 382C-D).

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Desire linked with speech also appears in the second *Homily on the Dormition* by John of Damascus, where the author says he is burnt by the sizzling torch of longing but in this case desire appears in a different iconological context since it is not part of the antithetical dipole of desire and fear but, on the contrary, it provokes joyful tears in the preacher.[23] In his homily *On the Holy Saturday*, John refers to the divine economy that cannot be apprehended through the intellect but only through purity of heart that is the outcome of divine desire and fear.[24] Later in the same homily, desire is replaced by *eros*.[25] Desire has won, fear is defeated, the author says in his homily *On the Nativity of the Virgin*.[26] In a superb reversal of the *topos*, John of Damascus tells us he is repulsed by desire: 'Desire repulses me [for] how am I going to depict your modest gait, the grace of your face?'[27] One last example comes from John Damascene's first homily *On the Dormition of the Virgin*, where desire and fear are woven into a wreath and with a trembling hand offered in gratitude to the Virgin by the faithful.[28]

The study of the use of the *topos* of desire and fear in the narrative of middle-Byzantine homiletics illustrates that the specific *topos* is often linked with the humility *topos* and that it occurs in variants. As regards its function, we may note that in most cases it occurs in the *prooemium* of the homily and only occasionally is it to be found in the main part of the sermons.

The way in which the *topos* of desire and fear, as well as the other *topoi*, are used in the narrative of homilies dating from the eighth and ninth centuries, demonstrates their specific role in the composition of the speech. The variants encountered, as well as the occasional combination of *topoi*, prompt the conclusion that homilists employed them as *formulae*, i.e. as set phrases memorised and retrieved in order to fill in the narrative. It is this practice that can be viewed in terms of the formulaic theory of composition as set forth by Parry and Lord with reference to the heroic poetry of Yugoslavia, and employed by them in the study of Homeric poetry. A detailed analysis of the way in which *formulae* operate in the homiletic narrative, definitely opens new ground for further research.

In conclusion, the examination of the case study of the *topos* of desire and fear has shown that:

1) the *topos* is not devoid of meaning since it reveals aspects of cognitive and anthropological perceptions and
2) its use in the narrative associates it with the theory of orality.

[23] John of Damascus, *Second Homily on the Dormition of the Virgin* (Kotter, 1988), 5.1-4, 522.
[24] *Id.*, *Homily on the Holy Saturday* (Kotter, 1988), 1.10-12, 121.
[25] *Ib.*, 1.13, 121.
[26] John of Damascus, *Homily on the Nativity of the Virgin* (Kotter, 1988), 2.26-27, 170-171.
[27] *Ib.*, (Kotter, 1988), 11.15-16, 181.
[28] John of Damascus, *First Homily on the Dormition of the Virgin* (Kotter, 1988), 2.7-9, 484.

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On the basis of all the above I would like to suggest that the content of the specific *topos* (and probably of many other *topoi* of Byzantine literature) may prove a useful source of information about the cognitive system and anthropological conceptions of the Byzantines and that perhaps we should revisit the literary *topoi*, and especially those of homiletics, in respect of their content as well as function. The study of the cognitive perceptions of the Byzantines may prove more fruitful than what we would have thought.

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Holiness and Education in Late Antique Hagiography

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Saint Augustine, reviewing his earliest writings, judges over *De ordine*: 'I disapprove of those books, because within them I have paid too much attention to the liberal arts which are not known to many saints, while those who are educated in a liberal manner are no saints.'[1] From this point of view it may appear more meaningful to speak of 'holiness *or* education' than of 'holiness *and* education'. Moreover, Augustine seems to suggest that education does not bear any importance for a Christian life at all, as the true Christian is either himself a Saint or at least acknowledges holiness as model or 'Leitbild' of Christianity. According to Augustine, the public schools are quite dangerous for Christians: They introduce children into the world of rhetorical skills and pagan literature, but do not teach them moral values, not to speak of the belief in God which is obviously necessary to be a true Christian and, of course, a Saint.[2]

Augustine's disapproval of his early philosophical writings echoes the hagiographical precept given by Pontius, the biographer of Saint Cyprian: 'The deeds of a divine man are only of relevance since he has been born again by God. Before this, he may well have been educated in the liberal arts and may have dedicated himself to their service, but I shall omit all this, for it was useful to him only for his worldly life.'[3] And indeed there are many *Lives* which do not pay any attention to the growing-up and education of the holy man or woman. However, the most prominent *Life* of the fourth century, the *Life of Saint Anthony* written by Athanasius, deals short but pointedly with the subject: Young Anthony rejects studying grammar or rhetoric in order to avoid any contact with pagan children.[4] Evagrius, in his latin translation, puts it slightly differently: Anthony did not want to suffer any molestation by foolish fables

[1] Augustine, *Retractationes* I 3.4 (CSEL 36, 19.18-20.2): *et quod multum tribui liberalibus disciplinis, quas multi sancti multum nesciunt, quidam etiam sciunt et sancti non sunt.*

[2] See Augustine, *Confessiones* I 17.27-18.28 (CChr.SL 27, 15); Christian Tornau, Augustinus und das 'hidden curriculum': Bemerkungen zum Verhältnis des Kirchenvaters zum Bildungswesen seiner Zeit: *Hermes* 130 (2002) 316-37, esp. 330.

[3] Pontius, *Vita Cypriani* 2 (CSEL 3.3, XCI.17-21): *siquidem hominis Dei facta non debent aliunde numerari, nisi ex quo Deo natus est. fuerint licet studia et bonae artes deuotum pectus imbuerint, tamen illa praetereo: nondum enim ad utilitatem nisi saeculi pertinebant.*

[4] Athanasius, *Vita Antonii* 1.2 (SC 400, 130.8-9). See Philip Rousseau, Antony as Teacher in the Greek *Life*, in: Thomas Hägg *et al.* (eds.), *Greek Biography and Panegyric in Late Antiquity*, The Transformation of the Classical Heritage 31 (Berkeley, 2001), 89-109.

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employed as school texts.[5] Even if the historical Anthony knew to read and write (he is most probably the author of seven coptic letters), he was painted as having been holy because of his extraordinary piety which is strictly detached from anything he would have learnt at school.[6] Of course, this is already a standard element in the rhetoric of ascetics, especially ascetic learned and educated men, and this is not only true for Christians, but also for pagan philosophers like, for example, Plotinus.[7]

In refraining from secular education, Anthony is paralleled by Martin of Tours in his *Life* that was written as a western counter-proposal for the ideal Saint of Late Antiquity. Martin is equally depicted as illiterate, that is, gifted not with rhetorical skills but with the grace of God.[8] The *Life of Martin* was to become the most influential hagiographical text of latin Late Antiquity, and at the end of the sixth century the model of the illiterate, wonder-working Saint has to be seen as universally established, as is shown by the hagiographical writings of Gregory of Tours and Gregory the Great. But until then, a variety of models of holiness had been produced, displaying quite different attitudes to education and its importance for a Saint's life. For the time being, I shall confine myself to Latin hagiography in order to point out some significant types of the relation of holiness and education besides the plain rejection of the latter in favour of the former.[9] This typology is by no means complete in respect of the Latin West and would have to be enlarged even more when taking into account the hermits of the Greek and Oriental East. What I would like to present is therefore nothing more than a starting point for further investigations.[10]

1. Jerome is well known for his 'romances of monastic life'[11] by which he wanted to trace the origins of monasticism beyond Anthony to the hermits Paul and Hilarion. They also inherited moderate wealth from their parents and equally left their possessions behind in order to conduct a spiritual life. However, their liberal education is by no means rejected or even criticised: Both are

[5] Evagrius, *Vita Antonii* 1 (PL 73, 127A): *non se litteris erudiri, non ineptis infantum jungi passus est fabulis.*

[6] See Athanasius, *Vita Ant.* 93.4 (SC 400, 374.21-23) = Evagrius, *Vita Ant.* 61 (PL 73, 168B). For Anthony's alleged illiteracy see Ugo Zanetti, Antoine n'avait pas appris les lettres...: Une allusion biblique (Jn 7,15)?: *Irénikon* 77 (2004) 537-47.

[7] See Porphyry, *Vita Plotini*, 8.4-8, in: *Plotini Opera*, Paul Henry and Hans-Rudolf Schwyzer (eds.) (Paris – Bruxelles, 1951), 14.

[8] Sulpicius Severus, *Vita Martini* 25.8 (SC 133, 312); *Dial.* I 27.1-2 (CSEL 1, 179.19-22).

[9] For a thorough treatment of this subject see Peter Gemeinhardt, *Das lateinische Christentum und die antike pagane Bildung*, STAC 41 (Tübingen, 2007), esp. 244-306.

[10] Such investigations are currently being undertaken by a research group located at the Chair of Church History at Göttingen University: 'Religiöse und gesellschaftliche Leitbilder in spätantiken Heiligenviten' (since 2009).

[11] Harald Hagendahl, *Latin Fathers and the Classics: A Study on the Apologists, Jerome and Other Christian Writers*, SGLG 6 (Göteborg, 1958), 105. See also: Susan Weingarten, *The Saint's Saints: Hagiography and Geography in Jerome* (Leiden and Boston, 2005).

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well acquainted with oratory *and* are, at the same time, true confessors of Christ.[12] Jerome was writing for Roman ascetics who had been themselves trained in rhetoric and philosophy and were now worrying whether this would hamper a Christian life from the very beginning. For Jerome, education and holiness are no opposites but coexist in a kind of subordination: There is no need to reject education but to move beyond it. This reflects a common hagiographical pattern of Late Antiquity: A noble man or woman (*nobilis*) gets even more distinguished (*nobilior*) by converting to Christ.[13] Jerome, himself incorporating his ideal of a Saint, remains free to employ what he has learned at school, as style and content of his letters display.[14]

2. As Gaul was occupied by the barbarians during the fifth century, the Roman nobility had to face considerable difficulties in following the traditional career paths within the administration of the empire. Although the Praetorian Prefecture of Gaul was still functioning, it is significant that noble men in many cases took over episcopal duties. However, they still conducted their office as if they were a *defensor civitatis*.[15] The impact of this development on Christian hagiography is striking: Hilary of Arles (d. 449), a preeminent figure among the bishops who had received their spiritual training at the isle of Lérins, is effusively praised by his hagiographer for his rhetorical abilities which he applied to his sermons. Of course, Hilary was able to speak in a simple manner when his listeners were people of modest education. 'But when he noticed that literate people entered the Church, he suddenly changed to extraordinary charm concerning eloquence and mimic. Therefore, the most famous contemporary authors expressed their admiration in the following words: Hilary's doctrinal and rhetorical abilities seem to be of superhuman origin!'[16] As preaching was one of a bishop's first duties, his rhetorical skill makes him appear the ideal bishop and, moreover, the ideal Saint. As Jerome aimed at reconciling education

[12] Jerome, *Vita Pauli* 4.1 (SC 508, 150.1-6); *Vita Hilarionis* 2.1-3 (SC 508, 214.1-216.10).

[13] Constantius of Lyons, *Vita Germani Antissiodorensis* 22 (SC 112, 164.4-5): *natalibus nobilis, religione nobilior*; Hydatius, *Chronicon* a. 424 (SC 218, 126.1-2): *Paulinus [sc. Nolanus] nobilissimus et eloquentissimus dudum, conversione ad deum nobilior factus*; Augustine, *Ep.* 150 (CSEL 44, 381.10-11) about Demetrias: *puella nobilis genere, nobilior sanctitate*. See P. Gemeinhardt, *Das lateinische Christentum* (2007), 149-50.

[14] Jerome, *Ep.* 108.1.1 (CSEL 55, 306.5-6): *nobilis genere, sed multo nobilior sanctitate* (speaking about Paula).

[15] See Claudia Rapp, *Holy Bishops in Late Antiquity: The Nature of Christian Leadership in an Age of Transition*, The Transformation of the Classical Heritage 37 (Berkeley CA, 2005), esp. 274-89.

[16] *Vita Hilarii Arelatensis* 14, ed. by Samuel Cavallin, Vitae sanctorum Honorati et Hilarii (Lund, 1952), 93.13-19: *Si peritorum turba defuisset, simplici sermone rusticorum corda nutriebat. At ubi instructos supervenisse vidisset, sermone, vultu pariter in quadam gratia insolita excitabatur, se ipso celsior apparebat, ut eiusdem praelati auctores temporis, qui suis scriptis meritissume claruerunt, Silvius, Eusebius, Domnolus, admiratione succensi in haec verba proruperint: 'Non doctrinam, non eloquentiam, sed nescio quid supra homines consecutum'.*

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with an ascetic life, Hilary's hagiographer (and many of his contemporaries) saw no obstacle to depict an excellently educated man as the perfect preacher – which is quite the opposite of what was again and again postulated by treatises on homiletic of the same time.[17] The question whether to apply classical rhetoric to Christian preaching, which had been pondered extensively in book IV of Augustine's *On Christian Doctrine* (see below), appears to be settled with respect to the hagiographical writings on the bishops of Arles during the fifth century: A bishop appears as holy – not only, but explicitly – because of his rhetorical skills (which is of course also true for eastern bishops' *Lives* like the funerary oration for John Chrysostom).[18]

3. Another example of an educated bishop is provided by the *Life of Germanus of Auxerre* written by Constantius of Lyons. The Saint as well as the author are contemporaries to Hilary of Arles and his anonymous hagiographer respectively, but the portrait of Germanus bears some interesting differences. First of all, like Martin of Tours he is a famous wonder-worker and is occupied with missionary activities; but like Hilary, he acts as *defensor civitatis* and as a preacher with high abilities. His *Life* gives a precise account of his parenthood, education and career within the Roman administration: He went to Rome in order to acquire comprehensive knowlegde of the arts and of the law; he acted as lawyer and prefect and was married to a woman of outstanding provenance and wealth. However, all this is nothing but an ingenious preparation for being a bishop: 'Beyond this, he must have been instructed secretly by God's providence. The forthcoming apostolic bishop should not be wanting in perfection. Oratory prepared him for delivering sermons, knowledge of law for distributing divine justice, the mutual intercourse with his wife for practicing chastity.'[19] Compared to the *Life* of Hilary, education does not only appear as reconcilable with holiness but is – at least for Germanus's hagiographer – a necessary precondition for being a holy bishop. Of course, education itself does not make the Saint; but in contrast to Augustine as quoted above, it is by no means a stumbling-block on the way to holiness. A closer look reveals that this is also true for Possidius' *Life of Augustine*: Here we learn that Augustine's predecessor Valerius needed someone who would 'edify the Church of God by preaching and teaching', because 'he himself was not very well acquainted with the Latin

[17] See P. Gemeinhardt, *Das lateinische Christentum* (2007), 320-37.

[18] See now: *Oratio funebris in laudem Sancti Iohannis Chrysostomi. Epitaffio attribuito a Martirio di Antiochia* (BHG 871, CPG 6517), ed. by Martin Wallraff, transl. by Cristina Ricci, Quaderni della Rivista di Bizantinistica 12 (Spoleto, 2007). However, in the East the ascetic qualification is, generally speaking, of more importance for a bishop's biography than in the West; see Andrea Sterk, *Renouncing the World Yet Leading the Church: The Monk-Bishop in Late Antiquity* (Cambridge, Mass. and London, 2004).

[19] Constantius, *Vita Germ.* 1 (SC 112, 122.16-124.20): *Erudiebatur profecto occulto diuinitatis iudicio, ne quid perfectionis deesset apostolico pontifici mox futuro. Parabatur eloquentia praedicationibus, iuris doctrina iustitiae, uxoris societas ad testimonium castitatis.*

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language and with the liberal arts' – and not surprisingly, with Augustine he chose a former teacher of oratory and even an official rhetor at the imperial court.[20]

Looking at the Latin west during the fifth century, holiness and education coexist within hagiographical literature. It is not until the beginning of the sixth century that education is again radically despised, most prominently by the *Life of Cesary of Arles*. Like Jerome, he experienced a terrifying dream and decided to neglect the wisdom of the world. And here we encounter indeed a contradiction between secular education and Christian preaching: 'He knew well that the jewelry of perfect oratory will not be wanting in those who have gained their insights in a spiritual manner.'[21] A few decades later, Gregory of Tours still admits to be frightened by educated readers of his works who might scoff at his simple speech without any rhetorical *decorum* and with deficiencies in grammar, but between the lines he leaves no doubt that *simplicitas* is what is apt to the contemporaries.[22] Being a Saint and writing about Saints is ostentatiously depicted as detached from liberal education, concerning the holy man as well as the author himself.

But the hagiography of the previous century is more than a last flare-up of the admirers of liberal education within the Christian Church. Instead, the various forms of the relationship of holiness and education reveal the ongoing debate about the overall model or 'Leitbild' for Christian life in a world with a rapidly increasing number of Christians while the Church only slowly established institutions of education. Whether Christians ought to visit public schools or not had been disputed since the lifetime of Tertullian, but no decision had ever been drawn that attending school or at least teaching the canon of pagan education should be prohibited for Christians.[23] Even Augustine who is extremely critical of the schools in his *Confessions* develops in *On Christian Doctrine* a hermeneutics of liberal oratory as a useful and even necessary means for

[20] Possidius, *Vita Augustini* 5.2, ed. Wilhelm Geerlings, *Augustinus. Opera – Werke, Sonderband* (Paderborn, 2005), 34.12-17: *Sanctus vero Valerius ordinator eius, ut erat vir pius et Deum timens, exsultabat et Deo gratias agabat suas exauditas a Domino fuisse preces, quas se frequentissime fudisse narrabat, ut sibi divinitus homo concederetur talis, qui posset verbo Dei et doctrina salubri ecclesiam Domini aedificare, cui rei se homo natura Graecus minusque Latina lingua et litteris instructus minus utilem pervidebat.* For late antique *Lives* of bishops see Eva Elm, *Die Macht der Weisheit: Das Bild des Bischofs in der Vita Augustini des Possidius und anderen spätantiken und frühmittelalterlichen Bischofsviten*, SHCT 109 (Leiden and Boston, 2003).

[21] *Vita Caesarii* I 9 (MGH.SRM III, 460.25-27): *Igitur contempsit haec protinus, sciens, quia non deesset illis perfectae locutionis ornatus, quibus spiritalis eminet intellectus.*

[22] Gregory of Tours, *Liber in gloria confessorum*, prologue (MGH.SRM I.2, 747.24-748.13).

[23] It was left to the pagan emperor Julian to draw the consequence of Christian criticism of pagan schools by means of his ‚edict on rhetors', issued in 362 – which the Christian theologians strictly refused to accept, thereby defending their right to teach and learn the pagan texts! See now: P. Gemeinhardt, *Das lateinische Christentum* (2007), 351-67; Klaus Bringmann, *Kaiser Julian* (Darmstadt, 2004), 123-8; Klaus Rosen, *Julian: Kaiser, Gott und Christenhasser* (Stuttgart, 2006), 270-3.

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preaching.[24] The *Lives* of Hilary and Germanus point at the special situation in Gaul after the barbarian invasion: Being a Roman becomes equivalent to being a Christian; and the environment is no longer the Roman world with its educational system and career paths but a 'barbarian society' in which the Christians are obliged to preserve the Roman culture and civilization.[25] In contrast, the *Lives* of Anthony and Martin require a surrounding world which is rhetorically seen as fundamentally anti-Christian. Finally, Jerome represents the growing interest of noble Romans in an ascetical conduct of life while not striving for ecclesiastical offices – and this is exactly what his hermits do. Therefore, the relationship of holiness and education indicates the changing attitudes of Christian authors to the secular Roman world; and at least some of them were of the opinion that this world was not as bad as prominent theologians had claimed for centuries.

[24] See Chr. Tornau, Augustinus und das 'hidden curriculum' (2002), 331 n. 64: 'Die "Confessiones" enthalten die Kritik am Bestehenden, "De doctrina christiana" bietet die positive Alternative.'

[25] This is obviously the case in the literary circle of Sidonius Apollinaris; see the recent papers of Sigrid Mratschek, Identitätsstiftung aus der Vergangenheit: Zum Diskurs über die trajanische Bildungskultur im Kreis des Sidonius Apollinaris, in: Therese Fuhrer (ed.), *Die christlich-philosophischen Diskurse der Spätantike*, Philosophische Arbeiten 28 (Stuttgart, 2008), 363-80, and Oliver Overwien, Kampf um Gallien. Die Briefe des Sidonius Apollinaris zwischen Literatur und Politik: *Hermes* 137 (2009) 93-117.

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Porphyry's *Sententiae* an Ethical/Spiritual Guidebook to the Neoplatonic Life

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Porphyry of Tyre (234/3 – 305 AD), *doctissimus philosophorum*,[1] was a very learned man, whose academic interests included metaphysics, logic, exegesis, grammar, rhetoric, arithmetic, geometry and music. But, among these disciplines, the ascent of the soul to the noetic world (νοητόν, ἐκεῖ) and reunion with the true or real self (σεαυτόν) was an object of his particular investigations. In his philosophical legacy we fund a very complex anthology of forty four statements commonly known under their Latin title as *Sententiae ad intelligibilia ducentes*.[2] This heterogenous collection is more than a metaphysical manual commenting on some of Plotinus' concepts. The philosophical ἀφορμαί offer an original insight into Porphyry's appreciation of the relationship between intellectual, ethical and spiritual life. As a highly philosophical exercise the collection has the power to lift up 'the eye of the soul' towards her ultimate destiny: participation in Being (τὸ ὄν). In this paper I explore the main elements of what could, at the risk of some inaccuracy, be called the 'spiritual' teaching of the two fragments of the *Sententiae*.

The blending of metaphysics and spirituality in the text is very characteristic of Porphyry. Some of the *Sententiae* echo Porphyry's supposed belief in the *via universalis* of salvation[3] as opposed to 'the particular way' promoted by Christian faith in salvation only through Jesus, the Jewish emphasis on the faithfulness to the Mosaic Law and the Gnostic belief in election/salvation of the few. The *Sententiae* reflect Porphyry's idea of the ascent of the mind, which must be seen on a larger canvas as one of many late Hellenistic soteriological narratives, which aim to endorse the specific ideal of attaining salvation. In Porphyry's case he also taught about the ultimate goal of our existence: union between the human νοῦς and hypostasis of Νοῦς, which brings about

[1] *De Civ.* XIX 22.

[2] On the history of the title see Richard Goulet, Le Titre de l'ouvrage, in: Luc Brisson (ed.), *Porphyre, Sentences* (Paris, 2005), I 11-6. The second volume of this French edition of *Sententiae* contains John Dillon's English translation which is used in this paper. See, *ibid.* 795-835. I quote *Vita Plotini* (*VPl*) from Arthur H. Armstrong, (transl.), *Plotinus: Porphyry on Plotinus, Ennead I* (Cambridge Mass. and London, 2000).

[3] Jeremy M. Schott, Porphyry on Christian and Others: 'Barbarian Wisdom', Identity Politics, and Anti-Christian Polemics on the Eve of the Great Persecution: JECS 3 (2005) 277-314.

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reconciliation with our real self constantly present in the noetic world. The *Sententiae*, as 'a guidebook',[4] may appear primarily as an anthology of philosophical, highly speculative investigations, however, some passages also discuss elements of Neoplatonic ethics as well as spirituality, supporting the model of a particular conversion (ἐπιστροφή).[5] This transformation, so central to the Neoplatonic βίως, is a result of human choice (προαίρεσις) to ascend or return to the realm of the divine.

The thirteenth *Sententia* recall Plotinus' concept of the disposition of all generated beings, which consequently turn towards (ἐπιστρέφει) their source of generation (*Enn.*, V 2 [11]; III 9 [13], 3).[6] This is their natural 'gravitation'. Therefore: ὁ Νοῦς turns towards the One, then, ἡ Ψυχή (or ἡ ὅλη Ψυχή) turns towards the Intellect and her lower part (ἡ ψυχὴ τοῦ κόσμου) turns to the higher part. This metaphysical law among hypostases represents to Plotinus and Porphyry an exact *matrix* for ethical and spiritual conversion. Within the context of anthropology, individual conscientious choice is involved. Man 'here' in this material world, has the potential to turn towards his origin 'there' (ἐκεῖ), who is its metaphysical source remaining in intelligible reality (νοητόν, ἐκεῖ). In the case of human beings, unlike hypostases, ἐπιστροφή is not a 'natural' or 'obvious' turning. It rather involves an ethical effort to set proper restraints on the body and its sensual life which may disturb the mind. This turning from sensual, multiple actions to the activity of the mind leads also from external to internal life, from the perception of diverse, accidental exterior impressions to self-contemplation[7] or rather to the contemplation of Being in ourselves. In this way, we also turn from observation of the posterior elements, to reflection on the prior, essential one.

The thirtieth *Sentence* highlights the potential of this turn to integrate human beings, here referred to 'divisible realities' (*Timaeus*, 35 a 3):

Ἐν δὲ ταῖς μερισταῖς ὑποστάσεσι καὶ πρὸς πολλὰ ῥέπειν δυναμέναις ἔνεστι καὶ πρὸς τὰ γεννήματα ἐπιστρέφειν· ὅθεν καὶ ἐν ταύταις[8] ἦν ἡ ἁμαρτία, ἐν ταύταις ἡ λελοιδορημένη ἀπιστία. Ταύταις οὖν κακὸν ἡ ὕλη τῷ ἐπιστρέφεσθαι ἐπ' αὐτὴν δύνασθαι, δυναμέναις ἐστράφθαι πρὸς τὸ θεῖον. Ὥσθ' ἡ μὲν τελειότης ὑφίστησι

[4] On the genre of the *Sentenatiae*, see Marie-Odile Goulet-Cazé, Le genre littéraire des Sentences, in: L. Brisson (ed.), *Porphyre*, (2005), I 17-29.

[5] See *Sent.* 7.1; 32.52. See the context of the notion in Paul Aubin, *Le problème de la conversion: Etudes sur un terme commun à l'hellénisme et au christianisme des trois premières siècles* (Paris, 1963).

[6] Among Porphyry's readjustments of Plotinus' teaching one is worth highlighting. Porphyry, unlike Plotinus, from very beginning of the *Sentence* stresses the superiority of the metaphysical source/generator over its product/generation, while Plotinus (V 1 [10] 6:39) points to this at the end of his statement. In my view, Porphyry's intention was clearly to indicate the importance and therefore value of the higher level of existence (what was 'before', chronologically and metaphysically prior) in comparison to its lower or later outcome.

[7] *Sent.* 43.31-35.

[8] Here the text follows Lamberz instead of Schwyzer = ἐν αἷς.

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τὰ δεύτερα ἀπὸ τῶν προτέρων τηροῦσα αὐτὰ ἐπεστραμμένα πρὸς τὰ πρῶτα, τὸ δὲ ἀτελὲς στρέφει καὶ πρὸς τὰ ὕστερα τὰ πρῶτα καὶ φιλεῖν ταῦτα ποιεῖ τῶν πρὸ αὐτῶν ἀποστραφέντα.[9]

Porphyry clearly indicates the role of turning attention to either a lower rank of reality (matter and its qualities) or a higher, level of being (νοητόν). This crucial ethical 'T-junction', as in Plotinus' teaching, signifies the assimilation either to the gods or to the beasts (*Enn.*, III 2 [47], 4:36-38). It must be stressed that the human being faces this choice without any determination or limits imposed on him or her by fate, astrology and god's or gods' will. And this choice opens either the process of ascension or degradation which further disperses the mind into lower worries and activities. As such it has many aspects. First, in relation to epistemology, this crucial re-orientation leads to either plunging into the distraction of multiple sensual impulses or, in the opposite case, towards a greater focus on the essential elements.[10] Secondly, in relation to metaphysics, ἐπιστροφή means either existence in the company of inferior beings approximated to matter, or the opportunity to encounter more excellent ones (e.g. good daemons).[11] Thirdly, in the context of theology, this important turn warns against either a fall into 'a superstitious religion' (e.g. as the Gnostics[12] or other sectarian Christians[13]), or offers ascent of the divine element in human being towards the divine (πρὸς τὸ θεῖον).[14] Therefore ἐπιστροφή itself contains ethical and spiritual aspects.[15] It reveals important characteristics of the

[9] *Sent.* 30.11-21: 'It is proper to divisible realities, however, which can incline themselves towards many objects, to direct their attention also to their offspring; whence also it comes about it that in these there is sin, in these there is the execrated unbelief. For these entities, therefore, matter is an evil, by reason of the fact that they can turn their attention towards it, when they have the capacity of being turned towards divinity. So the state of perfection brings about the existence of the secondary entities from the prior ones while preserving the latter concentrated on the first principles, while imperfection involves the turning of prior entities also towards what is inferior to them, and stimulates them to love them, when they have turned away from what is prior to them.'

[10] See *VPl.* 8.4-8: 'In writing he [Plotinus – P.A.-S.] did not form the letters with any regards to appearance or divide his syllables correctly, and he paid no attention to spelling. He was wholly concerned with thought [τοῦ νοῦ ἐχόμενος]; and, which surprised us all, he went on in this way right up to the end.' See *VPl.* 13.6-8.

[11] See *VPl.* 10.28-31: 'So the companion of Plotinus was a spirit of the more god-like kind [θειοτέρων δαιμόνιον ἔχον τὸν συνόντα], and he continually kept the divine eye of his soul fixed on this companion [πρὸς ἐκεῖνον].'

[12] See *VPl.* 16.10. As noted by Mark Edwards: 'The Gnostics recapitulate the errors of all Plotinus' other rivals. They practice magic (*Enn.* 2.9.14ff), traduce the stars (2.9.13.7) and claim to precedence in philosophy (2.9.6), disparaging the world with their unfounded claims to purity (2.9.15.32).' See: Porphyry, *On the Life of Plotinus*, in: Mark Edwards (transl.), *Neoplatonic Saints: The Lives of Plotinus and Proclus by their Students* (Liverpool, 2000), 28, n. 154.

[13] Eusebius, *Praep. Evang.* I 3.1.

[14] See *VPl.* 2:26-7: πειρᾶσθε τὸν ἐν ἡμῖν θεὸν ἀνάγειν πρὸς τὸ ἐν τῷ παντὶ θεῖον.

[15] Although in the text appears the Judeo-Christian notion of ἁμαρτία I agree with J. Dillon (Porphyre, *Sentences*, II 808, n. 95) that this term is later Christian correction.

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Neoplatonic ethos, embodied in Porphyry's master Plotinus,[16] as an example of integrity between the ways of thinking and living/acting. This noble purpose was realizable since human choice is an outcome of intellectual/spiritual self governance. The T-junction reveals ultimately an ethical *casus* presented by Porphyry to his readers in the *Sententiae*. It is in fact a case of 'to be or not to be', as in Neoplatonic ethos descent to the lower realm of sensual and material experience seriously obstructs true existence. Descent to the realm of matter goes against the natural (i.e. divine) status of the human soul and also undermines its eschatological purpose of return to its metaphysical homeland. Therefore Porphyry provides his readers with clear guidance in the thirty second *Sentence*, which is a *sui generis* ethical treatise.

The long narrative of the *Sentence* is composed of two major parts. In the first one (verses 1-94) Porphyry presents a systematic elaboration of four classes of virtues (civic, purificatory, contemplative, pragmatic), while in the second part (verses 95-140) he discusses the purificatory ones as well as the principal idea of κάθαρσις in detail. The development of the narrative and the order of these virtues suggest the direction of ascent from visible reality/various activites, including engagement in various aspects of social and political life, towards growing concentration on the intellectual contemplation of the highest realm. However, Porphyry does not indicate that this transformation is an instant act of 'illumination', but rather a long ethical and ultimately spiritual process. As an ethical transformation or conversion, this process has nothing common with the Gnostic notion of 'awakening from intoxication'[17], it does not call for any divine 'assistance' (as in the Christian notion of 'grace'), and is not related to any esoteric rituals, including theurgy.[18] On the contrary, the prescribed steady growth towards philosophical excellence is fully human and accessible through proper education and daily training. An important insight into the Porphyrian notion of ethical progress towards perfection and salvation can be found in the following passage of the *Sentence*:

Δεῖ τοίνυν καθηραμένην αὐτὴν συνεῖναι τῷ γεννήσαντι· καὶ ἀρετὴ ἄρα αὐτῆς μετὰ τὴν ἐπιστροφὴν αὕτη, ἥπερ ἐστὶν ἐν γνώσει καὶ εἰδήσει τοῦ ὄντος, οὐχ ὅτι οὐκ ἔχι παρ' αὐτῇ ταύτην, ἀλλ' ὅτι ἄνευ τοῦ πρὸ αὐτῆς οὐχ ὁρᾷ τὰ αὐτῆς.[19]

[16] One of the reasons which prompted Porphyry to compose Plotinus' biography was the wish to promote the Neoplatonic example of the true philosopher and divinised man. For further details, see M. Edwards, *Neoplatonic Saints* (2000), Introduction, XXXIV-XXXV.

[17] George W. MacRae, Sleep and Awakening in Gnostic Texts, in: *Le Origini dello Gnosticismo: Colloquio Di Messina, 13-18 Aprile* (Leiden, 1970), 496-507.

[18] I have discussed the function of theurgy in Porphyry's philosophy in: P. Ashwin-Siejkowski, Porphyry and Theurgy: Neoplatonic Background to Religious Practice: *Journal of Neoplatonic Studies* 9 (2004) 219-42.

[19] *Sent.* 32.51-3: 'It is requisite, then, that once purified, the soul unite itself with what has engendered it; and in consequence the virtue that is proper to it after its conversion consists in the acquaintance and knowledge of being, not because it does not possess it in itself, but it is not capable of seeing what is within itself without cooperation of what is superior to it.'

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It is thus knowledge of the real Being that provides the purified self with awareness of its identity. The self purified by virtue sees itself in the light of Being. At this advanced stage, having accomplished purification from bodily disruptions and having silenced all disturbances coming from a focus on material, insatiable needs, this self now reunites with its ideal origin. The man 'here' who has just freed himself from the realm of change and the man 'there' encounter each other. What was separated by embodiment is now liberated, properly prepared to participate in being where the ideal self is rooted. But Porphyry also suggests in the quoted passage that this true self is always present in the man who exists in the material world, yet is not recognised because of various lower concerns. At this point virtue is presented as γνῶσις (ἐν γνώσει... τοῦ ὄντος) but we must be careful not to confuse Porphyrian semantics with that of Gnostic vocabulary. Like the Gnostic notion of γνῶσις, this insight is achievable during earthly existence and it inspires the direction of moral acts. Unlike in the Gnostic case, however, this γνῶσις is not associated with any predestination to salvation. For Porphyry comprehension-γνῶσις is directly related to the ability of 'approaching ourselves' (χωρεῖν), where we encounter Being, and this experience of 'knowing ourselves as we are' is always related to previously acquired virtues.[20] The crucial ἐπιστροφή offers a way out of submergence in non-existence or an illusory life. While turning towards deceptive life leads to philosophical ignorance, moral chaos and religious superstition, the turn towards being is rewarded with true care of ourselves, the fulfilment of duties in society and also with a proper association with the divine.[21]

Conclusion

The *Sententiae* promote the idea of intellectual engagement with Neoplatonic metaphysics, as well as encouraging the adaptation of the Neoplatonic ethos to the aim of inculcating a more ethical life based on various virtues. The *Sententiae* present a philosophical appeal to what is best in each one of us, to our desire to participate in eternal life. They also promise that in the present, if guided by the Neoplatonic ethos, we may bear fruits such as righteous thoughts, noble deeds and teaching others by which each one of us becomes 'the father of gods' (θεῶν πατήρ).[22]

[20] See: *Sent.* 40.49-50: 'For the more that you approach yourself [χωρεῖν] (although you are present to yourself and inseparable to yourself), the more you also approach it [i.e. Being] which is essentially just as inseparable from you as you are from yourself. So it is possible for you to comprehend [γνωστικεῖν] what is present to Being and what is absent from it'.

[21] See: *Sent.* 40.59-68.

[22] *Sent.* 32.94.

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Blessed are the Rich: Leo the Great and the Roman Poor

Bronwen NEIL, Brisbane

Leo's pontificate, lasting for twenty-one years (440-61), was characterised by massive social upheaval. He guided Rome through two barbarian invasions, the first led by Attila in 452, when the Hun turned their attention to the West and attacked Italy, capturing the major cities of Aquileia and Milan. On this occasion Attila was held off from Rome through an exchange of gold. The pope's diplomatic efforts were not so successful with the Vandal leader Geiseric's attack on Rome in 455. The resulting social disorder was manifest in large numbers of refugees and displaced persons in the city who relied on charity to feed, clothe and shelter themselves and their families. The additional poor put pressure on the already stretched resources of the bishop's purse, and added to the scarcity of work for itinerant and seasonal labourers. In addition to providing for the existing and recently arrived poor, the pope had to raise the funds for the ransom of slaves captured by Attila and Geiseric. In this climate of civic disorder, the organisation of welfare to the poor in western urban centres – widows, orphans, refugees, prisoners, the sick and those without paid work – became increasingly the responsibility of individual bishops of those cities. Patlagean explains this shift as due to a change in the social imagination from a civic to an economic model of the community, which impacted on the focus of benefaction.[1] In Brown's recent work *Poverty and Leadership in the Later Roman Empire*, the author attributes this change to the emerging role of the Christian bishop as 'champion', 'governor' and 'lover' of the poor.[2]

The sermons of Pope Leo offer valuable information on the social history of the mid-fifth century, and particularly on the changes and continuities in attitudes to the urban poor under the leadership of this bishop of Rome. Leo's ninety-six surviving homilies are organised around major liturgical feasts, many of them fasts that were accompanied by a call to almsgiving. These included the December fasts leading up to Christmas, the Lenten fasts, fasting

[1] Evelyne Patlagean, *Pauvreté économique et pauvreté sociale à Byzance, 4e-7e siècles* (Paris, 1977). I am grateful to the Australian Research Council for supporting this research in the form of a Discovery Project Grant (2006-8), and to Australian Catholic University for their financial support. Prof Pauline Allen has once again given invaluable assistance in the form of comments on the draft.

[2] Peter R.L. Brown, *Poverty and Leadership in the Later Roman Empire* (Hanover and London, 2002).

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for Pentecost, the September fasts, and the Octave of Saints Peter and Paul, which was the occasion for church collections for the sick and the poor.

The first part of my paper examines the kind of rhetorical language and arguments Leo used in his sermons to motivate people to give alms to the poor. In doing so I ask in the second part whether Leo's conceptualisation of poverty indicates a substantial change in Roman attitudes to the urban poor from those that characterised the pagan elite of previous centuries. The third, perhaps most important part of the paper, looks at the degree to which these attitudes translated into effective action on behalf of the poor.

Part 1. Language: Terminology and Rhetoric

More than a quarter of Leo's homilies – some twenty-six – make mention of the poor. Leo most commonly uses the following nouns and adjectives to refer to the poor and the state of poverty: *pauper, paupertas, pauperies; indigentia, indigens; egestas, egenus; inopia, inopes.* These match well with the juridical terminology for the poor in the *Theodosian Codes* (312-438), according to the analysis of Grodzynski.[3] She identified the following terms for economic poverty: *inopia, inops*, the most common terms for the poorest of the poor, usually those who are accidentally poor as the result of some disaster; *egestas, egens*, designating the poorest of the poor, an artificially created poverty imposed by State penalty; *tenuis*, and the comparative *tenuiores*, vague terms for the relative poor; and *pauper* and *paupertas*, generic terms including all the other kinds of poverty: accidental, penal, temporary or permanent.[4]

Patristic terminology for poverty and the poor was in part constrained or shaped by the vocabulary employed in biblical translations, namely the *Vetus Latina* and the *Vulgate* in the Latin west. The book of *Sirach* (*Sir.* 10:34 twice and 13:3) in the *Vetus Latina* version opposes *paupertas* to *substantia* so that its use implies the lack of the means of subsistence. In the same biblical book we find the oxymoron *homo abundans paupertate* (*Sir.* 11:12). The word *pauper* appears frequently in Leo's homilies on the Beatitude of *Matth.* 5:3, following the *Vulgate* text (*Beati pauperes*: 'Blessed are the poor ...'). As was the case in Cicero's oratory, Leo's *pauperes* seem to be associated with higher virtues, in contrast to the connotations of the more concrete *egentes*. Many western preachers, such as Jerome, Augustine and Ambrose, evoke the poor as *egentes*,[5] but Leo, like Augustine, prefers a spiritualised reading of the Beatitudes, in

[3] Denise Grodzynski, Pauvres et indigents, vils et plebeians (Une étude terminologique sur le vocabulaire des petites gens dans le Code Théodosien), in: *Studia et documenta historiae et iuris* 53 (Rome, 1987), 140-218.

[4] Denise Grodzynski, Pauvres (1987), 146-52, 154-57, 160-68.

[5] Charles Pietri, Les pauvres et la pauvreté dans l'Italie de l'empire chrétien (IV[e] siècle): *Revue d'histoire ecclésiastique* 67 (1983) 267-300, 277.

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which 'the poor' are those deficient in spiritual virtues, especially humility, rather than those lacking material wealth. Leo's use of the spiritualised Matthean beatitudes may be contrasted with that of Gregory the Great who made the Lucan version (*Luke* 6:24-5) the subject of two admonitions to the preacher in his *Pastoral Rule*.[6]

While classical sources commonly speak of poverty as a negative, something to be relieved (Plautus, *Epid.* 556; Juvenal 14.236), endured (Cicero, *Tusc.* 5.107; Tacitus, *Ann.* 4.44.1); fled (Cicero, *De orat.* 3.116; Lucan, 1.166); or feared (Cicero, *Tusc.* 4.46; 5.15; Seneca, *Epist.* 17.3), Christian writers such as Augustine speak of 'confessing' poverty (*De civ. dei* 1.10.3)[7] and not despising it in others (*Enarr. in psalm.* 149.8). This language may have been inspired by Stoic philosophers such as Seneca who also, in the work *De beneficiis*, disapproves of those who look down on the poverty of others (Seneca, *De benef.* 1.9.5) and speaks of the need to maintain secrecy in helping a man who concealed his sudden extreme poverty because he was *inutiliter verecundus*.[8] The Stoics, however, challenged normal Roman attitudes and practice in this respect.

How did Leo use rhetoric in the mid-fifth century to motivate his listeners to give alms to the poor? The first distinctive departure from fourth-century Greek authors like the Cappadocians – Basil of Caesarea, Gregory of Nazianzus and Gregory of Nyssa – is his reliance on emotive language, appealing to the listener's mercy and compassion, rather than to their sense of justice. This was common to other earlier preachers such as Jerome[9] and John Chrysostom.[10] An exception to this characterization of the Cappadocians is Basil's moving description of the feelings of parents who are forced to sell their children into slavery to repay their debts. Below I will consider the 'new' rhetoric regarding the Christian virtues of mercy and spiritual poverty, and the distinctively Christian concept of stewardship of divine gifts.

The Virtue of Mercy: Attitudes towards the Poor

All of Leo's homilies on almsgiving place a great emphasis on mercy (*misericordia*) as a divine quality instilled in all human beings by virtue of each being

[6] Leo's use of the Matthean Beatitudes is analysed by Bronwen Neil, Blessed is Poverty: Leo the Great on Almsgiving: *Sacris Erudiri* 46 (2007) 143-56.

[7] *Qui inter tormenta paupertatem sanctam confitebatur, Christum confitebatur* ('... he who confesses holy poverty in the midst of these sufferings confesses Christ').

[8] Seneca, *De benef.* 2.10.1: 'too bashful for his own good.' (ed. F. Préchac, *Des bienfaits. Sénèque* 1 [Paris, 1926], 32. 14.) Transl. John M. Cooper and John F. Procopé, *Seneca. Moral and Political Essays*, Cambridge Texts in the History of Political Thought (Cambridge, 1995), 217.

[9] *p.* 66.5 to Pammachius (CSEL 54, 652).

[10] See Anthony Meredith, The Three Cappadocians on Beneficence: a Key to their Audiences, in: *Preacher and Audience: Studies in Early Christian and Byzantine Homiletics*, eds. Mary B. Cunningham and Pauline Allen (Leiden, Boston, and Cologne, 1998), 89-104, 95.

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made in the image and likeness of God (*Gen.* 1:26). Mercy to the poor is an imitation of God's mercy towards all human beings.[11] This is a sentiment which echoes Seneca's *De clementia* 1.1.2 (*pace* Holman).[12] Parkin discusses the Stoic disapproval of pity (*misericordia*) as a passion which distracts from *apatheia*, while conceding that the Stoics make an occasional nod to mercy (*clementia*), understood as giving practical aid to the poor, as laudable.[13] In *De clementia* 2.6.2 Seneca recommends the most fitting way to extend help to the shipwrecked traveller, hospitality to the exile and alms to the needy: *Non hanc contumeliosam, quam pars maior horum, qui misericordes videri volunt, abicit et fastidit, quos adiuvat, contingique ab iis timet, sed ut homo homini ex communi dabit.*[14] Leo, citing *Matth.* 5:7 (*'Beati misericordes quoniam ipsorum miserebitur Deus'*), claims that mercy is the greatest of the virtues and without it the other virtues cannot guarantee eternal life (*Serm.* 10.3).[15] In Leo's interpretation of *Matth.* 5:7, almsgiving is a shortcut to heaven, and a *testimonium pietatis.*[16] Similarly in *Serm.* 11.1, Leo teaches that works of mercy directed towards the poor are the single condition of salvation on the day of Judgement.

Leo was the first bishop of Rome to develop a thorough theology of self-interested giving aimed primarily towards the aristocracy, offering the standard advice to give from their surplus without requiring the radical renunciation embodied in voluntary poverty as espoused by Melania the Younger and her husband Pinianus, or Demetrias, granddaughter of the Anicii family. Leo advises that whatever is spent on such acts of mercy as feeding the poor, healing the

[11] A similar expression is found in Gregory of Nazianzus' Sermon 14, *De pauperum amore* (PG 35, 892C): γενοῦ τῷ ἀτυχοῦντι θεός, τὸν ἔλεον Θεοῦ μιμησάμενος. 'Be a god to the one stricken with misfortune by imitating the mercy of God.' The same idea is found in Gregory of Nyssa, *De Beneficentia*, in *Gregorii Nysseni Opera* 9, ed. Adrianus van Heck (Leiden, 1992), 102.15-16.

[12] *Egone ex omnibus mortalibus placui electusque sum, qui in terris deorum vice fungerer?* (transl. Cooper and Procopé, 128: 'Have I, of all mortals, found favour with the gods and been chosen to act on earth in their stead?'). See Susan R. Holman, The Entitled Poor: Human rights language in the Cappadocians: *Pro Ecclesia* 9 (2000) 476-89, 478-9: 'Even Stoic writings, in which many scholars have seen a particular concern for the needy, considered justice, not mercy, to be the most important criteria (*sic*) for assisting those in need.'

[13] Anneliese Parkin, 'You do him no service': an exploration of pagan almsgiving, in: *Poverty and the Roman World*, E. Margaret Atkins and Robin Osborne (eds.) (Cambridge, 2006), 60-82, 64-5. For example Seneca states that the ideal Stoic would not hesitate to give a copper coin to an anonymous beggar not as a gift to the man but to humanity (*De benef.* 4.29.2-3).

[14] '... not throwing them down in the insulting way that most of those who would like to seem full of pity do, disdaining those whom they help and fearing to come into contact with them, but as one man giving to another man from the common store' (transl. Cooper and Procopé, 162-3).

[15] *Quamvis enim qui fidelis sit, et castus, et sobrius, et aliis majoribus ornatus insignibus; si misericors tamen non est, misericordiam non meretur...* (SC 49bis, 52) ('For although a man is full of faith, and chaste, and sober, and adorned with other still greater decorations, yet if he is not merciful, he does not deserve mercy...').

[16] 'Manifestation of true religion': *Serm.* 78.4 (SC 200, 30); also *Serm.* 16.2 (SC 200, 178).

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sick, and ransoming prisoners, is 'not lessened but increased' and is laid up for the giver's eternal reward (*Serm.* 78.4).[17] The theme of divine accounting, whereby material loss is transformed into spiritual gain, is a favourite.[18] In *Homily* 9 Leo states the case plainly: *Cibus egeni, regni caelestis est pretium; et largitor temporalium haeres efficitur aeternorum.*[19]

This emphasis on self-interested giving is common to other earlier western preachers such as Cyprian of Carthage, Augustine of Hippo, and Ambrose of Milan, who also taught that generosity to the poor could legitimately serve selfish ends.[20] It is also characteristic of some eastern preachers such as the Cappadocians.[21] Almsgiving aids the salvation of the giver, and gifts given in this life are a deposit made, with interest, for eternal life. Leo also ascribed the role of creditor to the almsgiver in respect to God, who would repay money given to the poor with interest after death.[22] The notion of holy usury was common to others such as Ambrose and Augustine. Christ, who voluntarily made lowly human nature his own, rewards those who give to the poor as if they gave to him (*Serm.* 9.2). Christ, who 'considers the needy and poor' (*Ps.* 41:1) is the face of the poor. As Leo puts it: *Recte autem in egeno et paupere ipsius Jesu Christi Domini nostri persona sentitur.*[23] This was an argument used by many preachers before him, including Basil and Gregory of Nazianzus.[24]

The roots of the doctrine of self-interested giving are found in the Hebrew scriptures. In *Homily* 16 Leo cites *Proverbs* in spelling out the doctrine of self-interested giving most explicitly: *Quoniam, sicut scriptum est,* animae suae

[17] *Quidquid enim in cibos pauperum, in curationes debilium, in pretia captivorum, et in quaelibet opera pietatis impenditur, non minuitur, sed augetur.* (SC 200, 30) ('For whatever is spent on food for the poor, on care for the sick, on the price of captives, and on any kind of piety is not decreased but increased').

[18] Jonathan Mark Armitage, *The Economy of Mercy: The Liturgical Preaching of Saint Leo the Great*, University of Durham, unpub. PhD Diss (Durham, 1997), 204.

[19] *Serm.* 9.2 (SC 49bis, 42): 'Food for someone in need is the cost of purchasing the kingdom of heaven, and the one who is generous with temporal things is made heir of the eternal.'

[20] See Boniface Ramsey, Almsgiving in the Latin Church: the Late Fourth and Fifth Centuries: *Theological Studies* 43 (1982) 226-59. Scriptural support was found in Psalms, viz. *Ps.* 40:2: *Beatus qui intelligit super egenum et pauperem, in die mala liberabit eum Dominus*, cited by Leo in *Serm.* 6.3 (SC 200, 126).

[21] See Mary Sheather, Pronouncements of the Cappadocians on Poverty and Wealth, in: *Prayer and Spirituality in the Early Church* 1, Pauline Allen, Raymond Canning, and Lawrence Cross (eds.) (Brisbane, 1998), 383-5.

[22] *Serm.* 17.2 (SC 200, 194). For an excellent discussion see Jonathan Mark Armitage, *A Two-fold Solidarity: Leo the Great's Theology of Redemption*, Early Christian Studies 9 (Strathfield, 2005), 178-81.

[23] *Serm.* 9.3 (SC 49 bis, 44): 'Rightly in the needy and poor do we recognise the person of Jesus Christ our Lord Himself ...'

[24] Basil, *Ep.* 150.3, ed. Yves Courtonne, *Saint Basile, Correspondance*, 2 (Paris, 2002), 75.27-29; Gregory of Nazianzus, *De pauperum amore* (PG 35, 909B). Anthony Meredith, The Three Cappadocians (1998), 97-8, comments that this idea is absent from the two homilies on the poor by Gregory of Nyssa.

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benefacit vir misericors (*Prov.* 11:17), *et nihil est uniuscujusque tam proprium quam quod impendit in proximum. Pars enim corporalium facultatum, quae indigentibus ministratur, in divitias transit aeternas* ...[25] Inverting the traditional Roman model of patronage, Leo promises in *Sermon* 10.4 that not only will God know of the almsgiver's good works but the alms themselves and their beneficiaries will intercede for the giver in heaven. Leo interpreted the injunction to show mercy to one's neighbour as a common Christian obligation in a concrete and financial sense. While the philanthropist could legitimately expect to be honoured for his largesse, the Christian giver of charity should ideally remain anonymous to the recipients of his or her alms, content with the knowledge that such deeds were known to Christ.[26] Christian bishops, however, such as Gregory of Nazianzus, recognised that φιλοτιμία was unlikely to fade amongst their aristocratic converts, and accorded such recognition in private letters (for example Jerome to Fabiola and Julia, and the anonymous writer of *De vera humilitate* to the wealthy virgin Demetrias). Monumental evergetism, the practice of celebrating the donor of a dedicated building in an inscription, certainly persisted in the fifth century, for example with Demetrias' dedication of a basilica on her estate to St Stephen in the time of Leo.[27]

Almsgiving is described by Leo as a Lenten duty (*Serm.* 49.6). The delicacies which the Christian denies himself in this fasting season must be given to the weak and destitute.[28] In *Sermon* 49 we find the striking idea that the rich are blessed through the very existence of the poor, in that it allows them the opportunity to blot out their sins through acts of charity.[29] Almsgiving is equated with baptism and repentance. The idea of the poor as a vehicle for the salvation

[25] *Serm.* 16.2 (SC 200, 178): '... since, as it is written, *the merciful man does good to his own soul* (*Prov.* 11:17) and nothing is so much a man's own as that which he spends on his neighbour. For that part of his material possessions with which he ministers to the needy, is transformed into eternal riches...'

[26] This seems contrary to Finn's idea that Christian bishops encouraged a personal relationship between the giver and the recipient. See Richard Finn, *Almsgiving in the Later Roman Empire: Christian Promotion and Practice*, Oxford Early Christian Studies (Oxford and New York, 2006), 182.

[27] See *Vita Leonis* 1, *Liber Pontificalis* 1, ed. Louis Duchesne (Paris, 1884), 238, and an inscription recording the dedication: *Inscriptiones Latinae Christianae Veteres* 1, 1765, ed. Ernst Diehl (Berlin, 1925), 343. See Bronwen Neil, *On True Humility:* An Anonymous Letter on Poverty and the Female Ascetic, in: *Prayer and Spirituality in the Early Church* 4: *The Spiritual Life*, Pauline Allen, Wendy Mayer, and Lawrence Cross (eds.) (Strathfield, 2006), 233-46, 245, n. 56.

[28] See Boniface Ramsey, Almsgiving (1982), 244-6, for the nexus between fasting and almsgiving.

[29] *Serm.* 49.6: *ut peccata quae aut baptismi aquis aut paenitentiae lacrymis abluuntur, etiam eleemosynis deleantur* ... (SC 49bis, 192) ('... that the sins which are washed away either by the waters of baptism, or the tears of repentance, may be also blotted out by almsgiving'). This statement is supported by citation of *Eccl.* 3:30. A similar idea is found in John Chrysostom's homilies: see Wendy Mayer, John Chrysostom on Poverty, in: *Preaching Poverty in Late Antiquity: Perceptions and Realities*, Pauline Allen, Bronwen Neil, and Wendy Mayer (eds.), Arbeiten zur Kirchen- und Theologiegeschichte 28 (Leipzig, 2009), 88-9.

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of the rich recurs in *Homily* 16, delivered on the Fast of December. This winter fast, after the autumn harvest, was considered a most appropriate time for fasting and almsgiving, allowing each an opportunity for being more abstinent in himself and more open-handed towards the poor (*Serm.* 16.2). This time there is a spiritual purpose for the poor as well: their needy condition allows them to learn the virtue of patience.[30]

Stewardship of Divine Gifts: Attitudes towards Wealth

In *Homily* 10, pronounced in 444 as the fifth of a series of six sermons on the Collects, Leo emphasises that wealth is not given as one's own possession but for use in God's service. This message of godly stewardship is also found, in a more rigorist form, in the contemporary anonymous letter to the rich ascetic Demetrias, known as *De vera humilitate*,[31] and signals a definitive break with pagan oratory on almsgiving. God gives great wealth in order that the rich may help the poor, nourish the sick, ransom captives, comfort the stranger, and relieve the exile (*Serm.* 10.2). The rich will bring upon their souls starvation, shame and nakedness, characteristics normally associated with the destitute, if they do not spend their riches on heavenly treasures (*Serm.* 10.2). The notion of stewardship as an argument for divesting oneself of one's wealth is common in the Cappadocian writings on beneficence, and as Meredith points out, is a radical departure from Hellenistic rhetoric.[32]

A negative attitude towards wealth that is not spent is shared by Christian and pagan authors. In pre-Christian Rome the only obligational expenditure in the public sphere was on liturgies for the *civitas* – otherwise private wealth was considered properly to be disposed of among one's household and clients with whom one had a special relationship.[33] As the poor were barred from entering a network of patron-client relations, and excluded from municipal largesse unless they were citizens, they thus fell outside the narrow purview of classical Roman evergetism. In *Homily* 49, delivered during Lent, Leo makes the point that both material wealth and poverty have the potential for spiritual harm. Riches make people proud and complacent, poverty makes them fearful and complaining (*Serm.* 49.1).[34] Thus, it is earthly thoughts that are the cause of sin,

[30] *Quos ideo sub diversis molestiis justitia Dei laborare permisit, ut et miseros pro patientia, et misericordes pro benevolentia coronaret* (SC 200, 176) ('For God in his justice has permitted these people to be afflicted with various troubles, that he might both crown the wretched for their patience and the merciful for their loving-kindness') (*Serm.* 16.1).

[31] Leo has been put forward as one of two most likely candidates for authorship of this tract, along with Prosper of Aquitaine. See the summary of scholarly opinions in Bronwen Neil, *On True Humility* (2006), 234-5.

[32] Anthony Meredith, The Three Cappadocians (1998), 95.

[33] See Cicero, *De offic.* 1.68, 2.52, 2.54-56, 2.61-2, 2.69-70.

[34] *Insidiae sunt in divitiarum amplitudine, insidiae in paupertatis angustiis. Illae elevant ad superbiam, hae incitant ad querelam* (SC 49bis, 182).

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not the possession of wealth in itself (*Serm.* 49.1), an idea that has early origins in Hermas and Clement of Alexandria.[35] Indeed the idea that the rich are blessed is also found in these two early writers.[36] This exoneration of riches would have been welcome to his aristocratic listeners.

A notion that is found in Christian authors of both east and west is that of the poor as worthy debtors. In normal circumstances, no one was considered less worthy of credit. However in the Christian spiritual economy the poor automatically gain a credit rating that the rich can only envy. Through patronage of the poor, the poor become patrons of the rich, not in this world but in the next. The injunction to make the poor one's clients applies equally to aristocratic men and women. Wealthy widows are warned not to rest on the laurels of their late husbands' generosity. As De Vinne notes, 'episcopal rhetoric not only constructs praiseworthy evergetists out of those that give unstintingly to the poor; it also transforms the poor into worthy clients.'[37] Lim points out that only those who did not hold public office – aristocratic women, or men who planned to give up their senatorial careers – could make exclusively Christian forms of benefaction, unlike those who were bound to exercise *liberalitas* as a function of public office.[38] Simultaneous fulfilment of the two roles (public and private) was seen to produce a conflict of interest. The extra freedom granted to wealthy women in their spending allowed the widow Fabiola to assist the senator Pammachius in establishing a hospital for the poor at Portus in 395-7.[39]

Allied to this redrawing of the lines of patron/client roles is the notion that the better-off are made citizens of heaven by almsgiving, whereas the poor get automatic citizenship. The social inversion that this implies is a radical one. Two of the most important criteria of belonging in Roman society are newly ascribed to the poor in a Christian society: citizenship, and the ability to attract patrons. And these same rewards could only be earned in the greater society of heaven by those now better-off through almsgiving. The virtues of anonymous

[35] Herm sim 2.5b; Clement of Alexandria, *Quis dives salvetur*, 26. 950 (Cambridge MA and London, 1960), 326. See Carolyn Osiek, *Rich and Poor in the Shepherd of Hermas: an exegetical-social investigation*, The Catholic Biblical Quarterly Monograph Series 15 (Washington DC, 1983), 87-90.

[36] Carolyn Osiek, *Rich and Poor* (1983), 88 n. 37.

[37] Michael J. De Vinne, *The Advocacy of Empty Bellies: Episcopal representation of the poor in the Late Roman Empire*, unpub. PhD diss., Stanford University, 1995 (Ann Arbor, 1999), 98.

[38] Richard Lim, People as power: games, munificence, and contested topography, in: William V. Harris (ed.), *The Transformations of* Urbs Roma *in Late Antiquity*, The Proceedings of a Conference held at the University of Rome 'La Sapienza' and at the American Academy in Rome, *Journal of Roman Archaeology Supplementary Series* 33 (Portsmouth, RI, 1999), 265-81, 278. On the subject of aristocratic women and their obligations, Lim, 273 n. 46, makes this caveat: 'While women of senatorial rank could not hold office, they were nevertheless not exempt from liturgies which they inherited from their fathers together with their inheritances; see *CTh* 6.4.17 (issued in 370).'

[39] Jerome, *Ep.* 66.11 (CSEL 54, 661).

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charity, divine mercy, and spiritual poverty, and the motives of spiritual gain, heavenly citizenship and stewardship of divine gifts, were distinctively Christian, in contrast to those virtues and motives adduced by earlier preachers such as the Cappadocians. Meredith discusses the motives for generosity to which the Cappadocians appealed in their homilies on giving generously to the poor.[40] These were an interesting mixture of pagan or classical virtues (such as φιλανθρωπία, and φιλοτιμία) and ideas of wealth as a sort of disease, the sterility of 'dead' wealth that is not used for the benefit of others,[41] the need to imitate the gods/God, the effeminate luxury of the rich contrasted with the terrible physical sufferings of the poor, and distinctively Christian motives, such as stewardship of God's gifts, the poor as sharing with all humanity the face of God (rather than Christ), thus sharing the same body and the same destiny as all human beings, and the divine generosity which allows θέωσις to take place in believers. In Leo's homilies we see the final departure from the Hellenistic tradition of philanthropy and the transformation of its ideals to fit a remodelled and extended *civitas*. Now we must ask, who was excluded from this new model society?

Deserving versus Undeserving Poor

The Christian attitude towards passing moral judgement upon the poor points to a decisive shift from the republican and imperial Roman paradigm. Contrary to the earlier observance of a strict hierarchy from deserving to non-deserving poor, and the characterisation of voluntary poverty as a virtue in the rich (though mostly characterising figures of the ideal past such as Cato), in the Christian era the shades of negativity have disappeared from terms that described the needy, such as *egentes* and *indigentes*. While Cicero was typical of classical orators in showing no compunction in withdrawing benevolence (*benignitas*) from those who apparently deserved their misfortune,[42] few Christian writers were prepared to make the same qualification. Basil of Cesarea made an exception on one notable occasion where he described the undeserving poor, the man who begs through avarice, as akin to a troublesome dog.[43]

Contrary to some earlier Christian authors such as Ambrose, Leo does make a distinction between those more and less deserving of alms, showing a strong

[40] Anthony Meredith, The Three Cappadocians (1998), 94-101.

[41] See Herodes Atticus, the second-century sophist, in Philostratus, *Vitae Sophistarum* 2.1.2,547 (ed. Anton Westermann, [Paris, 1849], 226.11).

[42] *Propensior benignitas esse debebit in calamitosos, nisi forte erunt digni calamitate.* Cic., *De offic.* 2.18.62; 'Readier generosity will be owed to those who have suffered disaster, unless perhaps they deserved that disaster'.

[43] Basil, *Ep.* 150.3 to Amphilochius, *Saint Basile, Correspondance*, 2 (Paris, 2002), 75. Basil here interprets *Acts* 2:45 as meaning that one should distinguish between those who are truly in need and those who beg out of avarice.

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preference for giving alms to the faithful, as when he cites *Gal.* 6:10 (*Serm.* 10.4).[44] Particularly deserving are those poor who disdain to confess their neediness, and prefer to suffer deprivation than the shame of a public appeal (*Serm.* 9.3). This moral distinction is not however expressed through his choice of terminology.

We find this moral shift reflected in the changing meaning of the term *caritas* in Christian authors. Apart from its primary signification, the expensiveness of commodities, *caritas* was used for emotional regard in the Late Republic but it was rarely considered a personal emotion. Rather, *caritas* was that reverence directed towards the gods or one's country. Cicero explicitly distinguished *caritas* from *amor*, the love that one feels for one's friends and family.[45] Even in the fourth century, *caritas* encompassed a broader catchment of recipients than pagan φιλανθρωπία. Philanthropy, an emotionally neutral state, was that regard for one's city that inspired one to give generously to its citizens. The Christian use of the term was inspired by the *Vulgate* translation of 1*Cor.* 13:13, where *fides, spes* and *caritas* are identified as the three divine virtues. *Caritas* was the proper term for 'love' of the very poor or destitute. As Parkin rightly observes, 'No one claimed to love the destitute until the rise of Christianity as a power in the late empire, when patronage of the poor became an ideological and political force.'[46]

Homily 16 concludes with a condemnation of the Manichean heresy, in which Leo advises his flock to avoid contact with Manichees. At first glance this adjunct to a homily on almsgiving seems out of place. The Manichees, while claiming to be Christians, refused to accept some fundamental tenets of Christianity, including the birth of Jesus in the flesh, Christ's suffering in the crucifixion and his physical resurrection after death. They also believed in total renunciation of property. For all these reasons Leo considered the Manichees a real threat to the church in Rome, where their number had increased greatly after the Vandal invasions of North Africa in 429. Orthodoxy as defined by the pope was thus a new criterion for being considered worthy of material aid, and went some way to replacing the criterion of citizenship. In a climate of an investigation, one cannot imagine any Manichees coming forward for papal

[44] *Dum ergo tempus habemus, sic ait Apostolus, operemur quod bonum est ad mones maxime autem ad domesticos fidei* (SC 49bis, 54) ('While we have time therefore, as the Apostle says, let all our actions be for the good of everybody, and especially of those who belong to the household of faith').

[45] Cicero, *Part.* 16.56: *Nam aut caritate moventur homines, ut deorum, ut patriae, ut parentum; aut amore, ut fratrum, ut coniugum, ut liberorum, ut familiarium, aut honestate, ut virtutum* (ed. Augustus S. Wilkins, *M. Tulli Ciceronis Rhetorica* 2 [London and New York, 1935], 29-31) ('Either people are moved by charity, as for the gods, for their country, for their parents; or they are moved by love, as for their brothers, their wives, their children, their household members; or they are moved by respect, as for the virtues ...').

[46] Anneliese Parkin, An exploration of pagan almsgiving (2006), 68. Mary Sheather, Pronouncements (1998), 375-92, 389-90 makes the same point, noting that Christian love of the poor as a class was a significant departure from pagan commentary on wealth and poverty (389 n. 83).

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distributions of food, money or clothing, even if they were refugees in the city. Augustine on the other hand refutes the Manichean refusal to give to 'sinners', even those 'who hate and persecute the church'.[47]

Leo's concern to stress the triumph of Christianity over Rome shows the need to break with that city's proudly-held pagan traditions. In *Homily* 9, Leo explicitly links the relatively new tradition of collections for the poor with the effacing of pre-Christian civic traditions. On two occasions he refers to the Collects as an 'apostolic institution',[48] i.e. initiated by Peter and Paul themselves, but elsewhere he modifies such lofty claims for its beginnings.[49] In *Sermon* 8, Leo claims that the date for the Collects in November was deliberately chosen in order to destroy the snares of the Devil.[50] The purpose of the offering of alms was to protest against the unholy victims of the wicked.[51] These were both the sacrifices that accompanied pagan games, as well as those of the contemporary Manichees in Rome.

Patlagean noted among Christian and pagan authors in the Greek-speaking east two distinct approaches to describing the poor: first as a legal category, using the terms πτωχός 'destitute' and πένης, terms which presented poverty as a juridical and social state of being.[52] The term πτωχός had overtones of passivity that πένης did not.[53] The other tendency was to describe poverty as a concrete physical situation.[54] Those that remained faithful to the classical tradition described the poor in terms of social identity using the language of need, most frequently the participle δεομένος 'the needy', a term which recalled the

[47] Augustine, *Serm.* 164a (NBA 31/2, 736) = *Sermo Lambot* 28, ed. Cyrille Lambot, Sermon sur l'aumone a restituer à saint Augustin, in: *Revue Bénédictine* 66 (1956) 149-58, at 158.67-71: *etiam peccatores a misericordibus suscipi uel pasci iubeantur: illud attendat, quod iam superius memoraui, quia utique peccatores et maxime scelerati sunt, qui oderunt et persequuntur ecclesiam, de quibus tamen dicitur:* Bene facit his qui oderunt uos (*Matth.* 5:44). See the discussion of this sermon by Raymond Canning, *Unity of Love for God and Neighbour in St. Augustine* (Heverlee and Leuven, 1993), 391-92.

[48] *Serm.* 9.3: *Dies nos apostolicae institutionis invitat* ... (SC 49bis, 42); also the opening line of *Serm.* 10.1: *Apostolicae traditionis, dilectissimi, institute servants* ... (SC 49bis, 48).

[49] See *Serm.* 7: *Primus collectarum dies saluberrime a sanctis patribus institutus* (SC 49bis, 30-32); *Serm.* 11.2 (SC 49bis, 60).

[50] *Serm.* 8: *Ad destruendas antiqui hostis insidias in die quo impii sub idolorum suorum nomine diabolo serviebant* ...(SC 49bis, 34).

[51] *Serm.* 9.3: *Contra profanas hostias impiorum, sacratissime, nostrarum eleemosynarum celebraretur oblatio* (SC 49bis, 44). While this does seem to be a reference to pagan games, the identification of them with the *Ludi Apollinares*, based on an incorrect dating of the five Collect sermons to the feast of Saints Peter and Paul in early July, is erroneous. See Antoine Chavasse, CChr.SL 138, 26; and notes to Sermon 9, transl. Charles Feltoe, *The Sermons of Leo the Great*, NPNF series 2, vol. 12, 118, n. 669.

[52] Evelyne Patlagean, *Pauvreté* (1977), 25: 'Ils ont en commun de ne pas offrir un sens concret immédiatement intelligible, de présenter la pauvreté comme une condition juridique et sociale, et de servir au langage législatif.'

[53] Evelyne Patlagean, *Pauvreté* (1977), 26.

[54] Evelyne Patlagean, *Pauvreté* (1977), 25.

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social relation between rich and poor. Patristic writers such as Gregory of Nyssa employed their own categories of need which provided concrete and varied definitions of poverty, such as 'the hungry', 'the oppressed', and 'the stranger', categories which were themselves strangers to the traditional social classification but were borrowed from the Old Testament and the Gospels.[55] According to Finn, Latin writers such as Augustine took up the language of need: 'More frequently Augustine, like many other Latin preachers, chose to speak simply of the very poor as poor, *pauperes*, with little or no further specification as beggars, widows, orphans, the sick, disabled, debtors or the elderly infirm – specification he could have easily given.'[56] The same could be said of Leo on the whole, except for two important instances: in *Homily* 10.2, to which we have already referred, and in *Homily* 40, delivered during the fasting season of Lent,[57] which takes up the blessedness of those who hunger and thirst after righteousness (*Matth.* 5:6). This homily spells out the general categories of destitution: those who are considered worthy of financial or material assistance are the poor, the naked, the sick and infirm, exiles, orphans and solitary widows. Finn sees Augustine's reluctance to identify the very poor even by such general categories as these as motivated by the bishop's desire to foreshorten social distance between the givers and their recipients, in order to prevent the givers recoiling in disgust from the condition of the destitute and thus being reluctant to give.[58] One could also see Leo's occasional use of such impersonal categories as a deliberate distancing technique, a movement away from the graphic descriptions of individual cripples and beggars as found in Chrysostom and Jerome, to a more sanitised and impersonal taxonomy. Perhaps the reason for this is that in fifth-century Rome there was less need to render the poor visible; they were a far-too-familiar sight to the preacher's audience.

Part 2. Rhetoric or Reality?

Finally we must consider whether Leo's rhetoric translated into effective action on behalf of the poor. While heretics may have been excluded from the δῆμος / *civitas*, others were now included who had formerly been below the radar of civic largesse. As already noted, in Rome, the supply of grain and other basic commodities such as pork and oil was assured by the imperial government but these handouts were available strictly to citizens only, and not just to poor

[55] Evelyne Patlagean, *Pauvreté* (1977), 28.

[56] Richard Finn, Portraying the poor: descriptions of poverty in Christian texts from the late Roman empire, in: E. Margaret Atkins and Robin Osborne (eds.), *Poverty in the Roman World* (Cambridge, 2006), 130-44, 135.

[57] The date of 1 March 442 is given by Lucio Casula, *Leone Magno: Il conflitto tra ortodossia ed eresia nel quinto secolo* (Milan, 2002), Appendice I. Sermonario, 296.

[58] Richard Finn, Portraying the poor (2006), 134.

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citizens either. In the food crisis of 383 or 384 the *praefectus urbi* had been forced to expel all *peregrini*, or foreigners, from the city to ease the pressure on scanty resources. Ambrose of Milan sought to expose the humanity of these outcasts and the inhumanity of their banishers.[59] In smaller cities, such as Milan, the town councillors (*curiales*) were responsible for liturgical expenses: staging games, theatrical performances, and races; providing oil for heating public baths; maintaining public buildings. By the end of the fourth century, however, the curial class was in sharp decline, and was losing both the power and material substance to provide these services.[60] Local bishops were forced to step in to fulfil the role of the declining curial class in the fourth and fifth centuries. In any case, municipal largesse was rarely extended to the homeless.[61]

Voluntary public giving continued to sponsor services for the public good. State handouts of bread and meat to the poor were less strictly limited to Roman citizens – but these were gradually phased out in the fifth century to be replaced by the church's welfare. Bishops of Rome probably stepped in on some occasions in the fifth century to supply the *annona* when imperial food supplies ran short.[62] At least three of Leo's sermons (10, 16, 40 and possibly 78) out of those under consideration here pre-dated the Italian invasions of Attila and Geiseric. I conclude, therefore, that in the majority of sermons under discussion Leo was dealing with ordinary welfare for Roman citizens rather than emergency measures, even though a large influx of refugees had accompanied Geiseric's invasion of North Africa in the 430s.

Direct versus Indirect Giving

The initial emphasis of bishops in the fourth century was on direct giving to the poor. John Chrysostom complains that the better-off have forced priests and bishops to busy themselves with public affairs, indicating his own strong preference for direct giving.[63] In the transition phase of the fourth to fifth centuries, exemplified by Augustine's period as bishop of Hippo, the emphasis seems to shift from direct towards indirect giving, managed by the bishop and his deacons. In the fourth-century text known as *Apostolic Constitutions*, direct giving

[59] See an edited version of what was probably originally a sermon in Ambrose, *De offic.* 3.45-52. For discussion see Michael J. De Vinne, *The Advocacy of Empty Bellies* (1999), 35-40.

[60] See Aug., *Cur. pro mort.* 15 (CSEL 41, 644).

[61] Home ownership was a criterion for the *annona* until at least 396 (*CTh* 14.17.13), ed. Theodor Mommsen, 1, 796.

[62] By the sixth century total control of the *annona* had passed to the bishops of Rome, who also used the produce of their estates to provide for the poor. See Mark Humphries, Italy, A.D. 425-605, in: *The Cambridge Ancient History* 14: *Late Antiquity. Empire and Successors A.D. 425-600*, Averil Cameron, Bryan Ward-Perkins, and Michael Whitby (eds.) (Cambridge, 2000), 525-51, 542.

[63] *Hom.* 85.4 *in Matt.* (PG 58, 762).

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is even actively discouraged.[64] By the mid-fifth century the preference in Rome was for indirect giving, via the church. One way of financing the Roman church's charitable works was by the Collects, a collection was undertaken over several days throughout the churches of the seven regions of the city. Donations consisted of 'goods' (*bona*) (*Serm.* 9.3), which would have included food and clothing, as well as money. The distribution of these goods was overseen by deacons (*praesidentes*).[65] The system of diaconates, known as poor rolls, was brought to the West by Cassian (360-433).[66] While Augustine was the first to use the term, when he wrote of enrolling a poor widow *in matricula pauperum quos sustentat ecclesia* ('in the census of the poor whom the church supports'),[67] Leo was the first Western bishop to organise deacons to oversee this task.[68]

Conclusion: The Shift from Classical Evergetism to Christian Charity

Christian bishops in east and west from the fourth century sought to redefine what it meant to be a Roman citizen, and thus to be worthy of municipal generosity. At the same time, they tried to universalise the responsibility to give. Leo calls rich and poor alike to show mercy and goodness, as no amount is too small to give, and the fruit of their works is the same.[69] This injunction suggests that there were among Leo's audience some of lesser means, but few or none of the very poor.

Leo's system of welfare, based on the idea of individual voluntary giving, ultimately did nothing to challenge the *status quo* whereby the elite exploited the services of a vast and cheap source of labour constituted by the poor and very poor. However Leo did make some radical innovations to shore up the system of state handouts which was failing to meet the needs of both citizens and those excluded by this criterion. Adopting the eastern model, Leo was one of the first bishops of Rome to institutionalise the census of the poor, supervised by deacons. As Armitage rightly observes, 'This does not make Leo some

[64] *Apost. Const.* 2.27 (SC 320, 240-2) warns against private giving apart from a bishop because only bishops know who is afflicted and can give to each applicant for aid as is appropriate to their need. See Michael J. De Vinne, *The Advocacy of Empty Bellies* (1999), 115 and n. 1.

[65] *Serm.* 11.2: *sancta collectio, quae per praesidentium curam necessariis serviret expensis.* (SC 49bis, 60) ('... a holy collection from the resources of many, which would provide the necessary expenses through the care of the overseers').

[66] Michel Rouche, La matricule des pauvres – Evolution d'une institution de charité du Bas Empire jusqu'à la fin du Haut Moyen Âge, in: *Études sur l'histoire de la pauvreté*, Michel Mollat (ed.) (Paris, 1974), I 83-110, 96.

[67] *Ep.* 20*.2 (NBA 23a, 160). This letter is one of those more recently discovered and edited by Johannes Divjak, *Les lettres de S. Augustin, Lettres 1*-29*, Bibliothèque Augustinienne Œuvres de Saint Augustin 46b (Paris, 1987).

[68] Michel Rouche, La matricule (1974), 97.

[69] *Serm.* 40.4.

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sort of fifth century socialist ... but it is nevertheless true that [Leo's] vision is a social vision, and that he would regard any spirituality which is separated from its proper social dimension as in some sense defective.'[70] The ideals expressed in the Beatitudes of *Matth.* 5 matched Leo's social vision perfectly: the 'poor in spirit' included both rich and the poor in a material sense – the expression encompassed all those who embraced humility. For the rich this meant showing mercy to those less fortunate than themselves. For the poor it meant being satisfied with the little they had. Both rich and poor were called to give alms according to their means. All such gifts were to be directed through the church, for example in the annual collections for the urban poor. This was intended a move away from conspicuous individual giving in return for social recognition such as characterised pagan philanthropy and even fourth- and fifth-century elite Christian asceticism. Leo singles out no poor person for special mention – his poor are an anonymous mass, at best identified by categories, grouped according to their capacity to meet basic needs and their access to, or exclusion from, social networks: for example, the hungry, the sick, orphans, widows, slaves and refugees. The only criterion of eligibility for aid was orthodoxy.

[70] Jonathan Mark Armitage, *Economy of Mercy* (1997), 189.

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Alleviating Economic Injustice in Gregory of Nyssa's *Contra usurarios*

Brian MATZ, Leuven

Introduction

This communication explores one model for alleviating economic injustice employed by the Greek Fathers of the second through fifth centuries. One may diagnose several models at work in early Christian socio-ethical texts, including (1) defining the poor, (2) almsgiving, (3) shared labor, and (4) institutionalized redistribution. The model I explore here is what I call 'reprogramming the wealthy'. The model explains the attempts of several Fathers to reshape the psychology of the wealthy, to appeal to their self-interests. No program of alleviating economic injustice during this period would have been successful had the Fathers not appealed to the self-interest motives of the wealthy.

The title of this communication includes the word 'alleviating'. This is important, for at no time did the Fathers advocate a dismantling of socio-political structures that allowed economic injustices to continue long after the fifth century.[1] We have evidence that some Fathers wrote letters to government officials on behalf of a friend or a city asking for tax relief, but these generally were responses to a temporary period of suffering. The success of Christian churches in securing for themselves and for their bishops tax exemption was certainly helpful, but this only shifted the burden of proof to the churches that they were using their tax-exempt status to support charitable causes. The practice of money-lending was roundly condemned by the Fathers, but we do not find in their writings appeals for an overhaul of the judicial system that too quickly auctioned off the land of those in debt. Thus, we must accept that when we read the Fathers in order to understand how they confronted the economic injustices of their day, we will find not in their writings a comprehensive approach to the problems but rather a number of bandages applied to the wounds that economic injustice inflicts. One such bandage was the reprogramming of the wealthy. I am hopeful that an exploration of this model, as with any discussion of other models, promotes discussion without over-simplifying the issues.

[1] I have written more on this in the historical introduction to my collaborative project with J. Leemans and J. Verstraeten, *Social Ethics in Early Christianity: Compendium of Texts from the Greek and Latin Fathers to the Council of Chalcedon*, now under review at an academic press.

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Reprogramming the Wealthy

When it came to encouraging both almsgiving and the sharing of one's labor with the poor, the Fathers employed a carrot-and-stick approach. On the one hand, giving alms helps not only the poor, but also the almsgiver by forgiving that person of his or her sins. On the other hand, if you refrain from giving alms, your sins will not be forgiven and your prayers will not be heard by God. Thus, we have in appeals for alms and for the sharing of labor some traces of an attempt by the Fathers to reprogram the mindset of the wealthy. Yet, the shaping of the psychology of the wealthy, appealing to their self-interest, went further than that.

Our sample text is Gregory of Nyssa's homily *Against the Usurers*, which he delivered in 379.[2] It was directed squarely at those in the audience who loan money with interest and the problems attendant upon them. This homily is a good example of at least three ways in which the psychology of the wealthy was reshaped.[3] First, Gregory appealed to their desire for good, mental health. To Gregory, lending money at interest engendered a host of psychological and physical problems. He wrote,

> Why do you harm yourself with anxiety by calculating days, months, the sum of money, dreaming of profit, and fearing the appointed day whose fruitful harvest brings hail?... If he [i.e., the usurer] hears a bad report about anyone who has fallen among thieves or whose good fortune has changed to destitution, the moneylender sits with folded

[2] Gregory of Nyssa, *Contra Usurarios*, in: *Gregorii Nysseni Opera*, IX, ed. Ernest Gebhardt (Leiden, 1967), 195-207. ET: Casimir McCambley, Against Those Who Practice Usury by Gregory of Nyssa: *Greek Orthodox Theological Review* 36 (1991) 287-302. In the shadow of Basil's highly influential and popular sermon, Gregory's sermon is often dismissed as a mere imitation at best. But, Gregory's homily on usury stands quite independently from Basil's. See Brenda Ihssen, *They Who Give from Evil: The Response of the Eastern Church to Money-lending in the Early Christian Era*, Ph.D. dissertation (St. Michael's College, Univ. of Toronto, 2004), ix. Other secondary literature on usury that gives some attention to Gregory's homily include: Patrick Cleary, *The Church and Usury: An Essay on Some Historical and Theological Aspects of Moneylending* (Dublin, 1914), esp. 48-52; Susan Holman, *The Hungry are Dying: Beggars and Bishops in Roman Cappadocia* (New York, 2001), esp. 115-24; Robert P. Maloney, Teaching of the Fathers on Usury: An Historical Study on the Development of Christian Thinking: *Vigiliae Christianae* 27 (1973) 241-65.

For the date of the homily see Jean Daniélou, Chronologie des sermons de Grégoire de Nysse: *Revue des sciences religieuses* 29 (1955) 346-72, 348f. This was near in time to the writing of his *De hominis opificio*.

[3] Gregory comments frequently in the homily that his audience knows of what he speaks, and is aware of the problems he mentions. This demonstrates, on the one hand, a sizable percentage of Gregory's congregation at that moment hailed from the upper classes, and, on the other hand, Gregory is very much in tune with their experiences and ideas. He offered only a handful of comments about the plight of poor persons adversely affected by usury. At one point he said flatly, εἰ μὴ πλῆθος ἦν τοκιστῶν, οὐκ ἂν ἦν τὸ πλῆθος τῶν πενομένων ('If usury does not abound, then a multitude of destitute persons would cease to exist') Gregory, *Contra Usurarios* (GNO IX 202; ET: McCambley, 298).

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hands, groans continually, weeps much, rolls up the written bond, laments the gold it represents, and makes a contract which cuts off his son as though he were a garment.[4]

Gregory will go on to say that usurers are preoccupied with storms at sea and adverse weather patterns when they have loaned their money to sailors or to farmers, respectively. Importantly, Gregory, like a good psychologist, searches for and then hones in upon the root of the money-lenders' problem. In this case, the poor mental health of money-lenders is due to the fact that they have only paper money. That is to say, the only 'wealth' they have, with which they pride themselves, is money promised in contractual arrangements. Thus, the uncertainty of the future is ever an enemy to the usurer, and it contributes to poor, psychological health.[5]

Second, Gregory appealed to the wealthy person's desire for a good reputation. The usurer will inevitably leave to future generations a lamentable legacy. In the patron-client social structure that shaped much of life in late antiquity, a good reputation for oneself could pay material dividends for one's children and grandchildren. Thus, Gregory's lament that usurers contribute to the dismantling of their families and to a pitiable legacy surely struck a chord. At one point in the sermon, Gregory said: 'So many people are ensnared through usury and cast themselves headlong into torrential rivers! This is a more tolerable death than [being indebted to] a moneylender who has abandoned his children as orphans and has destitution as an evil stepmother.'[6] The comparison of a pauper's suicide to fiscal death at the hand of a moneylender is interesting in itself, but there is at the end of the quotation a description of the usurer as one who has abandoned his children. Elsewhere in the homily Gregory argues usury brings destruction on one's home; he also recalled a story familiar to his listeners of a usurer who was so afraid of financial losses that he hid his money

[4] Gregory, *Contra Usurarios* (GNO IX 199-200; ET: McCambley, 297).

[5] Gregory's brother, Basil of Caesarea, in his *Homily* 21, 'On Detachment from Worldly Goods', also emphasized the mental health problems attendant upon the wealthy. In the case of this sermon, however, the problem is the wealthy person's penchant for superfluous goods. Basil referred twice in the homily to riches being the consequence of acts of injustice. See Basil of Caesarea, *Homilies* 21.1 and 21.7 (PG 31, 540, 552); ET: Monica Wagner, *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, Fathers of the Church series, vol. 9 (Washington D.C., 1950), 487, 496. Following that, Basil argued that superfluous goods bring no true pleasure; on the contrary, once the feeling of satiety has passed and sanity has returned, superfluous goods actually cause a person to hate himself or herself for having indulged in them (*Homilies* 21.4, PG 31, 548; ET: Wagner, *Saint Basil*, 493). See also Asterius of Amasea, *Homily* 3, 'Against Covetousness' 12. Moreover, like Gregory, Basil understood that the wealthy person is constantly unnerved by superfluous possessions for he or she must always be concerned about robbers, about untimely death, and about the posthumous transfer of their possessions to unworthy recipients (*Homilies* 21.3, PG 31, 546-8; ET: Wagner, *Saint Basil*, 492). To such concerns Chrysostom will later add the loss of goods in transit at sea or on land, encroaching taxation, ruination of crops due to foul weather, and the spoiling of grain in storehouses. See his *Homilies on Philippians* 10 and *Homilies on 1 Timothy* 12.4.

[6] Gregory, *Contra Usurarios* (GNO IX 203-4; ET: McCambley, 299).

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so well no one, not even his children, could find it – even after his death![7] Because the only type of wealth a moneylender has are the contractual promises from others to pay, defaults on those loans could actually impoverish the usurer to such an extent that he or she is obliged to sell his or her children into slavery or otherwise disown the children. While such a move would reduce the usurer's day to day expenses as well as reduce his or her need for full repayment of the defaulted loan in the future, it would devastate the usurer's family and tarnish his or her reputation.

Finally, the third way in which Gregory appealed to the self-interest of the wealthy was when he explained that the pursuit of wealth is avarice, and avarice leads one straight to hell. Gregory writes of one usurer in particular, 'You have indeed ended your life with its vain pursuit of usury. Pains and hunger trouble you as you accumulate an inheritance of eternal punishment and leave your children penniless.'[8] In this quote, we see again the earlier problem that the usurer creates a lamentable legacy for leaving his children penniless. To that Gregory has added that the usurer inherits for himself or herself eternal punishment in hell. Two paragraphs earlier he had initiated this line of argument with an allusion to Jesus' rebuke to the rich man in *Luke* 16 who had asked that Lazarus be sent to teach his brothers. The rich man in the parable must remain in that painful hell where his brothers – and, as far as Gregory is concerned, the usurers – will one day surely join him. We find similar examples of this attempt to direct the self-interest of the wealthy person towards his or her experiences in the afterlife in other writings by the Fathers during the second through fifth centuries.[9]

All told, these three attempts at reprogramming the mindset of wealthy people reveal Gregory at some of his pastoral best. He does not shun his moneylending parishoners, but instead embraces the problems they face. He paints vivid pictures that help them see the world differently. He wants them to change their attitude towards money, towards themselves and their families, and towards the poor. Even so, one wishes he had subordinated his appeal to the self-serving motives of the wealthy with an appeal to the inhumanity of usury for the poor in the first place.

[7] Gregory, *Contra Usurarios* (GNO IX 197, 206; ET: McCambley, 295, 301, respectively).

[8] Gregory, *Contra Usurarios* (GNO IX 205-6; ET: McCambley, 301).

[9] Basil of Caesarea, *Homilies* 21.6 (PG 31, 549; ET: Wagner, *Saint Basil*, 495) writes: 'A man who has his own best interests at heart will therefore be especially concerned for his soul and will spare no pains to keep it stainless and true to itself.' Jesus' parable of Lazarus and the Rich Man (*Luke* 16) is a key text in this regard. Basil recalls it in his homily and then says: 'By thus refusing to imitate the cruel [Rich Man], we shall escape the fire of hell which was his portion.' (*Homilies* 21.8, PG 31, 553; ET: Wagner, *Saint Basil*, 497). We may turn as well to texts as diverse as *Shepherd of Hermas* Similitude 1, Clement of Alexandria's *Paedogogus* 2.11, Asterius of Amasea's *Sermon* 2 ('The Unjust Steward') and John Chrysostom's *Homilies on John* 77.4-5. Chrysostom, for example, argued wealth helps humans on their way to eternal punishment, whereas thankfulness and contentment aid in the remission of their sins. Furthermore, he said that almsgiving was of little use to the one otherwise given over to the acquisition of luxuries.

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Summary

This brief look at one of several models for alleviating economic injustice highlights at least two features of early Christianity with which we ought to be familiar. First, the Fathers believed alleviating economic injustice was largely in the hands of the rich and not in the hands of the poor. This goes some way towards explaining why early Christianity encouraged personal and corporate piety rather than social revolution in regards to alleviating economic injustice. Christians in the early centuries were little different from us today: they accepted existing class systems and they were pleased to acquire wealth for its own sake.

Second, it is increasingly understood nowadays that there was more than one category of poor people in late antiquity. This model suggests there was also more than one category of wealthy people with whom the Fathers were concerned. Anyone who possessed more than he or she needed was deemed 'wealthy'. Gregory of Nyssa's sermon *Against the Usurers* certainly was not directed to those at the lowest end of the poverty ladder, and I doubt very much Gregory was concerned solely with those at the top of the wealth ladder. We have seen how he empathized with the money-lenders' ever-present danger of going into bankruptcy themselves. Wealthy people did not have all their eggs in the money-lending basket, so to speak. It was, rather, those in the vast, economic middle of society with whom Gregory was concerned. Such people lived in 'shallow poverty';[10] they had jobs or tradecrafts but were ever on the edge of enjoying a feast or a famine with respect to their finances. During financial 'feast' times they, too, would have been prone to make financial speculations, including loaning money to others at interest. I argue Gregory believed he still had a chance to turn the attention of such people away from a dangerous love-affair with money. This sermon, then, and other texts like it suggest that the Fathers were concerned with more than one type of wealthy person much as they were concerned with more than one type of poor person.

[10] For discussion on the use of this term in scholarship, see Peter Brown, *Poverty and Leadership in the Later Roman Empire* (Hanover, NH, 2002), 14-6.

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